Artemis & Lycan

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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam & Adora (She-Ra)

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Werewolves, Were-Creatures, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Developing Relationship, Werewolf Adora (She-Ra), Hunter Glimmer, Blood and Injury, Swearing, Implied/Referenced Character Death, Additional Warnings In Author's Note, Mythical Beings & Creatures, Murder Mystery, Adora and Catra are Adoptive Sisters, Grief/Mourning, Growth and Healing, Angst and Hurt/Comfort

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by curiousscientistkae

Summary

Glimmer is a hunter-the protector of Brightmoon and all those who live there. After the death of her mother, she has taken up this role. Adora is a werewolf, bitten as a child and unable to control the monster inside of her. One faithful day, their paths converge. Glimmer seeks to find her mother's killer. Adora seeks to know about the truth of her family. Will either find their answers as unbeknownst to them, shadows lurk all around and danger is brewing.

Notes

Look what idiot has a new idea for a story! Okay I have had this in my head for a long time now but struggled to get it out. Now, finally, I think I can do it, hopefully. That being said, this is my first attempt at something more 'original'. As in, with chipped!adora, I had the show itself to follow and have pre-established stuff. This really it's just the characters in my own au, ya know? So, yeah bear with me with that lmao.

And yes, I got a lot of inspiration for things from MTV Teen's Wolf so ksajgabsgkjasgas. Everyone here is roughly in their early/about mid 20s because fuck it.

Anyway while I have other chapters queued, I am gonna post when I feel like it? Since i have so many other ideas, such as Single Mom Au, I just want to post when I can but I do truly want to see this to the end since I have so many ideas and it has been brewing for over a year now. So, hopefully yall will enjoy!

Tw for this is dead animal at one point

The Hunter and The Wolf

Summer is her favorite season. Not because of the warmth it brings. Not because of the fun one can have. Not even because of the prospect of enjoying cold ice cream or diving deep below a body of water to cool off. No. She loves it for the sun. How long it lingers in the sky. How the moon and darkness takes forever to overtake the world. The summer solstice is her favorite day by far. The shortest night out of the whole year. During these days, she remains *herself* . She remains ***Adora.***

Tonight, however, isn't her lucky day. The solstice is not for another week and a half. Thus, the monster inside begins to claw its way out early. Adora winces, still dull nails digging into the dirt, as her stomach twists tight. Burning bile tickles the back of her throat. She swallows, forcing it back down. Throwing up has not occurred in several months and she isn't planning on breaking that tonight. Yet, that is the only thing she can control.

She tastes blood as her teeth pierce her bottom lip. Her ears pick up the distance snapping of a twig. A growl escapes her and the first thought that crosses her mind is seeking the owner of the noise and striking them down. She quickly shakes it aside. Though, it won't stay away for long. The thought will consume everything part of her being. Adora prays it is not some human walking about the forest. Harming an animal is not ideal either but that's a bitter pill she is used to swallowing.

"I'm sorry," Adora mutters.

Her body finally decides to no longer make her wait for the inevitable. Pain *explodes* through every ounce of her being. Muscles tear and rip and bones break and shatter, all making room to reconfigure her form. A scream attempts to escape her but with a tightening throat, only silence comes out. The last coherent thought that enters her mind is hoping she is deep enough in these dark woods—far, far away from civilization.

Glimmer groans. Her left side aches; a dull pain radiating from the scars on her stomach. It's an annoyance, sure, but at least she is used to it. And being a night owl helps. When most would long since have slipped into the realm of dreams, she is wide awake. Even then, she only ever needed a few hours of sleep to feel well rested and alert. That is quite a great quirk to have when you are the designated "protector" of this land.

Bored and with nothing interesting on TV, she climbs off her couch and saunters towards the back door. A yawn escapes her as she passes her dusty, unused hunter equipment off towards the side. Since returning to Brightmoon a couple years ago, rarely has her past upbringing been needed. Her mother did a hell of a job in her last years to ensure Brightmoon remains a haven for those that seek to be hidden. No one new has come nor has the place needed to be defended in quite some time. Glimmer will admit, it can be dull living here.

She pulls open the door, a creak filling the air. Stepping out onto the back porch, she lets the summer air over take her. The heat and humidity of the day has long since died off, leaving the world cool and feeling refreshed. However, it shall only last a handful of hours. The sun soon will return to scorch the earth. Above her, stars decorate the dark sky canvas. Alongside them, is a large, pale, full moon. In this form, it gives power to many that lurk in the night. Dangers can be hiding everywhere if one is not careful. Especially in the forest.

Her eyes find what rests right behind her home. The Whispering Woods. A forest would be a better word. It goes on for miles and only has a select number of paths. One easily can get lost and never return into civilization. Yet 'The Whispering Forest' doesn't have quite the same ring. At least the first part of its name holds true. With all the creatures that do, or did, prowl around, one would hear confusing noises.

Glimmer squints her eyes and hones her ears, focusing everything on the dark, thick patch of wilderness. The only thing that catches

her sights is the black outline of a great horned owl. It spots her and lets out a ‘ *hoo’* before flying off. Crickets and the soft steps of deer fill her ears. Once more, the forest is just that. An ordinary place in any old ordinary town.

Another full moon without incident.

Glimmer spins on her heels and reaches her hand for the door handle when a noise pierces her ears. A cold, no, *freezing,* shiver runs down the length of her spine. She has not heard this sound in some years, not since that fateful night with her mother. The low, harsh, and chilling howl of a werewolf. She was raised to know the difference between a normal grey wolf and the creatures of myth (not to mention, actual wolves don’t really live in these parts, only coyotes come close). After so long, one of the most infamous creatures of lore has returned. Now the question is, are they friend or foe?

By the sounds of it, there is only one. Though, if there are more they could be keeping their mouths shut and lure the unsuspecting into a trap. Glimmer grew up on cautionary tales of young, naive hunters biting off more than they can chew. But she isn’t a child nor inexperienced. Rusty, sure, but this has been a part of her life for almost all of it.

Glimmer bolts into her house, the door slamming against the wooden framing and remaining open. The first thing she does is grab her cell phone. The crescent moon key charm at the bottom swigs as she rapidly types in Bow’s phone number. He picks up on the third ring.

“Glim...it’s four in the morning….” his voice is heavy and slow. Clearly, he is only half here.

“Bow! Did you hear that?!?” She has to make sure her imagination hasn’t run wild.

There is a creak of a bed from Bow’s line. “Hear what? What are you talking about?”

“I heard a howl. I think there is a werewolf in the woods!”

“Don’t you dare go out there!” Bow suddenly snaps, his voice more clear.

“Why do you think I am calling you? Though it’s not like anything bad could happen if I went alone.”

“You dying is bad!”

“Well what am I supposed to do! Just sit here right now?” Glimmer crosses her one arm against her chest. She begins to pace around the living room, eyeing her equipment.

“Remember the last time you went out alone? If something is out there, what if it’s a whole pack?” There is a pause where neither friend says anything. “Look, keep your eyes and ears out. The sun will be coming up soon anyway and that would be the best time to look. You know it will take me a half hour to get there anyway.”

Glimmer groans, knowing he is right. Her scars are aching more, reminding her of her brush with death. A good hunter is a smart one and doesn’t go rushing into a slaughterhouse without a plan. Least, that is what her mother always told her.

“Fine,” Glimmer complains. “You owe me coffee. And if shit starts to happen, I am not waiting.”

“Fair enough.” A yawn escapes Bow. “I’ll see ya in a couple hours, ‘kay?”

“Sorry I woke you. I’ll see you soon.”

Glimmer flicks her finger across the screen, hanging up on her best friend. Her phone returns to the home screen. Her mother and father on their wedding night stares back at her. Even back then, her mother dyed her hair in pink and violet colors. She runs a hand through her own locks that match the photo of her mother.

Is that your killer out there? Glimmer thinks. She looks out an open window. All sounds that fill her ears belong to the summer's night. Maybe it was her own imagination. Just the wind making odd noises. Yet, she cannot shake the feeling of something lurking in those woods. Something that could pose a threat. Or maybe not. That is yet to be seen.

Everything inside of her is telling her to grab her gear and find out what is going on. If it truly is a non-friendly being then she shall be letting innocent lives at risk. She can at the very least stun whatever it is and once they are back to human, figuring out what to do with them. Yet, Bow is right. Going out in the middle of the night, even with her skills and abilities, is a poor decision. Just thinking about it causes her scars to flair up again. As the protector of this area, her death would be catastrophic.

If there was any sleep inside of her before, then it is nonexistent now. She paces around her living room, nearly creating a rut in hardwood. Windows and her back door remain wide open. TV is off and her phone stays on vibrate. Nothing can distract her. For better or for worse, in the long hours waiting for Bow and the sun to arrive, there is not a thing to catch her attention. The moment there is a knock at the door and it begins to open, she practically teleports to the front of her home.

"Finally!" Glimmer states as her best friend steps into the house.

"Did you hear anything else?" Bow asks. Sleep is written all over his face and two steaming cups are in his hands. One has the letter *'G'* on the cardboard holder. Glimmer snatches it and takes a swig. It feels good against her throat.

"No. But that doesn't mean anything. If it is a werewolf, they'll be changing soon and probably be delirious. Best be going now."

"Right," Bow yawns. He lets the bag on his back slide off and throws it on the couch. "Grabbed some old clothes one of my brothers definitely won't miss. Hopefully they'll fit whoever."

Glimmer nods. With another sip of her coffee, she dusts off her gear and collects the things she'll need. As the sun rises and the moon loses its power over the world, whoever is out there will (hopefully) not be much of a threat. Regardless, she pockets her trusted silver knife as protection, followed by noise emitters. One click of a button and the small, hand held device will stun anyone with supernatural hearing. She makes a mental note to invest in earplugs but at least Bow won't be affected by it. Last but not least, some wolfbane's powder. If worse comes to worst, this will be their last defense.

Bow grabs his own weapon, a simple knife. He has not spent most of his life training to fend off creatures of fables but he cannot go undefended either.

"Ready?" Glimmer asks.

"Ready!" Bow replies. "Lead the way."

The two exit through the back door. The sky slowly is painted a soft orange by the rising sun. The navy blue of the night lingers, refusing to leave. There are no hints of its true color and won't be for a while. Glimmer takes a deep inhale when they reach the mouth of the forest. Pine and wet soil fills her nose. Nothing out of the ordinary. With a step forward, the two friends begin to trek through the woods.

Leaves on the ground from last fall crunch under their feet. Birds abruptly stop their songs as the two walk, watching them intently. Everything seems to pause. The wind halts, which does not help in their search. Glimmer might not have the best sense of smell but she definitely can pick up more than most. Yet, the world remains in place.

The trees become thicker, roots sticking out from the ground waiting to trip unsuspecting people. What little path Glimmer and Bow have grows smaller and smaller with each step. Both look around, searching for any clues to what possibly could be lurking

inside. The longer she is in here, finding nothing at all, the more Glimmer believes maybe she did only imagine things.

Above them, through the thick leaves hanging on the branches, hints of light blue start to appear. By now, whoever might be out here will be back in their human form. As time passes, the more time they will have to recover and not be completely out of it. She picks up the pace, Bow following close behind. However, as she breaks through some of the brush, a new smell hits her as if she smacked straight into a brick wall.

"Jesus fuckin' Christ!" she blurts out. A hand slaps over her nose and mouth but it does little to stop the smell penetrating her nose. The stomach wrenching scent of death and blood. She nearly pukes up the coffee inside her. She skids to a halt, eyes darting around to locate the source. It does not take long to find an answer.

In the distance, through a patch of trees, is a large brown lump. Red stains it's fur and the ground around it. The deer is half eaten and looks fresh. Even from this distance, Glimmer can tell this most likely was no coyote, bear, or rare mountain lion kill.

Bow catches up. It takes him several longer moments for the scent to hit him and to locate the deer. His own hand covers his mouth before speaking. "God. You think they killed it?"

"Maybe. Keep on your guard."

Glimmer and Bow spread out, remaining in earshot of each other. Glimmer inspects the carcass. Whatever has attacked it, the claw and bite marks are too large for a coyote. There are no bites behind the skull, the mark of a lion. The footprints around are more canine like rather than an Ursa. Definitely a werewolf. Brushing her hands against some leaves reveals more foot imprints in the soil. One catches her attention.

It's large like a wolf, the sharp nails indented at the top. Yet, the one above it is distorted. Long fingers and dangerous nails make

an imprint against the soft soil.. Yet, they lack the padding and most of the fur is gone. Glimmer slowly rises to her feet, eyes following any shifting tracks she spots. A hand hovers her knife sheath. Every step taken is carefully placed on the ground.

She pushes back a low hanging branch and steps into a clearing. She is not alone.

A young woman about her age is in the middle of the clearing. Dark blonde locks hang loose and cascade down her back. She is on her hands and knees, groaning as her body settles into her human form. A large, faded, and tattered golden blanket is tied around her shoulders, giving herself cover. Blunt fingers curl and uncurl in the ground, covering the blood in dirt. Frozen in place, Glimmer watches as the stranger's head turns. Eyes lock together. Blue like the sky stare back at her, unfocused. Glimmer swears there is a faint hint of red in them.

"Woah…" Glimmer gasps. It has been some time since she last saw a shift, though this is the tail end of one. She wasn't expecting someone her age either. Honestly. Glimmer doesn't know what she was expecting when stepping into these woods.

Somewhere between human and beast, the woman snarls at the sight of the hunter. Her canines are unusually sharp for any human. Glimmer puts up her empty hands.

"Hey. I am not gonna hurt you. You can trust me."

Another small growl escapes the woman's throat. A groan follows before eyes roll back in her head and her body collapses to the ground. Her chest slowly rises and falls, body twitching slightly. Glimmer sighs. She runs a hand through her hair.

"Wonder how long you'll be out for. Yo! Bow!" Glimmer twists her head in the last direction she saw her friend in. "Over here!"

There is a shuffling. Twigs break and leaves shift under feet. In a matter of moments, Bow breaks into the clearing. His mouth

opens to speak but is cut off at the sight. Glimmer, who now kneels besides the woman, turns to him.

“Mind helping me? I don’t quite think I can carry her without hurting both of us. No need to half drag her when she is in this state.”

Bow nods. He scoops up the woman. A small moan escapes her.

“Wonder where she came from,” Bow states.

“Well maybe she is a talker and we can find out.” Glimmer pauses for a moment, looking around the woods. Her head tilts, ears picking up for anything. Nothing is out of the ordinary. The sun continues to climb its way into the sky, warming up the world. A new day is upon everyone.

“You good?” Bow asks.

“Yeah. Let’s get her back to the house before she wakes.”

Her body feels like lead. Heavy. All around her is a thick, cold darkness. Adora is used to this sensation—swimming through the molasses in her search for a way out. The closer she is to the surface, the closer she is to taking control of her body once more. The blonde powers through. No matter how tired this makes her, no matter how much she wishes to lie down and rest, she refuses that need. Adora continues to claw her way towards the surface.

The world around her begins to take shape. Black turns to a shade of grey. Indistinct mummers fill her ears; strange voices that she has never heard before. Adora reaches out further, seeking to break out of this dark confinement. Fingers stick out of the molasses and finally—

Adora gasps as she returns to her body. Lights burn her eyes the moment they snap open. She winches and squeezes them shut once more. The headache she has should not be worsened. A

hand finds the side of her head, fingers gripping her skull tight. She takes deep breaths, settling her body from the shock of being thrown back into the world of the living. Carefully, Adora cracks open an eye. When the light poses no threat, she opens the other.

Her brain continues to reboot, adjusting for the correct mindset. Adora removes her hand from her head and examines it. Dull, dirty nails stare back at her. Dirt and blood cake the fingers up to the first knuckle. She lifts her head enough to take a whiff of hand. The forest floor and deer flood her nose. Her stomach twists, realizing what it has ingested. At least she can sigh in relief knowing no human has been harmed.

She shifts, adjusting to having control over her body once more. She expects to feel sticks and rocks digging into her back. However, it is the exact opposite. Something soft meets her spine, as well as her chest. Adora blinks, confused. After a moment, she realizes four walls surround her.

What the fuck?!?

Adora's voice is useless, always the last thing to return to her. Any shout or cry she wants to let out in her shock remains lodged in her throat. Her body snaps to attention, her back smacking against the headrest. She flinches at the wood hitting her but that is the least of her worries. Where the hell is she?

Her eyes dart around the room, seeking answers. The walls are nothing to note, only pale paint looks back at her. A dresser is off towards the side, a backpack resting on top. There are two doors. One closed in front of her. At right is the open one. A bathroom lies within. A nightstand with a lamp is besides her twin size bed, along with a cup of water and a note.

What the?

Shaking hands reach for the folded piece of paper. With a flick of her thumb, the contents are revealed. Black ink forms words that

have been quickly scratched onto the surface. The text reads:

Hey, You

I'll make this quick. Probably wondering where the hell you are. Don't worry, I swear we didn't kidnap you. We found you in the woods and brought you back here for safety. Swear we aren't going to kill you or anything either. You must be thirsty after your shift so have some water and take a shower. There are some spare clothes in the backpack, hopefully something fits.

Whenever you are ready, come out and we'll talk. Don't try to leave either.

-Your not murderer, Glimmer Mizari

Glimmer, huh? Adora thinks. She sets the note aside, unsure of what to do next. On one hand, she isn't dead. It does seem like this Glimmer person has helped her out of goodwill. Water, clothes, offering a shower. Yet, who knows if this is all just some bullshit. Though, the line 'after your shift' sticks in her mind. How the hell does Glimmer know this? Does a friend or foe lurk somewhere in this house?

I'll take some chances. It's not like I can't fight.

Adora reaches for the glass of water. The condensation tells her it must have once been cold. Regardless, the liquid feels good against her sore throat. She craves for more but this temporarily satisfies her need. Her stomach growls, begging for food. That can wait until she is sure it has settled. A shower is next on the agenda.

Legs swing over the bed. Even with little weight on them, Adora can tell they are unsure. She takes a moment to gather herself more. The blanket around her, one she has had for as long as she can recall, remains around her neck and shoulders. It always has protected her it seems. The blonde takes some of the fabric in her hand and brings it to her nose. A scent she never could put her finger on to why she knows it fills her. Her body relaxes at the

faint smell of apple cinnamon—like freshly baked sweets made with love. Despite all these years, it lingers on the blanket.

Alright, Adora. Get moving.

With a push off the bed, she stands to her feet. Legs wobble but keep her upright. With the wall for support, Adora makes her way into the bathroom. Already, there is a towel over the shower curtain. She takes a moment to study the nobs, figuring out which way they go. Once that is figured, the blonde turns the heat up. Steam begins to form as she takes off her trusted blanket and steps into the shower.

When was the last time she got to enjoy the wonders of a hot shower? Let alone, one right after a shift? Any ache that her bones and muscles might still have starts to fade away, joining the water draining at the bottom of the tub. The soap scrubs away the dirt and blood on her fingers and wherever else she had managed to get on herself. She cleans her hair of any twigs or leaves that have hidden away inside. Even as her body becomes freed of any hints from last night, Adora remains in the shower, soaking up the feeling.

Though, showers tend to lead one to think.

She places a hand on her right shoulder, her thumb brushing against the bite scar on it. Those she got as a child and marks her as a creature of the night. No matter how many times she has tried to pull that memory from her mind, figure out who cursed her so many years ago, nothing makes sense. Only a blur of colors and the feeling of sheer terror. The only thing she knows for sure is this has been a part of her life for almost all of it.

Okay, maybe staying in the shower for longer than needed is a *bad* idea.

Adora wraps up her wash, cutting off the water and drying herself off with the towel so gratefully set up for her. Now it is a matter of changing. Had she remained in the woods, she could’ve found her

way back to the place she stored her own belongings. Guess she will have to go search for them later. That is, if she can find her way around. She needs to figure out how far she has traveled in a single night as a bloodthirsty animal. As she travels towards the door, the hanging mirror above the sink gives her pause.

A pale, blonde haired woman stares back at her. Eyes show now signs of the fiery red color that appears once a month. Facing front and with the towel around her body, the long scars on her back remain hidden. Though, it's "twin"—the same being having given her both in the same night—can be seen. The left side of her chin bears two, small scratches. Any other injuries that have been given to her throughout her life have healed, no "magic" to keep them around. For all intents and purposes, she looks like any old ordinary human woman who had a rough night.

Back into the bedroom Adora goes. She grabs the backpack, flips it over, and spills out the clothing onto the mattress. Several articles pile up. She begins to search for anything that could fit or does not feel odd to her. By some stroke of luck, Adora finds a college t-shirt (the words 'Brightmoon University' written on it), boxers, and a pair of cargo shorts to use. Though, the latter is a tad loose and needs a belt to secure it. She needs to figure out where the hell she has ended up and locate her clothing but this will have to do for now.

"Alrighty then," Adora says to herself, her voice finally deciding to make an appearance, "time to see where the hell I am."

Before exiting the room she finds herself in, Adora pauses at the door. She presses an ear against the wood frame. Two voices are made out. They are either too far away from the door or speak in whispers as nothing is clear. Adora grumbles, wishing her hearing was properly working. No need to draw out the inevitable. The blonde twists the doorknob and takes a step out into the living room. Eyes quickly spot the owners of the muffled voices.

One is a young man. He has short, dark, cropped hair and his shirt clearly has been cut to style a midriff. A pair of glasses sits

on the coffee table beside him as he watches some random drama show. In the adjacent kitchen, sitting on the island counter, is a young woman. Her hair is dyed two shades of pink and purple. The heat doesn't seem to bother her as over her tank top, she dawns a jacket, though the sleeves rolled up. Her nose is buried in a worn out leather notebook that she scribbles in. Adora let out a cough.

The woman snaps her head up first. "Oh, you're awake!"

"How are you feeling?" the man asks.

"Uh...fine?" Adora shifts on her feet. "Mind telling me what is going on? I read that note." No need for small talk. Cut right to the chase.

"Right." The woman snaps her book closed and snaps a strap in place. "I was the one who wrote that."

"So you're Glimmer?"

"Yes."

"And I'm Bow. Bow Reccula," the man states. He sits up on the couch, crossing his legs over each other.

"Adora."

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. "Anyway, I am not going to bullshit you. I know what you are and I hope you aren't planning on killing anyone. 'Cuz if you are," she reaches down behind a counter before slapping a silver knife on the counter, "I'll have to kill you."

Adora's eyes go wide at the sight. "What are you? Are-Are you a hunter?!?"

Glimmer leans back in her stool, arms crossed against her chest. "Yes. I am the one who protects everyone who lives here. I don't take kindly to those that hurt my friends, family, or anyone else."

“I thought hunters just killed at random. Or at least, didn’t keep anyone alive unless it was for integration.”

“Well either any hunters you’ve met don’t follow the rules or your pack members are a bunch of bloodthirsty killers and they lied to you. We *protect* . Honestly, everyone we protect. Humans or people like you. However, if you attack without reason, that is when we take action.”

“Are you one?” Adora turns her head towards Bow.

He shakes his head. “Well, yes and no. I am not like Glimmer. I only help out so she doesn’t get herself killed. But I wouldn’t quite call myself a hunter.”

“Tell me Adora, have you ever killed anyone in cold blood?”

Adora looks back at the other woman. Her demeanor has totally changed. Before, it was more aloof—gauging Adora. Now, a cold aura radiates off of her. Daggers shoot out of her eyes and it is as if she is staring right into the blonde’s core. Adora swallows a sudden lump in her throat. There is something eerily familiar about Glimmer, something she cannot put her finger on. She takes a moment to ensure her voice is steady and sure.

“No. Never. I would rather die than kill another human being.”

Glimmer does not give an answer right away. Her violet eyes remain locked on Adora. Finally, her shoulders relax and she removes the knife from the counter. “I’ll take your word. Sorry if I am being harsh on you. I can’t just let anyone come to Brightmoon and risk causing havoc.”

“Wait, wait, wait.” Adora throws one hand in the air and with the other pinches the bridge of her nose. She thought the shirt she picked out just happened to have that name attached to it, that it wasn’t the location she was in. “ *Brightmoon?!?* I am in *Brightmoon?!?”*

“Yeah. Is...That a problem?” Bow asks.

“Christ, how far did I travel last night? That’s like—” Adora attempts to calculate on her fingers. Stupid math. “Really, really far. I was in the outskirts of Alwyn last night. Shit, my stuff is out there.”

“Yeah, that’s uh...pretty far. And the Whispering Woods are easy to get lost in.”

“Great,” Adora groans.

“Don’t you have a pack to return to?”

Adora lets out a huff. “No.”

“Well...ya know...Brightmoon is a safe place for all mythical creatures like yourself.” Bow gets to his feet. “There haven't been any werewolves living here in a while but you are free to stay here as long as you want.”

“Where am I supposed to stay? It’s not like I have money or anything. And...not like I have stayed anywhere permanent for a while.”

“Again, Brightmoon is a safe haven. And,” Bow looks at Glimmer. The hunter jerks in surprise.

“Are you suggesting she’d stay here?!?”

“You have the spare room and you *are* the protector of everyone who lives here, right? Kind of your job.”

Glimmer sighs, running a hand through the pink part of her hair. Her eyes squeeze shut. “How in the world did my mom ever do this? Alright! Adora, if you want to stay, you can Least ‘til you can get back on your feet. If not, we can still get you settled or not leave empty handed.”

“What do you say?” Bow asks.

Adora chews on the bottom of her lip in thought. Her gut does not warn her of being endangered. She is far away from her starting point and it will take some time to figure out which way is back. Even with all her supernatural abilities, Adora still is human ninety-nine percent of the time. Alone with nothing but the clothes on her back through woods she will not recognize shall only spill disaster. Does she really have much of a choice?

There always is the option to leave later. Though, where would she go? Jump around more towns, doing odd jobs to get by? Hiding away every month and praying to any possible god out there she doesn't maim or kill anyone? A place to rest might do her some good and if this place is a haven for creatures like her, maybe it isn't all bad.

"Well, it's not like I can do much else. The alternatives aren't that great." Adora states.

"Then I guess we need to get you settled. You'll need some clothes and what not. If you are feeling up to it, we can go into town today. I have to get things and talk to some people," Glimmer informs her.

"I don't have any money. And who do I have to thank for these?" Adora tugs on the collar of her shirt.

"I'll cover it for now. You can pay me back later." Glimmer then points a finger at Bow. "Thank him."

"Don't sweat it. Anything to help."

Adora can't help but smile softly. Her chest warms and her heart feels lighter. She's forgotten what kindness is like, even if there is some caution to it.

"Are you hungry? You must be after your shift. I was about to cook some lunch if you wanted something," Glimmer offers.

Lunch time, huh? Shit. Another sucky part with shifting. Besides losing herself, coming back takes hours. Her body might return as

the sun rises in the sky but her mind chugs slowly behind. Adora hates sleeping in but there is not much she can do in regards to waking up any earlier.

“You’re too kind.”

Glimmer shrugs. “It’s my job. Settle in. Got a hell of a day ahead of us.”

Summer Sun

Chapter Notes

> oh hey update. Yeah i got another chapter queued and got working on another (my brain is a mix of go! and .exe has stopped working so eh, why not?) this one is a little shorter probably take time for me to get longer chapters but either way enjoy
>
> tw for Shadow Weaver being a bitch mom

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Brightmoon is bustling with life. Summer's air and the shining sun on a Saturday afternoon brings everyone out of the woodworks. Children, filled with excitement that school shall be over with in a couple weeks, run around the sidewalks, followed closely behind by guardians. For so many that live here, they live blissfully unaware of the world within theirs. No idea that Glimmer and people before her have guarded and watched over everyone who calls this place home. Zero clue that the creatures from their fairy tales and storybooks live among them, going about their day just like them.

As Glimmer walks down the sidewalk, she takes a look around, searching for familiar faces. She spots a few. One is a family of four—mother, father, and their two children. They look like any old humans when in reality, they are a family of wyverns. The brothers chase each other around, circling their parents in their chase. When the older of the two spots Glimmer, he stops. The younger one crashes head on into his brother and is knocked right onto the sidewalk. He is about to say something when he sees the hunter. Beaming, both children wave. Glimmer returns the gesture.

Her sights go over her shoulder. Adora trails some steps behind her. Eyes do not remain on anything longer than a few seconds.

Any new sound be it hotshots in their cars, the sudden cry of a raven, or someone yelling at others for some stupid reason, causes the blonde to snap her head in that direction. Glimmer can't help but snort at the sight.

"You good?" she asks, pausing to let Adora catch up.

"Huh?" Adora pauses, blinking. "Oh. Yeah. Sorry. Just not used to, well...all this!" She gestures towards everything around her, half spinning on one foot. "Never been to a place this big before."

"Senses overloading?"

"Kind of."

"Yeah, it's kind of annoying. Trust me," Glimmer mutters the last bit.

"What?"

"Nothing. You'll get used to it. If not, we can always grab some earplugs or something if you like. C'mon. We are nearly at the store."

Adora remains close behind as the pair turns one more block. A few more yards and a clothing store comes into view. Many are scattered around Brightmoon but this one's a little special. No one is going to question Glimmer and a new stranger waltzing in and buying a crap load of clothing. Cold air from the central AC blasts the two as they enter. Behind the counter, a tall, strongly built woman reads a book. Her hair is dyed much like Glimmer, however, it is a single shade of snow white. When she lifts her head and notices the duo, she gives a wave with one of her prosthetic hands.

"Hello, Glimmer!" she says with a chirp in voice. The woman places a bookmark between the pages before snapping the novel shut. "How are you?"

“Fine. Need a little help.” The hunter steps aside and points her thumb at Adora. “We need some clothing.”

“Oh, fresh face!” Scorpia is immediately on her feet, leaning over the counter, and sticking out an arm as far as she can. “Name’s Scorpia. Scorpia D’Ream!”

Adora accepts the handshake. “Adora.”

“Scorpia and her girlfriend run this little store. On the outside it seems like any old, little place to buy quick clothes,” Glimmer begins, “However Perfuma is sort of like you.”

“How so?” Adora questions.

“Faery. Plant one. Helps create potions or whatever you wanna call them to help heal those that don’t have super healing powers like you or to keep them concealed; keep them in a human form. And, of course, makes, buys, and sells clothing. Especially to people in your position. Though, the clothing store also is a front for the humans around here.”

“Are you something then?” Adora turns to Scorpia.

“No. Just a little old human who stumbled onto this all by accident. Perfuma isn’t here today, so you know. Is visiting family. Feel free to look around. I’ll be here if you need anything.”

Glimmer gives a nod, thanking Scorpia. She guides Adora around the single floor department. All around them, summer apparel hangs on ranks. T-shirts, tank tops, plaid lightweight button ups, and shorts for all the eyes to see. Some footwear is off towards the side, mostly opened toed. Though, the hunter spots some boots that would look good on her and she needs some new gear.

Nearby, Adora moseys around. Hands brush against the shirts and plaid, button up tops. Glimmer watches her, wondering what to do. What would her mother do in this situation? She doesn’t remember many people staying for long in the house. Maybe a

day or two but they quickly were on their way. Either they had a family to return to or had the necessary equipment to get on their feet. Adora, seemingly, has none of these. No pack and nothing on her person.

Glimmer rubs the back of her neck, wishing her mother was here. Wishing she had spent more time with her. Wishing she knew what to do and wasn't so damn rusty at what she was born into.

Go fucking talk to her or something! She inhales deeply, though her heart refuses to settle down. *You're a hunter. A protector.* ***Act*** *like it.*

"See anything you like?" Glimmer asks, walking up to Adora.

"A few things," Adora answers. Her fingers brush across a simple t-shirt. "Are you sure this is okay? I can always try and head back to where I stored my stuff."

"Alwyn is a *long* way away by foot as a human. I am still surprised you made it all the way here. So, don't worry about it. Hey, what about this?" Glimmer grabs a stripped tank top.

"No, I don't—I don't do tank tops." Adora's hand finds her right shoulder, her thumb rubbing against the fabric of the shirt. "Everything else is fine though."

"Fair enough."

They continue their shopping. Adora ends up with a decent amount of clothing, enough to starve off any laundry for a bit. Glimmer herself gets a couple items, such as the boots she had eyed-up before. Scorpia gives them a discount, wishes them well, and informs Glimmer she'll tell Perfuma she had stopped by. With bags full, the pair leaves the store.

There is not much else to do. With lunch already eaten there is no need to stop at any restaurants. When asked if she wants to do anything, Adora replies to Glimmer with a no. Thinking of nothing else, and there honestly is no need to overwhelm Adora on her

first day here, the hunter leads them back to her home. With the warm weather, and for once lack of humidity, it was a walk here and is a walk back.

Buildings begin to become more spread out, trees taking over the land. The Whispering Woods become more apparent, waiting for others to risk venturing in and seeing what lies within. Clouds that swim around the crystal colored sky occasionally block out the sun, casting both a shadow over the woods and temporarily plunges the temperature several degrees. All the while during the walk, Adora takes in more of the sights, sounds, and smells Brightmoon has to offer.

Glimmer's home lies on the far reaches of Brightmoon. They already have passed the closest neighbour a good half a mile back. Sucks that it will take time to get into the heart of town where life occurs as well as everything she needs. Yet, duty is duty. She must be near the woods. Had she lived closer then who the hell knows what could've happened to Adora. The upside, at the very least, is less noise and annoying people. And when there aren't random creatures from fables lurking about, it does make for a great hike.

"You can drop everything off in the guest room. Feel free to make yourself at home in there," Glimmer says and she pushes open the front door.

"I still owe you big time. This is awfully nice everything you are doing," Adora tells her.

"Well I can't quite just leave you all alone, can I? You said you don't have a pack to go home to and not even you can do much without supplies. You're still free to leave whenever. I am not holding you hostage."

"I guess I have to thank you for that also. I'll be right out."

Glimmer watches her disappear into the guest bedroom. Once she is gone, the hunter travels up the stairs and into her room. Inside

the pale, pink room, she throws her bag into the full size bed. There is no need for this large mattress for one person yet, she enjoys the leg room. There are a couple dressers, closest, and a large desk with a TV sitting on top. Some of her gear sits under her bed, waiting to be used. Glimmer swiftly puts away her new clothing and tosses the bag aside.

Happy with things, she heads to her desk and pulls out one of the drawers. After Bow had left, and before heading out with Adora, Glimmer stored her notebook here. Force of habit. Never can be too careful when you live in an area full of humans who may not understand the supernatural world. The hunter picks up the worn, leatherbound book and sits on the nearby chair. Unlatching it, the contents are revealed.

Dull and torn papers have a mix of graphite and ink on them. Words are scribbled about, in between, above, and below drawings. All are of the creatures Glimmer has met since taking over her mother's role. She does not believe that she's much of an artist but the hunter does her best to capture their images. A lot of trial and error until Glimmer finds it *perfect.* If anyone else will ever read these, they need to have a correct image in their minds.

Most books on myths are written by those who have never truly been a part of this world. So many lies are in them it pissed (and still *pisses)* her off enough she has made her own. This is the second one and almost is practically used up. The hunter flicks through the pages until she reaches the last few pages.

Notes scribbled onto the pages stare back at her, her own little ramblings. It's the bottom that catches the attention of her eyes. Words on Adora. A simple paragraph to make note of what happened early this morning:

Found a woman my age(ish) in the woods just after shift. 99.9% sure was what I heard last night. Haven't had any werecreatures in Brightmoon in some time. Find out more?

Guess the new journal she has stowed away will start with Adora. If she sticks around long.

Knock, knock.

Glimmer snaps her head up and finds Adora leaning on the door frame. “Sorry. Didn’t know where you went. Can I come in?”

“What, are you a vampire also?”

Adora rolls her eyes and takes the hint. She enters the bedroom, taking some time to look around. Glimmer snaps her book shut and sets it aside. As the hunter rises to her feet, she quickly re-finds the blonde. She has stopped near one of the dressers. Hands shoved into her pocket, Adora stares at a photo frame. Glimmer lets out a long, heavy sigh.

A simple portrait of her mother. Smiling and alive. Camera shy, it is one of the only photos she has of her late mother. One she keeps close and always makes time to talk to. As Glimmer steps forward, drawing closer to it and her new housemate, she notices a look on Adora’s face. Eyebrows knitted and confusion and strain on her face—as if she is trying to pull something out of the depth of her mind.

“You okay?” Glimmer asks.

“Huh? Oh, sorry,” Adora's gaze turns toward the hunter. “You, uh, look a lot like her. Dyed your hair the same I see.”

“Yeah.” Glimmer twirls a small strain of pink locks on her index finger. “I wanted to be closer to her.”

“Oh, did she…”

“Yeah. A couple years ago.”

“Oh. I’m so sorry.”

“It’s okay. Still got my aunt and dad, though they live out in South Korea. Moved there a year ago.”

“How come you didn’t? If you don’t mind me asking. Are they like you?”

“No. They are more like Bow—just humans who helped out sometimes. And like I said, I am the protector here. Hunter, whatever you want to call it. It was my mother’s role before me and her mother’s role before her. I couldn’t just leave people behind when they needed me. I couldn’t do that again.

“Why don’t we go downstairs, get yourself more situated,” Glimmer quickly changes subjects. “You still need to settle in.”

Leaves and twigs crunch and snap under her foot. Any paths that run through this section of the forest are far behind her. Adora keeps her eyes peeled for anything, possible of those from her past. Even after all these years away from those that raised her, there always is a fear they shall reappear. One way or another, track her down and punish her for leaving or try and convince her to return. The blonde scoffs at that idea. She’ll never go back there.

Hopefully, this is the right direction. It has been over a week now since Glimmer and Bow found her unconscious. Part of groans at that thought. Finding an out cold woman with only an old blanket to her name out in the middle of the woods? What a sight that must have been! Though, if Glimmer has been seeing creatures like her since childhood, it couldn't have been that much of a shock. Still. You don’t have that happening every day.

Not helping in her search is the rain that passed by during the night. The damp soil and grass is a pleasant scent to her nose. However, she struggles to track her own. Curiosity has gotten the better of her. A need to know where she was found and what in the world she possibly was doing. According to Glimmer the answer to that was having venison for breakfast. Seems about

right since she woke up tasting and smelling it. But that need to know must be filled. Not like Adora has much else to do.

Finally, her feet have guided her to her destination. The deer she killed has long since disappeared. The musky smell of coyotes mixes in with a fading, rancid scent of death. Though, her meal isn't what she searches for. Adora walks past the spot of her kill and kneels on the ground. More difficulty. Coyote prints make a mess of things. A low growl escapes the blonde. Stupid ass coyotes.

Slowly and carefully, she shifts on the ground. Eyes scan over each print and push away anything that might act as covering. Inch by inch she goes, surely heading towards where she must have been found. More brushing and scanning. Just when Adora is about to give up and stand to give her legs a break, her eyes find what she is looking for. Flicking away some leaves, a new print stares back at her. Far too large to a coyote. Even then, only the palm vaguely looks like a canine. Toes are long like fingers and sharp nails cap them off.

Adora presses her hand into the mud. She inhales deeply before removing it. It may not look fully like its twin, but the size matches. Same length on the fingers and width of the palm. One of the prints human as can be and the other, something between reality and myth.

Something between girl and beast.

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14 Years Ago

Adora watches the sun make its slow descent in the sky. In only a few hours, the moon shall rise. She'll lose a part of herself, something inside of her will take hold of her mind and only the closest star to earth will break that spell. The preteen sighs, letting her hot breath fog the glass of the passenger side window.

With the cool, spring weather, it lingers. She reaches up and traces circles with her index finger. A dull, blunt, nail meets glass.

Her adoptive mother drives them home. A trip to the store to gather some needed items in the house. Heading out, getting away from the house is always an excitement. Her mother likes to keep a low profile. Even at her young age, Adora understands why that is such. Yet, she still is a child. Exploration, adventure, and making friends is a core part of her. Just like the wolf inside of her.

Two conflicting things both making a home in the same place.

"Do not look so gloomy," her mother suddenly says. "I do not like repeating myself. You know you shouldn't've asked."

Adora doesn't answer. At the store, she had to remain close to her mother, as always. Yet, upon seeing children running around and enjoying themselves, she just *couldn't* help but ask. Asked if she could say hi to them. Of course this lead to a stern *'no'* .

"Why did I tell you 'no', Adora?" her mother asks.

Adora resists the urge to groan. "We can't let people know we exist."

"Why?"

"They wouldn't understand us. They'd fear us. Try to kill us. It's why they are hunters. You never know who is one. If they see my bite scar, they'll kill first and ask questions later."

"Exactly, my dear."

A cold hand is placed under Adora's chin. The preteen does not resist her head being moved to face her mother. Bright green eyes remain on the road as she speaks. "It's why I took you in after all. The world saw you as a monster, something you could not control, but I did not. Saw you as a girl, a daughter. Isn't that right?"

“Yes..”

“Good girl.” her mother lets go of Adora’s chin. She pulls the driveway of their home. “Go get ready for tonight.”

Adora leans back in her seat, looking at her hands in her lap. “When will I learn to control it?”

Her mother pauses for a moment. “Eventually. Come now.”

Adora sighs and nods. As she steps out of the car, she takes another look at the sun. It has slipped further in the sky. Some more hours are left before she becomes lost between human and wolf. Though even now her shoulder itches, warning her of what is to come.

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The first thing she spots upon stepping out of the woods is Glimmer sprawled out on the backyard grass. In her hands, she has her phone. Eyes are locked onto the screen. With her hearing, Adora picks up that the hunter is watching a video. This makes an eyebrow raise. When the blonde had gone off on her walk through the woods, Glimmer was inside going about her day. Coming back to find her in the middle of the yard definitely is something Adora did not expect. Getting over her shock, the blonde walks up to the other woman.

“What are you doing?” she asks, stopping two steps away from the hunter. Adora hover over her.

“Chillin’” Glimmer replies. She hits the screen, pausing her video, before sitting up. “How was your walk?”

“Fine. Coyotes took the deer, which I am not surprised about. Happy to know where I was found. Still can’t believe you guys carried me all the way back here.” Adora tilts her head, trying to make out what video Glimmer had been watching. With the glare from the sun, it’s difficult. “What were you watching?”

“ *Fuzzfeed Unsolved: Supernatural.”*

“You seriously are watching that?” Adora asks.

“What?!? It can be a little funny to watch people piece things together. I also love just ripping when people get stuff wrong. Not to mention the banter. I watch their *True Crime* stuff also. It’s a fun watch.”

“Okay but why are you lying in the middle of the yard?”

“Can’t a chick sunbathe?” Glimmer leans back on her hands. “It’s a nice day out! Not too hot or humid for once.”

“I know what you mean.” Adora settles down beside the hunter. Legs cross over each other, eyes flutter shut, and she tilts her face towards the sun. Her body soaks in the warm rays, threatening to go totally limp as limbs relax. Inside her chest, her heart flutters. The sun is her friend, always has been and always will be. “The solstice is my favorite day of the year. The day lasts forever and ever.”

Whenever the moon decides to show it’s pale face, only a sliver shall be seen. No worry at all about the wolf inside of her ripping and clawing its way out of her chest. As the new moon draws closer, the more it slumbers—the less she feels it.

“Shortest time for the moon to be around.” Glimmer sighs. “I won’t lie, I love the moon. I don’t blame you for hating it but I’ve always been a night owl, the moon has been my companion during those dark hours ever since I was a small child.”

“Least someone can enjoy the night.”

There is a pause in their conversation. Only birds and crickets fill the air. Glimmer cuts them off. “Can I...ask a question? You don’t have to answer it.”

Adora opens her eyes and faces Glimmer. The hunter has her head on her hand, which is propped up by a leg. “What is it?”

“How...long have you been a werecreature? Were you bitten? Born?”

Adora takes a moment to think. She leans forward, fingers pulling at the soft, green blades of grass. “Bitten. I was only five.”

“Oh jeez, I am so sorry.” Glimmer’s eyes dart around in thought. Finally, a hand reaches out and lands on Adora’s right shoulder, unknowingly right on her scar. “I can’t imagine what it must have been like. You were so young.”

“Yeah. It’s pretty much all I know. Been twenty years now. Mind if we talk about something else?”

“Sure. Hey,” Glimmer jumps to her feet. “I’ve been meaning to check over hunter supplies. You want to check it out? If that doesn’t weird you out.”

Adora shrugs. “I mean, not like I have much else to do. Be interesting to see what the hell you used.”

There is a sudden twinkle in her violet eyes. Glimmer leads Adora into the house. Inside, the hunter drags out a black bag, dumping everything inside onto the flooring. Weapons, bottles with what looks like some type of power, and other trinkets Adora doesn’t know scatter about. She kneels down as Glimmer begins to examine everything.

“Doesn’t seem like you got a lot to defend yourself,” Adora states. She notices a couple of knives, all made out of silver, and what looks like a retractable staff.

“Well, I am not trying to kill people. Though, I have other stuff stored away for when I have to take more action.”

“That still doesn’t seem quite safe just using these…”

“Well, you don’t know what they do!” She picks up the bottle of powder. “Wolfsbane does wonder and has different uses to paralyze or knock creatures out. Just gotta make it right. Pain in

the ass to do though when you are allergic. Makes me sneeze like a motherfucker. Do not suggest you touching it at all."

"Don't worry. What else? What are these?" Adora grabs a small, pen-like object. The bottom is sharp while there is a button at the top, which her finger hover over.

"Noise emitter. You'll blast your ears out if you click that button. I already checked them out and they work well."

"This?" Adora picks up something much larger, like a club. It is made of metal and has two prongs at the top. A button is in the middle of the handle. Against better judgement, the blonde presses it. Nothing. She runs her free hand against the metal top. "Does this work?"

"It is supposed to be a taser. I have a couple but that one I think the batteries might be dead. Haven't been able to get it working for a while."

Adora shakes it, hearing a rattle. She hits it against her palm. "Guess this got a lot of usage then."

"Hunter's best friend." Glimmer checks over more of her items as she continues to explain what they do. Adora, meanwhile, continues to absentmindedly hit the taser against her hand, listening to it all. Who knew there was so much to it. Though, this does not work out for her in the end.

With another hit and a finger unknowingly still pressing down on the button, the weapon comes to life.

"Ack!" is all Adora can get out before her body hits the floor. Her only luck is that the taser goes off only for a moment. Enough to give her a good dose of electricity but not enough to stick around for long. Though, she lets out a groan as her body reels.

"Holy shit, Adora!" Glimmer scrambles to her side. She grabs the taser and tosses it aside. "Are you okay?"

“Fine…” Adora groans once more. “Body can take a hit. Guess we know it still kind of works.”

Glimmer helps her into a sitting position. Adora rubs the back of her neck, her muscles twitching slightly. “That really does pack a punch. I definitely don’t want to be at the end of that when it actually works.”

“Don’t worry about it. I think that is enough for now.”

“Couldn’t agree more.”

The hunter chuckles a little. With Adora’s help, weapons begin to be put away. While doing so, the blonde notices a symbol on the bag—that of a crescent moon with wings spreading out at its sides. Another memory scratches at the back of her head, one that remains unable to break free of its confinement.

Chapter End Notes

kudos/comments appreciated

The Shift

Chapter Notes

> So I have decided to post this and then ch4 next week and then take a break to refill my queue and get more outlines for future chapters so yeah. Idk if this has much tw so snfhshcbx enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Taptaptaptap…

Adora's fingers hit the tile countertop in rapid succession, waiting for the fresh, wake up miracle cure to fully brew and drink it in all it's hot glory. Or, in simpler terms, she is waiting for coffee. It's not like she truly *needs* it. Adora has always been an early bird. Catching the sunrise in all its beauty and enjoying the silence as one of the only living beings is a wonderful way to start her day. The only time she ever actually needs a cup of joe is the day after a shift. That day is still a bit away and Adora rather not dwell on the thought too long.

Coffee just tastes good. Despite the heat and humidity of the outside world, her taste buds crave the bitter drink. Who is she to deprive herself of that? Once it finally finishes and her mug she has chosen is filled, Adora fixes it to her liking. Some of the hot, dark, liquid remains in the pot. More for her later or some for Glimmer whenever the hunter rolls out of bed. Hopefully she likes coffee and not something else. With the cup in her hands, the blonde plops down on the couch. Adora flicks through channels on the TV until she settles on something for background noise.

Adora sighs, the steam from the coffee blowing forward. Sitting around doing nothing is not how she likes spending her time. Walking around town or the forest is beginning to be a bore. There is only so much to do. It's not like she has a job to keep her distracted nor a phone. Damn, she wishes her bag wasn't out in

the middle of who knows where. Not to mention, the feeling of ‘mooching’ off Glimmer does not bode well. Even if the hunter reassures her that she doesn't mind having a roommate and is happy to help, Adora cannot help but feel horrible. How can she just sit around and do nothing while Glimmer helped and still is helping her ass?

All she has been able to do to return the gesture is clean. All morning, Adora has cleaned up the living room and kitchen. She swears it is now sparkling. Despite knowing jackshit about caring for plants, Adora even watered anything that looked dry as a bone. Hopefully she didn’t drown anything in the process. She pinches the bridge of her nose and leads back against the cushions. God, she wishes she had more to do. Once Glimmer wakes, she’ll ask her for any idea how to starve off being bored and stir crazy.

Adora looks back at the TV. The news plays. More specifically, the weather. Another scorcher. No rain in sight. They predict the start of July will burn everything in its path. Ain’t that a blast? If there are any real perks to nightfall it's the world becomes ten times as cool compared to the day. And well, the stars are always nice. She can still see them here thankfully, at least from Glimmer’s home.

A creak from behind gains her attention. Adora twists on the couch in time for Glimmer to appear. The hunter’s dyed hair sticks up in every direction. A hand hovers over her mouth as a yawn escapes her. The other gives a wave as she enters the kitchen.

“Good morning, Glimmer,” Adora says as she watches Glimmer head straight for the coffee. “You’re up earlier than normal.”

“It’s only ten.” Glimmer pours the rest of the coffee into the first mug she pulls out of the cabinet. Adora is a little brought back by the fact the hunter drinks it without adding any sugar or cream or anything to take some of the bitterness away.

“Okay but what time did you go to bed?”

Glimmer pauses for a moment. “Four-thirty.” She walks up to the couch. “How long have you been up then?”

“Just before six. Made the coffee just ‘cuz and cleaned because I was bored. Hope you don’t mind.”

“You didn’t have to do that last bit.”

“I’m pretty much living here for free. I have to repay you somehow. Not like I have a job or anything.” Adora props her head up with a hand. “What about you? Is being a hunter your job?”

Glimmer takes another sip of coffee. “Yes and no. Don’t get paid really to protect but people will pay me sometimes. Not to mention, my mom left me money and my dad and aunt will help out. Though, I do some odd jobs around town. Mowing lawns, baby sitting, some stores will gladly have people work for a couple days to make some money, especially non humans and werecreatures. Can ask around and see what there is to do. Always odd jobs in Brightmoon.”

“Good to know. I do want to pay you back, feel bad if I don’t. And I want to replace a couple things that I lost in the woods.”

“You know-”

Adora cuts her off with a groan. “You don’t have to keep doing stuff for me! I don’t want to be a bother!”

“What else am I supposed to do? Leave you out on the streets to figure shit out on your own? Look,” Glimmer places her mug on the nearby end table, “if you are dead set on paying me back, then pay me back. You need what? Like a phone? I’ll get you one and then just pay me back. Be it money or helping out. Does that sound like a deal?”

Adora thinks it over. Glimmer has given her no reason not to trust her. The rug isn’t about to be pulled out from under her feet and a knife won’t be placed on the throat. Even if Adora is no child, the

hunter is right. At the moment in her predicament, it will be difficult to survive. She already knows that feeling and wishes not to experience it again. If Glimmer is willing to be paid in some way, shape, or form, who is she to argue over it? “Fine. Deal.”

The hunter smiles, causing Adora’s heart to skip a beat. The kindness being given to her by Glimmer has never ceased to amaze her. She has no clue how on earth she’ll ever be able to repay her for everything.

“The coffee definitely is one way to pay me back. Thank you for brewing it. I can’t wake up without it so I hate waiting.”

Adora chuckles. “Good to know.”

“What do you want to do if you are bored? There’s not much to do today, the heat probably will kill a lot of things.”

“Anything really.” Adora shrugs. “Just want a little excitement, ya know? I am not used to doing nothing for long periods of time.”

“What did you used to do?”

Adora rubs the back of her neck. Looking back at her life, her pack as Glimmer calls it, is not something she is fond of. However, there are a handful of things that are pleasant in a way. Such as, “Sparring.”

“Sparring?”

“Yeah.” Sparring is the best way to describe it. Really, it was more like training. Her mother taught her and the only other person in Adora’s life, her adoptive 'sister', how to fight anyone who got in their way. Bad intentions for sure. However, despite that, the blonde cannot lie there is a thrill to having your heart racing and trying to one up your foe. Most people would hate being covered in sweat and out of breath but she *loves* it. Nothing makes her feel more alive than that.

“Hm. We could do that. Will be outside though,” Glimmer states.

“It takes a lot more than heat stroke to knock me out. Just don’t electrocute me too much.”

Glimmer snorts. “Don’t worry. You already got that covered. Give me a little bit to wake up some more.”

Adora does not protest. Even if she feels like she wants to crawl out of her skin from boredom, the blonde can hold out a little longer if it means excitement. To distract herself as Glimmer gets ready, the blonde flicks through more channels. Her leg bounces in her wait. Every now and again, she takes a glance at Glimmer. The hunter chows down on breakfast and is quickly on her second cup of coffee. Adora continues to wait as patiently as she can.

She eventually ends up back on the news, albeit a different station. Covering the tri-state area, the reporter talks about some town Adora has no clue where or how far away it is. The headline reads something about a fatal animal attack that happened sometime ago and the citizens to remain mindful during the late night holiday celebration. Adora does not think much of it. Horrible, sad news to doubt but a rare occurrence that happens. The news lingers on the story for several minutes before switching to some other random story Adora struggles to pay attention to.

The moment Glimmer informs her that she is ready, Adora nearly jumps straight out off the couch. The two head out into the backyard for a little bit of fun. Though, the moment she is out of the house, Adora is nearly suffocated by the heat and humidity. However, she shakes the feeling off. Nothing can stop her from having fun with some good ol’ sparing.

“So, do you use any weapons or anything?” Glimmer asks as they find a shady spot.

“No. Just hands and fist.”

“Haven’t done any hand-to-hand in a while. This will be fun. Don’t go easy on me.”

“Neither have I, so we are in the same boat. Don’t hold back either.” Adora sets herself into a fighting position. “Ready?”

“As I’ll ever be.”

With a small nod of agreement from both, they begin their 'fight'. Glimmer makes the first move, surprising Adora with her speed. The hunter throws a left hook. Adora quickly throws up her arms, blocking the hit to her face. Her forearms take the brunt. She pushes Glimmer back with force, giving herself some breathing room.

As the hunter regains her footing, Adora makes her move. Throwing a leg into the air, spinning as well. However, Glimmer recovers fast. She not only ducks away from the hit but jumps backwards and out of range. Adora draws her foot back to the ground, stunned.

“Nimble, aren’t we?” Adora states.

“You can say that,” Glimmer answers with a smirk. “That *or* you are just a slow-poke.”

“So we are going to play that game, huh? Don’t count your chickens before they hatch.”

“That sentiment goes for you also!”

They continue on with their sparring. Blocks, dodges, punches, and kicks. Adora and Glimmer press on, using all their might to one up the other. Some hits land, stunning the other temporarily. Neither remain as such for long and both stay on their feet. The shade starts to shrink, bringing along the scorching heat.

The new brightening world stuns both of them. Adora attempts another attack, even if she is blinded. She stumbles forward, throwing a fist in the air. It hits something. A low groan fills the air. As her sight returns to her, the blonde sees Glimmer stumbling on her feet. A hand rubs a red cheek.

“Lucky hit,” the hunter grumbles. “But not lucky enough.”

“Bring it on!”

This match will not last much longer, though. Both wolf and hunter gasp for air and sweat stains their clothing. Soon, someone will come out on top.

Adora charges forward, wishing to win this battle. She readies herself for a hopeful, victory hit. However, once more, Glimmer is fast. A quick dart to the side leaves Adora to trip over air. In the moment she needs to regain her footing, the hunter uses this to her advantage. Her own foot hits the back of Adora’s legs, sealing her faith.

The blonde hits the grass, grunting as the earth hits her chest. Several coughs escape her as her lungs react to the impact. On the ground, a strange sensation overtakes her. A familiar one in fact. This is not the first time someone has used their speed and Adora’s own stumble to win. When she spins her body around to face the victor, she half expects to see one of the two faces she wishes to forget. Thankfully, however, instead the woman her age is Glimmer—who has the biggest shit-eating grin on her face.

“Ha! That’s one point for the hunter!” Glimmer pumps her fists into the air.

Adora scoffs. “Lucky shot.”

Glimmer rolls her eyes before sticking out her hand. Adora reaches up and locks her fingers around the hunter’s wrist. However, at the last moment, she allows herself to become dead weight. Not only does she reunite with the ground but so does Glimmer. The hunter hits the ground beside her. The blonde bursts out into laughter.

“That was a cheap shot!” Glimmer snaps, pushing herself onto her hands.

“You shouldn’t let your guard down!” Adora giggles.

Glimmer jumps to her feet and dusts herself off. “You can stand up yourself.”

Adora wastes no time in returning to her feet. She gives her body a good stretch before saying, “Damn, I needed that. That was fun!”

“Agreed. You fight good.”

“So do you. Let’s do it again when it’s not blazing out,” Adora waves a hand near her face.

“If you have had your fill, I know I have, let’s go inside. I don’t want my insides to bake.”

Adora fiddles with the phone in her hands, still adjusting everything to her liking. It adds to her growing list of things she has to repay the hunter for but with money beginning to flow in from odd jobs, she shouldn’t be in debt for long. Glimmer insists on taking her time but to the blonde, the sooner the better.

Having a phone now, though, is really nice. Can easily look things up, play games whenever she’s bored, and actually be able to make calls. Not like she has many contacts. She didn’t have much before losing her first one anyway. Only Glimmer and Bow, the latter of which the pair is meeting up with, are on her contact list.

She hits the home button. Her screen switches from the settings page to a default, bubble wallpaper. Eventually Adora wants to change it to something meaningful. The blonde shoves her new device into her shorts’ pocket before jogging to catch up with Glimmer. Heading through town, the hunter leads the way. The sun slowly descends in the sky, the ground waiting for it to settle in for slumber. Early evening and cooling air brings many people out of their homes. And, not to mention, fireworks shall light up the night sky.

Glimmer had suggested it—more things to get out of the house. Adora thought it over for a bit, never having been a fan of

fireworks. However, how can she pass up being outside? She can always cover her ears if they get annoying. And, the hunter added in the fact she knows a good spot from a couple of friends. Wherever it is, it's slightly hidden.

Passing through a small batch of trees and through a less densely populated area, the two reach their destination. A mostly empty area with a few patches, benches, and a pond. Bow stands near the edge, looking into the water. Adora picks up faint whispers but cannot quite make out what he is saying. She can't see *whom* he is talking to.

"Yo, Bow!" Glimmer shouts. When her friend turns, she gives a wave.

"Hey you two," Bow returns the gesture. "How are you guys?"

"Fine."

"Good." Adora adds. She tilts her head. The water shimmers in the dying light. "What were you doing?"

"Talking." Bow says.

"To who?"

Bow gestures with his towards the water. Raising an eyebrow, Adora cautiously steps forward. When the tips of her sandals are flushed with the edge of the pond, she leans forward. At first, all she sees is her reflection. Blue eyes and long, dark blonde hair tied back with the bangs hanging loose. She squints, trying to get a better picture. Still nothing. Adora huffs, blowing a tuft of hair from her face and readies herself to spin around.

Just as she lifts a leg up, something bursts out of the water. Adora yelps, the surprise causing herself to fall back and land on her ass. A curse escapes her lips as she rubs her rear end. Laughter fills the air.

“What the heck?” Adora snaps her head up. Staring back at her, upper body resting on the ground, is a young man. Forearms have blue fins on them, brown hair is wet, and shiny scales cover much of his fair body. Behind him, a tail, the same color as his fins, sticks out of the water. Dark eyes shine with joy. Adora stares at him slack jawed. She has never seen a merman before.

“Hello there! So you are Glimmer’s new roomie,” he says.

“Who the hell are you?” Adora asks.

“Sea Hawk Blithe!” The merman pushes himself free of the pond. As his lower half appears, the tail disappears and is replaced by trunks and legs. He sticks out a wet hand. “Sorry for spooking you.”

Adora takes his hand and is lifted to her feet. “Are you the only one I have to worry about? Is someone else hiding in that water?”

“Yes actually.” Glimmer steps forward, trying to repress the smile on her face. “Where is Mermista, Sea Hawk?”

“Right here.” Another body comes out of the water. A young woman, having the same mermaid patterns on her body, only a darker shade of blue. Her hair, the same color as her fins and tail, is braided. “So you are Adora I am assuming?”

Adora nods. “And you are?”

“Mermista Elaysia.”

“So is this it?” Adora asks. She takes another look around at the small park-like area. Her eyes pick up on a section of grass that has several towels spread out. There seems to be a small basket near them. Adora points. “That’s the spot?”

Glimmer nods. “Best spot. Not a lot of people come here and most that do are non-humans.”

“Yup! Pond might be small but it’s a great spot!” Sea Hawk says. He throws his arms out to the side and lets his body fall backwards. The merman hits the water with a big splash. With the flash of his tail, he disappears.

There’s still some time before the fireworks start. While Sea Hawk continues to swim about, popping his head up every now and again, the rest of the little group spends their time on land. Talking, playing some games, anything to pass the time. During one point as the night creeps into the sky, Bow tells the others random stories. Sea Hawk eventually joins in on this, adding his own tales. Mermista tries telling him multiple times to put a shirt on, saying the temperature will drop. Yet, the merman refuses, wanting to proudly show off the scars on his chest.

“Catch a cold then,” Mermista grumbles. “I am not gonna take care of your ass if you get sick.”

“She will,” Bow whispers, leaning into Adora’s ear. “Always does.”

Adora snickers, surpassing the laugh more with a hand to her mouth.

Night soon arrives. Stars begin to wake up and the moon starts to shine. Adora stars up at the far away rock. Just over half lit. Still some days away from the dreaded fullness. The blonde takes a breath, turning away.

Just think of tonight, Adora.

A loud bang, causing Adora to jump. She feels her heart pound in her chest. The sounds of something sizzling tells her that someone has fired off a firework. Guess it is time. With hands over her ears, she joins the others on the towels.

“Are you okay?” Glimmer asks as she sits down.

“Louder than I thought, s’all,” Adora tells her.

“Hm.” Glimmer digs through her pocket. She pulls her hand out and sticks the open palm to the blonde. Two, soft foam ear plugs rest on her hand. “Would these help?”

“You just happen to have those?”

“Yeah, I do. Do you want them or not?”

Honestly, can she really argue? Adora gives a ‘thank you’ before taking them. The moment they fit into her ears, the world becomes muffled. Enough that there no longer is a need to keep her hands over her ears. She can watch the show in the sky without issue.

More fireworks soar through the air, exploding high above in vibrant colors. Some are back to back, barely a second of breath. Others take a moment to pause, letting those who watch to enjoy their beauty. Adora is mesmerized by the sight. Not only has her ears prevented enjoyment, her mother always seemed to hate anything ‘fun’. Seeing the explosive show for the first real time, she feels like a child again.

Adora takes a moment to look around at the little group. Mermista and Sea Hawk are together, the merman resting his head on the mermaid's lap. Bow is at the blonde’s left, his eyes locked onto the sky. He is totally lost in the show, bringing a small smile to Adora’s face.

To her right, is Glimmer. She too keeps her eyes upward, yet, Adora cannot help but notice every time there is an explosion, the hunter flinches.

“Are you okay?” Adora asks, giving Glimmer a nudge.

“Yeah, I’m fine,” Glimmer mutters. Another explosion, another flinch. Adora raises an eyebrow.

“You sure? Are...Do you not like loud noises either? Is *that* why you had these ear plugs?”

“You can say that. Not as bad as you.”

Adora thinks for a moment. She reaches up and pulls out one of the ear plugs. “Is it too weird or gross to suggest taking one of these back?”

“Seriously?”

“More repayment. Have at least one ear blocked out and just use our hands for the other. What do you say?”

Glimmer answers by taking the ear plug back. “Thank you.”

Adora’s smile grows, her heart feeling light.

Glimmer shifts through the attic, looking for the box. Damn it, she should have labeled it. She squints her eyes, adjusting her eyes to the low light. Objects take some form, allowing her to move around with some ease. Plastic box after cardboard box she looks around. The hunter gets deep within her attic before she finally finds what she is looking for.

She grabs the paper handle and drags it towards the opening. Carefully putting it under her armpit, Glimmer steps down the ladder without incident. When both her feet are on the floorboards, she shifts the box into a more comfortable position. With a small sigh, she heads towards the guest room on the bottom floor.

Night is quickly chasing away the sunlight. The full moon will replace the sun soon and remain in the sky for hours to come. All day, though, it has loomed, waiting in the back of her and Adora’s mind. Tonight will be long, despite the shortness. The box in her hands rattles as chains hit against each other.

Adora already is in the guest bedroom. The blonde simply wears a simple t-shirt and boxers, things that won’t be missed as they are

ripped to shreds. She paces around. Glimmer can feel the agitation seeping off of her. This will not be fun.

"I got them," Glimmer breaks the silence. After discussing what to do tonight, Adora was the one who came up with the idea.

" *Do you have anything to, like, tie me up?"* she had asked.

" *I think so,"* Glimmer replied, " *I think my mom had some silver chains around. Are you sure about that?"*

"What other choice do we have? Let me loose?"

"Yeah, that's not a good idea, is it?"

Adora stops in her tracks, eyes locking onto the hunter. "Are these really going to work?"

Glimmer steps near the radiator in the room, the only sturdy thing in the room. She pulls out several chains. "Should. Haven't used these in a while. Actually, rarely have they been used."

Adora kneels down besides the box. "So they are silver?"

"Yes and no. Pure silver, who knows what that could do to you? Even if it is not shot into your bloodstream, touch might not end well either. They still are mostly silver, however, it's an alloy. I think some cooper is in it? Regardless, it should prevent you from escaping." The hunter gives a shake of the chains. "Are you ready?"

Adora huffs, "No. But what choice do I have?"

Not much else is said as they get ready. Adora sits near the radiator, her back near the steel. The moment the chains meet her skin, she winces, body reflexively jerking. Glimmer mutters an apology, which the blonde brushes aside. The work continues.

"Are they too tight?" Glimmer asks, worried.

“No,” Adora answers.

The hunter can’t tell if it's a lie or not. Adora’s eyes refuse to meet hers. Glimmer sighs, tightening the chains. A groan escapes Adora. The skin pressed against the silver metal has turned an angry red. The rash spreads up her arms. In the morning, it will bear no such marks. No memory of what happened tonight.

“Well, hopefully this is tight enough,” Glimmer says with one more tug.

“Better safe than sorry,” Adora retorts. “I honestly rather be chained up and locked in a room than out in the woods doing lord knows what.”

“I’m still sorry.”

“Don’t forget, I was the one who came up with it. Not y-” Adora’s body suddenly shakes, violently. The blonde gasps as her shoulders tense and her back slams against that radiator. Glimmer sees beads of sweat beginning to line her forehead. The nails on her hand, which are almost totally pinned to her side, have darkened.

“Shit, Adora…”

“I’m fine, I’m fine.” Adora lets out a halfhearted laugh. “I’m used to this. My body...My body is just getting ready. It’ll be a *lot* worse soon.”

“Christ. There isn’t anything else I can do to help?”

“No. The best you can do is not be around me. I’ll just want to rip your throat out.”

“How long does it take for...you know…”

Adora’s head rolls back, leaning on the top of what keeps her grounded. She pants, her eyes unfocused. “Dunno know.” She

shallows. “Never an...Never an exact idea. Short, long. Anything in between.”

Another jerk. Adora whines, eyes squeezed shut. Glimmer catches a tear rolling down her cheek, passing the scars on her chin. The hunter reaches her hand out, wanting to do *something* for the blonde. However, before her finger can even brush against skin, Adora snaps forward. The chains only allow a fraction of movement towards Glimmer but it does not take much to cause her heart to skip a beat.

A deep, guttural growl escapes Adora. Teeth are bare, revealing sharp, growing fangs. Her eyes have begun to lose their sky blue color, only to be replaced by a bright, fire red. Neither woman moves for several moments, only able to stare at each other. Adora, ready to strike Glimmer down and Glimmer, her brain unable to process this is *Adora.*

“Fuck,” the blonde softly says, blinking. She pulls herself back. “I...I don’t know how much longer I can hold on. I’m sorry.”

“Adora, I can-”

“No! Please, Glimmer. Just...Just leave. I don’t want you to see me shift. I...I don’t want to risk hurting you. I don’t want to hurt anyone.”

“But-”

“ *Please…* ”

Her eyes are filled with tears and have begun to stain her cheeks. Glimmer's heart sinks in her chest. Blue remains in charge of her irises. Yet, red is waiting for the split second moment Adora slips. The hunter bites down on her lip. How can she ignore this plea?

"Okay," Glimmer's voice is barely above a whisper. She rises to her feet. "I'll be in the other room if you need anything."

Adora chuckles and a faint smile shows of her sharpening teeth. "I'll try to remember that."

Glimmer hesitates for a moment, everything screaming at her to remain in the bedroom. However, she listens to Adora's request. The hunter exits, shutting the door behind her. The moment it *clicks* behind her, she begins to shake.

She has seen shifts before. Before and after and everything in between. There have been many times Glimmer has faced down an out of control creature and had to swallow her fear. A handful of times have been close calls. Adora is safe here. Safe from herself and safe towards everyone around.

Why does this feel like a red hot knife is being driven through her heart?

Why can she not seem to pull it out? Her attempt only makes it bury itself deeper.

Her hand grips her side, scars burning. In her focus on prepping Adora and ensuring her comfort and safety during the shift, she had forgotten about herself. The own effects the moon has on her every month. The fire that appears in her gut as night starts, never fully going away until the sun rises. Normally, that's all. An annoying pain she'll sometimes take Advil for. Now her stomach flips inside of her, threatening to make Glimmer stop at the bathroom. Did the AC suddenly cut out? Why does it feel almost unbearably *hot* in the house?

Glimmer catches her phone lighting up on a nearby end table. And not a moment too soon. Through the wooden door, she hears the chains rattling and a low groan from Adora. She cannot stand to hear the shift—no need to hear Adora in pain. With a deep inhale, the hunter reunites with her phone. The screen shows Bow's picture.

"Yo," she says into the speaker.

“Hey. How are you two holding up?” Bow asks. Glimmer can hear the clicking of a turn signal.

“Fine.”

“You don’t sound ‘fine’. What’s up?”

“Scars aching,” Glimmer sighs. She turns her head back to face the spare bedroom. “Adora’s shifting.”

“You aren’t with her?”

“She kicked me out. And...I didn’t really want to see it. They are always rough to watch and when was the last time I saw a shift?”

“I’ll be there soon. You know everything will be okay.”

“I know. Still doesn’t help much. Didn’t think this would affect me so badly.” Glimmer begins to absentmindedly draw invisible shapes on the top of the end table. “Though, it can't be nearly as bad as whatever Adora is going through. Can’t imagine what it’s like to go through that every month for pretty much your whole damn life.”

“I can’t imagine either. At least it’s still summer. The night will go by in a flash.”

“True. Morning can’t come fast enough, though.”

Suddenly, there is a loud sound of glass *shattering* . Glimmer very nearly jumps through the ceiling, the noise cutting straight through her ears.

“What the heck was that?!?” Bow shouts.

“It came from the spare bedroom. Shit, Adora!”

Glimmer scrambles to the spare bedroom door. Her fingers find the metal handle and quickly twist it open. The door flies open, slamming hard against the wall. The hunter does not make it far

when she is stopped dead in her tracks. The radiator has nearly been completely ripped from the flooring, it bends forward from an unknown strong force. Metal chains are scattered about, several loops broken. On the hardwood, small trenches from growing claws are deeply embedded. Glass sprinkles the area and above it, the window pointing towards the forest has a large, gaping hole in it. The cool wind enters, nipping at Glimmer's neck.

"Shit, shit, shit! She got out!" Glimmer shouts into the phone.

"What? What the hell are you talking about?"

"Adora! She isn't here!"

"How the heck did she get out? I thought the chains would keep her from getting out."

"You don't think I don't *know* that! Shit. I don't know what happened but we gotta get her before she gets hurt or hurts someone. Meet me in the forest."

"Glim, wa-"

Glimmer hangs up, racing to gather anything to stop Adora. Her heart races in her chest as she grabs her bag and a crossbow, the latter of which she hopes to god she doesn't need. A last resort. The second she has gathered her things, anything that will stop Adora, and blots out the door. The moon shines brightly in the night sky and the Whispering Woods beckon her inside. Without missing a beat, without care for herself, the hunter blots into the forest.

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14 Years Ago

"Hey, Mom?" The nine year old walks up to the older hunter who sits at the kitchen table. Her mother looks up from her paper, tea cup in hand.

“Yes dear?” Angella replies.

“Can I ask a question?”

“Of course.” Angella folds her paper and places it against the table.

Glimmer shifts from foot to foot. She isn’t sure where to start. “Um...What...What happens if someone you knew, a friend, could hurt people.”

Angella raises an eyebrow. “What do you mean?”

“If they were out of control during a shift. What do you do?”

“Try to stop them before they do any harm. Subdue them so when they shift back to a human, they are safe. You know that.”

“Yes but,” Glimmer groans, “what if you can’t? What if you can’t subdue them?”

“Now, what brought this on?”

Glimmer sighs and looks down at the ground. “I had a bad dream. Someone I knew attacked me and I couldn’t do anything to stop them. I was really scared. I woke up before anything could happen but...I couldn’t stop thinking about it. Did you ever do something like that?”

Angella takes a moment to think. A finger drums against the table. Glimmer sees sadness in her eyes. Finally, the older hunter speaks. “I have had to make many difficult decisions in my life. Some I regret to this day still. I hope and pray you never will have to face anything like that but, as a hunter I know you will.”

“What will I have to do?”

“Well, whenever that day comes, if it ever does, you can only hope you make the right decision.”

Chapter End Notes

Comments/kudos appreciated

A Rough Night

Chapter Notes

> annnnddddd here's an update! okay im probably not gonna post for about 2-3 weeks. I like the idea of like posting in 4s, and i am still working on finishing ch7 for the queue. I also just have a wrench thrown into my life, nothing bad just enough to throw me off, so I need some time to settle.
>
> So hopefully latest 3 weeks,by mid-end of Sept ill be back to post for 4 weeks before dipping again.
>
> tw for this chapter blood and injury, bit of a panic attack

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Her lungs *burn* —oxygen refusing to enter. Legs ache from muscle being stretched out further than ever before. Branches have sliced open her cheeks and arms, blood trickling down her skin. In her haste to race after Adora, she failed to slip on shoes. Rocks pierce her soles and fire shoots up through her ankles. The hunter grits her teeth, holding back a pained groan. She *cannot* pause, not even for a fraction of a second. Even if her home is a distance away from the heart of Brightmoon, Adora is far too close for comfort in these woods. One whiff of the wind to lure her towards town. One or more people camping in the summer's night making noise. Someone just out for a late night stroll in their backyard. It only takes one small moment.

Run faster damn it! ***Run!***

Glimmer forces her legs to pick up the pace. She definitely is gonna feel this in the morning. The hunter presses on, searching for the slightest of signs of a quite possible rampaging werewolf. Eyes have adjusted to the low light, spotting some broken branches and kicked up dirt. Though, they do not last long. Much of her search is up to sheer luck. With her mind racing, there is

not much room for focusing her sense of smell and hearing. For all intents and purposes, she is an old ordinary human right now.

Just how far has Adora gotten?

She makes a sharp turn, hoping it is the right way. However, luck suddenly slips from her grasp. One moment her feet are on solid, hard earth. The next they find nothing. For a brief moment, she is suspended in the air, weightless. Gravity quickly wraps it's fingers around her ankles and sends her crashing to the ground. Glimmer tumbles down a steep hill, doing everything she can to slow the train wreck she has found herself in. The hunter only comes to a stop several feet away from the foot.

"Son of a-" Glimmer groans. She spits out a handful of leaves and twigs that have stuck to the inside of her mouth. The hunter begins pushing herself onto hands and knees, despite protest from every inch of her body. Contents of her bag have spilled out all against the forest floor. She desperately begins gathering her life saving equipment. Fingers wrap around the metal of her noise emitter. However, both luck *and* time is not on her side. A gust of wind blasts against her face. It's not the cool, welcoming one of a summer's late night breeze. This one is *hot.*

Eyes flick upwards. Moonlight streams through the canopy, outlining the creature inches from Glimmer's face in a pale light. A large, menacing wolf. Though that is an understatement. This is no ordinary canine. It has to be two, no, *three* times bigger. It is made of pure muscles. Paws contain long fingers with sharp nails at each end. It's fur is a dark, ugly shade of yellow and looks harsh to the touch. Lips are pulled back as far as possible revealing a set of dangerous teeth, saliva seeping through the cracks. A low guttural growl emanates from its throat as burning red eyes stare into her soul.

The creature from those tales from others is staring right back at her.

"A-Adora?" Glimmer gasps.

She is answered by a snarl. Hunter training kicks in. In the split second her brain lags behind as teeth rapidly inch closer, a thumb presses down against the noise emitter. A high pitched sound pierces the night sky, one only she and Adora's ears can hear. Glimmer winces at the noise beating against her ear drums. So close, she swears it will split them into two. The werewolf howls in agony. Adora shakes her head, trying to rid herself of the noise. The hunter keeps her finger on the button as she rises to her feet.

Glimmer grits her teeth, pushing back pain once more. With a headache rising, she digs around her bag with her free hand. Her brain searches her memories for what to do. She struggles to remember the last time she had to fight a raging were creature. When her fingertips feel the handle of her taser, she decides this is a good start. With it being her *working* one and set to the highest setting, it might be enough to stun Adora enough to give her more time to think.

Letting go of the noise emitter, Glimmer thrusts her other arm forward. Electricity crackles through the air as it hits its mark. Adora only flinches. In fact, the shock into her body seems to have actually *pissed* the werewolf off.

"What the fuck?!?" Glimmer's eyes go wide.

Her pause of surprise does not help her in the slightest.

In a blinding flash of yellow, Adora shoves the hunter into the ground, teeth embedded into her right forearm. This time, Glimmer cannot hold back a harsh cry of pain escaping her throat. Her fingers release the weapon in her hand—it bounces out of reach. Thick, hot blood flows down her arm, dripping onto her clothing and the ground around her.

Shitshitshitshit! *Glimmer, don't you dare die here like this!*

Teeth bore further into her arm, snapping her bones in two. Her free hand desperately searches for anything to use. Her crossbow

digs into her back from the pressure of Adora on her chest. The force from the body slam has flipped her bag to her other side, away from her free arm. Luck really decided to give her the world's biggest middle finger tonight.

Something sails through the air just above the two. Glimmer hears a *thunk* from whatever the object is entering the thick bark of a nearby tree. Within the next second, a blinding white light surrounds the area. Eyes stings from the assault and they are forced shut. Adora's grasp on her arm disappears. When the light fades, the hunter dares to look into the dark world. As her sights adjust, she spots the werewolf pawing at her face.

"Glim! Are you okay?!?" Bow shouts. He suddenly is at his friend's side, helping her into a sitting position. "Your arm!"

"I'll be fine, you know that. We need to stop Adora."

Bow eyes remain on his friend's arm before looking at the werewolf. She continues to rub the light from her eyes. There is not much time before Adora regains the ability to see. He knows there is no room to argue right now.

"What do you have in your bag?" he asks.

"Weapons mostly. I tried using the taser on her but it only got her angry. It was on full blast!"

"What?" Bow blinks. He shakes his head, ridding the thought from his mind. He scrambles for Glimmer's bag and digs through it until he pulls out a couple vials of wolfsbane. Her friend grabs an arrow from his quiver and begins wiping the powder at the tip.

"What are you doing?"

"Perfuma taught me a couple tricks when we were dating. This mixture should knock any were out-cold." He sets up his arrow against the string of his namesake.

Glimmer's heart drops. She and Bow have stopped many rampaging creatures before. But this hits differently. It feels like someone is twisting a knife in her chest. The hunter bites her lip before saying, "Be careful."

Bow sighs through his nose. "I will."

He stands to his feet and spins around. And not a moment too soon. Adora has recovered and has her sights on the pair. Glimmer sees Bow's hands shaking in debate. But the moment the werewolf takes a step forward, his arrow is released. It hits its target. The right shoulder of Adora. She growls. Though, the effects of the wolfsbane begin setting in.

Adora steps only a couple steps before wobbling. A low groan escapes her rather than a growl. She attempts to move forward but her balance grows worse. Burning red eyes roll into the back of her head. With one last attempt of an attack, her paw only swatting at air, her body hits the ground with a hard *thud.* Only her chest moves in a slow rise and fall.

"Nice shot," Glimmer states.

"Do I ever miss? Can you stand?"

Glimmer shifts her legs. Her adrenaline has begun to wear off. She can feel every scrape, bruise, and pulled muscles. "I might need some help."

Bow simply nods. He squats down to allow Glimmer to sling her good arm over his shoulders. She temporarily uses his body as a crutch, finding her center of gravity. When she attempts to stand on her own, her friend grabs her wrist tight.

"Are you sure you want to do that?" Bow asks.

"We need to get Adora back home. We can't just leave her out here. What if she wakes up?"

Glimmer takes a better look at the unconscious werewolf feet away from her. Not fearing for her life and Adora not trying to maul her, the hunter realizes just how large and muscular Adora is. “It’s gonna take both of us to get her home.”

“Are you crazy? You’re lucky she didn’t tear you to shreds.”

“Do you really think you can get her back alone? You can baby me later.”

“You are not pushing yourself. We stop when I say so for breaks.”

Glimmer has no clue how long it takes to get back home. True to his word, whenever Bow thinks the hunter is in need of a break from carrying dead weight, they stop. The moon continues to hang in the sky, morning remaining hours away when they push through the back door. The moment Adora is (half) dragged into what has become her bedroom, she is tied back up. Bow is the one to re-chain the werewolf on the radiator, ensuring that they are extra tight this time.

The only cleaning done is sweeping up the floor of the glass sprinkling. No need for anyone to slice up their feet. Now, onto patching up Glimmer. Using the attached bathroom, the hunter allows her friend to patch her up. First things first. The injury to her arm. Glimmer hisses harshly through her teeth as peroxide scrubs away the dirt and blood. In the pale, yellow light of the bathroom, she can see how badly Adora got her. It’s like her arm has gone through a meat grinder, twice. Once it looks a little less gruesome, Bow begins wrapping up her arm.

“How are you feeling?” he asks. “Do you want me to splint this?”

Glimmer shakes her head. “I’m fine. It just hurts like a bitch. The bones hopefully will heal first. Maybe just sling it?”

“You sure you don’t want to go to the hospital? I can always keep an eye on Adora.”

"I'm sure. No need for questions. Just sling her up."

Glimmer allows him to tie a fabric around her neck, settling her damaged arm at the bottom. Everything else is a quick patch up and Bow orders some R&R. Fixed up as best as possible, the only thing left to do is slip into non-bloodied and dirt covered clothing. Try as she might to change herself, she needs assistance with that. Glimmer *cannot wait* for her body to stitch itself back together. Maybe Perfuma can whip up some cocktail of potions to speed things up even more.

The pair of friends exit the bathroom, returning to see werewolf Adora chained up against the radiator. She continues to show no signs of stirring anytime soon. Glimmer still cannot help but marvel at how different she looks compared to any other werewolves she has seen, even weres in general. Most with no control she has seen growing up are smaller, less fierce. Still scary as all hell and should never be messed with. Yet, a taser should take them out or even the silver chains.

Adora's muscles look like they can snap a mature oak tree in two. The teeth that tore into Glimmer's flesh and bones are stained red as well as the fur at the edges of her lip. Her clawed hands definitely could crush her skull if Adora tried. The blonde is far too menacing and dangerous during a summer's shift. Only one time does something this remotely close happen.

"It's still July, right?" Glimmer asks as her eyes remain locked on Adora. Her uninjured arm twitches, fingers wanting to brush against the rough looking fur. "It didn't all of a sudden become January right? It isn't a Wolf's Moon?"

"No." Bow gives a shake of his head.

Glimmer grimaces. A hand cups her mouth in thought. If only her mother was here to give her the answers to the questions lingering in her brain.

"That wolfsbane should keep her out all night, with any luck."

“Where’s my notebook?” Glimmer searches around the room, trying to recall where the hell she left it. There’s a growing fog forming in her mind.

“Are you seriously thinking about writing right now? You nearly got your arm torn off!”

Glimmer gives a wave with her uninjured hand. “I’m a lefty, so it’s all good.”

“ *Glimmer!”*

“You know I don’t sleep well on full moons. Besides, I don’t want to turn my back again and have her break more of the window panes.”

“I can keep an eye on her. And again, she *should* stay out. If not, loopy.”

Glimmer huffs, knowing he is right. Courage finally enters her body. The hunter reaches forward, placing a hand on top of Adora's head. The werewolf growls slightly but eyes remain shut. The ugly shade of yellow is harsh against her palm, like small needles. Glimmer pulls back, ridding herself of pain with a shake, and wondering, *What the hell are you, Adora?*

The moment Glimmer leaves, the second the door clicks shut, her body begins tearing itself apart seam by seam. Muscles begin to tear open, bones snap in two and threes, teeth elongate and sharpen, and skin blisters even more than it already did against the silver chains. It takes every ounce of her being not to scream.

Everything blurs together into a mix of colors and feelings. The red fire that courses through her every inch of her body. The taste of cooper filling her mouth. Her skin inches thick, dark coarse hair grows to cover every inch of her body–it all becomes one giant mess. Dark spots scatter around her vision, growing larger and larger by the second. Suddenly, the metal snaps and clatters

against the floor. Coherent thoughts are quickly seeping from her mind, being pushed out by the violent thoughts of the beast inside of her.

Nails carve into wood flooring as she struggles to battle against the thought of sinking her teeth into anything she can. Namely, whoever is the owner of the growing flowery scent in her nose. Somehow with her body shuddering harder than dressers in an earthquake, Adora tilts her head towards the nearby window. The last thing her own brain musters for a command is to break through the glass. Escape away from those in the house.

As window panes turn into small crystals that shimmer in the moonlight as the familiar, heavy darkness overwhelms her. The thick molasses keeps her in place, barely allowing for movement towards the surface. Adora does not question this, nothing out of the ordinary. Actually, she finds herself quite tired. Clawing her way towards the surface, that seems far too much of an effort right now. She has been fighting for control of her body every month for twenty years now, why can't she take a break for a moment? Maybe longer?

Stupid curse, always having to fight it alone.

You're not alone.

Adora blinks, wondering where the voice is coming from. It likes to appear at random, yet takes no form. She never understood its short sentences so similar to the one just spoken. Adora wants to ask who the hell they are, what they want, but something else catches her attention. In the pitch blackness, she finds a small speck of light. One that speaks in a soft, warm voice.

It's gonna be okay, Adora. It's gonna be okay…

The blonde has heard this before like the previous one, however more so. There is a familiarity to it though a name never appears in her mind. For all she knows, she has made it all up. Adora looks

around more, searching for the partner that usually accompanies the soft voice.

We'll figure something out. Together…

The voice is deeper, a rasp to it, yet like the first it is warm—comforting. Right. These voices always seem to find her when she needs it the most. She cannot lie here forever. With a deep inhale, Adora begins clawing her way upward.

As per usual, one of the first things she feels is some invisible force attempting to split her head open like a nut. Her body feels as if someone used it as a punching bag all night long. Adora groans, letting the pain slowly roll over her. Fingers flex, fleeing something soft and warm against her fingernails. Something else similar in touch drapes over her body. There even is something stuck against her cheeks, keeping her head slightly propped up. Slowly, Adora opens her eyes.

Blinking, she is reminded about the room that has become her own this past month. The bed below her stomach squeaks at her movement. Sunlight streams through the crack in the curtains, which moves in the wind. The sticky heat from the July weather seeps into the room. Yet, wondering why the hell the window is open is the least of her concern. Licking dry lips, she tastes something funny. Definitely caught something during the night, but what? Venison? No. Bird? Not that. Several more licks. The word finally comes into the forefront of her mind.

Pork.

Though, that *still* does not feel right. Wild boar is not a typical kill. The last time she ate one was shortly after her escape from her 'home'. That was years ago. Maybe she simply has forgotten the taste of fresh pork on her tongue. Thankfully, there is a glass of water waiting for her to sip it down. The strange taste washes away from her mouth, forgotten in her mind. Adora examines herself before taking off for the shower. She is less of a mess than normal yet dirt and twigs still have found its way onto her body.

For some reason, her right shoulder, near her scar, aches and itches.

What the hell happened last night? I gotta ask Bow and Glimmer…

Adora attempts to say something out loud, testing her voice. Nothing other than a rough groan escapes her lips. Any words she tries to speak scrape against her dry throat. No surprise there. With nothing else to do, it's best to get ready for the day. Shaking legs bring her towards the bathroom, a rinse and repeat of last month. As she twists the knob, steaming hot water streaming out of the pipe, the blonde swears the scent of iron is hanging in the air.

Warm water begins clearing the heavy fog surrounding her brain. As the soap scrubs away caked on dirt, she continues to wonder what the hell happened. Something inches at the back of her mind, an annoying tick. Adora gives a shake of her head, trying to free it. It remains lodged in whatever crevice it resides in. She sighs, turning off the water and scrubbing her face dry with the towel. Getting dressed as fast as she can to ask what the hell is going on is the best option. The metallic scent lingers in her nose as she steps into the bedroom.

Hot, humid wind continues to blow into the bedroom. Adora grumbles to herself as she slips on her t-shirt, wondering why either Glimmer or Bow left it open. Even if it was a pleasant night before, it's brutal now. Eyes flick towards the window, feet about to push forward to slide it shut when a sudden strong gust lifts up the pastel pink curtains. She would wince from the warm blast but the reveal of shattered window panes freezes her in place.

What a minute…

Adora manages to lift her hands into her field of vision. *Why the hell did I have dirt on my hands?!? D-Did I?* ***How?!?***

Adora looks down at the radiator that held her. The silver chains that were strapped around her body have disappeared but the

heater looks off—the aluminum seems bent. In the light that floods the room, long scratches have created small ruts in the hardwood. She remembers the iron smell in the bathroom and the taste of pork against her lips.

What. Happened?!?

She finds her legs again. Adora yanks open the door, almost ripping it off in its hinges. Eyes fall on Bow, who has jumped in the air from the sudden presence of the blonde. He fumbles with the phone in his hands but the device slips away, clattering against the ground.

"Are you okay, Adora?!?" Bow sputters "What's wrong?!?"

"Did I escape last night?!?" Adora cuts to the chase, wasting no time at all despite a harsh voice.

Bow clicks his tongue against his teeth. He reaches down for his phone before giving Adora an answer. "Thought we'd have more time to figure out what to say."

"So I did get out. How? I thought those chains were supposed to keep me from doing so."

"Dunno, neither does Glimmer honestly. But we got you back here, thankfully. Though, I had to shoot you with a wolfsbane arrow. Sorry about that. How are you feeling? How's the shoulder?"

Adora rubs a still aching shoulder. "It'll be fine. And I'm fine. I don't blame you for shooting me, it's okay. Good to know you stopped me." She feels a weight lifting off of her chest, breathing becomes easier. "What time is it anyway?"

"Almost eleven."

"Jesus Christ," Adora mumbles. She looks around the room, drawing closer to her friend. The TV screen is black, a dirty dish with half eaten eggs is on the table, and a blanket is haphazardly

placed against the top. In here, windows are shut and whole and cold air blows through vents. She and Bow are the only living beings in the room. “Is Glim still sleeping?”

“Yeah...she is…” Bow rubs the back of his neck, dark eyes unable to meet Adora’s blue ones.

Adora swallows a dry, hard lump in her throat. There is one question lingering on her lips. “Bow...did I attack something last night?”

No answer.

“Bow...What happened last night? Don't bullshit me, please.”

He takes a long inhale, holding the air in his chest, before releasing it slowly. “I was on my way to the house when you got out. Glimmer went after you first and I got there after when you two were in the woods. When I got there...you...you *might* have had her arm in your mouth.”

“W-What?!?” Adora’s blood turns ice cold. Her heart races inside her ears “I b-bit s-someone?”

“Wait, wait, wait. Don’t freak out. Glimmer is fine, I swear she isn’t going to turn.”

“How the hell isn’t she gonna turn? I *bit* her. You know how this works, right?”

“I know but she’s immune. She can’t turn no matter how hard someone tries.”

“How is that possible?!?” Never in her life has she heard such a thing. All her life she was told once someone was bit, that was it. Either the bite would turn you into a were or would kill the person, their body unable to handle whatever toxins resided in werecreatures saliva. Isn’t that what her ‘mother’ always said. Why people feared beings like them. Because of what a bite can do to a person?

“Look,” he starts slowly, taking time to think of his next set of words. “It’s not my place to say what happened. That is Glimmer’s story to tell if she wants to but...What I can say is she got hurt one day during a full moon. Got scratched pretty badly and scared the hell out of me and Perfuma. She's lucky she didn’t die. However, whatever got her, we don’t know what, still left something in her. It’s rare, but it happens. Have you ever noticed odd little things about Glim?”

“What?”

“Adora, try thinking. Don’t think of the bite.”

Oh. Trying her best to hold back racing thoughts from bursting like a dam, the blonde thinks back to anything in the month she has known Glimmer that is ‘odd’. The hunter does seem to shift on her feet, nimble. There were a few side comments like when she brought Adora into town for clothing. And what about how during the fireworks, she had a pair of earplugs with her and didn’t like the noise.

“A little, yeah,” Adora answers.

“She never has turned since that attack, and she has been bit before and still nothing. Whatever the hell happened to her, it somehow also protected her. She’s fine and is resting.”

“Are you *sure?”*

“As sure as sure as can be. She’ll heal faster than me but slower than you. The rest will help.”

Adora holds herself tight, looking down at her bare feet. Even knowing this cannot rid the vile taste in her mouth. It was human she tasted, not wild boar. The blonde digs through her memories as far back as possible, searching for any inkling of a previous bite. She isn’t sure, her ‘mother’ never spoke much of what happened when they shifted either in their isolated home or the large woods that wrapped around it. When she got an answer, it always was vague or ‘nothing to worry about’. How many of those

were lies? Something to relax her as her ‘mother’ learned to control her during a shift?

She isn’t totally sure she never killed anyone, despite her resolve of not doing so.

A hand resets against her right shoulder, giving it a squeeze. Adora looks back up to find Bow inches away from her. “You know she didn’t want to leave your side, I had to force her to rest. She won’t blame you for anything.”

“Thank...Still feel shitty…”

“I know one way to help. You met Scorpia right? She told you about Perfuma and how she makes potions to help heal others? Why don’t we go get some and bring them back. That’ll get Glimmer back on her feet much faster. Does that sound good to you?”

Adora only manages a small nod.

Adora remains silent as Bow drives through the center of town. The window of the car rattles against her head causes the return of a headache but she doesn’t care. This is a minor inconvenience compared to what Glimmer must feel. Despite reassurance from Bow, the blonde’s stomach remains twisted. She could barely hold down the toast her friend made her so she could have something in her system. Part of her wants to see the hunter herself, *hear* her say that everything will be okay and Bow isn’t lying, she needs that reassurance. But in the same breath she mumbles that to herself, she *doesn’t* want to see her. To see that damage she has done when she could not control herself.

But she’ll have to face her sooner or later, whether she likes it or not. Time has slowed to a crawl at that thought.

She tries to distract herself by watching the people zoom by. As a child, during those once-in-awhile trips to town, she would gaze out at the people, wondering what lives they led. Did they have to

hide like her, out of fear of being found out? Were they able to move about their lives without worry of attacking someone or someone else attacking them? Did they have lives like those the few books she had?

Now she wonders who is human and who isn't. Not many are out in this stifling weather. Many that do quickly dart into the AC cooled buildings. Very few are brave enough to walk about while there is not a single cloud in the sky to block out the burning sun. One group she does notice are the family of wyverns Glimmer had pointed out a month ago. While the parents look at a sign at what looks like a restaurant, Adora catches the older brother spitting some smoke at his younger sibling. She only catches the younger one begin a chase before the family is out of sight. A few more people come into her line of sight but if they are anything she has no idea.

Bow makes a turn into a parking lot. The car comes to a halt with a shudder. "We're here," he says.

Adora says nothing as she unbuckles herself. She hears the driver's door open and shut behind her. Bow waits for the blonde to walk around before speaking again. "Is there anything I can do to help?"

"Does Perfuma have anything to erase a day?" Adora replies.

"No."

"Then there isn't much you can do to help. Unless *you* can turn back time."

"I can't. I'm sorry. Everything still will be fine. We'll get the potions, give them to Glim, and she'll be back on her feet.

"That's really hard to tell myself…"

Adora walks forward, a hand rubbing her arm red. She and Bow make their way to the shop. Like last time, Scorpia is behind the counter. However this time she is not alone. Sitting nearby is a

slender, tall woman. Her hair wavy and longer than Adora's when not tied up and is a paler shade of blonde. Freckles are scattered against her tanned face and shoulders. At the sound of the bell, both women look up with bright smiles on their faces.

"Hello, Bow! And Adora!" Scorpia starts. "It's nice to see you again!"

"So you are Adora." the other woman says. "The new were in town. I'm Perfuma Scheimer. What are you two doing here?"

Bow steps forward. "We, uh, had a little accident last night. Glim got banged up, bit even, so we came for some potions to help her out."

Adora averts her eyes away from the girlfriends, not wanting to see the looks on their faces. The blonde kicks an invisible object.

"Still always getting in over her head, huh?" Adora hears Perfuma sigh. "Well, come with me. I can see what I got. You mind running the front, dear?"

"Not at all!" Scorpia replies.

There is a scraping of chair legs against hardwood and heels clicking against the ground. When Bow nudges her, Adora lifts her head. He gestures for her to follow. She follows his lead, quickly catching up with Perfuma. The other blonde leads them to a door in the middle of a hallway.

"You leave your potions in the closet?" Adora asks.

"Yes and no." Perfuma twists the handle, pulling the door wide open. Inside is nothing but jackets and some odds and ends. "At first it looks as such but with a little bit of magic-" she shuts the door, hand lit up, and opens it again. Now, rows and rows of bottles fill the space. Adora marvels at the sight. The once small closet now seems to go on forever.

"So you made all of these?"

“Yes, ma’am. I grow my own plants and with some magic and whatnot, I can make just about anything.”

Perfuma reaches into the closest and pulls out several glass bottles of a red liquid. Bow pulls out a bag (Adora has no clue where he was hiding it) and collects the potions.

“How much do I owe you?” Bow asks.”

“Don’t worry about it. You can pay me back by asking Glimmer not to keep getting herself hurt.” Hazel eyes look towards Adora. “Do you want something? You must still be recovering from your shift.”

“I’m fine,” Adora lies. Truth be told, there is a heaviness in her bones and it's not just the bad news from shortly before. The first day after a shift is never fun and it can range from said heaviness to wanting to sleep all day long.

“It still is a good idea to have them anyway. These last forever. Here, I’ll put them in the bag also.” Perfuma reaches in and grabs some other bottles. This time, instead of red liquid, it is green. “You can use them anytime your energy is low. Think of them as an energy drink.”

“What do we owe you for these?” Bow asks.

“Try not to blame yourself too much, Adora.”

“Can you read minds or something with that faery magic?”

Perfuma gives a shake of her head. “It’s written all over your face. Accidents happen. It’s the life of a hunter and creatures like us. I won’t lie, I’ve accidentally poisoned both Bow *and* Scorpia when testing a new potion but they are fine.”

Bow chuckles a little. “Did you ever perfect that one? Or do you just use it now against your enemies?”

“Both. But seriously, it’ll be alright.”

“Easier said than done.” Adora sighs.

“Well, thank you, Perfuma. C’mon, Adora. Let’s go see if Glim is up yet.”

They find Glimmer, awake, sitting on the couch. A half eaten bagel sits on a paper plate beside a glass of water. Random parts of her body have patches of bandages. Her right arm rests in a sling, snug against her chest. In her uninjured hand is her phone. Violet eyes are wide and locked onto whatever is on the screen and teeth bite her lower lip so hard, Adora is surprised she hasn’t split it in two. The hunter has completely failed to notice the entrance of the pair. Even as Bow sets the bag filled with glass bottles, Glimmer doesn’t so much as twitch.

Every part of Adora’s being wants to run up and hug the hunter tight and apologize until her throat is sore. There is, however, no need to accidentally hurt her more.

It takes her friend blowing air against her ear for her to snap back into reality.

“Bow! What the hell!” the hunter shouts. Phone still in hand, she rubs the side of her face.

“You looked really intense. What are you reading?”

Adora sees Glimmer lock her phone shut and place it towards the side as she says,”I’ll explain later. Nothing to worry about right now.”

“Are you sure?”

“Just trying to figure stuff out. What the hell did you two buy?” She reaches for the bag.

“Healing and energy potions from Perfuma.”

“Oh, sweet.” Glimmer grabs a bottle with red liquid, manages to pry open the top with her teeth, and chugs it down. “Perfuma sure knows how to make them. Hey, Adora.”

Adora winces.

“Hey, it’s okay. I’m still breathing, aren’t I?”

“Everyone keeps saying it’s okay but they aren’t the ones who turned into a bloodthirsty creature and maimed someone.”

Glimmer sets the almost empty bottle on the table. She reaches up and removes a white bandage from her cheek. Nothing lies under it. “Look, I’m healing. And you have no idea how much worse I have been.”

“She isn’t lying,” Bow interjects.

“I know you feel like shit but I am fine.”

“Will you accept an apology from me? It’ll make me feel a little better.” Adora asks.

“Okay.”

“I’m sorry.”

“Thank you, apology accepted. Now sit down and drink an energy potion. No offense but you look like shit and need it.”

Adora snorts. “You’re one to talk.”

She joins the hunter on the couch taking a green potion from Glimmer’s hands. Adora tosses it back and forth at first, staring at the shining green liquid splashing around. Finally, she removes the top and begins to sip. There is a minty taste against her tongue but it does not burn with her heightened senses. The moment it touches her lips, she feels her tiredness slipping out of her bones. Adora finds herself unable to stop drinking.

“Wow, this really is good!” Adora says.

Glimmer gives her a punch with her uninjured arm. “See? Feeling a little better?”

“Yeah. I am. Thank you.”

Glimmer grins, warming Adora’s heart. Seeing her alive, as well as can be, and that there is no ill-will over last night eases her racing mind. Even if it seems she is brushing the fact she nearly got her arm ripped off too much. The blonde finds herself smiling as well.

As she finishes off her potion, out of the corner of her eye she sees Glimmer’s phone light up with a message. The hunter snaps her head down, smile fading away as she scans it quickly before flipping it over.

Chapter End Notes

kudos and comments appreciated!

Lurking Shadow

Chapter Notes

> Heyo I'm back with an update! I got the queue ready for the next 5 weeks. Yeah I'm doing 5 this time for a reason. So, I hope yall enjoy this next set.
>
> Tw for this chapter is some mentions of injury, mentions of death, and I guess grief (just, emotions over death). Oh and nightmares

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The energy potion does wonders for Adora. Actually, it has done more than that. She finds herself unable to sit still, more so than usual. Sitting down on the couch does not last long at all. Beginning with a bouncing leg, the blonde has begun pacing around the lower floor of the house. She cleans up the half eaten food from Glimmer. The hunter gives a protest, saying she can do it herself, but Adora darts away too fast for her to do anything. She notices that the dishwasher needs to be run. Her appetite has returned, not in full but enough for her to have an excuse to keep her hands busy.

“So I guess we gotta tell Perfuma these work really well on you, huh?” Bow says, watching her begin to whip something up.

“I guess so. You guys want anything?”

“I’m good.”

“No.” Glimmer adds, staring back at her phone.

“Are you going to tell us what you’ve been looking at? It seems kind of serious.”

“Do you really want to hear possible bad news?”

“What happened?” Adora asks. She begins picking at her turkey and ham sandwich she has created. Having actual pork and not human flesh tastes good in her mouth. Her stomach begins to twist again at the thought she has something to do with more bad news. Though, Glimmer and Bow did bring her back home fairly quickly, right?

Glimmer sighs. Placing her phone on the table, she begins to rub a temple. “I’m in a chat with other hunters. Ya know, to make sure no one is starting shit. They are all over the states and the world. We will report about our nights if something happens.”

Adora not only swallows some of her food but a hard lump. “Did you tell them about me?”

“Yes and no. Told them I had my own scuffle but everything ended fine. Not everyone on the face of the planet needs to know I am immune nor have some idiot come after you. Anyway, one I am fairly close to hasn’t answered. No one has heard from them, not even the ones who live in the same area.”

“You don’t think-” Bow starts.

“I don’t know!” Glimmer suddenly snaps. Both Adora and Bow jump at the near hiss coming from her mouth. The hunter takes a breath yet her body remains tense as a statue. “Sorry. No one knows. Maybe they just overslept or maybe they have been kidnapped or killed. It’s too early to tell but it’s...it’s not looking good.”

Adora watches Bow rub a hand against Glimmer’s back. She bites down on her lip, wondering what to do. Comfort wasn’t the most common thing in her household growing up. Even then, sometimes it would be spat right back in her face. Is there anything she can do or say when there isn’t anything other to do than wait?

“Do you…” Adora starts, “wanna do something to get your mind off of it?”

“What?” Glimmer looks up at her. “Like what?”

Adora shrugs. “I don’t know. Anything, be it here or elsewhere.”

“Didn’t you just come back from town?”

Another shrug. The potion continues to course through her body. She sees Glimmer roll her eyes. “I’m gonna have to get dressed. That’s going to be a royal pain in the ass with this arm.”

“I can help again, you know.” Bow states.

“You don’t have to do it again.”

“I can do it!”

The words fall out of Adora’s mouth before she can even *think* about stopping them. As two pairs of eyes land on her, the blonde feels her face becoming hot like the world outside. Why did she even suggest that? It’s too late to take them back. “Well, I-I mean-” she stammers, rubbing the back of her neck. “Think of it as more of a repayment! Yeah! And I *was* the one that put you in this predicament so it seems only fair. I’ll feel better if you let me.”

Glimmer ponders this over for a moment. “Well do I have much of a choice? I’ll just need help getting my shirt on. I’ll meet you upstairs.”

The hunter stands to her feet and disappears up the stairs. Adora remains standing in place, still totally baffled by what just happened. Bow stays on the couch, a smirk on his face. After some moments, she shakes her head clear. No need to stand around like an idiot. Quickly, the blonde finishes her food and cleans up her place before traveling to meet up with Glimmer. Boards creek under her weight. Going by every two, she reaches the top in no time at all.

The upstairs has not changed at all since the last time she was up here. The closest nearby remains shut, no one needing anything at the moment. To her left is the bathroom. Nothing much to note

as it looks similar to the one she has been using. Towards the right is Glimmer's room. Adora sees her shadow moving about through the open door. Then there is the door at the end of the hall. Every time she has been up here, the door has remained shut. She's pretty sure she never has seen Glimmer go near the door. Best not to ask about it.

Adora enters the bedroom. Glimmer unfurls a pink tank top with her left hand. She has already gotten half dressed. Pajama pants have been replaced with shorts. Only her top from last night remains. When the blonde knocks on the door frame, the hunter looks over her shoulder. "Hey. You know, you still don't have to help me this way."

"Like I said, I was the one who put you in this predicament. Seems only fair," Adora answers. She steps further in. "How's the arm anyway?"

"Well, it doesn't hurt as much but still enough moving it is a pain. It'll heal soon enough, probably before the next moon. If there is one good thing that came out of almost dying is I got some of your abilities like healing, even if not as much."

"That's good to hear."

Glimmer places the tank top against her bed. "So, are you fine seeing me half naked for a couple seconds?"

"Depending on who put me in bed, you've already seen me like that, more so, twice."

Glimmer chuckles. "True. Okay, help me get this damn sling off."

Adora gets to work undoing the tight knot sitting against Glimmer's shoulder. She tosses the fabric towards the side. The hunter twists her arm slightly, resulting in a sharp hiss through her teeth. She begins to pull at her pajama top. Adora takes this as her singal to begin aiding in the removal. For the most part, Glimmer is able to get it off herself but with the blonde's aid, any

irritation against broken bone and torn up flesh is minimal. The shirt is placed on top of the bed. Glimmer has now nothing on.

Adora feels her whole body turn warm, from the tips of her toes to the bridge of her nose. Even if it's just her bare back, she finds herself looking away. She fiddles with the ends of her shorts, not knowing what to do. The blonde questions herself again why in the world she agreed to doing this. But this does not last long. Out of the corner of her eyes, she notices a hand fumbling for the straps of a bra.

"Ah! Let me help." Adora twists back, pulling the hooks and loops together. Her fingers brush against Glimmer's back, just under a set of tattoos. In the center of her upper back is a pale, white crescent moon. At the sides, against her shoulder blades, are a set of bird-like wings. Pink and purple ink stains the skin, the same shade has her hair. It's the same exact image that was on Glimmer's bag. The same one to cause a memory to itch at the back of her mind.

"What's this tattoo mean?" Adora suddenly asks, tapping a finger against it. "I saw it on your bag before."

"Hm? Oh, that? It's the Mizari family crest. A lot of hunters when they turn eighteen find a way to commemorate becoming an adult and full fledged hunter. Tattoos, silver necklaces, etc. I, uh, didn't get these until about two years ago. After…" Glimmer sighs through her nose, "after my mom died."

"Oh…"

"Yeah. I had gotten into a massive fight with her beforehand. Stupid teenage shit, wanting to do more, especially with being a hunter, and her being overprotective and not letting me on more missions and what not. When I turned eighteen, I left and didn't talk to her for a while. She passed just as we were starting to fix things. So, it's both for the whole hunter tradition and to honor my mom."

“I’m sorry to hear that.”

“There’s nothing anyone can do now.” A hand finds her side. “Help me get the tank on.”

Glimmer flips around, grabbing the tank top. Adora sees for the first time the long, jagged, claw marks running against her left side and stomach. The thing that has kept her safe from a turn. It’s a wonder what has gotten her. That question does not last long in her mind as she realizes the hunter is facing front. Once more her body turns warm and it must have also turned red as Glimmer suddenly snickers. Adora does her best to help get the new top on, again, avoiding her beat up arm. Her sling is tied back around her neck and shoulder and her arm returns snug against her chest.

“Thank you, Adora. I think I owe you one for doing that.”

“What, are we keeping tabs on it now?” Adora raises an eyebrow.

“Maybe, maybe not. So did you have any idea where you wanted to go out?”

It takes about a week for Glimmer’s arm to no longer need the sling. Between her heightened healing abilities and Perfuma’s potions, she doesn’t need much help with dressing after about a day. The wound slowly turns from a mangled looking mess that should’ve gotten stitches, to red, scabbed over gashes (which still don’t look great). Bandages will remain in place for some time before they are fully removed. Though, that is the only good news to hold onto.

There continues to be no word at all from Glimmer’s friend. Adora has heard the hunter pacing around upstairs in the middle of the night. The blonde has lied in bed during those dark hours, debating if she should go check up on her. Before she could ever make up her mind, the squeaking boards ceased movement. No longer is it a wait if they forgot to check in but if they are alive or

dead. No one seems to know anything about what has happened. Glimmer now jumps any time her phone chirps or vibrates.

Nothing seems to give her a peace of mind.

Adora does her best to keep her distracted. Little things like asking her to cook with her or play a game. Going into town, seeing Perfuma and Scorpia and/or what is going on around Brightmoon in general. Bow does his best as well. There are moments the tiniest of smiles faces against Glimmer's face but it never lasts longer than a moment. However, everything comes crashing down nine days after the full moon.

With a world deciding to not be hotter than the surfaces of the sun, Adora decided to take a walk through the woods. Now, having her fill, she slides the glass door open. The blonde wipes sweat from her brow, cold central air blowing away the rest. She opens her mouth to let Glimmer know she is back but stops short. The hunter leans against the kitchen counter. Her forehead presses against locked together hands. The phone on the marble is unlocked, it's light illuminating the lower half of Glimmer's face. Her mouth is twisted into a frown.

"Glimmer?" Adora says in a hushed voice. The hunter doesn't bug an inch. The blonde glups, her heart pounding in her chest with worry. Even with her dampened senses, Adora can still smell the fear and *anger* coming off of her friend. Slowly and carefully, she begins walking towards the hunter.

"Glim?" she repeats. Adora places a soft hand against Glimmer's back. This time, the hunter snaps to attention. Violet eyes have become red and puffy. It takes a moment for her to realize Adora is beside her.

"Already back from your walk?" Glimmer says, wiping off her face with her good arm. "Sorry, I didn't hear you."

"It's fine. What about you? What happened?" Her thumb gently brushes against the fabric of Glimmer's shirt.

Glimmer takes a long, unsteady, inhale. “I finally got an answer about what happened to my friend.”

“I take it that it’s not good?”

The hunter shakes her head. “No. Not at all...They found their body in the woods. The marks….The marks on them and around...it wasn’t an animal attack...It-”

“Was a werecreature,” Adora finishes for her. She feels the world spinning around her; her head swims. This isn’t the first time she has heard something like this. Yet, seeing the heartbreak on Glimmer’s face twists a knife in her heart. She whispers an apology to the stranger for something she did not do yet feels guilty about. But the blonde can’t feel sorry right now. “Is there anything I can do?”

“If you don’t mind,” Glimmer pulls away from Adora’s touch. “I just want to be alone right now. I...I have to process this all.”

“I, uh, okay. Just shout if you need anything.”

Glimmer says nothing more.

She’s alone. Alone in the dark, ***cold,*** *woods. Every shaky breath she takes crystalizes in front of her, turning into small clouds. Despite the jacket wrapped around her torso, goosebumps form on her skin. She rubs her arms for warmth that refuses to latch on. Glimmer looks around the area. The large, pale moon is her only source of light. The bare trees that stare back at her have no details, only pitch blackness. For miles and miles, there is nothing but the trees.*

Glimmer steps forward, dead dried up leaves crunching under her weight. The temperature seems to drop bit by bit. Teeth chatter and she zips up her jacket, but it does little to help. She wonders how the hell she hasn’t frozen to death yet. Where the hell is she anyway? This can’t be the Whispering Woods, could it? When did

it ever look like this? She grew up memorizing all the species and the pathways behind her home. Everything here looks out of place, warped. The further she ventures into this strange forest, the more it changes. Branches turn into clawed hands and she swears she can make out creepy faces against the bark.

The hunter opens her mouth to call out for anyone, hoping she is not all alone. But nothing comes out. No words, no noise, not even the tiniest of gasps. Glimmer's hand reaches for her throat, wondering what the hell is going on. She cannot recall how she ended up here or why she came here to begin with. Nothing is making sense.

Why did you leave me?

Glimmer's breathing ceases to be. ***Mom?***

Why didn't you come back? Why didn't you come when I needed you?

Glimmer squeezes her eyes shut, hot tears running down her cheeks. ***I'm sorry! I didn't mean to! I didn't know!***

The snap of a twig catches her attention. Glimmer whips her head around, eyes wide. Part of her expects to see her mother starting back at her, either alive and well, or her battered and broken self. Neither is the case. Instead, a large, shadowy figure stares back at her. All she can make out in the shadow are sharp, bright, white teeth. The hunter has no time to react to this threat. In the blink of the eye, it lunges for her.

Glimmer gasps for air, her soul thrown like a baseball back into her body. Every part of her is tense. Ears ring and her heart threatens to burst through it's confinement in her rib cage. Her eyes adjust for the darkness around her. The outline of the end of her bed, her side window, and dresser begins to take shape. Glimmer digs her nails into the mattress, reminding her she is in

the safety of her home. The dark woods conjured up by her mind slowly begins to fade away. Good riddance.

As the ring in her ears dies down, it is replaced by the noise of rain knocking against the glass and the occasional bright drum of thunder and lightning. Glimmer hones all her hearing to the storm outside, letting her body and mind settle.

Just another damn nightmare. Glimmer runs a hand through messy hair. *That one was a little too real for comfort.*

Glimmer pushes herself up, pulling her legs close to her chest. Her mind fills with questions, wondering if her online hunter friend was murdered by the same werecreature as her mother. A stretch, as they took place in two different states. Hundreds, if not thousands, of weres and other mythical creatures roam across the country. Not to say they won't travel around but the odds remain slim. The only saving grace with it being two different creatures is maybe there isn't a serial killer on the loose and is gearing up for more attacks.

A large bolt of lightning floods her room in a bright, white light. There is not a moment to breathe as thunder fills the air. Glimmer reaches over towards the drawer of her nightstand. One hand grabs her notebook, the other the Cooper chain of her lamp. Though, the hunter quickly learns that the storm has cut off the power.

"Great," Glimmer mutters under breath. This doesn't deter her from fumbling for her pen. Once she has it in her hand, the hunter flips through her book. The occasional light from the sky helps her see her filled up pages. She slows down towards the end, taking a moment to look at her most recent entry. The one of Adora's werewolf form, sketched out with the question of ' *Why does she look like this'* behind her head. Glimmer looks back at one of her older entries, seeing her other drawing of a werewolf.

Still menacing, still could easily kill someone, and still straight out of a nightmare. Yet they are smaller, have not as sharp features,

and have a bit more ‘wolf’ than ‘beast’ in them. All the other pages with werecreatures are similar to this one, not Adora. Though, does she really need more questions to flood her mind at the moment? With a sigh, Glimmer opens the last page and begins to write.

Writing about the recent murder. Writing about recalling her mother’s own murder years ago when the family was supposed to met up at Castaspella’s place. How there hasn’t been anything of this level in a while, especially only a couple states away.

Another crack of thunder brings her out of her thoughts. With little room left in her book, she sets it back in her drawer. Glimmer slips her heavy body off of her bed and in several steps, reaches her window. At first, all that stares back at her is pitch blackness, like that from her dreams. Rain continues to create its own symphony. When lightning streaks across the sky, the Whispering Woods are revealed. It remains quiet as always, if you don’t count finding Adora and almost being mauled by her.

As the light fades out, hiding everything in darkness once more, her mind continues to ponder about who the unknown murderer is.

Adora unscrews the cap of the chili powder bottle in her hand. She takes a whiff of the spice, having never had it before. Bad idea. The spiciness pierces through her sensitive nose and into her lungs. The blonde begins coughing, nearly hacking up a lung from the smell. She twists the cap back on before tossing it in the shopping cart.

“That’s what you need, right?” Adora asks through coughs, eyes watering.

Glimmer does not answer. The hunter leans against the handle of the cart, eyes staring off to nowhere. She rocks slightly, wheel squeaking, in whatever thought she is lost in. Adora rubs the back of her neck. She had hoped doing some grocery shopping would

get her mind off of things (and there was no food in the house anyway) but guess not.

Adora gives a small tap against her friend's shoulder. This makes Glimmer jump, the reaction forcing the cart forward and making the hunter lose her balance. She quickly regains it and returns to a stable upright position.

"Oh, sorry!" Adora apologies. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine," Glimmer grumbles. She looks at the cart. "We have everything we need from this aisle?"

"I think so." Adora runs a finger down the paper list in her hands. "I didn't see everything."

"If we got most of the stuff, then it's fine." Glimmer begins to push the cart forward, heading to the end of the aisle. Adora quickly shoves the note in her back pocket and catches up with her friend.

"Hey, are you doing alright?"

Glimmer shoots her a glare.

"You know what I mean."

It has been a couple of days since the reveal of the death of a hunter. As far as Adora knows, there has been no update. No clues on what killed them nor any reason why. The pacing above her room has not ceased, hell the blonde believes it has gotten worse. She has seriously considered heading upstairs to check up on the hunter but can never *quite* work up the nerve to do so. Never before has Adora lost someone like this, to death. She has no idea if her birth family is alive seeking her out (or not) or if they are no longer around.

"I'm just tired. I haven't slept well," Glimmer answers.

I sure know that. "Do you want to talk about it? At all?"

“No. Not really.”

Glimmer pushes past Adora, sights set on the check out. Before she can take her spot, Adora jumps in front. Hand grasp the end of the cart, stopping it from slamming into her shins. Bags rest under the hunter’s eyes and bright violet iris have dimmed. “Glim. I don’t want to push but...I’m worried. Is there *anything* I can do?”

“There’s nothing you can really do,” Glimmer huffs. “You can let go so we check out.”

She doesn’t wait for an answer. Glimmer pulls the cart away and takes her place on line, setting the groceries down on the belt. Adora takes a long inhale before joining her. Together the two pack away their items and split the bill, as best they can. The blonde has been doing the odd job here and there and has squirreled away money. Not enough to make a real difference but it’s a start.

Not much is spoken between them during the drive home. Adora does her best to make small talk, asking randomly if anyone is a mythical creature or not. Glimmer mutters answers but keeps her eyes on the road. After a while, she gives up, wishing she knew some way to help her.

The night creeps along with not much to note. Dinner, finding mindless things to do to pass the time, and Glimmer checking her chat for anything every now and again. The white silver of the moon soon rises into the dark sky, stars shining brilliantly from the lack of light blocking them out. Good nights are said and Adora finds herself lying by her lonesome. Sleep has slipped from her grasp but it’s not like she is trying to rest.

Glimmer is back to pacing. Or tossing around on her bed. Every time Adora thinks maybe, just maybe, her friend has finally slipped into sleep for the first time in almost two weeks, she is proven wrong. Each time Adora thinks this and is about to allow herself to try sleeping a new noise catches her attention.

Eventually, she looks at the digital clock sitting near her lamp. ***3:00am.***

More board or bed squeaking, more *pat pat* of footsteps. That urge to check up on the hunter begins to fill her. She debates what to do knowing only this morning Glimmer rejected her attempts to help. But that was hours ago. Night is different from broad daylight. Thoughts and feelings change. As this has gone on long enough. *Fuck it.*

Adora throws off the sheets and makes her way out of her room. Everything around her is dark. Even with her ability to see in the blackness, she presses a hand against the wall, guiding herself towards the stairs. Toes bump up against the bottom and she slowly makes her way up the steps. She takes her time upward, almost agonizingly slow. Any board that creaks under her weight causes her heart to skip a beat and her breath to itch in her throat. Once she knows Glimmer isn't going to pop out of her room, she continues upward.

When Adora reaches the top of the steps, she notices Glimmer's door cracked open. She inhales deeply before continuing her walk. There is no going back now. The blonde pauses for a moment before knocking with one knuckle. "Glimmer?" she whispers.

No answer but the footsteps cease to be.

Adora gives another knock, repeating her name before pushing the door open. Glimmer stands off towards the side. Arms are crossed against her chest and stare down at the ground. When there is no protest to her presence, the blonde pushes the door the rest of the way open and steps into the room. "Couldn't sleep?"

"No. You?"

"Not really, no. I heard you pacing around. What's keeping you up?"

"You don't need to worry yourself."

“Glimmer, I have been living with you for over a month now. You found my sorry ass and made sure I didn’t go through town on a rampage. You’ve done so much for me, let me help you.” Adora takes a seat on Glimmer’s bed. “Please?”

The hunter runs a hand through her hair, eyes squeezing shut. “You don’t have to do this, Adora.”

“But I want to. Is this about your friend? Or something more?”

Glimmer doesn’t answer right away. She rocks on her heels before walking over to settle down on her bed. Hands rest on her lap as she averts her gaze. “It’s both. I still can’t get my mind off the murder. How can I? But...This isn’t the first time I have dealt with something like this.”

“Other hunters have died? Were they murdered also?”

“Growing up I knew a handful who died but that isn’t what I mean. Not really. My...M-my m-mother...She was killed.”

Adora hears the crack in Glimmer’s voice at the end. The hunter’s body shivers in the low light and the blonde notices fingertips gripping short bottoms tight. There is a click in her head from the first interaction they had together. Adora’s heart suddenly feels heavy as she places a hand on her friend’s back.

“Glimmer, I didn’t know. That’s...That’s horrible.”

“There’s no way you could’ve known. This whole thing is reminding me of that. Reminding me I was powerless to do anything and that they died alone without any help. Without anyone there with them! I don’t know what their last thoughts were or if they were scared or not.

“I wasn’t there for my mother,” Glimmer says before Adora can interject. “I fought with her and gave her the cold shoulder for so long and then when I got over myself, yeah, we started to talk. Hell, we planned to see each other again for the first time in *years* at my aunt’s place, her idea. But then...I was too late. It was a full

moon...She went to go check things...and when I got there late in the night she still wasn’t back...and then...then...they…”

Glimmer chokes back tears. A hand wipes her face and she struggles to get words out. Adora wraps her arms around the hunter’s body, pulling her close to her own in a tight embrace. Glimmer’s body trembles against her chest while hands grip the blonde’s t-shirt. She takes several sharp and shaking inhales before attempting to speak once more.

“I want to find the bastard who killed my mom but I never have been able to find any clues! Now someone else has been murdered. It could be two separate attacks but for all I know it could’ve been the same killer! I don’t know. Sometimes I just wish my mom was here, that she wasn't dead. To help me figure out what the fuck to do as the protector of Brightmoon...I never got to say a true apology. I don't know if she ever was proud of me…"

"I think she'd be proud of you," Adora whispers into Glimmer's ear.

The hunter looks up with watery eyes. "What?"

"I never got to know her but you helped me and did protect Brightmoon. From what I know about hunters and what you told me, you are doing alright."

"You're just saying that," Glimmer scoffs.

"Maybe I am, maybe I'm not. But I think you are doing fine. And I understand a little."

"What do you mean?"

Adora takes a breath. "I don't know what or who my parents were. I don't know if they wanted me after I was bit or not, I can't recall. I was so little...But I do wonder sometimes if I am doing right by them. Not to mention, I miss them. Like, I don't know if they are alive or dead and I can barely remember them but I do miss them…Miss the idea of what they could be...

"I have no idea if I am making sense. I just know what it's like to wonder and be confused. Did I make you feel better at all?"

Glimmer chuckles softly, resting her head back on Adora'a chest, causing her heart to skip a beat. "A little."

"I'm glad."

“Do you mind staying a little longer? You’re warm.”

“Glim, it’s been like one hundred out lately.”

“The AC is making the house cold, shut up,” Glimmer retorts.

“I’ll stay, don’t worry,” Adora laughs.

“Thank you, ‘Dora.”

Adora remains sitting on Glimmer’s bed, holding the hunter in her arms. She pushes down some awkwardness bubbling up in her chest. Is it okay to be this close to her friend? Pressed up together, the blonde can fully take in Glimmer’s flower-scented shampoo. It relaxes her body and lulls her into a slumber. One she needs but knows she’ll not wake up from any time soon. Adora shakes her head clear of the cloud of sleep. She won’t allow that to happen. Wouldn’t be great to fall asleep on someone who needs her. She fights and fights and fights to remain awake, head snapping to attention just as darkness wraps around her mind. Just when sleep becomes *too* strong, a noise brings her to her senses.

Snoring.

Adora looks down and sees Glimmer has beaten her to the punch for slumber. The hunter even has a small bit of drool slipping out of the corner of her mouth. A small, soft smile breaks across the blonde’s face. *Finally. Hopefully she’ll stay asleep.*

Carefully, Adora lies Glimmer down on bed, pulling the covers over her body. She has just enough energy to wish the hunter a good

night’s rest before heading down to her own bed.

Chapter End Notes

Kudos/comments appreciated

Connect the Dots

Chapter Notes

> another week another chapter. I have no much else to say rip other than if you have been following me since my rwby days you might recognize one OC i threw in here since I needed characters. My other oc (who uses she/they) is from an old rpg I did
>
> I dont think there are really any tw in this so enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Wow, you really weren’t joking!” Adora’s eyes are wide as Glimmer finishes unwrapping the bandages around her arm for the last time. No longer does the skin look torn up. Bones have long since mended back together. All that is left are the remnants of bruising. “How did it not scar?”

“Perfuma's potions. Trust me, she perfected those bad boys. But you have to use it right away,” Glimmer tells her.

“Huh.” Adora’s fingers brush against the side of her face.

Glimmer tosses the bandages into the trash and wipes her hands clean. “Still feeling bad?”

“A little bit but better. Just gotta make sure I don’t get loose again.”

“We have time.”

August remains some days away, as well as the next full moon. Knowing now Adora’s odd strength, they can properly prepare for the shift. The two have been coming up with ideas how to handle the next one. Tightening the chains or using chains that contain more silver. Can always knock her out with wolfsbane again. Each idea brings their own problems, especially with Adora's weakness

to both. Trial and error. Adora has even joked about getting a muzzle to keep her from biting anyone else. If all else fails, at least they have that to fall back on.

While taking a swig of her coffee so gratefully made by Adora, Glimmer begins scrolling through her phone. The hunter checks her chat first, skimming the log to see how everyone is doing. Nothing to note. Afterwards, she pulls up her notes. Her list of things to do stare back at her. Most are checking up on others, seeing if they need help with anything. Others are more of your usual errands, such as getting gas and getting the mail. Gonna be a boring day.

"Hey, Adora."

Out of the corner of her eye, she catches Adora flinching. Glimmer sets her mug down on the counter. "You okay?"

"Yeah...yeah. I'm fine." Adora waves her off. "What's up?"

"Are you busy at all today? Any odd jobs on the agenda?"

"Not today. I've done a good amount already so there's not much right now. What's up?"

"I have to do some stuff if you want to come with. Whaddaya say? It is boring stuff though."

"Oh, sure! I don't mind coming along at all."

Glimmer smiles, joy filling her body. Despite spending a fair amount of time with Adora already, given the circumstances, the thought of being with her all day warms her. She feels as giddy as a child but she keeps it all inside. They spend the rest of the morning chit-chatting away. Little things about anything that comes to their minds. The weather, random shows they've been watching, or what they shall be having for dinner later in the day. Once their food is finished and plates are clean, the pair heads out for the day.

The first stop is to visit others. Some creatures of myth have moved here throughout the couple years Glimmer has been the protector. Always good to make sure all is well. While the night she confessed her internal struggle to Adora has eased a weight off her shoulders, the murder lingers in her mind. Next to humans, hunters will be the main target of attacks–from revenge to simply wanting to gain control of an area. This does not mean other creatures are safe from any attacks or harm.

Glimmer heads mostly for stores like the one Perfuma and Scopria own. Everyone seems well and no one has anything to note. No one has heard about the murder which is good. No need to start any sort of panic and worry. Adora enjoys herself during this time. The blonde gets more words in than the hunter, quickly getting to know others. She hits it off with many they meet, her warmth instantly winning them over. A satyr who runs a small sweet shop allows Adora to take her pick of candy. Though, Glimmer ends up needing to help her choose as she is quite indecisive. A king sized chocolate bar is what they settle on.

"Well, good to know that doesn't kill you," Glimmer states as they walk out of the building. Adora has already taken a large bite out of the sweet. "Are you even going to enjoy that?"

Adora mumbles something through a mouthful of chewed up chocolate. Glimmer raises an eyebrow, a hand on her hip. Adora takes the hint and swallows before repeating herself. "I *am* enjoying it. I haven't had chocolate in a long while, I've just missed it."

"Good thing to know. I'll add it to the shopping list next time."

Adora fumbles with the wrapper, ripping it off. She breaks off a small bit of chocolate from the unbitten end. "Have some!"

"Are you sure?"

"Totally! Take it!"

Glimmer takes the broken off piece of chocolate and pops it into her mouth. She hums as it slowly melts against her tongue. Adora, meanwhile, continues to chow down on the bar. Glimmer resists the urge at an obvious jab on how the blonde is eating. She deletes her first set of bullet points off of her phone as they walk towards the car. The trip to the post office isn't terribly long and the pair make it in no time at all.

Glimmer is not expecting much. Some junk mail, random bills– what you usually expect. However, she is surprised to receive a box wrapped in brown paper and string. She looks at the sticker, seeing it has come all the way from the other side of earth.

"My dad sent me something." When she notices Adora looking, Glimmer gives her the box to hold.

"You got any idea what's in here?" Adora asks. She turns the box around in her hands.

"Dunno. Can be anything honestly. My dad can be like that. We can open it when we get home."

When the pair returns home, Glimmer takes a seat on the sofa, plopping the box down in front of her. She hears Adora shuffling around behind her, placing all the letters on the dining table. With her knife, Glimmer breaks the rope around the wrapped box before tearing off the paper. Tape is now all over the slits on top of the box. The hunter groans, pinching the bridge of her nose. "Dad sure loves to be a little shit."

Once more, she uses her knife to gain access to her mail. Thankfully, her father does not continue his trolling. There are several items resting inside along with a piece of paper folded up into threes. Glimmer pulls it out first, seeing what has been scribbled on.

Dear Glimmer;

Hope you and that new roommate of yours are doing well and keeping out of trouble. Figured you two could have a care

package. Hopefully there are things both of you like here. Your aunt and I are playing on visiting eventually. Keep in touch!

Love,

Your Old Man.

"Dad sent me some stuff. He and my aunt do it every now and again. There is stuff for you also," Glimmer tells Adora.

"Wait, what? Really?"

Adora hops over the back of the couch, plopping right besides Glimmer. There is a little bounce on the cushions from her weight. Glimmer drags the table closer, wood scraping against wood. Together, they shift through the cardboard box. Snacks, ground up coffee, cooking goods, and a deck of cards among other things. At the bottom of the box is a brand new, leather notebook with the letters *'G'* and *'M'* inscribed on the front. Glimmer removes the book and flips through the page. All crisp and blank, waiting to be stained by ink and lead.

"A new notebook?" Adora asks.

"Yeah. My dad had good timing. I needed a new one. I ran out of pages."

"What do you even use the notebooks for?"

"Journals. A little before I came back to Brightmoon I started to keep track of all the creatures I met. Copied some of my mom's old notes I could find and put in things from memory beforehand or from other hunters. You're...kind of in there."

"I am?" Adora's eyes go wide.

"I mean meeting a random woman in the middle of the woods, naked, the night after a full moon. ..I think that warrants being in the journal. Trust me, it's nothing bad, I swear on my life. If you don't believe me, I think I'll allow you permission to look at it."

"Maybe. I've always tried to avoid seeing what I look like when I shift."

"That's more than fair." Glimmer places the book back in the box before standing up. "Dinner time. Your turn to cook."

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4 Years Ago

A low groan escapes Adora as she returns to reality. Cold stone presses against her cheek. A shiver runs down her spine. Blinking, she opens her eyes. The barren, abandoned basement stares back at her. She was lucky to find this place and even luckier she has remained here. Guess nothing caught her attention. Though, by the looks of the claw marks on the flooring and walls, it was not entirely uneventful. She wonders how long she has been down here, the last thing she clearly recalls is step down creaking steps. The small, two paned window gives her little information as clouds cover the sky.

Adora pushes herself off, peeling herself off of the ground. Her body shivers from the cold air that blows through the break in the glass. Hands rub against her bare arms. Where did she put her bag? The blonde scans the area, trying to remember. Under the stairs, she spots the strap. Unsure of her legs, she crawls towards the opening. Adora flips open the top and dumps everything onto the ground.

She has had the bag for about a year now, having found it after a shift. Though, it was more like someone *left* it for her. Adora was hesitant to take it at first, having no idea who in the world would leave her this, but it has become one of her most important items, easing some struggles in her life. The only hint to the previous owner, a rich perfume with a hint of roses, has long since been replaced by her own scent.

Despite the size of the bag, Adora has learned how to stuff as much as humanly possible inside. Her wallet, enough clothing that she isn't at some random laundromat all the time, and of course, her blanket. It has been with her forever and the thought of leaving it behind under any circumstances always has left a bad taste in her mouth. Adora slips on the warmest clothing she has. She laces up winter boots tight before shoving unused items back in the bag.

Time to go, Adora , she tells herself. At the foot of the stairs she finds the first couple steps of rotting wood have crumbled from her previous weight. Carefully, she hops over them and onto steady boards, though even they do not like her pressing down on them. She unlocks the door, a small precaution from last night, and walks through the dusty house. Adora wonders how long it has been since anyone last called this place home. Running a gloved finger against a table, it has been a *long* time. At least it saved her ass last night. Shifts this time of the year, during this month of all months, are the worst and most unpredictable.

Stepping out, she finds out the grey world has brought down several inches of snow and continues to do so. Adora takes a quick look around, ensuring there are no prying eyes. When the coast is clear, she presses a foot against the crisp, crunchy snow.

The town she has found herself in is not much to note. Barely would make a *blip* on anyone's GPS. Homes spaced somewhat apart, a couple abandoned buildings, one park, and a small town center. So far, no one has questioned a random stranger being here. Adora doesn't plan on staying long. Once she eats it off to the bus stop to figure out her next course of action. Maybe going somewhere not freezing cold. That'll do little to help her shifts, however.

A sharp gust of wind cuts straight through her. Adora winces, burying her face in the collar of her jacket. She quickens her pace, careful not to slip on hidden ice. Eyes search for any shelter away from the frigid temperatures as she enters town. Bookstore, dollar tree, a supermarket. Adora grumbles before finally finding what

she is looking for. A small little restaurant. She quickly dips into the building. Heat wraps around her like a cozy blanket.

Not many people have taken refuge here. There seems to be only two people taking care of everyone inside. One of them tells Adora to take a seat wherever she pleases. A nice corner booth seems good. She plops down and looks at the menu. The moment her eyes land on all the types of food, her stomach growls. Everything looks so good but she also must remain on budget. Damn it.

"So what can I get you today, ma'am."

Adora looks up and finds a young man, not much older than her. His dark red hair is a mess, ends tied back in a small ponytail. He has some stubble on his pale face and dark blue eyes stare back at her. The tag against his chest reads *Garnet.*

"Maybe a water? Still deciding on food."

"Coming right up!" he runs off. Adora wonders with the gloomy weather outside how in the world he can be so chipper. She digs into her bag and checks her wallet before settling on a cheese burger.

"Here you go! You look like you had a rough night, do you want anything to drink?"

"You don't even know how old I am. Can't you get in trouble for that?" *Please don't ask to card me anyway. I don't have ID.*

Garnet shrugs. "You look about my age. How old are ya if you don't mind me asking?"

"I turned twenty-one about a week ago, so I could legally have a drink if I wanted to. But I don't. Water is fine."

"Oh, hey I had mine last week also! I hope you had a good one. Okay, so what would you like?"

Adora tells him what she wants and once more, he disappears. She sighs and leans against the cushion back of her seat. *Tck.* A hand rubs against her right shoulder. *I don't remember the last time I enjoyed my birthday.*

Adora stares out the window, watching the snow continue to trickle down from the sky. Looks like it has gotten heavier. Soon, the snow will cover her tracks before melting when warmth returns, totally erasing her presence here. It'll be like she was never here. Part of her wishes to stay longer. Both for better weather and to remain in one place for a while, possibly settle down. Even as a child, she never stayed in one place for terribly long. But who the hell would want to keep a monster like her?

Garnet returns with her food. Adora resists the urge to gobble it all down. Her stomach didn't want much last night before the shift and now, it is *begging* for food to be put into it. Adora takes her time no matter how loud her rumbles get. Though, as she chows down, they go quiet. When she takes her last bite, she debates ordering some desert but ultimately decides against it.

"You know, I never seen your face in town before? You new?" Garnet asks as he returns with the check. "Sorry for all the questions, we just don't see many fresh faces."

"I'm just passing through. Don't plan on staying long."

"Really?" Garnet takes a moment to look out the frosting window. His dark eyebrows knit together. "A snowstorm is brewing. Traveling around in this weather is going to be rough. You really want to do that?"

No. "Yeah. Thank you for your concern though. I'll be fine." *This is nothing new, even if it's annoying.*

Adora pulls out the money needed, giving a little extra for a tip, before heading out. The cold air cuts her again like a knife. She shudders as she trudges through the snow, salt, and ice to the bus stop. Flurries have been blown onto the bench, which she

brushes off with the sleeve of her jacket. She sits down on the cold metal, waiting for the bus to take her who knows where.

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Adora rubs the soft towel against her head, turning wet to damp. She can still feel the steam on her body as she exits the bathroom. The sun fills the room in a bright light. By some stroke of luck, andlearning from last time, it seems nothing wrong has happened last night. The window remains fixed and Adora woke up with no blood and/or dirt on her skin. Though, she will need confirmation from Glimmer about this. With no idea past getting ready with stronger silver chains and some wolfsbane as a backup, best to make sure. She just has to find the hunter.

Though, it does not take long to do so.

What the hell? Adora blinks as she looks down at the ground. On the floor at the foot of her bed, is Glimmer flat on her back. The blonde failed to notice her as she went into the bathroom. Her brand new notebook covers half her face while she snores, mouth wide open and drool escaping out of one corner. A pen rests beside her left hand while her right is draped over her stomach. One leg is bent upward. While staring at her, Glimmer mumbles something in her sleep that Adora does not understand. The blonde can't help but chuckle a little.

Adora gives Glimmer a small nudge with her foot. The hunter does not respond, only snoring a little louder. Adora rolls her eyes before attempting to speak. It takes her a couple tries before getting her friend's name out. Still, nothing. *Damn, she's a heavy sleeper.*

She taps a finger against her chin, thinking what is the best course of action. Should she try nudging her again? Make a loud noise or wait until her voice fully comes back? Simply let her sleep? Many options crop up in her head, all good and bad. When a drop of water from her damp hair rolls down her cheek, Adora settles on what she wants to do.

Adora pulls the towel off from around her neck, hovers it over the sleeping woman for a moment, before letting gravity take a hold of it. The damp, heavy cloth smacks against Glimmer's face. This wakes the hunter up. The towel and notebook slip off her face as she snaps her head around.

"Huh? Wha? Who's there?" Her eyes land on Adora, who has a large smile on her face. Blinking, she says, "'Dora?"

"Morning, Sunshine," Adora snickers.

"Did you have to wake me up like that?"

"You weren't waking up any other way. Need help? Why the hell were you sleeping on the ground anyway?"

"Too lazy to go upstairs. I was up all night keeping an eye on you and after putting you to bed, I wanted to be close to you in case you needed something. It's no big deal at all."

"Well, let me return the favor. C'mon." Adora sticks out her hand. She sticks out her hand. Glimmer takes the offer and is helped onto her feet. The hunter dusts herself off before snatching her journal and pen from off the ground.

"How long have you been up?"

"Not that long. Just got out of the shower. I guess nothing bad happened last night?"

"No," Glimmer shakes her head. "Chains held up just fine. The wolfsbane was a lower dose than what Bow shot you with so you weren't knocked out. Growled at me a little but didn't try to escape or anything. How are you feeling? Any side effects?"

Adora thinks for a moment, remembering back to her awakening. "Definitely felt a little itchy, mostly around my arms. But other than that, nothing I am not used to."

Glimmer scribbles that in her notebook. She then snaps it shut before tossing it on the bed. “Well, that’s good then. If you don’t mind, I’m going to go get changed. I’ll be down in a minute.”

She dips out of the room. Adora hears Glimmer’s footfall up the stairs, followed by the opening and shutting of her door. A soft smile makes its way across the blonde’s face. While putting her towel away and the hunter’s book on the end table, she cannot get Glimmer out of her mind. It was surprising to see her sprawled out on the ground. But knowing she did it to ensure Adora’s own safety and needs warms her heart.

It’s nice to be around Glimmer.

No, no! Don’t think like that, Adora!

She slaps the sides of her face, snapping out of the thought that was quickly forming in her mind. For good measure, Adora shakes her head to rid the emotion fluttering in her chest. Glimmer is a good friend to have, something she has not had in so long (if *ever*). And she is just *that.* Being close to someone, even if they know all about this curse that has afflicted her since childhood, never ends well. Isn’t that what was in every children’s book? Werewolves are monsters? Her adoptive made sure never to allow close connections aside from their small pack just for that reason and more.

Why would Glimmer want to be with the same thing that killed her mother anyway?

Adora inhales deeply, holding it in her chest until her heart returns to a normal rhythm. For now, the relationship the two have is more than she can ever ask for. Once she gets more money and items and a new bag, she can always leave if worse comes to worse and forget all about Brightmoon. But, for now, she *has* to remind herself one step at a time. Her overthinking will be no good for anyone.

Once she doesn't feel her heart hammering away in her chest, she exits the room. The faint noise of Glimmer's shuffling continues to fill her ears. It won't be long before the hunter returns downstairs already for the day. The previous morning, the two decided on meeting up with Perfuma and Scorpia. Some brunch with some friends. While she waits, Adora takes some sips of an energy potion. She has learned her lesson about taking too much at once.

"I take it you like those better than coffee?" Glimmer's voice says behind her.

Adora turns around, facing the hunter. There is nothing unusual about her appearance except that she has failed to brush out her hair. Her pink dyed locks stick all over and she can see hints of black trying to show its face.

"Yeah. They're good. And you're going out like that?"

Glimmer shrugs before snatching her keys off of the table, swinging them around her index finger. "Yeah. It's only Perfuma and Scorpia. It's the morning after the full moon, who cares? If you are ready, let's go."

When Adora and Glimmer reach the brunch spot, Perfuma and Scorpia are already seated at a table, waiting for their arrival. Upon seeing the pair, Perfuma waves them over. The pair happily take a seat with them. While waiting for the waiter, the small group of friends catch up on the time they have been apart. When no one is looking, Perfuma even shows off some of her magic, making the closed flower bloom, revealing a bright daisy.

Adora laughs along with everyone else, enjoying the morning out. With the night of the attack now a month out, much of her worry has been forgotten. She can allow her some moments like these.

The sound of the bell ring catches Adora's attention. She looks towards the closing door and sees a new face walking into the building. Someone roughly her age and a bit taller. Jet black hair

falls down to their chin, bangs hang above green eyes. They wear a tank top, revealing scars all over toned arms, and fingerless gloves cover their hands. Adora cannot read the expression on their face as they look around the room.

“Hey, Glim,” Adora gives a small tap against Glimmer’s arm, “who’s that?”

The hunter, chewing on a straw, leans back in her chair. She raises an eyebrow. “Dunno. Never seen them before. Have you guys?”

Perfuma and Scorpia shake their heads. The stranger's eyes continue to scan the area until they land on the group, specifically Glimmer. After several moments of being locked onto the hunter, they walk over to the table, stopping only a couple feet away.

“Are you Glimmer Mizari?” they ask.

Glimmer let’s the front legs of her chair hit the tile ground. “Yes? Who are you?”

“You don’t but I met your mother once. You look like her. My name is Petra Maritimus.”

Glimmer’s eyes go wide. “You knew my mom. Okay, wait, wait, wait.” She spins her chair around to get a better look at Petra. “Back to my question. Who are you? And why are you looking for me?”

Petra looks at the table. When their eyes land on Adora, the blonde can’t help but give a little wave. Petra turns their sights back on Glimmer. “Do they know your profession?”

“Yes. I assume that is why you are coming to me. What’s up?”

“I don’t think it’s best to talk in such a public space. Can we talk somewhere else?”

“We can go back to my place but I am in the middle of eating. Do you mind waiting?”

“No. Tell me when you are ready to talk.” Petra turns their head to the counter before stepping towards it. As the conversion between them and the person manning the station begins, everyone looks back at one another.

“That was a little weird,” Scorpia breaks the silence.

“What do you think that was about?” Perfuma asks.

“Don’t know. It’s not the first time someone randomly has come up to me. Though not many have said to have met my mom, just heard of her,” Glimmer answers. She’s back to chewing on her straw. “Did you get any read on them, Adora?”

Adora shakes her head. All she can smell is the food being cooked and the confusion coming from everyone at the table. Heck, when Petra came over, all that entered her nose was a slight, musky order. “I have no clue. What do you think they want? Seemed pretty serious.”

“Help maybe. Could be anything, honestly. While many in Brightmoon are like you or Perfuma, everything is kept lowkey for a reason ‘cuz of humans. Though if it is serious, maybe I should ask the others if they wanted to stop by. They should know. Did you two want to come by?”

“Do you really not mind?” Scorpia asks.

“No. You guys are some of the only ones who know a lot about what I do, so why not?”

Petra sits at the table, head in hand, as she waits for Sea Hawk to appear. Glimmer insisted if it was important news, others would need to hear it. Both Mermista and Sea Hawk could talk to other aquatic beings while Perfuma and Scorpia those that come into the store. At first, Petra wasn’t keen on the idea, wanting to get straight to the point. However, Glimmer dug in her heels and told them to wait if they wanted to say anything. Adora couldn’t help but enjoy watching the hunter puff out her chest.

But Sea Hawk seems to be taking his time. Hopefully, based on his text to Mermista, he will be here soon. During the wait, Perfuma brews some tea for everyone. Once everyone has gotten a steaming cup, she takes a seat besides Scorpia.

"So, we have two merpeople here." Petra takes a sip of their tea. "What is everyone else?"

"Scorpia, Glimmer, and I are humans. Though Glim is really the only one with true hunter skills," Bow states.

"I'm a plant faery." Perfuma adds.

Petra's green eyes look towards Adora, standing off towards the side near the table. "What are you?"

Adora rolls the cup in her hands. "Werewolf. Bitten. What are you?"

Another sip. "Similar to you, though a bear and born."

"Huh, never met a werebear before," Mermista states

"I never met someone who was born a werecreature," Scorpia says. "What is that like?"

Petra shrugs. "Nothing special. It runs in the family so I was taught early on how to control it."

"You know how to control when you shift?" Adora asks. Her hands grip tight around the cup. Never was she sure about such a thing being true. All her life, she was told it could happen one day, that her adoptive mother and, supposedly, her adoptive sister knew how. How the latter learned before her, she has no clue. Granted, she *was* born one.

But that's the problem. No memories of her shift; everything she knows about control is based on word of mouth and not seeing it by herself.

“You don’t? How long have you been bitten? No one ever taught you?”

Adora scoffs.”My pack was not the best. I’ve been a werewolf for almost as long as I can remember.”

Petra opens her mouth to say something but is stopped by the front door flying open. The wooden frame slams against the wall as Sea Hawk waltz in, a large grin plastered on his face and twinkles in his eyes. “ *The fun has arrived!”* he says in a sing-song voice.

“Hi Sea Hawk…” Glimmer sighs. “Sit down. Perfuma made tea.”

Sea Hawk grabs a chair, spinning it around, before plopping himself down. With the tea in his hands, Petra stands up. “Now that we are all here, I can begin.”

They begin to dig through a bag. After some moments, they grab a rolled up paper and spread it across the table. It is a map of the United States. Several red ‘X’s, as well as some blue ones, dot the paper. Adora scans it, trying to make sense of what is going on.

“My family has kept tabs on other werecreatures and non-humans for many generations,” Petra starts, not looking up from her map. “We don’t really like those that just go off killing people for no reason.”

“So you are kind of like Glimmer,” Bow yes.

“Yes. Things pop up every now and again but recently, we have noticed an uptick in the tri-state area.” Petra pulls out a pen and circles the area she is referring to. Brightmoon sits smack in the middle of the circle. Several red and blue marks make their own home in the circle as well. “Have any of you heard of any?”

A silence falls over the group. Mermista, Sea Hawk, Perfuma, and Scorpia all shrug, offering no answer. Bow and Adora turn their sights at Glimmer. The hunter’s face has fallen. Adora can see her hands balled up into tight fist, knuckles almost white. Without

second thought, the blonde places her hand on Glimmer's shoulder, giving it a tight squeeze.

Glimmer looks up. Adora gives her a small smile and nod. The hunter sighs before reaching a hand up, resting it against the back of the blonde's. Adora's heart jumps in her chest.

"I knew someone who died about a month ago. Definitely was a werecreature or at least, non-human. Don't know who or what. It was…" Glimmer looks at the map before placing a finger on a red 'X' "here."

"I'm sorry for your loss. I heard about that one. These red ones are confirmed deaths. Blues are unconfirmed. Possible attacks but we aren't sure."

"There sure are a lot of both colors." Perfuma points out.

"Some of them are a couple years old. There a few a while back before they suddenly stopped. Now, it is picking up again. I've been going around to any hunters in these areas to see if I can get any more information or, at the very least, inform them of what is going on."

"You really think someone is killing others?"

Petra nods. They begin to point towards various Xs, telling them dates of each attack. Some, as stated before, are a couple years old. Others are only a few months. There is a slight bit of a pattern, attacks don't just from one side of the state to another, but it looks fairly random. Adora cannot make heads nor tails of any reasoning. Some attacks skip some months.

"Something is going on. And whoever is doing it is doing a good job of keeping who and what they are a secret. They go at random and hide their tracks well, even their scent no one has gotten a read on it. No one has been spared, not even us, and people, humans, are taking notice."

“We can’t let them expose us, is what you are saying,” Mermista says.

“Do you want a bunch of humans freaking out that their neighbour can turn into something every month?”

“Wait, back up a minute,” Adora starts. “It’s not just hunters, *humans,* being attacked? They are going after us also?”

“Yes. I don’t know what they are planning or why they are going after their own kin.” Petra rolls up the map before shoving it back in their bag. “I hope you all will keep an eye and tell others to be careful. I can give you my information, Glimmer, so we can remain in contact. I do have to be going.”

“Right. Thank you, Petra.”

Glimmer and Petra exchange their numbers. As they begin to leave the house, Adora stops them. She lowers her voice so only they can hear each other.

“You said you knew how to control shifts. How? Can you show me?”

“That’s hard to do when there isn't a full moon. Being a bitten and not a born doesn’t help either,” Petra says bluntly.

“But *how* ?!? That doesn’t mean I can’t.”

Petra opens the front door. “I’ll leave you with this. You have to *want* it.”

Chapter End Notes

kudos/comments appreciated

A Wolf with No Name

Chapter Notes

> Chapters getting longer yeah. Okay the next two chapters are big so fair warning there. Anyway
>
> Tw for nightmares, panic attack, death mention, some manipulation

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The low hum of the engine fills the air, accompanied by the pitter-patter of rain against the windshield. Wipers beat back and forth, the rhythm almost like a metronome for the music playing through the car's speakers. The song is only broken when the GPS comes to life to give direction. Of course, it always does so during the good part. The only thing anyone can do when this occurs is reset the song. Though, it doesn't matter terribly much. Glimmer has heard many of the songs thousands of times. Adora isn't listening. She is totally dead to the world.

Adora sleeps as Glimmer drives them to their destination. Despite her title of being an early bird, and having been the first one up this morning, the car has proven her otherwise. Guess that is another weakness of werewolves, just like a child. Unlike the hunter herself who, according to anyone who has spent the night near her, Adora doesn't snore. Only soft breathing escapes her. At some point during the drive, she pushed the seat back and tucked her legs under her body. Adora is totally and utterly in a peaceful state.

Glimmer is careful not to stop suddenly (if only there weren't so many idiots on the road). Adora deserves some sleep. It has been a little while since Petra's sudden appearance as well as their sudden disappearance. The last words spoken by the other werecreature stuck with her. And not in a good way. Neither can

figure out the message, if it is cryptid or they need to take it as is. The hunter can't even begin to imagine what wanting to be a werewolf could even mean. Of course, knowing there might be a serial killer out there does not help at all.

And that is what the two find themselves doing. One of the the places that had an attack was only a couple hours away. Green River. Best to do their own investigation. From that they have asked Petra about when they decided to come here, a non-human was killed and a hunter lived a little while ago. They didn't get the chance to talk to the hunter in full, only a quick chat. Maybe Glimmer and Adora will have better luck. This meant, however, getting up early. At least, according to the hunter's own biological clock it is early. Glimmer won't lie, she is a *little* jealous that Adora is sleeping at the moment.

Glimmer looks at her car's GPS system. There is another half hour before they reach Green River. The hunter sighs, wishing they were already there. The sudden rainstorm isn't helping. It honestly is making herself sleepy. Thank god it's August. The heater would definitely knock her out in a heartbeat. Maybe once they get there, before meeting up with the hunter, Glimmer can take a nap at the hotel. The hunter takes a glance at the sleeping woman. So lucky…

HHHHHOOOOOOOONNNNNNKKKKKK!!!!

"AH! SON OF A BITCH!" Glimmer's brain goes into autopilot. Her foot hits the brake pedal and her hands jerk the wheels to the side. The car comes to a stop partly on the grass, partly on the side pavement, and partly still in the road.

Glimmer's heart pounds in her throat as she gasps for air. *Holy shit! Did I just fall asleep?!? Thank g-*

"Shit! Adora!" Glimmer snaps her head around. Adora is *fully* awake. One hand has shot upward, nails gripping into the fabric interior of the car. Her other holds onto the armrest between the pair and her feet no longer are tucked under her body. Sky blue

eyes are wide and she looks like a deer in headlights. Slowly, the blonde turns her head around.

“You good there?” Adora gasps. She forces a smile.

“Yeah. Yeah I’m fine. I’m glad you are.”

“What the hell happened?”

“I just fell asleep at the wheel for a sec.” Glimmer uses the heel of her hand in an attempt to rid her eyes of the fog of sleep. It does little to help. “Sorry. I just need a minute.”

Adora shifts, returning to a more comfortable position. “Do you want me to drive? Let you sleep?”

“Do you know how to drive?”

“Yes.”

“When was the last time you did?”

“That I am not sure of, but how hard can it be? Like riding a bike! Though...I don’t have my license…”

“Was it in your bag?”

“No, actually. It’s, uh, I don’t want to talk about it right now. How far away is Green River? I think if I am careful no one's gonna pull us over. What do you say?”

Adora gives little time to argue. The second she finishes her sentence, she unbuckles her seatbelt. Glimmer sighs, finding herself far too tired to fight back. The hunter switches with the blonde, temporarily getting wet from the rain. It takes a moment for Adora to situate herself, fixing the seat and getting used to being behind the wheel. Thank god no one else has driven by. Finally, Adora backs the car onto the street and heads back towards Green River.

While Glimmer's body is heavy and wishes not to do anything, her mind is a little more awake. If anything, she only slips into the first stage of slumber. The voices from the radio, the GPS, and even Adora muttering to herself mix together into incoherent nonsense. For a brief moment, she can make out the fuzzy outline of her mother. She is sitting at a table, writing in her own notebooks. Though, when she spots her daughter, the older hunter smiles her warm smile.

Nothing is wrong, everything is right in the world.

"Glim." A hand gives a small shake against her shoulder.

Glimmer blinks. The rain continues to fall but no longer are they on the road. Rather, Adora has pulled into the parking lot of a convenience store. The hunter stretches out, letting her muscles and bones return to some semblance of normalcy. "That was fast."

"Well, you did nod off. Feeling better?"

"Yeah, I am. Thanks. You were fine driving?"

"We are alive, aren't we?"

Glimmer snorts. "Where did you stop?"

Adora turns the car off. "I figured we could get a snack before talking to the hunter. Maybe get yourself a coffee. I'll pay."

The two head in, spending a little bit of time browsing around the small shelves and fridges. Glimmer gets her coffee, a large, and a small snack. Adora, meanwhile, gets her own snack and water. The pitstop definitely helps the hunter snap back into reality. Walking to get her blood flowing, recharge her batteries, she feels ready to take on the day. Glimmer checks her phone for the address of the hunter they shall be meeting. She'll be expecting the two soon.

Glimmer takes charge of driving once more. The house is only five or so minutes away. Closer to the hotel she and Adora will be

staying at over the weekend. No point in heading there only to leave right away. While heading down the street, Adora texted the hunter for her so she knows they'll be there in a matter of minutes. As the blonde puts the phone down, she sighs.

"Nervous?" Glimmer asks.

"A little. I don't know what this hunter is gonna be like. Dunno their relationship with the non-human but still must be rough to lose someone like that."

"Hey, I get it. Nervous also. Besides my chat, I haven't talked much to other hunters. Petra didn't say much other than what happened. At least the hunter is willing to talk about it. That's something at least, right?"

"Right. Do you really think everything is connected?"

"Maybe?" Glimmer shrugs. "Maybe not. I guess that is what we have to figure out. I really don't like the idea of a serial killer out there." *There is no need for anyone else to die.*

Glimmer grips the steering wheel tight, knuckles turning white. If this person killed her friend, that already gives her enough reason to stop them. But could they have killed her mother? So many dots littered that map, so many close to her where her mother was slain. Even then, did Petra have all the murders? There are too many 'what ifs'. Thinking of the chance of it being all connected, someone out there is out killing people, makes her blood boil.

They pull into the driveway. The house is nothing out of the ordinary. Two stories, a simple yard, and a fence encasing the backyard. Glimmer and Adora exit the car and head up the front porch. With a deep inhale, Glimmer knocks on the door. Some seconds pass before the lock clicks and the door opens. A young woman about their age stands in the doorframe. Reddish-brown hair is tied back into a ponytail and blue eyes stare back at them.

"Are you Teela Gary?" Glimmer asks.

“Yes. I assume you are Glimmer Mizari?” Teela asks. She then turns her sights towards Glimmer’s side. “And who are you again? You’re a werewolf?”

“Adora. And you are correct.” the blonde replies.

“You’re just Adora?”

“Yes. Just Adora.”

Glimmer sees the blonde shifting on her feet before heading into the house. She follows closely behind. Teela leads them into a living area, gesturing towards a set of chairs near a small couch. She asks them if they wanted anything to drink but both Glimmer and Adora decline. With that Teela sits down across from them.

“So, you are here to ask about the attack?”

Glimmer nods. “If you don’t mind us asking. Petra told us there was an attack here. And there’s been more. We’re trying to figure out if everything is connected.”

“I’ve heard about some of those. Petra mentioned it briefly when she talked to me but that was about it in our conversation. I couldn’t talk much and she had to leave.”

“Are you willing to talk now?”

“If it helps, yes. What do you want me to tell you?”

“If you remember anything about the attack,” Adora states.

Teela thinks for a moment before speaking. “It’s hazy, it’s been months. But I didn’t know much about the non-human. Only met them the day before. We were out in the woods, just checking stuff. And then...We heard something. Couldn’t really see but then something jumped us. I don’t remember much since I was knocked out but when I came too, someone had found me alive and the non-human dead.”

You don’t happen to remember what attack you looked like?” Glimmer asks.

“A little. I think it was a werewolf. Definitely a canine werecreature.”

“A werewolf?” Adora interjects.

“Yeah. Like you. You wouldn’t know any bloodthirsty werewolves, would you?”

Adora scoffs. “I haven’t talked to anyone in years. I don’t know. I’m sure there are plenty of people who might attack others for the hell of it.

“You don’t remember anything else, do you?” Glimmer asks.

“No. Just that it was some werewolf. It was too dark to make out much. Well, now that I think about it…” Teela taps a finger against her chin. “I think I saw their eyes. Maybe green? I’ve seen a few werecreatures with green eyes so I don’t know how much that helps.”

“Green eyes, huh?” Glimmer makes a mental note to jot that down in her notebook. “Sorry for bothering you. If you need anything else, we will be in the area for the weekend. Gonna see if there is anything else we can find.” Glimmer begins to stand up.

“You know it’s been months since everything happened. What do you think you are going to find?”

“Dunno but since we are here, might as well, right?” Glimmer looks towards Adora. The blonde rises to her feet.

“Yeah. Who knows, we might be able to find something someone missed.” Adora replies. “What?”

Glimmer notices Teela looking at Adora. Eyebrows are furrowed in thought. “Sorry. You just reminded me of someone. It’s nothing. If

I can remember anything else I'll let you know."

"Thanks. C'mon Adora."

The elevator shutters to a halt with a *ding.* The electronic red number on the screen above Adora and Glimmer reads ' *5'.* Hotel halls are covered by a decorative carpet and pictures of random scenery line the hall. Some plants sit on small tables as they pass door after door after door. Adora double checks the card number for their room. *5985.* Looks like it will be at the end of the hall.

Small suitcases travel behind both young women, wheels jerking at the slightest bump. Enough clothes and items for the weekend are packed inside like a game of *Tetris* . Hopefully, these next three days will pass by quickly. Maybe, just maybe, they can find something to help figure out what is going on. Teela's info on what it is is a step in the direction. When they reach their door, Adora swipes them in. After all the traveling this morning, flopping down on bed sounds good right about now.

"What the hell?" Adora asks as she opens up the door,

"What?" Glimmer looks over her arm, seeing exactly what her friend is seeing."What the hell?"

The room is smaller than expected, which isn't much of an issue. What *is* the problem is the single bed sitting off to the side. The rest of the room consists of one small dresser, table, nightstand and a two seater couch. They had asked for two beds, one for each of them. The fact it is a twin size one isn't helping with anything.

"How did the hotel fuck this up? We did ask for two right?" Glimmer asks, looking at her own plastic key in her hands.

"Yeah. I made sure of that. I don't know what happened." Adora states. "Computer glitch maybe? Should we go tell them?"

Glimmer steps into the hotel room, looking around at everything in the room. She flicks on the light of the bathroom, getting a feel of the room, before turning it off. The hunter travels towards the couch and places a hand on one of the cushions. "I dunno. If you want? There is the couch one of us can sleep on. We are only staying two nights."

Adora steps in, shutting the door behind her. She takes her own look around. More scenic pictures, mostly of beaches, hang on the pale walls. Someone must have sprayed an air freshener before they came in. She can faintly make out the smell of fresh scent. "Do you really want to?"

"Do *you* really want to go downstairs and deal with trying to change rooms?" Glimmer raises an eyebrow.

"Point taken. But who is gonna sleep where?"

"Wanna rock-paper-scissors it? Loser sleeps on the couch tonight and tomorrow we switch!"

"Deal."

It's the best two out of three. Adora promptly loses both rounds, not even making it to the third. Glimmer has a large shit eating grin on her face as she wins. The blonde resists the urge to give her a shove in retaliation. Instead she throws her bag on the couch. There is some unpacking but honestly, much of her things can just stay in the suitcase Glimmer gave her. The hunter puts away some of her things in the drawer

Not planning on heading out for the next couple hours, needing the break of walking around (and hoping the rain lets up), Adora and Glimmer settle into the hotel room. Adora sits on the couch that will be her bed tonight and drags the table close to her. She pulls out some papers she brought with her and spreads them out against the dark wood. Almost all are simple notes the pair scribbled together before coming to Green River.

Things on the attacks they have gathered from Petra. How most have been within the tri-state area. Glimmer's mother, Angella, has been written down with a question mark beside it. Adora doesn't need heightened senses to know when writing the deceased hunter's name, Glimmer was displeased– *angry* . Everything else are random theories of what is killing people. With Teela's information, Adora crosses off all but one thing. The word *werewolf* remains free of a line.

"So, do you really think it's a werewolf?" Adora asks as she writes the words ' *green eyes'* on the paper.

"Possibly," Glimmer replies. She sits on the floor, her back against the side of bed as she scribbles in her notebook. "Out of all the werecreatures, werewolves are the most common. Was your pack made up just werewolves? If you don't mind me asking."

"It was just me and two others. I never saw what they looked like during shifts but from what I remember being told, my adoptive mother was a werewolf and my adoptive sister a werecat, a panther to be exact."

"Huh, I don't think I ever met a werepanther before."

I hope you never have to meet Catra.

"Hey-...Can I ask another question? You don't have to answer it."

"What's up?"

Glimmer taps the end of her pencil against her notebook. "What is your last name? You never said it at all when meeting us or anyone else, like today."

Adora leans back against the back of the couch, taking a deep breath. It's a miracle that she was able to go this long without telling anyone her last name. It was only a matter of time before Glimmer or Bow or someone else asked about why she only ever introduced herself as 'Adora'.

“If it makes you upset you don’t have to answer it, Adora. It’s okay,” Glimmer reassures.

“No. We’ve been friends long enough for you to know. I don’t like my last name because it’s my adoptive mother’s.” Adora leans forward, resting her head on her head. She stares out the window. High above, anyone she can spot looks like tiny ants. “I don’t know my real last name. I don’t even know if ‘Adora’ is my real first name.”

“Are you talking about your birth parents?”

“Yeah. Like I said, I don’t know after I was bit if they wanted me or not. All that, being just barely *five* , it’s hard to remember anything of that time. I have bits but most of my memories are with my adoptive mother and, later, sister. So the last name was ‘Weaver’. I was Adora Weaver.

"When I managed to get away from them, I was so angry and hated my last name, still hate it, I destroyed my license so I didn't have to see it anymore. Bit me in the ass for some stuff, I was only like nineteen, but I don't fully regret it."

"Your adoptive mother sounds like a bitch." Glimmer snaps her book shut and sets it aside. "You mind if I ask what she was like? Like, what made you leave?"

“They weren’t the best. My adoptive mother wanted to mold me into her idea. I didn’t know better for a long time. My adoptive sister was always jealous of that fact, something I couldn’t control.” Adora pauses for a second, remembering the spats she and Catra had. Even though the younger of the pair tended to get them in trouble, she always found a way to twist things and blame Adora.

“ *I can’t believe you got us caught,”* Catra would say a number of times. “ *How can you be that stupid?”*

“You were the one who thought of sneaking into her room!” Adora snapped back once after getting caught in their mother's room.

Stuck in their own room after being chewed out by their mother for over an hour, Catra decided now to take it out on her sister.

" *Yeah but you were supposed to be on look out! Who's fault was that, huh?"*

Adora never knew how to respond, only shutting her mouth. If it was now, she would call her out. Hopefully she'll never have to see Catra ever again.

Adora continues. "Anyway, my adoptive mother wasn't the best. Besides the manipulation, she hated humans. Hated anyone who didn't agree with her actually and wanted nothing more to get power and control others. All my life she tried to teach me that and when I turned eighteen, tried to get me to follow her lead.

"Once I learned more about it, it left a bad taste in my mouth. But then one day she hurt someone. She told me she had control so it was on purpose and I had it. I never liked the idea of hurting others, of making them turn into something like...me...So I grabbed what I could and never looked back."

Adora rubs the scars on the side of her face. Her escape wasn't smooth. The blonde still wonders how the hell she escaped her adoptive sister's grasp, especially doing a full moon. Maybe that is one good thing about being out of control. When she woke up the following morning, Catra was nowhere to be found and Adora was left alone with her few belongings.

"That's...horrible. You didn't deserve to go through all that. And damn, you were alone for that long?"

"Yeah...It was rough for a while but I got used to it. I have no idea what happened to them nor do I care."

"What about your birth family? Do you want to find them?"

"Maybe? It's complicated. It's been twenty years, ya know. I don't even remember what state I am from, if I was even born here.

Sometimes I wonder if I'll ever just bump into them on the street."

Glimmer chews the bottom of her lip, not knowing what to say. "I'm sorry. I don't know where to start, but I can always help you try finding your family."

Adora smiles softly. "Thanks. I don't have any clues either. And I think we have more pressing issues right now."

"Right. Scoot over so I can look."

The Crystal Forest is smaller than the Whispering Woods, though not totally different in appearance. Similar trees, oaks and maples, stand tall near each other. Much of the sky is blocked off by a thick canopy of green leaves. With the rain passing during the night, pale sunlight now streams through the cracks, lighting up small pathways. Birds sing their hearts out, their songs Adora cannot tell apart. One major difference between the two patches of forest, however, is the amount of flowers and bushes. Here, there is much more. The bloom has long since passed but the petals of the flora remain vibrant shades of white, pink, and yellow.

The attack happened not terribly far in. While Adora can't see the road, building, or cars, she can hear the activity. Bold move by the assailant. Only a vague idea was given about where the incident occurred. Teela could only recall so much. Weather and other people and animals stomping through leave little in the way of smells. Adora does her best to discern everything entering her nose.

"I'm not getting anything," Adora says. She shakes her hand clear of the dirt she just smelled. "We definitely are too late. Have you spotted anything?"

Adora watches Glimmer gingerly take steps across the forest floor. Her eyes scan around, searching for things the blonde might have

missed with her own heightened senses. Sunlight continues to pour through the canopy, landing right on the hunter. The pale yellow glow surrounds her, taking the air straight out of Adora's lungs. She never realized how stunning Glimmer is. Her dyed hair with the hints of the raven color sticking out, eyes the shade of lilacs, and the way she holds herself high when walking. Adora wonders if Glimmer knows how captivating she is.

Fuck...

Adora shakes her head, reminding herself of the creature inside. "Glim!"

"Huh? Sorry!" Glimmer shouts back. "I think I did! Come here!"

Adora sprints forward, leaves and dirt kicking up behind her. In a few short strides, she is at Glimmer's side. She quickly notices the large claw marks cut deep in a red oak. The blonde's fingers reach out, tracing the lines in the broken bark. Adora notices the smallest of tufts of hair in the crevice. She plucks it, rolling it between her thumb and index fingers. Rough and prickly. The color is too dark to accurately give a name to its shade.

"These definitely don't look like a bear's mark." Glimmer states. "Can you pick up a scent?"

Adora brings it to her nose. Nothing but a wet, dog smell. "No. It's been too long. But, it's like Teela said. A werewolf. Or...a werecanine at the very least. Guess we can narrow down our search for sure."

"Do you think we'll find anything else out here?"

Adora shakes her head. "Doubt it. We have been out here for what? An hour or so and this is all we got?"

"Right." They begin to walk back onto the path towards the street. "Where else do you think we should look or ask around? We do have the rest of the day."

“Aren’t you the hunter?” Adora teases.

“I am still getting my footing. Never had to deal with something like this before,” Glimmer huffs.

“Hey, I’m just joking around.” Adora gives her a gentle nudge with her shoulder. “You’re doing great so far.”

“Thanks. I don’t know, maybe we can go back to the hotel and think up our next game plan?”

“Sounds good to me.”

Dried up leaves, those waiting for their cousins to join them in a couple months’ time, crunch under their feet. The sounds of town slowly become louder, breaking up the peacefulness of the woods. While walking, Adora continues to roll the hair she found between her fingers, wondering who or what it has come from.

Adora takes another sniff of the tuft of hair. Still the same, musky wet dog smell. Absolutely no inkling of an owner. The blonde growls in annoyance. She feels sick at the thought of another werecreature out killing others for no real reason. Reminds her of how her adoptive mother would talk about how horrible others were and threatening anyone who got close. Did she ever attack and *kill* anyone when Adora could not recall anything?

“You okay?” Glimmer asks.

Adora blinks, coming out of her thoughts. The edge of the woods is only feet away. Cars zip by, paying little attention to the pair just in view.

“I’m just thinking about this all. About my own…’family’.”

“You don’t think they could be connected?”

“I dunno. The last place I lived with them was on the other side of the country. Took me forever to reach *here.* So, I would hope they were not close by. I don’t want to think about it. I’m sure there’d

be other werecreatures out there just as shitty, maybe even worse."

"I guess we have to figure it out. For your sake, I hope they're not."

"Thanks."

Adora bounces her leg up and down, fists resting on top moving along to the rhythm. She is waiting in the living room of her most recent home, alone. The room is empty, cold, and dim. She doesn't know where the light source is, only the area around her chair is lit. Everything else is covered in thick, black shadows. The hairs on the back of her neck raise. There is a sense of déjà vu, though she cannot put her finger on it.

She looks around, seeing if there is anything else around her. As she seeks answers, Adora recalls why she is here. Her sister, one that came into her life around a year ago, and Adora herself got into trouble. Catra was the one with the plan, the one to egg the blonde on. Sneak out of home and go do whatever the fuck came to the thriteen-year-olds minds. The blonde debated, knowing their mother would disapprove. But how could she say no? Get out of the house? See things without being under her mother's watchful eyes. Everything was going smoothly, the sisters could have made it back home without anyone knowing.

But they got caught trespassing. Brought straight home. The image of her mother's cold, disappointed eyes still burns in her mind. Now separated, her mother is with Catra. Soon, it will be her turn. Adora can feel her heart pounding in her chest in frightened anticipation. Her mother does not take kindly to disobedience. Especially not from Adora herself.

The air becomes colder. Adora swears that she can see her breath in front of her. Wait...She looks herself over. What is she wearing? She definitely has never seen these plaid pj pants before and why

*does she have a college football jersey on? Nothing like this has ever been in her wardrobe. She **feels** different as well.*

No time to think. The shadows around her swirl and morph around her. They stretch and grow, pulling high above Adora until her mother's shape takes form. Her bright green eyes stare down at her. Adora swallows a hard, dry lump in her throat. She holds her body tight, keeping it from shaking. "H-Hello, M-Mother."

"Hello my dear. You know why you are here, correct?"

Adora nods.

"Why are you here, Adora?"

"'Cuz...Because Catra and I snuck out and then got in trouble. We shouldn't have when you always said it's better to not get close with others. Because of what we are." Adora repeats what has been drilled in her head over and over again.

"Why did you disobey me, then? After I took you in and raised you after you were abandoned?" Her mother leans closer, her mouth near Adora's ear. "Remember?"

*Adora winces, fingers digging into her shorts. The shadows swirl around her once more. Twisting, **contorting** , into two new figures with faceless figures. With sharp edges. Her mind struggles to put faces to them, desperately trying to reflect herself in them. Are the voices that come out of nothing even their correct ones? Are their sentences real? Their harsh words, calling her a 'monster', that she 'isn't their daughter', and 'forget about her', ring in her ears. She wonders if they are right. That the moment she was cursed, their child was as good as dead.*

Adora holds back the tears in her eyes.

Her mother continues. "I took you in. Even gave you a sister so you were not alone. Though, she seems to pull you down a lot. You are a special case, you know? You can go on to do great things but you must listen to me. You're too young to know what

you want. I know what is best for you. I'm your mother after all, right?"

Adora nods. "Yes. I'm sorry mother. I won't do it again. I promise."

"Good, good. You are so strong and wonderful, I wouldn't want that to go to waste."

Her mother places a hand on her right shoulder. The next thing Adora knows are the flashes of images. No, ***memories*** *. The cold, winter's night when a shadowy wolf stared down at her. Her attempt to escape her home and the betrayal of her sister–her face and back stinging. All those nights alone. A flash of purple and a mouth moving with no words coming out. Everything blurs into one single entity. Another wolf, different from before, stares back at her. Large and more menacing than out of any story book or stories told.*

Her own reflection.

Adora bolts awake, a shout trapped inside her lungs. Her senses fail her as darkness meets her. All she hears is her pulse. The images of the faithful night she was bit, her adoptive 'mother', *herself,* and so much more streaming through her brain. Fight or flight kicks in, however, that mechanism has been long since broken. Something else always loves to take control during this.

A jerk sends a shock wave of pain throughout her body. Adora falls to the ground, entangled by the blankets. This does *little* to help the situation *No, no no! Stop!* She thinks, scrambling out of her sheets. *Stop, stop, stop!*

Adora gasps for the air that her tight throat refuses to let in. Her mind races as it struggles to keep control. She has to calm down, she *needs* to calm down. How can she be this stupid to let this happen? Her heart claws against the bones of her ribcage, it too does not want to be here for a sudden, unexpected shift. The

blonde whines, feeling her teeth grind together as they sharpen and elongate against her lips; nails start darkening and curling to dagger like points .

“Adora! Adora, look at me!” Glimmer’s voice rings in her ears. She is suddenly in her line of sight. Concern is written all over her face.The hunter grips Adora’s arms, covered in growing goosebumps. Fingers wrap tight around her biceps. Lilac eyes stare back at her, warm like meadows in summer. “Adora, listen. Can you listen to me?”

Another whine escapes her as she nods. She can feel her muscles and bones readying to turn into something completely different from her regular form. The wolf she always struggles to keep down crawls its way out of her body. Adora squeezes her eyes shut at the pain but a small shake makes her open them again.

“No, no. Keep your eyes on me, alright?” Glimmer presses her forehead against Adora’s. So warm… “Just look at me and listen to my voice. Okay? Can you talk?”

“Unh-uh,” is all Adora can squeak out.

“Okay.” Fingers loosen around her arms and thumbs rub Adora’s blustering skin. “While I count, you breathe. Think you can do that?”

Adora flinches as she feels something else jerking inside of her. Her stomach. She barely has the strength to nod. Glimmer begins to count. Every command of inhale, exhale, or hold Adora obeys. Slowly, her heart begins to settle inside, returning to a normal rhythm. Her stomach, twisted into a knot, loosens. Glimmer continues to count, singing each word softly. Goosebumps fade away, nails shrink back to blunt keratin, and teeth dull themselves out. With so much of her energy sapped, the blonde collapses into Glimmer’s arms.

“I got you, Adora. I’m right here.” Glimmer states, wrapping arms around a now shaking body.

“I’m sorry…” Adora sniffles.

“Not your fault. Panic attacks happen.” A hand rubs gently against Adora’s back.”Do you want to talk about it?”

“N-Nightmare...N-No. I don’t...I-I-I-” Words and incoherent noises fumble out of her mouth. Glimmer continues her rubbing back, whispering soft ‘shh’s in her ear. Adora chokes out tears, part of her not pleased her friend had to see a near sudden shift. A rare occurrence she has fought not to happen again. Yet, here she is.

Slowly, Adora’s body settles and her breathing returns into some semblance of normalcy, only occasional unsteadiness. She pulls away from the hunter, wiping her tear stained face with the collar of her jersey pajama top. “God, I am a mess. Sorry.”

“You saw me as a mess during the middle of the night, remember? It’s alright.” Glimmer scoots closer to her friend. Their skin brushes ever so slightly together, sending a shiver down Adora’s spine. “Are you okay now? Feeling better?”

“A little, thank you. I just had a stupid nightmare about my past. It’s all confusing.”

“Nightmares will be like that sometimes. Oh, can I fix your hair?”

“Uh, sure?” Adora blinks. A hand reaches up and fingertips brush against the side of her face. The blonde holds back a wince, not wanting to give Glimmer any more need to worry. But rather than an icy cold, rough hand against her skin, it’s warm and soft. Locks of her dark blonde hair are pushed back behind her ear.

“Do you want to go back to bed? You should get the rest.”

“Yeah. Yeah I think that’s a good idea.”

Glimmer begins to stand, ready to curl back up in her nest on the couch. However, Adora quickly stops her with a shout. The hunter looks back, bewilderment on her face. Adora feels her face turn warm.

“I...Well I was wondering. Would you stay with me in bed? I-I know it’s small but I rather have someone closer. To keep the nightmares away, ya know?”

Adora swears in the low light, she can see a blush spread across Glimmer’s face as she gives an answer. “S-Sure. If you like! I don’t mind.”

It takes a bit of figuring out and twisting and turning until they get comfortable. Adora and Glimmer face each other, legs bumping up against each other as their bodies press up against each other, only an inch separating them. Thank god the hotel has AC. Between their bodies being so close on the small bed and the warmth from Adora’s face spreading all throughout her body, any cold air is good. The blonde cannot recall the last time, if ever, snuggling with someone. Honestly...it feels nice.

A heaviness creeps along Adora’s body, begging her to join it in sleep. The blonde hesitates doing so, scared that her nightmares will return. Awkwardness hangs in the air. Maybe asking Glimmer to stay with her wasn’t the best idea. She tries not to think about it. How warm the hunter is. How she has an aura of safety around her. And...her heartbeat? Adora blinks, sometimes forgetting how strong her hearing is even when human. Its steady rhythm fills her ears. Her eyes begin to flutter shut.

“You better sleep…” Adora mumbles as darkness creeps along vision.

“I know I am a night owl,” Glimmer retorts.

“I woke you...Sleep…Promise?”

The last thing Adora hears is the hunter softly whispering “Okay, ‘Dora. I promise.”

Glimmer doesn’t go to sleep right away, waiting to make good on her promise. She wants to ensure there are no more nightmares.

The hard thud of Adora's fall from bed scared the living daylight out of her. Of course, seeing the sudden shift was the last thing she expected to see when scrambling over to check on her. She's only seen it once as a young teen. A werefox getting so angry at her mother over something she can no longer recall. At least this time, Glimmer could stop and reverse what was happening.

Adora slowly begins her soft breathing, letting Glimmer know she has finally slipped into the world of dreams. The hunter can't help but smile. With what little moon there is, it manages to spill through the curtain, landing on the sleeping woman besides her. Adora's dark blonde hair hides part of her face, covering the scars that rest on the side of her chin. Glimmer can see how tone Adora's body is. She wonders if that is a side effect of being a werewolf or just how she is. Whatever the case, she is amazed by it. Makes her heart flutter inside her chest.

Glimmer decides to remain awake a little while longer. Ensure that Adora does not startle awake once again. After all, didn't she do the same the night the hunter opened up about her mother?

No need for another heart attack. No need for another near shift.

Adora mumbles something in her sleep, burying herself closer to Glimmer. "Mommy...Papa…" Something else escapes her that Glimmer can't make out. The hunter pulls the covers up to Adora's neck before settling down on the bed herself.

"We'll find out about them, Adora. Hopefully they don't suck. You deserve it." *Hopefully they aren't dead, either. You deserve that also.*

Try as she might to stay awake, sleep creeps along her bones. Glimmer fights back against the weights forming on her eyes. Every time she snaps them open, Adora's peaceful self stares right back at her. It becomes harder and harder to remain awake, to keep an eye on the blonde. It's a losing battle, however. One moment Glimmer is doing her best to keep herself within the

world of the living, of reality, and the next a heavy darkness overwhelms her.

The next thing she knows is the sound of shuffling filling her ears. The next thing that happens is sensing light behind her eyelids. Glimmer groans, wanting to return to her dreamworld. Even with the lack of said dreams this time around, the feeling of nothingness always is something to enjoy. The hunter grabs a fistfull of sheets and pulls them over her head, burying herself in a cocoon.

A light laugh, one with a slight snort, replaces the shuffling in her ears. "Glimmer, you can't stay asleep forever ya know."

Glimmer slowly pulls the covers down to her neck, letting one eye crack open. Lingering sleep blurs her vision, she can only make out a tall figure. With a blink, it takes the shape of Adora. True to Adora-fashion, the blonde is already dressed and perky as ever. The nightmare and near shift of the previous night either has been forgotten or has been pushed back down inside, masked by her wide, crooked smile. Glimmer hopes that it is the former.

Slowly, the hunter pushes herself up to one elbow. The bed groans as she finds a comfortable position. "What time is it?" Glimmer asks, words slightly slurred.

"About nine," Adora replies.

Glimmer promptly flops back down on the bed, eyes snapping back shut. "Let me sleep more please."

"C'mon, Glimmer. You are the one who has to drive back."

"You can drive…"

"Yeah but I don't have a license. The drive is long and you *know* if I drive, it will be the one time a cop pulls us over. Do you really want us both to get in trouble?"

"Not like I haven't gotten a ticket or two before."

A new weight settles besides Glimmer. The hunter opens her eyes again, finding Adora sitting inches away from her. Her bright smile has turned into an imp like one. There's a twinkle in her soft blue eyes. "If you don't get up, I'll flip the bed."

"You wouldn't dare."

"You really wanna try me?" Adora says with a chuckle.

"Fine, fine, I'm up." Glimmer sits up, stretching out her body and feeling everything settle into place. With a yawn, she turns back to face her still smiling friend. Eyes have become soft and warm, making Glimmer feel hot in the face. "W-What is with that look?"

Adora blinks, realization washing over her. Her own face turns red as she snaps her head around, stammering, "N-Nothing. I'm just glad you're up. I was getting a little bored, I've been up since seven. I kind of wanted to get breakfast with you before we left. Is that okay?"

"I would love that, Adora. Think you can last like ten more minutes so I can shower and get dressed?"

"I think I can manage that."

Chapter End Notes

Comments/kudos appreciated

Memories

Chapter Notes

> Surprise update. I'll be busy tomorrow so it'd be cutting it close and if I have something done I rather post early than late.
>
> Anyway tw are death mention, a bit of a panic attack?, a bit of a panic attack, some medical stuff very minor, and minor nudity? Idk yall I'm covering my bases but enjoy. Oh and there is a minor skip back like its not 100% linear you'll see

See the end of the chapter for more notes

15 Years Ago

The first of the snow of the year slowly flutters down from grey skies, piling up on the white sheet that covers the ground. Only through the pale yellow street lights can Adora watch the flakes dancing as they descend. The young child looks over her shoulder, staring at the closed front door. No one will be coming out to snatch her away, take her back into the confines of her room. Even so, she *is* only on the front porch. How bad can that be? She turns back around, eyes landing on the small clock she brought out with her. The red second hand twitches forward, only seconds away from all the components of the clock line up.

Her hot breath begins to fog up the glass surface. Adora rubs it away with her sweater sleeve. Almost there.

Five seconds…

Adora grips the clock tighter, hands red and stinging from the outside temperature.

Four seconds…

The wind picks up, howling like the creature inside of her.

Three seconds…

Adora's breath stops.

Two seconds…

Are her hands shaking from the cold or anticipation?

***One** second…*

Time stands still.

Finally...midnight. It's January 19th.

"Happy birthday, Adora…" she mumbles to herself.

This should be a joyous moment. She is the big *one-oh* now. Ten whole years! Yet, the feeling is bittersweet. This is not only the anniversary of her birth but it has been five years since she was bit. The night she no longer was human. A bitter taste always finds its way into her mouth at the thought. She wants to enjoy her birthday like everyone else seems to do but how can she when a horrific memory is connected with it? The dark forest, a strange menacing creature inches from her...time and her brain have done work to blur it. But never can they fully erase that night from her memories.

Thankfully, her adoptive mother will not do much. Sure, might give her something nice but she does not make a big deal about it.

Adora looks back at the dark, white world. Clouds mask the new moon, her favorite phase of the lunar cycle. Alone in this still world, the blonde can find a small semblance of peace on her day. For a moment she can forget how her birthday and curse are connected. With the moon facing away from the earth, she can barely feel the wolf inside of her.

For once she can feel just like *Adora.*

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Adora gets the surprise of her life upon opening her door. She has to check her phone, ensuring this is the right time. Sure enough, the numbers resting against her lockscreen of Bow and Glimmer when the trio went out for the day reads *7:30.*

What the actual hell is Glimmer doing up?

“What’s that look on your face?” Glimmer asks. Below her a pan of eggs fry, filling the air in the mouth watering smell. “You look like you’ve seen a ghost.”

“Yeah, I think I am staring at one. Did Glimmer die? Because who the hell are you and why are you up this early in the morning?”

Glimmer laughs, warming up Adora’s heart. “Trust me, it’s not like I do this often. Was debating it actually. I am on my third cup of coffee. But I have two reasons. One.” Glimmer twists the knob, turning the flame below off. Half of the scrambled eggs go on one plate while the other half on the other. “You know what tonight is.”

“Right…” Adora sighs through her nose. Another month, another full moon. Normally in the morning hours before the moon, the blonde cooks her own meal. Fuel for before and after the shifts are always nice and help her not feel like total shit. Glimmer being the one to cook is a surprise.

“You know, you don’t have to do this. I can cook my own breakfast,” Adora states while sliding into the chair by her plate. “But thank you.”

“It’s no big deal,” Glimmer replies as she takes her own seat. She starts to scratch the side of her red tinted face. “I wanted to do something nice for you. I don’t know if I can do it every full moon since mornings aren’t my thing, but I can always try.”

“God, you're cute when you blush,” Adora mutters.

“What?”

“What?” Adora blinks. Damn, she keeps forgetting Glimmer has better hearing than most humans. The blonde shakes her head before taking a bite of her food. Delicious.

“Nothing,” she continues after swallowing, “I was just talking to myself. So what is the second thing?”

“Well, it’s Bow’s birthday. He’s gonna be twenty-five. So I figured we’d celebrate beforehand.”

Oh great. Another birthday this thing ruined. “Oh! I didn’t know that. Wish I got him something.”

“Hey, don’t worry about it. We usually just do something small. Just planning on doing some random things like seeing a movie. Maybe getting a bite after. What do you say? Get your mind off things for a while?”

“I wouldn’t mind that. What time?”

“Anytime. He’s an early bird also. Though, not as much as you. After we eat we can call him.”

"Sounds good to me.”

Adora and Glimmer chow down on their food. The eggs definitely hit the spot. Maybe she should get some lessons in cooking from the hunter. Adora finishes up first, cleaning up her spot and getting Glimmer another cup of coffee. The moment it is set on the table, the cup is empty within a minute. Once both are ready, they head out to enjoy the hours before the long night ahead.

To Adora’s surprise, Glimmer offers *her* to drive into town. At first, she declines, unsure. That time going to Green River was to ease a load off of a tired Glimmer. The hunter insists, saying that their destination isn’t far at all. For further reassurance, she’s reminded how long she has lived in Brightmoon; she's already memorized

many of the roads. After some more gentle nudging, Adora caves and gets in the driver's seat. Glimmer helps her friend settle in.

Adora is unsure as she drives into town. Before, the road to Green River was more open. She only was in the town for a short bit before waking her friend. Now, she is going right through all of it. Glimmer does her best to aid in driving while not trying to be a backseat driver. Adora does appreciate the help, what with her knuckles white from how hard she grips the wheel. But soon it is no longer needed. By the time they reach their meeting place, a movie theater, there is no need for aid. Fingers have eased and blood flows freely in them.

She has forgotten how nice driving feels.

Bow is already there, waiting at the sidewalk by the parking lot. As the car passesby, he gives them a wave. Once Adora and Glimmer are out and on the sidewalk, he gives them both a huge hug.

"Happy birthday, Bow!" Glimmer shouts.

"I didn't know, so sorry I didn't get you anything," Adora admits. "But happy birthday."

"Hey, it's okay. This movie is fine by me." Bow replies. The three friends begin walking.

"So, what have you chosen for us to suffer through?" Glimmer jokes.

"Some zombie movie that just came out. A bit early in the season but hey, they are always fun, right?"

"Oh hell yeah! Do you like zombie movies, Adora?"

Adora shrugs. "I've only seen a few but they aren't bad."

"I gotta see what movies are coming out in a couple months so we can see them for my birthday," Glimmer says as they get to

the ticket booth. The time the three friends have picked out is not for another half hour. Gives them enough time to get their snacks and settle in for the two hour long movie.

“When’s your birthday?” Adora asks, realizing she never asked this about her friend.

“December 1st. So a bit away. Hey,” Glimmer pauses, tilting her head and raising an eyebrow, “when’s yours?”

I should’ve known this was gonna be asked. If everyone else already said theirs… “Uh, it’s January 19th. So not for a while. Though, I never really celebrated it even after I left home.” She begins to rub her right shoulder. The ‘birthday gift’ she wishes she could get rid of.

“Did you want to celebrate it when it came around?” Bow asks.

“Not really, no. I just...Bad memories…”

“Hey, that’s fine. Don’t worry about it. Plenty of people don’t celebrate it.” Glimmer states.

Adora sighs a breath of relief. She focuses on shifting her brain to something else. She’s here to spend time with her friends and celebrate Bow being another year older. Tonight is already going to be ruined by her, no need to bring it down anymore. That’s when a thought pops into her mind. As they reach the concession stand, Adora pulls out her wallet and pays for Bow’s things.

“You don’t have to do that, Adora.” Bow says.

“I want to. Give you a birthday present. And...and with what's going on tonight I just wanted to do something nice.”

Both Glimmer and Bow exchange looks at each other. The hunter is the one to speak up, starting to form words but Adora cuts her off.

“Let me just do this, alright? Well, I mean I already have done it.” Adora gathers up her items, giving Bow’s his. “This is your day, right? Let’s get some good seats before they are taken.”

Her friends make another set of faces but don’t say anything more.

“You don’t have to stick around you know.” Adora states, managing to get a whole sentence out without a stammer. A wince cannot help but escape her a moment later. Chains rattle as her body shivers. Another night, another full moon. The agonizing wait for the shift is at hand. Glimmer has already tied her friend up and given her a cocktail of wolfsbane and magical potions made by Perfuma with help from Scorpia. It will take some time to kick in, though.

“I want to.” Glimmer replies. She settles down on the bed, the mattress shifting under her. She resists the urge to scratch her stomach. “I don’t want you to be alone.”

She hears Bow shifting around the living room. After some debate, he has decided to wait until the shift is over. Doesn’t have the stomach to see or hear it. No one can blame Bow in the slightest. Took some time for the hunter *herself* to stomach the cracking of bones, tearing of muscles, and the painful noises that will sometimes come from those whose bodies are twisting into something new.

“I’m-” Adora starts.

“‘Used to it’. I know,” Glimmer sighs. She hates that thought, that Adora was alone for so long without anyone. Even then, based on what the blonde has told the hunter, did she ever truly have someone to help out? Glimmer’s heart twists hard inside her chest. “But I am here now. Even Bow!” she jerks her head towards the closed door.

“I r-really got l-lucky with you g-guys, huh?” Sharping teeth chatter as she speaks. Red goosebumps are all over skin, her body hunches over (as best it can with the chains), while nails darken. There’s sweat on her brow, hints of red in her blue irises, and a low groan escapes her.

This is really taking its time tonight. Adora must be fighting hard.

Glimmer wishes she could do more, do *anything* to ease Adora’s pain. She feels so helpless. There *has* to be something she can do. She can’t stand to watch the blonde suffering every month. Yet, all Glimmer finds herself able to do is sit and be a (hopeful) comforting presence. She’ll be damned if she doesn’t do at *least* that.

“Can...Can I ask… *fuck* …”

Time is short. The chains are rattling harder and Adora's eyes are glazed over.

“What is it, Adora?” Glimmer pushes herself to the very edge of the bed, barely touching the sheets.

“W-Why...W-”

Time is up. Before she can get out any other words, her body violently lurges forward, stopped by the silver around her. Adora bites down on her lip, drawing blood, suppressing a cry. Her mouth rips into an elongated snout with razor sharp teeth. Her dark hair changes into a ugly shade of yellow, covering every inch of her body. As her bones snap, contorting into a new form, muscles bulge and grow, the fabric of Adora’s tank top and boxer shorts ripping apart. Nails blacken and grow and a tail sprouts behind her.

As quickly as it begins, it ends.

“Adora?” Glimmer whispers. She kneels down on the ground, keeping her distance. She is answered with a snarl, teeth bear for all to see. The threat does not last long. Adora’s burning eyes roll

back into her skull and body goes limp. She remains mostly still. The occasional growl and flash of fangs will now be, for the most part, all Adora does.

Glimmer inhales deeply, holding the oxygen in her lungs for several seconds before expelling the carbon. Let the night begin.

"Bow! You can come in now!" Glimmer shouts.

The door creaks open, Bow gingerly stepping into the bedroom. His eyes land on the sleeping werewolf on the other side of the room. There's a frown on his face as he sits down besides his best friend. In his hands is her new notebook.

"These nights are just gonna get longer and longer," Bow says.

Glimmer takes the book from him, flipping over to the most recent page. There are notes on everything she and Adora have gathered over the past few weeks. The hunter begins sketching out the snoozing werewolf in front of her, still in awe of the strong, dangerous look.

"Tell me about it," Glimmer sighs. Staying up all night with Adora, making sure nothing bad will happen to her, making sure she *isn't* alone, it can weigh on her. But, she would never not do it. Not in a million years.

Adora jerks in her slumber, snapping at some invisible entity. She growls before returning to her stillness. Even when a werewolf, the blonde does not snore, only breathes softly. No matter what Glimmer is looking at, it's still Adora.

"Are you okay, Glim?" Bow asks after some time.

"I'm fine." Glimmer states. Faint granite lines create the outline of her sketch. She flicks her eyes up every now and again, ensuring her drawing is perfect.

"Are you sure?"

“Yes, I am. Why do you ask?”

Bow answers by snatching the book away. Glimmer barely has time to *gasp* what is going on before her friend has flipped a page and new pages stare back at her. Ones she had hoped no one else would ever see without her permission, even if it meant tearing them out later on. The hunter feels her face turn into a furnace and by the look on Bow’s face, she must be a bright red.

Sketches of Adora, her human self, stare back at her. At night when sleep was a fantasy, she would do her best to draw the blonde from memory. A couple times when Adora was not paying attention, lost in her own little world, she couldn’t resist drawing her. Her friend makes for the perfect image to sketch, no matter what she is doing. Practicing her punches or doing push ups, cooking or reading, *anything* and *everything* always catches Glimmer’s eyes.

She convinced herself it’s okay to add these drawings of human Adora since after all, she still is a werewolf. Still technically works into her filling notebooks with mythical creatures. Why can’t she have their human selves in there? If Adora ever wanted to see the pages, she would let her and *only* her...After all they are sketches of Adora, it's only right...Least she *thinks* she would without having her heart pounding in her chest and palms becoming covered in sweat. Which...is exactly what is happening to her now. Shit.

“So, are you gonna explain or what?” Bow asks. He fails to hold back a shit-eating grin.

Glimmer steals the book back, snapping it shut with one hand before clutching it close to her chest. “Why the hell did you look in it?!?”

“You never stopped me before. So,” Bow rests his head on his hand, “are you okay?”

Glimmer sets the book to her side. With little risk of having her arm being torn off, she reaches out and rubs her fingers against Adora's thick, coarse fur. A low rumble escapes the werewolf but it quickly dies away. The hunter does not stop.

"I don't really know. I feel bad Adora's gotta go through this every full moon. She said she's been alone for a long time. I can see it on her face how much she hates these nights." Her hand moves upward, towards one of Adora's large ears. Nails scratch at its base. "I wish I could do something else. But I don't know what."

"There's nothing to help lycanthrope?" Bow asks.

"If there is, it's been lost. My mother only knew so much. Hunters share information but some stuff has become muddled through time and human folktales."

"Petra seems to have an idea."

"Yeah but they haven't been much help. She's a born one though. I don't think I have ever met a bitten werecreature who had a semblance of control over their shifts. I dunno where I would even start to try and help."

"Well, I think you have the right idea doing this. You really care for her. Like her even, huh?"

"Yeah…" Glimmer's hand moves to Adora's chin. The wolf flinches as her fingertips brush where her scars are. Hair hides most of it, however, a simple brush back will reveal the damaged skin. The same goes for the long, jagged scars on her back. "I guess I do."

…

"Wait, *what* did you ask me?!?"

Bow bursts into laughter. The hunter feels every inch of her body turn into a fire. Oh, how she wishes to tear out of her skin right about now. Her friend is not wrong, however. She reaches up

towards the bed and grabs a nearby pillow, hitting Bow in the face with it. More laughter.

The night goes on. Glimmer and Bow busy themselves with chitchat, card games, or watching youtube videos. *Fuzzfeed Unsolved* has yet to update since their season finale and the hunter has waited impatiently for any news on their return. Nothing. At one point in the night, snacks are brought into the room for some energy.

Adora continues to do nothing other than noises and jerks. As dawn slowly creeps along, the werewolf starts to stir. She's still on Jupiter, however. Glimmer decides to give her delirious friend some water. The werewolf attempts to bite her but teeth only snaps air. She waits a moment for Adora to settle before trying again. This time around, the hunter gets water into her, though sloppily. Water gets all over Adora's fur and Glimmer's clothing.

At the first signs of orange slivers in the sky, Glimmer lifts her tired body from the floor. Bow follows suit, trailing right behind her. He is doing his best to stay awake. No one seems to be able to keep up with Glimmer's internal clock. The hunter tries to get her friend to rest up but he refuses. At least until he has helped set up breakfast for Adora. There isn't any need for help, all there's to it is water and some crackers or bread to help the blonde get the gears going for the day. Yet, Bow pours the water needed while Glimmer puts some butter on slices of bread. Once everything is set, Bow finally collapses on the couch to recharge his batteries. The second Glimmer hears the *thud,* snoring fills the air.

Rest easy, Bow.

Glimmer pushes open the door and settles the food and drink down on the nightstand. Behind her, Adora groans. The second shift is at hand and the wolfsbane is beginning to wear off. She knows this from the low growl that the werewolf keeps emitting whenever she gets a bit *too* close. The hunter continues to set up shop for when Adora gains control. Heading into the bathroom,

she throws a towel over the curtains. She checks the blonde's things in the room. Her condition and shampoo. Plenty. Her sandalwood soap. Still good (and still smells wonderful). Almost everything is in place.

She steps back into the room, eyes falling on the blanket at the edge of the bed. The faded yellow fabric that has seen better days sits as a square, waiting to be unfolded. It was the only article of clothing on Adora all those months ago. Ever since then, she keeps it in the room. Glimmer has never asked why she keeps it around, though she suspects this is her last personal belonging before coming to Brightmoon. The hunter has decided today, once Adora is in bed, she'll spread it over her.

There is another groan, one more harsh. Glimmer whips her head around, finding the werewolf shaking violently. Fur recedes into either light, pale hairs on her arms and legs or long, dark blonde on her head that falls down her back. Her muzzle becomes non-existent, teeth becoming near useless for piercing flesh and bones. Clawed fingers become calloused hands and her ears and tail disappear from the world. Where there once was a meaning and drugged up werewolf now resides a naked, confused woman.

For a moment, Adora opens her eyes. Her head rolls to the side, sky blue irises showing no signs of anyone being home. She mumbles something before going limp again, body far too exhausted from the shift to continue on. Glimmer sighs before digging into her pocket.

"Let's get you somewhere comfy, 'Dora."

She unlatches the chains. The silver falls to the ground, clattering against the hardwood. Glimmer wastes no time in reaching out, grabbing Adora before her body hits the ground. The hunter gathers up her friend, finally having learned how to carry so much deadweight by herself, and settles her in the bed. She pulls the covers up, including the old blanket. The moment her belonging is brought near her, Adora sighs softly. Glimmer swears she spots the flash of a small, small smile.

“Rest up, Adora,” Glimmer says, tucking a loose strand of hair behind her friend’s ear. Part of her wants to stay with her. Hell, *curl up* besides her to ensure further safety. But nothing bad will happen now that they have a rhythm. Sleeping on the ground was one thing, Adora asking her to stay in the hotel bed was another, but this...this is a bit too awkward and weird. For now, it’s her own bed.

“If you need me, you know where I’ll be.”

“How are you guys doing?” Perfuma asks as the ringing bell dies down. The faery is playing around with her magic. A potted plant besides her blooms and closes up with every flick of her wrist. By what Glimmer knows of flowers, it’s some type of orchid.

“Fine as I can be,” Glimmer states. “Gotta get ready for fall.” She gestures towards Adora dressed only in a t-shirt and shorts. While the temperature has not become frigid, the heat from the sun has dimmed. Even Adora, who claims to be a living furnace, needs to be bundled up for the harsh Brightmoon winter.

Scorpia’s head suddenly appears out from a clothing rack. Dark eyes are bright. “Oh!!! Need new clothing? I can help with that!”

Adora, Glimmer, and Perfuma all chuckle at the sight. Adora leans forward, eyes landing on the faery. “Hey, do you have any of those energy potions? I forgot to take some this morning.”

“Oh yeah sure.” Perfuma’s hands light up. In a matter of seconds, a glass bottle with green liquid floats through the air. Adora snatches it and begins sipping it down as she walks around the room.

Glimmer, meanwhile, takes her own look around. She has no interest in buying anything but browsing around is always nice. Maybe as fall goes on, she’ll get her own things. For now, making sure Adora doesn’t freeze her tail off is top priority. There were a couple of times in the past where either someone would show up

or her mother found someone nearly frozen. Fur only lasts so long.

By the time Glimmer is looking at some scarfs, fingertips brushing against the cotton, Adora and Scorpia have already gathered up clothing. There is shuffling before the blonde pops out of the dressing room, dawning a white and gold jacket. Scorpia absolutely loves it by the look on her face. Adora dips back into the dressing room for something else in her pile.

Least she seems to be enjoying herself.

Out of the corner of her eye, Glimmer sees Perfuma leaning on the desk. "How've things been living with Adora?"

"Fine. Didn't know how much I wanted a roommate around."

Adora pops out of the dressing room again, wearing a light blue sweater. She does a small spin for Scorpia. It looks good on her.

"You're smiling," Perfuma chirps.

"Yeah, so?" Glimmer replies.

"Bow's been telling me he sees the way you look at her. I'm seeing it now, I know what that feeling is like." She gestures her head towards Scorpia.

"God, remind me why you two broke up when guys you still have the same damn brain cell."

"We still love each other, just ya know, not romantically anymore. Love can be weird but it was worth taking that chance with him. I don't regret it."

For Adora's final outfit, she has slipped on a dark red sweatshirt. When the blonde spots her friend, she waves before spinning on her heels. Thumbs go over her shoulders, pointing at the pair of small wings on the backside. "We can match!" she shouts.

“She’s one heck of a girl, ya know,” Perfuma smiles.

“I’m going to tape both yours and Bow’s mouths shut at this rate.” Glimmer pinches the bridge of her nose before changing the subject. “Heard anything yet at all?”

Perfuma’s face goes dark, knowing what she means. “No. Not yet. Not even any injuries. It’s still early in the day.”

"Worth a shot to ask.” Glimmer blows a tuft of hair away from her face.

“We’ll let you know if we hear anything. Don’t worry about it.”

“Thanks.”

Adora and Scorpia walk up to the pair, a bundle of clothing in their arms. Pefuma checks everything out, stuffing everything in a paper bag.

“All ready for the fall?” Perfuma asks. “The leaves are really pretty when they change colors.”

A twinkle forms in Adora’s blue eyes. “I can’t wait to see ‘em.”

“You know, since Glimmer has been here all her life I bet she knows all the great spots.”

I’m gonna kill you, Glimmer mouths. Perfuma gives a wink. Out of the corner of her eye, the hunter sees Adora trying to hide her redding face with her bag.

There is no word for a while. September creeps along, slowly turning down the world’s thermostat. Adora continues to push her luck with her clothing, wearing shorts even as the morning temperatures barely past the 60s and frost begins to appear. One day when most of the day was spent in the 50s, Glimmer *somehow* got Adora to put on jeans and her new jacket, the latter of which she has taken quite the liking to.

It is not until the leaves begin to change, when tips become red, orange, or yellow and snap away from branches, is there news. One that no one wanted to hear but everyone has been dreading. Adora and Glimmer are enjoying getting hands on some fall special coffees and treats, almost forgetting what has been going on when Glimmer's phone vibrates.

"Huh, it's a link from Scorpia," Glimmer states.

"What's it say?" Adora asks after chewing a cinnamon donut.

Glimmer clicks it. Her phone exits out of the messages and sends her into a new tab on her web browser. From the quick glance she got of the link, it's a hunter website. Sure enough, when her browser loads, it asks for a password. She quickly types it in with only her thumb. It accepts it and gives her access to the website. She chokes on her coffee as she reads the headline, her heart sinking in her chest.

Adora is quickly at her side, rubbing her back as her airways clear. "What the hell did Scorpia send?!?" the blonde asks.

Glimmer shifts her phone. When she hears a soft ' *oh'* , the hunter knows she must be feeling the same way. The headline reads:

WEREWOLF'S BODY FOUND AT MIRROR LAKE,

STILL IN THEIR WOLF FORM.

"What the hell does it mean 'still in their wolf form'?" Adora whispers. She takes a glance around to make sure no one has heard her.

"Let's walk," Glimmer replies.

They quickly pay for their things, making the dine-in a take-out. However, neither say anything while going through the streaming crowds. Chatter fills their ears, words of people blissfully unaware of the events going on. Even if they have heard about animal

attacks on the news, they pay little mind to what is happening. *Never could happen to me,* they all think.

Glimmer grits her teeth and quickens her pace. *Who got killed this time? Did I know them? Could I have done something if I knew about these attacks sooner? Why the hell did they never shift back?*

Questions stream through her mind. Words begin to meld together, sentences becoming indistinguishable from each other. All she knows is whoever this bastard or bastards are, she wants to *find* them.

"Hey, hey, hey!" Adora's hand grips her shoulder, spinning her around. The crowd has disappeared. Hell, they are in a small alleyway, prying eyes and ears will not be able to spy on them. The blonde's thumb rubs gently at the base of Glimmer's neck. "Are you okay?"

"What do you think?" Glimmer groans.

"You know what I mean." Adora takes a look around, tilting her head for a moment. She lets go of her friend. "I think no one will hear us here. So, what did that mean? I am guessing it's bad."

Glimmer runs her head through her hair. "Yeah, really bad. I don't even know how it's possible they found them still in that form."

"What do you mean?"

"Normally, when someone like you or just any non-human who doesn't have a natural 'human' form dies, they'll revert back to what they normally are. Say, someone like a...," she pauses for a moment, letting anything come in her mind, "centaur. If they died while looking human, whatever they used to look like that be it magic, potions, whatever, it will wear off. They'll turn back to their centaur self.

"With werecreatures same thing. If they die when in a wolf or cat or whatever form, when the sun rises they *should* still return to

their human form. They wouldn't've been gone long enough to prevent anything from stopping it. A lot of times in the old days, like medieval, after a werecreature was killed they waited to see who the hell it was."

Adora tugs on the collar of her shirt, gulping.

"Sorry."

"So, this is *really* bad. You have no idea what could have happened? Do you think Teela or Petra knew?"

Glimmer shakes her head. She crosses her arms against her chest as she paces around. A crumbled up soda can stands in her way, which she kicks. The aluminium bouncing down the concrete, echoing off the close walls. "No. Not at all. And I'm not sure. They may or may not have gotten all the details of attacks or maybe this is the first one like this. I really don't know."

There is a pause in their conversation before Adora speaks. "Would your mother have any idea?"

"What?" the hunter stops in her tracks, turning to face Adora. Her friend rubs the back of her neck.

"Your mother didn't leave anything behind that might help? Never took notes like you do?"

"She did. What I was able to find didn't have much but there probably is more. She was the one watching over Brightmoon for so many years and probably kept stuff hidden. I'm sure I missed stuff."

"Would it be okay to try and look for them? Do you know where she would have hidden them?"

"Yeah...Yeah I do…"

It's in the one room she hasn't been in for years. Her mother's room. Only once after Angella's death did she step foot inside. It

was too much for her to bear, however. Seeing the neat and tidy room, seeing all of her mother's belongings. The things she'll never use again, never get to add to her collection. Once her father moved out, Glimmer shut the door and that is how it has stayed since. Sealed up.

"Glim?" Adora softly asks.

"It's...It's would be my m-mother's room."

"Oh. Oh, I'm sorry. We don't have to if it's too painful."

Glimmer takes a deep breath. Shaking hands curl into tight fists. She can feel the tear pricking at the edge of her eyes. People are dying, being murdered. Even if it is the slightest of chances that her mother has answers to what is going on, they *need* to take it. The bloodshed needs to end.

"No. No. If she knew something, we have to. She wouldn't want me, us, to sit by."

Footsteps draw closer to her. Rough yet warm fingers brush against the back of her hand, getting her own fingers to unfurl. Once not in a fist, Adora takes the hunter's hand in her own. Glimmer looks up and finds the blonde smiling softly. Behind dark bangs, blue eyes are warm and loving.

"I'll be right there if you need anything. We'll do it together."

Glimmer's heart flutters in her heart. She squeezes Adora's hand back, wordlessly thanking her.

They head back. Glimmer's foot crunches up the few leaves that rest on the sidewalk. Hands remain locked together. She doesn't care if anyone thinks they are together. If Adora lets go, she'll crumble. Every step closer to her home, the more her body trembles. The more her heart beats in the middle of her throat. The more she wants to curl up in the middle of the sidewalk and not return home. Not rip that would open anymore than it has these past couple months.

If Adora minds, she doesn't announce it. She tries to pass the time with small chat but with little response from the hunter, she drops it. Once in a while, her thumb will brush the back of her hand. Glimmer has no idea what she'd do without Adora.

The house seems different when they get home. Quieter...Stiller...Even the creaking of the boards under her feet do not sound the same. The shut door gives off a dreadful aura. Once she opens this door she cannot turn back. She *has* to do this.

"You okay?" Adora asks, hand still in hand.

"No." Glimmer takes a deep breath. "Let's get this over with."

She lets go of Adora, her hand now wrapping around the brass knob. Another breath. A twist and push. The door squeaks as it opens.

The room is exactly as she left it. Her bed, one with a blanket draped over the mattress with the Mizari family emblem on it, is neat. Waiting for the elder hunter to return and take a long rest in it. Dust has ended up on the dresser but besides that fine layer, everything is neat. Put in place with a careful eye. Curtains wait to be drawn shut as they let the orange sunset pour into the room. Glimmer can still faintly smell the scent of roses from her mother's perfume.

Glimmer feels her mouth quivering. She wants to hold onto Adora again, cling to her and get away from this place. But she needs to keep pressing forward. The hunter stops at a small table, lined with photos. Her mother when she was her age, young and eager to prove herself. Her hair, blonde from the lack of dye, is tied into a braid. Another photo is the wedding photo, the same one as Glimmer's lockscreen. But it's the one in the middle that breaks her heart into millions of pieces.

A shaking hand reaches out, bringing the frame closer. Letters on the metal read *'Precious Memories'.* Inside, is her mother at the

hospital. Swaddled in a purple blanket, is Glimmer herself. Small– smaller than most infants should ever be. A tuft of raven hair rests on her head and violet eyes stare up at her mother. There's a thin, small tube taped to her tiny cheeks, running into her nose to help keep her alive. This must be the first time her mother *finally* got to hold the child she and Micah desperately wanted.

When was the last time her mother held her?

"I'm so sorry, Mom," Glimmer sniffs.

She wipes misty eyes, trying everything in her power to keep herself together right now. Glimmer places the photo back down, remembering what she is here for. The hunter spins around and opens her mouth, wanting to ask Adora if she has spotted anything. However, she finds the blonde on the other side of the room, back turned. Glimmer swears she is shaking.

"Adora?" Glimmer asks.

Slowly, her friend turns around. Grasped in her hands is, surprisingly, her mother's perfume. Blue eyes are wide and swimming in water. A hand cupped over her mouth, tears running down her arm.

"Adora?!?"

"G-Glimmer…" the blonde starts after removing her hand, voice uneven. "I-I-I know this smell," she points at the bottle in her hand. "I know this!"

"How? Only my mother really used that one!"

"I know. I know it sounds crazy, Glimmer, that is what I am saying! I think...I think I knew your mother!"

The moment Adora enters the room, her heart picks up its pace and goosebumps form on her skin. There is a sinking feeling in

the pit of her stomach. She recognizes the symbol on the blanket. Once more, some claws at the back of her mind, trying to pull itself free. As Glimmer slowly walks around, the blonde does her own stroll. Eyes land on something on the dresser. A glass perfume bottle.

Curiosity gets the better of her. She grabs the small bottle and brings it to her nose. There is no need for her to press the top to figure out what is inside. Her nose can pick it up easily enough by the pinprick opening. She expects something soft to her scenes, warm and welcoming. This is, yes, what she gets. But the moment her brain picks up on the rosey smell, it *jolts* awake. Whatever has been clawing at the back of her skull breaks free. The hole in her mind now spews out long forgotten images.

Adora gasps as her mind is assaulted. She's a recent runaway, struggling to live. The woods are her only friend, the only thing that keeps her from harming anyone. She's shifting, something she always struggles to recall. The moon is hanging high above, waiting for the creature inside of her to tear free. But then, the outline of a tall, slender woman appears. Her dyed hair flows behind her and eyes like amethyst stare back at her with sadness.

On her chest, embroidered on her vest pocket, is a crescent moon with bird-like wings at its side. The bag she is missing since June replaces everything, putting two and two together.

A hand covers her mouth, stifling a cry crawling up her throat. Nothing can stop the memories forming. There is no doubt about it, Angella is staring back at her.

"Adora?" Glimmer asks from behind.

Slowly, Adora turns around to face her friend. She cannot hold back the tears falling from her face. For a brief moment, she sees Angella again, reflected back in her daughter. With a blink, it is only Glimmer.

“Adora?!?” the hunter says again, worried.

“G-Glimmer…” Adora removes her hand in a shaking voice. “I-I-I know this smell,” she points at the bottle in her hand. “I know this!”

“How? Only my mother really used that one!”

“I know. I know it sounds crazy, Glimmer, that is what I am saying! I think...I think I knew your mother!”

Glimmer takes a step back. Shock is written clear as day on her face and her jaw drops open. She shakes her head, trying to rid the unbelievable thought in her head. “H-How the hell did you know her!”

Adora clutches the side of her head, trying to piece all the images in her head into something coherent. She cannot control her breathing. “I’m trying...It’s all confusing. I...I know this smell. It was on my bag! I...I,”

Her legs, shaking from the revelation, no longer can hold her weight. She collapses onto the soft carpet, back smacking against the drawers. Adora winces from the pain. Though, it helps bring her back to some sense of reality. Glimmer wastes no time to be at her side.

“Are you okay?!?” she worries.

“I’m fine, I’m fine,” Adora gasps, gaining control of her breath. “Give me a minute.”

Glimmer settles beside her. “You really knew her?”

Adora looks back at the bottle in her hands. She takes another whiff, the same rosey smell filling her. The images become crisp—clear.

“Yeah. I do. Least, I met her once.”

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5 Years Ago

Adora breathes heavily, the night just cool *enough* her warm breath forms a thin cloud. She wraps the pale, yellow blanket around her, keeping her exposed body shielded from the elements. Her small bag, barely able to hold her few belongings, is kept close by. With only one strap working, it's only a matter of time before it becomes obsolete. But that is the least of her worries right now.

She lifts shaking hands to her face. Nails are darkening, ready to turn into something that'll tear up flesh and muscles. She feels her canines, *fangs,* pressing against her lips, wanting to break bones. Adora has already thrown up her dinner and continues to taste bile in her mouth. A groan leaves her lips, her body pressing up against the hard birch tree as it shudders. Her stomach continues to do backflips.

Above her, the bright, pale moon taunts her. It's partner in crime doesn't want to come out yet. They both cause her suffering right now. As much as Adora dreads becoming a monster, she *hates* the waiting. She wants this to be over. Over so she then can regain control of her body.

Adora squeezes her eyes shut, a tear escaping. She's alone in these strange woods. Unfamiliar trees stare back at her. Animals she's never seen before watching, curious over what a lone, twenty-year-old is doing by herself in the dead of night. But this still is far better than being with her adoptive mother and sister. Hopefully, she has put much distance between them and will never see their faces again. Never have to deal with her mother trying to get her to *hurt* people. To be the monster that rests inside of her.

She'll never let that happen.

A snap of a twig pulls her out of her thoughts. In the battle to keep control, the wolf temporarily wins. Adora releases a low growl and stands on hands and feet. Even as she takes back the steering wheel, she remains still, frightened at what could be lurking out here. Out from a line of trees, a woman appears. In the moonlight, Adora can make out all of her features.

She is older. Old enough to be Adora's very own mother, though she looks *nothing* like her. Whatever color her natural hair is, only she knows. Rather, long locks are dyed pink and purple. Her fair skin only has a few wrinkles. Though, her amethyst eyes are full of...sadness? Tiredness? Something Adora cannot put her finger on. Her vest has some symbol on it the blonde never has seen before. Doesn't matter much. The wolf is starting to fight back.

Another growl.

"You poor dear," the woman says softly. She slowly walks forward. Adora backs up.

"W-Who a-are you?" Adora manages to say. "S-Stay away f-from m-me!"

The woman kneels down on the forest floor. "I won't harm you. I want to help."

Adora scoffs.

"I know what's happening to you, that time is short. A shift right? I guess you can't control it."

Adora's eyes go wide. Who the hell is this woman? She watches as the woman digs into her pocket, pulling out some concoction.

"I cannot stay long, I must be on my way. This isn't my area to be in. You may not even remember me in the morning. But you look like my...like my daughter's age." Her voice breaks at that statement. Adora can smell the sorrow, no, the *wrenching heart-ache,* coming from her. "I would like to help you."

“Please.”

This is the last thing Adora gets out before she is kicked out of the driver’s seat. Red hot pain overwhelms her.

…

The next thing she knows, Adora is staring up at a wooden ceiling. She groans, feeling her body against a hard mattress. Her trusted blanket covers her sore body. Why the hell does her neck hurt? Did she sleep on it weird? Slowly, the blonde pushes herself up, getting a better gauge of her surroundings.

Somehow, she has ended up in a one room wooden building. All there is is the bed she lies on, a small dresser and desk, several windows, and a door. Adora blinks, confused. Wasn’t she outside before? How the hell did she end up in this building? Did someone bring her here? Who on earth would do that without being mauled to death? Or, who would when seeing a naked woman in the middle of the fuckin’ woods?

Something draws her attention elsewhere. There is a new bag sitting on the dresser beside her. Adora gingerly takes it and places it on her lap, feeling the new weight. All of her things are in here, which is not much. Some clothes and money. But that’s not all. There is food, protein bars mostly, and bottles of water. She definitely did not have this much cash before and there seems to be some extra clothing for her. Adora wonders if they will fit her. Some pockets have small bits of medicine or first aid. There still is room to spare.

What the hell? Adora wonders. Did someone find her? That is the only answer. Why else is she here? This must be why a practical care package is in her hands. She brings it closer to her nose, hoping to get a scent. What enters her nostrils is the scent of roses. She can see them blooming in a beautiful field in her mind. Her own angel is made up of these wondrous flowers.

When her stomach growls, Adora takes the risk of eating the food. Thankfully, they aren't lace with poison and hit the spot. After sipping down water, putting on clothing, and stuffing her blanket away, she throws the new bag over her shoulders and heads out.

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There is a silence between the two as Adora finishes her story. She herself cannot believe the words that have come out of her mouth. After so long of wondering, and having given up years ago, who the owner of the bag was, she has an answer.

"She...She must've knocked you out with wolfsbane or something like we do," Glimmer is the first to speak. "If she was traveling I can see why she couldn't stay but she brought you to a safe house. Some areas have those to make sure werecreatures or anyone else have a safe spot during the night."

"She saved my life," Adora states. "I was pretty down on my luck then. That bag helped me a lot. Hell, the food I don't know how long I went without something really good tasting before then." She sniffs, wiping a tear from her face. "You both helped me out, huh? Like mother, like daughter?"

"Yeah...Yeah I guess so," Glimmer sighs. She too wipes tears away from reddened eyes. "It's good to know she helped you. That you did get to meet her."

"She was an amazing woman and I wish I could've thanked her."

"I'm sure just being alive and happy is good enough for her." Glimmer fiddles with her fingers. "But I know what it's like to have words not said to her."

"I remember."

"You deserve to know more." Glimmer stands.

"Where are you going?"

“I think we both need some water right now. When I come back, I have my own story to tell about her and…” Adora watches as the hunter grips her stomach, where her scars are. “Something else.”

Chapter End Notes

Comments and kudos appreciated

One quick note there will be one more update, it's a big one and then it will be a break which I'll give more info on but I will see yall next week!!! (On sunday!)

Let It Out

Chapter Notes

> so this chapter i went insane with and is like....11k....so have fun. Like i said before this is the last chapter for now as I am taking another break. How long will it be? Idk cause I have written like nothing, Ill explain more below. But yeah maybe ill shorten the next batch to like 2 or 3 chapters but we will see.
>
> anyway, tws are panic attacks, death, nightmares, blood and injury, grief, uh idk if i am missing anything else this chapter just has a LOT going on but enjoy (oh and there will be another small skip back like last chapter)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

2 Years Ago

Glimmer sits alone at the traffic light, waiting for the red glow to turn green. The steady rhythm of her blinker is the only noise that fills her ears. At this hour of the night, there isn't really anything good to listen to on the radio. Fingers tap against the steering wheel. This must be the world's longest light. How long has she been sitting here waiting to make a left hand turn? Glimmer is tempted to say 'fuck it' and just go. However, she refuses to move her foot from the brake pedal. She has to be good. For her mother's sake.

Months ago, Glimmer got over herself and slowly started to talk to her mother again. Their last talk, if you want to call it that, was a fight. Newly eighteen, she had wanted to *finally* go out to help more with hunts. After all, isn't that what she was raised up to be? There had been some non-humans causing issues in neighbouring areas and Glimmer ***desperately*** wanted to prove herself. But one again, her mother told her no. 'It's too dangerous', 'You're not old enough', 'Next time'. Over and over

again, like a broken record, Glimmer heard this and on that fateful night, everything she held in, bottled away and pushed back, burst out like a damn.

The words she spatted at her mother still ring in her ears.

` ***I hate you!*** ’

And that was that. She stormed off. When her mother was not home, Glimmer went back, took her things, and never looked back. She bites down on her lip now, forehead pressing against the hard steering wheel. How stupid could she be? Why did she say that? Why didn’t she take it back right then in there. Normally having a stoic mask on, her mother’s face *broke* that night. Never before has Glimmer seen that type of painful heartache in her eyes.

“Stupid. Stupid. Stupid.” Glimmer hits her forehead against the wheel. “You’re a real fuckin’ asshole, Glimmer.”

She cannot fully blame her mother for being overprotective. When you try for so long to have a child, only for their birth to be fought with issues, can you blame anyone? Add on the job of being a hunter where death can linger right around the corner, anyone would want to protect their child. Glimmer still wishes her mother allowed her to do more but she does understand Angella’s viewpoint now.

And it seems her mother has begun to understand her daughter’s view of wanting to live up to their name and helping others. They can start over, and now they have.

It began with simple text once in a while before evolving into calls at least every week. Now it will be the first time either have seen each other in person in about three years. Her nerves run wild from anticipation of seeing her mother again after so long and the anxiety of giving a proper apology for those words she said.

A blaring horn snaps her to attention. The light has turned a bright green and a car has materialized behind her. Glimmer

removes her foot from one pedal and places it to the other. Her car jerks back to life and down the next street she goes. Her aunt's house is not terribly far away now and no more lights stand in the way, only a couple stop signs.

By the time she gets to the small ranch house, it is almost two in the morning. By far not the latest she has stayed up. Though that does not stop tiredness from attempting to take hold. Maybe she should have taken a nap before driving all the way down here. With a yawn, Glimmer gathers her things and steps out into the cool night air. Legs shake as she travels down the pathway and towards the two stairs. She pauses at the first one, her whole body now trembling. This is it. She'll finally be face-to-face with her mother after so long, after all the things she said to her.

Finally…

With a deep inhale, Glimmer forces herself up to the front porch and through the front door. "Hello?"

"Hello, dear!" her aunt's voice rings in her ears. Before she can even locate the older woman, Castaspella's arms wrap around her torso, crushing her rib cage. Glimmer wheezes as all the air is forced out of her lungs. "How are you?"

"Fine! Fine!" Glimmer gasps. "Please let go!"

"Right, sorry."

Castaspella lets go, allowing Glimmer to breathe once more. She begins to rub the back of her neck. It does not take long to spot her father. His beard has grown longer the last time she saw him and he has put his hair back up in a small ponytail. He gives an equally tight hug but manages not to break any ribs. To add to the loving gesture, he ruffles up her raven colored hair.

" *Dad!"* Glimmer almost whines. She shoves him away.

"How are you doing, my little Sweetpea?"

“Fine. Just a little tired.” Glimmer takes another look around the room. “Where’s Mom?”

“She got called out to deal with something in the forest,” Castaspella replies. “Didn’t say much but she should be back soon.”

“O-Oh.”

“Do you want to go out and find her? I’m sure she wouldn’t mind the help,” Micah adds on.

Glimmer rocks on her heels, thinking. She is disappointed her mother is not around, that she has to continue to wait to see her once more. But duty called and it is a full moon. “I might just pass. The drive wiped me out. I can wait for her for a bit or see her in the morning.”

“Let's get a bed ready for you. Put your stuff down and settle in.” Her father bends down and places a kiss on his daughter’s temple. “Maybe we can all get breakfast in the morning.”

Glimmer nods with a heavy head. While Micah sets up the pull out bed inside the couch, Castaspella aids her niece in finding a place for her things. They stow everything away in a nearby closet. By the time everything is stacked away, with no risk of toppling over, the bed is all set and ready. Glimmer doesn’t even bother changing into her pajamas. She promptly flops down on the creaky bed face first. Her father pulls the covers up to her neck before wishing her a goodnight. The last thing she hears is the howl of a creature of the night.

…

Glimmer is a heavy sleeper, always has been. However, the next morning, something disturbs her slumber. Soft whispering. Glimmer blinks open her eyes, her sight blurred. Her vision slowly returns to normal. Nothing but the wall stares back at her. The noises that stirred her awake come from behind. With a groan,

she pushes herself up and twists her head to the side. Shadows dance around nearby, their owners hidden by a wall.

“Dad? Aunt Casta?” Glimmer mumbles, recognizing two of the *three* shadows. No answer. Confused, she climbs out of bed and staggers towards the front door.

When she rounds the corner, she finds her father and aunt standing by the door. Whoever they are talking to is blocked by their bodies. For a moment, Glimmer thinks maybe it is her mother finally returning from the forest. However, the other voice speaking is gruff and deep. Now she is even more confused.

“Dad? Aunt Casta? What’s going on,” Glimmer asks, louder for her family to hear.

Both siblings turn around. Castaspella’s brown eyes have turned red and misty. Her father has its own sheen and tint to them. Glimmer can see how tight he is holding his jaw, as if he lets go everything will crumble. The man they are talking to is not one she recognizes. Based on his clothing, various scars on exposed skin, and the hidden knife in his sock Glimmer’s trained eyes can see, he’s a hunter.

Her heart sinks to the pit of her empty stomach, making the bile tickle at the back of her throat. Why is he here?

“D-Dad? Aunt C-Casta?” Glimmer repeats, voice unable to remain steady.

“Sweetpea, have you eaten yet? Why don’t you go eat or take a shower. Sorry for waking you,” her dad says as if she was a child. A child who walked into something she should not have. He is pushing her out. By the looks on their faces, it’s for protection. But Glimmer is no child.

“Dad.” Glimmer steps forward. The closer she gets to her family, the more she knows there won’t be turning back. Whatever is going on, she wants that bandaid off *now* , even if it kills her. “Dad. Dad what is going on! Please don’t lie to me.”

“Honey, go back to bed,” Castaspella says in a quivering voice.

“No. No, I'm not a fuckin’ child. *Tell* me what is going on! W-Where’s Mom?!?”

The siblings exchange a concerned look, neither wanting to speak first. The strange hunter decides for them. He walks past them and right up to Glimmer. He towers over her by a foot and his light irises have their own sadness to them. “You have her eyes,” he softly says. “So you’re Glimmer? Your mom told me a lot about you.”

“You know my mother? W-Wh...What ha-” The words stick to the inside of her throat. No matter how hard she tries to pull them out, it is of no use. She fears once they leave her lips, she will hear the worst news of her life.

The older hunter glups before continuing. “She went out last night. A few others were nearby and when she never checked in later we went looking for her. And...And,” his voice begins to quiver. “I’m sorry. We found her not too long ago. We were too late.”

Too late…

“N-No. Y-You’re joking,” Glimmer starts, unable to believe the words spoken.”S-She’s...She’s not gone. I’m still d-dreaming, right? *Right?!?”*

Her father steps forward. “Sweetpea...Glimmer. I’m sorry.”

Ears begin to ring. Glimmer sees mouths moving but nothing comes out of them. The world becomes *hot,* like she has been sent to the center of the earth. Some unseen force squeezes her throat shut, marking it near impossible to breathe. Someone touches her but the moment she feels them, Glimmer pulls away. Everything in her line of sight has become blurred and the world spins out of control.

This ***can't*** be happening. Her mother is gone? Dead? It cannot be *real.* Everything feels like a horrible dream that she cannot wake up from. Didn't she *just* talk to her mother over the phone only yesterday morning? Didn't she *just* text her before driving? How? How the hell did this happen?!? Why did this happen?!?

Glimmer opens her mouth to say something, she feels something coming out but hears nothing but the ring.

The next thing Glimmer knows, she is on a bed. Her aunt's to be exact. She's alone in the room, afternoon sunlight seeping through the blinds. Glimmer's head pounds, her throat ache and feels like sandpaper, and her left hand stings. She tilts her head to the side and finds her fingers and palms wrapped in white bandaging stained in red. Almost everything that has happened, why everything aches and why she is in this room, is a blur. All but one thing.

Her mother is gone.

Eyes become wet and her aching throat becomes more raw. There is nothing she can do to stop the tears and sobs coming from her body. Her mother is *gone.* She'll never hear her mother's voice again. Never receive a comforting hug again. Never share with her the things that are bothering her. She'll never get to say sorry for all the shit she did.

Why didn't I go out last night?!? Glimmer questions to herself. *I could've helped! I could've saved her!*

Her sobs must have caught the attention of those outside of the room. The door creaks open, her father appearing in the frame. His brown eyes have finally turned red and puffy. Without saying anything, he walks over to the bed. Glimmer quickly nestles into her father's arms, burying her face into his chest. Arms wrap tightly around her body and fingers rub her stained cheeks. Micah's chin rests on top of her dark hair.

“I’m sorry. I’m sorry. I’m sorry.” Glimmer sobs into her father’s chest.

“Shh, shh. There is nothing to be sorry about. It’s not your fault,” Micah whispers into her ears.

“I should’ve gone out! I should’ve helped her!”

Micah squeezes her tighter. “That’s not your fault. You could’ve gotten hurt or killed also if you went out. It’s not your fault, Sweetpea.”

Words no longer fall out of Glimmer’s mouth, only sobs. She knows her father means well, she *knows* this isn’t her fault, that she isn’t to blame. Yet, guilt has her like a vice grip. A hot one full of rage.

A month has passed since her mother’s death. The funeral and wake—attended by many hunters, humans, and non-humans alike—has come and gone. They cremated her, spreading her ashes within the Whispering Woods. Now, she’ll forever be watching over the place she has protected all her life. Forever keeping an eye out for any troubles. Glimmer was the one to let the wind carry her mother off. An unconventional passing of the torch.

That has been the only time she has returned to her home since leaving it years ago. She had to deal with some stuff at college but there also is the job of gathering her mother’s things that she left behind at Castaspella’s house and trying to locate any inkling of clues to who attacked and killed her mother. Whatever was out in the woods last month, no one knows. The only person who does is gone. No matter how hard anyone has tried, it all has been in vain.

Glimmer isn’t about to give up.

She has waited for this night all month long. The next full moon when creatures of the night shall be out. The past week has been nothing but a blur leading up to this moment. She cannot recall

how many hours of sleep she has gotten, only that the grocery store probably has her on a banned list for buying coffee. Now that the full moon is hanging high in the night sky, she prepares for her search for her mother's killer. For the first time in a while, she has dug out her hunter gear and is just about ready to step out into the woods.

Thankfully, or not, her father and aunt are not around. They won't be back until tomorrow. Her only concern comes from those blowing up her phone. When it buzzes once more, Glimmer clicks the button on the side, not bothering to look at the name. She knows Bow and Perfuma will be here soon. Most likely, they won't like the idea of her going out in the middle of the night. Stubbornness is a key trait of hers, so it's not like she can easily be swayed once her mind is made up.

Another vibrate, another click off. Glimmer finishes gathering up her things, settling her crossbow against her back and her silver knife in her boot. Without a second thought, without missing a single beat, she heads out into the dark woods. The moonlight, a trusted companion of hers, allows her to see for the most part. However, her human vision does little to help. Wrap tightly in her fingers, a flashlight gives her more sight in the darkness.

She has no idea if the thing that killed her mother is still here. A whole month has passed, who knows how far anyone can travel in that time frame. But sometimes, non-humans will linger around. Glimmer recalls stories of killers hanging around the area they attacked others to see the panic, chaos, and anger. She wonders if her target is around and is getting some sick satisfaction from her misery. Well, if they are, she is going to wipe their smile off their face. Glimmer continues her hike through the woods.

Any snap of a branch, call of an unseen animal, or leaves rustling in the wind sends the hunter's heart into a frenzy. Her head spins around, knowing every second matters. Part of her is tempted to call out, *dare* the creature to come out and try their luck with her. She wants the element of surprise. The best thing to have when you are blind as fuck and have no supernatural powers.

Glimmer begins to circle back, covering parts she failed to do so. She grumbles the whole way but remains determined. Nothing is going to stop her from her mission.

Everything that happens next, happens in a dark blur of fur and nails. One moment, Glimmer is making her own path and the next, a heavy weight *slams* her face first into the ground. All the air escapes her lungs and she is shocked that the cracking of ribs have not filled her ears. The hunter squirms out of a heavy paw, scrambling to her feet. She pries off her crossbow but just as it sails through the air, clipping *something,* sharp claws slice through her stomach.

Glimmer cries out, pain erupting all throughout her body. In a desperate attempt to live, feeling her shirt stick against her skin, she manages to pull her knife free from it's holder, slashing it and possible air. Another mark is made, she has no idea what. Colors are blurring together, shapes have no outline or figure. The hunter uses all her mind to focus on what has assaulted her.

A dark, shadowy form stands feet away from her, one paw stained red. Glimmer swears she hears it open their mouth to say something, a *threat* possibly, but her hearing has failed. Only her heart rapidly beating from fear and adrenaline, fills her ears. The last thing she can barely make out are silted eyes that are of two different shades.

The blackness that grips her is dark, cold, and heavy. She can't move, not even an inch. Is she dead? Is this what death is like? Has the long Mizari family line of hunters finally ended with her? This unknown creature or creatures in only a month has killed off both mother and daughter. At least now, maybe if there is a heaven or afterlife she can see Angella and say everything she had wanted to say.

Glimmer grits her teeth. She can't die, not yet. Her father and aunt, she cannot do that to them. Not when they are still so grief stricken. Bow and Perfuma, what about them? They had been calling and calling and calling her before. What will they feel if

they are the ones who discover her body? And, her mother's killer is still out there.

No. No she cannot die. Not here. Not where there is still so much left to do. Glimmer finds her strength, pushing herself forward, clawing her way out of this dark ocean. The world slowly comes back to her. She feels the weight of her limbs, hears the whispers of others, and the breeze of wind. Fingers break through the oil like water.

Glimmer opens her eyes. The ceiling fan of her aunt's home spins around above her. A soft blanket covers her body and her head is propped up by a pillow. Judging by the light pouring into the room, it's morning. Flicking her eyes to the side, she spots two familiar figures sleeping together on a smaller sofa.

"Bow? 'Fuma?" she croaks out. The words coming out of her throat feels like hundreds of small knives.

Perfuma's hazel eyes flutter open first. The second she sees that the hunter has returned to the world of the living, she begins shaking Bow.

"Honey, wake up!" she says

Bow groans as he exits whatever dream had been in. When he sees his best friend smiling back at him, his dark eyes grow bright lights and tears form. " *GLIM!"*

Perfuma lets him go. Bow scrambles off the sofa, nearly tripping and falling flat on his face, and races to her side. Glimmer attempts to push herself up but the moment she does, pain spreads out from her lower abdomen. The hunter suppresses a harsh cry.

"Take it easy," Bow softly says, brushing some of her bangs away. "You got really hurt."

"I bet," Glimmer laughs lightly, vaguely aware of what has happened. "I hope I didn't scare you two too much."

"Just be happy that Bow and I found you when we did," Perfuma states, drawing close to the sofa. "I did my best to patch you up but you need to take it easy."

"I don't think I'll be doing anything anytime soon." Glimmer finds her eyes growing heavy. No matter how hard she tries to keep them open, it is a losing battle.

"Rest," Bow whispers. "Your dad and aunt will be here soon."

Damn it. They're gonna worry so much… Glimmer thinks. However, she can only give a small nod in response before she slips back into unconsciousness.

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"And that's pretty much it," Glimmer finishes. The pair have migrated onto Angella's bed, backs pressed up against her head rest. One of Adora's arms is draped over Glimmer's shoulders while the hunter rests her head on her chest. "Freaked out my dad and aunt. Got a bit sick from whatever attacked me and infected me. But ya know. Never shifted. Just got some better hearing, smell, all that."

Adora's hand is twisted up, fingers brushing behind Glimmer's ear. "That's rough. I'm sorry."

"You have nothing to be sorry about," Glimmer sighs. Tears have long since dried up even with the water they have drunk. "There's nothing we can do to change the past, no matter how much we want to, huh?"

"Yeah…"

Glimmer shifts her head up. Adora's eyes are distant, her brow furrowed. Fingers continue to brush against the hunter's skin. Glimmer gives her friend a nudge. "Adora? What are you thinking about?"

"You said what attacked you had odd eyes?"

Glimmer gives a small shrug. "Well, I *think.* Kind of was dying at the moment. I don't even know what type of werecreature it was in all honesty."

"And my eyes turn red when I shift, correct?"

"Yeah. Why?" Glimmer pushes off of Adora, getting a better look at her. Sunset has nearly completed its course. The last of the sun's rays cast the blonde in a soft, yellow glow. She has her fist against the edge of her chin in thought. The hunter's eyes lock in place.

"I don't want to jump the gun, it *could* be anyone especially since you don't know what got you. But, my adoptive sister, Catra, had odd eyes. I don't know what she was like in her panther form but… *gah* !" She growls. "I really hope it's *not* her because I was hoping never to have to deal with her again. Guess we have a name to put on the list, though."

"For your sake, I hope it isn't her." Glimmer rubs small circles against Adora's back.

"Thank you. Man, this has been a lot of unloading. And we still haven't found anything in your mom's room."

Glimmer chuckles slightly. "I forgot all about that. I guess we need to look."

She swings her legs over the bed, feet pressing back against the floor. The two return to what they came here to do. Drawers are open, carefully checked. The mattress is lifted and all corners are inspected. Closet, nothing. Under the dresser, nothing. Adora has to check higher areas. Glimmer definitely didn't get her mother's towering height gene. Hell, the blonde doesn't come close either. Her tongue sticks out as her hand moves against the wooden top of a bookshelf.

"Ah! I think I got something!" Adora shouts, eyes bright.

“Really?!?” Glimmer says back, pulling herself out from behind the dresser.

Adora smiles broadly as she pulls the object down. An old, dusty, and faded notebook. The blonde blows the grey layer off the leather, regretting it right away. She coughs and sneezes.

“H-Here you g-go,” Adora wheezes, handing the book to Glimmer.

The hunter rubs a thumb against the cover. A little of her mother is back in her hands. Inside these pages might hold answers she and Adora have been seeking. Shaking hands pull back the paper, opening up to any old page.

“What the hell is this?”

What stares back at her, yes, is her mother’s neat handwriting. She recognizes the letters within the lines anywhere. However, the order they make up words is what spins her head.

“Is that...Latin?” Adora asks, looking over Glimmer’s shoulder.

“Yes it is. Jesus Christ, Mom!”

“Why did she write in Latin? How the heck does she know it? Is it a hunter thing?”

“It’s a hunter thing, yes. Some know another language, Latin is really popular. It’s tradition and if some idiot finds our notes, they’ll have a hard time reading it.”

“I’m guessing you can’t read it?”

“No,” Glimmer huffs. She snaps the book shut and sets it against the nearby dresser. “She tried to teach me but Latin never stuck. God, why didn’t she write it in something I understand!”

“Well, at least it’s something, right? We just have to find someone who can read it or understand enough.”

"Tck. Well I don't know anyone so it's going to be fun trying to find someone. Great…"

The growling of stomachs cuts them off. Both laugh. Neither realize just how long they have been here. Glimmer definitely has had enough being in here. She takes another look around, her heart still shattered. But upon eyes landing on Adora, the hunter can feel it starting to mend back together.

The room she's in is almost bare. Her and her sister's bed are on either side of the room (hers having a golden blanket resting on top). The dressers only have lamps on top and the sole bookshelf only has a handful of reading material. Any other possessions she or Catra might have are stowed away in small boxes under their beds.

Aside from her golden blanket, there is nothing on her bed. Same goes for her sister. The two have stripped the covering and built their own fort. Pillows become seats and Catra has dragged a lamp into the middle. When there isn't much to do and it's just the two of them, the sisters make their own fun and excitement. Both giggle as they tell their own made up stories.

Adora loves having a sister around, especially one around her age, only a few months younger. It's like a hole has been filled in her heart somehow. Catra is like her, almost. Born a werepanther. Left by her family and taken in by Shadow Weaver. Much of their talks, like now as they whisper into each other's ears, are of the future. What they want to do when they are older. Their pack is small, not much in the way of others. Their mother always says how others are horrible and Catra always agrees. She always talks about making sure humans never mess with people like them again. If they want to live in fear then ***so*** *be.*

Adora agrees with how humans can act—cruel—but everything else she's doesn't necessarily share the same thoughts as her sister and mother. She doesn't want humans to fear them. She wants the opposite. She wants them to accept her, not see her as

a monster. If she never can get rid of this curse, she doesn't want someone to find out about her and kill her. Maybe it's a fairy tale but she still is a child. Can't she make a wish like that?

Maybe she can get her family to change their minds. They are all she has after all.

Lights form in Catra's cyan and amber eyes. Laughing, she pounces at her sister. Adora's own laughter fills the air as she is knocked out of their fort.

She does not land on her bedroom floor. The next thing Adora knows, she is pinned against hard earth. Rocks and twigs dig into her already torn open back. Catra stares back at her, anger and hatred in her oddly colored eyes. One hand, already clawed, hangs above her with bright, crimson blood dripping off it. ***Adora's*** *own blood. The side of the blonde's face stings.*

"You left me!" Catra hisses through sharp teeth. "How could you abandon me!"

"I did not leave you!" Adora spats back, trying to believe her own words. For once, she is happy the full moon is giving her strength. With her own sharpening hands, she shoves her younger sister off full force. Catra yelps as she is flung.

Adora lets out a pained groan, feeling the wolf inside of her clawing against her body. She can't let it take over. Not yet. Somehow, the blonde rises to her feet. Her own anger at her sister mixes in with the rage of the beast.

"You ran off without me!" Catra snaps back.

"I ***asked*** *you to come and you didn't! You-ack!" Adora collapses to her knees as another wave of pain rolls over her. She hears Catra laughing, a wicked cruel laugh.*

"Hey, Adora. You can't get away from what you are. A monster like me."

The rage builds further inside of her. With the final ounce of control, the blonde looks up to see her sister shifting into her own form. The last thought she has is wondering how the hell they ended up like this.

Another nightmare jolts Adora awake. Another nightmare sends shock waves throughout her body. Her brain scrambles to adjust being thrown back into reality, continuing to see Catra mocking and belittling her. It feels like her heart is about to burst straight out of her chest and an invisible noose tightens around her throat. As her flight or fight kicks into overdrive, Adora feels her curse clawing at the inside of her chest.

*No. No damn it! We **aren't** doing this again!* She screams to herself.

She curls hands into fist and clenches her jaw tight, fighting back against the thing inside of her. Harsh breaths are taken, her attempt to gain some semblance of control. No use. Her stomach twists into a tight knot and her body shudders. Adora hunches over on itself.

*Fuck, fuck! Do you **want** to wake up Glimmer again?!?*
Wait...Glim…

Adora begins to think about the hunter. How she always sticks around for the shifts. Cooking for her before said curse took over. The way she laughs and smiles. She is always amazed by Glimmer's ability to stay up late into the night. Or how her eyes are a rare shade of purple. The way they sparkle in the moonlight. The kindness she has shown her over these past several months. Everything is right in the world when Glimmer is near.

Her heart begins to settle and her breathing evens out. The knot in her stomach loosens enough that she doesn’t want to puke out her guts. When Adora unfurls her fingers, she spots red marks against her palm but no blood and no sharp nails. The wolf inside of her returns to a slumber, waiting for its moment during the

next full moon. A breath caught in her throat escapes from her nose.

Knowing sleep will not come back to her for sometime, if at all tonight, Adora exits her bedroom. With clouds covering the stars and moon, little light guides her. The blonde keeps a hand out just in case, not quite trusting herself in these conditions. Once she reaches the fridge, she pulls open the door. A wince escapes her at the sudden bright light. Blinking back the sting, Adora grabs a water bottle.

Just as the bright, white light turns into nothing more than a sliver, eyes catch something. A book rests on the island. *Did Glim leave her mother's notebook down here?*

Adora shuts the rest of the door with her foot before walking to take the book in her other hand. With eyes slowly adjusting to the darkness, she takes a seat on the couch. While taking some quick sips of her water, Adora feels the weight of the book in her hand. Eyebrows raise. Feels different from the last time she held it. Maybe lingering sleep is getting to her. With her throat happy with the water taken in, she places the bottle down and opens the book.

She regrets this decision. Thank god she wasn't drinking at this moment.

Staring right back at her, is a set of skillfully done drawings. Ink and graphite stain the pages, a rare few colored in. Words are scattered around the pictures. Adora brings the pages closer to read what is inscribed.

Adora's Werewolf form

Red eyes, huge as fuck, nearly killed me

Hard to Stop, Dangerous

Monstrous, Menacing, needs extra Precautions during Full Moon

The noose from before appears again, wrapping even tighter. Eyes look closer at the drawings. After all these years, has she finally found out what she looks like when she shifts? Snarling werewolves stare back at her, drool dripping from between sharp teeth. Some have her sleeping, drugged up from the wolfsbane, but still there is an air of intimation, the words around her not helping. Glimmer even has scribbled down the injury she got that night back in July.

No wonder why everyone fears her. Her adoptive mother was right. Catra was right. She really is a monster, isn't she?

When tears start to drip on the pages, Adora snaps the books shut and places it back where she found it. No need for Glimmer to get suspicious. She uses the heels of her hand to wipe clean the stream of tears flowing from her eyes. It does little to help. She can't stop them from becoming streaming rivers down her face. Hands shake and legs wobble.

Why does Glimmer put up with her? She attacked her once, nearly ripping off her arm and *worse.* Every month she is putting herself at risk. If she ever got loose again, what would happen? Her mother and friends and others have been killed by something like Adora. She has been staying at her house for months now. Even if she has gotten jobs to help around, how hasn't she overstayed her welcome yet?

Damn it. Damn it! Adora shouts in her head. Her heart aches—Like someone has shattered it into millions of tiny pieces. *I don't deserve someone like her. God fuckin' damn it!*

The floorboards above her creak. Adora slaps a hand over her mouth, stifling her cries. Glimmer does not need to see her in this state, or have her know she snooped in her book even if it was by mistake. When there is no sign of Glimmer coming down, the blonde removes her hand.

She could leave if she wanted to. She has enough money for bus fare and food if she is careful. She has clothing and can get a bag

easily. Slip right back into old habits. Get out of Glimmer's life and have her not worry about making sure Adora doesn't go on a rampage. She doesn't need another burden in her life with everything going on.

But she can't leave her when so much is going on. When they now are starting to gather clues about who is out there killing others. The hunter needs her right now, doesn't she? And even then, her heart breaks further at the thought of never seeing Glimmer again. Never seeing her lilac colored eyes. It's like a war is tearing her up inside.

Somehow, Adora makes her way into her room, curling up in her bed. She wraps her old blanket around her body and buries her face into her pillow, letting herself break.

"Adora?"

The soft voice stris Adora from her dark, heavy slumber. The blonde groans, burying her face further into her pillow. Small specs of water stains brush against her face. Her body feels heavy and she doesn't want to attempt moving her limbs at all.

"Adora?" someone shakes her. "Are you awake?"

Adora groans again before moving her head enough to see who is the owner of the voice. With one eye open, the world comes into focus. Glimmer. Her hair is a mess, clearly has not been brushed yet, and she's yet to change out of her tank top and shorts. What catches the blonde's attention the most is the concerned look written all over her face.

"Yeah." Adora forces herself up onto her arms. It's like dragging an anchor out of a thick liquid. "Yeah, I'm awake, Glim."

"Are you okay?" the hunter settles down on the bed. A hand reaches over and gingerly places it on a leg. Adora feels fingers gently brushing against her through the blanket.

Even right after rolling out of bed, Glimmer's *being* makes it impossible for Adora to pull her eyes off of her. She has to shake that thought from her mind, reminding herself of what's inside.

"Yeah. Why?" Adora lies, hating to do that at Glimmer.

"Because it's, like, ten. I went downstairs and didn't see you at all or any signs you were awake. Are you feeling okay?"

Glimmer reached out, presumably to touch Adora's forehead. The blonde backs up instinctively, feeling the claws of her sister and the cold fingers of her mother on her face.

"Ah! Don't. Please don't go for my face like that without warning me!"

"Oh! Sorry!" Glimmer immediately pulls her hand back.

"I'm fine, Glim. I promise. I just...Couldn't sleep. Just one of those nights, ya know? So I slept in to make up for it!"

At least that's not a total lie.

“Are you sure? You only ever sleep in after a shift.” Eyes go wide. “Nothing happened last night, did it?”

“No! No. I swear everything’s okay.” Adora places her hand on top of Glimmer’s. She gives it a small squeeze. “I’m fine.”

“If you say so. Well, if you aren’t going to go back to bed I am going to cook breakfast.”

“I can cook breakfast this time. You did it yesterday.”

“So? I don’t mind it. You can help if you like. How’s that sound?”

Adora rolls her eyes. “Sure.”

With a flash of a smile from Glimmer, Adora feels weights lifting off of her body. She rolls out of bed, following closely behind the hunter.

The autumn equinox has come and gone. October has creeped its way into the forefront. With it, the greenery of the forest has disappeared. Instead, vivid warm colors paint the canopy. Reds like bright apples, oranges like sunsets, and yellows like daffodils hang high above, waiting to coat the ground. Some leaves are a swirl of the colors. Fall is a wonderful time of the year. Glimmer has always loved this time of the year. Sometimes she forgets she was born during the dying days of this season.

Speaking of which, October means two things. One, her mother's birthday. She would have been fifty-five in a couple weeks. Glimmer does not want to think much about that, what that day will mean. Each day that passes, her heart sinks a little deeper with dread. But, at least she does have something else to look forward to.

The second thing is Halloween at the end of the month. Ever since she was a small child, Glimmer has enjoyed the holiday. As much as other humans have twisted and changed stories of non-humans in their fables, they can be fun to listen to. The movies, the decorations, and costumes can make for a good time. It's the one time of year where she can freely talk about what she knows without worry that someone will give her a strange look.

To Glimmer's surprise, Adora *loves* the holiday also. The blonde states despite the shorter days and some movies (Glimmer has a feeling she knows which ones), she loves the feeling of fall. With her heightened smell and taste she can experience the wonders more than the average person. Deprived of many holidays as a child, she won't miss out on celebrating them now. But what really has captured Adora's heart is the abundance of sweets. Glimmer already has hidden away a bag for Halloween so it is not ransacked.

But with another month, that means another full moon. Preparations have already been made. The chains are piled up in the bedroom as well as the cocktail of potions and wolfsbane.

Glimmer and Adora have spent the morning getting ready for the long night ahead. This will be the last one before the time jumps back an hour. With some time to spare, the two want to get their mind off of things.

That means getting a start on decorations. Glimmer has pulled out her ladder to reach into the higher parts of her home. Adora jokes about carrying her on her shoulders. The hunter ponders over that idea for a bit before declining. No need for either of them to fall and eat shit by mistake. The offer does remain open.

While putting up the decorations—animatronics, lights, stickers, and so much more—a radio plays in the background. Some random radio station Glimmer and Adora have tuned in to plays a good mix of music. Sometimes, it's a hit from today, the next from several years ago, and of course, some Halloween tunes. Right now, it plays something neither recognizes and easily tunes out.

"Adora, can you hand me the stapler?" Glimmer asks. She has one hand holding some lights steady above the windows. The ladder wobbles under her feet. This does not deter the hunter.

"Here ya go," Adora chirps.

Glimmer sticks out her hand without looking. When she feels the weight of the stapler against her palm, she finishes up hanging the lights. Beaming, the hunter looks at her work. Come nightfall, the exterior of the house will be lit up in orange colors. Gravity should not be able to pull these down.

Though, it sure as hell can grab something else.

The ladder rocks too far back for Glimmer to control. Arms swing all over, a feeble attempt to regain a sense of balance. Too little, too late. Feet, slip free off the top and gravity wraps its hands around her. All she can do is brace herself for the hard impact. However, that is not what she lands on. Rather, she lands on something soft.

"Woah. You okay?" Adora asks.

Glimmer feels her whole body turn warm. Adora's eyes are bright as ever. A wide, crooked smile is spread across her face. The blonde haired woman has caught the hunter in a perfect catch, saving her from a battered back.

"I-I-I-Yeah! I'm fine! Thank you for saving my ass."

Adora laughs lightly. "Anytime!" She sets her friend down on the ground.

Glimmer sighs a breath of relief. Both from being saved and from seeing Adora lightening up. These past several days there has been something *off* about her. Ever since that morning she found the blonde sleeping. By the way she walks, her shoulders hunched over, the way she looks out the window, eyes distant, and her voice lower than normal, it's good to hear that brightness again. That cloud still hangs over her, somehow the hunter can sense it, but maybe finally it has begun to lift.

The radio suddenly changes to something unexpected. One moment it is playing some pop tune, upbeat and lively as ever. The next moment, the tune is slower. Soft and loving. At the first drop of a note, Glimmer recognizes the song. It's the same one her mother and father would listen to all the time. She feels her heart twisting inside of her chest.

A small sigh escapes her.

"Everything okay?" Adora suddenly asks.

"Just the song. It's my mom's and dad's song," Glimmer says softly.

Adora kneels on the porch, hands near the radio. "Do...Do you want me to change it?"

Glimmer shakes her head. "Nah. I want to listen to it." She can see them now, in each other's arms, moving to the beat of the music. Words are softly whispered into ears for only them to hear. "They used to like dancing to this."

Adora takes back and forth glances at the hunter and then the radio. After a moment's pause to think, her eyes land back and stay on Glimmer. "D-Do you...wanna dance to it?"

"What?" Glimmer blurts out.

Adora rubs the back of her neck, her fair face turning red. "I dunno. Something to kill time before night? And if your parents did it, why not? Ya know what, no. It's stupid. Forget I said anything." she snaps her head to the side, hiding her face from the hunter.

Glimmer squats down beside her friend, giving a small tap on her shoulder. When Adora looks back at her, that distance back in her eyes, she smiles softly. "I wouldn't mind that."

"R-Really?"

Glimmer sticks out her hand. "Do you know how to dance?"

Adora snorts before taking the hand. "I can try. No promises."

Glimmer pulls both of them to their feet. They stand face to face, inches apart. With one hand grasped in Adora's, Glimmer drapes her other around the blonde's neck. She feels the strong arm of her friend wrapping around her mid back. Taking a moment to listen to tempo, Glimmer begins to lead the way. Adora does not protest in the slightest and follows her lead.

This close to Adora, Glimmer *swears* she can hear her steady heartbeat. With the full moon almost on top of them, all her senses are on alert. Not only can she hear her heart, she can smell that sandalwood soap. And...the hint of morning dew? Does the blonde like to spend time outside in the early morning hours? What about those eyes? Blue like the bright spring sky?

Her heart fluttering in her chest, her palms sweating, her legs becoming jello, and the music setting the mood, can she really deny what she is feeling anymore. Just the thought of it makes her mouth go dry with nerves.

“A-Adora?” Glimmer croaks.

“What’s up?” Adora whispers.

“I...Well...Have I ever said how much I have enjoyed having you in my life these past few months?”

“No. But, I can say the same for you. I don't know what or where I would be without you.”

“Knowing you with your shorts, probably freezing your ass off,” Glimmer laughs.

Adora clicks her tongue against the back of her teeth. “I’m in jeans now, aren’t I?”

"You're still in just a t-shirt though."

Glimmer continues to lead the two. The music will be ending soon, she knows every beat of this song by heart. If she is going to say anything, she should say something soon. Why does this have to be so hard?

“Anyway...I am being serious. You being here, especially with everything going, I don’t think I would have been able to keep my head without you. And when we get this all over and done with, I want to help you find your family. Everything you are doing for me, I want to repay you in some way.”

“You don’t have to.”

“I want to!” Glimmer affirms. “I want to! I wanna help! I wanna see you smile and be happy! I wanna because-because-”

Glimmer is cut off by her own gasp of pain. Adora’s hand has shifted, readjusting itself. However, thin yet *sharp* pain erupts from the areas on her back being touched. The hunter finds herself burying her face into the crook of her friend’s neck, hissing back more pain. It’s like small knives have cut through the fabric of her jacket and a layer or two of skin.

“Glimmer! Are you okay?!? Wha-”

Glimmer feels Adora’s hand being removed from her back. A harsh curse escapes the blonde’s lip. It’s in that moment, the hunter realizes just how dark it suddenly has become. Light from the sun is dying, gasping for one last breath as the dark navy sky overpowers it. Stars are bright and the full moon looms over everyone.

Shit!

“Adora!” Glimmer pushes off of the blonde. She quickly spots Adora’s shaking hands, nails darkening, speckled with red. Fear is etched into every corner of her face.

“I’m sorry! I’m sorry! I didn’t know!” Adora worries, breathes coming out fast and short.

“Adora! Adora, don’t panic!” Glimmer takes Adora’s hands in her own. “Panicking will make it worse! I’m fine! I’ll be fine, they’ll heal!”

A whine escapes the blonde, body beginning to shudder.

“We need to get inside. C’mon!”

Glimmer wastes no time in dragging Adora through the doors. Thank god they left her bedroom door open, every second counts right now. She feels the blonde stumbling behind her as surely her legs are reading to shift into something totally new. The faster fear and adrenaline pumps through Adora’s system, the sooner the wolf will come out. Glimmer needs to act *now!*

They stumble to the radiator, Adora tripping and nearly smacking face first into the metal. Glimmer mutters an apology as she fumbles for the chains. The pained groans from Adora and nails scraping against the wood causes her hands to shake. Fuck, she has to gain control of her own body. Glimmer curses as her sweat causes the metal to slip from her grasp. She doesn’t have time to wipe the tears forming in her eyes.

Glimmer spins around. Adora is hunched over desperately trying to keep the shift from occurring before she is tied up. There is no time to change into clothing that easily can be replaced by packs at the store.

“I’m putting these on, Adora!” Glimmer says.

She wastes no time in wrapping the chains around her friend. Adora winces from the silver touching her skin, it quickly blisters her skin. Glimmer mutters another apology as she tightens them, struggling to do so. Everything is spiraling out of control.

“Why,” Adora whines.

Glimmer looks up. Adora’s teeth have sharpened, almost peeking out of her lips. Tears are streaming down her cheeks out of blue-red eyes. That same word was asked last month before the wolf inside of her cut her off.

“What, Adora?” Glimmer asks, trying to have the blonde's focus elsewhere. “‘ *Why* ’ what?”

“Why do you do this! Why do you put up with me every damn month!” Adora cries.

“Adora. I don’t mind it! It-It’s no big deal!”

“I hurt you! *Twice!* Y-You’re mother *died* because of something like me!” she groans in pain, body shaking harder. Watery eyes look up at her with great sadness. “You have to keep tying me up so I don’t hurt someone. I-I’m just a monster! Why do you still do this. Why-”

Glimmer has no idea what comes over her. Her body moves without her thought. An arm wraps around Adora’s neck as Glimmer pulls her close. Fingers lace through dark blonde hair as she locks their lips together. Salt from both their tears mix into the embrace. Never before has Glimmer kissed anyone, never before has anyone stolen her heart. Rushing in like this, she had little

clue what this experience would be, especially given the circumstances.

She does not regret this. Adora accepts the kiss, leaning into it. A warmth spreads to every inch of her body and the world becomes non-existent. Only she and Adora, only *this* very moment, that is all that is in the universe. All her worries, all her fears, every negative emotion inside the hunter fades away, only leaving pure warmth and passion.

Glimmer must break for air. She pulls away, staring right into Adora's wide eyes. The red has faded, the iris almost nothing but sky blue. The hunter takes a breath before saying in a soft voice, "That's why."

Adora makes a choking noise as more tears run down her cheeks. "G-Glim…"

"Shh, shh. I'm gonna touch your face, gonna wipe your tears." Glimmer places her forehead against Adora's. Thumbs stroke her cheeks, breaking up the rivers. Even as Adora loses her battle for the night, the hunter whispers to her.

"I'm right here, Adora. I'm right here. I won't leave, I promise."

How could I be so stupid! Adora screams in her head, staring at the blood at the tip of her nails. This is happening fast, faster than normal, because she let her guard down. Because she allowed the wolf inside of her to sneak up behind her, waiting for the last slivers of lights to turn into embers. How did she let this happen?

She couldn't help it, that's why. How could she when she was so close to Glimmer, enough that her lavender soap filled her nose? How could she when soft music filled her ears and the hunter guided them in a dance? How could she when Glimmer was speaking to her in such a loving voice?

She *absolutely* could not help being totally sucked into every inch of Glimmer's being. Now she is paying for her own stupidity, cutting up the hunter once more.

“I’m sorry! I’m sorry! I didn’t know!” Adora gasps. Her heart beats *hard* against her chest, it feels like she's breathing through a chewed up straw, and she swears everything around her is collapsing.

“Adora! Adora, don’t panic!” Glimmer takes Adora’s hands in her own. “Panicking will make it worse! I’m fine! I’ll be fine, they’ll heal!”

All Adora can muster in response is a whine. Her body shudders and she struggles for control. The wolf already has dug its heels into the ground and refuses to give her an inch.

“We need to get inside. C’mon!”

She feels Glimmer yank her arm, dragging her through the house and into the bedroom. Every second that passes feels like an entirety. Legs do not know who to take orders from. If it wasn't for the hunter, she would've long since tripped over herself.

They make it to the room, to the radiator. Adora barely registers almost colliding with the cold hard metal. She begins curling in on herself, groaning as her stomach tightens and her muscles and bones ache as they prepare to split apart. Nails create more trenches on the ground, joining their cousins from months prior.

“I’m putting these on, Adora!” Glimmer says.

The hunter does what she does every month. Ties up Adora to one of the strongest things they have. But what about the potions? She'll eventually escape without them. The silver chains, that burn at the slightest contact of her skin, will only do so much. Glimmer will only be at risk.

Damn it! Adora screams to herself as the chain. Glimmer shouldn't have to do this every month. She shouldn't have to keep risking

her life. She shouldn't have a creature like *her* around.

“Why,” Adora whines. She's unable to hold back her tears. She wanted to ask this before but she was cut off last month. Adora has zero clue if that'll happen again but she has to know.

“What, Adora?” Glimmer asks. “‘Why’ what?”

“Why do you do this! Why do you put up with me every damn month!” Adora cries.

“Adora. I don’t mind it! It-It’s no big deal!”

“I hurt you! *Twice!* Y-You’re mother *died* because of something like me!” she groans in pain, body shaking harder. The drawings in the notebook flash in her mind. “You have to keep tying me up so I don’t hurt someone. I-I’m just a monster! Why do you still do this. Why-”

Adora is cut off, words lingering in her tongue as Glimmer's lips lock around her own. Fingers lace through her hair as the hunter pulls them closer. A wave of emotions Adora has never known explodes through her. She never dared to kiss anyone in her life, scared of the thing inside of her. But here, in the state between woman and beast, Glimmer has taken the first step. Adora accepts the kiss.

Time freezes in place. Where her heart once races from fear, it now flutters in her chest–light like air. The only thing Adora can think of is Glimmer, how she feels against her and the taste of her strawberry chapstick. Her body even stops shaking as a comforting sense overwhelms her. Why was she worrying again?

Glimmer break for air. Adora's eyes are wide, brimming with tears. Her brain catches up with the meaning behind this action. The hunter's lilac eyes, almost sparkling like the stars at this moment, do not break away as she softly says, “That’s why.”

Adora chokes upon hearing these words. Tears form rivers on her cheeks. “G-Glim…”

“Shh, shh. I’m gonna touch your face, gonna wipe your tears.” Glimmer places her forehead against Adora’s. With warning, she allows the hunter to stroke thumbs against her cheeks, breaking up her tear trails. Forgetting about the shift, having it come full force out of nowhere, and now this, Adora no longer has the strength to fight back. The last thing she hears before losing control is:

“I’m right here, Adora. I’m right here. I won’t leave, I promise.”

When the darkness takes over, somehow...it’s different. Adora cannot put her finger on why. After so many years of going through the same motions, she knows when something is amiss. If only she could put a name to this strange feeling. There is the same heaviness, those same two voices reassuring her everything will be okay and something will be figured out, and those specs of light. But looking closer, the shadows around her take *shapes.* Unlike her nightmares, she isn’t afraid. Only...curious.

In front of her, the darkness only lightens a few shades, becoming a dark grey. Whatever is looking back at her does not take a true form. If she squints, yes she can make out it is some animal. Definitely not human. The shades of grey float around but Adora *knows* it is staring at her.

“Who the hell are you?” she asks when the... *thing* says:

“ *You.”*

“What? What are you talking about?” Adora spats back. “Are you those voices I keep hearing?”

“ *No. You don’t know them but you know them.”*

“What the hell does that mean?!?”

The thing ignores her question. “ *Don’t reject yourself. Don’t bury things deep inside.”*

Before Adora can say anything else, question this thing more, something catches her attention. The sound of Glimmer's voice. The blonde snaps her head around, seeing multiple shades of greys and blacks. She can recognize the outline of Glimmer anywhere.

"Adora? Can...Can you hear me?"

"Glim!" Adora shouts, feeling her heart being tugged.

"Are you in there?"

"Glimmer! I'm here!...And you're still here…"

" *Don't reject. Don't deny. Burying yourself leads to just that. Suffocation."*

"What?" Adora spins back around, however, the thing is gone. Only the specs of light, continuing their words of comfort. The blonde blinks, wondering if she made up the whole thing.

She hears Glimmer sigh. "I wish I could do more. I'm sorry, 'Dora."

"No! No! You have done enough! *More* than enough!" Adora shouts. She has no clue if her voice is reaching Glimmer. The blonde needs to get back control of her body. With a small growl, she begins to claw her away forward.

Adora gasps for air as reality slaps her in her face. Somehow, she manages to snap her body up right away. Her brain searches for something. Something important. Eyebrows knit together as she tries to piece things together. There are blurry images in her mind and indistinct whispers. Somehow she pieces together one thing.

Glimmer.

The hunter is nowhere in sight. Adora is all alone in her room. An open window blows a gentle breeze inside and daylight makes everything clear. Right...She's in her room. It's the morning after a

shift. Still, everything is telling her to locate her friend. Make sure everything is okay. Adora scrambles out of bed, the sheets wrapping around her ankle and nearly causing her to smack her face on the ground. She decides to forgo taking a shower, quickly dressing in whatever fingers grip first. As her head pops out of the blue sweater, her hands pull open the door.

“Glim?” her voice is harsh from the words forced out of her throat.

Glimmer, in the kitchen area, spins around on her heels. Eyes are alert. “Adora?!? Are you okay?”

Adora beams, eyes becoming misty. Looking at her is like looking at a miracle. She races over towards Glimmer, arms wrapping tightly around her body and burying her face into the hunter’s soft, black, pink and purple hair. “I’m okay,” she sniffs. “I don’t know why but I was worried about you. I’m so glad you’re okay.”

“I’m fine, Adora! God, you still smell like a wolf. Did you shower at all? That doesn't matter,” Glimmer hisses through her teeth, “please let go of me!”

Adora begins to release her friend. As her fingers brush against her back, she feels something between the fabric. She only wonders for a moment what it is. The image of fingers slicing through jacket stitching and skin enters her mind.

“Wait! I cut you last night, didn’t I?” Adora asks.

“You remember that?” Glimmer shakes her head. “Look, Adora, I’m fine. Seriously, it’ll be gone by tomorrow. That doesn’t matter. Do you know what time it is?”

“No?”

“Adora, it’s about nine-thirty! Do you understand what that means?”

“I...That’s early, isn’t it.”

“Yeah, and that’s not the only thing! Hold on.”

Glimmer runs over to the end table near the sofa. She snatches her notebook before returning to Adora’s side. The hunter flips through the page before spinning it around. Adora stares at the pages. At first glance, she sees nothing different from the other night. With a blink, however, she notices the outlines are different. The wolf that looks back at her seems...smaller? Less angry and ferocious. Still something you wouldn’t want to mess with. One drawing looks like it has a curious expression. Words have yet to be written.

“What the heck?”

“I haven’t finished yet but your shift. You looked different! You didn’t try to kill me as much. I didn’t even have to use any wolfsbane or potions! Your eyes were still red but not as bright. They were dimmer? Softer? You still were bigger than most werewolves but still."

Adora’s eyes go wide. “Wait, what? Really?” Something pops into Adora’s mind. “Did...Did you talk to me at all? Were...Were you upset?”

“I-Yeah, I was...You remember that? You heard me?”

“So that was real...Yeah, I think so.”

“That’s interesting.”

Adora brushes her fingers against the pages of the notebook. Her heart twists in her stomach at the thought of what else lies in here. “I have to admit something. I saw your notebook before. That day I overslept, I had seen those other pages. Of what I am during the full moon…”

“I knew something was bugging you,” Glimmer says. She pulls her notebook back, flipping through the pages again. “I never wanted you to see that. Not those pages. I’m sorry. I took the notes like I always do but...you never saw this.”

Glimmer hands the book back. This time, the pages are all of her. *Her* as her human self. Doing simple things like reading or just smiling a crooked smile. There are words around the drawings. *Beautiful, wonderful, smart, amazing.*

"That...That is how I really see you." Glimmer says, eyes looking away. "That other page was to keep up with all my other notes. These...These are *you.* I hope you don't mind that I drew you. "

Adora cannot remove her eyes from the pages. This time, when tears stain the paper, it's from elation. "I love it, Glimmer...Hey. Can you answer me something?"

"What is it?"

"Real or not real. Did...Did you kiss me last night? It didn't *feel* real but..."

Silence. Adora swears she can hear crickets chirping. The parts of Glimmer's face she can see turn red. "Uh...So you remember that also, huh? Yeah, I did. And if I am being honest, I would do it all over again." Glimmer looks back up at Adora. "I wasn't kidding with that answer. When you asked me why I always do what I do during the full moons. I care about you, a lot, and I won't change anything about it...Fuck I hope I didn't make anything awkward."

"No, you didn't." Adora snaps the book shut before setting it aside. "If I am being honest, I feel the same. Probably have for a while. Being what I am, how I was raised, I always have been scared of love. Scared of what will happen. Still am…If we do this...I want to go slowly, if you don't mind."

"I don't. I rather go slow also. Though, can I give you another kiss."

"I would like that. Can't fully remember it."

Glimmer states up on the tips of her toes, brushing her lips against Adora's. Warmth spreads through all of Adora's body, making her feel on top of cloud nine. Arms, gently, wrap around

the hunter’s body, pulling her closer. As they break apart, the blonde sighs softly. Foreheads tap together.

“So,” Glimmer starts, “did that feel real?”

“Yes, totally. Do you want to cook breakfast?”

“I dunno about you,” Glimmer yawns suddenly. “But I wanna take a nap. Do you mind?”

“Nah, rest up. I’ll cook. And when you wake, I’ll be right here.”

Chapter End Notes

so, the reason I have not written anything for the next queue is because I wrote a short story. It's 3 chapters long and another au (deltarune adora au) so for the next three weeks that will post on sunday. After that I should have a better idea when werewolf will come back but I need a break after this

ANYWAY kudos/comments appreciated!

Quiet Time

Chapter Notes

> heyo I am back!!! yeah starting off slow again but there will be a lot going on in this next patch that is coming up. I have 4 queued so yeah! enjoy dont think there are any tws really for this but like death mentioned

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora floats, her mind somewhere between the solid sturdiness of reality and the kaleidoscope of mixing colors of a fantasy world. She can feel her body against something soft but she is disconnected from the command center. There is a chirping noise in her ears and a low, horse noise, neither of which she can identify. But something else catches her attention the most.

The soft, saccharine scent of flowers. More specifically, lavenders. Thin outlines, the colors seeping through easily, form in her mind. Rows upon rows of the purple flower, as far as the eyes can see. Adora can even see the orange sunlight pouring out of the horizon, casting everything in a soft glow. This place is picture perfect. If she could take a snapshot of this, she would treasure it forever. Hell, she wants to remain here forever.

But slowly, the colorful world fades from existence. For a moment, it's nothing but darkness. She begins to gain control of her body, twitching her fingers and shifting into a more comfortable position. It slowly dawns on her that there is something strange going on. The mattress is softer, the sheets are made up of a different fabric. There is a warmth besides her, something radiating their own heat. Putting two and two together, she realizes it is the source of the horse noise. It's snoring!

Adora eyes flutter open. There is a temporary blur before the world comes into a crisp focus. She is in a strange yet familiar room. Pale, purple walls stare back at her. Morning sunlight pours

through the slit in the curtain, landing directly on the other body besides her, casting them in a yellow glow.

Glimmer.

The blonde resists the urge to jerk back in surprise. No need to wake the hunter nor slip out of bed and connect with the ground. She blinks for several seconds, trying to remember what is going on. Right. They are together now aren't they? Adora still can feel the warmth of Glimmer's lips against hers from the kiss during mid-shift the previous night. Awkwardness of the confession. Glimmer coaxing her to sleep with her last night. So that all wasn't a dream. Adora cannot help but smile softly, her heart dancing around her chest. She wraps her arms tighter around the hunter, pulling her as close as possible.

Glimmer's warmth relaxes Adora's body and her flowery scent makes her feel as light as air. Nothing in her dreams can ever match this reality. She fears something will snatch this away, dream or not. Adora still cannot believe someone would have fallen for someone like herself. After everything that has happened to the hunter, after everything that has happened to Adora herself, don't they deserve a little bit of happiness?

Glimmer mumbles something in her sleep. The hunter shifts before opening up her own lilac eyes. The moment they land on Adora, the fog of sleep lifts. Glimmer sighs softly before burying her face into Adora's chest. "G'morning, Adora. Did you sleep alright?"

"With you around, I did," Adora whispers into her ears. This earns a snort from the hunter.

"Dork."

"How did you sleep? It, uh, wasn't weird to have me sleeping with you?"

"I asked you to come, didn't I? After all, I have a bigger bed. But, yes, I did sleep fine." She suddenly groans. "I *so* don't want to get

up. Can we just stay here forever?”

“We have to get up, you know that,” Adora chuckles, rolling her eyes. She places a kiss on top of Glimmer’s head. Though, she quickly pauses. “Do you like that?”

Glimmer returns the gesture, placing a peck on the tip of Adora’s nose. The blonde becomes several degrees warmer. “Does that answer your question?”

“Yes, yes it does.”

Adora sits up in a shift movement. The warmth the sheets have captured from both bodies escape. Glimmer groans as the cool blast of air hits her. Fists grab the fabric and pull it tight around her body. Her face becomes hidden, only the top of hair being seen. This earns another eye roll from the blonde. Adora takes this as a hint to leave her new girlfriend in bed. She leaves her be, slowly slipping out of bed without much of a disturbance. Glimmer does not protest. Actually, she has gone back to snoring.

Adora slowly makes her way down the steps, avoiding the creaking one as best she can. Before making breakfast, she turns tail into her bedroom. It’s an odd feeling to step in here after spending the night in Glimmer’s room. Her bed is untouched from when she made it yesterday. She still needs to do her laundry. Clothes are beginning to spill out from the top. Maybe later today. She, instead, strolls over to her dresser.

A quick change into warmer clothing. With the lack of Glimmer besides her, Adora definitely feels the cold October air against her body. A shiver runs down her spine as her torso is momentarily bare. She slips on her dark red sweatshirt. Once warm, and after tossing her pjs in the overflowing basket, she heads back into the main portion of the house. Might as well make some breakfast. She walks into the kitchen area and begins to think what to cook.

She taps a finger against her chin. What to make, what to make. Adora paces around, wanting to make something good. She

searches the cabinets and fridge for anything that can satisfy her cravings. After some debate, the blonde gathers up some pancake mix, chocolate chips, oil, a spatula, and a pan. This should wake Glimmer right up and lure her right downstairs. Definitely makes her own stomach growl. Adora gets to work quickly, wanting to eat as fast as she can. Once the batter is stirred to perfection, Adora begins sizzling it, scattering the chips on top.

Adora whistles a small tune as she flips over the pancake, revealing a golden brown bottom. Thank god it isn't burned. The circle is lopsided and far from perfect but who honestly really cares? Food is food and the smell makes the blonde's stomach audible if anyone were to be in the room with her. Part of her is *quite* tempted to eat some of the batter. To curve her craving, once the last of the batter is in the frying pan, she licks the spoon clean.

Boards creak, pulling Adora's attention away from the oven. Glimmer yawns as she finishes her trek, plopping down at the table. "That smells amazing. You better have put chocolate chips in it."

"Don't worry, I did." Adora moves the pan around a little. She begins to scratch the side of her face as her nerves begin to fire off. "So, uh...what do we do?"

"Whaddya mean?"

"I have never been in a relationship before." *Never thought I'd ever be in one.* "I, uh, I just...I don't know…Seriously. I don't know anything. I didn't have anything to look to besides TV or stories."

"Oh that…" Glimmer's eyes flutter shut, head suddenly becoming heavy. The hunter manages to stop herself from connecting with the table. "Ah, fuck, sorry."

Adora reaches her free arm out, fingers pressing against the buttons of the coffee maker. Thankfully, everything has been set

up the night before. Coffee soon will be ready to be drunk straight by Glimmer. “We should just keep this in your room.”

“Trust me, I thought about it.” Glimmer rubs her tired eyes. “Anyway, I don’t know either. Never been in a relationship before either.”

“Blind leading the blind, huh?”

“Seriously. You know you’re burning the pancake.”

“Shit!”

Adora scrambles to keep the food from becoming charcoal. The flames die as she twists the knob. In her panic, the stack of pancakes beside her is nearly knocked over. Somehow, she avoids having a total breakfast catastrophe. A sigh of relief washes over Adora's body, as well as disappointment that this final pancake does not match the others. The blonde grumbles as she sets the plates down on the dining room table.

“Still smells amazing,” Glimmer chirps. She takes a bunch of pancakes as Adora preps the coffee. The hunter even takes the burnt one. Adora scrunches up her nose and sticks out a tongue.

"You’re really gonna eat that? That’s not gonna taste great.”

“You left it on the pile. And I have less sensitive taste buds than you. It’s no big deal.” Glimmer proves this by shoving a small stack of cut up bits into her mouth.

“Suit yourself.” Adora begins eating her own non burnt breakfast. Though, half way through, she finds herself distracted. Distracted none other than Glimmer herself. Thoughts of the beast inside of her, being told repeatedly about being a ‘monster’ and others would ‘fear’ her linger in the blonde’s mind. They wait to pounce, almost doing so as she becomes lost in her own thoughts.

But something forces them back to the far reaches of her mind. Starting at Glimmer, remembering snuggling up with the hunter

during the night, sharing a kiss...Adora does not want to let go of this. The hunter now stands as the greatest thing that has happened in her life. She'll dig her claws in and do everything she can not to fuck this up. Not to lose the greatest thing that has ever happened to her and not let anything bad happen to her new girlfriend. If what Glimmer said about the most recent shift is true, maybe she can keep the monster inside of her at bay. Anything for Glimmer.

Both eat some more before speaking again. Adora takes her own sip of coffee before saying, "What do we tell the others? You know, about us."

Glimmer leans back in her chair, keeping herself stable with one leg propped up. Arms cross against her chest in thought. "I don't know. Bow and Perfuma didn't say right away when they first started to date. Same with Sea Hawk and Mermista." The hunter rocks a little. "Honestly, I like the idea of not saying anything right away. What do you think? Enjoy ourselves before everyone flips out. "

A warm grin flashes across her face. It is infectious.

Adora rests her chin on the palm of her hand. "I like the thought of that." Eyes gaze up. The raven colored hair, the true shade of Glimmer's hair, continues to grow, forcing out the pink and purple dyed locks. For a moment, the blonde shuts her eyelids, wondering what her girlfriend would look like without her vibrate hair. So used to the two tones, a solid color looks strange in her imagination.

"What are you thinking about?" Glimmer hums.

Adora opens her eyes. The hunter sips down another cup of steaming hot coffee.

"You," Adora replies.

"Tck. What about me?"

“Your hair. There’s a lot of black. Are you going to dye it again?”

Glimmer runs her hand through her multi-colored locks. “I’ve been meaning to, actually. With everything going on, I kept forgetting. Not to mention, it can be a bitch to do by myself. No matter how many times I do it I always seem to make a mess out of my bathroom and sink somehow.”

“Do you want me to try and help? I never dyed hair before but you can tell me what to do.”

“Are you really up for it? It can take some time to do.”

“Totally!” Adora beams. “You said it yourself. Why not spend some time just to ourselves and enjoy it?”

“I do like my ideas.” Glimmer lets gravity bring the legs of her chair downward. “Let’s do it! I just gotta get the bathroom set up.”

Adora and Glimmer finish up their morning meal, the hunter downing yet again another cup of coffee. It is a bit of a wonder how her blood isn’t purely made up of the brown liquid. After cleaning up dishes, it is off to the bathroom. Glimmer suggests that Adora change out of her good clothing and into something she doesn’t mind possibly getting stained. With herself still in pjs, it doesn’t matter. The blonde shrugs before pulling off her sweatshirt and wrapping it around her waist. All that covers her torso is a white tank.

“This should be fine,” Adora states.

“You and your allergy to wearing warm clothes in cold weather. Suit yourself.”

They travel back upstairs, semi-racing each other to the top. Though, neither really keeps track of who got to the final step first. Not that it matters much as their playful giggles fill the air. Adora feels light as a feather as she follows Glimmer into the bathroom. The walls of the room are pale and tiled, not much

different than the one Adora uses downstairs. The only real differences are the purple towels and stars and moon shower drapes.

Glimmer opens a drawer and rummages around for a moment before pulling out everything necessary for hiding away her black hair. The hunter explains everything that has to be done. She even shows some pictures to help aid in the guide. Once there is a thumbs up by Adora, it's time to get to work.

Adora happily brushes out Glimmer's hair. Any knots that are found are freed. While brushing, she can't help but run her fingers through the dyed locks. So soft. It's as if someone has snatched the fluffiest cloud from the sky and placed it on top of Glimmer's head. Adora could just play with her girlfriend's hair forever and ever. How can one's hair be this soft? However, work still must be done and she can always enjoy playing with it later. With everything smooth and not a single entanglement can be found, it's time to get to the dyeing. She grabs the brush, already stained in the color needed, and gets to work.

Every so often, Adora checks the phone laid out on the bathroom sink, making sure she isn't fucking this up. No need to ruin Glimmer's hair. The hunter flicks the screen when needed and keeps her eyes on the mirror, instructing Adora when needed. The blonde starts to get lost in her thoughts, so focused on getting everything right. When all the steps that she can do are completed, Adora sets the brush down. Hands rest on her hips, just above her tied up sweatshirt.

"There we go!" Adora chirps, chest puffed out, feeling proud of her work. "Now we just gotta wait, right?"

"Yes. Also." Glimmer states to her feet, spinning around on her heels. She grabs Adora's wrist, pulling her hand to her face. Fingers are coated in the hues of pink and purple. Looking down, colorful fingerprints stain her bright white tank top. "I was waiting to see how long it took for you to realize you didn't have the gloves on."

There is a bright twinkle in Glimmer's eyes and an imp-like smirk on her face. Adora sticks out her tongue before using her other equally stained hand to wipe it against her girlfriend's cheek. A pink streak now goes from under her lilac eye to almost her chin. "That's what you get for not telling me."

"Oh so we are playing that game." The smirk grows as Glimmer uses her free hand to grab for the brush. "It's on."

Despite the close quarters, Adora ducks out of the way from the assault. Only days after the full moon, both their senses and reaction times are quicker. Though, even though Adora has more of the supernatural power flowing through her veins, Glimmer has the advantage of a possible werepanther in her. Nimble on her feet, all she needs is her toes on the ground to spin around. Tile does not deter her in the slightest. A hand shoots forward, a finger gripping Adora's tank top.

Adora throws up her arms, protecting her face. She feels the cool dye and the soft bristles against her skin. After regaining her own footing, Adora herself takes the opportunity to grab her girlfriend's wrist. She pushes it towards Glimmer's face. Her nose soon becomes a bright pink. The blonde grins from ear to ear, pleased with her work. It does not last long at all.

With her hand still grasping Adora's tank, Glimmer forces her forward. The blonde is taken off her feet, tile squeaking as her soles slip on the tile. Lips connect with each other, taking Adora totally off guard. Her whole body goes tense. This sensation is still something she has to get used to. Warm spreads from top to bottom, to every inch of her fingers and toes. Slowly, her body relaxes. She soaks up every ounce of the embrace.

"What was that for?" Adora hums as she pulls away.

"Hm." Glimmer clicks her tongue against her teeth. "I just wanted to. And," Glimmer flicks her wrist. Dye from the brush splatters against Adora's cheek. "And to lower your guard."

“Asshole.” With the dye on her fingers still wet, she taps her index on the tip of Glimmer’s nose, painted even more. Their battle quickly restarts.

By the time the timer goes off, it is not just Glimmer’s hair that has changed color. Both women’s faces and arms have some streak of colors. Both their tops are stained. Even parts of Adora’s sweatshirt could not escape the battle between the two.

“Sorry about that,” Glimmer says with a slight laugh. “I didn’t mean to ruin that for you.”

Adora waves her off. “It’s no big deal, I don’t mind it. Not like I can’t still wear it, right?” She rubs her cheek. “More worried about this stuff.”

“It’ll come out eventually, don’t worry. Now if you don’t mind,” Glimmer places her hand on her girlfriend’s chest, pushing Adora out of the bathroom. “I gotta wash my hair. Might as well take a shower shower as well.”

Adora feels her body turn red hot. “Y-Y-Yeah. Uh, I’ll be i-in the living r-room.”

Glimmer chuckles as she shuts the door. Adora spins on one foot, turning herself around to face the stairs, and slowly makes her way back into the lower half of the house. She muddles around, flipping through her phone, wondering what would be good for dinner later, and what else to do for the day. It does not take long for Glimmer to reappear. Clean, dressed for the day, and her hair showing no signs of their true raven color. A towel rubs against the top of her hair.

“Looking good.” Adora says.

Glimmer grins. She walks up to her girlfriend, who is resting on the couch. Once close enough, she drops the wet towel on Adora’s head. The blonde winces for a moment before, quite literally, shakes it off of her body.

“Thanks for the help. It’s nice having some help with that.” Glimmer settles down beside her girlfriend. “Sorry for the mess.” She brushes fingers against Adora’s painted arms.

“Eh, it’s fine. It’ll wash off eventually, right?”

“Eventually.”

“We still have a whole day ya know. Do you want to do anything else?”

“Do you want to get out of the house?” Glimmer raises an eyebrow.

“Yes.” Adora begins to slip on her stained sweatshirt. At home, wearing little covering for her shoulder has become common, what with wearing tanks for shifts. But outside, no. That remains forbidden. Her head pops free, hair slightly messy. “We can keep everything a secret for a bit and still go out right? Just act like before?”

“I like that idea. Though I guess that means we both have to pay for lunch.”

Adora snorts, rolling her eyes, before standing to her feet and snatching the keys off the counter.

Adora rubs her cheek, an absent minded and feeble attempt to get rid of the fading dye from her face. Most of the other stains have disappeared and if not, they are hidden from view. The same goes for Glimmer. With any luck, all will be gone within the next couple days. But that is the least of her worries right now. Try as they might to keep the relationship a secret in an attempt to enjoy alone time, a slip up has occurred.

It was completely by accident. Adora and Glimmer were hanging out with Bow, nothing special at all. A simple walk through the park, enjoying the changing weather and leaves. The two women were doing their best not to let their friend know. They wanted to

spend just a *little* more time alone. But they couldn't help themselves. When Adora and Glimmer thought Bow was not looking, the blonde snuck a kiss—a small peck against the hunter's cheek. She tried to be careful but was not careful enough.

Bow caught this action and immediately asked about it. Neither Adora or Glimmer could come up with a good excuse and had to admit defeat. Bow could neither stop gushing or hold in his excitement. Part of the joy came from the fact he apparently won a bet against Mermista on when the two would get together. With no more point in hiding their relationship, they let everyone know.

And now here Adora and Glimmer are. Waiting inside a small yet retro looking diner, waiting for Perfuma and Scorpia. The pair sit side by side, both having anxiety about their first double date (and honestly, first *date* date) following equally through them. Hidden from view, under the table, both clutches the other's hand. Adora's leg bounces rapidly, unable to remain still with the anticipation.

"You think they'll be here soon?" Adora asks, now chewing on one of her jacket's strings.

"Soon. They have to close down shop. And you know, there are probably better things to gnaw on."

"I can't help it...This is still all so new and I didn't expect it to happen so fast."

Glimmer gives a soft squeeze of her hand. "I know. I've known them for such a long time now. Seen 'Fuma go through two relationships and my nerves are still running amuck."

Adora leans back against the padded booth. She lets her head roll to the side, gazing out into the orange world. The glass window is decked out in Halloween decals. Pumpkins, black cats, witches, candy corn—you name it. Outside, hay and straw are stacked on

top of each other. Pumpkins wait to be craved. Some places even have corn stalks by their door frames. Eyes scan the sidewalk, searching for her friends. After a couple minutes of seeing unfamiliar faces, Adora finally spots the familiar faces.

"Ah!" she pushes herself off. "They're here!"

"Shit, really?" Glimmer leans forward, looking out the window. When each pair spots the other, they give a wave. Once in the diner, Perfuma and Scorpia quickly slide into the seats across from the other couple. Both have large smirks on their faces.

"Go on, get it out of your system," Glimmer sighs.

"I am *so* happy for you two!" Scorpia squeals. "We all were waiting for it to happen!"

"That's what everyone's been saying," Adora chuckles. "How long was everyone starting to make bets?"

"Long enough to start getting impatient," Perfuma states. Everyone is cut off from their conversation when the waiter comes and takes everyone's orders. Once that is done, Perfuma continues her train of thought. "Everyone is happy for the two of you. I hope you were able to enjoy yourselves before word got out. Scorpia and I only had a couple days before it was known to all."

"We had about a week, thankfully. It was nice but I guess it had to get out eventually."

Scorpia's eyes have grown bigger and bigger as the time has passed. "We gotta do a triple date with Mermista and Sea Hawk one day. That would be a lot of fun, wouldn't it?"

"God, going on a date alongside Sea Hawk? That will be interesting," Glimmer jokes.

"Not to change the mood," Perfuma leans forward. "You didn't hear anything, did you? It's been quiet on our end, for once."

“Same,” Adora replies. After her last shift, both have waited to hear anything. Even checking in with Petra yielded nothing. Going from hearing about a werewolf not returning to their human form to not a single peep does not sit well in her stomach. Adora wonders if they have yet to find anything or the killer has decided to take a break.

If it is the latter her nerves are so unease, Adora doesn't think she can enjoy this moment of peace or even call it that.

“Tell me about it.” Glimmer huffs. “I’m just *waiting* for my phone to go off in the middle of the night to tell me there have been more murders. I don’t know what’s worse.”

“Well if the enemy is taking a break, then we can use it to figure more things out, right?”

“She has a point,” Perfuma points out.

“Well, I think you all need a rest,” Scorpia says. “You three have been worrying yourselves so much you guys deserve it. How about I treat you all to dessert? Especially for the new couple!”

“You don’t have to do that!” Adora retorts.

“Too late! I am already going to do it! You all have your powers and skills, I am the one that pays for dessert. No if, ands, or buts!”

“We are going to be here all afternoon if you two keep this up. Besides, we are here to celebrate you two becoming a couple right? Our present to you two,” Perfuma adds on.

“Fine but we get next time,” Glimmer states.

Glimmer sits on the top step of the back deck. The Whispering Woods start back at her, barely a shade of emerald on their leaves. When the cool wind picks up, branches shake some of

them off. The ground is nothing but leaf litter. Somewhere in the distance, the smell of pumpkin cinnamon travels in the air. The sky above her is blue, remnants of the warm sunrise having faded away. A gaggle of geese honk loudly as they fly, heading for their southern destination. Between her fingers, Glimmer rolls the steam of a flower. A white chrysanthemum.

It's a rare sight to see the hunter up this early. She did honestly try to sleep, especially as Adora slumbered just besides her. No matter how hard she tried, no matter how many times she snapped her eyes shut, sleep never found her. Though, that is not surprising given what day morning has brought. It's her mother's birthday after all.

She tilts her head upward, watching the clouds float by. Birds sing their songs as they get ready to spread their wings. In the peaceful, still moment, Glimmer wonders if her mother is staring down at her, watching everything she does. With everything going on, it's anyone's guess what Angella could be thinking of wherever she is. The hunter sighs and shuts her eyes, letting the cool air overtake her.

Thoughts trickle into her brain, little in the way to stopping them. Is her mother proud of what she has been doing? Would she be lecturing her on how to properly handle the situation? Would *she* even know what the fuck to do? Or would the experienced hunter be just as lost as her daughter. And most of all, what *did* she know? What was hidden in her notebook and in her mind? What did she take to the grave with her…

Each thought is like a punch to the gut, a twisting of the heart. What she wouldn't give to see her mother one more time, ask her all the questions inside of her. Apologize for how she is handling the fact a serial killer is out on the loose and there is barely an inkling of clues...Embrace and receive a kiss one more time...Hear her *voice* again…

Her hand grips the steam tightly. If only she knew who snuffed out her mother's life.

Something warm and heavy drapes against her shoulders. Glimmer's eyes flutter open, finding Adora hovering over her. Her girlfriend has placed a jacket against her torso.

"Guess I rubbed off on you if you aren't wearing anything warm when it's barely fifty out." Adora plops down on the step. "You doin' alright?"

Glimmer sets the flower down on the porch. "I'll be alright."

"With what, though?"

"Just throw a dart and see where it lands. God, where the hell is my dad and aunt?" Glimmer grabs her phone, unlocking the screen. The number of unread messages are the same. There is no need to open them up. All are from her father, asking the same thing over and over again. The moment he was told about his daughter *finally* dating someone, he has eagerly been blowing up Glimmer's phone. For better or for worse, with Angella's birthday so close after the reveal, he does not have to wait long to go full proud dad mode upon seeing her.

She is just waiting for her front door to be kicked off its hinges. Not only will there be a new addition to the family, but this will be the first time anyone has seen each other in about a year. That itself is worth excitement. Glimmer won't lie, she can't wait to see her father and aunt again. She has a feeling they will take well to Adora. Some joy and brightness is a nice change of pace on this yearly event.

Placing the phone back in her pocket, Glimmer lets her back fall onto the deck. With the roofing above, most of the clouds and sky are hidden. Only slivers can be seen. "I wish they'd get here already. I've been doing enough waiting around."

Adora joins her in lying on the porch. Arms go behind her head. "What are your dad and aunt like?"

"Dad...He can be a little much but he means well. Has a lot of love to give but he can be a little out there. My aunt is a bit more

down to earth but they are siblings. She can have her own quirkiness. I think I have, like, a hundred knitted sweaters in the attic waiting to come down for the winter."

Adora chuckles. "Are they bad?"

"No. Some are silly, like ' *World's best niece'* on the front. Watch out, she might take out measuring tape and start making you one."

"Can't wait."

The silence falls between them. Clouds slowly swim through the sky. The wind gently blows, nipping against Glimmer's cheeks. Somewhere in the forest, she hears the crunching of leaves and snapping of twigs. If she had to take a guess, a buck is wandering around nearby. Rutting season is about to kick off. Someone is off to an early start.

Boards begin to creak. Glimmer has just enough time to register that Adora is the cause of the noise. She rolls over the hunter, arms at either side of her body. Faces rest inches apart. This close, Glimmer can see how blue Adora's eyes are. They are more vibrant than the sky above and the lights in her irises are brighter and warmer than the sun.

"Is this okay?" Adora asks.

"Don't worry." Glimmer lifts her head up enough to place a kiss on the tip of Adora's nose. "I love it."

"Good. I'm glad."

Adora leans even closer. Her loose flowing hair tickles Glimmer's cheek, causing her to giggle. "What are you even doing?"

"I dunno. I am not allowed to be close to my girlfriend?"

"No. It's illegal."

"Well, I guess I am a serial criminal. 'Cuz I am not about to stop, especially at night. I'm not giving up cuddles."

"Well I guess I am an accomplice since I don't want to stop either."

Adora leans closer. Foreheads connect. Hands shift up and warm, callous fingers rub against Glimmer's cheeks. "Glad to see that smile of yours."

"All thanks to you." Glimmer reaches up, arms wrapping around her girlfriend's neck. She wishes to stay here forever, just the two of them. The thoughts of her mother's birthday slip away. Adora replaces them all, being the sole thought in her mind. A little beacon of hope and light is only centimeters away. She pulls the blonde closer, wanting nothing more to connect their lips together.

There is no need for a jacket with the warmth emanating from Adora's body. The wide, open world shrinks, only becoming the two women. Adora's blonde hair continues to brush against Glimmer's cheek. Eyes flutter shut once more and all of the hunter's senses hones in on her girlfriend above her. Ears fill with the sound of Adora's strong and steady heartbeat. The scent of her sandalwood soap enters Glimmer's nose. Fingers lace through her girlfriend's soft locks. All the hunter wants to do is close the gap between them.

However, before their lips can connect, the back door swings open with force.

"Sweetpea are you out here?"

Micah's voice echoes through the air. Both Adora and Glimmer twist their heads in the direction of the older man, both frozen in place from the sudden interruption. The hunter can hear both hers and her girlfriend's hearts pounding in their chest. Warmth that was comforting turns into heat that makes you want to crawl out of your skin.

Everyone blinks, neither quite knowing what to do or say. Adora's mouth is slacked while both Glimmer and Micah's eyes are wide. After what seems like forever—seconds having turned into hours—the older man clears his throat before speaking.

"You know, there are bedrooms inside. You probably would be a lot warmer there than out here. Your aunt and I can come back later."

" *DAD!"* Glimmer snaps, glaring at her father. He has the cheekiest grin on his face.

Adora scrambles off of Glimmer, struggling to stay steady on her feet. She nearly topples over herself before straightening out. Her face turns such a bright shade of red, for the first time the hunter notices the faintest of freckling. Adora can barely keep eye contact with Micah.

"Ah! N-No Mr. Sir Micah, sir!" she stutters. "I just-We were-It's nothing! I'm not even into that! It-It was nothing! We were j-just having f-fun! Nothing more!"

Micah bursts out laughing, clutching his stomach and propping himself up against the door frame. Glimmer, meanwhile, still lying with her back on the porch, pinches the bridge of her nose. "Dad, please don't embarrass Adora."

"But she is my new daughter. I have too!" her father replies through his chuckles.

Adora blinks. "What?"

"It's barely been a month, Dad!"

"So?" Micah walks up to Adora, wrapping an arm around her neck and pulling her into a tight embrace. He begins walking back into the house. "C'mon. Tell me about yourself."

Glimmer flips onto her stomach, watching her father and girlfriend enter the house. Adora looks over his shoulder, not knowing what

to do and eyes begging for help. The hunter remains where she is, her own jaw's turn to go slack.

Did he just kidnap her? ...Did he just ditch me?!?

She hurries to her feet and quickly catches up with the pair. Thankfully, by the time Glimmer enters, her father has let go of Adora. He has joined his younger sister's side, carrying in a set of bags. The moment Castaspella sees her niece, she almost teleports to her.

"How is my favorite niece doing?"

"I'm fine, Aunt Casta." Glimmer returns the hug, squeezing her aunt tight. Man she missed her family. "Though, I would like my girlfriend back, *Dad!"*

"C'mon here, Sweatpea." Micah opens his arms out wide, waiting for his daughter. Glimmer breaks free from her aunt and quickly settles herself against her father's chest. Within his tight embrace, a different kind of peace forms. In his arms, he can shield her from all the horrors from the world. Just like when she was little and storms threatened to bring down her home.

"Is everything okay? How are you holding up?" Micah whispers into her ears. She knows what he means.

Glimmer buries her face further into his chest. She already told him about what occurred all the way back in July and some details of the serial killer on the loose. How much does he or Castaspella need to know before their worry becomes too great to hide? "I'll be alright. I don't really wanna talk about it. Not today."

"Okay." He plants a kiss on top of her head before letting go. "Now, why don't you properly introduce me to your new girlfriend of yours?"

Adora gives a small, nervous wave when eyes land back on her. She stands quite tall—stiff as a board—and she looks like she is meeting the Queen of England. With a hand to the shoulder,

Glimmer reassures her girlfriend and gets her to relax. Though, it is not enough to get her to settle down on the couch. Instead, she remains on her feet, rocking back and forth.

Before taking their own seats, the two siblings grab one of the bags they have brought in. The contents are spilled onto the coffee table. There are a number of snack foods, different from the ones received in the care package months ago. A couple of DVDs of movies Glimmer never has heard of stare back at her. Dead in the center is a small bag off a cookie mix.

"Some stuff for you guys," Micah says. "We would've gotten you guys more to celebrate getting together but it was such short notice."

"This is more than enough, thanks! Adora, look at this!" Glimmer snatches the cookie mix from her table before tossing it at her girlfriend. The blonde catches it with ease. "We can make those this weekend, what do you say?"

Adora studies the packaging closely, running a finger against its side. "I'm down for it, though do you know how to read Korean? Because if not, we are screwed on the instructions."

"Don't worry, I can."

There is a lot of catching up to do as everyone settles down. Micah and Castaspella have found a hotel just outside of town, planning on staying for the week. There are others they wish to see and places they wish to revisit. Glimmer keeps her mouth shut on a number of things, such as the werewolf who never shifted back after being murdered. There is no need to talk or think about death anymore then she will be today.

Adora doesn't seem too keen on doing it either, or saying much about herself. Whenever Micah or Castaspella ask her about where she has come from or what she did before meeting Glimmer, she manages to deflect it onto something else. Glimmer

steps in a couple times to change the topic onto something else, such as how life has been across the globe.

Soon, lunch is on the horizon. It becomes an event for everyone, resulting in the whole kitchen becoming a mess from top of bottom. Some rice and meat are made and enjoyed together. Micah continues to tease his 'new daughter' whenever he gets the chance, welcoming her into the family. Adora doesn't seem to mind and even starts asking Micah random little questions.

"Well, he has taken a shine to her," Glimmer says as they wrap up cooking.

"He has been excited to meet Adora, after everything you have told us," Castaspella replies.

Glimmer gives a small snort. "Everyone seems excited over us being together. I swear everyone saw it but us and had a bet on it."

"If I am being honest, your father and I had the same thing going. I won."

"Ah, come on!" Glimmer protests, her face turning red. "Not you too!"

Her aunt can only laugh. Everything is brought to the table to enjoy. More stories are being told, mostly but Micah who cannot seem to stop talking. Everything is bright and cheerful until dessert.

Glimmer takes a deep inhale before standing from the kitchen table. She grabs a slice of strawberry shortcake. Her favorite. But also, her mother's. Before, she set up a photo of her mother on an end table with a candle. The plate is placed in front of the frame before the candle—a lilac scented one—is lit.

Adora steps closer, gently wrapping her arms around her girlfriend, giving her a tight squeeze. "Thank you, 'Dora," Glimmer says. She leans her whole weight against her girlfriend's body as

she stares misty eyed at the photo of her mother. “Happy birthday, Mom. I love you.”

*And I **will** find your killer.*

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated

Baby Steps

Chapter Notes

> so little update, I got another chapter done for the queue for reason so instead of 4 all together, you guys will be getting 5!!! but yeah this ch not much tw other than the usual death mention ya know and some alcohol mention. enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So, where are you two off to next?" Micah asks. He, Castaspella, Glimmer, and Adora take time to have a nice meal at one of the many restaurants in Brightmoon. With the siblings heading back to South Korea tomorrow, having one last togetherness is needed. Who knows the next time the family will be back together again.

"Colmany." Glimmer replies.

"Why there? It's awfully far away, honey," Castaspella states.

This is true. Colmay is in a whole ass other state. It will take *time* to get there. Even waking up before the sun does, one will not be able to get there until nearly noon. Glimmer barely wants to entertain the idea of rising that early. Even Adora, when told about heading to the city, said *that* was too early for her. That is not a good sign when the early bird wants to sleep rather than get up and drive.

Glimmer pushes back against the chair. She crosses her arms against her chest while chewing on her plastic straw. "I know Mom went there a few times. I was hoping to see if I could meet any of the hunters or non-humans there. See if they know anything about what's going on. At this point, any information is better than none, right?"

"You are becoming quite the hunter, Sweetpea. Your mother would be proud of you," Micah tells his daughter.

Glimmer doesn't know how to reply. Eyes dart away from her father as she continues to speak. "Thanks." *I hope so.* "I know they have their own little hidden stores there also so we can gather some stuff."

"Just be careful. No need to get yourself hurt again."

"Don't worry, sir. I'll make sure nothing happens," Adora replies.

"Adora, how many times do I have to tell you to call me ' *Micah'.* "

Glimmer sees her girlfriend scratching the side of her face. She holds back a laugh, knowing Adora *is* trying not to be so formal. A tough habit it has been to break. Glimmer reaches out a hand and squeezes Adora's free one.

"Everything will be fine," she says, looking at Adora and her family. "Colmany is safe. And if anything happens we can handle ourselves, right, 'Dora?"

"Right!" Adora replies.

"You know we just worry, right?" Castaspella says.

"I know. But let's not keep talking about this. We are here to eat and enjoy before you guys leave! Don't forget this is on me."

"Oh yeah, since that reminds me." Micah waves for a waiter, "Can I get another platter!"

"Asshole." Glimmer grumbles.

"God it's been a while since I last was in the car for that long." Glimmer stretches out her limbs, her muscles and bones happily sigh in relief, overjoyed to no longer be confined in the car seat. Besides her, Adora does the same, doing her own stretches. While getting their body used to moving around again, the hunter takes the time to gather her surroundings.

With Halloween only *days* away, every inch of the city is covered in decorations, much more than back home. Grim reapers in trees, tombstones everywhere each with a different message inscribed, craved up pumpkins waiting to be lit, and ghosts hanging on porches. Some houses are covered head to toe in lights, animatronics, and other various decorations. Somewhere, someone is blasting ` *This is Halloween'.* With every inhale, Glimmer smells the scent of warm spices.

"Where too, Glim?" Adora asks, holding a leg behind her back.

"Hm." Glimmer looks around. She only remembers being here once, many years ago. Things sure have changed. Most of what she has to go off of is based on what her mother would tell her. Yet, like before, the passage of time will have affected everything. The hunter closes her eyes, searching her memories for a map to her destination. There is a fuzz to everything, faces blur together and pathways twist in odd directions. After some thought, she finally has a feeling where to go.

"I think it's this way. Hopefully…"

Glimmer makes sure the car is locked and slings a bag over her shoulders before heading down the sidewalk. Adora follows right behind. The hunter looks around, scanning the walls for any signs of what she's searching for. She hopes that none of the random graffiti hides the symbol. Glimmer bites down on her thumb, worried that she has made a wrong turn. That she is going the wrong way. What if they moved? That always is a huge possibility. Staying in one place for a long time sometimes is not the best idea.

More walking, more nothing. Glimmer groans to herself, truly believing she has fucked this up. How hard is it to find this place? You'd want it hidden, yes, so no unsuspecting regular old human can stumble onto it. Though, even then it's known how to keep your mouth shut. But when hunters or non-humans need aid, you don't want them to be lost in a strange city. Growing up, others

found her mother through word of mouth and seeing the Mirazi crest that she'd have somewhere on her body.

Glimmer herself has relied mostly on word of mouth. Not moving houses has helped a lot at least. How else did Petra find her? Speaking of which, she needs to contact her again and see if they know anything more.

"Yo, Glim." Adora's voice breaks her train of thoughts. Glimmer stops in her tracks. She lets go of her thumb and turns her attention to her girlfriend. The blonde runs a hand against a stone wall, fingers brushing against an inscription. "You know what this is about?"

Glimmer steps forward. Her eyes go wide at the sight. What's painted on the wall is simple, not much in the way of things. Only two letters in length. ' *Ag'.* What catches her attention the most is the circular part of the ' *g'.* Half of it looks like the shape of a crescent moon.

"Adora, you found it!" Glimmer wraps her arms around her girlfriend, pulling her close and straight into a kiss on the cheek. When Adora's body becomes tense, she immediately releases her and takes a step back. "Sorry. Didn't mean that, I got caught up in the moment."

Adora rubs her cheek. "It's okay. I know you didn't mean too. But, thank you for apologizing." She does not remove her hand from her face as she looks back at the wall. "So,what does this mean? How do you know this is the place we are looking for?"

"Hunters will mark places with symbols to tell other hunters or non-humans about safe places and what not."

"Like a code?"

"Exactly!" Glimmer taps the wall. "You know what these letters mean?"

Adora squints, the gears turning in her head. Her hand slides down her face, stopping at her chin. She begins tapping a finger in thought. "I feel like I know it from somewhere. I can't remember."

"It's the symbol for silver. The most common thing hunters will use. And the moon, of course, for you guys. I guess the crescent moon looked better than a full one with this. But this is it! Let's go!"

Glimmer grabs Adora's hand, pulling her up a small flight of stairs. A mix of emotions bubbles up inside of her. She cannot recall the last time she met up with many hunters or non-humans. Much of her time has been spent in Brightmoon, making sure nothing happens there, and occasionally stopping back at where her aunt used to live, hoping for clues. She realizes up until Adora waltzed into her life, her life was a bore. However you want to use the word, she has not had *this* much excitement in a *long* time.

However, that fact also causes her nerves to run wild. She'll be on her own for the first time in this type of setting. There will possibly be hunters much more experienced than her. Who knows how many non-humans will be there, ones she has never seen before. She and Adora shall be the odd men out. People here will most likely know one another. Glimmer squeezes Adora's hand tighter, happy she will not be alone.

By the door, Glimmer can faintly hear the steady tempo of a pop song. Besides her, Adora tilts her head towards the side. Her ears must be picking up more of the music. Glimmer gives her a small nudge. "I still have earplugs if you need them."

Adora thinks for a moment before speaking. "I think I will be okay. I will keep that in mind, though."

Glimmer gives a small nod before wrapping her hands around the door handle. With a push, they enter the bar.

At first glance, it does not look terribly different from others. There is a section right at the bar. Bottles rest on the wall and bartenders go back and forth in the enclosed space to hand customers their drinks. TV screens play various types of sports games. Off towards the side, booths rest against walls. Decorations and paintings hang above and there are some neon lights around the room.

The music, despite being at a fair volume, is drowned out by the sounds of loud laughter and chatter. With evening slowly inching close, a number of people are already drunk. A scan of the room —everyone in the room is human. Or at the very least, in human *form.* Glimmer steps in closer, looking around for anyone to talk to. It does not take long for someone to appear.

Someone not much older than her and Adora. They are tall and slender, their long, pale blonde hair shaved at the sides. Bright, yellow-green eyes twinkle with excitement.They grin widely. Written on their name tag is ' *DT'.*

"Welcome, welcome!" DT says with a song in their voice. "How may I help you wonderful darlings?"

"We are here to talk to others." Glimmer pulls her bag up, showing her family crest to DT. "My name is Glimmer Mizari. You might've known my mother, Angella."

DT clasp their hands together. "Yes I do. I met her a number of times before. Come, come. I am Double Trouble by the way, but you can call me DT." As they begin to walk, they look over their shoulder. "And who and what might you be?"

"Adora. I'm uh...a werewolf...What are you?"

"A shapeshifter. Somewhat like you but I can turn into anything I please. However, I cannot show off my prowess out here."

DT picks up their pace, pushing past a small crowd of people, weaving in and out with ease. Glimmer and Adora, meanwhile, jostle against the group of people, a number already drunk. The

hunter shoves one such person away when they stumble backwards. Now she remembers why she never really attempted to go to these places before. Not enough breathing room.

Finally, a door appears. DT pushes it, revealing another room. The interior looks almost the same as the previous section. Same set up, similar decorations, and just as many loud people. However, it is the crowd that is different, not just because it is a whole new group of strangers. Centaurus, harpies, faeries, vampires, and those somewhere between their human form and true form. Glimmer spots some dragons in that state, scales on their arms, fingers twisted into claws, horns poking out of their forehead, and some with wings out of their back.

Others are 'human', however, they are most likely stuck under the same circumstances as Adora. Only the power of the full moon can change their appearance. Others can simply be hunters or people like Bow and Scorpia—friends.

"Wow!" Adora marvels. "I don't think I've ever seen so many people like...like me!"

"I don't think I have either," Glimmer replies in awe. As she slowly takes in all the sights, a familiar face startles her. Out of nowhere, Adora is *inches* from her face, a wide grin dead centered on the blonde's face. Glimmer yelps and tumbles back in shock, smacking against a chair and table. Regaining her footing, she blinks, realizing, in fact, there are *two* Adoras staring at her. One has just as much shock and confusion on her face as the hunter does and the other is about to burst out laughing.

"D-Double Trouble!" Glimmer gasps, remembering what they had said moments before. "Is that you?!? What the fuck!"

The howl of laughter DT has tried to suppress burst out. They throw back their head, clutching their stomach. The true Adora slowly steps over to her girlfriend, still staring wide eyed at her exact copy. DT's laughter slowly dies down and they look back at the pair. Still as Adora, they wipe some tears from their eyes. "Oh,

I *love* the faces people give when they first see my performance. Oh, wait!”

A sparkling, dark glow overtakes DT. Their body shirks, hair becomes short, and even the outline of their clothing changes. As the glow dissipates, the form of Glimmer stares back at her with a stunned expression. DT exaggerates this by posing as if they are about to faint from the sheer shock of seeing a double.

“Tell me, did I capture your reaction right? I am a bit of a perfectionist,” DT says in Glimmer’s voice.

“If I say yes, will you go back to being you? This is creeping me out.” Glimmer shudders as a cold shiver runs down her spine.

“If you say so,” DT returns to their previous form, clicking their tongue against their teeth. “No one seems to enjoy seeing themself for the first time.”

“I wonder why,” Adora mumbles.

“Now before you start going around asking a million questions, would you two darlings like a drink?” DT points to Adora. “You said you were a werewolf, right? Would you like something that tastes good or one that gives you a good time?”

“Eh? What do you mean?”

“You don’t know?” DT blinks back in surprise.

“Well got kept in the dark about a lot of things.” Adora turns her attention to Glimmer. “What are they talking about?”

“You can’t get drunk on normal booze. A lot of non-humans can’t because their chemistry is different. You can still enjoy drinks but nothing will happen. However, there are specially made ones that can get you drunk.”

“How?”

“Typically wolfsbane. Ya know how we use it to keep you from killing us during the full moons? The low doses and whatever else they mix in gets you drunk.”

“Correct!” DT interjects. “I’m still waiting for an answer.”

“I’m good. Driving,” Glimmer states.

“No thanks,” Adora declines.

“Suit yourselves. Pick a table. I’ll bring some water then. If you would like any food let me know!”

DT disappears into the crowd. Glimmer and Adora spot a small table off to the side. Once settled into the chairs, the hunter looks around. Sure enough, there is not a *single* living being that Glimmer recognizes. A total fish out of water. Her heart begins to pound in her chest. If it wasn’t for the fingerless gloves, someone could easily spot the beads of sweat forming on her palms.

Glimmer lets out a long, low groan. She sprawls out her whole upper half on the table.

“You okay?” Adora softly asks. A hand is gently placed on her back, creating small circles against her fabric.

“Just trying to figure out what the hell to do. I don’t even know who to talk to first.”

“Should we pick at random?”

“We could but who knows if we choose someone totally plastered.”

“Do you think DT would know anything?”

“Know what?” DT asks, suddenly having materialized by the table. They set down two glasses of water, ice knocking together.

Adora and Glimmer exchange looks. So far DT is the only person they have talked to and they seem chatty enough. With lives being lost and the killer still on the loose, there isn't any harm in asking them.

"Depends," Glimmer looks back at the shapeshifter. "How much have you been keeping up with the news."

DT pulls up a seat, sitting in it with the back forward. "Depends. What type of news are we talking about?"

"How much do you know about the string of deaths? Both hunters and non-humans."

"Ah, that. Not a lot of people like to think 'bout that." DT drums their fingers against the table. "Colmay has been spared, what with little greenery a bloodthirsty beast can be more easily seen, but I have heard a number of stories. Both from online and through word of mouth. Albeit, some drunken."

"Hear anything interesting?" Adora asks.

"You two playing detective or something?"

"You can say that."

DT thinks for a moment. "I do not know what you have heard. Random deaths, non-humans not turning back, hunters being killed, no one seems to have an inkling of an idea."

"You don't have anything useful?" Glimmer presses. "No one ever saw this damn thing in passing or escaped? Did it have a buddy or was it alone? Does anyone have an idea what it is or how the hell it is stopping the shifts back?"

DT shrugs. "Most people think it is a werewolf like your friend here. No one ever said anything about a partner but not many people have survived being mauled by whatever the hell this thing is. And that stopping of shifts has everyone on guard. Honestly, the best I can offer is if I were you two, I would be extra careful."

Glimmer scoffs. “Tell me something I don’t know.”

“Why are you two playing detective anyway? You are much younger than some of the other hunters trying to make heads or tails of this. And they haven’t had much luck, if any.”

Glimmer’s fingers curl into fists. It takes effort to not let the hot, red angry suddenly boiling and bubbling up inside of her. *Why? Because they took away my* ***mother!*** “I have my reasons. I’m sure everyone does. And I think I am one of the people who survive being mauled.”

“Oh?”

“Glim. Are you sure about this?” Adora whispers.

“What else am I supposed to do?” Glimmer turns her attention back to DT. “I am pretty sure I was attacked by the same thing that took the life of...of my mother. Bastard beat me up quite badly.”

“I see. Is little Ms. Hunter a werecreature now?”

“No, and we are getting off topic.”

“Do you know *anything* ?” Adora asks.

“All I got is whoever is out there is not something to mess with. I must be going back to my duties.” DT pushes back against the chair and stands. “I am almost always here to answer some questions, especially if you have some spare change for me.”

They disappear back into the crowd. Glimmer sighs, pinches the bridge of her nose. She tries thinking of anything useful from that conversation. Everyone is essentially lost as they are. Others are out there trying to piece two and two together. No one has any idea it seems with the strangeness at the deaths. But none of this comes as much of a shocker. Glimmer already had a feeling she was not alone in the feelings she shared.

If there is anything she can take from the conversation, whatever is out there is indeed a werewolf. Everything is circling back to that creature. Doesn't narrow down much, who knows how many of them are running around, but at least that is a defendant *something.* That does beg one question, however. What attacked her in the woods? She struggles to get anything other than a blurry, shadowy image. There is no way to say for sure what it was but the sleek figure does not sit right with her.

"How are you holding up?" Adora asks. "Want me to order you something?"

"Honestly, maybe I will take a drink. I can really use one right now."

"I can always drive to the hotel if you want."

"One drink won't kill me."

"Excuse me?" an unfamiliar voice says.

Glimmer looks towards the nose. A new person now stands slightly away from the table. She seems to be in her mid-thirties. There is an eyepatch over her left eye. Sticking out from under it are jagged claw marks. She is not much taller than Glimmer and her hair hangs above her shoulders. A small smile appears on her face before speaking again. "Are you Angella Mirzai's daughter?"

"I...Um y-yeah! I am. Did you know her?"

"Kind of yes. She'd come here every now and again. Went on some outings together. She saved my ass once," the woman points to her eyepatch. "I'm sorry about your loss. She was an amazing woman."

Glimmer feels her heart twist inside her chest. No matter how many times she meets someone her mother knew, no matter how many sympathies she is given, it never is any easier. Though, knowing that her mother protected the life of someone does give her some sense of comfort and warms her heart.

“Thank you. Yeah...She sure was amazing.”

“You know, your mother used to talk about you a lot when she came here and whenever I met up with her. She said a bit about the fight you two had but she talked a lot more about how proud she was of you. She always hoped you were staying safe and enjoying your life. Once you guys started to talk again Angella *couldn’t* stop talking about it. I had never seen her so happy before! Mrs. Stoic had a soft side and you were it.

“She was excited to see you again and couldn’t wait to hear about everything you did. She really loved you.”

And I fucked it all up. If only I did something different…

“Hey, is that Mizari’s kid?” a new voice pipes up.

“Yeah! It is!” the woman replies.

In an instance, a swarm of people appear at the table off to the side. Adora and Glimmer become deer in headlights and claustrophobia starts to set in. The hunter nearly becomes one with the nearby wall in the presence of so many people. Everyone seems to have their own story to tell and jostle with one another to speak first.

Glimmer listens to them all. Ones such as how as a toddler, Angella brought her here on at least one occasion. A harpy retells how the two-year-old ripped off a fistful of tail feathers when Angella wasn’t looking. Apparently, Glimmer could not stop laughing after doing the deed. Meanwhile a hunter who looks to be an elder recounts how he helped train Angella when she was much younger. He beams when he learns Glimmer has learned some of his skills from her mother—having a crossbow as her main weapon.

More and more stories. How whenever someone met up with Angella when Glimmer was a young, young child, the little girl always caused something. Taking hunter’s equipment, spooking anyone who stepped into her home, and even a few pranks like a

whoopie cushion. Glimmer has little to no memory of her hell-raising days but she can see why her mother didn't have others over much when she was little. Thankfully, though, every one of these stories is accompanied by a chorus of laughter.

Then, of course, the retelling of Angella herself. Stories of her missions with others and always trying to protect others. Trying to piece things together when things got confusing. Learning what she could to get better whenever she failed. And just how *often* she raved about Glimmer, even after their fight. Everything seems to circle back to her. Each and every story the young hunter hears makes her sad, wishing for just one more moment with her mother. But that warmth from before grows to every inch of her body.

"Your mother was one of the best," a young (but probably centuries old) vampire states. "The last time she was here, she had a lot on her mind. Kind of was doing what you two are doing but she didn't say much about it."

"Guess we are really following in her footsteps, huh?" Adora gives Glimmer's hand a squeeze.

"I guess so. Nice to meet you all."

"Hey, let's get you guys something nice. Oi! DT!" Someone hidden in the crowd shouts. "Put their stuff on my bill!"

This is gonna be a long afternoon.

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10 Years Ago

Glimmer inhales, letting the air rest in her lungs for several moments. She grips the wooden frame of her crossbow. The arrow, held back by the strong string, waits patiently to be sent soaring through the air. Yards away is her target, resting up against a tree. Two other arrows are impaled in the fabric but

neither are close to the bullseye. The best she has gotten is one on the thin, black line between red and yellow.

She is determined to make this one count. Her mother has only allotted three arrows to use. You never know when your supplies will run low, when you have to think of every action, or when you *have* to hope luck is on your side. Another test the young hunter is eager to pass. She is a Mizari, the daughter of a skilled hunter. Glimmer refuses to fail.

Time to do this.

Glimmer pulls her index finger towards her body. The trigger follows. In the blink of an eye, the arrow flies free. In a second, it hits the target. While it does not land directly in the bullseye, it comes damn near close. Just outside of it. Glee begins to bubble up inside of the young teenager. It begins to spill out in the form of giggles.

I did it! Well, almost, but this is the closest yet! Finally! I am getting there!

The snap of a twig sends her heart into her throat. Resting on her stomach, Glimmer scrambles to her feet, for a moment forgetting she has no arrows. Her crossbow moves around widely, searching for a target. On unstable feet and not fully aware of what is going on, an unseen force taps her against the chest. She lands hard on her ass.

Glimmer groans as she sits up, rubbing her tailbone. She blinks, looking up. Her mother stands nearby. One hand is on a hip.

"Mom! What was that for!" Glimmer asks.

"Always be aware of your surroundings, even as you focus on other things. You never want to lower your guard and be attacked." Her mother says. She sticks out a hand. Glimmer takes it with a free hand and is brought up to her feet. As she dusts herself off, Angella takes a look at her work. "You are getting better. Picking that up much faster than I did."

“You really think so?” Glimmer grins from ear to ear. Hell, she is *vibrating* with excitement at the praise. “Do you think I can start coming out with you?”

“You’re still too young.”

“Ah, come on, Mom!” Glimmer whines. “I am thirteen now! I’m not a little kid anymore!”

Angella sighs. “There are many dangerous beings out there, honey. Some have no control over themself and will not know friend from foe. Some are out for nothing other than blood. You have gotten better at your skills but you are young. Those that are out to truly harm will go after the least experience.”

“I know other hunter kids my age are already going out.” Glimmer huffs.

“And that is the choice of their own parents. You still have a long way to go. If you really want to start doing more,” Angella hands her daughter another set of arrows. “Train more. And do not forget to-”

“Pay attention!” Glimmer snatches the bundle of weapons. “I am not going to get jumped, don’t worry.”

Glimmer returns to her training, traveling from target to target. Some are like the ones before, stationary, only their distance varies. Some, on the other hand, move at different speeds. Everything to ensure future skills if she ever is forced into this position. From what her mother has spoken about and what she herself knows, trouble makers are few. It’s mostly those with no control of whatever it is that is a worry. Werecreatures under the effect of the full moon. Vampires that went too long without a meal. Newly turned non-humans frightened out of their mind on their new abilities.

When she can remember, Glimmer pauses and looks around for any strangeness. She attempts to focus her hearing, searching for any anomalies. Nothing more than the stray bird or chipmunk.

After ensuring her mother, or anything else, won’t appear out of nowhere, she returns to her practice. By the time the sun is setting, the young hunter is out of arrows and out of breath. She still has yet to get a bullseye—god must really hate her right about now. The closest she ever gets is on the line, totally denying her sweet, sweet glory.

Glimmer slowly trudges her way out of the Whispering Woods and to the backyard of her home. The kitchen light is on and the window is wide open. As she draws closer to her beloved home, the smell of dinner enters her home. Burgers. Glimmer picks up the pace, jumping over the steps of her back deck and throws open the door. Entering her home, she finds her mother at the stove.

“That smells really good!” Glimmer hums, mouth watering. She walks up to her mother, eyeing the food in the frying pan.

“You were out for so long and training so hard, you deserved something since.” She turns to face her daughter. "Your face is a mess, c'mon here."

Angella grabs a dish rag and quickly wets it before rubbing it against her Glimmer's dirt stained face. The young hunter realizes she had a few nicks as the wet fabric brushes against her skin.

" *Mom!!* I'm almost in high school! You don't have to do this!" Glimmer complains, though not budging an inch.

"You will always be my little girl and I will always be here to care for you." Happy with her work, Angella places a kiss on her daughter's forehead. "Go rest up. I'll bring your food to you. Love you."

“Thanks, Mom. I love you too."

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Adora pushes herself up, her body still heavy from the tendrils of sleep. She groans, wondering why there is a void besides her. Blurry sights remain unfocused as she goes from the bed to the balcony's door. Squinting, she sees the outline of her girlfriend. The blonde groans as she stretches her body out. She is unable to fully shake the sleep from her body. Regardless, Adora rolls out of bed.

Adora grabs the blanket off the hotel bed as she saunters over to the door. The moment she slides open the door, the cold night air blasts against her body. Adora shudders but presses onward. Glimmer does not seem to notice the new presence. Adora feels the cold concrete against her bare feet as she inches closer and closer to the hunter. Within arms reach, she lifts up the blanket.

For another moment, coldness seeps into her bones. Adora wraps an arm around Glimmer's neck, pulling her close against her body. The blanket drapes over the two, encasing the two women's body warmth in a small cocoon.

"Whatcha thinkin' 'bout, Glim?"

Glimmer sighs through her nose. "Stuff."

Adora places her chin on top of her girlfriend's head. Her soft, fluffy hair tickles her chin. "Stuff you wanna talk about? Is this about how everyone knew your mom?"

"Yeah, I still can't believe how many people had a story. And don't really want to talk anymore about it other than it hit really fuckin' hard."

Adora wraps her arms tighter around Glimmer's body. Lips gently brush against her girlfriend's scalp. "Okay. We don't have to talk about it. Do you want me to distract you? Get your mind off of your mom?"

"Yes please."

Adora clicks her tongue as she thinks what to say, what to ask. Her brain is far from fully awake. Words and sentences are fuzzy and slippery. She struggles to grasp onto something. With the warmth of Glimmer and being at an unholy hour of the night, she simply could fall back asleep right here and right now. Adora shakes her head, clearing it enough to ask the first thing that pops into her tired mind.

"Is there a reason you never turned? It is only a bite that turns, right?" Adora flicks her eyes up at the sky. With all the lights from the city, almost all the stars are blocked out. The only thing that outshines the artificial lights is the near full moon. She swallows a lump in her throat thinking how a shift is around the corner.

"Yes and no," Glimmer answers. Honestly, Adora is surprised. The question is an odd one and doesn't fully pull away from the topic at hand.

"What do you mean?"

"The bite is the main way werecreatures turn others but it's because of the spit. Whatever the fuck changes you is in the saliva when you turn every full moon. So, ninety-nine percent of the time scratches don't do anything. Whatever got me must have had some on their claws or when I was out cold it drooled on me, which is gross.

"Anyway, it still wasn't enough. It was enough to get me a little sick and give me some powers. But now that my body is used to it, it's not affected by other bites. Does that make sense?"

"Hm...half asleep. Sort of?"

Glimmer chuckles slightly. "Think of it like getting a flu shot. Does that make sense now?"

"Ah! Yeah it does."

Try as she might, a yawn escapes her. Adora buries her face further into Glimmer's soft hair, taking in her flowery scent. Eyes

heavy and it becomes a battle to stay awake. The darkness is winning—she is no match.

"Don't you go falling asleep on me! I don't need all your dead weight on top of me!" Glimmer gives Adora a shake, snapping Adora awake. The blonde snorts.

"Sorry, Glitter-bug...So warm…"

"What the hell did you just call me?" Glimmer twists, looking up. Her eyes are alert and show no signs of sleep. However, there are hints of red around her lilac irises. " *Glitter-bug.* The hell did you come up with that?"

Adora blinks. Honestly, she has no idea where the hell it came from. The word simply slipped from her mouth. The blanket now becomes a *furnace* from the heat she is emitting alone. "S-Sorry. Do you not like it?"

"No! No! I love it! I didn't expect it, s'all. I gotta think of one for you now!"

"In the morning. If you are feeling better, come back to bed. You'll catch a cold out here."

"And you won't?"

"More of a reason to come in. Will you?"

Adora begins to step away. Hands move to lace around Glimmer's finger. The hunter does not protest, letting herself be dragged into the heated hotel room. The radiator rattles and whistles as it continues to pump hot air. Every step closer to the bed, the more Adora feels like she is about to collapse. She is the first to flop onto the mattress. It takes everything in her not to totally pass out. Adora waits until Glimmer lies down beside her before nuzzling up against her and closing her eyes.

"Feeling better?" she asks.

Glimmer snuggles as close as possible to her sleepy girlfriend. “Yeah. A little. Thank you for checking on me.”

“‘Course...I’m here for you, hon…”

Adora’s body is heavy. No matter how hard she tries to move or keep her eyes open, it is all in vain. She can barely feel or sense the surroundings around her. All she can hear is Glimmer’s heartbeat, which only pulls her into sleep even more.

“I love you, Glim.”

“I love you too, ‘Dora.”

Tonight is the moment of truth. The moon slowly crawls its way up through the dark sky, inching to join the stars. Temperatures have dipped almost to freezing with the lack of sunlight. Most likely, there will be frost staining the grass tomorrow morning. But that will have to wait to be found out. There are much more important things right now. Adora feels her stomach twisting into a tight knot, wanting to make her throw up all of her insides. Guess some things don’t ever change.

Adora groans, both from the growing nausea and the rashes forming on her skin. Despite the events of last month, caution mustn’t be thrown into the wind. No need to let herself run loose if she is just going to revert back to a bloodthirsty monster. Glimmer keeps the chains tight around Adora’s body. The usual cocktail of wolfsbane is off to the side, waiting to be used as a last resort.

Adora presses her body hard against the trusted radiator, metal digging into her back and spine. Sweat forming on her brow rolls down her cheek, stopping at her chin before dripping down to her leg.

"Still a bitch, huh?" Glimmer says.

"Sure as hell is." Adora groans.

"Nothing has changed at all?"

Adora shakes her head. As far as she is *aware* , which at the moment isn't very, nothing has changed. The same feeling of sickness, feeling parts of her body gearing up for the change, knowing the wolf inside of her is clawing its way up her throat. Same old same old. Even the jerking of her body has not changed. Not a bit.

"Can I kiss your head?" Glimmer asks.

Adora can only nod, her throat so tight words cannot squeeze out. Glimmer leans forward, gently brushing her lips against Adora's forehead. The blonde sighs at the feeling, body relaxing. Her forehead isn't as off limits as the rest of her face but Glimmer ensuring boundaries is another comfort. Adora does wonder how the hell she survived so long without the hunter.

Just as lips leave, Adora'a body shudders one last time. The only noise that escapes her is high-pitched whine. As the pain erupts through her body, darkness grips her vision. The last colorful thing she sees is the pink and purple of Glimmer's hair.

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At first, the heavy, black darkness is the same. She feels nothing, hears nothing, hell, is unable to sense herself at all. Slowly, however, things come into focus. Albeit, with a blurry filter over it. Everything around her lacks crispness and there is a strange feeling of discontent from her body. Adora *knows* she can control herself, that she can do commands, but at the same time–somehow–it's like she *isn't* in control.

Her body suddenly flops forward. She feels her chin smack against the hardwood. She nearly bites her tongue in the process. Adora mumbles something to herself as she tries pushing herself up. However, she finds herself like a deer on ice. Limbs go every which way. No matter how many times she tries to push herself either on her hands or feet, gravity pulls her straight down.

"What the fuck?" Adora questions.

"A-Adora?"

The only thing Adora can do at the moment is roll onto her back. Feet away from her is her girlfriend. Adora's heart jumps in her chest, almost leaping straight out of her ribcage. If she had a tail, it would be beating so hard against the flooring. Hell, she can *hear* a thumping in her mind from the excitement.

"Glim!" Adora shouts. She twists and turns, flopping back on her belly. Hands and feet scramble to find anchorage. Somehow, she is able to launch herself forward, arms wrapping around the smaller woman, and places a kiss right on her cheek.

"I love you, Glitter-bug!!!" Adora gleefully states. She has no idea what the hell has come over her. Why she feels weird both from the disconnect and the *sheer* jubilation overcoming her. Is this what a kid on Christmas feels like? She still doesn't understand why the world is like she needs some glasses.

Whatever the case, Adora doesn't care. Glimmer is with her. That's what matters the most.

"What the *fuck?!?* "

This is all Glimmer can get out as she stares up at her girlfriend. Adora has a wide, toothy grin plastered on her face and her tongue hangs from the side as she pants. A tail thumps on the ground while vivid, golden eyes stare back at her. There is not a *trace* of red in the irises. Glimmer’s mouth hangs wide open.

“Adora? Are you in there?” Glimmer asks.

Adora only responds with a bark. She gives another lick, slobbering up Glimmer’s cheek even more. The hunter squirms, pushing her girlfriend’s snout away from her face.

“Ew! Gross! I don’t need all your spit on me!”

Adora ignores her. She begins nuzzling Glimmer, sniffing her body all over. Thankfully, something catches the werewolf’s attention. A fall storm causes icy rain to tap rapidly against the glass window. The ears on top Adora’s head perk to attention as she climbs off of her girlfriend. In only a few strides, she is on the other side of the room, staring out through the glass into the dark world.

Glimmer pushes herself up and places her hands on her lap. She cannot pull her eyes away from the sight in front of her. With Adora now free to roam (Glimmer still hopes she isn’t going to turn around and attack) she is able to get a better view of Adora’s brand new look.

She remains large, still twice the size of what Glimmer has seen before in her past. Her body is much more wolf-like. While hands still have long nails that can easily slice through skin, they themselves are smaller. Somewhere between hands and paws with her thumb looking half useless. Her fur no longer takes on an ugly shade of yellow. Actually, it matches her hair color almost to a tee. There is a less menacing aura around her.

Never before has Glimmer seen this. In all her years of growing up in the hunter world, of seeing so many creatures, this is a first. Either the werecreatures she has met are in zero control of their actions or they *are* aware and choose to either cause havoc or not. Does Adora know what the fuck she is doing right now? She sure as shit isn’t trying to kill anyone but clearly has a bunch of sudden energy.

As the wind picks up, whistling as it blows thrown near barren tree branches, Adora’s ears go up once more. She sits back down on the ground, one paw lifted, and throws her head back, letting out a howl. Glimmer slaps her hands over her ears as the noise bounces off the walls. Stupid super hearing.

“Adora!” Glimmer attempts to say over the howl. Her girlfriend doesn’t respond. “ *Adora!* Please stop that!”

This time, the howling ceases. Adora lowers her head, eyes landing back on the hunter. Another bark before she begins barreling towards Glimmer. The hunter has barely enough time to throw her hands up as a shield. “Woah! Woah! Stop!”

Adora skids to a halt. Inches away, she lowers her upper body, butt wagging high in the air and tail wagging like mad. She barks happily, eyes remaining on the hunter.

“D-Do you want to play?” Glimmer asks.

This gets Adora excited. She starts to bounce around, making strange, low pitched noises. As if she is trying to talk but is unable to form words. Slowly, Glimmer stands to her feet, unable to pull her eyes away from her girlfriend. Hands fumble through the air, searching for any signs of the doorknob. The moment she finds it and the door swings open, Adora flies out of the room. She begins to sniff every inch of the large room.

Glimmer digs through her pocket, pulling out her phone. She quickly types in Bow’s number—he picks up after only one ring.

“Everything okay?” he asks.

“No, yeah, everything...everything’s good.”

“That doesn’t sound like it. What’s going on?”

Glimmer takes a moment to look away from Adora. “Well...Adora’s fine. More than that actually it seems! She uh…” She turns back to Adora. In that brief moment of having her back turn, her girlfriend has managed to stick her whole upper body under the couch. Her tail wags happily and Adora continues to make her noises. *Least she is enjoying herself…* “She’s not a bloodthirsty killing machine anymore.”

“What do you mean? Is she in control?”

“No. Well, I don’t think she is? She’s...she’s acting like a husky. That’s the best way I can describe it. She’s under the couch right

now. *Really* hope she isn't stuck."

She hears Bow snort. "That must be a sight to see. Odd though. That's a good sign though, right?"

"I guess so."

"Did you need me to come over? I can see if I can later but I am not sure…"

"No. I think I'll be fine. I just had to tell someone about this. I still can't believe what I'm looking at."

"If you need anything, call."

"Will do. Catch ya later."

Glimmer hangs up, shoving her phone back in her pocket. Adora remains half under the couch. The hunter raises an eyebrow, wondering what the hell is so interesting under there. There'd only be some dust bunnies. Whatever the case, she shouldn't be there all night long. She strolls over to her girlfriend. Adora's tail continues to wag. It smacks against Glimmer's face as she wraps her arm around the werewolf's hips.

"C'mon you!" Glimmer grunts as she slowly but surely drags her girlfriend out from under the couch. The end of Adora's muzzle is covered in dust. A fit of sneezes escapes her. Glimmer cannot help but laugh lightly. Kneeling on the ground to brush off the dust, she realizes Adora is several inches taller than her while she sits on the ground.

"You know you are a dork, right?" Glimmer states. She taps her index finger against Adora's wet, black, nose. "What am I gonna do with you?"

Adora barks loudly before nuzzling her head under Glimmer's chin. The hunter reaches up and begins scratching her fingers at the base of her girlfriend's ear. Adora squints her eyes, letting out an almost purr-like noise from her throat.

“Ya like that, huh?” Glimmer notices the scars on Adora’s face and back are still present, hidden by her fur. Which, the hunter realizes is no longer harsh to the touch. It remains coarse but is much more gentle against her skin. Glimmer makes a note to write all these changes down in her notebook later. With the nights longer now due to the jump back in time, there surely will be many things to write down when she gets the chance.

Glimmer looks around the room, seeing if there is anything to do for the time being. What does one do when your girlfriend is a giant dog? She clicks her tongue in thought. It’s not like she has much for something like this. When eyes land on the nearby closet, she comes up with an idea. The hunter gently pushes Adora away. Her girlfriend whistles through her nose, tilting her head to the side.

“Don’t worry. I just wanna get something.” Glimmer tells her.

The sounds of nails against the floorboard alerts Glimmer that she is being followed. When she reaches the closet and opens it, she begins to rummage around. She hopes what she is searching for is here. Behind her, Glimmer feels the hot breath of Adora against her neck. Hands find a small box which she pries open. Inside is the treasure she seeks.

“I can’t believe I am about to ask this,” Glimmer grabs the tennis ball, bounces it against the ground, and snatches it in mid-air. “You wanna play with this?”

Adora yips, bouncing up and down before spinning around in several circles. This makes Glimmer burst out laughing. She throws the ball as far as she can in the clearest path she can find. Adora scrambles on still unsure paws before chasing after it. Glimmer bites down on her lip, her heart leaping in her chest as she hopes Adora doesn’t break anything. Thankfully, none of this occurs. Instead, as Adora snatches the ball in her mouth, she trips over herself. Head over tail until she smacks her rear end against the back door.

Adora woofs in glee once she comes to a stop, her tail *still* wagging a mile a minute. Glimmer rolls her eyes, glad she has figured out quickly how to keep her girlfriend happy. Still a little weird. If she is being honest, she'd rather have Adora be happy and a big old, dopey dog who can roam freely than an out of control, bloodthirsty beast who has to be tied up and drugged.

Glimmer whistles. Adora's eyes widen before she gets to her feet and *prances* towards the hunter. At least tonight's long night will be fun.

Adora nuzzles up against Glimmer, rubbing her cheek against her girlfriend. Arms are wrapped around the hunter's body, keeping her close. All the while, Glimmer laughs, tears pricking at the edge of her eyes. She attempts to push away the blonde but it is all in vain. Adora continues to adore her girlfriend.

That joyous feeling inside her chest before has spread all throughout her body. All that is on her mind is to be right up against Glimmer and give her all the love she can. Cuddling, giving all the kisses she can, and simply messing around with her by playing catch has all been a blast throughout the night. Now, as the navy blue sky turns into a pinkish color, Adora is more than happy to just be next to Glimmer.

The world remains *off,* the fuzz and blur never has gone away. She continues to feel a lack of control of her body. Even as she has stopped slipping every which way when walking, it continues to feel like someone else is using the steering wheel at the same time. Though, every time her eyes land on Glimmer, all those thoughts go away.

However, this time of enjoyment cannot last.

Adora groans, her stomach twisting tight. All she wants to do is curl up in a ball and do nothing. However, Glimmer starts to guide her back to the lower bedroom. It has been left for her use, in case some nights she wants the legroom in her own bed, and it

continues to be a place for her things. Her own space. The pain continues to grow as she is placed in bed. Before a darkness takes hold of her, Glimmer places a kiss on her head before pulling her old blanket over her body.

Darkness takes over her first before the smell of apple cinnamon does. The blackness turns into dim colors. No shapes, only colors. She picks up on two the most. A faded color of yellow and orange running around. Children's laughter fills the air. Two other shapes, with no true color at all, stand off to the side.

Adora tilts her head, wondering what the hell this is. She looks around, searching for the lights that normally appear when she is in this place. But they are not around at all. Only the sound of children laughing and the blurry colors. After a couple spins (how she doesn't get sick she doesn't know) something does change. A new, grey shape stares back at her. Unlike last time, this has a bit more structure. Not enough to give a definitive form, but she knows it is not a human. Rather, some type of four legged animal.

"You again!" Adora states.

The creature takes a step forward. Adora, somehow in the void of a world, moves back. "Stay back! Who the hell are you!"

" *You."* It repeats again.

"Good to know you are still no help."

" *Don't deny yourself, any of* ***them*** *. They were all you and you were them all."*

"Can you please stop talking in practical riddles!"

It ignores her. " *Learn from them and accept them. Deny parts of yourself—your wants, needs, and hurts—you'll only suffocate."*

With that, it, along with the darkness and other colors, fade away. The next thing Adora knows, she has returned to her room. She groans, rolling onto her side and curling up under her covers. The

lights string her eyes. Despite her internal furnace, she is freezing. That's what happens when you go from having fur all over your body to buckass naked when fall is around the corner. At least the covers do her some good.

"You okay?"

Adora flicks her eyes up, finding Glimmer setting down a cup of water and some food on the nearby table. The blonde opens her mouth but remembers words are useless right now. Trying will hurt her throat. Instead, Adora shivers.

"Cold?"

Adora nods.

"Let me turn the heat up a bit." She disappears for a moment, the thermostat in the living room. In a flash, she returns to the bedside. Glimmer shuffles through her pocket before pulling out her phone and unlocking it. "Here. Tell me if you need anything else."

Adora types away...to the best of her ability with sleepy fingers.

Stau with mw?

"You know the bed is small. It will be tight."

Stay!

She pauses for a moment before typing again.

U dont mind me begin naked?

Glimmer shakes her head. "No. Long as you don't mind. Scoot."

Adora moves over slightly, allowing Glimmer her flop down on the bed. She nestles close. Every muscle in Adora's body relaxes at her girlfriend's presence. Adora swallows a lump before attempting another try with words.

“What...happen?” Adora rubs her throat.

“Do you remember anything?”

“Kind of? ...Feels like a...dream.” Words slowly become easier as she lets them slip out of her mouth. “Real or not real. I kept cuddling you.”

“Real. So you remember that! That settles it, you got more control I believe. Though, you were acting like a giant, dorky dog. I will show you the book later.”

“Dorky dog?” Adora blinks. She has zero recollection of that. In her ‘dreams’ she still was herself, wasn’t she? Guess not. But what about the rest of her dreams?

“Real or not real? We played catch?”

“Half. I found a tennis ball and we played more like *fetch* together. Sorry, I had no idea what to do with a husky in my house.”

Adora chuckles a little. “‘S’okay.”

“You should rest more. And after that take a shower. You stink of musk.”

“You do too.”

“No thanks to you, Ms. Rub her face on me all night long.”

Adora has nothing else to say before nuzzling herself against Glimmer’s chest.

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated!!!!

Pesky Little Sibling

Chapter Notes

> a shorter chapter but...the ending has to be one of my favs cause the next two warning, are gonna be a doozy. Don't really think I need a tw for this one. Enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer waits impatiently for the ring from her laptop. Petra promised to talk to her and others while they are at their own home. More information to be exchanged. The time they agreed on is still minutes away but that does little to settle her nerves. Hell, it makes her whole system fire off like wild. Anticipation is a hell of a drug to be on. Not helping in the matter is being aware of more death.

After a month of silence, a faint sliver of ease, the cold harshness of reality has come crashing back down. Glimmer is only aware of so much, mostly just the fact someone has died. Petra seems to know more. How much? Glimmer will find out soon enough. She simply has to survive the wait.

While doing so, she walks around Mermista's and Sea Hawk's home. Never before has she been in a merperson's house. There is plenty of 'dry' land to walk around on. Though, most of it is high above. Glimmer currently resides on the second floor. Though, instead of being filled with a couple bedrooms or a bathroom, this is a mix of a typical top and bottom floor. She is in a living room like area and a small kitchen is nearby. Just down the hall is a bathroom and two bedrooms, a main and a spare. There even is a door leading to the outside patio and a flight of stairs to the backyard.

Downstairs is a whole other ballpark. There is a small section of floorboard, letting anyone with legs into the building and access to the upper floor. However, after you take a few steps in, there is

nothing but water. There are some strips of dry land to let others walk over the small, indoor sea. From what Glimmer has gathered from her time staring into it, there is another living room, kitchen, and surely bedrooms. The hunter wonders how all those appliances work and don't fry everyone from getting wet. Sea life must have gotten inventive with it.

Adora currently remains downstairs. Glimmer has yet to hear any splashes or Sea Hawk laughing his ass off. That is a good sign. There is no extra clothing if she falls in. If it comes to that, the only option she would have is sitting by a heater.

While waiting, Glimmer walks around the room, taking in the decor. Sea Hawk and Mermista seem to really be into pirates. Paintings of old timing sail boats hang on the walls. There is a black flag in the dining room with a skull and crossbones. Many of the cups have something pirate related on them. Hell, even the table in the living room, the glass sits on a steering ship wheel.

The sound of her laptop ringing catches her attention. She stops at the top of the stairs, shouting for Adora and the others. She hears her girlfriend suddenly yelping—Glimmer assumes she has lost her footing on one of the small strips of land. Thankfully, the sound of a body falling into the water does not fill the air. Rather, she hears feet racing against the floorboard.

As she settles down on the couch, the footsteps get closer. Glimmer takes a moment to look over her shoulder and sees Adora and Sea Hawk racing up the step. Despite being wet from head to toe, the merman has beaten the blonde, much to her dismay. Adora huffs before joining her girlfriend on the couch. Just as Glimmer clicks *accept,* she hears Mermista finishing her trek up the stairs.

The screen is black for a moment before Petra appears. They have their hair tied back in a small ponytail and much like Glimmer, rests on a sofa. Shadows of others in the house dance around in the background. One earbud hangs freely.

“I see you got almost the whole gang here,” Petra states.

“Hell yeah!” Sea Hawk gleefully shouts. “We are here to help out our friends as much as we can! Us sea creatures are always around to give aid and see what we can find out!”

“Sea Hawk! Personal space!” Glimmer shoves the merman’s head away from her own face.

Petra snorts. “Well, the more ears the better. What I was told is troubling.”

The warm room suddenly grows cold. Everyone stares at the laptop, wondering what the dreaded news is. What now has been added to the never ending fire? Glimmer leans forward, shaking hands clutched into tight fists on her lap. Petra grabs her phone for a moment before speaking.

“You guys know who died?”

“No.”

“How much do you know about minotaurs?”

“Tough, smart, love to create their own weapons. I sure as shit wouldn’t want to mess with a pissed off minotaur.” Glimmer’s eyes go wide. “Wait! Don’t tell me!”

Petra gives a small nod. “Whoever attacked the minotaur well, they might be a bit out of commission for a while. Good for us but we will have to see what happens next month. There definitely was a hell of a fight.”

“Did they do, like, what they have been doing. Stopping the turn back?” Mermista asks.

“Hard to say.” Petra leans back against the cushions. “I was told he was found already in his minotaur self. Must have fought like that. However, I wouldn’t be shocked.”

Glimmer begins to half listen, waiting to hear for anything important. She begins scribbling in the pages of her notebook. Never before has she written about a minotaur. Hell, she cannot recall ever meeting one. They tend to be a little reclusive. That makes it even more surprising that one was sought after and killed. Glimmer begins to chew on the end of her pen in thought.

She hopes whatever the hell killed the minotaur is indeed injured. Maybe they can find them more easily. Hiding any injury from something like that would not be easy and definitely takes a lot out of you. And, if they are hurt, maybe there can be another break this upcoming month. Glimmer pinches the bridge of her nose. *Great, more waiting. Did my mom ever know anything?*

"Oh hey!" Glimmer snaps her head up. "Petra! Do you know Latin at all?"

"Latin?" Petra blinks. "No. Why?"

"Ugh. I found a notebook of my mom but she wrote it in it. I never understood it…"

"Sorry. My family uses something different. I can't really help."

"Figured I ask."

Petra turns their attention to Adora. "I meant to ask. How have you've been?"

Adora grins, eager to tell Petra about the progress. Glimmer sits back and lets her girlfriend go off about what has happened the past couple months. The slow control of her shifts, even if everything seems like a dream to the blonde. Being able to roam freely without worry about mauling someone again or worse, to death. And of course, her new relationship with Glimmer.

Out of the corner of her eye, Glimmer sees Sea Hawk beaming from ear to ear. Mermista shoots him a glare before snapping her head away. The hunter knows *exactly* what the whole wordless exchange is about. Everyone in a world within a world seems to

have taken guesses on her and Adora's relationship. Glimmer has given up trying to see who *hasn't* placed a bet or two.

"I am glad to hear that. Congrats you two." Petra replies.

"How do you get full control though? I am still wondering about that."

"Like I said, you have to *want* . But you also have understand it is a part of-"

Before Petra can finish, there is a loud crashing noise in the background. Everyone nearly jumps out of their skin at the sudden sound. Petra spins around, looking at the unknown person. "DAMN IT, DRAKE! I KNOW YOU DID THAT ON PURPOSE!"

There is a howl of laughter in the background before another *crash.* "C'mon, Pet! Lighten up! I am trying to cook!"

"You sure as shit aren't! Go bother Zephyr or Brooke!"

More laughter before it fades away. Petra sighs, rubbing a temple before settling back down on the couch. "Sorry. That was my little brother. He can be quite the pain in the ass. Do you guys have any siblings like this?"

"I am the annoying little brother!" Sea Hawk says a bit too happily.

"Glimmer and I are part of the only child gang." Mermista states.

Glimmer lifts up her hand. Mermista does not miss a beat and gives the hunter a solid high-five. Adora is the only one not to answer, staring down at her feet. Fingers play with each other as she debates what to say. Glimmer gives her a small nudge, snapping her out of the thoughts swirling around in her mind.

"I have a sister but it's complicated." Adora finally states, a finger scratching the pale scars on her face. "Is there anything else to

know about the murders?"

"Other than it happened an hour away from my hometown? No. I might go out with my siblings to see what's up. Least with all four of us that might help. Safety in numbers, right?"

"Well, be safe. We don't need you and your siblings on the list of people who died."

Out of nowhere, a young man appears in front of Petra. He has the same green eyes. His hair, rather than jet black, is a russet color. There is some stubble on his chin. "Don't you worry about us! I will keep my silly, ol' sister out of trouble!"

"DRAKE!"

Drake bolts away, revealing a steaming Petra. The werebear cuts off the feed and. presumingly, goes off to go kill her brother. It is time like these that Glimmer is glad she has no siblings. She has no idea what she would do if she either had a little one annoying the shit out of her or an older one *calling* her annoying—or *both!*

Glimmer shuts her laptop before looking back at her book once more. Another life lost. Another person that no longer will be able to return home. The hunter wonders if the minotaur had a family, a partner, kids, siblings, and friends. Have their loved ones been left with their heart scarred and bleeding and a thousand questions in their head? Her fingernails begin to dig so hard into the paper, they threaten to tear into it.

She refuses to allow this book to be filled with almost nothing but the names of the deceased.

Glimmer snaps her book shut and sets it aside. "Well, I guess that's that." She takes a moment to look around the room. Adora has her gaze back down at the ground, fingers playing with themselves again. Eyes hidden by bangs, Glimmer cannot tell what her girlfriend is thinking.

Sea Hawk, meanwhile, rubs his chin. For all his hyper activeness and lack of impulse control, he has an air of maturity around him. Even he knows when to cut the shit and be serious. Mermista, on the other hand, face is expressionless. Never one to show what she is thinking on the inside. No matter the case, the once warm room has continued to drop in temperature.

“What does everyone think?” Glimmer breaks the silence.

“We definitely should keep our guard up,” Mermista bluntly says. “If that thing can take down a minotaur then who knows what else they can do.”

“Hopefully they did a number on the killer,” Adora adds. She leans back against the couch. Glimmer sees the tiredness in her eyes. Glimmer can feel that. “If they are weak, maybe someone can take them out for good.”

“Hopefully. I really hope this bastard is caught. This nightmare can finally end."

Sea Hawk jumps to his feet. “Well, there isn’t much we can do at the moment. Mermista and I will make sure the seafolk know what’s up without freaking everyone out. No one of our kind has died yet but never can be too careful.”

“We will keep our eyes out for anything weird. Communicating under the water will help, long as the killer doesn’t understand it.” Mermista states.

“Thanks guys,” Glimmer says.

“Anyway, Adora!” Sea Hawk puffs out his chest. “Why don’t you come back down so I can continue showing you the first floor?”

“You aren’t gonna try and drag me under, are you?” Adora raises an eyebrow. “You know I don’t have extra clothes.”

Sea Hawk scoffs. “Don’t worry. Besides, I can give you some spares. And I thought werewolves are supposed to be big, bad,

and tough!" He puts his hands slightly away from his armpits and begins to make clicking noises as he moves about. "What are you? A werechicken?"

This gets the blonde's attention. She stands to her feet. Nearly the same height, the two non-humans stare each other down. Adora jabs a finger at the center of Sea Hawk's chest. "You are on, Fish Boy!"

The two bolt back downstairs, leaving their girlfriends alone in the dry, upper floor.

"How much you wanna bet if Sea Hawk drags Adora in, she is going to find a way to keep him trapped under there?" Mermista asks.

"She'll probably find a way. This will be fun."

November speeds along, almost in a blur. Not much happens to note, barely anything to write down in her notebook. One of the things that suck when you are trying to hunt down a killer werecreature. Activity is low until the moon is full and bright. Such a pain in the ass. Glimmer tries to look on the bright side. Trying to come up with a plan. However, how can one make a plan when you only have table scraps to go off on?

She and the others try to pass even more time and get their minds off of things, no need to keep battering it with bad news. Back out to the heart of Brightmoon Glimmer, Adora, and Bow go today. While the hunter takes the lead, chosen as the person to pick the next place to go. Her girlfriend and best friend stay several strides behind. They whisper to each other, hands covering their moves, and totally out of earshot. Every time Glimmer looks over her shoulder or pauses in her step, the two stop and try to put on their best ' *We aren't doing anything'* face.

No matter how hard she asks the pair what they are doing, neither gives her a straight answer. After a while, Glimmer gives

up, not wanting another beating around the bush response. She lets them go back to their hushed conversation. Right now, she has to figure out where the hell the trio should go next.

Though, just as she begins to narrow down her choices—maybe going to the bowling rink—when fate has different plans.

Out of the corner of her eyes, Glimmer catches movement. Her body reacts before her brain can catch up. Hand shoot out, preventing the head on collision. The hunter stops and is surprised to see who is looking up at her.

“Edgar?”

It’s the elder wyvern brother. If Glimmer recalls correctly, he is no older than ten or eleven in human years.

“Ms. Mizari!” There is worry etched onto his face. “Can you help me?!?”

“Um...Yeah? Where are your mom and dad, though? And where is Alvin?”

“My mom and dad are at work and Al and I had off. So we were playing in the park. And Al isn’t great still at hiding his wyvern form, he needs magic from Ms. Scheimer from time to time. He started to change and ran up a tree to hide! I didn't know what to do, I was gonna go to Ms. Scheimer.

“Can you help?”

“Yeah, of course Ed. Lead the way!”

Edgar nods before running back down the sidewalk. Glimmer takes a quick look over her shoulder. Adora and Bow give her a nod, ready to follow. Not another second is wasted before the trio begin to tail the young wyvern. The park is about a five or so minute walk away. However, with everyone picking up speed, the time is cut in half. Once they reach the park, they slow to a jog. No need to make anyone raise eyebrows at them.

“Over here!” Edgar says. He stops at a tall oak tree, looking up into the branches. Leaves still cling to the tree, allowing for a young non-human to remain hidden from prying eyes. After a couple of moments, Edgar points upward. “He’s in here!”

Glimmer stops at the foot of the tree. At first, she sees nothing but the orange and red leaves that stubbornly refuse to fall. Squinting, she strains her sights to see better. Glimmer is about to give up and as Edgar where on earth his younger brother is when her eyes catch movement. Peaking out of the leaves is a burnt orange muzzle, a perfect shade to blend into the dying leaves. It is quickly followed by large, bright, yellow slitted eyes.

The young wyvern has his wings wrapped tightly around a tree branch and all his claws dig deep into the bark. His tail sits close to his body. “E-Ed?” Alvin whispers.

“I’m here, buddy!” Edgar replies. “I got help! Just hold on.”

“I think I can climb up that.” Adora rolls a shoulder.

“You sure?” Glimmer asks.

“Hm! I would climb trees a lot. Bow, you’re taller. Give me a boost”

The two work together to get the blonde up to the closest, thick tree branch. When her feet find purchase, Adora quickly scrambles up the tree. She does not miss a single step. There isn’t one slip. Adora hops easily around the branches until she reaches Alvin.

“You good up there?” Bow asks.

“Yeah! This is nothing!” Adora replies. “You’re, Al, right?”

“Yes.” Alvin replies.

“I have never met a wyvern before. You’re pretty small. Must be scary up here. But you're being pretty brave right now.”

“T-Thank you.”

Adora pulls herself up onto the branch Alvin clings to. She swings her legs on either side and lets them move back and forth. “I think you are small enough to fit in my hoodie. Think you can squeeze in here? You can stay hidden and we can get you to Perfuma. Whaddaya say?”

Alvin hesitates for a moment. He begins to click, a nervous tick of wyverns. Edgar shifts on his feet at the noise, surely wishing to reach his younger brother. Finally, Alvin nods. Shaking, he crawls forward, slithering under Adora’s hoodie. The blonde hisses slightly before making her way down. Bow helps her down to the ground.

“Al!” Edgar races up to Adora. “Alvin! Are you okay?!?”

Alvin peeks his head out from the collar of Adora’s sweatshirt. “I’m okay, Ed.”

“Let’s get you boys to Perfuma.” Glimmer says.

Thanks to Bow call a head of time, Perfuma has the potion needed ready the moment everyone enters the building. Adora lifts up her hoodie enough for Alvin to crawl his way down to the ground. The young wyvern stretches himself out before spreading his long, leathery wings and flying to a nearby table. The moment he settles down, Perfuma sticks out a bottle with a magenta colored liquid inside.

Alvin gulps it down in a matter of seconds. A hiccup escapes him. Then, in a sudden puff of smoke, he changes into an about eight-years-old looking boy, taking on a similar appearance to Edgar. The older wyvern wastes no time rushing up to his brother and hugging him tight.

“You gotta make sure you start carrying these around with you.” Perfuma hands the brothers a bag full of bottles. “At least until you can fully control staying in your human form, Al.”

“Don’t worry. We will now!” Alvin replies.

“Run along now. Don’t get into trouble.”

The brothers scurry out of the store, the bag of bottles in their hands. Everyone watches them leave, disappearing behind as they pass the windows. Glimmer catches the look on Adora’s face. Soft and happy. How can one not be seeing the reunion of brothers? But there is something else in her eyes.

Sadness? Longing? Melancholy?

“‘Dora, you okay?” Glimmer softly asks. “You handle that really well. Didn’t know you were good with kids.”

“Neither did I,” Adora sighs. “And it’s nothing, don’t worry.”

“Are you sure?”

Adora begins scratching her scars on her chin. “I am.”

The cool night air nips at her skin, trying to convince Adora to return to the warmth. She ignores the world’s wishes, remaining on her back on the rooftop. One arm is used as a pillow while her other drapes over her stomach. A leg sticks out while one is bent upright. Above her, the dark sky is free of clouds and much of the moon faces away. This leaves plenty of room for the stars.

Tiny, pinpricks of light stare back down at her. Worlds millions miles away from earth. Adora reaches her free hand up, outstretching it as far as possible in a feeble attempt to reach them. She wonders if there is life out there and if there is, what they are like. Do they have beings like her, bound to the cycle of the moon? Do they have to deal with mysterious serial killers who very well could’ve killed their partner’s mother? Do they have people wondering where they are from and who they are?

…

She wonders if her birth family is looking up at the same sky wondering the same thing. If they still care for her and seek her out. Or was Shadow Weaver right? Did they abandon her once she was bit? No longer seeing them as her daughter but as a monster?

Fuck, the night is the worse to be awake during.

Adora brings her hand, now a fist, back down, pressing it against her forehead. All these emotions and thoughts begin to flood her mind and swirl around like a whirlpool waiting to take her under. Petra being annoyed by her younger brother and Sea Hawk's smug comment about himself. Seeing Ed and Al together. And the month before even creeps into her mind. Glimmer got to spend time with her father and aunt. Is that what it's like to have such people in her life? After all, how would *she* know?

Why is she thinking about them now? With so much going on, would there be anytime trying to search for her birth family? After all, it has been over twenty years now. Most memories she has are forgotten or blurry, the latter of which she doesn't like to ponder over. They few that she can recall in some semblance, she rather forget completely. No matter how many times she has tried in the past to remember anything else, nothing ever has appeared other than a headache.

And even if it doesn't feel like her skull is being split in two, those blurry images morph into solid figures. However, they are not of her birth family. Rather, they are of her adoptive one. Shadow Weaver raising her up, taking her in and telling Adora about how her parents abandoned her. (She still has no clue if that is the truth or a lie). How for quite some time, it was just the two of them. Moving around, never staying in one place for long, and rarely letting anyone in. How she'd say she loved Adora, yet, her affection only ever came when the young girl acted how Shadow Weaver *wanted* her to.

Catra entering her life, finally having a sibling. For a time, everything was good, peaceful. Might have been a little family but

it was *her* little family. That shattered, however, as time passed. Shadow Weaver became more demanding and Adora saw more through her lies. Catra always twisting the blame onto her, rarely taking responsibility, and the consistent reminders of what lies within them.

Adora bites down on her lip, doing everything in her power to keep the tears escaping. One manages to sneak its way down her cheek, rolling right past her scars. Why did she ever deserve something like that? After all, she was only a *child.*

The night really is a horrible time to be awake during when your brain hates you.

Get your shit together, Adora tells herself.

She takes a deep, shaking inhale. The heels of her hand are used to wipe away the tiny streams rolling down her face. Eyes blink away the pools that have form. As the blur begins to fade away, she catches something in her watery, unfocused vision. The pinprick lights, millions of miles of way, some begin to move. Adora blinks more, wiping her face clean as she sits up.

Nothing.

At least, at first.

Adora stares up at the near blanket of darkness. All the stars remain in place. The only movement comes from the slow, blinking lights from a lone airplane. She thinks that is what she had seen but quickly realizes that what she spotted was faster. Maybe it just was a figment of her imagination. But then, something appears, clear as day.

A shooting star streaks across the sky. The ball of light expands for several seconds before dimming and fading away. Only a thin tail is left behind. But that too fades away. Adora is left to stare up in awe. She can't recall the last time she has seen a shooting star. *'Make a wish '* one would say. But what does one wish for?

Part of her wants to be selfish. Wish that her family would walk right through the front doors. Wish that maybe this curse given to her so many years ago would be lifted. But then, her thoughts turn to Glimmer. What about her? She could use the wish to allow some luck in finding her mother's killer. Or even for her mother to come back. Glimmer deserves to have that peace of mind and no longer lack closure.

But would it really matter? Shadow Weaver shattered that wonder and belief that something so small can have the power to change the world. Though, how far fetched could a wish be when she is bound to the cycle of the moon and so many other creatures exist?

"Tck." Adora pushes herself up, feet finding themselves on slanted paneling. Maybe that is one thing she was right about. How can a measly hunk of space rock change anything that is happening. It's merely a false sense of hope, a security blanket. No one from her family is going to waltz in unannounced. Angella is dead. This serial killer on the loose will not stop simply because of a child's wish.

Adora spins on her heels and carefully climbs up the slope. As quietly as she can, she pushes the window open and slips back into Glimmer's bedroom. Her girlfriend remains sound asleep, snoring, even as the blonde locks her escape to the rooftop. At least she has this. Adora never imagined in her wildest dreams that she'd end up with someone like Glimmer in her life. Honestly, she could watch the hunter sleep forever. Even as she drools in her sleep and continues to snore, Adora cannot pry her eyes away.

Maybe there is a little bit of magic in wishes.

Carefully, Adora tiptoes across the floor. It took her some time to memorize which boards squeak under the slightest ounce of weight. Even so, the moment toes land on one, it's like she has stepped on a noisy trap. The squeak is fairly loud, causing her to suck in air through her teeth. Adora freezes, hoping this did not

disturb her slumbering girlfriend. Thankfully, this seems not to be the case. Glimmer lets out a snort before rolling onto her side, her back now facing Adora.

Sighing a breath of relief, she continues her slow and steady steps towards the bed. When she reaches it, Adora carefully crawls under the covers. She begins to settle in, letting the warmth of the covers and Glimmer herself push away any lingering cold from her body. Just as she lies her head on her pillow and lets her eyelids grow heavy, arms suddenly wrap around her. A gasp cannot be stopped from escaping her mouth as Glimmer buries her face into her chest.

“You’re cold,” the hunter whispers.

"And you're warming me up," Adora replies.

"Why were you outside? You 'kay?"

Adora runs her fingers through Glimmer's soft hair. "I just needed some air, s'all. Just one of those nights, ya know?"

"Talk 'bout it? Need anythin'?"

Adora sighs softly. "No. I don't." She leans forward and places a gentle kiss on top of Glimmer's head. She doesn't move for several seconds. When Adora does, she simply says, "Rest."

Glimmer responds by wrapping her arms even tighter around Adora and burying her face deeper.

"What are you doing, hon?" Adora asks. Not that she is complaining.

"I'll absorb some negative energy from you. No escape."

Adora can't help but laugh. "Thank you. Now go back to bed."

The next thing she hears is the return of Glimmer's snoring. Sleep took no time at all to drag her back under its depths. A little smile

forms on Adora's face as she nestles closer to her girlfriend. She had no clue if she'll find peace in slumber tonight. But, at least, she has one thing for comfort her until the morning sun.

“She isn’t listening, is she?” Bow whispers.

Adora takes the chance to look over her shoulder. Sitting on the sofa , she cranes her neck to spot her girlfriend. Glimmer sits outside on the back deck. With the weather somewhat nice, the back door is open, letting the late, albeit cold, fall air flow freely. The hunter has much of her gear spread out across the wood, some in pieces. Hands fiddle with something Adora has no clue about. It’ll be a little bit before she is done making sure everything is in order.

“Don’t think so.” Adora settles herself back onto the couch. “Should still keep our voices low.”

“Right.”

He slaps down the paper in his hands, unfolding it from its fours. Scribbled in blue ink is a list of ideas the pair has for Glimmer’s upcoming birthday. December is *right* around the corner. The hunter’s birthday shall bring in the last month of the year. With everything going on, Glimmer deserves something a little nice. Adora and Bow want to ensure this remains a secret.

They have been debating on what exactly to do. Should they do something small and simple? Just get her a nice gift, something she has been dying to get her hands on? Bow has managed to nab a hunter magazine full of deals for equipment, accessories, books, or potions. Honestly, there is so much more but neither he nor Adora could finish before trying to think what else they could do.

They always could do something grand. Give her a party and invite others along. According to Bow, however, Glimmer isn’t big on grand gestures. She wouldn’t necessarily hate it, knowing that

it was something out of the bottom of her friends' hearts. But would it be worth it if they are not her thing? After all, this is *Glimmer's* birthday. It should involve something she'd enjoy.

So, the two ponder over what on earth to do. Time is short and running out. Adora and Bow whisper under their breath as they plot. Back and forth they go, coming up with ideas to scribble down or scraping others also immediately. Every now and again, one of them looks over their shoulder to see if Glimmer is listening in. So far, so good.

Adora begins to chew on the back of her pen. For every thing they scribble out, more things pop up. So much for narrowing down their choices. At this rate, they'll never have anything ready in time for Glimmer's birthday. Bow too feels her frustrations. Head in hands, leg bouncing, he stares down the paper. How hard can it be to figure out what to do for someone's birthday?

There is a sudden rap on the door. Adora and Bow exchange looks, each equally as baffled. When the knocking continues, the blonde turns her attention towards the outside world. Glimmer is leaning back, looking through the door with a quizzical expression on her face.

"Guess you're not expecting anyone?" Adora asks.

Glimmer gives a small shake of the head. "Not really. But could be a non-human looking for help. Do one of you mind getting it for me?"

"Sure!"

Adora hops off the couch before Bow can react. She begins to stroll over towards the door. Whoever is behind it sure is *insistent.* They do not let up on the knocking. Hell, the sounds have become louder and more paid. "I'm coming! I'm coming! Hold your Kelpies!" Adora shouts.

Fingers wrap around the brass colored door knob, pushing it downward and opening the door. "Hello, how can I he-" she starts

but is quickly cut off, word lodged in her throat.

The being standing before her is slender. Only an inch difference separates them in height with Adora squeaking out at top. Dark brown hair is tied back in a high ponytail, giving some order to its natural wildness. Eyes, one amber and one cyan, stare back at her with twinkles glowing inside them, and a wide smile runs from ear to ear. A black, leather jacket covers her red shirt and the ends of her dark pants hide in laced up boots–her allergy to shoes having gone away in the late fall weather.

Adora's heart ceases to beat and her breath becomes non-existent. The cold air that blows in is warm to her, nowhere able to compete with the icy chill running down her spine. The woman opens her mouth—sending boiling, red hot anger through Adora's body as she says;

“Hey, Adora.”

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated!

Ghost of the Past Part I: Sis & Mom

Chapter Notes

did I post early? yes because I am excited for these two lmao. So enjoy a little treat. Note, tho, the tw here. Tw for blood/injury, esp with children, manipulation/possible gaslighting, parental abuse (mostly mental) and neglect. I might have OVER tagged but i rather do that and remove tags later than under tag and have someone get triggered

anyway still enjoy!!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Nothing bad can ever happen when we are together, Catra. Sisters forever? Promise?"

"I promise, Adora."

The edges of her sights are red. Her fist aches, pain radiating up into her lower forearm. Adora didn't hear the breaking of bones but she wouldn't be shocked if such an event occurred. After all, Catra is now sprawled out on her back, like a starfish, against the front deck. A harsh hiss escapes her younger sister as a hand cups her injured cheek.

"What the *hell* was that for!" Catra growls as she snaps up.

"You know *exactly* what that was for!" Adora spats back. She takes a step forward, her body fully out of the house. "What the actual fuck are you doing here?!?"

"This sure is a hell of a 'welcome' towards your sister."

Adora's hands ball up tightly, knuckles turning white. "I am going to ask you one more time before my other fist says ' *hello* ' to you. Why. The. *FUCK!* Are you here!!!"

Her mind begins to swirl. Flashes of images—no, *memories* — assault her brain. Catra and her whispering secrets to each other. Catra lashing out at her whenever they were caught...Catra and her planning out their future together. Catra refusing to own up to any of her actions...Catra coming into her life for the first time. Catra hovering over her, the full moon in the background, Adora's blood on her hands.

An inhuman growl crawls up Adora's throat.

"Hey, hey, hey! What the hell is going on out here?!?" Bow voice enters the front deck. There's the sound of two pairs of footsteps. "Adora?!?"

Adora ignores him. She takes more steps forward, almost hovering over Catra now. The only noise she can hear is her heart *pounding* in her ears. A wound on her heart, one she has desperately tried to patch up and hide away, has now been ripped wide open. Nothing can stop the flow of red, hot blood flowing freely.

Glimmer is suddenly in her peripheral, giving Adora pause. Bow appears slightly in front of Catra, who stares up at everyone with wide eyes.

"Adora, love, what is going on?" Glimmer asks. Soft hands wrap around her fist. Thumbs gently rub against her skin. Slowly, fingers unfurl. The hunter does not stop the gesture as she continues to speak. "Who is this?"

Adora lets a harsh hiss of air leave through gritted teeth. "My sister."

Glimmer's eyes grow large. "What?!?" She snaps her head towards the still fallen werepanther. " *You're* Catra?!?"

"Oh? So I am famous around these parts!" Catra hums. "Good to know I am still being talked about!"

“Why you little-” Adora starts. She attempts to take a step forward but is stopped by Glimmer, who still has her fingers wrapped around the blonde’s hand.

“Your sister?” Bow asks. He shakes his head. “Okay, okay. We should go inside. We can talk inside and figure out what is going on.”

“Tck. Don’t help her up. And don’t expect me to go nice on her.”

Adora spins on her heels, not bothering to look at her fallen sister. She pulls her hand out of her girlfriend’s. Steps are heavy as she reenters the living room. Adora refuses to sit on any of the furniture. Instead, she paces behind the couch, keeping her eyes on Catra. Her younger sister slinks behind Glimmer and Bow, rubbing a reddening cheek. Everyone else settles either on the couch or on a single seater sofa.

Silence. The air becomes so thick with tension, you could easily cut it with a knife. Adora continues her pacing, already almost creating a rut in the hardwood. Catra has joined in on the stare down. Dual colored eyes watch the blonde every movement. The werepanther’s face is hard to read, making Adora wonder what on earth she is thinking. At one point in their lives, the two sisters *could* read one another's minds. All it took was a look for them to understand what the other was thinking and feeling. Now, there is nothing.

Adora does wonder what is going on through her sister’s mind. It’s been about half a decade since their last encounter. The one that left Adora with the lasting scars on her face and back. Staring at her sister now, she can feel them stinging just as much as that fateful night.

Bow finally breaks the silence. “So, you are Adora’s sister?”

“Yes. Name’s Catra Britt.”

“You are going by ‘Britt’ now?” Adora asks. “What the hell happened between you and Mom?

“Same thing that happened between you and her. I left that old hag a while back. Like hell I was gonna keep her name or go back to my birth family’s. I made up my own. Are you still going by ‘*Weaver’* or what?”

“I abandoned that name a long time ago.”

“How did you find this place?” Glimmer cuts in.

Catra shifts. Adora failed to notice the bag resting on her shoulders beforehand. The moment it is set down on the small table, her heart stops in her chest.

“That’s my bag!” Adora scrambles around the couch and snatches her long lost possession in her hands. She opens it up. Somehow, almost everything she lost back in the summer is here. Her clothing, her phone (long since dead), and her money. The only thing missing is some food, which is the least of her worries. She snaps her attention back on Catra. “Where the hell did you get this?!?”

“In the forest. I stumbled on it by mistake and realized it was yours. That’s how I found you.” Catra taps the tip of her nose.

“You *tracked* me?!?” Adora feels her blood begin to boil even more. She sets her bag back down before inching closer to Catra. The last thing she needed to know was that her sister essentially followed her to Brightmoon. “Why the hell did you track me down?!?”

“Well I couldn’t just call you, could I?” Catra replies.

“You don’t know how hard I am resisting the urge to pummel you! Give me one good reason why you tracked me down and showed up here unannounced!”

Adora’s words are slowly turning into growls. The longer she stares at Catra the more her anger grows inside her chest. The more she wants to let everything inside of her out and let her sister know *exactly* the torment she has put her through.

Catra slowly rises to her feet, coming inches away and face to face with Adora. Neither break eye contact as the werepanther jabs a finger on the center of her sister's chest. "Because I was traveling around and heard a blonde idiot and a dumbass hunter were sticking their noses into places they probably shouldn't."

"Yeah? And what of it?" Adora glowers. "You wouldn't have anything to do with that?"

"You lot have been trying to figure out who the killer is and I just happen to know who it is."

"You *what?!?"* Adora, Glimmer, and Bow are all taken aback by this revelation. It causes the blonde herself to take a step back. She hears Glimmer standing up off the couch—the hunter is quickly at her side.

"What the hell do you mean you know who it is?" Glimmer asks. Her body has become tense. Even with both women now ready to go after her, Catra refuses to back down. The werepanther ignores Glimmer, only taking a moment to glance her way, before locking eyes right back at her sister.

"You know who it is, Adora."

Adora's throat tightens, becoming like a chewed up straw. The icy feeling returns, flowing right through her veins. "No," she starts. She doesn't need this. Catra's sudden return into her life like a curve ball is already more than enough to handle. Adora would do anything to shove her sister right back out the door and never see her again. Now, the other person she never wanted to see again, the one who beats out Catra, quite possibly has been thrown back into her life.

"You are lying!" Adora growls.

"You know I am not. It's her. It's Mom."

"Wait, what? It's your mother?" Glimmer looks back and forth between the two.

“How do you know it’s her?” Adora presses.

Now Catra’s demeanor has changed. Shoulders lower and there is a change in her eyes. That fire of stubbornness, refusal to back down, has turned into hesitancy. She bites down on her lower life, looking like a child who doesn’t want to admit to something.

Something *wrong.*

“Catra. How do you know?” Adora asks again. “What did you do?”

The werepanther takes a look around the room. “I will tell you everything if you promise me one thing. Immunity.”

“Immunity? This isn’t a court, Catra.”

“It’s the only way I will talk!” she crosses her arms against her chest. “Promise not to kill me and I can tell you all you need to know. Why Mom is doing this and how she is. And,” Catra looks over Glimmer, “who she killed.”

Glimmer goes still besides Adora. Eyes have fallen to the ground and her own hands turn into fist. Adora’s mind swirls more than ever now. So much information is being thrown at her there is no time to take anything in before something else slaps her right in the face. The possibility of her own mother being the reason Glimmer is without one makes her sick to her core. Her own shaking hands curl, fingers digging into her palms.

“You have to tell me, us, before we decide.” Adora can no longer look at her sister. The anger inside of her threatens to spill clean out of her, like a pot left unattended on the stove. “How do you know it’s her? How do you know the things she did and the people she killed?”

Catra doesn’t answer right away. Adora hears the squeaking of floorboards under shifting weight. Her patience is wearing thin. The blonde is about to open her mouth, when her sister finally gives an answer.

"I know because I was there with her."

Adora tastes blood.

It's the growl, far from human, that snaps Glimmer out of her rising thoughts of her mother's death. It's possibly the only thing that could stop the flood of anger from wreaking havoc on her mind and body. Slowly, she looks up, eyes landing on her girlfriend. The sight that greets her is one straight out of her nightmares.

A thin line of blood drips from the corner of Adora's mouth, right where a growing fang pierces her lip. A ring of a bright, fiery red wraps around her constricted pupil, threatening to push out the sky blue shade with its tendrils. A quick glance down reveals even more blood, thicker in consistency, seeping through the cracks between her fingers.

"Adora!" Glimmer gasps. Both Catra and Bow have recognized what is playing out in front of them and have taken several steps back. Glimmer's hand shoots out in front of her, once more grasping her girlfriend's wrist. Memories of others losing themselves before the full moon fill her mind. Her mother telling her to stay behind her as the werecreatures lose themselves in a blind rage. How many stories was she told of people accidentally maiming or killing their loved ones in their anger? Too many.

"Adora! *Love!"* Glimmer almost pleads.

This gets through to Adora. Enough that Adora's changing eyes shift towards her own. A soft light of recognition forms, beginning to push out the shades of red. She says nothing, however. She pulls her hand out of Glimmer's and unfurls her fingers as she brings them to her face. Under a coat of crimson, nails are almost black in color. Blood pools in her palms and Adora lets out a shaky gasp.

"Adora," Glimmer says softly, "are you okay? Are you there?"

No answer. Only the locking of eyes. The red rim has dimmed but remains wrapped around her pupils. While the flame of anger still burns, fear and confusion mixes in. Adora looks at her younger sister, narrowing her eyes and letting a small growl escape her throat, before storming out of the house. She disappears into the backyard.

"Still has no control, huh? Some things never change," Catra says.

Now it's Glimmer's turn to growl. She spins on her heels, arms quickly reaching out for Catra's shirt. The hunter pulls her close, caring little for the fact Catra has the advantage of height.

This is one of the people who has given Adora so much grief, who made her life miserable. She only has been told slivers of information about her girlfriend's past, about her family, but she doesn't need much. Not after seeing the look on Adora's face a moment ago.

"You are lucky Adora needs me right now or I would be giving you another sock to the face! If what you are implying is true, you better have a damn good reason to show up here knowing who my mother is."

"Trust me, Shorty, I wouldn't be risking getting torn a new one if I didn't."

"You're lucky we might need you." Glimmer glares at Catra, fighting every urge in her body to clock her. Looking into her dual colored eyes, she finds something eerily familiar. But there isn't time to put two and two together. Adora needs her.

She lets the werepanther go. "Bow, can you keep an eye on her?"

"Don't worry. I got it," Bow replies.

Glimmer gives Catra one last look before racing outside. Adora is nowhere in sight. She steps to the end of the back deck, seeking any signs for her girlfriend. A cold wind blows, cutting easily

through her clothing. Glimmer shivers but refuses to take a step back. Eyes continue to sweep the whole area, praying for something to locate Adora. The Whispering Woods will be near impossible to search for. Thankfully, if you want to call it that, she notices specs of blood. Some pinprick-like, some like large splattered blobs.

It all forms a straight line into the woods.

"Oh, 'Dora…" Glimmer sighs.

Not knowing what she will find, Glimmer snatches two things from her pile on the porch. A small kit of medical supplies, only having a single roll of bandages and a tiny bottle of spray, and her taser. Hopefully she won't need that latter (or anything more). She shoves the weapon in her hoodie pocket, clutches the kit in her hand before heading out into the forest.

With only socks protecting the soles of her feet, Glimmer feels every twig, rock, and dried up leaves pricking at her skin. She bites back the hiss of pain scratching at the back of her throat. Eyes remain locked onto the ground, searching for any hints of red in the sea of dull browns. There are moments where she must squint and lean forward to spot the tiny specs. Glimmer begins worrying. The blood trail continues on for several yards. Even a human with their comparatively slower healing response should not have left something this far into the woods. She presses on, determined to locate her girlfriend.

A harsh noise catches her attention. Glimmer stops in her tracks, snapping her head around. Did she just imagine that? The Whisper Woods can easily play tricks on someone. She closes her eyes, focusing all of her energy into her hearing. The sounds of bird songs, leafs dancing in the wind, and nearby brook all fade into static. The world is nothing but herself.

She hears it again. The sound of unsteady breathing—the some of someone desperately trying to gain control of their lungs—fills her ears. It comes from her right side. Glimmer snaps her eyes open

and looks towards that area. Behind a large, red oak tree, she spots the tip of a foot covered in a sock. Hints of red dot the ground, leading right to the person hidden.

Glimmer slowly makes her way towards the tree. Adora soon appears in her line of sight. Her girlfriend is pressed up against the hard bark of the tree. Legs are pulled all the way up to her chest with her arms draped on her kneecaps. Bleeding hands are fist and half her face is buried into her closed up body, eyes staring out in the distance. Only when Glimmer kneels down beside her does the blonde turn her head.

Pure blue, the color of a clear spring sky, stares back at her. Not a single hint of red anywhere.

“Hey,” Glimmer softly says. “Feeling okay?”

Adora says nothing. She simply places her chin on her arms. The wound on her lip remains fresh. Glimmer pulls her sleeve past her hand. “Can I wipe off your chin?”

“Hm.” is all she gets for an answer.

Glimmer slowly reaches forward, using the hem of her sleeve to wipe the blood off Adora’s face. It’s all she can do for that injury. Eyes flick to her girlfriend's hands. She reaches out for them, stopping for a moment when fingers wrap around Adora’s wrist. When there aren’t any signs of protest, Glimmer pulls one towards her.

The bleeding has slowed but the four puncture wounds are covered in a sheet of blood. Far too much for Glimmer to use her sleeve. With a free hand, she digs around the kit, searching for anything to clean up all the blood. In the end, she rips up some of the bandages to use as a wipe. Once clean, she sprays it down, just in case. Adora winces slightly at the sting, which Glimmer mutters an apology for.

When one hand is wrapped up, Glimmer quickly works on the other. In no time at all, both are covered. The white bandages are

already turning red. At least, for now, it is *something.*

Adora mumbles a 'thank you' before pulling her arms back towards her body. Glimmer says nothing else and settles down right besides her girlfriend. Adora lets her head flop to the side, resting against the hunter's shoulder. Glimmer rests her own against Adora's. They let the sounds of nature fill the air.

Birds continue to sing their songs, some almost as if they are doing a duet. More leaves dance around as the wind blows through the branches. Glimmer watches a fat chipmunk scurry across the forest floor, it's cheeks puffed out. It pauses in its tracks, turning to look at the quiet pair sitting under the tree. Beady, black eyes blink before it scampers off.

High above, the sun begins to make its descent into the sky. There still are a couple hours before it reaches the horizon and the moon and stars take over the world. For now, fluffy white clouds, like that of cotton balls, float freely through the sky.

"You know, I might still have some of those healing potions I got back in the summer," Glimmer starts. "Can help with your hands. They taste good also."

"What flavor are they?" Adora asks, her voice no louder than a whisper.

"Strawberry."

She hears Adora chuckle lightly. "Of course *you'd* say that flavor tastes good. But maybe, yeah."

"Good...You know we have to go back."

"I know…"

"I don't want to go either. Everything Catra has said, that it's your adoptive mother doing this, that she was with her, the way she implied that...t-that my mother was killed by her...God this is all so much!"

“I know. I don’t like any of it either. I *hate* that she has come waltzing back into my life. I thought I was done with her...I don’t want her here but…”

“She might be of help?" Glimmer finishes.

Adora growls under her breath. This time, it sounds much more human in nature. “She’s our only lead. Fuck, why does it *have* to be *her!”*

Adora’s body goes tense. Glimmer feels the same way. Her own body becomes rigid. What the hell does she make of Catra? Did she have a hand in murdering Angella. If so, this taser isn’t going to cut it for revenge. But what about Adora’s adoptive mother? That is a whole other can of worms. Either way, her own anger is coursing through her body. The only thing that keeps her grounded to the world is Adora. If she lets go of this tether, if she lets go of her focus on her girlfriend's plight, she has no idea what she’ll do.

This might be the closest she will be to finally ending this nightmare of two years but is a whole new terror of its own.

Glimmer grips Adora’s arm, words bitter as they come out of her mouth. “We have to see what she says. The enemy of my enemy is my friend."

Another growl. Glimmer slowly raises to her feet, sticking out her hand. Adora takes a moment before reaching out. Fingers lock together and she is brought to her feet.

“I am not ready.” Adora states.

“Neither am I. Together?”

“Together.”

Her hands *ache.* One has the added bonus of finger stinging. Adora wonders just how fast everything has happened. Only a few minutes? Longer? Wasn't she *just* planning out things to do for Glimmer's birthday? That feels like years ago, a distant memory. Every step she takes is agonizing. She has no choice but to walk straight into a nightmare she has always tried to put behind her. Why can't the past stay where it belongs? In the past?!?

Adora stops when the steps are a measly few feet away. Glimmer pauses at the top, looking down at her with worried eyes. There is no use in waiting, in prolonging the pain. Rip the bandage off now. Not like she hasn't been forced to do that a hundred times by now. With a deep inhale, she places a foot against a creaking board.

Back inside, Catra has planted herself back down on the chair. Her head is in a hand while the other drums fingers against the armrest. Bow stands nearby, eyes shifting only for a moment before returning to the werepanther. Glimmer settles on the couch, Adora taking the seat right besides her.

"Finally cooled off?" Catra asks.

"Don't start." Adora quickly snaps. "I don't want to hear any of your bullshit right now." She takes a breath, recomposing herself. Adora looks at Bow. "I know Glimmer said she's willing to hear you out since you are our only lead. What about you? What do you think?"

"If it means stopping the murders, agreed. But you two are the most affected by this. Whatever you guys do, I will be behind you."

Adora holds her arms. Nails dig into fabric and skin but do not pose a threat to break anything. She looks at her sister. "We won't kill you or anything, you can have your damn immunity. But that doesn't mean we will be nice to you."

“I think I got that message already loud and clear.” Catra huffs. “What do you want to know?”

“Everything. Spill. How do you know it’s Mom? Why is she doing this? Who did she kill? Tell!”

Catra leans back in the chair. “You know what Mom was like. Hated humans and anyone who sympathized with them. Your stereotypical werecreature. Humans and others wrong her so she wanted payback. *So* was pissed when you left. She kept going on about how her plans were ruined since she didn’t have you and your strength anymore.”

“Screw her. I never wanted anything to do with her or her twisted thoughts on the world.”

“Anyway, she still started up with her plans. Started with attacking anyone who didn’t listen to her before slowly killing them, especially those that got in her way. She started to learn something after killing others. Though, I think Mom always had a hunch.”

“What would that be?” Glimmer inquires.

“Non-humans all have something that makes us different from humans, right? Our shifts, magic, whatever. Mom always wanted to be powerful and control things. She learned after enough kills, she could essentially ‘steal’ whoever’s dead powers.”

“Wait, wait, wait! Hold up!” Adora pinches the bridge of her nose for a moment. “What the hell does that mean? Is that why some victims never turned back after they died? *How?!?”*

“Why do we shift? Why do half man, half fish exist? I don’t know, it just is! But yes, exactly. Each time she kills someone, she somehow takes that power and becomes stronger.”

“Which makes her much more dangerous,” Bow adds.

Catra slowly turns her attention to Glimmer. For a moment, Adora swears she sees a hint of sadness in them. "You're Angella Mizari's kid, right? You look like her."

"Yes. What do you know?" Glimmer asks, a coldness to her voice.

"I didn't kill her. But...my mother did. I...I was there."

Adora can sense the anger seeping off of Glimmer. She sees why now Catra wanted immunity. No one talks, allowing Catra to hesitantly continue.

"I...Might have helped track Angella down. She was getting her nose in places that she shouldn't have and Mom was pissed. But, during the fight, I don't know what Angella did, but she wounded my mother before dying. I brought her back and she was...weaker than before. Both in her werewolf form and human, like everything she did before was all for not.

"I had always thought about leaving, getting away. So after a couple months, I did. I can tell you all that if you want."

"No one cares, Catra." Adora snaps. "Get back on topic."

The werepanther scoffs. "Well, there isn't much else to say. I heard about the murders starting up and knew who it was. Guess she recovered. Found your bag and started to look for you."

"Why me? Why no one else?"

For the first time, Catra cannot make eye contact with anyone. "You can say I did some soul searching, learned how much of a shit I had been. So once I heard about this and found your bag and then heard you were looking into it...I had to find you. Try and...make up for everything. Or at least, try to do some good."

Adora is taken aback by this. The grip on her arms loosens every so slightly. She cannot figure out if this is a lie or not. Catra doesn't let her dwell on it much.

“You also know her the best after all. You’d have an idea how to handle her better than me.”

“Son of a bitch,” Adora grumbles. She leans forward, head in her hands. How she wishes this nightmare would end. That she will wake up at the start of the day once more. The biggest thing she would have to worry about is having Glimmer finding out about her and Bow’s secret.

A hand rubs against her back. “Adora? Are you okay?” Glimmer asks.

“This is all way too much,” Adora mumbles into her hands.

“You don’t have to say or do anything you don’t want to,” Bow says.

“No,” Adora lifts herself back up. She takes a deep breath, holding inside her chest for several moments, before exhaling. “Catra has a point. She did pretty much raise me all my life. If we are going to defeat her at all, you guys should know who she is. Getting the best idea means...starting from the beginning. Least, what I can remember."

“Starting from the beginning?” Glimmer repeats.

“Yes. The night I was bit.”

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20 Years Ago

Her breath crystalizes in front of her. The fresh blanket of snow becomes distrubed by her footfall, the crunch filling the air. High above her, the bright, pale full moon watches over her chase. Why and what is she running after? Adora can’t recall why. All she knows is that it is important. All the young child can see around her is the path in front of her. Barren trees are black with no defined details, only outlines.

She comes to a halt, her head snapping around in her search to find whatever it is she is looking for. Adora doesn't find what she is searching for Instead, a low, guttural growl enters her ears. The young child freezes, her temperature matching that of the mid-January air. Adora spins around, finding a large, shadowy figure staring back at her. If she wants to scream, the noise has become non-existent.

A large, toothy grin creeps along their face. Adora has no time to react before a great force pins her to the cold, snow covered ground. A ***hot, fiery*** *pain, like nothing she has ever felt before in her young life, erupts from her right shoulder; It spreads throughout her whole body. The scream that has been trapped in her the moment she saw them burst free from her lungs.*

She kicks and punches the creature, trying to throw it off her. However, a small child like her is no match for something three times her size and even more than that body weight wise. For the first time, at only ***just*** *five-years-old, Adora thinks she is going to die.*

But as quickly as it started, it is gone. The weight is lifted off her chest and her back no longer is freezing. Something warm cradles her. A blank face — just like the trees that continue to stare down at her — is the new figure. A soft feminie voice speaks but it's like static. The only thing she can make out is 'I got you, Adora.'

The blood that flows from her wound is warm, thick, and sticky. Adora feels her jacket become plastered to her skin. She begins to shiver despite being close to someone so warm.

A house comes into focus, it's lights pouring out. Two blurry figures stand nearby, getting closer and closer.

What a way to celebrate her birthday…

Adora presses her ear to her door. The soft February light fills her room in a yellow glow as she listens in to her Mommy and Papa.

While their voices are muffled as they talk under their breath, Adora finds herself able to easily pick up words clearly every now and again. The thick wood of her door no longer prevents noises from seeping into her room.

“What do we do?” her Mommy asks.

“...don’t know...can’t believe this...There isn’t anything else to explain what happened the other night.” her Papa replies.

“That animal...full moon. A werewolf...a monster.”

“A monster...That isn’t our daughter. Our daughter...”

“What do we do? We can’t...be ***killed!*** *forget about...her."*

"I know. There has to be someone...take...her…

"...give up hope... "

She stands by a large, faceless being. March remains cold, winter refusing to loosen its grasp and make way from spring. Adora rubs her eyes, wondering why she has been pulled out of bed this early. The sun is barely up! No matter how hard she tries, the blur will not leave her vision.

Only the woman clad in red is crisp.

She is tall and slender. Jet black hair flows down her back. Scars are all over her face, irregular and jagged. Behind her bangs, eyes as bright as neon green lights stare back at her. Adora finds herself unable to take her own eyes from them.

There is a shove, forcing Adora forward. The young girl looks up. Even with no face and the blur around the world, Adora knows who stands behind her. Her Papa.

"Hello, Deary," the woman says. She kneels down and places cold fingers around Adora's chin.

"Who are you?" Adora squeaks out.

"Beatrix Weaver. I am here to help you. I am going to take good care of you."

A smile forms on the woman's face. One that lacks warmth. Adora doesn't like it, not one bit. She turns to look back at her father but with no details on him, she cannot tell what he is thinking. He only gives one more nudge.

"Let's go," Ms. Weaver says. "Everything will be okay now."

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17 Years Ago

Adora sighs, flicking the pencil on her desk. It rolls several inches, pauses, before rolling back down to her fingertips. The sheet of paper given to her by her mother remains half finished. The older woman will be home soon and won't be pleased to see her daughter hasn't finished her homework.

Adora turns her head to her open window. The cicadas are quite loud today, screeching like there is no tomorrow. With the glass wide open, the humidity of the day fills her room. Only occasionally a breeze breaks the stove-like temperature. Closing her window is no better. How she wishes her mom would invest in an AC.

She decides on getting up. Adora pushes the chair she's on away from her desk, passes her bed with her golden blanket spread out on top, and makes her way to the open window. Her mother does not like her lingering around openings for everyone to see but it won't be the end of the world. There are far 'worse' things Adora could do to piss off her mother. Such as getting to know the neighbours, what little they have.

Her mom always says it's to keep Adora safe. With what happens to her every month, it is best to stay away from humans. If they ever were to find out about what she is, that deep inside of her is

a bloodthirsty beast, they would not take kindly. All the story books Adora has been read to or read herself always has the same ending for a werecreature like her. Yet, she still wonders what others are like. They can't all be bad? After all, her mother does talk to them when they are out and is good at not letting anyone know anything.

Some people walk down her lonely street, a family no less. Two fathers with one older child, a girl her age by the looks of it, and a toddler in the stroller they push. Adora wonders what they are doing. Are they heading to the town's swimming pool? She always wanted to go there. Maybe they actually like this weather and are simply out for a stroll. The young girl rests her arms and chin against the small window still.

She wishes her mother and her could things like this. Her mother will give her all the praise (so long as she isn't doing something stupid) and push her to be the best. She taught her almost everything she knows and knows the food Adora loves and hates and even lets her have a lot of free reign with the TV. Yet, little things like walking or going out to the movie theater, Adora can't remember anything like that. She has a feeling asking would only lead to a 'no' or a brushing off.

The family disappears around a corner. Adora sighs before slinking away towards her desk. Her hands cup her face as she looks down at the paper. Inky numbers become nothing but black blotches. Adora groans. Stupid math.

She wishes she had something else to do. Someone else to be with and help occupy the time when mother is away. Boredom is a great incentive to sneak out, to find any of the neighbour kids no matter how far they may be, and be with them. Just someone to play with so the time does not drag on for hours and hours. Just someone so she is not so alone.

She hears her long before she'll arrive. Adora has learned the distinct sound her mother's car makes, one of the brakes squeaking every so slightly. Once more, she is on her feet. Who

cares if she hasn't finished her homework. Hasn't her TV shows told her normally kids don't have to deal with school during this month? Adora throws open her door and races down her stairs. By the time she is at the bottom of the stairs, the front door opens. Adora stops a couple feet away from the entrance.

Her mother, Shadow Weaver, enters the building. Her first name isn't actually 'Shadow'. She just likes to be called that, the whole name, for whatever reason. Though, of course, Adora does not call her this in the slightest. Only 'Mom' or 'Mother' will do. In her arms are a bag of groceries. With only the two of them, they don't need much.

"How was your trip, Mom?" Adora asks. She rocks on her heels. "Do you need help with the groceries?"

"Did you finish your homework?" her mother asks bluntly.

"I-um, n-no," Adora looks down at the ground. "I'm sorry, Mom. I was doing it! I got distracted."

"But what, if I may ask?" Her mother begins to walk into the kitchen. Adora trails right behind her.

"Alotta things. But I saw a family walkin' by. They seemed nice."

Her mother pauses in her unpacking, allowing enough time for Adora to realize her mistake. "You stayed in your room, correct?"

"Yes, Mother…" Adora groans.

"Don't whine, my dear." Her mother turns around, kneeling on the ground. She tucks a loose strain of hair behind her daughter's ear. Cold fingers brush against Adora's cheeks. "You know I do it for your protection."

"But they seemed nice! And I hate being alone when you are out! It's so boring!"

“Remember what they have done to me.” Her mother runs her free hand against her face. “You especially don’t know who are hunters in disguise, waiting to pounce on the chance to harm you. And don’t forget what your family did.”

A cold shiver runs down Adora’s spine. She doesn’t like to think about that. Though, her mother always loves to remind her how bad humans can be.

“Remember they called you a monster? They didn’t want you anymore—their only child they gave up on you so fast. I don’t think they even tried to help you. Tsk tsk.” Fingers continue to rub her daughter’s cheeks. “What luck you came into my life. That I am able to give you this wonderful life. Am I right, my dear?”

That’s what happened, right? Her birth mother and father gave her up just like that? Once she was bit, something out of her control, that was it? That’s all it took?

Adora sighs. “Yes, mother.”

“People will not understand you. People will reject you and not want you around. Do you understand why I do want you around others? I don’t want my little girl getting hurt.”

“I do. I’m sorry.”

Her mother grins. “Good girl. Now go finish your homework. You know the rule.”

Almost on cue, Adora’s stomach growls. The young girl grips her lower abdomen. She learned her lesson long ago. Adora gives a nod before heading back upstairs, determined to finish her homework. Though, upon reaching her little room, she does not go to her desk. Not immediately. Instead, she stops at her window.

No one is outside.

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14 Years Ago

Adora stares up at the sky, looking at the small dot up high above her head. One hand rests just above her eyes, keeping the light from blinding her. It only takes a matter of moments before the dot becomes larger and larger. Gravity pulls the tennis ball back down to earth. She shifts slightly and sticks out her hand. Adora stops the descent before the ground can take the impact.

Once again, her mother has left her to her own devices. She honestly doesn't know what her mother does half the time. Adora has learned to stop asking questions about that. As per usual, she is told to keep to herself. Not like she has to be told that again. She never has broken that rule imposed by her mother. Which has ended up working in her favor.

Adora is free to do whatever the hell she wants otherwise. She can honestly walk into town, get herself something from the local convenience store and grab a bite to eat. That is the only exception the whole 'keep to yourself' rule. Part of her thinks about doing just that. Maybe she will later, once this gets boring.

She tosses the tennis ball in her hands a few times before gripping it in her right. If there is one good aspect about having superhuman strength, it can make things more fun. With age comes more of it, which she will test out as a human. She has yet to reach past the rooftop of her home. Close, but no cigar. Maybe *this* time.

Pulling her arm back as far as possible, Adora *slams* the tennis ball on the ground. The force creates a small divot in the grass and dirt. Her tennis ball shoots upward, so fast it takes Adora a moment to register what has happened. She snaps her head up, eyes quickly locating her possession. It has reached past the rooftop. Adora's eyes go wide. Joy explodes out of her body.

The moment it is back in her grasp, Adora begins to pump her fist in the air. How long has she been trying to achieve that feat? Far too long. The preteen jumps up and down, unable to contain the

feelings bubbling up inside of her. Her sights return to the bright, crystal clear sky above her head. Puffing out her chest, she figures why not try again?

Adora gives a good spin of her arm before hurling it at the ground. It skyrockets back towards. However, this time, she does not get to see how far it goes. Something else distracts her.

“You toss pretty good!”

Startled, Adora snaps her head towards the direction of the voice. Who the hell would be out here? Any house she and her mother move into always are the most remote area of the town. But what stands feet away from her is a girl her age. She has long, jet black hair tied back in a ponytail. Purple like eyes stare over a pair of glasses. In the sunlight, Adora can see freckles covering her face.

“Who are you?!?” Adora asks, taking a hesitant step forward. Where the hell did she come from?

“Heather. Who are you?”

TWACK!

Adora yelps in pain as the tennis ball bounces off of her head. The shock knocks her off guard and off her feet. The next thing she knows, her chin has connected with the ground. A groan escapes from her lips.

“Are you okay?!?” Heather asks. She reaches Adora’s side in no time at all. Hands grasp her arm and the preteen is lifted to her feet.

“Yeah...Just...wasn’t paying attention.” Adora shakes her head, clearing some of the pain radiating from her skull. “Uh, my name’s Adora.”

“I never seen you before at school. Are you new here?"

“Uh, n-no. I’ve been here for a while. My mom just homeschools me.”

"Woah! That's cool! Do you, like, get to do your homework whenever? Like, do you get freedom?"

"Not really, no." Adora rubs the back of her neck. "My mom's kind of strict. Makes me do work on Saturdays and Sundays sometimes."

"Damn." Heather pauses for a moment. "Is she home?"

"No?"

"Do you want to play?"

"Huh?" Adora blinks. She just met Heather and she wants to do something with her?!? Not to mention, her mother would kill Adora for disobeying the main rule.

"I don't bite! Don't worry!" Heather flashes a smile, revealing a set of colorful braces.

"What are you even doing way out here?"

"Exploring! My moms and sisters are busy doin' their own thing so I went off on my own. C'mon! It'll be fun to have a buddy! Your mom'll never find out!"

Adora rocks on her heels. She knows her mother won't be happy, not in the slightest. But Heather seems nice. She's a girl her age, something she never has experienced before! Looking down at her hand, will a tennis ball truly fend off her boredom?

No. It for sure won't.

"Sure." Adora tosses her ball towards her home. "But I can't stay out long."

"No problem! Let's go!"

The two dart off, Heather in the lead. Adora feels her heart racing with joy. Any thoughts about her mother being furious are pushed away by the laughter that escapes from her. She half follows, half chases Heather as they head into the more populated area of town.

She is guided all over. Through gaps between two buildings to search for things behind the dumpsters. Through a section of the park, hoping the cool, spring weather has brought out frogs. There's one point where at the snack bar of the park, Heather convinces Adora to climb up into the rafters of the sitting area. While up there, her new found friend digs into a small bag, pulling out two kudos, m&m granola bars. Adora's eyes go wide. A rare treat she hasn't had in what feels like forever. Adora chows down on the bar, enjoying every bit. Once they have had their fill, the girls hop down and back out on their adventure.

They continue to walk around. At one point both have grabbed some lollipops and shoved them in their mouths. Adora pays attention to the sun. She hopes her mother isn't back by now. Isn't searching for her and ready to tear her a new one. Heather seems to have picked up on this and gives Adora a small nudge under the rib cage. She reveals she knows a shortcut they could take. Adora does not question this at all and follows.

Heather leads Adora through an abandoned lot. They hop over the fence, feet landing on cracked, hard dirt and dead grass. The house that once watched over this area is in disarray. Windows shattered and boarded up, holes in the porch, and the door half off its hinges.

"If we just get past here, it'll be a clean shot to your house," Heather tells her.

"What happened to this place?" Adora asks. She walks up to the house. A hand rubs a pole holding up the canopy. Whatever color it was is a mystery—the sun has long since bleached it away.

Heather shrugs. “Just got forgotten about. No one ever moved in and it just fell apart. At this point, I don’t think anyone would want to come back.” She kicks a slab of broken wood. “It looks like it would be a lot of work to fix.”

“I think everything deserves a chance, no matter how broken it is.”

A low growl fills the air. Both girls jump at noise, bodies tense. A large dog, hackles raised and teeth bare, stares back at them.

“He doesn’t look happy,” Adora starts. “You didn’t tell me there was a dog here!”

“I didn’t know!” Heather snaps back. “Crap, did it make this it’s home?”

The dog lunges forward.

“I take that as a ‘yes’! GO! GO! *GO!”* Adora shouts, shoving Heather forward.

They bolt, the dog hot on their heels. Panicked shouts and threatening growls fill the air. With the whole area covered by a fence, there is little room for error. Adora and Heather must time their scaling at the right moment.

Adora can feel her heart in her throat, making it even more difficult to breathe. If she wasn’t running at full speed, she believes she would be shaking as if she was in an earthquake. *Damn it!* Adora screams in her head. *I am not dying here! I am not getting* ***mauled*** *again!*

A rock becomes her undoing. For the second time today, her chin meets the ground. Adora groans, biting back the pain from hot needles stabbing her ankle. She definitely twisted it. An easy heal, a day at most, for someone like her. Though, that is, if she lives to make it out of this hell lot.

The growl grows in her ears. Adora's throat tightens, breathing is an impossibility. Her heart is about to burst out of her chest and flee from this nightmare. Fingers begin to curl, creating small trenches in the earth. The shadow of the dog now hovers over her.

"HEY! UGLY! STAY AWAY FROM HER!" Heather shouts.

Out of the corner of her eye, Adora sees Heather racing to her side. Her words, however, are turning into static in her ears. The dog suddenly whimpers before taking off, taking the shadow with her.

"Oh hey, I scared it away! That wasn't hard! Hey, you okay?"

Adora pushes herself onto her hands and knees. She lifts one shaking hand up. Dark claws stare back at her. A twist of the stomach causes her wince.

"Adora?!?" Heather is now in front of her. "Hey, what's the matter?"

"S-stay back, Heather. I-I-just need air," Adora struggles to get out.

"What? Are you sure?"

"Yes! P-please!"

Adora winces again. She bites down on her lips, feeling her growing fang pierce through her skin and copper filling her mouth. Adora fights for control, knowing she *has* to calm down before it's too late. But the wolf inside of her is beginning to take hold.

"Adora?"

" *Stay back!"*

A hand lashes out. Adora feels her fingertips become wet. Red dots fill her vision and the static grows in her ears, drowning out a high pitched noise. The wolf inside of her has dug its claws in and isn't going to let go. Adora is unable to stop the bearing of her teeth and step forward towards Heather.

Something hits her hard in the back of the neck. Adora gasps, her body going limp. The last thing she sees is a tall, looming, familiar shadow standing over her.

The next thing Adora knows, she is stirring in her bed. Her lamp fills the room in a dull light, pushing out much of the darkness from the outside world. Though, it cannot reach the end of her bed. A figure is concealed by the cloak of blackness.

Adora blinks, letting her eyes adjust to the lighting. "M-Mom?"

Her mother leans forward, the back of her hand rubbing against Adora's cheek. "Hello, my dear."

Adora slowly pushes herself up. "What time is it...Why does my neck hurt?"

"I do not know. Why don't *you* tell me?"

The coldness of her voice snaps Adora to attention, and floods her mind with the events of the day. "I-I'm sorry! I didn't want to break your rule!"

"Why did you, though? You know I trusted you."

"I was bored and Heather seemed fun! *Heather!"*

Adora brings her hand to her line of sight. Dull nails are caked in dry blood. Her hand begins to shake. "I-I didn't mean—Is she okay?!? S-She doesn't know, does she?!?"

Her mother gives a shake of the head. "I convinced her and her family that the dog came back and attacked you two. Cut up her face. You know doing that was not allowed, and now look what

happened! Do you understand now?" Cold finger grip Adora's wrist. "Why people call us monsters? Why they attacked me? And why we don't interact with them?"

Most of her mother's words fade away, leaving only one thing in her mind. ***Monster.*** It repeats over and over again in her brain.

"Tell me again. Why did you leave"?"

"I-I," Tears prick at the edge of her eyes, small streams form on her cheeks. "I just wanted a friend!"

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13 Years Ago

"Adora!" Her mother's voice enters through the open door. "Come down here."

Adora pulls her head away from the book she reads. "Coming!" she replies. Not expecting to be long, she flips the book down onto its pages before exiting her room. In the little ranch house she lives in now, it does not take long to see why her mother has summoned her.

Standing in front of her is a young girl. Dark brown hair is wild and amber and cyan eyes stare at Adora. She has a scrawny build and doesn't look much older than her. The girl says nothing as Adora inches closer.

"Who's this?" Adora asks.

"This is Catra. She is going to be part of our family now," Shadow Weaver answers.

"What?"

"Consider her your sister. Go on, Catra, say hello."

Catra looks up at her before her gaze turns back to Adora. A hand shoots out. “Hi. What is your name?”

Adora takes the hand, giving a slight shake. “Adora. Are...Are you like us?” No way her mother would bring a human here.

“Werepanther. Born.”

“Werewolf. Bitten.”

“Adora, show Catra your room. We will have to figure out where she will sleep but run along now.” Her mother disappears into another room.

“Is she always like that?” Catra whispers into Adora’s ear.

Adora nods before copying Catra. “Yeah. You get used to it. C’mon!”

Adora leads the way into her room. There is not much really. Just her bed with the blanket she always has had, a small bookshelf, and a desk with her computer. “It’s not much but it’s something.”

Catra looks around the room, taking in all the details. “More than I ever had…”

Adora bites down on her lip, not knowing what to say. Catra has her arms crossed against her chest and keeps her body tense. Maybe asking questions isn’t the best idea. If she is going to live with her now, if she is now her *sister,* first impressions are important.

“Hey, you wanna play a game? I think I might have a board game under my bed, hold on.” Adora quickly darts under her bed. Her hand shifts around, searching for anything to play with. Fingers find something. She drags it out and blows off the thin layer of dust on top. A simple game of chess.

“Wanna play this. Do you know how?” Adora asks.

“Never played it before…” Catra replies.

“I can teach ya! Don’t worry.”

Catra shifts on her feet. “You don’t have to be nice to me, ya know.”

“I want to be. You're gonna be living here now, right? We are family. That’s what we’re supposed to do.”

“My family wasn’t the best at that.”

Adora sets up the chess board, sitting down behind one end. “I’m sorry to hear that. But I won’t let that happen here. We are sisters now. We take care of each other.”

Catra hesitantly sits down on the other end. “Never had a sister before.”

“Neither have I. We can learn together! Nothing bad can ever happen when we are together, Catra.” Adora sticks out her pinky finger. “Sisters forever? Promise?”

Catra thinks for a moment. With one arm still on her chest, she sticks out her own pinky. A small smile appears on her face. “I promise, Adora.”

Chapter End Notes

two things 1) heather is an old oc and it just was sheer chance she has similar looks to Glimmer. She was the best fit and it just happened she looks a bit like her

2) comments/kudos appreciated!!

Ghost of the Past Part II: Decisions

Chapter Notes

heyo got one last one out a little early again! tw for blood and injury, more parental abuse/mental abuse, death mention, etc just all that stuff

so....why post a little early? Well...idk when I will come back for break i am hoping its another 3-4 weeks but i, unfortunately, not only just had a rough start of dec but i am currently getting over/dealing with Covid! So writing yeah has been rough (dw i am on the mend)

So yeah. I say just keep an eye on my Tumblr and Twitter (yeah I have that now) for updates.

But also, thank you all for 1k hits. I still do not have an exact amount of chapters left in my head but there is a lot still in there so i just want to say thank you for sticking with me with this and heres to another 1k!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

13 Years Ago

Adora groans. Her most recent transformation lingers within her bones and muscles. There still is the occasional jerk of a body part as it finalizes her human form. Her *true* form, she reminds herself. She finishes getting dressed, brushes out her hair, and cleans her dull teeth. So soon after the full moon has gone to rest, the mint flavor is strong against her tongue. But any reminder she's now in control is better than none at all.

Once everything is set and done, she takes a moment to look at her reflection in the mirror. A young girl, not yet thirteen. Hesitant fingers hover over the right side of her shirt's collar. After a pause, she pulls the fabric down enough to reveal the scarred, pale skin. She still wonders, after all these years, what took a chunk out of

her. What gave her this curse. And...if she will ever control it and not black out once every month.

A pounding on the door draws her out of her thoughts. Adora fixes her shirt and goes to unlock her bathroom door. Standing mere inches from her face is Catra. The young werepanther has only been in her life for a little under a month. Some things are still very much getting used to. Such as sharing this space with another being her age.

“Hey, Adora. You finally in there?" Catra reaches her hands out. One grasp Adora's chin while the other, balled up into a fist, gives several small knocks on her forehead.

"Ow! Hey! Quit it!" Adora says. She slaps Catra's hands away. "Personal space!"

"Ah! So you are back. Took you long enough."

"What are you talking about?" Adora enters her bedroom. She takes a look outside. Nothing but gloom. No sun to greet her. Adora can’t help but sigh at the sight. “How long did it take you to come back to?”

Catra shrugs. “Never takes me long. I was bored waiting for you, ya know.” She hops onto Adora’s bed. Bare feet step all over her sheets, including her golden blanket. Without thinking, Adora grasps the end and yanks it away full force. Catra yelps as she falls onto her bed against the mattress. Adora keeps the blanket close to her chest, brushing out the wrinkles.

“What the hell was that for!” Catra shouts, shooting up into a sitting position.

“Don’t step on this!” Adora replies.

“What? Why? It’s just an old blanket! What’s so special about it?”

“I-” Adora pauses. She can’t quite explain *why* she had such a reaction. After all, didn’t her mother get this for her? It’s just a

simple blanket that has begun to fade with age. However, something gnaws at her—at her *heart.* She doesn't know what or why but there is one thing Adora does know. That the blanket *does* mean something and she refuses to be told otherwise.

"I just really like it, alright?" Adora states. She folds the blanket up into a neat square before setting it beside her pillow. "Don't touch it, got it?"

Catra throws her hands up in front of her. "Alright! Sheesh. So...Now what?"

"What do you mean?"

"What do you do after the full moon, anything?"

"Nothing really. Just getting back to normal really. Did you do something different?"

Catra scoffs. "My family didn't really care. You could do nothing or whatever. The only time anyone cared or paid attention to you was if you were trying to blow something up or set something on fire. Even then you were getting reprimanded for breaking something."

"Well, Mom doesn't like when chores go unfinished. Is Mom around?"

"I haven't seen Shadow Weaver anywhere. Does she do this often?"

Adora places finger against her lips before heading towards her door. Carefully, she cracks it open, enough to stick her head out. Eyes close and all her senses go towards her hearing. Down the hall, to the furthest door in the house is her mother's room. A place always forbidden to enter. Even with her enhanced hearing, especially just after a shift back, Adora must strain to hear the slight shuffling of her mother.

"She's in her room," Adora tells Catra.

“Why does she spend so much time cooped up in there? Aren’t you her kid?”

“Well, you are her kid now also. But she’s in there a lot. Never know why. No matter what house we are at, I am *never* allowed in her room.”

“Huh. Interesting…”

Adora notices a tinkle forming in Catra’s eyes. Before she can ask what on earth she is thinking, the werepanther hops off the bed. “Okay. So we have to do chores?”

“Why do you seem so excited? You hate doing them!”

“Yeah but I bet I can do them better and faster than you!”

Before Adora can retort, Catra bolts out of the room. She shouts, surprised, before darting out after her. The younger of the near teenagers has already retrieved a broom and sweeps up tiny dust bunnies. Not wanting to be beaten, Adora races to the closest to gather her things. As she does so, she passes the closed door of the basement. A shiver always runs down her spine, remembering the monthly “ritual” that always occurs down there. At least now, she doesn’t have to think about that for sometime.

Adora pulls open the door, snatching the cleaning supplies. Spray and rags for the tables. She shuts the door behind her, though the force she uses causes it to bounce right back open. Without wasting any more precious seconds, Adora quickly gets to work. Tables and windows begin to be freed from dust and smudges. All the while, she keeps an eye on her sister, Catra doing the same.

Laughter begins to fill the air. The sisters try sabotaging the other in an effort to win this little competition of theirs. Catra knocking over the bottle or stealing her rags and Adora breaking up the pile of dust and dirt her sister has made. At one point, Catra is using the broom as a weapon against Adora while the blonde will throw wet rags at her face.

Though, their fun quickly comes to an end. The door to their mother's room opens, her head petting out from the frame. "Girls! Quiet down! Chores are not playtime!" Without another word, she shuts the door.

Adora and Catra quiet their laughter into soft giggles. Their little war ends but not their fun. Under their breaths, they joke and prod at each other. Occasionally, they attempt to trip the other up. A smile cannot fade from Adora's face. She has not had this much fun in...well, *forever!* How did she go this long without having a sister in her life? Without having a friend?

At least now, she won't ever be as lonely.

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10 Years Ago

Adora watches from afar. She hopes no one is looking at her and thinking she is some sort of creep. Though, she can't help it much. Across the street, is a park, full of life. Children run around, laughing on the top of their legs as they chase each other. Parents watch carefully from a distance, making sure no one darts out into the street or trips and eats shit. Though, whenever someone tumbles, they get up as if nothing has happened.

Walking down the twisting and turning paths are a few couples. They hold hands as they take in the blossoming trees that welcome spring. A few lone souls walk on their own as well, lost in their own world with headphones playing music only they can hear. Finally, Adora spots some teens her age playing wiffle ball on the softball field. Though, they seem to have made up their own rules, not really caring about strikes.

A sigh escapes through her nose at the warm sight playing out in front of her. Invisible strings pull at her heart, daring her to cross the street and join in on the activities. No matter how many times her mother warns her to stay away, to only remain with her and Catra, another voice will whisper in her ears. But knowing how her

mother would react, knowing what could happen again if she got too close, it all keeps her feet planted on the concrete sidewalk.

"Hey, Adora!" Familiar arms wrap around her neck, a weight threatening to knock her over. Adora holds her own, steadying out before she smacks face first into the hard ground. "The hell are you looking at?"

"Nothing." Adora shakes her sister off. She takes a moment to look behind her. The store she waits outside is the same as ever. No one is in the windows, though shades half block it. "Is Mom *still* in there? What is she doing?"

Catra shrugs, letting her arm slide off of Adora's neck. "Hell if I know. She kept looking for a book or whatever and told me to leave after I knocked a stack of them."

Adora snorts. "You didn't have to cause trouble to leave. You could've just walked out or stayed out here like me."

"Eh, that would've been boring! But seriously, what have you been doing out here by your lonesome?" Catra looks out across the street. "Ah. Why do you keep doing this to yourself? You know Mom'll skin you alive."

"Yeah, I know that. I am not an idiot!"

"Then why are you acting like one?"

"I dunno! I just-" Adora groans. How can she explain to her sister about what she feels inside. A longing to be a part of that somehow familiar world. Every time she has tried to reach out, an invisible wall stops her, sometimes covered in blood. Still, Adora wants to *shatter* it and cross that threshold. But would that world accept her? "I just wonder what it's like! That's all."

"You know what it's like! The moment people find out what you are, they aren't gonna like you. All it takes is one full moon and-" Catra half lunges at Adora, growling as she does so. The blonde teen can't help but jump backwards.

“Don’t do that, Cat!” Adora snaps. “It isn’t funny!”

“You know it’s true.”

“What if it isn’t, though?” Adora’s eyes fall back to the park. “There are millions, *billions,* of people on Earth. How can everyone be like that? There has to be others who wouldn’t be afraid of us, right?”

Catra begins to walk around her, dual eyes refusing to budge from her sister. “Yeah but do you want to take that chance? You don’t know who is and isn’t on your side. Who is a hunter and who isn’t. I mean, even with us! My family just ditched me with Shadow Weaver cause they didn’t want to deal with me. Your parents didn’t want to deal with you. How else do you think Mom got those scars on her face?”

Adora grips her arms, fingers digging into the fabric of her long sleeved shirt. “That can’t be true for everyone! It just...can’t be.”

“You and your dumbass heart. I might not agree with Mom on everything but I do agree with her views on humanity. We are better off without them. And *we* shouldn’t be the ones living in fear.”

“Will you just shut up already!” Adora walks away from Catra in a vain attempt of escape. Can’t go far when you’ve been ordered to stay put.

“C’mon!” Catra jumps in front of Adora, stopping in her tracks. “You know I’m right! ‘Sides,” she gives her sister a punch in the arm, “you are better off here! I mean, Mom can be, well, *Mom!* But you and me? What more can you ask for!”

Before Adora can say anything, be it a rebuttal or agreement, the sound of a bell above a door catches her attention. She and Catra both look towards the noise. Their mother steps out onto the sidewalk, a bag in one hand. She slowly walks up to her teenage daughters.

“You two aren’t causing any trouble, are you?” she asks.

“No.” Both Adora and Catra speak together, each standing at attention.

“Good. Come now.” Their mother walks in front of them, leading the way back to their home in this little town. Adora and Catra quickly fall into line, trailing just behind her.

The sisters begin to whisper to each other, making jokes and wondering what they will have for dinner. Adora begins to forget about the conversation she had only moments ago. Her stomach growls at the thought of food. She suggests after getting home and settling down, playing some video games in her room. When she sees the twinkle in her sister’s eyes grow, Adora knows the werepanther has agreed.

Once home, the two sisters are tasked with finishing up their homework. They settle down at the living room table while their mother steps into the kitchen. Though, not before stopping to drop off her bag in her room. Adora catches a glint in Catra's eyes as their mother leaves her room.

“Hey. Hey, Adora!”

Adora groans, rolling onto her side. She really does not want to be awoken from her nap. They are few and far between. Each time she gets this rare treat, Adora wants to take it all in. However, her sister doesn’t care. Slender hands grip her shoulders and shake her body with force.

“Adora! Wake up already! I know you can hear me!” Catra hisses into her ear.

Adora snaps open her eyes. Her hand swats away her sister’s before she sits up. “What do you want, Catra?” A yawn escapes her. Fingers lace through her dark locks. “I am trying to sleep.”

“Mom’s gone.”

"Yeah, and? You know she usually disappears without warning. Why are you waking me for that?"

"No you idiot! Wake up will you? If she's gone, then her room has been left unattended!"

"So? It's locked."

Catra shakes her head. "She forgot!"

When a sly smile spreads across her sister's face, Adora's brain becomes fully alert. Eyes go wide. "You are not thinking about going in there?!? *Why* are you thinking about that?!?"

"Why not? She always has it locked but today. When else would we have this chance to see what she is hiding in there? I know you want to know what's in there also!"

Well, she's not wrong there. How long has Adora been with her mother now? She cannot recall at all if she has ever seen the inside of her room in all of the many houses they have been. But there is a damn good reason for that.

"You know she'll kill us if she catches us, right?" Adora hisses through her teeth. "Do you want to be skinned alive?!?"

"Don't bitch. Long as someone— *you* —keeps look out, we will be fine! You aren't a chicken, are you? Big bad wolf is scared to go into Mom's room for five minutes?"

Adora huffs. "I'm not scared! I just...I don't want to get in trouble."

"That sounds like being scared. We can go in and out, we don't have to stay there long. Five minutes, tops! Let's go already!"

Before any more protest can be made, Catra makes her way out of the room. Adora curses under her breath before leaping off her bed. Even if she doesn't go along with her sister, if Catra is caught, Adora still will get in trouble for it. Being on lookout is the

only way to save both their skins. And besides, Adora can’t help but be a little curious as to what lies within her mother’s room.

Catra is already downstairs and at their mother’s door. The werepanther pushes it open. A high pitched creak fills the air. Both sisters tense up despite no threat being present. When the noise dies down and muscles relax, Catra steps into the forbidden room of the house. Adora takes a glance at the front door. Shut. She hopes that it remains like that.

Adora makes her way towards the room. She hesiants at the threshold. Even with the door opening, an invisible barrier remains. Inhaling deeply, Adora (quite literally) takes a leap forward.

There is not much to note of the room, at first. Only slightly bigger than Adora’s and Catra’s room. A single bed, made up nice and neat, rests at the side near a window. There’s a dresser and closet. No TV sits anywhere, rather, random trinkets take its place. Jewelry, plants Adora can’t identify in pots or small glass vials, and some books.

Actually, there are a lot of books. Most rest on a large bookshelf off to the side while another large pile rests on a desk. All of them are closed shut. Some have bookmarks sticking out on top. Adora takes a close look at some of them. A fews bindings have begun to lose their glue and are hanging on by threads. Others’ pages have turned yellow from the passage of time and the strength of sunlight. One thing is the same about all of them, however. They all look older. Written and printed long before Adora was brought into this world.

Fingers brush against the harsh, almost brittle binding. "What do you think are in these?" Adora asks. She takes a moment to look out the door. No one.

"Dunno. Why don't you open one?" Catra replies.

Out of the corner of Adora's eye, she can see her sister shuffling around near the desk.

Adora finds something that doesn't look like it will crumble if she touches it. Carefully, she opens the books. Stained pages, with ends tattered, stare back at her. And...strange looking text. She raises an eyebrow as she tries to make heads or tails of the ink.

Some letters look familiar, even if slightly off, such as 'B's looking slightly longer at the end. Others, however, are totally forgien. The only thing she can recognize is what looks like math symbols like 'π', the symbol of Pi.

Adora replaces the book in her hands. Once again, the same similar yet strange words stare at her. She bites down on her thumb.

"Cat, do you have any idea what this language is?"

Catra joins her sister, peering right over her shoulder. "No. Latin?

Adora shakes her head. "Don't think so. Doesn't look quite like it."

"Turn the page and see what else is there."

Adora does as instructed. On one side, more text stared back at them. On the other is a drawing. At least two beings are there, one to the left and one to the right. The latter has an animalistic face as it flees the table. All the while, smoke and fire billow out from a building. This is all Adora can take in before the book is snatched from her hands.

"What do you two think you are doing?"

Their mother stands tall over the sisters, bright green eyes *boring* into them, right into their souls. A fire of anger, one Adora has never seen, burns brightly inside her irises. The shadow she casts is cold, just like the aura seeping off her body.

"I-I-I," Adora stammers, not knowing what to say. She didn't even *hear* her mother entering the house. When the hell did she get back?

Adora shrinks besides Catra. The werepanther, too, has become small upon coming face to face with her enraged mother.

Their mother sets the book aside, placing it on the desk with force, before grabbing both her daughters' wrist. She drags them both upstairs, entering straight into their room. The moment she lets go, their mother shuts the door behind her. Eyes quickly return to the pair of sisters, continuing to bore into them.

Adora glups, both knowing and *not* knowing what is to come.

They lie in silence. A peep could spell disaster. Their mother could be standing outside their door, listening into their conversations. Waiting to burst open the door and yell at them again. Or, she could be downstairs, ignoring them. Only letting them *think* danger is lurking outside.

Adora can still hear her mother’s angry voice ringing in her ears. Much of the shouts were directed at Catra, demanding to know why she was in there and why she brought Adora along. The werepanther nearly fused into the floor as she shrunk under the beratement from her mother. Threats of leaving her just like her birth parents are thrown at Catra. Adora can do little to stop it. Stepping in will only cause more harm than good.

Then, it was her turn. Her mother’s voice lowered, no longer a shout but not lacking its venom. More of how she took Adora in after her family abandoned her, that she gave her so much and this is how she is getting repaid? It quickly became Adora’s turn to shrink into the ground.

For over an hour it was like this. Knocking Catra down and asking Adora why she could betray her mother like this.

Now darkness has come and Adora should be asleep. Yet, rest is a far off dream. When the sun rises and brings light to the world, it'll do little to help the mood. Surely, her mother will have plenty of things for the sisters to do as punishment. More chores, harder ones at that, and possible lack of breakfast. Anything to drive home the point of their wrong doing. How can one sleep when that is looming over their heads?

The boards creak besides her. Adora does not budge, keeping her eyes on the pale, blank wall.

"This is your fault, ya know," Catra chastises, keeping her voice low.

"How the hell is this my fault?" Adora spats back.

"You got us caught, stupid!

"You were the one who thought of sneaking into her room!"

"Yeah but *you* were supposed to be on look out! Who's fault was that, huh?"

Adora bites down on her lips, fingers digging into the fabric of her sheets. She refuses to play this game of Catra's. Every time they get in trouble her sister seems to find a way to twist it. Adora wonders why she continues to listen to her, to go along with her plans. Either she lets Catra do her own thing and she'll get in trouble for not keeping her sister *out* of it, or she goes along and gets wrapped up in said trouble.

"Why don't you learn to be a better fuckin' lookout? Or do you not because you know your Mom's favorite?"

This is a hot knife in her heart. Adora feels tears prick at the side of her eyes. She refuses to let them fall. *I can't control that!* she thinks to herself. The words are lodged in her throat but fail to come out. Her body becomes tense.

Catra scoffs. “Sleep well. Maybe in your dreams, you won’t get us in trouble.”

Boards creak once again. She hears the springs of Catra’s bed squeaking under her weight. Adora remains still, body tight as a drum. The moment she allows for any relaxation, her whole body will crumble under the weight of words from her mother and sister.

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8 Years Ago

“Where are we going?” Adora asks. She looks around the woods of her home. Sunlight streams through the green needles of the hemlocks. Fresh snow crunches under her boots. Adora takes a moment to look over her shoulder, her house nowhere in sight. Her mother won’t mind her and Catra being here, long as they don’t cause shit. But how much trouble can you get in in the woods? With their home so secluded from the rest of town, there shouldn’t even be any hikers out in this unmarked area.

“You’ll see! Trust me, it’s really cool!” Catra replies. “Hurry up, slowpoke!” She begins to laugh as she darts behind a set of trees.

“Hey! Wait up!” Adora scrambles forward. Snow kicks up behind her as she races to catch up with her sister. She follows the sound of Catra’s laughter. Adora rounds a corner, hoping to spot her sister. However, the next thing she knows, something hits her in the legs. She falls forward, smacking hard against the cold earth. *What the hell?*

Adora spits out the now melted snow that has found its way into her mouth. She flips onto her back, finding her sister standing tall over her. Adora freezes in place when she sees the look in those dual colored eyes.

Hate.

“Cat? Catra, what are you doing?”

“I’m going to prove a point.” Catra kneels besides her sister. “I’m sick and tired of Mom giving you all the attention and care.”

“What are you talking about?”

“Don’t play dumb! Mom only ever cares about you!”

Adora’s heart pounds in her chest. She attempts to rise to her feet but a foot to her chest keeps her in place. “Cat!”

“She always goes easy on you! I am always the one taking the abuse from her! Just like the other day!”

Adora squeezes her eyes shut, the memory of that night seeping into her mind. They went out on a task, simply to gather some things at the store their mother ordered. But while walking back, the two got distracted. Took a long way home, laughing over some stupid stuff. They became so lost in their own world, the sisters didn’t return home until nightfall. Their mother was *furious,* to say the least. Apparently, she needed these things right away. Plus, some was food that needed to stay cold and very nearly spoiled.

Catra took the brunt, their mother singling her out and thinking she was the ringleader. Truthfully, it was both their ideas to take their time. Neither really *wanted* to go home. Their mother didn’t care though. While Catra was yelled at, Adora only received a small scolding.

“That isn’t my fault!” Adora’s eyes reopen as she pleads with her sister. Catra continues to stare down at her.

“You sure as shit don’t do anything about it!”

“What am I *supposed* to do?!? Anything I would do would make it worse for you! Mom would just be even more pissed off!”

“Oh *yippee!* Guess I am supposed to be grateful for that?”

Adora grabs her sister's leg. In one swift moment, she throws Catra off her body. She scrambles to her shaking feet. Her breathing comes out fast and harsh, crystallizing in front of her, while it feels like her heart is about to *explode.* Did Catra bring her out here, away from the home, just to tear her a new one?

"What do you want me to do?!?" Adora asks

"Shift."

"What?"

Catra takes several steps forward. "You heard me. Shift. You still never learned how to control it while I have." The werepanther begins to back Adora up against a tree. A hand shoots out, slamming right near Adora's ear. "I am gonna prove to Mom which one of us is better."

"C-Catra…"

Adora has just enough time to register Catra's other hand, a tight fist, coming straight for her head. She yelps as she dodges the attack. She very nearly tumbles to the ground again but somehow manages to remain on unsteady feet.

"Stop! Why are you doing this?" Adora pleds.

"I told you. It's about time Mom sees who's the better were. You know, during the full moon when you are trying to tear everyone's head off, she is trying to keep you in line. *Control* you. She never gets past you not attacking us as long as we keep our distance."

"What are you talking about?!?" Adora's ears ring as the stream of words fill the air. That is what her mother has been doing all this time? She always has been vague, only saying she has it under control. That there is nothing to worry about.

"She's getting pissed the older and stronger you get and how little you fuckin' listen," Catra hisses. A hand raises in the air, poised to strike again. Once more, Adora scrambles out of the way from the

blow. However, her limbs have started to betray her, gaining a mind of their own. She falls flat onto the earth, allowing Catra to plant her foot back on Adora's back.

"Why the hell does she put all her focus on you? Someone who can't control the monster inside of her? Someone who always has to be all goodie-two-shoes." Catra begins to speak in a mocking tone. "' *Oh, Mom! I don't want to hurt any humans. Even though my human parents ditched me and humans hurt you! And how hunters have hunted us down for a millenia!'* Do you ever hear yourself?

Adora cannot stop the tears rolling down her face. "Shut *up!* How do you know anything Mom says is true?!? How can everyone hate us or want us dead?"

"Mom told me about that kid once when you were eleven. You don't think that's why people fear us? Especially when you can't control it and just let yourself become a monster?"

"I said, *Shut. Up!"* Adora growls, throwing Catra clean off her back. She gasps for air as her body trembles violently. Her stomach twists tight and she can feel her heart beating in the center of her throat.

Catra begins to laugh a cold laugh. "You can't control who you are. And Mom's gonna see exactly who is superior!"

"*Why?"* Adora asks again. Black specs form in her vision. They dance against the pure white snow. Everything stings. Goosebumps form against her skin. The cold air slices through her clothing, adding to the blistering.

Catra doesn't give an answer. She only glowers, watching as her sister's body reshapes itself.

Adora blinks, the world nothing but a blur of dark shadows. Anything she can make out is nothing more than featureless figures. A crunching noise faintly enters her ears along with the

chattering of teeth. There is a bounce to everything around her. Any movement Adora attempts to make fails. The command never gets past leaving her brain.

There are whispers, words she cannot piece together. There are two voices. So familiar yet no faces, no names come to her mind. Adora tries so hard to figure out what is going on but as time goes on, she realizes one thing. Whoever speaks the most has a harshness to their voice. She would rather not be a part of this.

However, just as the world slips from her grasp once more, a new sound enters her mind. Another voice. Something once more she has a sense of recognition but cannot make heads or tails of it. The only thing she knows, it does not belong to either of the previous speaking voices.

It's gonna be okay, Adora. It's gonna be okay…

Adora trudges through the woods, retracing her footsteps. A freezing rain that swept through this area has layered the soft snow in a thin sheet of ice. The once soft, fluffy blanket that lies on top of the Earth's crust now is hard and sharp to the touch. Each step causes it to break into jagged pieces. This does not deter Adora.

" *What happened?"* she asked last night to her mother. Upon waking up in her bed, naked and cold, she could not piece anything together. Wasn't she just out with her sister?

Adora pauses for a moment, hoping she is on the right track. This deep in, the trees can all blend into the same image. None looking different from the other. She closes her eyes and inhales deeply. The scents of winter fill her nose, the cold stinging her insides. She also smells *herself.*

Her anger and fear.

"We are going to have to move because of you and your sister," her mother replied. Cold hands grasped Adora's chin as she

continued. " *Your lack of control can be so…"* she took a moment, " *troublesome."*

The scents grow stronger and stronger in her nose. She now can smell *hurt.* The scent of utter betrayal. The pain, *her* pain, is ripe. It drowns any other smells. Even the crispness of the winter air is no match for it. Only one thing can come close to matching it. Another smell of fear. The one that came off of her sister.

" *Your sister is in a heep of trouble. Though, her acrobatic skills saved her skin from you. It's surprising she made it out with only some bruising after you threw her like a ragdoll."*

"What?" Adora had gasped. She had hurt her sister? Though, hadn't Catra done the same?

Adora finds what she has been looking for. The epicenter of her explosive anger. She walks into the center. The snow beneath her feet is torn to shreds. Clawed so deeply, even the hardened ground has been pulled up and thrown all over. The proud trees that stand so tall now bare deep scars in their bark. Adora steps up to one of them. Fingers perfectly match the marks on the wood. All the others are sure to give her the same result.

" *We are going to have to move because of you and your sister."* She repeated *. "You're lucky you didn't kill any of those hikers."* Her mother said. " *We can't risk them or others coming after us once the secret gets out."*

Adora takes a deep inhale. The only things she smells are the same as before. Not a single drop of a stranger's scent in the air. Her's and Catra's could mask it. With all the destroyed snow, prints are next to impossible to tell apart. There easily could have been others out and about enjoying the winter wonderland. Or...maybe they are nothing more than tales. An excuse.

The only clear indications of life forms making their way through here is a lone werewolf print. Adora slowly walks up to it. She stares at her own human hand. The blunt nails, the callous skin,

cracked from the exposure to the cold. Legs suddenly refuse to carry her weight. Knees connect with the frozen ground. Her hand breaks her fall, landing right beside her werewolf one.

Eyes remain on her hand. It looks so small compared to her werewolf one. Two sides of the same coin…

A crunching of snow catches her attention. Adora slowly turns her head in the direction. A cold wind blows through the trees, knocking some snow off of the green needles. The dust does little to conceal the new presence. Catra stands yards away, remaining totally silent.

Adora narrows her eyes at her sister, feeling the bubbling of boiling anger filling up her chest. There is no threat of the wolf busting out and causing even more damage. However, Adora doesn't even bother to hold it back. She wants her sister to know exactly what she feels inside of her. She wants her to know how the pain inflicted burns her heart and soul. She wants her, the sibling she longed for, to know the exact thoughts in her mind.

Adora breaks the silence.

"I hate you."

000000

5 Years Ago

Adora mindlessly flicks through the TV, hoping something will catch her attention. At this time of day, there usually isn't much to enjoy. Most people would either be at school, at work, or running errands. The only people ever to be home at this hour are sick kids, those playing hooky, or someone who has nowhere else to be. No job, no school, nothing at all. So... *her.*

Adora chews on a popsicle stick in her mouth, the frozen part long since eaten. Thankfully, the AC helps keep her cool. She continues to flick through the channel, still nothing catching her eyes. There isn't much else to keep her entertained. Her mother is somewhere

in the house doing who knows what. Catra...Well, she isn't in the mood to be with her sister. They have come to a neutral(ish) standing with each other. Ever since that day all those years ago in the woods, their relationship has become a simple 'you live with me' type deal.

No more going out on adventures. No more messing around with each other. Hell, no more shared bedrooms. If she is being honest, Adora is happy this way. Least she doesn't have to worry about being dragged into something stupid.

Adora groans, pressing herself hard against the pillows. How can she find *nothing* to watch! There is nothing even mind-numbing to put on. Unfortunately for Adora, she doesn't have any tapes or DVDs to put on. She is about to give up, go off and find something else to do when something catches her attention. A news headline makes her heart stop cold in her chest.

Wolf Attack. One Dead.

The reporter begins to speculate about how this is possible. Wolves do not live in this part of the country. Not for hundreds of years. No nearby zoos have any such creatures in their care. Did someone harbor them and they got loose? If so, who was their owner and where are they? And of course, everyone must be on guard.

But Adora knows better.

This was no wild animal. This was no escape pet. This was no *accident.*

"What the hell!" Adora shouts. Feet slam against the floor and hands smack against the coffee table. An empty glass she drunk previously nearly topples to the ground. "Are you fuckin' kidding me?!?"

"Something the matter, dear?"

Adora jumps, nearly going straight through the roof. When she spins around, her mother appears out of nowhere behind her. She steps out of the shadows, the only thing between her and her daughter is the couch. The older woman towers over her daughter. Bright green eyes remain locked on Adora.

Adora glups a dry lump in her throat. “Did you do that?” she asks, her voice small.

“Do what?” her mother asks.

Adora straightens herself up. Even with her heart pounding in her chest, sweat forming on her palms and brow, she cannot back down. “Did you do that?” She gestures to the TV still broadcasting the animal attack. “Did you kill them? Did you…”

She licks her lips. Nothing. There was no bloody taste anywhere in her mouth this morning. Adora herself couldn’t have gotten loose herself. There is only one possible answer.

“Did you murder someone?”

Her mother doesn’t answer right away. Her face remains stone cold—unreadable. Adora must keep her hands into fist in order to keep them from shaking. For a moment, her mother flicks her eyes towards the screen. They quickly return to Adora.

“Does it matter?” she says.

“What?!? Yes! It matters! Why did you do that?!?” Adora’s voice rises several octaves.

“They were a hunter sticking their nose in the wrong place.”

“But did you have to *kill* them?!? There was nothing else you could’ve done?!?”

Her mother’s face remains the same. No signs of remorse. No signs of any wrongdoing. Adora grits her teeth together.

“It had to be done.” her mother states.

“ *How!”* Adora slams foot on the ground. The fierceness combined with her natural strength, especially so close to the full moon, threatens to break the wood. “Did they even attack you or did you just *murder* them!”

“Don’t you raise your voice at your mother.” Her mother somehow grows taller. Adora fights the urge to tuck her tail between her legs and run away.

“You didn’t have to kill them! Did you?!? What sick idea is this?!?”

A hand shoots forward. Fingers grip her chin, nails ready to pierce through skin. Her mother brings Adora’s face close to her own. There is a burning fire in her green eyes. “You will listen to your mother! You will *not* question me! I took you in and raised you when humans abandoned you! I gave you-” she cuts herself off, quickly changing the topic. “You will *listen* to me! You will *obey* me! You will not question what I do and will follow me! Do you understand!”

Adora stares at her mother. Part of her does wish to fight back, to say something to her. But there is one thing that rings true in her ears. She is her mother after all. That alone is enough to keep her mouth snapped shut. The only thing she can do is dart her eyes away from her mother and lower her shoulders. Her mother grins from ear to ear.

“Good.” she lets go of Adora. Her mother then reaches for the remote and shuts off the TV. “No more questions on this. Go find something else to do.”

“Yes, Mother.”

Adora watches her disappear, back into her room. As she walks down the hallway, she passes her other daughter. Adora wonders just how long Catra has been standing there, listening to this spat. The werepanther looks at her, tilting her head slightly. Adora

doesn’t bother to give any sort of answer to what has happened. She simply walks away.

The new moon would be hanging in the night sky right now,allowing for all the stars to shine brilliantly. Storm clouds, however, are all one can see when looking up. Though, it does only mask the celestial beings. The new moon is still there, hidden. Heavy rain falls from the clouds, accompanied by occasional claps of bright white lightning. The whole world outside is nothing more than darkness.

This will be Adora’s only chance of escape.

The new moon keeps her wolf form suppressed the most. With rain pretty much acting like a waterfall, her scent will be masked. When will she ever have this stroke of luck ever again? Never. It’s now or never.

Adora stuffs whatever she can into the biggest backpack she can find. Clothing, what little money she has, some food she took from the cabinets, anything of use she shoves inside. While filling it up to the brim, Adora’s eyes land on the blanket resting on her bed. She hesitates, not knowing if this should be added to her supplies. What little reminders she can have of her family is the best option. Yet, something tugs at her heartstrings.

Bring it! her mind screams at her. Adora chews on the bottom of her lip before deciding to shove it in there. At least it will keep her warm.

Once she has triple checked everything, Adora closes the bag and throws it over her shoulders. Before leaving, there is one last thing she must do. Taking a deep breath, she carefully makes her way out of her bedroom. Every step she takes is careful. No need to wake her mother up with a creaking board.

Adora stops at the closed door of her sister’s room. Hands shake as she prepares herself for this. She could just *leave.* After how

Catra has treated her a number of times, she doesn't have to do this. Yet, part of her knows that isn’t right. Adora has to at least offer this chance to her.

Biting back a taste of bile rising in her throat, Adora twists the doorknob. Thankfully, or not, it is unlocked. “Catra?”

Like the rest of the house and world, her sister’s room is dark. At this time of month, Adora must squint to see the outline of her sister lying in bed. Slowly, she steps closer. “Cat, are you awake?”

“What if I am? What do you want?” Catra replies. “The hell are you doing up at this hour?”

“I’m leaving?”

“What?!?” Catra snaps up. She keeps her voice low. “What are you talking about?!?”

“I’m sick of living here. I am sick of Mom. Her killing that person, that was the last straw! I can’t take it anymore!”

“Are you insane?!? You know the second she finds you aren’t home she is gonna kill you!”

“I know, and I don’t care.”

“Why are you coming here, though? Going to rub it in?”

“No. Come with me. Leave and get away from mom!”

“I thought you hated me.”

Adora scoffs. Mixed emotions build up inside of her. She might not like it, but Catra is her sister. She *did* pretty much grow up with her. How could she just leave her? Especially with someone like their mother? No. She can’t do that to her.

“Do you want to come or not?”

“What if I don’t? What if I rat you out to Mom?”

“You better not,” Adora growls. “At least do me that favor. So do I take that as a no?”

Catra does not give an answer. She flips back on her bed, keeping her back towards her sister. “You are insane,” Catra repeats. “You are going to get yourself killed.”

“Fine, be like that.” Adora says. “I hope you are happy with your choice.”

“The same goes to you, idiot.”

Without saying another word, Adora not only exits her sister’s room, but her home as well.

The full moon hangs high in the air. Adora can already feel the wolf twisting and clawing its way out of her body. She does her best to keep it at bay as long as possible. However, that is a problem when your sister has hunted you down.

Adora struggles to dodge her sister’s attacks. Already her back *bleeds.* Her shirt has been torn open and skin now is shredded from the surprise attack from the changing werepanther. Her legs shake from fright and what is about to come bursting from her body.

“Catra, what the hell are you doing?!?” Adora asks. She knows their mother must have sent her after her. Guess she wasn’t good enough with covering her tracks.

The thing she knows, pain radiates from her chin. More blood flows freely as she is pressed down hard against the ground.

“You left me!” Catra hisses through sharp teeth. “How could you abandon me!”

“I did not leave you!” Adora spats back, trying to believe her own words. With the full moon giving her the strength of many men,

she places sharpening hands on Catra's chest before shoving her off. Her sister yelps as she is flung through the air.

Adora lets out a pained groan, feeling the wolf inside of her clawing against her body even more. She can't let it take over. Not yet. Somehow, the blonde rises to her feet, shaking all the way up. Her own anger at her sister mixes in with the rage of the beast inside.

"You ran off without me!" Catra spats.

Even more fury flows through Adora at this comment. "I *asked* you to come and you didn't! You-ack!" Adora collapses to her knees as another wave of pain rolls over her. She hears Catra laughing a wicked cruel laugh. A cold shiver runs down her spine at the sound.

"Hey, Adora. You can't get away from what you are. A monster like me."

The rage builds further inside of her. With the final ounce of control, the blonde looks up to see her sister shifting into her own form. The last thought she has is wondering how the hell things got this bad with her sister.

Adora groans. Opening her eyes, she is immediately met with the harsh sting of sunlight. She winces, squeezing her eyes shut to rid herself of the pain. Once she feels like her retinas won't be burned, Adora cracks them open. Above her are birch trees. Their leaves dance in the soft breeze, causing the gaps of yellow lights between them to flicker.

Adora looks around, gathering her surroundings. The woods stretch on for miles and miles. There is no one in sight, not even any animals. Tattered clothing sticks to her body, as well as her intact bag. Moving, she realizes her back is sore.

"Fuck," Adora mumbles. The memory of her sister launching an attack, claws digging into her skin, hits her like a freight train.

Gingerly, she reaches up and touches the side of her face. Her wounds have already healed thanks to the shift, however, it is not a smooth one. Beneath her fingertips is a set of itchy, jagged skin. If the pain from her back is any indication, those wounds have stitched up just the same.

Adora remains on the ground, staring up at the canopy. Whatever has happened to her sister during the night is a mystery. Hopefully she, and their mother, are not lingering around. The more distance she puts between them, the better. But, despite this, the feeling in her chest is the same one she has had for several years.

That Adora is all alone.

Chapter End Notes

comments and kudos appreciated and happy new year!

Aches

Chapter Notes

> Hey back a little early lmao. Yeah i said fuck it and I didn't want to end on a cliffhanger for this next batch so you all will get 3 chapters this round. yeah its shorter but I am back sooner.
>
> anyway uhhhh tw i can't think of much other than some breakdown and just EMOTIONS

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer keeps her head in her hands. She does her best to process everything that has been said, everything that still hangs in the air. Adora's life has been put on full display for everyone to know. The pained and shaking voice of her girlfriend whenever she spoke on something heartwrenching continues to ring in her ears. How Adora did not crack at all, did not cry while retelling her life, Glimmer has no idea.

No one says anything. Silence hangs everyone's heads, waiting for the being who dares to break it first. Glimmer hears the shifting of boards of uncertainty. The hunter has no idea how to feel, how to respond to everything she has been told. No wonder why Adora never spoke about her past before. Knowing what her mother and sister did boils her blood. Having Catra here now does little to help.

Slowly, Glimmer lifts her head up. Bow shifts on his feet, unsure. Catra remains on the couch, eyes looking away from everyone. Meanwhile, Adora is hunched over. One hand rests on her forehead while her hair and bangs cover the rest of her face. Glimmer can see how tight Adora is holding her body. Can see how *hard* she is trying not to tremble.

"Well…" Catra clears her throat, "that about sums it up. Mom was a bitch."

Glimmer shoots her a glare. Though, with her eyes still diverted, Catra most likely does not see it.

"So she has killed before," Bow pipes up.

"Yes. Once Adora left, she started to pick up a few more kills before she got fucked up by this one's mom," Catra points at Glimmer. "Did she ever tell you how one fucks up a werecreature like that?"

"No," Glimmer bluntly says. "I have no idea what she did. How can I when she's *dead* ?"

"Right…Well, it is her. I guess she has healed enough to start killing again. I don't know what she is fully planning, what she is going to do in the end, but I know it isn't going to be pretty."

Glimmer turns back to Adora. Her girlfriend has not moved a *centimeter.* She remains still as a statue. The hunter sighs before setting her sights back on Catra. This has gone on long enough. "I think that is enough for today. We've heard enough."

"You sure? Don't want anything else from me?" Catra's eyes finally meet Glimmer's.

"I'm sure. Even though I would like to strangle you, I won't. But if you want our trust, I would suggest leaving."

Catra huffs before jumping to her feet. "Tck. Alright. I'm going to be lurking around town for a bit. Got a place to stay so if you need me for anything else, I'll be close."

Out of the corner of her eye, Glimmer sees Adora become even *tenser.* Bow takes a step closer to everyone. "I'll walk you out."

Catra looks far from pleased at this but she doesn't protest. *Good call,* Glimmer tells herself.

Though, without warning, as Catra and Bow draw close to the door, Adora's voice fills the air once more. It's strained. "Cat...I

have a question.”

“Adora?” Glimmer places a hand on her girlfriend’s back. She still remains unable to read, let alone *see,* the blonde’s face.

“What is it?” Catra asks, pausing in her tracks.

Adora takes a deep, shaking breath. "What...What did you do the month after Mom k-killed Angella?"

Glimmer’s eyes go wide. She had forgotten all about what happened to her shortly after the death of her mother. With so much information getting thrown at her in such a short time, it became buried under it all. The hunter looks up at the werepanther, staring right into her dual eyes.

Catra chews on the bottom of her lip. “Guess that jig is up.”

“ *You* attacked me?” Glimmer holds back the growl in the back of her throat. “What the fuck did you do that for?”

“Like mother, like daughter. You were about to get your nose in places it doesn’t belong. I tried warning you about meddling with things.”

Is that what she was saying? “Well, thanks for almost killing me. What the hell were you doing beforehand?”

Catra gives a small shrug. “Wandering around, making sure no one was after Mom. Was thinking about leaving her also.”

“You weren’t licking your paws or anything were you?”

“I don’t know! It was years ago! Why?”

“Nothing.”

“Weirdo.”

Catra leaves the house. The moment the door clicks shut, the moment the werepanther is out of view, Adora cups both her

hands over her face.

" *Fuck!"* Adora shouts, her voice harsh and muffled.

Glimmer quickly kneels in front of her girlfriend. "Love?"

Adora is suddenly on her feet. She begins pacing around the living room. The air becomes tense around her. Hair continues to block much of her face, only revealing her tight jaw. Hands are clenched into fist again, the bandages turning even redder.

"Why the hell is she back! Why does it have to be Mom! Of all people! *God fuckin' damn it!"*

"I don't know, Adora, I don't know." Glimmer says.

"Why did she come *here!* Why did she track me down! Why of all times, *now!"*

"Adora-"

"How are you so calm right now!" Adora snaps. She finally looks up. Her eyes are puffy and red, her blue irises swimming under tears. They stain her cheeks with their salt. "My mother killed *your* mother! My sister nearly killed *you!* My family…" Adora begins to choke.

Glimmer takes a step forward, fingers wrapping around Adora's wrist. "I'm *not."* she croaks out. Glimmer's sights become blurred with tears. After all this time, so many sleepless nights of wondering what happened to her mother, the answer has now fallen straight into her lap. However, in the worst way possible. Of all the people it could have been, how and why on earth did it have to be those that caused so much hurt and strife to Adora?

Adora lowers her shoulders. She begins to look like a small, small child. Like she is five all over again. Her voice quivers as she speaks, " *I* hurt you in the summer! My whole family...We all hurt you and your family. I'm so sorry! If-If I had stayed there m-maybe..."

“There is nothing you could have done. None of that was your fault.” Bow steps forward, closing the gap between him and his friends. “And if you never left, you’d never have come here, right?”

"He's right. There isn't anything you could have done different. You did the right thing leaving. It's okay."

Glimmer wraps her arms around Adora, holding her tight. The blonde immediately buries her face into the crook of her girlfriend's face, tears following even more. Legs can no longer bear Adora's weight. They collapse right under her. The hunter stumbles for a moment before guiding her and a shaking Adora to the ground.

Bow joins his friends on the ground, wrapping his arms around both of them and squeezing them tight. Glimmer lets herself cry in the arms of her loved ones. She lets the waves of emotions—the relief of *finally* knowing who caused the death of her mother and the bitterness that comes with it—roll over her.

She lets herself crack.

Glimmer stares at her pale ceiling. Tonight, sleep is a mystery. A thing that is nothing more than a foreign entity. Outside, she hears the whistle of wind as it flows through the lifeless tree branches. Inside, she hears the heat being pumped into her bedroom. As well as, the breathing of Adora besides her. The blonde has her back turned, body curled up under the covers. But the near quiet noises that come out of Adora are not her typical soft ones of sleep. Honestly, Glimmer would be *shocked* if her girlfriend could be sleeping right now.

The hunter thinks of everything that was thrown at her face earlier in the day. Seeing Adora’s sister for the first time. She’s a lot scraper than Glimmer thought she’d be. Being told it was her girlfriend’s mother that took the life of her own mother. That Angella injured her enough to take her out of commission for a

while. Glimmer thinks back to the map Petra showed all those months ago. How long of a gap between attacks was it again? What did her mother do to Shadow Weaver?

A hand finds its way to her stomach. So a werepanther's power really does flow through her. Glimmer is grateful she didn't get a hankering for fish. That's not really something she would want to be eating all the time. If she is being honest, she is a *little* grateful that Catra gave her some powers. Definitely helps her out in a pinch. But that 'thanks' only extends so far.

But what about Adora? Telling of so many horrors of her life. The faint memories of her getting bit and being taken in by her adoptive mother. Being kept away from so many and those moments she couldn't keep the wolf inside of her. Finally getting the courage to leave only to be assaulted by someone you grew up with side by side. So many years of lies and abuse. It makes Glimmer sick to her stomach.

Glimmer rolls onto side, propping herself up on an elbow. Adora remains as she has been. Back turned. The hunter takes a sigh before saying, "I know you're awake."

Adora lets out a small grunt.

"Can't sleep either, huh? Is there anything you want to talk about?"

This finally gets Adora to flip onto her back. Eyes remain turned upward, staring at the same area as Glimmer before. "What the heck is there to talk about? Don't really want to think about what we have to do."

"That's fair. Way too late for that." Though that doesn't stop Glimmer's mind from wandering. She doesn't know what exactly to do. Even if Catra was not the one to end her mother's life, she still has blood on her hands. She still was there watching Angella take her final breaths of life.

But...she is the only one who can help them get close to the true killer. The sole being she has been searching for for about two years now.

She shakes her head. She needs to find something else to think about. "I don't know what or if there is really anything to talk about. There was so much with your sister and your mother and-"

Glimmer suddenly shoots up straight, spooking Adora. As the hunter scrambles out of bed, her girlfriend sits up, shouting, "Glim? What the hell?"

"I just remembered something!" Glimmer runs her fingers against a small set of books on her dresser. "You said your Mom had a book written in another language. One that had what looked like the 'pi' symbol?"

"Yeah?"

"Can you remember—did any look like a horseshoe?"

She hears Adora clicking her tongue in thought. "I *think* so? It's been years! I can't really remember. Why?"

"Ah! Found it!" Glimmer snatches an old children's book. She takes quick, long strides to the bed, hopping right onto the mattress. "I think I know what it was. Or at least, the language and photo you saw. Soot over a little."

Adora does as she is told. Glimmer presses herself right up against her girlfriend. She runs a fingernail at the edges of the book until she finds what she is looking for. The hunter lies the now open book flat on her lap.

On one page, a whole image takes up the sheet. No colors other than black and white are in the picture. Multiple figures are shown, one of which looks to have a wolf's head. Sure enough, in the background, it looks as if a building has been set blazed.

"Is this what you saw?" Glimmer asks.

Adora takes the book from her hands, bringing it close to her face. She squints her eyes, studying every inch of the photo. The moment Glimmer sees a twinkle of recognition, she knows she's right.

"What even is this?" Adora asks, handing the book back.

"This is a children's book my mom used to read to me. It tells the story of King Lycaon."

"Lycaon?" Adora blinks in surprise.

"Hm. It's where we get Lycanthropy from. The sparknotes version is he pissed off Zeus and Zeus turned him and his sons into wolves. It's the legend of how werecreatures came to be. They all came from werewolves." Glimmer flips through the pages, searching for what she needs. She ends up skipping it by mistake but quickly back tracks.

Staring up at her now is a small little diagram. At the top is a werewolf. Arrows spread out into other different types of werecreatures. Glimmer continues her speech. "As the legend goes, all the children of those cursed were born as werewolves. And of course, when they bit people they turned. However, and this still is true today, sometimes when someone gets bit there is a chance they turn into a different werecreature. So after many millennia, that's how we have so many different types running around."

"Huh. I didn't know that. So, what does this have to do with my mother?"

"Well, it's a Greek myth. I don't know if there *is* a connection but who knows. Your mother had something about it, right? If you want to look at it, here ya go."

Adora takes the book back, flicking through the pages. Glimmer leans forward, resting her head on a hand as she watches her girlfriend learn more about herself. "Ya know, we hunters kind of got our name from Greek mythology and 'cuz of Lycaon."

“How so?” Adora asks, not taking her eyes from the book. She is currently on the page about the uses of wolfsbane.

“Well, we did start off as just hunters. Since we were the ones with weapons, when Lycaon and others would attack for no reason. A lot of time it was just plain hunters who protected others. Lot of them used to look up to the Greek goddess Artemis. Over time, as people actually learned and started to do things to protect humans and later help non-humans, the name just stuck.”

“Interesting.” Adora snaps the book shut before setting it aside. “I keep learning new stuff about myself. I wonder if those books my mom had more information. No wonder why she had it in a different language. Kept me from learning anything.”

Glimmer gives her a little nudge. “We learn together. I still don’t know everything so I am just as lost as you sometimes.”

Adora flops back down on the bed, one arm draped over her forehead. "Blind leading the blind. Yet our only source of light is from the worst person." She shuts her eyes and out a heavy, long sigh. "I'm going to try and sleep again. Do you want to join me?"

"I'm okay right now," Glimmer replies. She grabs her girlfriend's free hand and places a small peck against her palm. "You know me."

"Okay. Wake me if you need anything. Got it?"

"Got it."

Glimmer turns her attention towards the window of her room. Shades block out most of the moonlight, only small streams seep through the cracks. The woods remain hidden from sight, keeping secrets within. Glimmer squeezes the sheets beneath her.

Is one of said secrets keeping Shadow Weaver hidden?

She tries to be as secretive as possible. She tries focusing all her hearing on her friends. Nothing. Adora is keeping her and Bow's voices as low as possible. Glimmer attempts to look over her shoulder when she can, hoping to sneak a glance. However, the pair of friends have ensured to keep whatever they are doing a secret.

Glimmer huffs, turning her attention back to cooking her lunch. She has a feeling she knows *exactly* what those two are up to. After all, her birthday is only a couple days away. Why else would they be acting so hush-hush around her lately? Hopefully, they aren't planning anything too wild. There has been far too much excitement as of late. She really doesn't want more.

Glimmer brings the wooden spoon to her soup. Homemade chicken noodle soup. Her mother's recipe. Not quite done yet. Almost. Hopefully that is true since her stomach is growling like crazy at the moment. Guess this is what she gets for waking up late and not getting breakfast.

She attempts again to listen in to Adora's and Bow's chatter. The only thing that fills her ears are whispers. The type you cannot distinguish at all. At this pitch, it is quite annoying. Glimmer quickly tunes it out, not wanting it to feel like someone is scratching their nails on a chalkboard right besides her.

Thankfully, something else grabs her attention. Her phone begins to vibrate, screen becoming lit up with a message. Glimmer snatches her phone and quickly unlocks it. Petra has finally gotten back to her. The hunter has given the werebear some of the information she has recently learned. Though, the short version. Telling them who Shadow Weaver is and, with Adora's permission, who the source was. The fact that Adora is related to either of them has been left out completely.

Thankfully, Petra does not ask if they know anything more about Shadow Weaver or Catra. They are simply relieved to finally have a name.

"Soup's almost done if you guys want any!" Glimmer shouts at the others.

"Thanks!" Both say together.

Bow, for a moment, pops his head up. "Smells great, Glim!"

Glimmer turns back around, ready to send a text asking g how Petra is doing. Before she can, she notices the three dots of Petra typing away. The hunter raises an eyebrow, wondering what she could be typing. For a moment, she has to look away to stop her soup from boiling. Once she looks back at her phone, she notices the new message.

Are you guys going to be seeing this Catra person more?

“Ah, fuck,” Glimmer mumbles.

She pinches the bridge of her nose and takes a breath. That topic has yet to be discussed. Catra appearance only the other day still hangs in the air, waiting to be spoken more on. The thought twists her stomach into a tight knot. Thank god for her soup choice right now. She doesn't think she would be able to hold anything else. Glimmer really doesn’t want to think about asking Catra for any more help.

But what choice is there? She has not waited *this* long to find out what happened to her mother just to let it slip from her grasp. Catra is a stepping stone, a *tool she* could use to reach her goal. If the werepanther truly wants to help, that she will listen to whatever they have to say, that is of great use. And if she does any shit, she has a whole arsenal at her disposal and a crap ton of knowledge to stop her with.

But there is something that tugs at her heart, making her stop in her tracks.

Glimmer takes a breath and pours herself the finished soup and covers the pot for later. “I’m coming over you two! I need to sit!”

There is a shuffling, papers being shoved away and pens and pencils being collected together. Glimmer waits for them to finish, rocking on her heels and humming a tune. She lets the heat from the soup seep from into her hands. Once she gets a thumbs up from Adora and Bow, the hunter plops down on the couch.

“Where the hell did you put everything?” she asks as she looks at the near immaculate table top.

“That’s our secret.” Bow smirks.

“Course it is.”

“I’m going to get a bowl. Bow, you want one?” Adora asks as she jumps to her feet.

“In a little bit. Don’t worry.” he replies.

Glimmer lets herself soak in the warmth for several more seconds before beginning to sip it out. Nowhere as perfect as what her mother used to make but she likes to think she is improving. Adora soon reappears with her own steaming bowl in hand. The blonde smiles as she settles down on the ground.

Glimmer's hands grip the bowl tight in her hands. Adora goes on about her and Glimmer’s upcoming double date with Perfuma and Scorpia. Her eyes are bright as ever with the excitement of tomorrow. How can she shatter this happiness her girlfriend is showing right now? How can she remind her of how her past is lurking within the place she now calls home? But how can she leave this to be brushed aside and forgotten about either. Neither option is good…

Glimmer bites her lower lip. Bites back the words crawling up her throat. But this dam cannot last.

“Adora,” Glimmer starts, rolling the bowl in her hands.

“What’s up, Glitter-bug?” Adora chuckles from a joke.

Where do I start? "Was talking to Petra a little bit."

"Oh yeah, how is she?"

"Didn't get a chance to ask but I think she's fine. She did ask something though."

"What?"

Fuck me. "They asked about Catra. Asked if we were going to talk to her more."

The wide, bright smile on Adora's face fades from existence. Her sky blue eyes turn dark. "Oh."

"You know we have to figure this out. We cannot not talk about it!"

"Are you considering actually letting her help us?!?"

"Yes! What else are we supposed to do?!? Just stay blind in all of this?!?"

"No! But you know what she has done!"

"Yeah I do! I got the scars to prove it!"

Adora suddenly is on her feet. Nostrils are flared and teeth are bare. "She could be tricking us for all we know!"

Glimmer stands as well, not deterred in the slightest at the height of her girlfriend. "I know that! But what if she is not?!? What then! We can't let more people die!"

"I know that! But we can't trust her!"

Both their voices have raised into shouts. Neither wants to back down. Their shoulders remain tight as each stands as tall as possible. Hands have turned into fist as they stare each other down.

Bow appears in front of them, one hand on each of their chest.est. “Hey! Easy! There’s no need to fight!”

“I don’t trust her not to just backstab me and hurt me again!” Adora says in a low growl.

“We have no choice,” Glimmer snaps back.

Adora huffs, her body refusing to loosen. She snatches her bowl from the table. “I’m going to my room.”

Adora storms off, disappearing into the lower bedroom. The door slams behind her. Glimmer herself lets out a frustrated growl before falling back down on the couch. Hands cover her face as she feels her anger turn into bright embers, waiting to be relit. However, something else begins to fill her body. Starting at the center of her chest is the pain of regret.

“Glim?” Bow says.

“I fucked that up.”

“Was that your guys’ first fight?”

Glimmer lifts her head from her hands. She pushes rests back against the back cushions of the couch. “Yeah. God, we have to do something about Catra. How else are we supposed to figure out what the fuck to do with Shadow Weaver!”

“You probably need some space right now. That’s what Perfuma and I did whenever we got into an argument.”

Glimmer does not give him an answer. She stares at the growing cold soup. Her appetite has disappeared. For a moment, the hunter looks at the shut door, wondering if it has been locked.

Adora chews on the string of her hoodie. Half of it is in her mouth as her nerves run wild. You’d think with how well she knows Scorpia and Perfuma, she’d be calm. You’d think that she is

tapping her foot a mile a minute because of their lateness, even minor, simply throwing her off. No, it's none of that.

She flicks her eyes to the side. Standing besides her, back resting against the stone building, Glimmer keeps her gaze fixated on the people walking by. Though, even then there is a fog covering her eyes.

Neither have said much since their spat yesterday. Adora spent most of her time in her room both out of shimmering anger and out of unknown fear. Hearing Glimmer's voice raise, hearing her *own* voice raise, yesterday still sends shivers down her spine. How long did it take for her to settle her breathing down when she bolted into her room? How many angry and loud memories entered her mind during that time?

Adora is at a loss. What do you do when you get into a fight like this? With the person you love with all your heart? Waiting it out for both of them not to be in a bad mood probably isn't a good idea. It doesn't *seem* like Glimmer is pissy but the fear of being lashed out freezes her in place.

She kicks herself for thinking that but her brain is being relentless. On top of all this, there is something eating away at her chest—at her *heart.* She hates Catra. The fact she has appeared back in her life is as if a hurricane has blown through. But Glimmer is right. She is the *only* link they have to Shadow Weaver. To solve and end this goddamn nightmare. Ending this will be some sort of closure to Angella's death. If Adora could take away her girlfriend's pain she absolutely would.

Why did it have to take the form of *Catra?*

With any luck, Scorpia and Perfuma will be here any minute to give her distractions.

Adora takes a deep breath, forgetting she has half a string in her mouth. It goes straight down her throat. Her gag reflex kicks in immediately. She gags and coughs, gasping for some semblance

of air, before the string flops back down on her chest. Thanks, in part, from Glimmer grabbing the string with a finger.

“Are you okay?!?” Glimmer asks. A hand finds Adora’s back.

“F-Fine!” the blonde wheezes between coughs. “I didn’t expect that.”

“What the hell were you thinking about?!?”

“I, uh…” Adora chews on her lip for a moment. “Nothing. I just was spacing out.”

Glimmer’s hand moves in slow circles. “You sure?”

“Yeah, I am.” Something catches her eye. “I think I see them.”

Glimmer looks over her shoulder. Sure enough, Scorpia and Perfuma appear walking down the sidewalk. When the other pair sees them, they give a wave. Adora and Glimmer return the gesture. The blonde straightens herself up.

“Hope we didn’t keep you long.” Perfuma says.

“Nah, you are fine.” Adora replies.

The four begin to walk down the sidewalk. They weave past other groups walking by, some surely starting to get ready for the quickly approaching holiday season. In the windows of stores people are already either putting up trees or menorahs or lights to match the colors of the holidays. Through the sea of chatter and vehicles both large and small whizzing by, Adora can hear someone playing some music matching the season already.

The friends chatter, using mostly small talk at the moment. Anything that they want to get off their chest, that they wish to discuss, have to wait. Not until they get to the less populated area of the city. Adora is happy about it. The longer they remain in the heart, the better. But sometimes slowly ripping off a bandaid is more painful than doing it in one, swift go.

Try as she might to get her mind off of things, as the crowds slowly thin out, Adora's heart begins doing laps inside her chest. Hands stuffed into pockets become sweaty. No matter how hard Adora tries to focus on something else, the thought of what's to come only grows stronger and stronger. Oh, how she wishes to curl back up in her bed and pretend none of this has happened.

They soon reach not only a quieter part of town but an area more populated by non-humans. More freedom to speak. More for anxiety to be shot straight through Adora's veins. She buries her face into the collar of her hoodie. Her brain screams so loudly that she can barely form any sentences, let alone words.

Scorpia is the first to change the topic. "So we have been able to do some digging."

"Oh?" Glimmer starts. "What did ya guys find?"

Perfuma digs through her bag before pulling out a few pieces of paper. She reads as they continue to walk down the sidewalk. "Remember how a while back there was a fatal animal attack? Honestly I thought it was just that since it was a regular human. But looking more into it, it was on a full moon."

"Of course it was…" Glimmer grumbles.

Perfuma continues. "So I think you know where I am going with this. There was a gap between the attacks, right? Well the second round, it seems it started earlier than we expected."

"Maybe a test run? Catra did say Shadow Weaver was hurt by my mom beforehand."

"Oh right, tell us more about that."

Adora groans internally. The urge to chew on something grows. From string to collar, by the time this day ends, her hoodie is gonna need a hell of a wash.

Just like with Petra, the pair have informed the others of what they can and what Adora chose to reveal of her past life. But things can never be as easy as saying something and being done with.

"We are trying to figure out what to do about Catra," Glimmer states.

"What do you mean?" Scorpia innocently asks.

"She means I hate Catra for everything she did and I don't really want her around," Adora says, pulling her head out from her hoodie.

"And I mean we still should let her help in some way. We can't just go blind!" Glimmer quickly shoots back. "I don't want anyone else to be killed by Shadow Weaver!"

"I get that! I don't want that either but I don't want Catra to hurt anyone else or you again!"

Perfuma suddenly is between them. "Both of you need to keep your voices down," she hisses.

Both Adora and Glimmer turn their heads away from each other. The few people roaming around have pause in their trek and stare at the group. There are at least a couple kids looking at them with confused expressions on their faces.

Adora feels a bottle, filled with a number of emotions, shatter and explode. The anger from the day before, frustration over being stuck between a rock and a hard place, and hatred that the people she has desperately tried to put and keep in her past have come barging right back.

She lets out a small growl before spinning on her heels.

"Where are you going?!?" Glimmer asks.

"I need to be alone!" Adora snaps back. She doesn't want to face her girlfriend. She doesn't want to let this anger seeping off of her go towards the wrong person. "Don't follow me!"

She doesn't hear anyone following. Regardless, Adora picks up her pace, putting as much room between her and the others as quickly as possible.

Adora holds her legs tight against her chest. Her hoodie conceals much of her body and once again, the string is back in her mouth. She stares out at the large pond at a nearby park. The light dances against the blue water. In the distance, she spots a bird slowly moving around. It moves its head and lets out a long, haunting call. Squinting, she realizes it’s a common loon.

She shifts her weight, finding a new comfortable place against the wooden deck she finds herself on. Thankfully, the park isn’t that crowded today. No one should be bothering her. She can stay alone.

All the anger from before has disappeared. Evaporated. All that is left is a cold, heaviness in the center of her chest. If she were to slip and fall into the waters below, that weight alone would be enough to drown her. Adora just wishes she knew what to do. That she didn’t feel so lost and so alone.

...She wishes she was with Glimmer right now.

As much as Adora wishes never to see her sister again, as much as she wishes this all was just a nightmare, what’s happened has happened. There is no turning back the clock now. Catra is here now and has the long sought after information she and Glimmer need. She is the one that could help bring down Shadow Weaver. Or...she could bring them right *to* her.

Adora wants to protect Glimmer at all costs. After everything she has suffered through, she doesn’t need more. But she also deserves to finally be at ease with the death of her mother.

“Is this seat taken?”

Adora turns her head enough to see Scorpia has appeared a couple steps behind her.

“No.” Adora replies, the string still in her mouth.

Scorpia settles down right by her. Neither say any. Instead, they let the sounds of the loon and other birds fill the air. Adora watches some ducks skid across the water before coming to a stop. The boards continue to creek under shifting weight. After a while, Adora finally breaks the silence between the two.

“Where’s Glimmer?”

“She went to blow off steam also,” Scorpia answers. “Perfuma and I talked and we decided to track the two of you down. ‘Fuma is looking for Glim right now. Don’t worry.”

“That’s good.”

“She did tell us something before she stormed off. Catra is your sister?”

“Unfortunately.”

“That sounds rough. That’s all she said, by the way, didn’t elaborate. And I won’t ask. However, I will say it’s not fun watching you two fight.”

Adora pushes her arms through the correct holes and leans back against the deck. “Tell me about it. I don’t like fighting, it’s never been fun with anyone. What do you and Perfuma do if or when you guys get into one yourselves?”

“We figure it out. A disagreement can’t break us apart that easily.”

Adora sighs through her nose. “I really hope that doesn’t happen with us. All of this is so confusing and I feel like I am being torn

apart. I want to stop Shadow Weaver just as much as she does but...I just *hate* how it has to be done.

"I don't want Glimmer to be mad at me and I don't want to be mad at her."

Scorpia lifts up her hands. Prosthetics go half way up her forearm. "You know I wasn't born like this. It was a freak accident when I was a teenager."

"O-Oh...I didn't know that. I'm sorry."

"It's alright. Anyway, it took some time to get used to it and these as well. But of course, people started to judge me differently. Sometimes gave me weird looks or saw me as something else. I was worried for a while that no one would treat me as *me.* As a human who just was a little different.

"Eventually, though, I met Perfuma. I didn't know she was a faery until later. But that didn't matter and it didn't matter that I had prosthetics and sometimes needed help. She didn't care and treated me like she would anyone else. Honestly made me fall even more in love with her."

Scorpia leans back against the deck as well. Dark eyes stare out into the shimmering water and there is a soft smile on her face as she talks about her girlfriend. "I have phantom pains sometimes and Perfuma does what she can to help me with that. We lean on each other. Both of us come from different worlds. She's a non-human and I am a human. We don't always agree on things nor understand each other. But, that doesn't matter. At the end of the day, no matter what, we always find a way back to each other. Our paths never stray far."

She turns her attention to Adora. "I believe in the same for you and Glimmer. There's nothing to worry about. If something like this ruins your relationship, well I better be on the lookout for flying pigs."

Adora can't help but snort. "Thanks, Scorpia."

“Feeling any better?”

“Slightly.” The heaviness still rests against her chest, threatening to drown her if she is not careful. But there is a sliver of light in that darkness. Arms, though, snake back around her legs. “I still dunno if I want to go back right now.”

“You don’t mind me staying, do you?”

“Not at all.”

Glimmer sips down the tea. Just like with her coffee, she doesn't care if the hot water burns her throat. She wants the calming herbs in her now. Though, they seem to have little effect right now.

"You can't do any magic on this?" Glimmer groans. She places her hand and cup down a bit *too* hard on the table.

"No." Perfuma states. "Just because tea has plants in it doesn't mean I can do anything once it's made."

Another groan. Glimmer runs her hands down her face. “I don’t know what to do, ‘Fuma. Catra coming to the house has been like a powder keg has exploded. You should have seen how broken Adora was after Catra left.”

“And she’s the only one who can help us with this whole situation. This is a heck of a curve ball.”

“I don’t want to see her like that again. She doesn’t deserve it—none of this! But what are we supposed to do?!?"

She takes another swing of her tea, finishing it off. Glimmer twists her wrist, letting the last drops of her drink move around the bottom. She debates getting another cup but from the look of her friend’s face, getting a fifth one is not a good idea.

“Do you and Scorpia fight?”

“We have our disagreements. First one’s always rough, though.”

Glimmer rests her chin against the table. “What do I do?”

“Time and space.”

Glimmer lets out a long sigh. Perfuma drums her fingers against the table. With her other hand, she picks at the muffin she already has half eaten. Finally, she figures out what to say.

“You know after Bow and I broke up, I felt a bit lost. Didn’t know what to do. Sure, it was amicable but it still sucked. We were together for a while. Got kind of depressed. You remember how I was.”

“Both of you, I do,” Glimmer admits. She recalls how both her friends were not themselves. A weight was on both their shoulders, their eyes dimmer, and their smiles less vibrant. It took time for that to return.

“Well, one day I met Scorpia. Just by chance. She started to come to the store more and more. And, well, got me to smile more and more. Really got me out of the dumps. Made me feel happy again. Now, I can’t imagine my life without her. I trust her with my life. Hell, afterall, she knows who and what I am and our whole world. She knows how to make me laugh and feel better after a terrible day.

“Not saying Bow wasn’t any of those things. I just know in my heart, she is the one and I love her no matter what, even if we don’t always see eye-to-eye.”

Perfuma rests a head on her hand and gives Glimmer a look. Eyebrows raise, a small smirk on her face, and a gleam in her eyes. “You know what I mean?”

Glimmer chuckles, pulling herself off of the table. “I do.” she softly replies. “Do you really think that?”

"I do. You guys will pull through. There is a lot going on and you two are dealing with so much. Trust me, you two just need a little space."

"Thanks. I hope you are right."

Perfuma reaches a hand out and places it against Glimmer's. "How about we stop at my place and I can whip you up some of my tea. Would you like that?"

"I would love that."

Glimmer hates being up this early. Her body begs to rest more and not roll out of bed until almost noon. Yet, her mind refuses to listen. Up all night it has been, just like the day before. And of course, there is the fact that the other side of her bed is cold again. That doesn't help in the slightest. Though, thankfully any tension there was between them was gone upon returning home. However, it was replaced by awkwardness.

So here Glimmer finds herself. In her pajama tank and shorts, waiting for the coffee to *finally* finish. Every now and again, while pacing around, she takes a look at Adora's room. The door is cracked open, yet no noise emanates out of it. Surely, her girlfriend would be up by now. Though, who could blame her for not wanting to get out of bed.

The hunter bites down on her thumb, wondering if she should go in and check. Even if things have calmed down between them, is there a chance something might spark shit up all over again? But didn't she herself say to Adora things can't be left unsaid? Why do fights have to suck so much?

Glimmer looks back at the coffee pot. It is taking its sweet ass time. *Fuck it!* The hunter bites back all her worry and pushes open the bedroom door. "Adora, can we-"

The room is empty. The bed is unmade, blankets wrinkled on all sides. Glimmer steps further in. Even the bathroom, it's door wide

open, is devoid of any life. Where the hell could Adora be? Glimmer takes a moment to think before. One idea pops into her head.

She heads out of the bedroom, through the living, and exits into the outside world. Glimmer shivers as the cold air blows against her exposed skin. Looking around, there are no signs of Adora out on the front deck. The hunter says fuck it and begins to walk around her house. Thankfully, her search pays off. She pauses in her tracks upon seeing Adora.

Her girlfriend sits facing the woods. Almost all of the leaves have finally fallen, leaving everything barren. Adora herself has her legs pulled up to her chest and keeps her eyes looking out in front of her. At the moment, her mouth is free of her jacket's string.

Glimmer says nothing as she strolls over to Adora. Instead of taking her place besides her, the hunter opts to settle right behind. Backs press up against each other as the two sit in silence. This early in the morning, blue still struggles to push out the orange from the sky. The songs of birds mix together, becoming hard to tell one from the other. Not that Glimmer knows any bird songs anyway.

Adora slowly pushes herself backwards. "How are you up at this hour?"

Glimmer returns the gesture. "Couldn't sleep. Did you have any luck?"

"Nah. Thought I'd come out here for a bit. Sunrises are always nice to watch."

"I gotta see more of them."

"You know that means getting up *before* them right?"

"Fuck me. I'll stick to sunsets then."

Adora burst out laughing. Several snorts accompany her chuckles. A warm sensation forms in the center of Glimmer's chest and spreads all throughout her body. She almost forgot how wonderful it sounds. Pure music to her ears. And, it is super infectious. The hunter can not help but giggle as well.

"Maybe one day I'll wake up with you to see them. I promise," Glimmer says.

"I am gonna hold you to that," Adora replies. As the laughter dies down, the blonde lets out a soft sigh through her nose. "I'm sorry."

"I'm sorry, too. I shouldn't've yelled."

"And I should not have gotten so angry at you. Cause I'm not. I'm pissed off at everything else."

"I get that, Adora. I feel the same way."

Glimmer feels a hand land on top of hers. It's rough but no matter what, there is always a warmth to them. Her girlfriend gives a small squeeze as she continues to speak. "What are we going to do, Glim?"

"I don't know. We don't have a lot of options."

"I really don't want to see her again."

"You know, I can always see her alone."

Glimmer feels Adora's body going tense. "I don't want you to get hurt again. I don't like the idea of her being alone with someone, especially you."

"And I don't want to see you so upset again. That's not fair to you."

"Christ, I hate this."

Adora suddenly removes her hand as well as her back. Glimmer peers over her shoulder to see her girlfriend spinning around. The hunter copies her. Soft lilac eyes find bright sky blue eyes. There is tiredness in Adora's eyes, a feeling Glimmer knows all too well. She lifts up a hand, letting it hover near her girlfriend's face. Once permission is given, Glimmer places it on Adora's cheek.

"I want to be there for you if you talk to her. I won't let her hurt you again," Adora says.

"How do you think I feel? Look at you." Glimmer brushes a thumb against Adora's warm cheeks. The single drop of tear that has rolled down her face now is gone. "You don't have to do that."

"I want to!"

"Do you?" Glimmer asks. "I sure don't want to talk to her."

Adora leans her head against Glimmer's palm. "What about…I go only if I feel like it? Like, when I don't want to murder her as much?"

"That sounds like an idea. And I have plenty of things to protect me if things go south. You also can stay close by like in the car if I need you."

"I like that idea."

Glimmer grins. A start's a start. She removes her hand and leans forward. Her lips lock against Adora, taking in every ounce of her girlfriend's being. The blonde wraps her arms around the smaller woman, pulling her as close as possible. Glimmer forgot how warm Adora can be even as the weather struggles to creep above freezing. With only her pajamas on, the hunter leans against her girlfriend as best she can.

When they break for air, Glimmer rests her head against the crook of Adora's neck. She is unable to hold back a shiver as her body begins to freeze.

“You get after me for not wearing anything in the cold?” Adora jokes, keeping her arms around Glimmer.

“S-Shut up,” Glimmer replies through chattering teeth. “I g-got c-coffee waiting for m-me inside!”

“Then let’s go get it!” Adora chirps. In one swift motion, Adora is on her feet, cradling Glimmer. The hunter yelps in surprise as she swept off the ground.

“You don’t have to carry me!” Glimmer says.

“Are you really gonna complain about it?” Adora smirks. “You don’t like it?”

Glimmer rolls her eyes before wrapping her arms around the blonde’s neck. “‘Course not, you dork. Let’s go back inside. There should be enough coffee for you also.”

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos very much appreciated!!

Two Steps Foward, One Step Back

Chapter Notes

> another yea!!! uh tw for this chapter blood, mentions/hints of nudity, dead animal, panic attack--its a doozy
>
> edit: artwork in this chapter was made by Kaereth! A big shout out to them for doing this for a kofi

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The last breaths of autumn stand little chance against the cold fingers of winter. Frost stains the glass in icy patterns. As the sunlight seeps through, it brings out the artwork even more. The outside world is preparing for a flurry of snow set to appear in the afternoon. Trucks drive down the streets, letting salt fall against the black pavement. Others do the same to their driveways and steps.

Glimmer rolls onto her back. Eyes blink back the blur of sleep. She stares up at the ceiling, trying to summon the energy to pull herself out of bed. How she'd love to just stay in here, curled up under the covers, and return to her slumber. Her eyes do begin to flutter shut, they too wish not to do anything. But, a new smell slowly creeps into her nose. One that makes her mouth water. Eyes snap back open.

Slowly, she pushes herself up onto her arms. Glimmer looks towards her side. To no one's surprise, the other side of the bed is empty and cold. Adora has long since risen. But with a lake growing inside her mouth, the hunter has a feeling she knows *exactly* where her girlfriend is. The idea of sleeping until noon has been thrown clean from her mind as she jumps out of bed.

"Adora?" Glimmer says from the top of the staircase.

"Down here!" she hears her girlfriend say with a chirp in her voice. "Hurry up before your breakfast gets cold!"

“Give me a min!”

Glimmer quickly darts into the bathroom. Brushing her teeth and patting down some hair that stands up at attention. For good measure, she even splashes some cool water against her face. She hopes that she doesn’t look too much like shit. With a deep inhale, she begins her journey downstairs.

With every step down she takes, the stronger the scent grows in her nose. The scent of batter frying on a pan mixed in with strawberries. Her stomach begins to rumble with the thought of what her breakfast will be. The moment her feet land on the solid hardwood, she picks up her pace.

Adora stands in the kitchen, back facing Glimmer. The blonde is humming an unknown tune. A stack of pancakes sits beside her on the counter. Her stomach must be growling as loud as a werecreature as no other noise could have gotten her girlfriend’s attention. A bright smile is plastered from ear to ear on Adora’s face.

“Morning, Glitter-bug!”

“You better have made coffee also.”

Adora bursts out laughing. She points her battered spatula to the brewing coffeemaker. Through her chuckles she says, “Should be *just* about done. Sit. I’ll bring everything to you.”

“I can get the coffee myself.” Glimmer strolls over to the cabinets. She rummages around for her favorite mug. Fingers find what they are looking for. A near pitched black cup. It’s not much at first glance. But the moment she puts the steaming, hot coffee in, that is when the magic happens.

One by one, white specks appear on the surface. They almost glow against the dark background. Slowly, they begin to take the shapes of constellations. Big and little dippers. Orion. Lyra. Even her zodiac, Sagittarius. Finally, at the end, the outline of pine trees surround the bottom.

She glances towards the side. Of course, her girlfriend's eyes are wide and full of amazement. "I didn't know you could get a cup like that! That's so cool!"

"We gotta get you one then. They make a lot of different ones so I'm sure you can find one you like."

A small blush forms on Adora's face. Enough that along with the morning light, Glimmer can *just* make out the light freckling on her face. The hunter makes a mental note to bring those out more.

Adora clears her throat before speaking. "Enough about me. Today is your birthday, go sit."

"You don't have to do this, ya know."

"Well, you already do so much for me and it is *your* day. Go sit." Adora jabs her spatula in the center of her girlfriend's chest. "Don't make me make you."

Glimmer throws her hands in the air. "Fine! You win." She snatches her hot, steam cup. "Only because I haven't had my coffee yet."

Adora rolls her eyes before returning to finish her cooking. Glimmer takes several sips of her drink as she settles down on her chair. It does not take long for Adora to set the stack of strawberry pancakes down in front of her. It takes everything Glimmer not to immediately wolf down the food and eat it whole. Instead, she takes her time to savour every bite of the home cooked meal.

Adora quickly preps her own food. Just a simple batch of chocolate chip waffles. Glimmer purses her lips at the sight. She puts her own eating on hold. A fork stabs its way into an uncut pancake. The hunter uses her knife to push back some of her girlfriend's waffles, allowing just enough room for the pancake.

“You know I made them for you, right?” Adora says, raising an eyebrow.

“Yes but like you said, it is my day. And for my day, I want you to eat something a little less pathetic. No ifs, ands, or buts. Eat it.”

“You’re the boss.”

Adora begins to stuff her face. The moment she begins to chew on her own cooking, her eyes light up with wonder. She pauses to look at the small slice of pancake on her fork before shoving it in her mouth. Glimmer smiles from ear to ear at the sight. She returns to enjoying her own breakfast.

While eating, Adora begins to explain what she, and Bow, have planned today. Glimmer is not shocked at all to hear that her girlfriend and best friend have concocted something for her. At least, it isn’t something grand and blown out of proportion. All they have planned is to go over to Bow’s house and watch some movies. Apparently, he has a box waiting so all three can enjoy baking a cake together. There are a couple gifts waiting there also.

“You guys can be too much sometimes.” Glimmer sighs.

“You love us for it,” Adora hums.

“Dork.”

Adora beams from ear to ear before snatching the dirty plates off the table. “Tell me when you are ready to go. Bow already told me his address and I have it set in my phone so I’ll drive.”

“Driving me around and cooking for me? Man, I feel like a princess right now.”

Adora scoffs. “I was hoping to make you feel more like a queen today. Guess I should try harder.”

Glimmer chuckles. “Don’t. This is more than enough for me, Adora. Thank you.”

While Adora does the dishes (whistling a tune as she does so) Glimmer decides not to waste any more time. She pushes herself away from the table and heads back upstairs, hopping up the stairs two at a time. The moment she is back in her room, she begins pondering what to wear. Glimmer checks her phone for the temperature. It will remain below freezing for the rest of the week.

Best not to freeze to death. Glimmer throws open her closest. Fingers grab the least embarrassing sweater her aunt made for her. One that is a dark purple in color with the Mizari family crest on the left breast. The only other thing to note are the hints of stars on the cuffs of sleeves and the end of the sweater. If there is one thing that can always be guaranteed by her aunt’s handwork, it is that the clothing always is warm as hell.

Glimmer quickly pulls the slightly too big sweater over her head. Already, the warmth spreads throughout her body. She always forgets how comfortable they are. Glimmer is sure the next time she checks her mail, there will be yet another one. Hopefully, it’s one she can wear without becoming beet red.

Ready for the rest of the day, Glimmer makes her way back downstairs. Adora is typing away on her phone. When a board creaks under Glimmer’s foot, the blonde snaps her head up. “Oh? All ready?”

Glimmer gives a small nod. “Yeah. No point in waiting, right?”

“Can’t argue with that!” Adora quickly taps something into her phone before shoving it in her pocket. “Let’s get this party started!”

Glimmer shakes the box in her hand, hearing whatever is inside rattling about. This fails to create anything in her mind on what it

could be. Saying fuck it, she tears open the wrapping around the present. Glimmer tosses the box to the side. She peers inside, seeing what exactly Bow has gifted her.

"Oh, hey! Thanks, dude!" Glimmer reaches into the box and pulls out one of several bottles of cleaner for her gear. There even is a brand new rag. "I was running low! Hopefully this'll last a while."

"Figured you needed some more." Bow grins. He takes a moment to look over at the oven. With the timer broken, everyone must keep an eagle eye on the cake baking. Believing there is no need to get up, he looks back at his best friend. "Open up Adora's!"

She sees a small blush form on Adora's face as she pushes the wrapped up present forward. It's larger than Bow's and sure is heavier. There is no way to shake it and give her an idea of what it could be. Glimmer plops it in her lap. Like with the gift before, the hunter quickly rips it open to reveal what lies inside.

Her eyes go wide and she finds the breath in her lungs disappearing. Staring right up at her is a new pair of boots. Gingerly, she reaches in and pulls them out. Fingers brush against the smooth leather.

"I talked to Perfuma. She said you had eyed some boots a couple times you went into the store. With winter coming, and pretty fast it seems, I figured you could use it."

"It's perfect. Both of them. Thank you."

"Glad you like them." Adora pauses for a moment. She takes several sniffs of air. Eyes go wide as she snaps her head towards the direction of the oven. "Oh shit, I think the cake is about to burn."

"Wait what?" Bow jumps to his feet and begins racing over to the kitchen. "I don't smell anything!"

"I do!"

Glimmer watches as Bow pulls out the cake. The hunter herself takes a whiff, but her nose fails to pick up on anything useful. Slowly, she stands to her own feet and makes her way into the kitchen. Adora follows right behind. They watch as the cake is taken out of the pan. Sure enough, it is pushing how golden it can be in color.

"Good call," Bow says. He grabs a small tub of pink frosting. Knives are handed out and the three friends begin to spread the colorful icing. Though, of course, the cake is not the only thing that gets covered. The three friends have their own little fight which results in tips of noses and parts of cheeks turning some shade of pink.

By the time the cake is covered in frosting, as well as part of everyone's faces, slices are made for everyone. They settle down on Bow's couch, enjoying the warm sweet. Glimmer wipes some of the frosting off of her cheek before taking a look outside.

The sky has become a dark shade of grey. Small flakes of snow furry down and slowly coat the ground. "Damn, how much do you think we are gonna get?"

"I don't think we are going to get a lot this time but in a couple days we are supposed to have a good storm blow through," Bow says.

"Fun, fun." Glimmer makes a mental note about this. It will be a close call with Adora's shift. But if everything goes like it did last week, there shouldn't be any issues at all. Maybe being stuck in an almost-blizzard with a giant ass husky won't be such a bad idea.

Adora gives a small nudge of her shoulder. "Enjoying your birthday?"

"Yeah I am. Thanks, guys. I really needed a break. I think we all did."

“So what shitty movie are we watching this time, Glim?” Bow cuts in.

Glimmer drums her fingers against the nearby table. “Let’s Russian Roulette it. Throw some movies in a randomizer and see what happens.”

Needless to say, all the movies they watch are horrible.

She has a feeling she is going to regret this. Already, her hands shake and sweat from anticipation. This doesn’t help with her catching as she tosses a tennis ball up and down in the air. Lying on the couch, she watches it almost hit the ceiling before landing right back in her palm. It thankfully keeps her attention away from the door.

Glimmer sits on the chair nearby. Her nose is buried into her mother’s book, still trying to make heads or tails of the Latin. No one they have asked knows it at all outside of the names of animals. Now, they are stuck with guesswork and hoping they might get some sort of luck. Every now and again, her girlfriend lets out a frustrated groan before flipping a page.

Just stay calm, Adora. Everything will be just fine. Breathe.

More tossing the ball up in the air and catching. She chews on her hoodie string as she repeats the motion over and over again. The faster Catra gets here, the faster Adora’s heart can settle in her chest. She isn’t about to cancel this little meeting now. She was fine in the morning when she agreed to listen to more of what her sister has to offer. Now, her mind is screaming at her to tuck her tail between her legs and hide away in her room until the threat passes.

You can do this, Adora. You can do this. Glimmer is right by your side and if you need to leave, she can cover for you.

Adora throws the ball, adding a bit of spin to it. This causes it to travel almost out of her reach. A hand shot out past her head,

grasping the tennis ball by the tips of her fingers. She sighs in relief over the fact it has not come crashing down to the ground.

“You having fun there, love?” Glimmer asks.

Adora readjusting herself into a sitting position. Legs cross over each other. She rolls the ball in small circles against one of them. “I guess. What about you?”

“Well, I haven’t given myself a headache yet so that’s a win.” Glimmer snaps the book shut and places it on the nearby table. “How are you holding up? Do you like the taste of cotton?”

“Tch.” Adora can’t help but let a small smile creep along her face at the last comment. “Doing my best. Wish she’d show up already. Though, I'm used to this."

“So I guess this is nothing new?”

“Yup.” Adora leans back against the couch. A finger rubs her temple. “I don’t know what’s worse. Her coming or the fact it’s a full moon tomorrow.”

“It could be just like last month. Don’t think we have to worry that much. Besides, ya know, you trying to chew on something you shouldn’t.”

“I’ll try not to tear up the sofa too much.”

“If you do, don’t worry, it wasn’t that expensive. Oh, speaking of full moons. Can I ask a question?”

Adora chews harder on her string. “I guess it’s gonna be one I don’t like. Shoot.”

“You said you were bitten on your birthday? Which is in January?”

“Yeah. What about it?”

“Do you know what they call the moon during January?”

Adora raises an eyebrow. “There are names?”

“Yeah. Most just know the harvest moon. But the first year’s moon is called the Wolf’s Moon. Most people call it that ‘cuz that is when wolves would howl a lot. But within our world, it has another meaning to it. For whatever magical bullshit reason, werecreatures tend to be stronger. I know you can’t really remember anything, especially before now, but was there anything ever different when you shifted in January?”

“I always felt more shitty before and after. What does this have to do with being bit?”

“I think it’s the reason you are so strong and powerful and bigger in your werewolf form. Because you were bitten then, it affected you in that way.”

“Oh great, more reason to hate getting bit. So next month what is that going to mean?”

“I don’t know. We will have to find out I guess.”

“More fun to look forward to...”

Glimmer opens her mouth to say something when a knock on the door cuts her off. Adora lets out a small growl, fingers digging into the tennis ball. With all her senses heightened, she can hear the rhythmic tapping of her sister’s foot against the mat outside. Glimmer rises off the chair and begins to travel towards the front door. However, she stops for a moment to place a kiss on her girlfriend’s temple.

“Just tell me if we have to cut it short,” Glimmer says before finishing her trek. She takes her own breath before pulling open the door.

“Surprised you guys didn’t keep me waiting,” Catra bluntly says.

“You’re one to talk,” Adora replies, getting up off the couch to stand behind her girlfriend and glare.

“Please don’t do any bullshit.” Glimmer adds on.

“Fine, sorry. Can I come in?”

Glimmer steps out of the way, gesturing to enter. Catra steps in. “So where do I sit?”

“Couch.” She gestures with her head before moving out of the way.

Adora says nothing as she sits down on the ground. Glimmer takes the seat beside her while Catra sits across from the pair on the couch. The coffee table is the only thing that separates them from each other. Catra removes her jacket, places it on the back of the couch, and takes off her messenger bag. She rummages around the thing until she pulls out a beat up notebook. She flips through the pages until she finds what she is looking for.

“So, you want more info on what the fuck Mom's doing, right?” Catra slaps the book down. “I did my best to remember what she was killing before so this might be inaccurate. I don’t know much of what she has been doing now so feel free to add if you know.”

Adora brings the book closer to her. She lifts it up so Glimmer can read as well. There is a small list on the page of non-humans most others would be familiar with. Almost all are some sort of werecreature, mostly wolves. There are a couple others such as a faery and unicorn. The most menacing thing on here is the last one. A chimera.

Glimmer and Adora exchange a look before scribbling down what they know. All the hunters and non-humans. The list more than doubles in length. Once everything is written, Adora slides the book back towards her sister.

“Damn, Mom sure has been busy.” Catra mutters. Eyes go wide as she reads the list. “Holy shit, she killed a minotaur! Fuck man.”

“Do you know anything else?” Glimmer asks.

“Yeah, hold on.” Catra flips through several pages. She curses when she must back track. “Like I said, your Mom was starting to stick her nose in places it didn’t belong. I don’t know what she knew, but she knew Shadow Weaver was up to something. So after…I…” Catra hesitates for a moment. Whatever was waiting to escape fails to do so.

“Ya know…Your mom and mine fought. My mom pushed me to the sideline. Not out of worry I would get hurt but just so I was out of the fuckin’ way. Anywho. Like I said before, Angella did something to Shadow Weaver before she died. Shot her a couple times with arrows and after that Mom got all fucked up.”

“My mom was a hell of a shot.” Glimmer drums her fingers against the table. “So that’s what she did.”

“Sounds like maybe something similar to when Bow got me back in July.” Adora states. “She might have mixed some stuff in.”

“So do either of you two have any idea what that is all about then?”

Glimmer shrugs. “I would assume some mixture of wolfsbane or something. I only know about ones that knock or sedate. Never heard of anything that would completely fuck up a werewolf to the point they can’t kill anything for two years.”

“What exactly happened to Mom anyway? You said you stayed with her for a bit before ditching her. What do you mean when you said she was weaker?”

Catra leans back on the couch. “She didn’t have all her senses. For example I was doing whatever and dropped and broke something. I thought for sure she was going to have my head but she didn’t hear a damn thing.That’s also how I escaped. When she shifted she didn’t look like what she usually does.”

“Which is?” Adora asks, honestly wondering what her mother looks like in that form.

"Big and menacing. Smaller and less scary than you, though, but still someone that you'd not want to mess with. But after that fight, she was nothing like that anymore. She was half the size of me and I don't think she could win any sort of battle."

Glimmer has pulled out her notebook and is jotting everything down. Her eyebrows have furrowed as she chews on the end of her pen. "So you got anything else to tell us."

Catra shakes her head. "No. I left and was just doing my own thing and lo behold, Mom has bounced back. I have made some connections since I left, it's how I heard about you guys. I can see if anyone knows anything more."

"Any information is better than nothing, right?" Glimmer says.

"Right," Adora sighs. She chews the bottom of her lip, keeping her sister in her peripheral. "That is really useful."

Catra snorts. "You're welcome. I hope whatever you two figure out, you don't get killed."

She already feels the effects of the full moon. Adora leans her head against the frosted window. The cold glass soothes her aching aching body, even if only slightly. Outside, the world is dark and covered in snow. Not a single blade of grass or patch of dirt can be seen. The full moon hangs high in the night sky, taunting Adora.

At least tonight will be different. If the last two months are anything to go off of, tonight there should be no need for chains. No need for any wolfsbane. At least she can take some sort of solace in that. Still, it does not make the before anymore better. *Fuck why does this still hurt like a bitch?*

Adora decides to peel herself off of the window and walk a little. Get her blood flowing. She exits the lower bedroom and enters the living room. Just the sight of seeing her girlfriend roaming

about helps lift her spirits ever so much. But this does not last long.

Adora groans, her stomach doing acrobatics inside her lower abdomen. One hand reaches out and keeps her propped up against the back of the couch. Her other one grips her stomach in a vein attempt to calm it. She feels beads of sweat forming on her forehead, threatening to roll down the side of her face. For a moment, the world blurs together in a collage of colors. Rapid blinking brings the lines back to focus.

“Are you alright?” Glimmer asks, suddenly close by.

Adora turns her head towards her girlfriend. Words do not properly form in her head. She needs to shake it to jiggle anything out from wherever it's stuck. A halfhearted laugh is let out. “Don’t worry. Same old, same old.”

A thin line forms on Glimmer’s face. “Are you gonna be okay if I step outside to fix the backyard light? The damn thing just blew.”

“Yeah, I should be fine.” To prove a point, Adora straightens herself out. It takes everything in her not to wobble in the slightest. “I’ll be just fine.”

“I’ll leave the door open. Shout if you need anything.”

Adora gives a small nod. She watches as Glimmer disappears. The cold air seeps into the room. It causes her already shivering body to shake more. Legs give out. Once more, the couch catches herself. This, however, proves to be her undoing. Despite the passing of a day, the scent of her sister, the pines from when she was out in the woods, enters her sensitive growing nose.

A sharp jolt of pain, as if she has been sucker punched in the diaphragm, ripples throughout her body. Shaking legs no longer can support her weight. Knees smack against the hardwood. A hand slides down the back of the couch. She hears a slight tearing of fabric. Looking at her hands, the nails are no longer a pale pink. Adora swallows, trying to keep the wolf down for a little

while longer. But that becomes almost impossible to do as her mind turns against her.

The more the smell of her sister enters her nose, the more images flashes within her mind. Even if Catra's info is useful (more than that actually) even if she hasn't pulled any shit yet, that does little to ease the bubbling anger inside of her. These past few weeks alone seem to want to make her life a living hell.

Everything from her past beings to flood her senses. Her sister alone is the most in focus. Her betrayal when she found her after the escape from home. Tearing her down and blaming her over little things. And what about her mother? The person they have been looking for all this time is a 'blast from the past'. Even if her mother hasn't always been the best of persons, far from it, what *are* the odds it is her doing all these things? If there is some god or gods watching over everyone, why the hell do they love to fuck with her?

Why can't she escape her past? Why does it have to come back and haunt her?

The wolf inside of her claws harder inside of her, begging to be let out.

'Don't hold it back.'

Adora doesn't protest.

"Adora?" Glimmer steps back into the house, brushing off the dust of snow that blew onto her shoulders. She heard a *thump* while outside and got back inside as soon as she could. Stupid light. Now, in the warmth of her home, she searches for her girlfriend.

"'Dora?" She calls again. *Crap, did she already shift?*

Glimmer steps further into the room. The smell of musk, of *wolf,* hangs heavy in the air. Her heart skips in her chest. The scars on

her stomach flare up as Adora comes into view. A curse enters her mind as she stops short, freezing in place.

Adora is half way through her shift. Shoulders curled, hands twisting into large and sharp claws, and muscles rippling across her body. Her torn clothes clings to her shifting body. When a board suddenly creaks under Glimmer's weight, Adora's head snaps up. The hunter gasps at the sight laid out before her.

A large muzzle, covered in dark, rough fur, forms. Dangerously large teeth jut out, ready to pierce anything. But what catches her attention are Adora's eyes. Tears freely flow down her changing face. Her eyes are neither sky blue nor rich gold. They are a bright, burning, red.

As Adoda finishes her shift—turning into the same werewolf Glimmer saw back in the summer—she takes a step forward. Teeth are bare as a snarl rips across her face. Glimmer tries to move, *screams* in her mind to not be frozen like a fuckin' statue. But the information remains trapped in her brain, refusing to be sent throughout her limbs. The only thought that is clear as day in her head is wondering how and why the hell this is happening.

Adora takes another step forward, mere inches away from the hunter. Her dark nose twitches momentarily before she stops in her tracks. A low growl continues emanating from Adora's throat as eyes remain locked on the hunter. Suddenly, she lunges.

Glimmer instinctively throws her arms up in front of her. Her mind flashes back to that July summer and the pain of bone and flesh being torn apart. However, none of this repeats itself. Instead, the weight of Adora slams against her chest, knocking her clean off her feet. Glimmer winces as her tailbone smacks against the hardwood. In the temporary spinning world, she catches the tail of Adora disappearing into the night.

"Shit, not again!" *Why is she like this?*

Glimmer scrambles to her feet. She stumbles forward in her flight. If she doesn't act fast, well…Glimmer doesn't want to think about it. The boots given to her by Adora finally will be given some use. She tears her closest apart in the search for her bag. All the while, she hears her heart drumming in her ears and beating inside her throat. The last thing she does before racing after her girlfriend is throwing on a jacket. She grabs the one off the dining room chair.

Snow crunches under her fast moving feet. Cold December air nips at her cheeks and nearly burns the inside of her lungs. Glimmer has dug out a flashlight from her bag, aiding her greatly in search. Adora's footprints are clear as the pale yellow light flickers against the ground. The further she goes into the Whispering Woods, the thicker and lower the tree branches become. Some, she must duck to not get a face full of bark and snow. Others, however, lie broken and managed on the ground.

"Adora! *Adora!* Where are you?!?" Glimmer only hears her echo give a reply. The only things around her are the dark trees, twinkling stars, and looming moon. Her ears hear nothing other than the whistle of the wind and her shaking breathing.

Her flashlight continues to help her locate the path Adora has taken. The further she goes, the more the snow is torn up. Taking a moment, Glimmer kneels on the ground. In the mess of werewolf paw prints, something else catches her eyes. Fingers prod into the ground, right in the middle of a large hoof print.

But that is not the only oddity. Glimmer takes a sniff, nose already dripping from the freezing temperature. But something new, *unknown,* enters her nostrils. Somehow in this weather, it is *hot,* like a steaming cup. Mixed in, there is what she swears is salt. Glimmer has no name for what hangs in the air. Yet, whatever it is, makes her stomach flip and fills her bones with dread.

Shit! Glimmer scrambles to her feet. She resumes her tracking. There does not seem to be an end in sight. The hunter curses at the fact she was born with short legs. Though, no matter how

much her body protests, Glimmer refuses to let up. Not until Adora is safely back in her arms.

Something new comes into her field of view. She doesn't notice it at first. Pinprick size dots of red. But as more appear and begin to grow in size and shape, it sends Glimmer into a panic. If her mind already wasn't focused on Adora, now every *atom* inside of her screams her name. Hidden ice nearly causes her to fall flat on her face. At this point, she doesn't care how much noise she is making.

" *ADORA!"* Her words practically tear out of her throat. The blood stains against the snow only grows. Whatever is injured is far from okay. Even at her size, if a buck with it's razor sharp antlers catches her in the right place then…

Don't you dare think about that! Glimmer screams at herself.

" *ADORA! PLEASE!"* Glimmer feels the tears freezing on her face. Her brain begins to betray her, no matter how hard she tries to fight back. The deer is not her only worry. The further she travels, the further from home she becomes. The longer it will take to get home. The more time the sun will rise and revert Adora back into a delirious state.

And it will all be your fault again for not doing enough.

Glimmer's voice becomes small, childlike, at the thought. "I can't lose you too…"

A strong metallic scent suddenly enters her nose. It's followed by heavy breathing. Slowly, she twists her body towards the noise. Her flashlight lands on a large, menacing werewolf. Fur, coarse and an ugly shade of yellow, is covered in crimson. Paws up to the forearms, muzzle, chest, neck, and parts of ears and back feet all are stained. When lips are pulled back, teeth are no longer white.

Glimmer flicks her eyes towards the lump behind Adora. A buck, at least nine points, lies dead. It's abdomen has been totally

gutted. Blood and innards are strewed across the ground. There are hints of red against its white antlers. Where did it get her?

"Love," Glimmer starts, "Love, it's me! Glitter-bug!" With her free hand, she sticks out her palm. "You're okay now."

Glimmer steps forward, feeling the snow shift under her boot. Adora flinches back, hackles raised. This does not deter the hunter. She takes another step, whispering, "I'm not going to hurt you."

Adora's nose twitches, taking in Glimmer's scent. For a moment, her bright eyes dim. However, in a blink, they burn like fire again. For the second time tonight, Adora lunges. Glimmer has only enough time to shout as paws slam into her chest. She expects to feel teeth bore into her body once more and her own blood to mix into the deer's blood. None of this occurs, though.

Teeth instead grab the collar of her jacket. Adora tugs with all her might. Not wanting to become a ragdoll, Glimmer wiggles free. She plops down into the snow, skin already protesting the cold sensation. Glimmer flips onto her chest and watches Adora throw the jacket as far as possible. Her girlfriend stands over her, growling fiercely at the tossed clothing.

Glimmer blinks, staring at the jacket. It's then she remembers Catra had left it at the house by mistake. They had moved it out of the way earlier in the day. Guess she won't get that back anytime soon.

"Adora! It's okay!" Glimmer scrambles out from under her girlfriend. "Look at me!"

Glimmer stands faces to face with Adora. Her eyes remain their bright red color and teeth bear for all to see. Slowly, the hunter places her hands on Adora's furry cheeks. The werewolf flinches for a moment before sighing softly through her nose. Thumbs gently brush against the rough, blood stained face. The only time she has ever been this close to a raging werecreature is either

when they were in chains or were trying to rip her arm clean off her body. During all those times, there always was a sense of fear of death or worry of escape. Here…the only thing Glimmer can feel inside of her is *relief.*

"You're okay, Adora. We're okay!" She places a soft, tender kiss between Adora's eyes before settling her forehead against her girlfriend. Adora's eyes flutter shut. Within the musky wolf scent Glimmer can still smell sandalwood. Her voice is barely above a whisper. "I'm right here, 'Dora. Everything is going to be alright now."


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Suddenly, strong arms wrap around her body. Adora adjusts her head, placing it against Glimmer's shoulder as she pulls her close. Glimmer chuckles lightly, beyond overjoyed. When they pull away, she sees that while Adora's eyes are red, they are not as bright.

"How 'bout we go home?"

Adora lets out a chuff. Glimmer leads the way back out of the woods, retracing her steps. Every now and again, she looks over her shoulder. Adora snaps her head towards any sound she picks up. Snow falling to the ground, twigs snapping under hooves, or the hoot of a great horn owl. It all causes her hair to stick up on its end and lips to be pulled back. Occasionally, there is a growl.

When a loud noise, possibly a branch breaking free from its tree, echoes through the air, Adora suddenly is in front of Glimmer. Every part of her fur is sticking up, as if struck by lightning. She shows every one of her razor sharp, bloodstained teeth and growls as loud as possible.

"Hey. Shh." Glimmer steps to Adora's side. She rubs her head against the top of her girlfriend's head. "It's nothing. I'm fine."

Adora gives her a look. She does not lower her guard, not even by an inch.

"C'mon. It's okay." Glimmer's body shudders violently. Hands rub against her arms, seeking any sort of warmth. "We need to keep moving."

Another chuff. Adora lets her hackles fall and returns to following Glimmer. She continues to jump at anything but doesn't attempt another guard. By the time they reach the end of the woods, Glimmer's teeth are chattering a mile a minute and goosebumps are on every inch of her skin. She really is regretting leaving the jacket behind.

Warmth, however, is only a few yards away.

Glimmer hops up the steps and opens the door. She is about to enter when she realizes Adora has stopped dead in her tracks. Her nose twitches before she darts off the porch. Adora freezing in the middle of the backyard, puffed up and growling again. Glimmer groans, pinching the bridge of her nose. Her shivers are getting worse.

"Adora. You g-gotta c-come in! You can't just s-stay out here!"

Adora does not budge. Glimmer trudges over to her girlfriend. "C-Catra is g-gone! She's n-not there any m-more! You have t-to come inside!"

Still, nothing. The hunter curses loudly before flopping herself against Adora's side. Her face buries its way into her girlfriend's thick, rough fur. Fingers grip it tight. Her shivering grows uncontrollable and she feels like her teeth will break themself by how hard they clack together.

"I'm not g-g-gonna let y-you fr-freeze out h-here!" *God, she's so warm.* "Please, 'Dora."

Adora refuses to move forward. However, she does budge from her position in the snow. Her body curls around Glimmer's body. Tail and head cover the hunter's freezing body in a tight embrace. Warm spreads out through her body, pushing out all the cold that clings to her bones.

Glimmer sighs through her nose and lets her body go limp against Adora's body. She fixes herself so she is even more encased in the warmth. The image of a fireplace, bright and crackling, appears in her mind. "You know what, I don't mind this."

Adora gives Glimmer a lick against her face. Her still red eyes flick upwards, staring up at the night sky. Even with the brightness of the full moon, many stars shine brilliantly. Even the ones close to the celestial being fight to show off their beauty. Glimmer sees Adora's eyes become wide and she swears there are even sparkles in them.

“They are wonderful, aren’t they?” Glimmer whispers. “Do you like them?”

Adora gives a noise that sounds like agreement. A yawn escapes Glimmer, her body becoming heavy like lead. She cannot fight back the weights pulling down her eyelids. “I think I found your nickname…” Glimmer mumbles before she slips into sleep.

It’s a sharp, unnatural jerk that snaps Glimmer back into the world of the living. A kick nearly sends her flying. Her brain scrambles to catch up to all the information being thrown at it. She realizes the jerking is from Adora. The moon has been replaced by the bright morning sun. And the werewolf in front of her is about to be replaced by a human, young woman.

Adora’s body is already beginning to shrink. Muscles and fur disappear, nails become blunt, and teeth become dull. The blonde whines with every tear of her tissues and every breaking of bone. Glimmer’s heart twists in her chest at the sight of her girlfriend in utter pain. She doesn’t need her brain working to know what to do next.

Arms wrap tightly around Adora’s changing body. Even if nails can still slice through her skin, even if she still can receive a chomp out of her shoulder, Glimmer does not give a damn. She hugs Adora as tight as possible. Her body continues to jerk violently, nearly breaking free of her girlfriend’s grasp a couple of times.

“I got you, ‘Dora,” Glimmer starts. She pauses for a moment. “I got you, Starlight.”

Adora’s own arms snake around her Glimmer’s body. Fingers digs into the back of her t-shirt. Adora whines turn into shaky gasps. Slowly, jerks settle down. The blonde still struggles to catch her breath as she buries her face into the crook of Glimmer’s neck.

“Deep breaths, ‘Dora. Deep breathes,” Glimmer whispers into Adora’s ear. She rubs a hand against her back. Fingertips can feel

just how rough the wounds on her back had healed. Once Adora's body almost completely settles, Glimmer lets go.

Blood still stains Adora's body. Even parts of her hair stick together from it. Eyes are back to their natural sky blue color. However, a fog covers her irises. Adora fights to keep her head from going limp.

"You can rest, Adora. It's okay."

Adora makes a noise of disagreement. She continues to fight back the heaviness of unconsciousness that usually accompanies her shift backs. The freezing cold begins to nip at Glimmer's exposed skin. She doesn't really want to suffer from hypothermia.

"Okay. Let's get you inside." Glimmer snakes Adora's arm around her neck. Her girlfriend is totally unstable on her feet, barely able to hold up her own weight. Slowly but surely, the two make it inside the warm building. Glimmer uses her foot to shut the door before turning her attention towards Adora. Some of the fog has begun to lift from her eyes.

"How about we go clean you up? A warm shower might do you some good."

She struggles to find her footing. She is a baby deer and the flooring is fresh ice. The only thing that keeps the darkness on her edges from taking over is the scent of lilacs in her nose. Despite being unable to fully make out what Glimmer is saying, the way she speaks is comforting. Adora tries to stand up straight but her legs are like jell-o. She very nearly takes Glimmer down with her.

Her brain struggles to stitch anything together. She sees flashes of red and smells copper in her nose. She shivers away the cold that has refused to leave her body. And of course, the faint memory of snuggling up against her girlfriend. Adora opens her mouth, wanting to ask what is real and what is not, but no words come out of her mouth. Only horse noise escapes.

"'Dora, do…go in bed…?. ..don't…fight it." Glimmer's voice comes in and out like waves.

Adora manages to shake her head. She *really* doesn't want to fall asleep. Blacking out all night is never fun. No need to extend it. Trying to stay awake is proving to be a challenge, however. But every inhale of Glimmer's shampoo gives her the motivation to keep pushing on.

One moment, Adora is walking through the living room. Next, she is being placed in the cold tub. Glimmer fiddles with the faucet behind her. "Tell me if it's too hot or cold."

A stream of water suddenly hits Adora's back. She winches not from the blast but rather the temperature. Ice cold. Thankfully, it quickly is replaced by heat. The blonde leans her head back, letting the rhythm of the water massage her scalp. While steam slowly builds up, the fog in her mind begins to disappear.

Glimmer shuffles around, gathering up Adora's things. Once she gets everything in her arms, the hunter kneels down on the bathroom floor. The first thing Glimmer does is lather up Adora's hair. She hums a tune as fingers gently rub the top of her head. Adora practically melts against her girlfriend's hands. She can't help but let out a purr-like noise.

"Like that, huh?" Glimmer chuckles. "Hm. Gotta get this out. Might hurt."

Fingers shift downward, running straight through her hair. They are stopped by what feels like a knot. Adora winches as she feels a tug. Glimmer mutters an apology before attempting to rid the tangles. As that is being worked on, Adora happens to take a glance at her arms.

Her blood stained arms.

Adora's breathing becomes erratic. Everything hits her like a freight train. The smears of blood on her legs and chest and mouth. The fresh taste of venison on her tongue and lips. Flashes

of her sinking her teeth into the neck of the buck. The soreness of her ribs where it tried to fight back. And, the over whelping anger that wrapped tightly around her heart.

Blood that slips from her body mixes in with the water and bubbles below, tinting the white foam red. The edges of Adora's vision blur.

“Adora?!?” Glimmer comes into her shrinking field of view. “Adora, what’s wrong?!?”

“Why am I covered in blood?!?” Adora cries. “What the hell happened?!?” She gasps, struggling for air. “ *What did I kill?!?* ”

“It was a deer. It was just a deer!”

This does absolutely nothing to calm her. Adora can do nothing to stop the flow of tears running down her face. “Why did I kill them?!? Why did I get out?!? I was getting better!”

Hiccups mix in with her sobs. Her body trembles with every breath. Why did this happen? She had hoped the last time she tasted flesh was back in the summer. That the last time harm ever came to someone or something was back then. Hadn’t they made sure she would never escape again? And what the hell was with last month? Was that a fluke that now made them let their guard down?

She stares back down at her hands. Her skin still is stained. Dirt, and surely flesh, is caked under her fingernails. Her stomach flips inside of her, unsettled by the realization of what it has digested. Adora bites back the stinging bile tickling at the back of her throat.

“What did I do wrong?!?” Adora breaks into a million pieces, her sobs overwhelming her.

“Nothing!” Glimmer’s arms wrap around Adora’s body. Clothes immediately are soaked from the stream of water. Adora finds

herself holding on tight to her girlfriend. She buries her head into the crook of Glimmer's neck.

All she can do is cry and shake. Glimmer says nothing but her tight embrace speaks every word she needs to hear. Fingers gently brush through her hair, careful to avoid the knots and tangles. Slowly, her sobs turn into coughs. And then into soft gasps as she tries in some attempt to gain control of her body. Her hiccups refuse to leave, however.

"I hate this," Adora mumbles. She shifts her head to lie her chin on Glimmer's shoulder. "I hate being bit. I hate that my mom killed your mom. This isn't fair." Adora sniffs. "I wish this never happened."

"I know." Glimmer whispers into her ears.

"You don't deserve this."

"Neither do you." Glimmer gently pushes her away. Adora can see she is drenched from head to upper torso. Her pink and purple hair sticks to the side of her face. Glimmer smiles softly. One that makes Adora's heart jump in her chest. "How are you feeling?"

"Still like shit," Adora admits.

"Do you mind if I finish washing you off? Or do you want to do it yourself?"

Another sniff. Adora wipes her nose with her arm. Though, it does little to help. "I don't mind you finishing. Thank you."

"Alright, lift up your arm."

Adora lets Glimmer scrub away everything from her body. Blood and dirt disappears down the drain. Soap coats her arms, legs, and body. Glimmer is gentle as she scrubs everything away. Whenever she has to use a little more force, she lets Adora know before doing so. Once her body no longer has hints of what happened during the night, it is back to the hair.

Adora's head slowly becomes heavy. Between the warm steam filling the bathroom, Glimmer's tenderness as she cares for her, and her previous refusal to sleep, it all beckons her into slumber. There is no need to accidentally drown herself. She asks Glimmer for a rag, which the hunter happily gives her.

She begins to clean her face. It does not take too long for the dried up blood to be transferred onto the rag. She rings it out before wiping herself down one last time. By the time she finishes cleaning herself off, Glimmer is wrapping up with her hair.

"I think you are good. I hope I didn't miss anything," Glimmer says. "Do you want to stay in the shower for a little longer or do you want to come out?"

"I'm pretty exhausted. You think you can help me stand?" Adora asks. "I think I'll be fine afterwards."

"Right."

Glimmer grabs the last towel off the top of the radiator cover. She turns off the water before wrapping the towel around Adora's body. The blonde sighs as the soft fabric encases her. "So warm."

"How about we get you into something even warmer."

Glimmer helps Adora to her feet. Once back in the bedroom, Glimmer slips out to get into drier clothing. Left to her own devices, the blonde decides to put on a pair of pjs. She barely has the energy to do that simple task. The moment she is no longer nude, the only thing Adora can muster is flopping down on her bed. She can't even summon the energy to burrow under her blankets.

Thankfully, Glimmer appears to tuck her in herself. She drapes her old blanket against her body before flopping down beside her girlfriend. Glimmer keeps her head propped up with one hand. With her other, she hovers it over Adora's cheek. When given permission, she lowers it to tucks some hair behind Adora's ear.

“You should rest, Starlight. You deserve it.” Glimmer whispers.

Adora chuckles. “So that was real, huh? Thought I made that name up.”

“Do you like it?”

Adora’s eyes begin to flutter shut. “Glitter-bug and Starlight. I like that.”

“Good.” Glimmer pushes herself closer, placing a small kiss on the tip of Adora’s nose. “I love you, Starlight.”

“I love you too, Glitter-bug.” is the last thing Adora mumbles before the unconsciousness she has struggled to push back finally wins.

Chapter End Notes

a number of ideas i have in this/been working on have been given to me by friends/they helped me spitball i can't say everything and give credit yet cause spoilers but

the scene with adora killing the deer + breakdown was given to me by my good friend Athetos Please go check xem out

and as always comments and kudos very much appreciated!

Time of Rest

Chapter Notes

> :v here's the last chapter of the bunch. This was partly written when I had covid so oof and struggle yadda yadda enjoy. the next batch might be a little longer cause LIFE but we will see. i dont think there are any tws in this one...
>
> oh and this has officially surpassed chipped adora au!!! both that chipped au ended at 17 chapters and was about 120k. So hell yeah to that!!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

6 Years Ago

The landlord of the apartment Glimmer lives in doesn't seem to want to turn the heat up anymore. There remains a nip in the air, one that makes the young woman keep her jacket on. Thankfully, she has bought a small space heater but it is only useful when she is lying on her bed. At least she has decided to remain there currently.

Glimmer slurps down her instant beef ramen. Despite the warmth from the heater, she keeps her jacket on, hood over her head. The moment she leaves her bed, the cold from the winter will bite at her skin. To keep herself entertained, she watches some *Fuzzfeed Unsolved.* Her favorite of the two, True Crime, is currently airing. She's finally getting around to watching the latest episode. At least there will be something to look forward to every week for a while.

And…It keeps her distracted from the rest of the world. Outside her little apartment, festivities are in full swing. Christmas lights hang all over the place. Music blasts from every radio there is. It seeps through Glimmer's walls, becoming that annoying muffled sound. Thank god for headphones. No matter where she goes

there is the smell of cinnamon or ginger. She's really beginning to regret not buying anything to bake.

But that is not the only thing. She dares not take her eyes off of her computer and check her phone. Having it on silence already keeps her from doing so but the urge still gnaws at the inside of her chest. She knows what will be on her notifications the second she unlocks her screen. Eventually, Glimmer will have no choice but to check and rip that bandaid off. For now, however, she does what she can to forget.

When the episode ends, she takes a moment's break. She needs a new cup of ramen anyway. Glimmer hops off her bed, tosses the empty cup in a nearby trash bin, and exits her little bedroom. The moment she leaves the small area the space heater reaches, cold wraps around her. A shiver runs down her spine. *Gotta make this quick.*

Glimmer grabs the first instant cup she sees and quickly prepares it. The second the microwave beeps, she snatches her food. She soaks up the warmth spreading through her hands. Time to scurry back to her room. The moment her bed is in reach, Glimmer leaps onto the mattress. However, she miscalculates how hard she lands.

The bounce tosses her phone in the air, enough that it topples off the bed. Glimmer curses as the phone smacks against tile ground, lighting up as it's side button is clicked. It lands face up, staring right at its owner. The screen reveals what Glimmer has been trying to avoid.

Unread messages.

"Fuck," Glimmer mumbles.

There is no use in ignoring it any longer. With a heavy sigh, she grabs her phone and fully unlocks it. A shaking thumb hovers over the message app. She has no idea who it is from but there are

only three people it possibly could be and one makes her heart beat hard in her chest.

Just do it already, Glimmer!

Her thumb hits the app. The screen shifts to the list of past messages. Unopened at the top is one from her father. Glimmer sighs a small breath of relief. She hits her screen one more time to read what has been sent to her.

Dad: *Merry Christmas, Sweetpea! I hope you are doing well. Missing you. Love you.*

Glimmer runs a hand through her dark hair. There are no other messages, thankfully or not. She doesn't need to know that this is not only from her father but her aunt and her *mother.*

It has been a couple weeks now since she stormed out of her parent's home. How the hell she got this apartment so fast is a goddamn miracle. Though, seeing with how the heat is and how small the place is, can it be that much of a shocker Glimmer got it this quick and this fast? Being a college student has *some* perks when looking for places around campus.

But already in that time away, guilt and regret has crept into Glimmer's heart. She can still see the broken face of her mother clear as day in her mind. Maybe she shouldn't have used such a harsh word as 'hate' at her mother but her anger couldn't be held back. Hell, still now she feels that bitterness. Leaving, escaping to this tiny little apartment, at least now Glimmer can do what she please. Such as when trouble starts up during the full moon, being able to finally protect others.

Though, she has to find other hunters or non-humans. This far from home, there are not many connections to go off on. She'll find them eventually…hopefully. There are other things she has to worry about right now, however. Even if it is Christmas, she really isn't in the mood to think about her mother.

Glimmer clicks her phone shut, setting it off to the side. This can be dealt with later. She locks her phone, sets it aside, and pinches her nose. *Deep breathes, Glim. Deep breathes.*

This does little to settle her erratic heart. She needs a distraction. Glimmer quickly finds something to play, the first thing that looks at least vaguely entertaining. The moment it begins, she leans back against the hall as her body becomes heavy. Noodles have totally lost their taste and her stomach no longer seems that interested in eating.

She looks around her room. There is only her bed, space heater, a dresser, closet with a mirror, and a desk. Nothing else. Her walls and windows remain pale and barren. The same goes for the other parts of her apartment. It's nothing like her home. Glimmer wonders how decorated the house is thanks to her father.

Actually, she rather not think about it.

Glimmer focuses all her attention on her laptop, listening to every word that is spoken through her speakers.

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"Be careful you two!" Perfuma shouts. "I am not going to give either of you potions if you hurt yourselves!"

Glimmer snorts, knowing that is a *blatant* lie. But she can't blame her attempt at a threat. Both their girlfriends are attempting to put the star on the Christmas tree Scorpia's apartment. But, it's how they are doing it that's making Glimmer laugh and Perfuma groan. Adora rests on Scorpia's shoulders. In her hands, is said star. With the tree quite tall, even with their combined height, Adora must stretch to reach the top.

A tongue sticks out of Adora's mouth as her fingers grasp the tip of the branch. She pulls it close and places the star on the top. The moment it's on, Adora let's go. The tree bounces back to a straight position. Some needles flutter to the ground from the shaking.

“Ha! There we go!” Adora chirps. She places fists on her hips. A large, crooked grin spreads across her face. “See, Perfuma! We got it, no sweat!”

Perfuma rolls her eyes.

“Alright, you two. I think that’s enough,” Glimmer states.

Scorpia kneels down, letting Adora hop off her back. With their work complete, everyone takes a look at the now decorated tree. From head to toe, branches have some sort of ornament on it. Some simple glass balls while others are some sort of animal or thing. White lights wrap around the tree, twinkling brightly. To top everything off, candy canes join the ornaments.

Adora’s chest is puffed out with pride. Her eyes sparkle just like the lights on the trees. Her smile has not faded in the *slightest* against her face. It is infectious, as Glimmer feels her own lips pull upward.

“How did you like decorating your first tree?” Glimmer asks.

Adora spins on her heels to face her girlfriend. “Yeah! I didn’t think you could have this much fun putting stuff on a tree. I can’t wait to do ours!”

“Just gotta wait for Bow to get back from visiting one of his brothers. He should be back soon.”

“Sweet!”

“I’m gonna make some hot chocolate.” Glimmer stands up from off the ground, having been sitting near Perfuma who’s on the couch. “Anyone want some?”

Everyone agrees with the idea of the warm drink. Glimmer quickly gets to work, gathering up everything she needs. While everything comes to a boil, she gets four cups and a bag of small marshmallows. As she waits, laughter fills her ears. Glimmer can

hear Adora's snort as she chuckles at something either Perfuma or Scorpia have said. Her heart flutters in her chest.

It doesn't take long for the hot chocolate to finish. Glimmer tops it all off with the marshmallows, giving a little extra in Adora's cup. Somehow, the hunter manages to get all the cups into the living room in one shot, not a drop slipping on the floor. Though the second Adora spots her girlfriend, she bolts over and takes two of them.

"Those are for Perfuma and Scorpia," Glimmer states.

Adora gives a nod before handing out the cups. Once everyone has their drinks, Glimmer settles back down on the ground. She takes a couple sips before saying, "So, what are your guys' plans? Anything fun and interesting?"

"We are going to see my family," Perfuma states. "Or rather…we are going to meet up elsewhere since Scorpia can't fit into my parent's house."

"You can be human sized but there's nothing to make Scorp faery sized??"

"I've been small before and that magic didn't sit well with me," Scorpia replies. "I was sick for a couple days. I rather like being tall anyway."

"My family is excited anyway. Half of them haven't met Scorpia yet so it definitely will be fun," Perfuma finishes off. "What are you guys going to do?"

"Going to stay at my house," Glimmer answers. "My dad and aunt aren't able to come over, which is no big deal. Bow was gonna come since his dads and brothers are all going to do something the day before. Hopefully everything remains quiet at least for the holidays. Gotta make sure Adora's first Christmas is a good one, right?"

Glimmer gives a small nudge with her elbow just under Adora's ribcage. The blonde jumps slightly.

"Right! Right." Adora leans back on one hand. "I am still trying to figure out what to get everyone."

"I already had my birthday so I don't really care."

" *Still."*

"Honestly, it's more about being with your loved ones," Perfuma points out.

"See?" Glimmer replies. "Don't fret."

Adora snorts. "Easier said than done."

"There still is time left, don't worry. Right now…" Perfuma starts to dig around a nearby plastic bag. She pulls out a box and slaps it down on the table. "We gotta bake some gingerbread men! Don't you think this is more pressing, Scorpia?"

Scorpia nods. "Yes. I agree! Baking is much more important! Neither of you are getting out of it!"

"Alright, alright." Glimmer laughs. She sets her empty cup down on the table. A thumb sticks out towards Adora. "Just make sure this one doesn't eat all the batter before we throw it in the oven."

"Hey!" Adora shouts.

The bottles click together, bouncing with every step Glimmer takes. Adora walks beside her, whistling a tune. Hands and arms are behind her head. The hunter has no idea what the song is but whatever it is, she hums along to it. While doing so, she takes a moment to look at her phone, hoping they are still going in the right direction. Thankfully, this is the case.

Before leaving, Perfuma asked to drop some stuff off to Ed and Al's house. Being cold-blooded, this weather can be rough on the family. The family doesn't like the idea of moving back and forth from cold to warm weather, so they have learned to make do. Bundling up, keeping the heat up or using their fireplace, or, magic. Perfuma makes a killing selling and making these.

On today's menu, the potions are orange in color. Apparently they taste just like that. And the brothers not only love the fact it keeps them warm for a number of hours, but the taste as well. Glimmer has tried it a couple times but the citrus is not a favorite of hers. At least someone enjoys them.

They turn a corner. Adora stops in her tracks, pointing at a nearby apartment complex. Glimmer checks her phone one last time before giving a nod. At the door, they pair search for the right button to click. The word *Whitewood* is written on the small slip second from the top. Glimmer hits the button, letting the *buzz* fill the air for several seconds.

Once Glimmer removes her finger, it does not take long for a voice to come over the speaker.

"Hello?" a young child says.

"Is that Ed or Al?" Glimmer asks. "Adora and I are here with some gifts. Can your mom or dad come down?"

"Ah! I'll get them!" Before the microphone cuts off, the sound of wings flapping is heard. Glimmer and Adora chuckle.

As they wait, Glimmer checks the bottles one more time. There should be enough to last the family for a while. With how the weather is looking for the next couple weeks, they better last. No need for any wyverns icicles.

There is another buzz, one louder and more high pitched. Glimmer looks up to see the door opening up. Edgar and his mother wave in the pair.

“Thank you for bringing these.” Edgar’s mother says.

“Not a problem, Mrs. Whitewood.” Glimmer hands off the bag.

“What’s Al up too?” Adora asks, taking a look around the lobby.

“Can’t come out. Might spook some people,” Edgar replies, a cheeky grin on his face.

“Eddy,” his mother says sternly.

“Well, make sure he gets some. Don’t hog them all.” Adora tells him.

Edgar’s mother digs into her pocket, pulling out some money. “We already gave Ms. Scheimer money but since you guys delivered, you guys deserve some.”

Glimmer throws her hands out in front of her. “You don’t have to do that!”

"I insist!" The older woman puts the money in Glimmer's hands and pushes her fingers down. "It's the least we can do. Especially after you helped Alvin? My boys can't stop talking about you two."

"Yeah, yeah!" Edgar's light brown human eyes grow wide and bright. "You two are so cool! I wanna help other non-humans like you Ms and Ms. Mizari!"

Glimmer feels her face turn up a degree. Turning her head towards Adora. She has turned a slight red.

"Alright, you." Edgar's mother gives him a nudge on the back. "Go back upstairs before you freeze your scales off."

Edgar does as he is told and scurries back up the stairs. His loud, rapid footsteps bounce off the walls.

"My husband and I can't say thank you enough for you and your friends keeping an eye on Ed and Al."

"Anytime, Mrs. Whitewood," Adora says. "Ed and Al are great kids."

"Thank you." Edgar's mom turns her attention towards Glimmer. "I've only ever met your mother two or three times but you are just like her. You're doing such a wonderful job."

Now Glimmer's face really is warm. She is about to look down at the ground, away from a different mother's eyes, when rough ringers wrap around her hand, giving it a squeeze. The smell of sandalwood prevents her heart from racing in her chest. Glimmer takes a breath.

“Thank you. Enjoy and happy holidays.”

“The same to you. If you need anything else, let us know.”

Edgar’s mother waves them goodbye as they leave. Adora does not let go of Glimmer’s hand as they walk down the sidewalk. The hunter buries her face into her scarf, already feeling the spikes of negative thoughts scraping at the back of her mind.

“You okay, hon?” Adora’s voice softly enters her ears. Another squeeze of the hand.

“I will be. I just wanna go home.”

“Okay. I gotcha. Let’s go home.”

Glimmer’s fingers brush against the bindings of books. Eyes carefully read the words on the spine. Once she finds what she is searching for, she pulls it off the shelf and places it in her ever growing pile. Down the rows she goes until she finds even more books.

Everything she has grabbed is on anything about non-humans. Most deal with werewolves and vampires as humans seem to have the most interest in them but there are some books with chapters on others. A decent little mix. Glimmer doesn’t really need these,

as there can be misconceptions (like werewolves are *all* bloody-thirsty creatures) but Adora is right. She suggested this morning getting books to see if there could be anything to give them an idea about what her mother is up to.

So while Bow and Adora are tasked with setting up the Christmas tree, she has been sent to get said books. Partly because she needed to go food shopping and the library was on the way. Two birds with one stone.

Any information is better than none, Glimmer thinks to herself as she grabs one last book.

She thinks a whole *stackful* of books is enough. Now it's time to check out. Glimmer hums a small tune as she walks down a flight of steps. No one is at the front desk. The hunter happily slaps the stack of books on the counter. She pokes her head out from the side. "Can I check these out?"

"Sure thing!" the person behind the desk smiles. She begins to scan the barcodes. "Interested in the supernatural, huh?"

You sure can say that. "Yeah. I'm, uh, doing it for college. Paper."

"Well good luck on it." She finishes up checking out Glimmer. "There you go! Have a nice day!"

Glimmer returns the gesture before shoving the books in her bag. It's time to step back out in the cold winter air. She bundles herself back up before exiting. Right away, a gust of wind cuts right through her. Glimmer buries her face into her scarf. Salt, snow, and ice crunch under her boots as she heads towards her car.

However, she only makes it halfway through the parking lot when something stops her in her tracks.

"Catra? What are you doing here?" Glimmer asks. Only a car separates the two.

Catra looks, probably from her phone. “Oh, didn’t see you. And what? Am I on house arrest or something?”

Glimmer snorts. “No. I just didn’t expect to see you here.”

“Neither did I. But if you must know, I just went shopping. Had to get out of the place I’m staying at. What are you doing?”

“Getting some books. If your mom was doing research, why shouldn’t we? Don’t know how much we are going to find but ‘Dora thought of it.”

“Smart thinking. Well, if you knuckleheads figure something out, if you don’t mind tell me. I really want to take that bitch down also.”

“We’ll let you know. And, thanks again. Your information has been helpful.”

“Well, no problem. Oh, hold on.” Catra digs into her pocket as she walks around the car. She pulls a candy bar out. The werepanther slaps it down in Glimmer’s hands. “Here you go.”

“The fuck is this for?” Glimmer examines the candy. Nothing out of the ordinary. Something you can easily grab off the register for about a buck or so.

“It’s a chocolate bar.”

“No shit. Why are you giving me this?”

“For Adora. She still has that sweet tooth of hers, right?”

“Well there you go!” Catra spins on her heels and begins to walk away.

“I-Wha-” Glimmer sputters. “You still didn’t answer me! Why are you giving me this? Why do you want to give this to Adora anyway?”

Catra pauses in her tracks. She doesn’t turn around, leaving her back towards Glimmer. The hunter sees rubbing her thumb against loose fist. “She’s my sister. That’s why.”

Without uttering another word, Catra walks away. Glimmer watches her go, disappearing at a turn in the sidewalk. The hunter remains standing in the parking lot, chocolate bar in her hands. She blinks, still trying to understand what just transpired. After she spends enough time pondering, Glimmer heads back into her car.

"So what is this again?" Adora asks. She tosses the plastic decoration in her hands. The gold color shimmers in the light.

"Garland." Bow replies. He pops out from behind the tree. "We gotta wrap it around the tree like the lights. Come on. Let's get it on before Glim gets back."

Adora nods. Like with the lights from before, the two friends work together to decorate the Christmas tree. Adora sighs a breath of relief that the garland did not have to be untangled like the lights. So far, that is the worst part of Christmas. This slips on the branches with ease, however. It takes no time at all to finish this simple task. And just in time.

The front door opens wide. Glimmer hobbles in. Plastic bags hang from her arms and one from her mouth. Both Adora and Bow look at her in surprise as she uses her foot to shut the door.

“I thought you just went to get a couple things!” Adora shouts. She runs over to her girlfriend, grabbing several of the bags. Bow is right behind her, following her lead.

“Well, that didn’t happen,” Glimmer says the moment she spits out the bag from her mouth. “There was some good stuff on sale. Least we don’t have to go food shopping for a bit now.”

“Did you get the books?” Adora begins to put away some of the groceries. Soup, bread, fruits, baking goods, and some snacks among other things. One by one, they are put in their proper place.

“Yeah. Got a good amount actually!” Adora hears the books being placed on the coffee table. The moment she finishes unpacking the bags she took, she heads back to the couch. Plopping herself down on the cushions, Adora grabs the first book on the stack. Pages flip as her thumb runs across the edges. She stops at the first page she sees with the word *‘werewolf’* on it.

“You think you are gonna find anything useful?” Bow asks. He pries open a box of ornaments he and Adora brought down from the attic earlier.

“Who the hell knows,” Glimmer replies. She grabs her own book to look through. “Even if people get stuff wrong, a lot of stuff has to come from some truth, right?”

“This is true. Though…”

Bow’s hand suddenly grips the book Adora holds. She barely has time to *yelp* before her friend takes it away from her. He repeats the process with Glimmer before snapping both of the books shut and returning them to the pile. “I’m worried also. I want to get to the bottom of this too but I think right now, we all need a break. No reading the books until after we finish the tree, got it?”

“Seriously?” Glimmer sighs.

“Yes, seriously. Don’t make me hide these.” He gestures to the tree and boxes sitting around it. “We have more pressing issues to deal with. C’mon! Adora you gotta put on your first ornament! You get first dibs!”

Right. The other day she went out with Glimmer to buy her own ornament for the first time. What she decided on was a golden, four pointed star. Far too small to be put on top but a branch will do just nicely. Adora snatches the ornament from its box and

searches for a good place to put it on. She clicks her tongue against her teeth until she finds a spot. A little on the low side but still, it's perfect.

With the first ornament now placed on the tree, everyone gets to work on decorating. Glimmer has an assortment of them. Some are little santas or something like ' *Baby's First Christmas'.* But then there are things like a small crossbow, the Mizari family crest, and the atomic symbol for silver.

Adora begins to lose herself trying to find places to put ornaments. A couple of times after she places one, she quickly changes her mind and puts it elsewhere. At least one time, Adora takes the ornament back in its original place.

Half way through, as space slowly becomes harder and harder to come by, Adora spots Glimmer sitting at a box, an ornament in hand, and a thumb running against it. The blonde kneels down on the opposite side. She sees the ornament in question is a handmade gingerbread man. Whoever added the details must have been a child with how uneven and haphazard the lines and eyes are. Adora then notices the word *'Mom'* on it.

"What's that?" Adora asks. Though, she already knows the answer.

Glimmer sniffs before saying, "Something I made for my mom when I was like six. Was so damn proud of it and couldn't wait to give it to her. My mom always hung it up, even when I had my phase of being embarrassed about everything I made as a kid. I… I actually haven't hung it up since I came back…Apparently she kept hanging it up after I left…"

"Do you want to hang it up?" Adora cups her hands over Glimmer's. "We can put it back if you want."

Glimmer thinks for a moment. Her eyes remain downcast. The hunter chews on the bottom of her lip as she thinks. Adora wishes

she could open that head of hers, see what is going on, and fight any negative thoughts that are swirling around in there.

“No. Let’s hang it.” Glimmer says.

“Okay.” Adora lets go of Glimmer’s hands. She watches as her girlfriend slowly stands to her feet and makes her way over to the tree. In the corner of her eye, Adora sees Bow watching just like her. Glimmer finds a place, almost centered on the tree. Once on, she takes a step back, arms crossing against her chest.

Adora rises to her feet and walks up behind her girlfriend. She gently places a hand on one of Glimmer’s shoulders. Bow joins them as well, putting his own hand on his friend’s other shoulder.

“It’s looking great,” Bow says. “How about we light her up?”

“It’s still daylight out,” Glimmer states. She makes an extra point to look out the window. “There isn’t even a cloud in the sky.”

“So? You still can have the lights on! Back me up, Adora!”

“Hey, leave me out of this!” Adora retorts. “I don’t know what to do on Christmas outside of cartoons!”

Glimmer bursts out laughing. “Don’t fight, please. We can turn it on for a little while, how does that sound?”

A grin forms on Bow’s face, going from ear to ear. He quickly is at the outlet, plugging it in. The lights come to life, shining in a bright white color. Everyone takes a seat on the couch, looking at their handiwork. Adora feels a sense of pride swelling inside of her chest. Part of her wants to decorate another tree. Though, she doesn’t want to lose the magic by doing it over and over again.

Glimmer rests her head against Adora’s shoulder. She grabs her arms like a koala bear. “Still liking decorating now that you put the lights up?”

“Heck yeah I do!”

“Wait until we gotta take everything down and pack it all away,” Bow states.

Adora retorts by sticking out her tongue.

“Oh, Adora. Dig into that bag. There’s something there you might like.” Glimmer points to the closest one to them. Adora does as she is told and begins searching. Most of what she feels are some things that need to go upstairs in the bathroom. But then, her fingers brush across something covered in plastic.

“A chocolate bar?” Adora questions as she brings it into her line of sight.

“Before you say anything, no. I didn’t buy it. I, uh, actually bumped into Catra in the parking lot of the library. She wanted you to have it. Remember that you have a sweet tooth. You good?”

Adora tosses the bar in her hands. She feels a stab at her heart at the thought of Catra in general. But she is surprised that her sister remembered such a small detail about herself. Adora can feel the corners of her mouth ever so slightly twitch upward. Any anger towards her sister she might have, becomes nothing more than a simmer.

“Yeah…” Adora starts slowly. She sets it down on the nearby table. “I’ll have it later but I guess I owe her a thank you.”

Adora rolls onto her side, eyes landing on her girlfriend. Glimmer is curled up besides her, face half buried in the covers. This only muffles her snores. Part of Adora does not want to disturb her slumber. She could stay here forever and watch the hunter sleep all day. But today, well everyone agreed to wake up on the earlier side. Open some presents and enjoy each other’s company. Bow has stayed the night to celebrate and there is a good chance he already is up.

Adora reaches out a hand, using the back to stroke Glimmer's cheek. The hunter half mumbles, half groans. She buries her face further into the blankets. Adora scoffs, ready to take on this challenge. Fingers grasp the hem of the covers, pulling them down. Before Glimmer can protest, Adora quickly places a kiss on her girlfriend's nose.

"Gah!" Glimmer jerks back, whipping her face. "What was that for?"

"I can't kiss you?" Adora chuckles. She gives the hunter another kiss on the nose.

"Did you have to do it while I was sleeping?"

"Yes. You are so cute when you sleep! But remember our agreement? We have to get up."

Glimmer flops onto her back, one arm draped over her eyes. She lets out a long sigh. "Can't I have five more minutes?"

"You are going to pass out within five *seconds.* C'mon on. We shouldn't keep Bow waiting. Plus, I want you to be part of my first Christmas. What do you say?"

Glimmer removes her arm, letting her head roll to the side. While there is a small cloud of sleep in her eyes, the light in them grows and sparkles. "I can't say no to that, can I? Alright, alright. But you are cooking breakfast!"

"That's a fair enough trade."

Adora gives Glimmer one more kiss before sitting up. She hears the bed squeaking as her girlfriend pries herself off of the bed. Neither bothers to get dressed, at least not yet, and make their way out of the bedroom and downstairs. Bow is already out of the guest room. He sits on the couch, a book in hand, and glasses resting on his nose. Once he hears his friends coming close, he looks up.

“Can’t believe you got Glim to wake up at this hour,” Bow states. He puts both his glasses and book on the coffee table.

“Shut up,” Glimmer quickly spats back. She plops herself down by the tree. There are only a few gifts under it. Apparently there will be more coming from Glimmer’s father and aunt. They just have to *get* here.

Before doing anything else, Adora quickly puts on the coffee maker. While that warms up, she joins Glimmer, and now Bow, on the ground. Half asleep, the hunter yawns as she grabs one of the gifts. She reads the label, taking a bit longer than she should, before tossing it at Bow. it doesn’t take long for everyone to get their presents, two for each of them.

Bow gets a small toy robot, powered by solar panels, to build from Glimmer. From Adora, he gets a DVD of a season from his favorite show. Meanwhile, Glimmer gets a bag of her favorite coffee from Bow and from Adora, she gets a box of chocolate covered strawberries. Finally, to top everything off, Adora begins to unwrap her gifts. From Bow, she gets her some new sandalwood soap and from Glimmer a necklace with a rubber sword, colored in the lesbian flag, hanging from the chain.

“I think this is better for you to chew on than your hoodie string,” Glimmer says.

“Thanks.” Adora quickly puts it on, tucking the sword under her t-shirt for safe keeping.

“So, how was your first Christmas?” Bow asks. “Sorry if it wasn’t a lot.”

“No, it was great!” Adora leans back on her hands. “Honestly, just spending time with you guys is more than I can ask for.”

She shuts her eyes, mind wandering for a moment. Her mother never had a tree up for her or Catra, never bothered to really get presents. Adora has no rhythm or reason for her mother’s reason not to celebrate other than to suck away any possible fun. She

pushes away the thought of if her birth family, wherever they may be, celebrates today or not.

But Glimmer, Bow, Scorpia, and Perfuma have been more than enough. Hell, Sea Hawk and Mermista have a New Year's party planned, another thing to look forward to that she never really celebrated. Her heart feels light at the thought of being with her friends and enjoying themselves even more. Honestly, having them around is a present enough.

"This is great." Adora says as she opens her eyes. "Thank you, guys."

Both Bow and Glimmer grin from ear to ear. And Adora can't help but smile as well.

Chapter End Notes

> comments/kudos appreciated!!!!!!!!!! I do have other things I am gonna post during the werewolf break (cause I also hit a wall i need a break from that) so look out for some of that!

The Wolf's Moon

Chapter Notes

> heyo i am back!! so this time around we will have 4 chapters and all of them are pretty long so i hope you enjoy! the support i have been getting has helped me keep up with this and I am glad yall have stuck with me for so long ^^
>
> so for tw in this some flashbacks really and some mentions of blood/injury. This chapter had one of my fav scenes I ever wrote to enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

New Year's comes and goes. Somehow, Adora managed to stay awake past midnight. Though, that's thanks in part due to Sea Hawk jabbing her in the side with her finger every time she had begun to nod off. Though, just after midnight rolled around, Adora promptly passed out on the couch. Despite tending to be a light sleeper, nothing but the morning sun could wake her up after that. At least she woke up with a blanket over her body and nothing written on her face.

Now, that fun has come and gone. It is back to business. Meaning, pushing forward. More attempting to figure out both how Shadow Weaver is preventing others from shifting in death and where she will strike next. Her silence the past month does not sit well. Even if it allows Adora and everyone else to come up with a game plan (if they ever *can*), the same thing goes for Shadow Weaver. Who knows what she is plotting.

Adora leans back against the passenger side door of Glimmer's car. She chews on the necklace Glimmer gave her for Christmas. In her hands, is one of the many books from the library. So far there has been nothing truly useful. All the two have been able to gather is people really love to use silver (which is correct) and fire (which is only half correct) in their stories when informing others

how to defend themselves against werewolves. At the moment, she reads a more general book, one about multiple creatures. More books wait in the trunk.

The plan of the day, or rather *days,* is to meet up with Petra before the next full moon. The Wolf's Moon to be exact. Adora doesn't really want to dwell too much on that thought. If everything goes as planned, if this snowstorm is just being blown up by the news, then they'll be safe at the werebear's house for the worst shift of the year. They have said they and their siblings are more than equipped to handle Adora if things go south.

Things won't go south! Adora yells at herself.

She turns a page of her book. The page that looks up at her is about the shape shifting sea folk Selkies. There is not much on them and Adora doubts Glimmer would know more. What little she knows, Selkies aren't common. Least, in their human form. Sea Hawk and Mermista would possibly know more living under the waves. Even if there is not a lot of information on them, at least this is keeping her distracted. She needs it.

Adora bites down harder on her sword. She swears she could easily puncture it at the moment. Catra will be tagging along for this trip. Petra wanted to meet her and gain her own perspective on the werepanther. Seeing as her sister does not have a car and the bus would be utter hell, there is little choice in the matter. Adora just has to survive being so close to Catra just for the car ride there and back. Everyone will be staying at Petra at least for a couple nights due to the distance but at least there, there will be breathing room. Now only if her sister would come down already.

Another page. Another creature. Unicorns. Creatures with magic like faeries though a little more broad than just plants or water or what have you. However, the ink on the pages have begun to blend together. Adora marks the page before snapping it shut. "I'm about to go in there and drag her out."

“Me too,” Glimmer buries her face in the scarf around her neck and tucks her hands in the sleeves of her jacket. Her voice is muffled as she speaks. “At this rate I am going to become an icicle and you’ll have to drive all the way there.”

“Why don’t you sit in the car? Warm up, hon.”

“Are you sure?”

“Hm. Go.” Adora gestures with her head.

Glimmer says nothing else before ducking into the warmth of the car. Thankfully, however, only a minute or so after the hunter starts up the engine, the doors to the hotel open. Catra steps out into the frigid world. She’s almost as bundled up as Glimmer is.

“I still never will understand how you don’t freeze to death,” Catra huffs.

Adora shrugs. “Is that all you have?” She points at the large backpack behind her sister.

“Yeah. We aren’t staying *that* long, right? I’m gonna pack again if not.”

“You’re fine. Besides, we need to get going. You can either put your stuff in the trunk or keep it with you in the back.”

Catra answers by walking past Adora and opening up the back door. She tosses her bag on the other side before jumping in herself. With everything in order, Adora takes her place on the passenger seat. The moment she buckles herself up, Glimmer drives off. Adora leans back against her seat, getting ready for the long trip ahead.

With one hand on the wheel, Glimmer fumbles around her center console. After a couple of moments of mumbling and pushing hidden items aside, the hunter pulls out a tape. She shuts the console, allowing for both her and Adora to rest their elbows

when needed, and shoves the cassette into her radio. Some punk rock band starts to escape from the speakers.

“Do we have to listen to this?” Catra groans from behind.

Adora sees the biggest, shit eating grin form on Glimmer’s face. She pinches the knob and slowly turns up the volume. The hunter stops short of blasting it. The werepanther lets out a louder groan before flopping back in the seat. Glimmer throws her head back, laughing. Adora can’t help but snicker as well.

Catra digs around in her bag before she grabs a set of headphones. She shoves them in her ears and looks down at her phone.

"Do you want me to lower it at all?" Glimmer asks Adora.

"Nah. It's fine for now," Adora replies. "I'll let you know when my ears start to hurt."

Glimmer gives a thumbs up before focusing back on the road. The GPS shows a long road ahead. Adora grabs a book from her backpack, a different one from the last. This time around, she decides on a book of fables and fairy tales. She gets lost in the story about faery rings and their strange magic.

How if one dares to step into them, time will pass you in the *blink* of an eye. This tale in particular tells of a young boy who ran out into the woods, following something that caught his attention. He barely took notice of the rings until he saw the small, glowing creatures. Still, even then, fear never worked its way into his heart.

Instead of tucking his tail and heading back home, back to *safety,* he stays. He plays with the faeries for what only seems like an hour or two at most. Nothing to worry about. However, upon returning home, he found his parents old, as if they were his grandparents' age. And that now, he was an adult.

A shiver runs down Adora's spine. She flips to a new story, hopefully one that doesn't give her an existential crisis. Story after story she reads. She knows there won't be many answers to the questions she seeks. But at the same time, at least she can learn more about the world around her. Creatures that are common like her. How pegasus and griffins soar high in the sky. How sea serpents that hide deep within the underwater trenches.

She gets to ones that many don't know about, ones that are low in numbers and or keep to themselves from human kind. Phoenixes, who turn to ash at death but moments later, a newborn chick pops its head out from the embers. Or a banshee, who's wail forebodes death. A terrible power to have, knowing a life will be lost soon.

Words begin to blend together. Letters are nothing more than ink blobs. The shaking of the car is doing little to help. In fact, it's like the blotches are bouncing around like an old Windows computer screen saver. Adora snaps the book shut. She pinches the bridge of her nose.

"You okay?" Glimmer asks.

"Yeah. Yeah, I'm fine. This is just the probably hundredth book I read. Eyes just hurt."

"Then stop reading."

"Noted."

Adora takes a look at the GPS sitting on the dash. Still *quite* a hike away from Petra's home. The blonde can't recall the last time she was in the car for this long of a time. The music from Glimmer's counties seep out of the radio speakers.

"What do you think Petra's siblings are like? They got three of them." Adora says.

"Hopefully not all like Drake. He seems like a handful," Glimmer replies, a chuckle in her voice.

“I can’t wait to meet them all. Hopefully with all our heads together we can come up with a game plan.”

“This storm just has to hold off for a little longer.” Glimmer lifts a finger from the steering wheel. Clouds have blocked the whole sky, leaving no room for blue to appear.

Adora and Glimmer keep up some chatter as they continue down the highway. Exit signs of places Adora has never heard of pass overhead. She wonders what some of those places are like. She has seen many different towns, big and little, in her time hopping around with no place to call her own. So many of those towns and cities, their names and what landmark belongs to who, blur together. Adora very well could be passing somewhere she stayed at for a while and not even know it.

At least twice, someone cuts Glimmer off without the use of the blinker. Adora has to hold her laughter from her girlfriend saying every curse under the sun and flipping them off. Each time, after swallowing her back her chuckles, the blonde reassures Glimmer that they are not worth it.

Things slowly turn into small talk, neither really knowing what else to talk about. There is only so much you can go on in a long car ride without things getting boring. By the time they cross a state line, silence falls between them. Adora starts to play games on her phone, hoping to pass the time before they reach a rest stop. Though, Glimmer eventually speaks up as they hit a slight bit of traffic.

“She fell asleep.” Glimmer says.

Adora looks over her shoulder. Sure enough, Catra is out cold. She’s curled up on her seat, legs tucked under her. Her jacket has become a pillow as she rests her head against the cold window. Headphones are still in her ears. Catra does not snore at all, she is as quiet as can be as she snoozes away. Adora swears there is a little bit of drool coming out of the corner of her mouth.

Something tugs at Adora's heart. A sudden, sharp pain that comes straight out of left field. Something that wants to tear up all her insides and leave her for dead. For a moment, she does not see Catra as she is. A young woman, barely younger than herself. The person who refused to come with her when she extended her hand only to attack her a month later. Someone who has harmed Adora and left her body scared.

No. No, she sees her as that twelve-year-old girl, still adjusting to life with Adora and Shadow Weaver. Her first move and trapped in the car for many hours. Wondering what was going on and where they would be going. Adora sees just *them,* her and Catra, sticking together through it all.

Such simpler times.

"Everything alright, Starlight?"

"It's nothing," Adora mutters. She rests her head against her own window. The low vibrations do not bother her. Eyes stare off at the mix of woods and cliffs that zip by her. The sky continues to darken, threatening to spill out the tons of snow they hold inside. Adora's mind wanders… "It's nothing at all."

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13 Years Ago

The dark sky lights up in a pale, *bright,* flash. There is no time to breathe before the crackle of thunder tears through the air. Adora swears that the car trembles at noise. Her hands slap over her ears. The noise sounds like a cannon has exploded mere inches away from her. When the ring fades away, she places her hands back in her lap. She hopes that this car ride does not last much longer. It already feels like a month has passed.

At least this time around she isn't alone in the back seat. Her new found sister sits right next to her. Catra stares out the foggy window. She runs her finger against the glass, drawing any shapes that come to mind. They disappear only moments later as

the fog takes over again. later Rain continues to hit the side of the car. Much like Adora, whenever a clap of thunder echoes through the world, she flinches. Sometimes a yelp escapes her.

Other than that, Catra has not said much. She did not like the idea of moving—got quite upset at the fact. But once their mother has made up her mind, there is no use in fighting. You will never win against her. Catra continued to grumble the whole time they packed until they got in the car. Adora is pretty sure she hasn't heard one word from her sister since they left.

There is no rule against talking. As long as they don't get loud or bicker, their mother shouldn't care about what they do. This ride is already boring enough. Her gameboy has died and any batteries there would be shoved with everything else in the trunk. What else is she really supposed to do?

Adora leans as far forward as she can, restricted by her seat belt, and taps her sister on the shoulder. Catra jumps slightly before snapping her head around. "What?"

"You've been really quiet. You alright?"

Catra huffs. "I'm fine. Just don't like being trapped in the car for a long time." She pauses for a moment. "You do this a lot? We are just going to a new house, right?"

"Yeah. You get used to it, don't worry. It's kind of fun to guess what type of house it will be."

Her sister chuckles. "Why am I not surprised you made a game out of that? But, thank you. Good to know."

"Gotta have fun, right? Did ya wanna take a guess?"

"N-No." Catra crosses her arms against her chest, looking down at her feet.

Adora tilts her head. Something heavy fills the air. She can't quite put a name to it but she feels an invisible weight press down

against her chest. A frown forms on the young blonde's face. She thinks for a moment, chewing on her lower lip. Is there anything in the car she can use to help out her sister?

Out of the corner of her eye, Adora sees the flash of a bolt of lighting connecting against the open field. The largest clap of thunder she has ever heard fills her ears. This time, the car *definitely* shakes. While their mother remains unfazed by the eruption of noise, the pair of sisters jump. Adora hears a curse leave Catra's lips.

"Stupid thunder!" the werepanther growls. "Why does it have to be so loud!"

More thinking. Even if Catra is only some months younger than her, Adora is still technically older. She is an older sister now and she has to act like it. A thought comes to her quickly, like second nature. She wraps an arm around Catra's neck and shoulder and brings her as close as possible.

"Hey, remember what I said? Nothing bad is gonna happen now that we have each other!" Adora grins. "We are safe in the car and once we get to our new home, well that is going to be exciting! You can finally have a bed all to yourself."

"That sounds nice…"

Adora lowers her voice to a whisper, hoping that her mother won't hear her. "And if we get lucky, maybe there will be woods nearby and we can explore them! How does that sound?"

"I can't wait to see you eat shit falling out of a tree." A smile finally forms on Catra's face.

"Hey, who says you won't first?"

"Cause I am the feline and you the canine. Is it that hard to guess who has the advantage?"

"Guess we will see."

The sisters continue to talk, laughing and making jokes together. They tear open the few snacks they have with them in the back seats of the car to settle their growling stomachs. The rain does not let up at all and neither does the thunder. Yet, eventually, Catra falls asleep. She rests her body against Adora, head on her shoulder. Adora herself begins to find herself nodding off, the car vibrates pulling her into the world of dreams. Plus, having someone besides him pushes her further into unconsciousness.

Adora does not try to fight it anymore. Resting her head on Catra's and listening to the rain pitter-patter on the glass, she happily falls asleep with her sister.

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The shout from her girlfriend, coupled with sudden breakage, jolts Adora awake from her slumber. She snaps her head around, trying to figure out what the hell is going on. Large snowflakes begin to flutter down from the dark grey sky. Already, some of it covers the ground. Grass shoots just recently freed from past melt struggle to stick out from the fluff.

In front of the car, there are headlights of other vehicles. More than usual. Adora snaps her head towards Glimmer. The hunter runs a hand through her hair, grumbling something. Looking behind her, she sees her sister is wide awake as well. Catra pulls her headphones out and leans between the gap of the driver and passenger seat. "The fuck is going on?"

"There is traffic first off." Glimmer states. She shuts off her music and quickly fiddles with the radio. The local radio station comes on. Sure enough, they are talking about a road accident a few miles up from them. It will only be a matter of time before the trio reaches a total standstill.

"Second of all," Glimmer continues, "the weather. The news sure as shit got it wrong and the storm is coming early. With the traffic I don't think there's any way we are gonna make it to Petra's."

“You want me to text them?” Adora asks, already digging into her jeans’ pocket.

“Yes please.”

“So what are we supposed to do?” Catra asks.

“Hope that there is a hotel or something nearby that has rooms and hunker down. Like hell I am driving in a snowstorm.”

“Do you want me to see if there is one close by? I can book something before it all fills up.”

“Uh, yeah sure. Thank you, Catra.”

Catra rests herself back against her seat. “Just pay me back later.”

Adora checks her phone the moment it vibrates in her hands. “Petra says that’s fine. They hope we get to safety and just let them know when we are back on the road.”

While Catra and Glimmer figure out what is the best hotel nearby and won’t cost too much, Adora checks the weather. Tonight will be fine, one night in a hotel room won’t kill anyone. But tomorrow…tomorrow is what worries her. If it becomes impossible to leave, if the roads are backed up and are nothing more than snow and ice, the Wolf’s Moon will have a fun time torturing her.

Adora chews on her thumb as she checks. Her heart drops into the pit of her stomach as she looks at the hourly forecast. Snow, snow, and more snow. It doesn’t look like it will end until mid-afternoon tomorrow. The window of opportunity to get to Petra’s house before the full moon will be *far* too narrow. Adora gnaws harder on her thumb.

Better not go attacking everyone in the whole hotel! Probably will have a kill count just like your mother!

“Adora, you’re necklace,” Glimmer reminds her.

Adora quickly switches out her thumb for her necklace. A less painful alternative.

“What’s wrong?”

“Just worried about tomorrow night. I don’t want to be stuck in a hotel room tomorrow.”

“We will figure it out.” Glimmer reaches a hand out. Fingers interlace with Adora’s. “Take a breath.”

Adora takes a deep, long breath through her nose. It does little to keep her heart doing laps around her stomach. At least, though, her mind decides to quiet down an octave or two. She gives a squeeze back.

“Hey, lovedodos,” Catra cuts in. Her hand shoots out between them. “I got a place! One room for the two of you and one for me. Take the next exit!”

“Sweet. I don’t think that is too far away. We can get inside before the storm really hits!”

The three stay on the lookout for the exit, looking for any of the signs. It’s Adora who spots it first, pointing it out the moment it appears. By some stroke of luck, just as the traffic is about to become a standstill, the turn appears. Glimmer squeezes by some cars and finally gets away from the highway of hell. From there, it is smooth sailing. They enter a medium-sized town. There are some restaurants, a bookstore, and a couple grocery stores to name a few things. Cars line the supermarket. There doesn’t look to be any parking spots available.

“Glad I ain’t working in retail anymore,” Catra states. Suddenly, she points forward. “There! I think it’s up on the hill.”

Glimmer makes a quick turn to the right. Unlike the parking lot down below, there are spaces. Not a lot but at least some. Glimmer parks the car in a spot in the middle of the lot. Everyone gathers their things and exits. The world has become cold, air

nipping at any exposed skin. The snow piling up on the ground crunches under everyone’s boots. Inside, thankfully, the heat quickly melts away growing frost on their bones

Catra checks everyone in. It’s revealed that the two rooms are on the third floor and across from each other. With everything now set, the three head up. There is a bit of awkward silence as they wait in the elevator. At least there isn’t any music to add to it. After three dings, the metal doors open wide.

The hotel is no different from the one months prior. Only the difference are the patterns of the carpet and the pictures that hang against the walls. The atmosphere remains the same. Surreal. A place to call home while away from home. So many people have passed through these halls and many remain hidden behind closed doors. Inside, rooms will be immaculate. Through the window, in the distance, you’ll be able to see the nearby city. One so familiar yet foreign. Nothing like Brightmoon.

“Well, here we are.” Glimmer taps the room card on the scanner. The *click* from unlocking fills the air. “Guess we gotta see what the hell happens tomorrow.”

“Guess so, yeah.” Catra unlocks her own door. “I’ll see you idiots later. Keep me updated.”

“See ya later.”

With that, they go their separate ways.

Glimmer watches Adora flop face first into the bed. The blonde does not budge, keeping half her body on the mattress and half off. While she cements herself, Glimmer does a quick check of the room. Nothing at all to note. Just your regular hotel room.

She sets up her bags besides Adora's. The TV is turned on to whatever channel was left for background noise. With everything in place and not in the mood to unpack, Glimmer joins her

girlfriend on the bed. Instead of lying face down, the hunter rests on her back.

Adora remains still.

"You dead?" Glimmer asks.

Adora gives a thumbs down.

"How are you holding up?"

This time, she receives a 'so-so' gesture.

"I feel that. At least we don't have to worry about being stuck out in the cold. We probably should listen to the weather later and see how long this storm lasts."

Finally, Adora twists her head. "Hopefully not long."

"Hopefully." Glimmer stretches out before sitting back up. "What time is it?"

"I think like three or four."

"Well I don't know about you but I need a shower."

"Alright. I might go searching for a vending machine. You want me to get you anything?"

"Surprise me."

There isn't much to note for the rest of the day. The weather outside becomes almost like a blizzard. Wind howling, only able to see a thick sheet of white for miles, and if anyone dares step outside they are turned into icicles almost instantly. According to many news reports, this storm will not end until late afternoon the next day. Roads won't be cleared until a little while later. No one really wants to think about that fact.

To get their minds off of things, Adora and Glimmer head down to the bottom of the hotel to see if there is anything to do. The latter

of which does not care she is already in her pajamas. To no one's surprise, there isn't much to do. There's the inside pool that no one is prepared to use, a gym that no one has ever seen anyone use, and a small room connected to the lobby. The doors are closed and probably won't be opened until the morning.

Speaking of the lobby, it is almost packed. Everyone who did not get the memo early about the fast moving storm sure as shit have gotten it now. People trying to figure out what rooms they will be in and for how long while the staff attempts to keep up with the flood of patrons. Glimmer wonders if there is any chance someone is a hunter or non-human.

So instead, they wander around the halls aimlessly. Adora and Glimmer talk about whatever comes to mind. If they should just eat snacks or see what the hell room service has to offer. What there might be on the limited television stations. Anything and everything to get their minds off of things.

Neither sees Catra until the next morning in the area closed off before. Some breakfast has been placed out for others to grab. Glimmer grabs some scrambled eggs, toast, and sausage. Adora grabs something similar, the only difference is grabbing a small box of cereal which she shoves in her jacket pocket. As they search for somewhere to sit, that's when they spot Catra. Sitting on a far table, some strangers around her. She ignores them, however, by paying attention to something on her phone.

Glimmer and Adora somehow find a spot for both of them to sit together at. As they eat, the hunter takes a look through one of the windows. The world is still white as ever. She wonders if she ever is going to dig out her car. From what Bow has told her, Brightmoon is getting a punch but not as badly as here. Glimmer wishes here had been so lucky. Thankfully, he has offered to shovel the house once he is done with his.

"Adora, you need to eat."

None of her food has been touched. All Adora does is poke and prod at what is on her plate. Her other hand keeps her head propped up. It takes her a moment to register the question that has been asked. “Huh? Sorry. I’m not that hungry, Glim.”

“Then why did you get so much food?”

Adora shrugs. “Thought I’d be.”

“What’s on your mind? Is it Catra or…,” Glimmer lowers her voice, “you know.”

“The latter. I’m still hoping by some miracle we can get out of this place and to Petra’s. God, I hate this time of year.”

Suddenly, the wind picks up once more, almost howling like last night all over again. Lights flicker momentarily. As the wind settles, the power returns to normal. Glimmer lets out a sigh through her teeth. Could the hotel really lose electricity?

Glimmer eventually persuades Adora to eat at least half of her food. Small nibbles turn into decent bites. At least the box of cereal remains in her pocket for later. People begin to stream out and head back into their rooms. When Adora clearly isn’t going to eat anymore, the pair decide to head up as well. Though, before leaving, they decided together on something.

Inviting Catra up to their room. Everyone needs to be on the same page about what is happening. Having already finished her meal, Catra follows them up, no questions asked. In the room, they watch the news report yet again. Nothing has changed. The storm is here to stay for several more hours. If anything, the end time has been pushed a little further into the afternoon.

Adora groans, burying her face into her hands. Glimmer doesn’t know what to say. There is no place to tie her girlfriend up if needed. The only thing of use is the wolfsbane in her suitcase. It is the only thing that will keep Adora from a building full of people if the worst outcome happens. Even if the nights have slowly shortened, this one will be *long.*

It’s Catra who breaks the silence. She leans back against her hands. “Well, fuck.”

Her body feels like it is on *fire.* Tiny needles prick every part of her skin, refusing to leave. Adora’s body shakes violently from the impending shift. It already has thrown up what little dinner she had before, breaking her long streak of not doing as such. The taste of bile continues to sting her tongue. Breathes come out jagged. Nothing she does will help her gain control of it. How can it while tears are pricking at the edges of her eyes?

All she can do is rest on her side against the cold, bathroom tile. It barely helps cool her off but feeling like she’s in a volcano rather than the center of the sun is better than nothing. Adora tries to focus on something else. Something other than the wolf wanting to take over. How her fingers are still small and blunt as she curls and uncurls them. How her arms are meant for hugging and holding.

Or how Glimmer’s fingers brush gently against her neck. Occasionally, the hunter softly speaks words of reassurance. ‘I’m here’ or ‘It will be over soon.’ Whenever Adora’s body has a violent pre-shift shake, the hunter squeezes the hand she holds. Sometimes, placing a kiss on the back.

“I’m scared,” Adora whimpers. “I d-don’t want t-t-to hur-”

“Shh.” Glimmer cuts her off. “Don’t say that. You won’t.”

Adora’s body curls in on itself. She feels her nails and teeth growing. It’s almost time. Pain is spreading all through her bones and muscles. Her stomach twists so tight inside she swears she is going to throw up again. With her legs being like jell-o, there will be no way she can make it to the toilet again. Teeth begin to chatter as Adora speaks again.

“I love you, G-Glitter-Bug.”

“I love you too, Starlight.”

These are the last words Adora hears before the world turns black.

Glimmer doesn’t want to move. She doesn’t want to let go of Adora’s hand. But there is no choice. There is little room in the bathroom to move, little in the way to dodge an accidental swipe of a hand or attempted bite during the shift. Glimmer snatches her crossbow, (thank god the hotel didn’t check her luggage) already poised with an arrow laced with wolfsbane before scrambling into the bathtub.

Adora jerks harder than ever before. Her foot hits the cabinet with force. Thankfully, not breaking the wood. Hopefully no one is in the room below them hearing all this commotion. Glimmer has zero idea what to do if that happens. The shift seems to take forever this time and the bathroom shrinks. Adora’s body barely can be contained by the room. After what seems like an entirety has passed, the wolf in front of her flops to the ground. Other than her chest, there is no movement at all.

“A-Adora?” Glimmer whispers. She keeps her hands gripped on her weapon as she swallows a lump in her throat. The hunter tries speaking again. “Adora, are you there?”

A low groan catches her attention. Slowly, Glimmer leans forward. Adora’s head is propped up on the tub while her legs half rest on the cabinet below the sink. Her werewolf form looks more akin to the one back in November. Though, the Wolf’s Moon has caused some differences. Besides growing in size, her hands are more like that of her original form. Teeth look even sharper as if they can cut through bone like butter. Her fur is the same shade as her hair yet it looks a little rough to the touch.

The truth, however, lies in her eyes. They flutter open, revealing golden eyes. Adora blinks before twisting her body. The werewolf stares up at Glimmer with confusion written all over her face.

“Oh, thank god,” Glimmer sighs. She drops the weapon and reaches a hand out. Fingers scratch right under Adora’s chin. Right away, her tail begins to wag. A low moan escapes Adora’s lips as her eyes squint. “New favorite spot, huh?”

Adora lets out a small woof. Without thinking, Glimmer wraps her hands around Adora’s muzzle. “Shh! Shh! Don’t bark!”

Adora begins to paw at Glimmer’s fingers, whining. The hunter releases her girlfriend, letting her girlfriend rub her nose “Sorry. But you *can’t* bark. We don’t want to get kicked out, do we? Please show me some sign that you understand me.”

She gets an answer by the form a lick to the face. While wiping off her face, Adora rests her chin against the tub edge. Yellow eyes flick up, lights of joy bright as ever. With a smile, Glimmer gives a peck between Adora’s eyes and rises to her feet. She must carefully maneuver around the bathroom and towards the door. However, at the last moment, before she can fully exit, Glimmer ends up tripping over herself. She barely has enough time to break her fall by sticking out her arms. They connect with the wall.

“What a way to start the night,” Glimmer remarks.

Looking over her shoulder, she sees Adora twisting around, struggling to flip over onto her feet. After several moments of struggles, and letting out annoyed huffs, she manages to get herself upright and walk out the bathroom. Adora sits down and tilts her head.

"I don't know what to do either," Glimmer replies. "We have to stay inside and be quiet."

She decides to look through her bag, hoping for something to keep her girlfriend occupied during these long, dark hours. Hands dig through clothing, medicine, and some knicknacks. Finally, her hands land on something that can possibly be useful.

Glimmer waves Adora over. The large werewolf saunters over. She attempts to shove her muzzle into the bag, making it a few inches before she is shoved away by her girlfriend. With breathing room, Glimmer pulls out her treasure. A strong rope toy. Adora's eyes grow wide. Teeth immediately grab the toy, snatching it away from the hunter's hand.

Adora quickly finds a spot before plopping down on the ground. She gnaws against the rope, sometimes tugging at it. Glimmer chuckles slightly before scooting over towards her girlfriends. Fingers begin to rub the back of one of Adora's ears. Her tail wags behind her.

This is nice, Glimmer thinks. No TV for background noise and the wind no longer howls on the top of its lungs. Tomorrow, Adora will wake up with, hopefully, some of her memories. They'll be at Petra's house and get to meet the rest of her family. Come together and work on a plan of attack or at least, gather a little more knowledge.

But for tonight, it's just them. Adora is distracted and happy with her toy. Glimmer is distracted and happy watching her doopy girlfriend. She might not be at her house, she might not be in her bedroom or living room, but she is at home. The hunter leans back against Adora's side, letting herself get lost in the moment.

She doesn't know how long it is until a rapid knock fills her ears. Both Glimmer and Adora look at each other, equally as confused. Hesitantly, Glimmer rises to her feet and walks up to the door. She peers out the peephole, finding no one.

"What the hell?" Glimmer mutters. She twists her head around. Adora has drawn a little closer, eyes blinking with wonder. "I don't think it was anyone."

Another knock proves her wrong. Glimmer looks once more. This time, instead of seeing the carpet and walls of the hotel, she sees a bright blue eye staring at her. Glimmer suppresses a yelp wanting to break free from her throat.

“I hear you shuffling in there! Open up!”

“C-Catra? What the hell?!? That was you knocking?!?”

"Yes! Now let me in before someone sees me!" Catra's voice seeps through the door in a hiss.

Glimmer flicks the latch, twists the lock knob, and pushes down on the handle. The moment the door cracks open, a flash of brown flies past the hunter. She quickly shuts and locks the door once more before examining what has just entered.

A large feline. Fur is a dark brown. The hair around her neck almost makes a sort of mane. On her legs and back there are stripes. She is larger than a mountain lion and has some more muscles to her. Though, she remains smaller than Adora. Cyan and amber eyes, pupils slitted, blink at Glimmer. For a moment, the hunter no longer finds herself in the hotel room. Instead, she is on the forest floor, hot, wet pain radiating from stomach.

Glimmer jerks back, colliding with the door behind her. The hotel room comes back into view, though the edges are blurred. She focuses on keeping her breathing from becoming erratic.

“You okay there?” Catra asks. Pointed ears flick.

“I’m fine.” Glimmer shakes her head free from any lingering memories as well as the blur. She walks towards Adora, leaving a large gap between her and Catra. Adora quickly is at her side, eyes locked onto her sister. The fur on her neck stands at attention. “What are you doing here?”

Catra remains unfazed by this. She stretches out, yawning, before lying down on the ground. “Was bored in my room. Wanted to see what you two were up to. Does Adora actually have some control? Amazing.”

“Some. Though, I advise not pissing her off.”

“Don’t worry, I won’t.”

“You can relax, Adora.” Glimmer places her hand on top of Adora’s head.

The fur on Adora’s neck settles. She blows a puff of air through her nose before pacing around the room. Glimmer decides to settle down on the bed, sitting cross legged. For several moments, she watches Adora walking about. She does not seem happy with any spot she sniffs. She even ignores her toy, stepping right over it. Occasionally, Adora lets out an annoyed chuff. Eventually, she settles down by the balcony door. Her breath fogs up the glass.

Glimmer rubs the back of her head. She honestly is at a loss at what to do. If only the snow ended earlier. Maybe then they could have made it to Petra’s. There would be more freedom to move about. Looking at the alarm clock sitting on the nightstand there are many hours left in the night.

“So, is this what you usually do during shifts with her?” Catra asks. She has her eyes on Adora, who still stares out the window.

“Lately, yes. What do you normally do?” Glimmer replies.

“Sleep. Go out on a hike. Whatever so I am not bored. Better than being with Mom.”

A low growl fills the air. Adora’s ears fall back against her head and her hair stands back at attention.

“Really was bad, huh? What the hell happened, if I can ask.”

“You can say that. I didn’t get control for a while so I don’t remember much of the earlier times. Mom always made sure whatever new house we went to had a basement so no one didn’t break out and attack someone without her permission. Once I could start remembering, she paid more attention to Adora. Didn’t care if I stayed or left. Only rule was not to cause trouble.

“Anyway, you know the story. Adora never got control, never really agreed with Mom. She kept waiting for the moment Adora would listen and wouldn’t just go off of bloodthirsty rage.

Sometimes Mom actually left me alone with Adora so she could do whatever it is she did. There isn't much to note after Adora left."

Adora now whines. She has curled up into a ball. Golden eyes look down at the ground, Glimmer swearing they are misty. The hunter pats the bed beside her. Ear flick up and Adora quickly reaches to the bed and hops up. She returns to her curled up position, body pressed up against Glimmer's thigh.

With one hand rubbing Adora's side, Glimmer's places her other against her stomach. Her scars ache and itch. She does her best to ignore it, as usual, but between the Wolf's Moon and a new thought, it becomes impossible. That thought, being, her own lack of a shift.

She still wonders how she survived that night. She could have easily bleed to death right there in the woods, just like her mother. If it wasn't for her friends, Glimmer probably *would* have died. Yet, she was given some semblance of powers for her mistake. Her senses and her healing. The worse she gets, however, are these aches during the full moon. Nothing close to what Adora is forced to suffer through once a month for the rest of her life.

"Does it always hurt?" Glimmer asks. She looks down at Adora, wishing she knew what she was thinking right about now. "The shifts."

"Truthfully? Yeah. I mean, your *whole body* is breaking, tearing, and contorting into a whole ass other creature. How wouldn't that hurt?" Catra replies.

"So it never gets better…How do you deal with that?"

"You get used to it. Simple as that. Sometimes it's better, sometimes it's killer, and sometimes it's in between. You learn to live with it." Catra pauses for a moment. "So, what the hell do you do while waiting for the sun to rise?"

“Keep an eye on Adora and just *wait.* If we were at Petra’s we wouldn’t have to be. Nothing we can do right now.” Glimmer does reach for the remote to turn something. “We can at least not be bored.”

“Let’s just hope that a friend of yours doesn’t have too much fun without us.”

“I was waiting for you to show up,” Adora says to the creature. She can now tell it is some sort of canine. Be it a wolf, coyote, dog, fox—what have you—she honestly doesn’t know. It lacks enough shapes and details to make out it’s true form. "What riddle do you have for me now?"

" *Why do you hate me?*"

"I don't know? Maybe because you don't give me a straight answer?"

" *That's not what I mean.*" The canine steps forward, closing the gap between the two. Adora does not yield. Whatever this thing wants, she wants it to know she is afraid. Plus, curiosity is getting the better of her.

The shape never changes as the creature gets closer. It remains impossible to truly tell what this thing is. Adora kneels down. Hands reach out, brushing against the blurry figure. Faintly, Adora can make out the feeling of fur. *Soft* fur. Almost exactly like Glimmer’s hair. A familiar scent enters her nose. The same one in almost all her soaps. Sandalwood. Strange….

“What do you want from me?” she asks.

“ *What you want. What do you want?”*

“What do *I* want?” Adora pauses for a moment. She looks over herself. Her callous hands, ones she has used for climbing, catching, and who knows what else. Her legs might not make her

fast but keep her upright. Her pale skin is free of thick fur. One could forget or imagine that the scars on her chin and back might be from something else. Something not out of a child's fairy tale. But that damn scar on her shoulder. The one she hides day in and day out. Bite marks from that long ago faithful day. Adora rubs the bare skin, vividly recalling the pain and blood of that night over two decades ago.

"Not to be cursed," Adora says.

" *That is impossible,"* the canine says.

Adora scoffs. "Some help you are."

She spins around, sitting down with her legs pulled to her chest and chin on knees. The darkness doesn't show any signs of leaving any time soon. Adora huffs at that thought. Though, it does show her the blobs of colors from before. The yellow and orange with children's laughter. In a blink, the orange changes to red and the pitch of giggles changes.

" *The past cannot be changed."* The canine sits down besides Adora, leaving several inches of gap between them. " *What's done is done."*

"That's pretty shitty if you tell me."

" *No. Without the past—the good, the bad, the horrible, the wonderful—you are not you. Everything has a light and dark to it. Rain can flood and drown but also allow life to flourish and grow. The sun can scorch and blind but melt away the cold and let people see. The past can hurt, make you wish for something else. But it is the reason you are here today, the reason you are you. And,"*

The colors fade away, leaving only a shade of purple and the smell of lilacs in Adora's nose.

"Can lead us to a better future. Tell me again. What do you want?"

“My family not to be royally fucked up? Or to know who my birth family is? Or, *still* , not to be a werewolf?!?”

Adora swears the canine sigh.

“ *Why do you hate* me? ”

This time, she is caught off guard. Adora feels her heart drop to the bottom of her chest. She herself sighs. The darkness around her begins to seep away as she says, “I don’t know…”

…

When she wakes, she needs a moment to register where on earth she is. It definitely isn’t her home. Far from it. The pale walls, the random boat photo hanging besides her, and the odd smells. But as the fog lifts from her mind and edges of eyes, a single word comes to her mind. *Hotel.*

Adora groans as she rolls onto her side. The first thing she spots is Glimmer curled up under the covers besides her. A soft smile creeps across the blonde’s face at the sight. Vague images, the lingers of what’s like dreams, fill her mind. A lot of nuzzling. Chewing on something. Based on the taste on her tongue, something fiber. But there is a hint of anger mixed in. She doesn’t want to think why there is that. Besides, asking what is real or not real won’t be happening at the moment. Judging by the lack of blood and her memories, nothing went wrong.

Rest up, Glim, Adora thinks. She brushes the back of her hand against Glimmer’s cheek before placing a tender kiss on the tip of the hunter’s nose. With that, Adora slips out of bed. She takes a quick shower, using the little free soap and shampoo the hotel has given her. After drying herself off and slipping on her last pair of clean clothes she decides to grab something to eat. Her stomach actually wants food now.

Adora hops into the elevator, hoping there still is some food left. Just as the metal doors are about to close shut, a hand shoots

through. The doors shutter to a halt before reopening. Catra appears.

“Oh! I didn’t see you walk in,” Catra says. “Glimmer passed out?”

“Yeah. Are you going to come in or did you open the door for no reason?” Adora replies.

“Uh, okay.”

Catra enters, standing on the other side of the elevator. The doors shut this time and it begins its descent. Music fills the small box as the sisters remain silent. Catra shifts on her feet while Adora fiddles with her fingers. The *ding* of being on the correct floor breaks the tension forming in the air. With that, it helps someone speak.

“You finally have some control. That’s really good,” Catra states as they exit the elevator. “Didn’t try to attack me.”

“I wish I had more like you,” Adora huffs. “Still never going to tell me how you got control.”

“I can’t. You know it's different for born and bitten. All I did was keep telling myself to get control and eventually I just did. I really can’t say anything else.”

“Well that really hasn’t helped me.” Adora runs a hand through her loose hair.

She and Catra enter the makeshift dining area. There are not as many people as the day before. Food is essentially leftovers. Yet, it still makes Adora’s stomach rumble. Hopefully, her body won’t reject anything.

Adora reaches for a plate but something stops her.

“I’m sorry.”

Adora slowly looks up. Catra keeps her eyes locked onto the blonde, though she seems to be struggling. Adora glups. "What?"

"I'm sorry. I did a lot of terrible things. Hurt you, a lot, and your girlfriend also. I should've said it earlier, and for that I am sorry. Like I said, I want to make up for everything, though I don't know if I can. The list of the shit I did is far too long, we'd be here another night if I did so. Just know, I mean it when I say I'm sorry. You have every right to hate me."

"I-" Adora blinks. She finds her shoulders relaxing. "Thank you, Cat."

"Anytime."

They grab their plates and what food doesn't look too soggy. As they finish getting a halfway decent meal, Adora looks out the window. The sun shines brilliantly. Snow remains fresh, no footprints have destroyed the beauty. There is not a cloud in the crystal blue sky. Roads are clear and ready to be driven on.

"Catra. Do you remember the time it snowed a lot and we ripped off a huge piece of bark to use as a sled?"

"Yeah, I do,"Catra replies, a small slice of bread in her mouth. "We hit a rock covered in snow and ice and went flying. Lost our boots on the way back up the hill."

"Mom was *so* pissed when we got back. We couldn't go out in the snow for like a month!" Despite the circumstances of that day, and now, Adora can't help but chuckle a little. Of course their harebrained, fourteen-years-old idea would end with them pulling themselves out of almost two feet of snow.

Catra snickers as well. "We made a fort to bundle up and get warm together. Fun times. Anyway, I'll get out of your hair. Tell me when Glimmer wakes so we can finally get the hell out of here."

"See ya."

With that, the sisters separate and head to different tables.

Glimmer yawns. Her body still wishes to be curled up in bed and slumber away. Maybe Petra won't mind if she takes a little nap. With a turn, the werebear's home quickly appears on the side of the road. An average looking building. Two story house, a porch out front, and chimney sticking out from the roof. There is a garage with a couple snow covered cars sitting in front on the unshoveled driveway.

"Huh. Guess they haven't had time to clean up." Glimmer states. She parks on the side of the road.

"It's noon. What the hell are they doing?" Catra asks.

"Hope they are alright," Adora states. She unbuckles her seat and exits. Everyone follows suit. The snow nearly comes up past Glimmer's boots. A few bits of the frozen water does fall in, nearly causing her to jump straight up in the air. To avoid any more risk of frostbite, she walks on the tips of her toes. Glimmer trudges behind Glimmer and Catra, who walk with more ease.

She sighs a breath of relief the moment boots get on wood. Glimmer shakes off her boots, knocking her heel on the ground. She's the one to walk up to the front door and give it a knock. Nothing. Not even the sound of shuffling feet. Another knock. Still nothing.

"You texted Petra we were on the way, right?" Glimmer asks, looking at Adora.

"Yeah. She never got back to me, though."

"Adora…" Catra starts. Her eyes are narrowed and shoulders tense. "Do you smell that?"

"Yeah, I do…" Adora's voice is low. Glimmer swears she hears a growl mixed in.

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. She attempts to gauge the situation herself. All she gets at first is the coldness of the winter's air. Nothing out of the ordinary. However, she then catches a whiff of something new. Something familiar. *Hotness.* Unlike last month where the scent of salt hung in the air, this totally lacks it. Instead, the hint of copper is present.

Something else begins to form in her mind.

The color of red.

The color of anger.

Snow crunches behind the trio. Everyone jumps and spins around. Two figures stand near the bottom step. Both look only a little older than Glimmer. One has jet, black hair, his bangs almost covering his eyes. Café au lait spots rest on his left eye and lower right chin (also covered in stubble). The other, only slightly smaller in height, has her brown hair tied up out of her face and a beauty mark near her right eye. Based on their same brown irises and lean builds, they are brother and sister.

Each has a metal bat in their hands. It's the sister who speaks first.

"Who the fuck are you three and why the fuck are you at our house!"

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated

The Bonds of Brothers & Sisters

Chapter Notes

another chapter i really enjoyed writing aksfjsakj the ending well...i have had in my head for a while :3

anyway, tw for blood/injury

Edit: I forgot to mention facts about Petra and her sibs

Zephyr is a Cis man (he/him) and Aro/Ace and 27/almost 28 (birthday is in Jan)

Brooke is a Trans woman (she/her) and a Lesbian and 26

Petra is non binary (she/they) and Bi asexual and 25 (a few months younger than Adora)

And Drake is a cis man (he/him) and het and 24

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora's arm shoots out towards the side, preventing Glimmer from taking any steps forward. Her body tenses with the possibility of a fight. Catra, however, is the one who takes the lead. She already is at the edge of the porch. She stands right in front of the hunter. It is her who speaks first. "We're supposed to be here! Drop your weapons!"

"Like hell we are!" the brother growls. His grip on the bat tightens. Knuckles are white. "Why are you here! State your business!"

"Petra asked us to come!" Adora reasons. "We couldn't come until now because of the storm!"

The siblings exchange looks. They keep their grips on the bats and do not lower their stances. Adora and Catra themselves do

not back down. The blonde can smell the anger and fear dripping off the brother and sister. What were Petra's older siblings' names again?

Glimmer squeezes through Adora and Catra. "We aren't here to fight, I promise. I'm Glimmer Mizari and this is Catra Britt and Adora."

Now the siblings relax. The brother lets his arms fall to his side, the end of his bat hitting against the snow. His sister, however, only lowers her weapon slightly. She keeps her brown eyes locked onto the trio. Adora's body loosens up, though her heart drums hard against her chest.

"So, you're them. Pet told us about you guys. I'm Zephyr. This is Brooke."

"Pleasure to mean you," Catra mumbles. "Can we go inside? It's freezing out here."

"Yeah, hold on." Zephyr hops through the snow with ease, nothing breaking his stride. He lands on the porch without slipping in the slightest. Brooke slowly follows behind, stepping in the path her brother made. The door finally opens, allowing access to the world of warmth.

Catra quickly scurries inside, sighing in relief. Everyone else enters, throwing their jackets against hanging hooks. Zephyr leads them into the living room. There isn't much to note. A couple couches, a coffee table, TV, some plants in the corners of the room, and decorations such as paintings hang against grey walls. On some tables off to the side, there are framed photos.

Adora swears she smells bleach. Her nose stings half the time she breathes in. She tries not to think much about the thought. Just mopping the floor before company came over. Stupid nose.

She decides to take a quick look at the photos. Inspecting them closely, she sees they are all of Petra and her family. One has the four siblings, all close in age, with two women. The family of six

are at some amusement park, having the time of their lives. Another has a set of young looking bears. Two are brown, one with eyes the shade of soil and the other like the leaves on a tree during summer. The other two are black, one solid with similar emerald iris as the one before and the other having patches of brown on their body, almost matching their eyes.

The last of the photos Adora examines is just of the Maritimus siblings. They look to be around older teens or early twenties. All are on the porch of their home. Petra stands in the middle, holding a key in their hand that hangs from their neck. Despite the small smile, their face is melancholy. Zephyr, Brooke, and Drake stand around her, the same expression. The eldest of them has his arm around his sister's shoulder, holding her near him.

Adora settles down on the couch, next to Glimmer. Catra has taken up residents on a recliner, though she keeps the back upright. Brooke has disappeared upstairs while Zephyr remains in the living room. He clasps his hands together before he speaks.

"Sorry about before. I hope you can forgive us. Are you three hungry? Anything to drink?"

"Water, please," Adora says.

"Same," Catra adds on.

"I'm good." Glimmer finishes.

"Alright. Be right back!" Zephyr dips into the kitchen. It does not take him long to return with glasses of water. Adora happily takes the cup. Even though the world outside is frigid, the cold water still feels good against her throat. Zephyr settles down on a second, smaller couch.

Footsteps fill the air. In a matter of moments, Brooke reappears. She settles down on the couch's arm cross from her brother. She takes a deep breath. "Drake is asleep. I put a blanket on him. Hopefully he will sleep for a while."

“Have a long night too?” Adora asks. She places her half filled water on the table in front of her. “It was not fun being trapped in a hotel room all night long. Glimmer was barely able to get out of the bed when we had to leave.”

“Shut up,” Glimmer groans. She is already struggling to keep her head up now in a comfortable piece of furniture.

Zephyr and Brooke exchange looks. Frowns form on their faces. Hands hide their mouths and they whisper to each other. Adora raises an eyebrow. She first turns to Glimmer, who remains struggling to stay awake. She barely has noticed what is going on. With no answer from her, Adora turns towards her sister. Catra has an equally confused look on her face.

Finally, the siblings lower their hands. Brooke looks away as Zephyr lets out a heavy sigh. “Well, we did have a long night. If only it was like yours. There…There is a reason we were so on edge before.”

This gets Glimmer’s attention. Her slumped body stiffens and any sleep in her eyes disappears. “What do you mean?”

When Adora takes another breath, she smells the anger from before. However, this isn’t any type of anger. No, this one comes deep within, from the bottom of someone’s soul and heart. With another sniff, Adora realizes it is one she has felt before. When she was younger and much closer to Catra. One memory crops up in her mind from a couple months after Catra came into her life. When some local, older teenagers were being assholes to the werepanther. Adora didn’t know what she was doing when she jumped in, fist flying, to defend Catra.

That sheer, blinding anger only ever appeared whenever her younger sister was in danger and threatened, no matter how small it might have been.

“Well…Petra’s hurt.” Zephyr says. “She’s pretty banged up but alive. She’s upstairs and Drake was watching her but he must be

exhausted. We all are."

"Wait, what?!?" Adora and Glimmer both gasp.

"What the hell got something like you guys?" Catra asks.

"The same exact thing that has been raising hell lately," Brooke says.

"You got to be fucking kidding me!"

Adora leans back against the couch, not knowing what to say. Hell, she doesn't even know *how* to feel at the moment. There's a numbness spreading throughout her chest. Any emotions that form inside of her are quickly swallowed by that blackhole. Limbs become heavy. She can barely keep the static from forming in her mind.

It should come as no shock that her mother once again has had a hand in this. But the fact it has come so close is what drives the knife straight through her body. Had the snowstorm not halted everyone in their tracks, Adora could have come face to face with Shadow Weaver after so many years. Could she have helped Petra? Or would her own mother strike her down? Would she try worming her way into Adora's brain and tear her up inside?

The fact all these scenarios could've been sends a cold shiver running down her spine. Shadow Weaver's bright, cold, green eyes *burn* in her memory.

"Are they going to be okay?" Glimmer asks, breaking up the growing, tense silence.

"Yes." Brooke answers. "We don't know how long it will take for her to get back on her feet, but she will get there eventually. She's sleeping upstairs right now. Has been out since we carried her back in here.."

"What happened?" Adora asks, mouth dry.

The Maritimus siblings begin to recount the events of the night prior. The four had shifted and decided to head out into the woods both to make sure nothing was going on and for the hell of it. There really was not much to worry about, apparently. No attacks were close to this area and it had been many years since anything horrible occurred. So, the siblings split up.

Brooke was the first one to hear her sister engaged in a fight. She raced over towards Petra to see her being overpowered by a large werewolf. Thankfully, Brooke did not have to fight off Shadow Weaver alone for long. Drake and then Zephyr appeared to defend their sisters. Shadow Weaver, presumingly from being outmatched, ran off. With Petra in serious condition and barely conscious, no one gave chase. Not to mention, while the brothers got away unscathed, Brooke did not.

"Still healing but it should go away soon," Brooke says, lifting up her shirt. There are large, white bandages wrapped around her lower abdomen. "We dragged Petra back here and did what we could, cleaned up as best we would, but something's wrong."

"They aren't healing like they're supposed to," Zephyr finishes.

"What do you mean?" Catra asks.

"Petra *is* healing. And for what happened to her and by who, it's not at a standstill like a human…but it's not healing as fast as it *should* be. I don't know how to explain it."

"Christ." Glimmer groans.

"Adora, was it?" Brooke starts. "You haven't said much, are you alright?"

"I don't know," Adora mumbles. "I can't believe this happened. I'm sorry this happened."

"We know the risks. We were raised to protect and help others, especially Pet," Zephyr states. "I think we all need a break right now. If you guys don't mind, we both are pretty tired."

“I’ll show you all to your rooms.” Brooke says.

She jumps from the couch and gestures for everyone to follow her. Brooke first shows Adora and Glimmer their room. The guest bedroom on the lower floor. There is a bed just large enough for the both of them to fit in. There is not much else to note. A TV, dresser, what have you. Adora and Glimmer begin to set aside their things while Brooke takes Catra away upstairs. Apparently, Zephyr doesn’t mind sleeping on the couch.

Adora sits down on the bed. Her mind continues to swirl around. How the hell did she dodge the bullet hell of meeting her mother for the first time in years? How the fuck did that happen? She begins to wonder about the ‘what ifs’. What if the snowstorm didn’t stop her little group, could they have prevented any of this from happening? Or, what if they did go out upon getting here, would more injuries have been sustained? But what did Petra’s siblings mean when they said she wasn’t healing right?

Adora places her head in her hands. She takes a long, deep inhale, holding it in her chest for several seconds. Once her lungs can not bear the carbon build up, she exhales. The numbness in her chest barely changes, if at all. Her brain cannot process this all.

A new weight besides her causes her to peek one eye out from her hands.

“Should I even ask what you are thinking about?” Glimmer asks.

“I can’t believe what happened,” Adora answers, voice muffled.

“I know. I really hope Petra’s alright. I mean, I know they said they’re alive and sleeping but I’m still a little worried.”

Adora finally removes her hands from face. She places them in her lap, fiddling with her fingers. “Maybe we can see them in a little bit. Maybe when they wake up.”

“Well, they were the one who wanted us to come. I’m sure they would want to once up.”

“I guess so, yeah.”

Glimmer yawns before plopping her head against Adora’s shoulders. The blonde pats her girlfriend’s shoulder. “Rest up. You deserve it and need it.”

“What are you going to do?”

Adora shrugs. “Just read, probably. Maybe watch some TV. Dunno.”

“Well wake me if there is anything interesting going on.”

“Alright.”

The pair shift in bed. Adora sits up with her legs outstretched while Glimmer rests her head on her girlfriend’s lap. The hunter curls up and flutters her eyes shut just as Adora begins to run her fingers through pink hair. In no time at all, Glimmer out like a light and snoring. Adora can’t help but chuckle.

Adora doesn’t quite know what to do with herself. Honestly, she doesn’t really want to read at the moment. The thought of trying to concentrate on tiny words does not sit well with her. Flipping through the channels, her brain refuses to latch onto anything. She ends up stopping on some old, 90s TV show and sets the remote off to the side. Adora pinches the bridge of her nose.

Don’t think about it, Adora. Don’t think about it.

The more she tries *not* to, the more the thought of her mother enters and roots itself in her mind. Angella and so many others no longer draw breath. Petra has barely escaped her clutches. Had her mother never been murdered, Glimmer never would have been been seriously injured. Whose life has Shadow Weaver not utterly fucked up?

Adora places her rubber sword in her mouth. Her body threatens to shake as her mother continues to stay in her mind. Her tall, intimidating figure. One that radiated menace and manipulation. Her cold stare. Adora can't ever remember seeing any warmth in her mother's eyes or smile. Her stomach twists in a tight ball thinking about the woman who raises her.

Adora looks down at her sleeping girlfriend. Right now, she is far from reality. Her brain has conjured up something. Hopefully it is something pleasant. Maybe she is one of her favorite video game characters and goes through the levels with ease. Or maybe she is with her family, laughing and having a good time. Heck, maybe she is with Adora herself and on something like a dinner date.

I hope you are enjoying yourself, hon.

With her free hand, Adora reaches down and takes Glimmer's hand in her own. The single touch alone helps settle her racing mind, ground them. She dares not let go, not even for a split second.

Glimmer is the first to hear the sound.

After waking up for her much needed nap, Glimmer decided to head back into the living room with Adora. Her girlfriend seemed more than excited to do something besides lying around. There wasn't much really to do with all the Maritimus siblings all resting upstairs. However, Adora managed to pull out a deck of cards to play whatever games that came to mind. Catra eventually popped in and seemed eager to try and beat Glimmer and Adora. Needless to say, the girlfriends were equally eager to win themselves.

But when Glimmer hears a new noise, she turns her head towards the open part of the stairs. The youngest werebear appears. He blinks his green eyes in surprise.

“Oh, hey guys. How long have you been here?” Drake asks. He stops half way down the steps. His hair is a mess and he only wears a pair of brown pajama pants with bear paw prints on it. He hops down the rest of the steps. He disappears into the kitchen, asking if anyone wants anything.

Glimmer, Adora, and Catra reply with a no (and that they have been here for a couple hours). When he reappears, he’s drinking a can of beer. “So Zeph and Brooke were ready to beat you guys up. Man, I sure missed some fun.” He starts to laugh.

“Sure getting a kick out of this, huh?” Glimmer says.

“Gotta have some fun after everything, right?” Drake finds a chair and sets it down. He sits on it backwards. “I do wish I could’ve seen your faces. I bet it was fuckin’ amazing!”

“Well, now that you are awake,” Glimmer starts. She stands from her seated position on the ground, needing the stretching. “How’s Petra doing? You were watching her, right?”

Drake takes another sip of his beer. “Fine. We gave her some medicine so hopefully she’ll be out for a while. She needs all the rest she can get.”

Glimmer turns her attention back towards the vacant stairs. Upstairs, Petra remains unconscious. She has no idea the extent of their injuries. Zephyr and Brooke did not go into great detail over what happened. The latter’s wounds looked bad enough, what on earth does Petra look like? And what about the fact their siblings found them like that? What must have that been like?

She swallows a lump growing in her throat. That very nearly happened to her. The regret of not going out into the woods the night of her mother’s death continues to keep its thorns wedged in her heart. However, she knows had she gone out not only could she have been killed by Shadow Weaver, but she would have been the one to find her mother’s lifeless body. One of the many things

that haunts her. Glimmer refuses to let her brain come up with that scene.

Glimmer bites back anger tickling at the back of her throat. Another life suffering from this monster of a woman…

She shakes her head, cleaning it.

"I'm just glad you guys are okay. Or, at least, will be," Glimmer says.

"Tell me about it." Drake's eyes grow dark as he looks down on the ground. He leans his head against his arm draped against the chair. "I don't know what the three of us would have done if she…"

He doesn't finish. He doesn't need to. Instead, the youngest werebear takes a deep breath before starting up a new sentence.

"You know…She's the one that took up the role as head of the family," Drake says.

"Zephyr isn't?" Adora asks, surprised.

Drake shakes his head. "No. When our moms died suddenly—it was a random work accident—Zeph and Brooke were at college. Zeph already had settled in and Brooke just started. Petra and I were still in high school. So…Petra gave up on whatever ambitions they had for college so that Zephyr and Brooke could keep going and later, so I could.

"Zephyr and Brooke tried to tell them they didn't have to do that but Petra refused. Honestly, everyone knew Petra would take on that role, just not so suddenly. She was the first to shift and learn control and always has had her head on her shoulders. I can't focus half the time to save my life, Brooke always just wanted to live a life of fun, and Zephyr isn't one for a lot of confrontation. Petra wanted to travel, so she was sort of already born for the role as head. "

“Sounds like you look up to her a lot.” Glimmer finally sits back down on the couch, her legs happy to get blood flowing through them.

“Yeah. But I think that’s enough of that.” Drake sits up straight. He finishes his drink, crushing it against the side of his head and palm. Tossing it aside, he then grabs the deck of cards. With ease, and without even *looking,* Drake shuffles the cards. “You ladies know how to play blackjack?”

Glimmer grins from ear to ear. Growing up, her father taught her many card games and hundreds of little tricks and tips. Though, not everything as she always lost to him. But this isn’t her father. She cracks her knuckles and dares Drake into a challenge. Catra is eager to get another game going, no matter what it is or who it is with. However, Adora is the one that is unsure. Stating that she never played blackjack, she is willing to sit out. But Glimmer has other plans.

She wraps an arm around her girlfriend’s neck, pulling her close. The hunter suggests they work together. Adora shall hold the card while Glimmer whispers into her ears what to do. Catra calls out cheating. Drake ignores it, stating that since Adora is learning, he’ll let it pass.

They only manage to get one game in, *barely* that, when the creaking of boards catches everyone’s attention. The four snap their heads up in time to see Petra trip over herself on the last step. She catches herself on the wall with her one good arm. She mumbles some curse before standing up.

Glimmer can now see just how badly the werebear has been thrown through the wringer. Their left arm rests in a sling with their whole hand and arm wrapped in white bandages. With them simply being in a sports bra and shorts, there is nothing to cover all the other dressings on her skin. A couple of them have dull patches of red against the whiteness. While Petra stands on both feet, more weight is being applied to her right.

Petra turns their head, Glimmer sees a couple, final bandages near the side of their right eyebrow. Their green eyes are not fully alert but there isn't much of a haze in them either. Actually, the moment they land on the small group, there grows a twinkle.

"Petra?!?" Drake jumps so fast to his feet, the chair topples over and smacks against the ground. Tripping over the legs, he scrambles towards his older sister. "What are you doing up! You should be resting!"

Petra waves him off. "I am walking and breathing, aren't I?" She begins hobbling towards the couch. Drake remains where he stands totally baffled, jaw slacked and eyes wide. Glimmer and Adora move out of the way, standing up and allowing the werebear to plop down on. They place their left foot on the cushions.

"Are you alright?" Glimmer asks.

"Damn, Mom really did get you good." Catra blurts out.

Petra raises an eyebrow. "Mom?"

Catra quickly realizes her mistake. Her amber and cyan eyes go wide as she slaps a hand over her mouth. Glimmer rubs her temple, feeling a headache growing. Meanwhile, Adora has her palms together in front of her face. Her eyes scream that she is about to strangle her sister.

Petra studies the trio's face. She remains silent, waiting for someone to speak. No one says anything, too stunned to say anything. This was not in the plans at all, letting this cat out of the bag. The only one not totally caught off guard is the one who speaks first.

"Uh…everyone alright?" Drake asks.

"Waiting to get an answer from these guys," Petra says. They wrap a strain of hair around their index finger. "I knew you guys

had more information but I didn't know it would be a bombshell like this."

With the jig up, Adora, Glimmer, and Catra reveal the connection with the Shadow Weaver. The fact she is the adoptive mother of both Adora and Catra as well as some other key details. The strange books she had in her room when the two were younger, the fact somehow Angella was able to stop the attacks temporarily, and how the second wave of attack most likely started earlier than once first thought.

Petra listens intently to it all. They don't say a word, only nodding every now and again. Drake taps away on his phone, taking notes as fast as he can. Once the explanation is over, the werebears remain silent. The older of the two taps their chin while the younger reads over all his notes. Finally, Petra readjusts herself, swinging her injured leg onto the ground.

"That's a hell of a revelation. Your mother is a real piece of work."

"Tell me about it," Adora sighs. "I'm sorry we kept that from you."

"It's understandable. I don't blame you guys in the slightest."

"So, what do you think of it all?"

"It's definitely a lot to take in. I do wonder what those books were and how much she learned about things in them. I didn't know about the whole stealing power thing until this happened. So much has been lost to time and-"

Before they can say anything else, a harsh gasp escapes them. Petra snaps their teeth together, hissing, before curling in on themself and clutching their side. Glimmer sees the red blotch growing past her fingers. The werebear staggers their breathing and a small line of sweat forms on their forehead.

"Shit, Pet. I knew you shouldn't've gotten up." Drake groans. "I am going to get the medical kit."

Before Petra can retort, her younger brother disappears. Petra grumbles to herself. “I hate worrying him, Zephyr, and Brooke.”

“Well can you blame them?” Glimmer says.

“Why aren’t you healing? If I may ask,” Catra questions.

“Really, Catra?” Adora says.

“No, she’s fine.” Petra leans back against the couch. She shuts her eyes and takes a deep breath. “I think it has to do with whatever your mother is doing. You know, taking powers. When she was holding me down, I felt…weaker. And not just because of the blood loss.”

“How so?” Glimmer asks, drawing a little closer.

“I didn’t feel like *myself.* Being a werebear, it’s all I have ever known. I felt like a part of my soul was being torn out of me. If it wasn’t for my brothers and sister, I probably would be dead or even weaker.”

Petra reopens their eyes. They look down at themself. All the bandages that riddle their body. Glimmer wonders how many more scars they will get from this. The werebear continues. “I think, though, she still took something away. I can still shift, clearly. But…I can’t heal properly. My wounds shouldn’t be like this.”

“Well, it doesn’t help you got out of bed.” Drake scolds. He plops down down on the floor and gets to work on patching up his sister. “Brooke is going to flip her shit if she finds out you reopened this.”

“She won’t if you don’t tell her.”

Adora steps up to Glimmer. Her arms are crossed against her chest. “She took away your power? At least, some of them?”

“Adora?” Glimmer whispers. Her girlfriend looks at the ground, hiding her face. Petra narrows her eyes.

“Yes.” They pause for a moment, giving Adora a hard look. “However, I don’t know what would have happened if she took it all. For all I know, with my powers so interwoven within me, it still could have killed me. As I said, it’s as if a part of me was being torn away. I doubt blood loss is the only deadly threat here.”

Glimmer quickly realizes the implications behind Adora’s question. Her girlfriend begins to shift on her feet. She begins to rub the back of her neck., eyes turned downward “Alright. I just thought I asked.”

“Well, it’s a good thing she didn’t take everything away. Don’t know who’d you be without being the head bear, Pet.” Drake finishes patching up Petra. He packs up the first aid kit and sets it aside. “There. Try not to tear it open again or we might have to stitch it.”

“Hopefully I can heal enough that I don’t need that. Anyway, I am sorry for all this shit. I wish I could make it up to you guys.”

“Well, you can help us beat your brother at blackjack,” Catra pipes up. She grabs her forgotten cards. “I swear he is cheating.”

“No I am, you just suck!” Drake snaps back.

Petra snorts and a smile forms on their face. “I think I can beat him.”

The rest of the time at the Maritimus Family mostly winding down. There is no point in driving back to Brightmoon until tomorrow. When Brooke wakes, it doesn’t take long for her to figure out what has happened to her younger sister. She immediately chews them out. Petra replies with a simple ‘Yeah, yeah, I’m an idiot’.

Once Zephyr awakes, the only other thing happens. Attempting a plan of attack. Which does not amount to much truthfully. It really comes down to at the current moment, if you see Shadow Weaver, get the hell out of dodge, especially if you are alone. The best thing anyone can do is warn others not to go out at night and be on *extra* guard if you must.

Night passes and when daybreak comes around, the trio leaves for home. Everyone wishes the other well. Petra promises to get back on their feet as soon as possible. Adora, Glimmer, and Catra head back to Brightmoon, returning back around late afternoon. The werepanther goes back to where she has been staying. While Adora and Glimmer finish their trip back home, the blonde leans back against her seat.

A hand runs through her dark locks. She can feel the heaviness in her eyes from her struggle to sleep during the night. Adora hates the fact she has seriously pondered over the fact Petra has lost some of her powers without being killed. Though, that was only because of her siblings' intervention. But the thought is implanted itself in her mind and refuses to loosen its grip.

It leaves a bitter, stinging taste in her mouth. Actually *thinking* of possibly having her do something like that to her? The woman who put her through hell and back and wanted to wrap her mind into what *she* wanted. And wouldn't Shadow Weaver just *want* to take away and use Adora's own powers?

Adora groans as the car comes to a halt in the driveway. *Stupid, stupid stupid!* She yells at herself. Even if that was a possibility, it very damn well can kill her. She has had her power…her *curse* … whatever you want to call it for nearly as long as Petra. How woven into her soul is the wolf? Adora does not want to begin to think of what that feeling is like, having a part of you being *ripped* straight out of your body.

Her body feels like lead as she exits the car. Adora slaps the side of her face. The more she tries to rid her mind of the idea, the

harder it sinks its claws into her brain. She needs something, *anything,* to distract her before her mind explodes.

Adora gasps as she is suddenly forced off her feet. She has no time to process if hidden ice is her downfall or some other unseen entity. The next thing her brain can comprehend is the stinging cold of snow against her face.

She pushes herself onto her elbows, spitting out the now water from her mouth. Adora shakes her head, freeing some of her hair from the balls of snow that latched onto it.

"You back?" Glimmer asks.

Adora rolls onto her back, still propping herself up. Glimmer kneels down in front of her. A finger scratches a reddening cheeks. "Sorry for that. I was trying to get your attention but you were so lost in thought. Didn't look happy about it either. I thought the shock of the cold could snap you out of it. Are you okay?"

"I'm fine. I didn't hear you at all, sorry."

"What were you thinking about?"

"What happened to Petra…And what I asked them."

"Oh…" Glimmer frowns. Her shoulders droop. "I can see why you are thinking about that."

"It's stupid to think about. I don't even know why I am even thinking about it!"

Glimmer crawls into the snow. Hands disappear next to Adora as the hunter's body hovers over her. A gentle smile rests on Glimmer's face. "I don't really have anything to say about it. There is a lot to process right now, not just *that.* But, whatever you want to do about it, long as it doesn't kill you, I will be here for you."

Warm lips peck the tip of Adora's frozen nose. The blonde sighs before flopping down into the snow. "Thanks, Glim. I don't really want to think anymore about it."

"Gotcha. Let's get inside. My hands already are like icicles."

Adora snorts. "You have no one else to blame but yourself for that."

The next several days blur together. Everyone it seems is busy with their own things and there has been no real time to gather and talk with the others. Adora damn near goes stir-crazy finding things to do to distract her mind. It continues to refuse letting go of the thoughts of her mother. How she missed a bullet and her growing powers. It's becoming harder and harder to believe that there is any way in stopping her. Time is lost to her, becoming nothing more than static.

So much so, she doesn't realize a certain day is now on top of her until Glimmer reminds her.

"Whatcha doin'?" Her girlfriend asks. Glimmer drapes her arms against Adora's shoulders as she sits on the couch.

"Nothing." Adora replies honestly. She sets down the remote, stopping her aimless scrolling. "Why?"

"Well, do you want to go over Bow's for something?"

Adora raises an eyebrow. She shifts her head to look at her girlfriend. "For what? Is there something going on today?"

"Well…We figured—me, Bow, Scorpia, Perfuma, Mermista, and Sea Hawk—" Glimmer hesitates for a moment. "Well, we wanted to do something nice for you today. Ya know…for your birthday!"

"Oh wow, that's today, isn't it?" Adora leans back against the couch. She didn't realize how fast her birthday came around. Heck, she forgot all about it all.

"Is that okay?" Glimmer asks. "I know your birthday is rough but with everything going on, something nice is needed. It's nothing big so it's no big deal if you don't want to do it."

Adora drums her fingers against her leg. She cannot recall *ever* celebrating her birthday. Not to mention, the whole getting bit hangs over her head. That already is a good enough reason not to celebrate the day. However, she knows her friends would do anything to make the day special. They already have for a number of other days.

"Well," she begins to scratch the side of her face, "I really don't want to be doing nothing anymore. So, why the hell not?"

The grin that forms on Glimmer's face makes Adora's heart flutter around in her chest like a butterfly. That alone makes her feel all the better about the day. With nothing else really to do, and now eager to get outside, the pair of girlfriends head out. Adora realizes as they drive down salt covered roads, she has yet to see Bow's home. Everyone else she has been to at least once. This adds to some excitement of the day.

Adora actually finds herself growing eager to celebrate her birthday for once. What better way to spend it than being with friends? That is what you are supposed to do, right? Either way, Adora realizes she hasn't seen many of her friends in a while. Mostly just Bow. Now she really is getting excited. Her thoughts from before begin to fade away.

When the pair reach Bow's house, he is waiting outside. The moment the car pulls into his little driveway, he hops down his deck and is quickly by the vehicle. Bow wastes no time hugging, almost *tackling,* Adora. The blonde uses the passenger side door for support.

"Happy birthday, Adora!" he gleefully shouts.

"Thanks, Bow. But did you have to throw yourself on me?" Adora asks with a laugh in her voice.

“You know Scorpia is going to do ten times worse. This is nothing.”

“Fair point.”

“Is everyone inside?” Glimmer asks as she locks the car.

“Yeah. Everyone’s been waiting for you guys. C’mon!”

Bow happily walks ahead of his friends, guiding them to the front door. The moment they get inside, sure enough, Scorpia throws herself onto Adora. She is only saved from slamming onto the ground by Glimmer. Being directly behind her, her hands shootout against Adora’s back, keeping her upright.

“Happy birthday, Adora!!!” Scorpia squeals.

“I’m happy to see you too, Scorp!” Adora squeaks out as her ribs get crushed.

“Tell me, how old are you?!? I don’t think I ever asked!” She releases Adora from her grasp.

“Twenty-six.”

“Oh, cool. Only a year younger than me! That still makes me the oldest of the group.”

“Okay, old lady, can you move out of the way so we can come in?” Glimmer jokes.

Scorpia shoots her a glare at her before stepping away. Everyone else, Perfuma, Mermista, and Sea Hawk, all wish Adora a happy birthday. Adora doesn’t know what to really make of all the attention being directed at her. Thankfully, with Glimmer right by her side, her heart doesn’t want to make a total break for it. Once all the greetings are done, everyone takes some seats in the living room. Only Bow disappears for a moment, returning with a cake in his hands.

“How did you make that so fast?” Adora asks as it is placed down on the table. The cake is average size, covered in a thick layer of chocolate frosting. Written in large, somewhat sloppy, yellow letters is ‘ *Happy Birthday Adora!!!’* Rainbow sprinkles are all over the place.

“Luck. We were banking a little on you coming since you probably would want to get out of the house,” Bow admits. He rubs the back of his head.

“Well there is no point in wasting good food by questioning how it got done.” Sea Hawk states.

“Slow your roll!” Mermista says. She grabs a large knife Bow also has brought in and hands it to Adora. “The birthday girl has to make the first cut and get the first piece.”

Adora blinks. “What?”

“It’s a tradition for whose every birthday it is, the both make the first cut and get the first piece,” Bow informs. “You don’t have to do it if you don’t want to. But we gotta offer it, ya know?”

“Oh. Well sure!” Adora happily takes the knife and begins slicing up the cake. While she places a piece for herself and places it on the side, she doesn’t eat it right away. Instead, Adora cuts up something for everyone. Only when all her friends have a plate of cake and a fork, does she dare take a bite.

Still warm, nice and soft, and a little gooey.

“This is delicious!” Adora hums.

“So, birthday girl.” Perfuma starts. “What do you want to do? We can open presents now or watch something or do whatever! It’s your day!”

“Um, I don’t really know. I’m just happy to be with you guys. I honestly don’t need anything else.”

“Quit being so humble!” Sea Hawk shouts. “Just pick something out.”

“Then,” Adora suddenly points at Glimmer. “Glim can pick!”

“What?!?” Glimmer replies in shock.

“Help me out here, hon! I don’t know what to pick!”

“Bow!”

“Don’t drag me into this!” Bow retorts.

After a *lot* of debating and back and forth between, well, everyone, they finally settle on something. The rest of the day is spent watching whatever movies they manage to agree on, teasing each other, or playing either card games or board games.

Glimmer yawns, stretching out her arms. She should go to bed, curl up beside Adora and sleep until the sun hangs high in the mid-winter sun. After all the fun of today, she should honestly do just that. Yet, she has been *dying* to finally watch the latest episode of *Fuzzfeed Unsolved: True Crime.* With Adora passed out upstairs, here she is on the couch, laptop booted up and ready to be watched.

“Alright, boys,” Glimmer says, “let’s see what you have tonight!” She begins to take a quick sip of her water before clicking on the youtube page. But this ends up not being a great plan.

As the page loads, revealing the new video ready to be played, Glimmer’s heart skips a beat. The water in her mouth nearly goes down the wrong pipe. She slaps one hand over her mouth, stifling her hacks, and balls up her other to drum it against her chest. It takes several long moments to have her breathing return to some form of normalcy. Glimmer blinks back the tears in her eyes before locking them onto the title. She must reread it several

times for it to stick inside of her mind. Even then, the hunter cannot fully comprehend what she is looking at.

The Mysterious Disappearance of Adora Glenn.

*There's no way…*Glimmer sets her glass gingerly on the table. The thumbnail has a photo of a young girl, her smile wide and crooked. She stands besides a boy her age. By how they look, all their similarities, they must be twins. But what catches her attention the most are the eyes of the girl. The same sky blue shade.

Glimmer swallows a hard lump. Fingers shake as they hover over the mouse button. Her heart now beats *hard* in her ears. What are the odds that this girl could be the same woman sound asleep upstairs? Could all the answers Adora has been searching for be here in this video? There is only one way to find out.

She bites down so hard on her lip Glimmer, she swears she tastes copper. With a click, the video begins to play.

It starts off slow. Giving some small backstory, how a young girl was kidnapped right under her parents' noses. That if anyone by the end of this video has any information to call a number or go to the links down below. With that, the full story begins.

Adora Glenn, born in the evening twilight of January 19th 1996. The older of fraternal twins, the latter of which said shortly before Adora's disappearance to his family that he was a boy and goes by the name Adam. The siblings were as thick as thieves—best friends who did everything together. They were raised by their mother and father, Marlena and Randor Glenn. Life was not terribly special in the sense, they were your everyday family. Went on a couple trips, lived in the suburbs, and the twins made friends with everyone. Life was perfectly ordinary.

But that all changed on the twins' fifth birthday. Adora ran out of the house, into the large woods behind their house after the family's cat ,who had just darted out. It was Marlena who ran

after her daughter while Randor stayed with Adam. For several long minutes, father and son didn't know what happened to their two other family members. Finally, Adora was brought home in her mother's arms, bloodied from a wild dog attack.

Glimmer holds her breath as the story continues. The missing puzzle pieces of Adora's life are slowly falling into place. The story continues. Adora healed from her wounds and everything seemed to have gotten back to normal. However, about two months after the attack, life wanted to fuck with the Glenn family even more. Randor and Marlena hired a babysitter for Adora while the rest of the family had to do something. She was left with the woman, Beatrix Weaver, but never returned home.

In fact, it seemed both Adora and Beatrix disappeared off the face of the planet. No clues at all. False information given by the woman lead to dead end after dead end. For over twenty year now the Glenn family has been searching for Adora, following any inkling of a hint to her whereabouts. The last part of the video is one of the hosts talking via call to someone from the family. That being Adam. A photo of him sits next to the sound waves while the two talk.

The first part of the conversation becomes nothing more than static to Glimmer. Her eyes stare at the photo in stun and awe. Adam has the same crooked smile as Adora and the same bright lights in his eyes. His hair is the same exact dark shade of blonde. Irises are blue, albeit a darker shade—more like the evening sky. His freckles are more pronounced against his face though, some are hidden by a set of glasses.

Words begin to form in her ears. Glimmer hears Adam's somber voice. "I know she is out there, *somewhere* . I only have so many memories of my sister but all of them are bittersweet. They make me smile but make me wonder what life would have been like if she never was taken away. If I grew up with my twin—it's like I've been missing a part of myself for all my life. I *know* she is out there, somewhere…

"And wherever she is…" Adam takes a deep, long sigh. "I hope she is happy. Happy and healthy and living a good life, even if she doesn't know who we are or if she is searching for us. I know in my heart, though, whoever she grew up to be, that she is an amazing, wonderful, and kind woman. I hope to see her again."

The call ends and an aged progressed photo of Adora pops up. Any suspicions, any doubt that might linger in Glimmer's mind disappear. Even with the minor differences, the glasses and several more clear freckles, *Adora* stares back at her. The same, bright sky blue eyes. The same smile. Everything Glimmer loves about Adora, it is all right there. Glimmer feels her breath getting caught in her throat.

Glimmer scrolls back several minutes, stopping at an image of a four-year-old girl. She sits near a creek in the middle of the woods, Adam nearby. Judging by their wear, a yellow t-shirt for Adora and orange for Adam and both in shorts and sandals, it's summer. That same crooked smile rests on Adora's face. There are no scars at all on her skin. No weight of trauma and abuse pushing down against her shoulders. Adora's eyes are bright, *brighter* than Glimmer has ever seen before.

"Oh, 'Dora." Glimmer brushes her fingers against the screen. A life before being bitten. A life before being taken by Shadow Weaver. A life before Catra. A life before all her pain and suffering.

A life that *could* have been.

Shit! Shit! Shit! Adora!

Glimmer scrambles to her feet. She doesn't care how much noise she is making up the flight of stairs. The hunter nearly trips and almost breaks her nose and laptop in the process. This does not deter her in the slightest. By the time Glimmer *kicks* down the bedroom door, she is gasping for air.

"Adora!" she wheezes out. "Adora! Starlight! Wake up!"

Adora groans, wishing she wasn't just pulled out of her dreams. She pulls the covers over her head, attempting to block out reality. It does little to do as rapid footsteps fill her ears. A split second later, a hand is shaking her.

"Glim!" Adora groans, swatting away the hunter's hand. "It's like three in the morning! Let me sleep!"

"You have to wake up! I need to show you something!"

Covers are pulled away from Adora's face. The blonde whimpers as her small bit of warmth is taken from her. Glimmer really does not want to let up right now.

"Can't it wait 'til the morning?" Adora yawns, burying her face further into her pillow. "I've had enough excitement for today."

"Today is over, it's a new day! But that isn't important. You *have* to watch this! I wouldn't've woke you if it wasn't! Please!"

Adora grumbles before sitting up. She attempts to blink back the fog of sleep in her eyes. Though that is quickly forced out when Glimmer's laptop is set on her lap. She winces at the bright light assaulting her eyes, nearly blinding her. Glimmer quickly fiddles with the brightness, dimming it down enough that Adora's sensitive senses are no longer overwhelmed. As the blonde blinks the world into focus, she finally looks at the screen. "What am I supposed to be looking at?"

"Read the title! What does it say?" Glimmer plops down on the bed, settling on the other side of Adora.

The blonde squints, eyes scanning the pixels. She can read the words, she can understand what they mean. However, stringing them together into a sentence takes several long seconds to piece together. Once it does, Adora feels like a truck load of bricks has collapsed onto her. Any and all sleep that remained on her bones disappears from her body.

Adora opens her mouth to say something but finds her words are non-existent. Eyes wide, she looks at her girlfriend. Without saying anything, Glimmer takes one of Adora's hands in her own, giving a tight squeeze. With the other, she plays the video.

Adora remains frozen as a statue. She has no idea if she is breathing or blinking. Every minute that passes feels like an hour to her. Her jaw slacks, unable to believe what is being shown to her. Many images yank memories she never knew she had.

She recalls sharing a room with her brother, pulling forts with him and playing pretend. Her fingers grip the old blanket below her, remembering how her mother would make apple cinnamon pancakes for breakfast. And, how her father would scoop her up with one arm and carry her around while she would laugh hysterically.

Adam soon speaks. Adora stares at the small icon of her brother. She can see herself in his reflection. As he speaks about his sister, wondering how she has become, Adora feels her heart twisting inside her chest. So many years apart, having become two different people from their kindergarten ages, he still believes in her.

He still wants to be with her.

The video comes to an end. Adora feels her body begin to tremble. Words are still at a loss as choking sobs come out her throat. Tears stream down her face, staining her cheeks. Hands cup over her mouth as she gasps for air. Her brain struggles to comprehend what has just been laid out in front of her. A life she couldn’t recall. A life she once had before being forcefully stripped away from her.

Through all the emotions racing through her—the relief, the sadness, the joy—anger mixes in. She always had a feeling Shadow Weaver lied to her about her family. How they did not want her because of what happened to her and that they only

ever saw her as a monster. Now, she has the confirmation she has longed for. Yet, it still pisses her off to think about.

“Adora?” Glimmer softly whispers. A hand squeezes her shoulder.

“They wanted me, Glim,” Adora croaks out, words finally forming. She removes her hands from her mouth and looks at her girlfriend with misty eyes. Hiccups begin to escape her as her body shakes more than ever. Adora wraps her arms around Glimmer, squeezing her tight as all the emotions pour out of her. “My family is still looking for me!”

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated

All We Have Is Now

Chapter Notes

> 20 chapters! that's a hell of a milestone! While I dont want to put a cap onto the chapters on ao3, I will say we still have a good chunk to go, my outline is planned into the low 30s so :,) oh and i know i said there would be a 4 update but eh I am trying to plan something out so this will be 5. you'll get two more chapters this round!
>
> anyway tw for nightmare, grief, and i guess minor disassociation hopefully thats the right word but ye enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora doesn’t know when she stops crying. She doesn’t know if it's because her tear ducts have dried up or because her body can no longer take the trembling or maybe she has released all the emotions needed. Either way, she finally becomes still. Arms remain wrapped around her girlfriend. Adora neither has the strength nor will to pull herself away from this safety net. Glimmer does not move either. A hand rubs against the blonde’s back.

Her brain struggles to grasp all the thoughts swimming around in her mind. She has a mother and a father. She has a brother, a *twin* brother! They have been thinking about her since her disappearance, wondering who and what she has become. The video left out any details about her being a werewolf, why the hell would they mention that? That question of how her family felt about what happened to her remains up in the air. If they know they have to not care if they are still looking for her, right? Why would they search for her if they say her nothing more than a monster.

But that word, *monster,* rings her mind. Foggy as it might be, it is in her memory. Adora heard her parents say it after all, didn’t

she? But, hasn't much of her life been one huge lie? How can she trust what her brain remembers?

"How are you feeling?" Glimmer whispers after sometime.

"I don't know," Adora replies, struggling to get her voice audible.

"I'm sorry to drop it on you like that but…I couldn't just *not* tell you right away!"

"No, thank you." Finally, Adora pries herself off of Glimmer. She wipes off her tears before turning her attention back on the screen. The thumbnails of suggested videos wait to be clicked on. She ignores them in favor of scrolling back several minutes.

The still image that stares back at her is that of her Mom and Pa. The former has reddish-brown hair, tied into a braid. Behind glasses are the same night sky blue eyes as Adam. In the photo, Marlena grins a crooked grin from ear to ear. She is at a carnival gun game, her target torn up in the middle. Besides her is Randor, looking defeated. His own target has holes spread sporadically across the paper. His dark blonde hair is cut short and despite his loss, his own sky blue eyes look at Marlena with pure love. In the sun, Adora can see freckling hiding behind his own glasses.

"I guess I know now who I take after more." Adora runs her fingers against the screen. So close, yet still so *far,* to touching her parents. She wonders what their embrace feels like. Are their hands rough and callous yet warm like hers? Or are they smooth and gentle like Glimmer's? Maybe something else entirely.

"I bet they are just as wonderful as you," Glimmer reassures.

"You think so?"

"I *know* so." Shoulders bump up against each other. "What do you want to do?"

What do I want to do? Adora leans back against the headrest. Night grips the world and refuses to let go any time soon. At this

hour, it is neither day nor night. A time where you really shouldn't be thinking about anything other than sleeping. Not ask over twenty years of questions. "I don't even know how I should *feel,* Glitter-bug. This is just…How do I even put it into words?"

"Do you want to sleep on it? We can try and figure out something in the morning."

"Yeah. I think that would be best." Adora shuts the laptop before handing it back. As Glimmer sets it aside, she lies down on the mattress. An arm drapes against her forehead as she stares up at the ceiling. Adora doubts she will sleep tonight. Her dreams will not compare to her new reality.

Glimmer begins to find a comfortable position on the bed. That being, Adora's stomach. She uses it as a pillow, remaining on top of the covers. The blonde runs her fingers absentmindedly through the soft, pink locks. Her mind cannot remain on one thought for long. One second she is thinking about how she has her mother's smile, then a split second later she is in awe over the fact she is a twin.

Suddenly, she snorts. Glimmer turns her head enough to face Adora. "What's so funny?"

"I have a last name. Glenn."

"Do you like it?"

"It's better than 'Weaver'. I do really like it. But that's not what made me laugh." She can't help but chuckle.

"So are you gonna tell me or what?"

"Well, since I didn't know what the hell my last name was, and after Ed's comment, I kind of started to think of what it would be like to have your last name. Hell, didn't your dad already call me his daughter? Didn't think I would ever find out what my name really was."

“Adora Mizari.” Glimmer hums. “I like that name!”

“Well, I like Adora Glenn better. I think I am gonna keep it! Though, Glimmer Glenn sounds like an interesting name. Whaddaya think about that?”

“Dork.” Glimmer lightly slaps the back of her hand against Adora’s chest. This only makes the blonde laugh harder. Once it dies down, she sighs.

“Thank you, Glimmer. This is the best birthday present I could ask for.”

“You do know it’s the twentieth now.” Glimmer points out.

“Close enough.”

“Well, you’re welcome. I’m glad. Try and sleep, love.”

“I can’t make any promises.” Adora lets her eyes flutter shut. Fingers continue to play with Glimmer’s hair. Slowly, her brain begins to believe she is touching the clouds high in the sky. Surprisingly, her limbs become heavy. No matter how hard she wants to move them, her body refuses to listen. Maybe returning to sleep is for the best. At least the day will come sooner then. With her girlfriend besides her, there is nothing to fear about.

Adora lets herself slip back into the world of dreams.

Adora rubs her eyes. She didn’t realize how much sleep she needed. Though, hasn’t she been getting her rest lately? Maybe her body is just exhausted after all the excitement. Maybe she’ll take a nap later. Glimmer loves to use her as a pillow when resting, it’s her turn to do so. Though, the question is, where the hell is her girlfriend?

She begins to walk down the stairs. Adora didn’t see her when she woke up this morning. Strange. She wonders what on earth got Glimmer up out of bed so early. Once she locates her, she’ll

definitely have to ask. It has to be interesting. Or, maybe, she never slept at all and is already guzzling down fresh, hot coffee.

However, just as her foot leaves the final step and onto the floor, the world around her changes. Like a ripple, the lower part of the home changes. At first it's small. The wood below her feet turns a different shade of brown. Even the texture turns into something new. But more and more begin to become unfamiliar. Couches change in shape and size, the kitchen moves to another part of the house, walls collapse or rebuild themself.

Nothing is left untouched. Nothing looks as it did only hours before.

Adora feels the hairs on the back of her neck stand at attention. She quickly assesses the situation. No one is around, at least not that she can see. Anyone can be hiding behind closed doors. The blonde opens her mouth, wanting to know where Glimmer is, but stops. No. If a foe is lying in wait, she shouldn't let them know she is here. But, that won't stop Adora from finding her girlfriend.

Adora begins to walk around. She does her best to avoid any creaking boards but whenever one groans under her weight, she pauses and holds her breath. When no one suddenly pops out of thin air, Adora continues. The first few areas she checks yields nothing. She huffs in annoyance as she shuts a closet door.

There is a growing sense of familiarity. Adora cannot put her finger on it. Like a memory she does not know is real or fake. There is only one more door to check before she gives up on finding answers. With a deep breath, she pushes it open. The moment her foot passes the threshold, it's like her body has become ice.

Her heart pounds in her ears as her blood runs cold. While she still cannot grasp a name, she ***knows*** *she has been here before. This room has two small beds. One has sheets in a golden color while the other is a warm orange. Toys—wooden blocks, stuffed animals, and some trading cards—are scattered all over the floor.*

There is a fuzz to much of the room, colors seep out of their lines. The light that streams through the windows is warm and bright.

Adora steps in further. She stops when her foot lands near one of the stuffed animals. Grabbing it, she realizes it is a wolf. The fake fur is a normal, dark grey color. Beady, plastic eyes stare back at her. She rubs a thumb over the stitched up nose. Adora can't help but smile at the inanimate creature. Judging by dulling color and a few loose strains, a child has poured all their love into it.

A noise catches her attention. She holds the stuffed wolf close to her chest, frightened. "H-Hello?" Adora finds herself squeaking out. There is no answer. Something tells her to move forward. Before she can process and decide, her legs move without command. Once more, she finds herself in the hallway. This time, however, the world has become cold and dark.

Another step. Out of the corner of her eye, something darts across her peripheral vision. Adora snaps her head around, finding nothing other than a sheet of pure darkness. The hall simply… ***ends,*** *swallowed up by whatever that thing is. There is no time to piece together what is going on when something touches her right shoulder.*

"What are you doing here?" a voice says.

Adora spins around once more. This time, the darkness has taken shape. She sees the figure of a woman about her height. Many of her features are indistinguishable in the darkness, however, one thing remains clear as day. Those dark, night-like blue eyes.

"Mom?" Adora grips the stuffed wolf harder.

"We gave you up. What are you doing here?" Marlena asks.

"Wh-What? I thought-"

"You thought what?" a new, deeper voice says. A new shadow appears. Taller and with eyes the same shade as her own. "Why would we want a ***monster*** *like you as a daughter?"*

"I-" Words stick to the sides of her throat. Was that video a lie then? Did she make it all up in her head? Breathes come out harsh.

"There is a reason we gave you up." Randor continues. "You never should have come back."

"N-No! Sh-Shut up!" Adora chokes out. Try as she might, she cannot stop the tears from slipping out of her eyes.

"You are not our child," both say together. Their shadows begin to merge together, growing larger and denser. "We don't want you."

Their blue eyes change into a bright, cold, green color. The new shadow now towers over Adora. Dark tendrils begin to wrap around her body. Her arms, her legs, her chest, her neck, almost nothing is left untouched. As they reach her cheeks, they feel like fingers against her skin. The stuffed wolf presses so hard against her body, she swears it will become a part of her.

Those green eyes draw close, boring straight into Adora's soul. Shadow Weaver speaks in a harsh tone. "I told you they only ever saw you as a monster. Why wouldn't they, when you are just like me?"

Shadow Weaver suddenly changes.Her body morphs into a large, menacing werewolf. White teeth are poised to sink into her chest and razor sharp nails are ready to slice through her. Adora cannot even scream, hell cannot even ***blink,*** *before her adoptive mother lunges at her.*

Reality crashes back into Adora like a car crash. Violently and swiftly. Adora gasps for air as all of her nerves light up. Her body tenses for a moment before loosening as it shakes. It feels like she is about to throw up her heart, which finds itself in her throat. She barely knows where she is, *who* she is. Her brain screams at the top of its lungs, drowning out any noises that are around.

A hand clutches her shirt, nails almost breaking the fabric. Her body breaks out into a cold sweat. Adora blinks, the world slowly coming into focus. Eyes shift from the ceiling, to a window hidden by the shades, then to the nightstand within arms length, and then finally, to the sleeping woman resting on her stomach. For once, Glimmer isn't snoring. Instead, she drools.

Adora's breathing slowly returns to a semblance of normalcy. Her body continues to shake, unable to calm down from her nightmare. Her parents' words, all three of them, ring in her ears as her heartbeat quiets down. 'Monster' bounces around her mind, not wanting to give her a moment of peace. Adora places a hand over her mouth, stifling any possible noises.

C'mon Adora, calm down! Calm down!

She closes her eyes, concentrating on her breathing. Adora counts down from fifty. With each count, her body finally decides to relax. By the time she gets to zero, she feels *almost* back to normal. Enough that she removes her hand and settles on it against Glimmer's. Though it no longer feels like something is firing off on every part of her body, her mind is not at ease. While what she has just woken from is nothing more than something her brain made up, how can she know if it is false or not?

How can she know what the hell her family thinks based on a video alone?

"Starlight?" a soft voice calls for her attention before her thoughts can take over.

Adora looks downward. Glimmer stares up at her, her eyes half lit up. The one corner of her mouth still has a small river of drool. Eyelids struggle to remain open. Her body begs for a return to dream, to escape from the morning light. She is not designed to be up this early.

"Sorry, did I wake you?" Adora replies.

“No, you didn’t.” Glimmer yawns. Still using Adora as a pillow, the hunter flips onto her side and curls up into a small ball. “I just wok-Adora, are you crying?”

Adora blinks. The moment she does, a teardrop rolls down her cheek. She catches it with her index finger and lets the sun rays glisten off of it. With a second blink, another small tear exits her eye.

“Are you okay?” Glimmer asks, sounding more awake.

“I’m fine, Glim. I didn’t even know I was crying,” Adora admits.

“Are you sure? Did something happen?”

Adora shakes her head. She is not in the mood to talk about what she has just experienced. “It’s nothing. Don’t worry about it.”

Now, her girlfriend is fully awake. Glimmer sits up and crawls close to Adora. Before the blonde can react, Glimmer places her head in the center of her chest. Adora damn near jumps out of her skin. She can feel her heart skip a beat. The hunter acts nonchalant about the whole situation.

“Well, your heart isn’t racing and your breathing sounds fine. Guess I’ll have to take your word for it. If there is anything bothering you, you know I am here, right?”

“I know, hon.” Adora bends forward. Lips gently brush against the top of Glimmer’s head. Soft hair tickles her nose as the hint of flowers fills her senses. “Don’t worry about it.”

“I can and I will.”

“Do you want to go back to bed? It’s pretty early.”

“Nah. I’m already up.” Glimmer stretches out. “‘Sides, we have… *things* to do.”

Adora groans. She wonders what is the lesser of two evils. Return to unconsciousness and allow herself to forget about the troubles around her, but risk another nightmare? Or, remain awake, face life head on, but be weighed down by it at the same time? Honestly, neither sounds great. But as Glimmer slowly pulls herself out of bed, it no longer remains a tough decision. Any place with the love of her life is better than none at all.

With heavy limbs, Adora pries herself off of the bed. She slowly follows behind Glimmer, neither bothering to change out of their pajamas. While traveling down the steps, for a brief moment, Adora wonders if this is nothing more than a false awakening. That the moment she lands on the flooring below, the world will contort into something new. Thankfully, nothing of the sort happens. Everything remains as it should.

Before daring to do anything else, a meal is quickly made. Nothing too complicated. A simple throwing some frozen waffles in the toaster. While those defrost into something edible, Glimmer impatiently waits for the coffee to come to a boil. They finish at almost the same exact time. Adora preps her food with only some butter before shoving it in her mouth. While she nibbles on it, she plops down on a chair by the table.

Glimmer's laptop already rests on the tabletop, brought down by the hunter. It waits for Adora to open it, as if staring her down. Adora feels her heart beginning to pick up pace once more. She'll have to investigate eventually. Should she rip off the bandaid in one shift movement now? Is that better or should she peel it off slowly but surely? The pain from both is not pleasant.

"What are you thinking about?" Glimmer says from the other side of the room.

"Looking up my family. Maybe start with my brother."

"Are you ready for that? It's barely been a few hours."

"I can't stop thinking about it. If I don't do something, it's only going to get worse, ya know?"

"I'll be over in a minute if you decide to do it."

Adora finishes up her waffle, finding that her stomach already is full. She drums her fingers against the table before finally making a decision. With a breath, Adora pulls the laptop closer and opens it up. She quickly types in the password before heading towards the most popular social media site. Surely her brother must be there. Surprisingly, there are quite a few Adam Glenn.

After scrolling a little bit, she finally locates her brother. He has the same profile picture as the one from the video. She places her mouse cursor over the link but stops short of pressing it. Her finger shakes with anticipation. Adora is shocked that her nerves haven't been completely *fried* at this point. Once she clicks this, there is no going back. A new path will open that she'll be walking down on. One where she doesn't know if it will lead to an abyss of pain or a field of hope.

Come on, Adora. Just do it already!

Adora takes another breath before clicking on her brother's profile. The page needs a moment to load before taking up the whole screen. It's time to learn everything she can about Adam. Behind her, she hears Glimmer stepping close to her and sipping down yet another cup of coffee.

His profile has more pictures of himself. Some are him at a Pride event where he shows off his trans and gay flags. A few have him at home with Marlena and Randor enjoying family life. There even are some with him at Grayskull Academy, the college he recently graduated from. Among the pictures are little bits of information. Loves cats, enjoys sour candies, and loves anything to do with space.

"Huh, so he went for astronomy?" Glimmer states. She leans a hand on the table and squints her eyes as she scans the screen.

“He got a masters in the universe, interesting.”

“Must be really smart then.” Adora clicks through some of the college photos. Some are of him out with his friends, walking about town. A few have him in a football uniform. In at least one, he has a bloody nose. Yet, that crooked smile is plastered on his face. According to some stuff she quickly reads, Adam was not that half bad of a player.

Adora hits another photo. She blinks in surprise at the person Adam sits across from at a restaurant. Looks like a party.

“Glim! Look!” Adora points at the woman. “It’s Teela!”

Adora has totally forgotten about her. But now that comment from before makes sense. She wonders if the two were close at all or maybe only knew each other through friends. Whatever the case, who knew she was that close to her brother all those months ago?

Glimmer’s eyes go wide. “Holy shit! I can’t believe it. Who would’ve thought! I wonder if he knows she’s a hunter.”

“Maybe, who knows…”

Adora leans back in her chair. Its front legs hover off the ground. One arm hangs at her side while her other hand rests above her eyes. With her body feeling heavier than lead, she is surprised that the chair hasn’t toppled to the ground.

“Okay.” Glimmer sets her coffee mug on the table. “What the hell is going on with you? You don’t have to go into details if you don’t want to. But just tell me what is going on in that head of yours.”

“I just don’t know how to feel about all this! Am I happy that I know who my mom, dad, and brother are? Sure! But…” she hesitates, chewing on the bottom of her lip. Does she really want to tell her girlfriend about her nightmare? She hasn’t really had time to process it herself.

Adora feels a darkness growing in her chest. It weighs her down even more than her lead-like limbs. Those shadows from her nightmare rest inside of her, waiting for the right moment to pull her under a deep, dark ocean. Does she really want to worry Glimmer about this? There is already so much to worry about, so much on everyone else's plates. Does she want them to experience this dread of the unknown?

"I just don't know," Adora finally answers. She leans forward, letting the chair fall back to the ground. A finger rubs her temple. "There's so much going on, ya know? Hard to keep track of things."

"Is there anything you want to talk about?"

"No." Adora stands to her feet. She snaps the laptop shut before spinning on her heels. She hopes the smile puts on does not look terribly forced. "We have other things to do. We shouldn't worry about this right now. We can always come back to it."

Before Glimmer can say anything, Adora begins to move. "I'm gonna go take a shower."

Glimmer tucks a loose strand of hair behind her ear. It's a little awkward waiting alone with Catra. Even if she is on a video call and not actually present, there's still unease that hangs in the air. Adora's sister doesn't seem to be happy either. Though, according to her, she had plans on going around nearby towns to do her own investigating and is annoyed she is waiting. *Apparently* Brightmoon has become too boring for the werepanther.

However, they must endure this for the moment. Adora has darted off to the bathroom while Perfuma is finishing up a call from Scorpia. Her girlfriend is visiting her family for the weekend. So, while she waits, Glimmer looks over the notes on her phone. While not everyone has been able to come, there can no longer be any delay. Everyone else can learn about new information. No matter how small it is.

- *Petra being attacked, almost killed*
- *What they said about their healing*
- *Shadow Weaver retreating*
- *Adora regaining some control*

The last point was only added to give a little bit of positivity. It's not like there is anything else to say. Finding out about Adora's family is far too fresh. And, it is also up to the blonde to make that decision if she wants the others to know. One thing at a time.

Soon, Adora comes back. Settles down on the couch, cuddling up right besides her girlfriend. Glimmer drapes an arm over the blonde as she settles into a comfortable position. It does not take long at all for Perfuma to return.

"How's Scorpia doing?" Glimmer asks.

"Very well. She's enjoying spending time with her moms." Perfuma takes a seat on the other side of the couch. She rests her elbow on the armrest while her hand prop ups her head. "Gotta admit. Kind of jealous of you two right now. Once Scorpia gets home, all I am going to do is cuddle her."

Catra promptly makes a gagging noise. "You guys are making me sick! Do you lovedodos do anything else other than being ungodly mushy?"

"You're just jealous," Adora fires back.

"Yeah, *sure."*

"Let's not waste anymore time. What happened with you three?" Perfuma cuts in.

"Where do we even start?" Glimmer sighs.

They start from the beginning. The three recount how on their way to Petra's house, the snowstorm cut them off and trapped them in a hotel for a couple nights. This ended up being a mixture

of good and bad luck. Besides the whole Adora not going bloodthirsty, especially on a Wolf's Moon, they did not have to come face-to-face with Shadow Weaver when so ill-prepared. But of course, that meant a downside.

Perfuma's face grows dark as the three recount what happened to Petra. How she was attacked and only because of her brothers and sister did she manage to get away. They add the fact how the werebear said they felt like their soul was being ripped out of them. And, of course, the weakening healing ability. Even if that was not the case, seeing how badly beaten Petra was, it will be a while before she is back in the game.

Perfuma rubs a hand against her chin as she takes everything in. After several long moments, she said exactly what Glimmer expected. "That is not good news at all."

"Ya think?" Catra retorts. "Mom really just wants to fuck everyone over. It doesn't seem like she's going to stop anytime soon taking her anger out on everyone."

"What's her end goal?" Perfuma asks.

"Probably just to make everyone scared of her and take her revenge on human kind." Adora answers. "She never told me or Catra, as far as I am aware, what happened to her but who knows if that wasn't just a lie."

"I never heard shit." Catra adds on.

"A simple motivation sometimes can be the most powerful," Perfuma mutters. The faery takes a breath before speaking again. "Guess this means we have to figure out how to stop her sooner than later."

"Which means coming up with a plan. Which, you know, has been *so* easy for us." Glimmer groans. She rubs a temple. "At this point all we got is getting lucky and being in the same area as her one night."

“And then what?”

“Not die.” Catra huffs out.

“We are guessing Angella slowed Shadow Weaver by using wolfsbane or something of the sorts, right?” Adora says. “We should start from there.”

“I have some books since I use them in my potions. They are at the store so I don’t have them on me.” Perfuma replies. “Mermista and Sea Hawk can get some information on stuff that grows in the water. You have no idea what your mom used?”

Glimmer shakes her head. “I have never been able to find anything of the sorts. No notes. If anything it’s in her book that is written in Latin. We still haven’t had any luck finding anyone who can read and translate it.”

“I’ll still look around and see if someone knows anything.”

“Thanks.” Glimmer sighs through her nose. She doubts that is going to happen any time soon.

Glimmer *knows* something is up. She might not be able to smell the scents of emotions that seeps off everyone, but she knows her girlfriend. The past couple days, Adora has not been herself. Her smile has lacked it’s brightness. Whenever she walks, half the time her shoulders are curled. Glimmer *swears* that the twinkles in her eyes have dimmed. She can’t say for certain, but the hunter has an idea floating around in her head on what is causing the cloud over Adora’s head.

Adora currently is folding laundry. She has decided to take a seat on the table as she does her work. Two baskets are nearby. One has a pile of fresh out of the dryer clothing. The other has a slowly growing stack of neatly folded items. Adora is meticulous about getting everything flat and in a perfect line. Once satisfied with her work, she gets to work on the next one. Some music

plays from her phone and she barely notices Glimmer walking nearby.

"Yo." Glimmer starts.

"Yo yourself." Adora sets aside a shirt before leaning back slightly on the table. "What's up?"

"I can ask you the same thing." Glimmer sits down on the ground, cross legged. "I know something's up with you."

Adora raises an eyebrow. "What do you mean?"

"I know you didn't want to talk about it the other night but…have you thought anymore about your birth family? About the video I showed you?"

Adora takes a breath. The lights in her eyes dims and her gaze turns away from Glimmer. She begins to fiddle with her fingers. Her mouth opens momentarily but no wonders come out. Adora snaps it shut before shaking her head.

Glimmer runs her hand through her hair. "Do you want to talk about it?"

"I don't know," Adora finally speaks. She rubs the back of her neck. "I mean, I thought of it a little but I've been trying not to. I don't know where to start or how to process everything."

"You haven't thought about contacting them? Isn't that what you always wanted?"

"It is. I always wanted to know who they were! You'd think now that it has fallen right into my lap I would jump right on the chance. But, I don't know. Seriously! That's the problem. I don't know anything about them. And they don't know me.

"Are they going to like me? Will I like them? I was only *five* when I was taken from them. I am not the same person I was then. I'm not the same as I was a few years ago. And I am sure they are

different people also. I want to see them, honest! But…I don't know what I am walking into too. I've had at least one nightmare about it."

Glimmer places a hand on Adora's knee. "I think you should do it. There is no better chance than now. And you have waited this long already."

"I know, I know!" Adora groans. "I'm scared. I'm excited. I'm worried. I'm in awe! There's so much and it happened so fast! Not to mention, everything else that is going on."

"When will you have another chance like this! You can't let it slip by."

"I can always wait until after we deal with Shadow Weaver."

Glimmer feels something boiling up inside of her. As the bubbles burst, the bits that fly off threaten to burn anything that it touches. She bites it back as she speaks. "You don't know what will happen during that time! It might be too late by then!"

"I went this long without seeing them. As long as we are careful, it's not like I am going to die or they are."

The last bit causes her heart to stop in chest. She shoots up to her feet without thinking. The boiling inside of her grows, more bubbles growing and threatening to spill all over. In fact, it begins to stream down the sides of her face. Words burn Glimmer's throat as she speaks. " *You don't know that!* "

Adora jerks back. Her eyes have returned to meet Glimmer's. Sky blue irises are wide and confused. The hunter quickly realizes her mistake. Realizes how tense her body suddenly has become. She loosens up, shrinking her body. "Sorry. I didn't mean to snap. I…I need a minute."

Before Adora can say anything, Glimmer leaves the living room. She quickly races up the stairs, stopping at the very top. The hunter pauses for a moment, letting herself catch her breath she

suddenly has lost. One shaking hand finds itself on a kneecap while another clutches her shirt. She can feel her heart beating against the inside of her chest.

Glimmer slowly turns her head towards the doors in the hallway. Her bedroom is open while her mother's is shut as always. She has not been there since that day with Adora. It feels like a lifetime has passed since then. Her heart begins to tug her towards the room. Glimmer swallows a hard lump that has formed in her throat. Does she really want to re-enter her mother's room now?

Fuck it. Slowly, Glimmer's feet begin to guide her towards the shut bedroom. She is aware that her body is moving, that her arm is reaching for the handle, yet the hunter does not feel like she is in control at all. Every action she takes is not one on her own accord. Even as she crosses the threshold, her legs move without any command. Only when she stops at the closet does she suddenly return to the driver's seat.

Glimmer takes a deep breath before opening it up. Her mother's clothes stare back at her, waiting to be worn once more. Many are blouses or beautiful sweaters. Angella always loved those. Some are dresses for more formal occasions, or when her mother just wanted to feel pretty. And then of course, her jackets for the colder weather. Fingers brush up against one of them. The leather is still smooth as always.

She brings it close to her. Glimmer has a different build from her mother both in height and build. This jacket is not a perfect fit, the sleeves and ends will be too long. But that doesn't matter. Holding this in her arms is like holding a piece of her mother again. Even if her perfume has long since faded away and been replaced by a hint of mildew, she clings to this small piece that her mother has left for her.

Glimmer clutches the jacket close to her chest as she sits down on the bed.

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19 Years Ago

Glimmer giggles as she rummages around. Rarely, if *ever,* has both her mother's bedroom door *and* closet are open. This is the opportunity of a lifetime! Tiny hands push away books and small boxes. The young girl does not stop her search until she finds her mother's boots. Eyes bright, Glimmer slips on the far too large shoes. Hands then reach upward. Fingers grip the hem of a jacket.

It takes several tugs for the leather to fall down. It lands on top of Glimmer, obscuring her vision momentarily. The young girl staggers back in shock, her shoes causing her to fall onto her rear end. Though, this does not deter her in the slightest. Glimmer shakes the jacket off, returning her vision, before slipping it on. Her arms don't even make it half way through the sleeves.

It's perfect!

Glimmer pushes herself back onto her feet. She waddles like a penguin towards the standing mirror her mother has in the room. Upon seeing her reflect, the young girl cannot help but grin from ear to ear. But her outfit is not complete. Her toy crossbow sits inches away. Set on top is a fake arrow, a suction cup it's end. With the sleeves covering her hands, she fumbles with her weapon, nearly sending the ammo flying. Thankfully, Glimmer steadies out. *Now* it is finished.

"What are you doing here?" a soft voice says, a light laugh mixed in.

Glimmer looks up. Her mother has materialized in the doorframe. She cannot hold back a large smile. Her violet eyes are warm and soft as always.

"Imma you!" Glimmer shouts.

“I see that. Though, you are going to have to dye your hair one day to finish that costume of yours.”

Glimmer beams. She somehow spins around to look directly at her mother. The young girl puffs out her chest as far as possible. “Imma gonna protect others like you!”

“Yes you will.” Angella walks forward, closing the gap between the two. Arms reach down and pick up her daughter. Glimmer’s feet slip out of the boots as she is settled against her mother’s chest. A scene of safety and love overcomes the young girl. Whenever she is here, Glimmer never has to worry about the monsters under her bed or the shadows trees make at night. Her mother will chase them all away.

“When can I come with you?” Glimmer asks, eyes wide. “I wanna be a hunter!”

“You will, one day.” Angella taps her index finger against her daughter’s nose. “You have a lot of growing to do.” To make her point, Angella lifts up a sleeve of the jacket. “You barely fit into this!”

“I will grow up one day. Then I can come out with you! And I can protect others! And help others! And be with you!”

Angella chuckles. “I like you small right now. If you grow too big, then I won’t be able to carry you anymore! Can you promise me you will stay small for a while?”

Glimmer rocks in her mother’s arms. She mumbles something as she strings together her thoughts. Being held *is* a wonderful feeling. Especially when her feet are tired and she doesn’t want to walk to her bed. Yet, she is eager to get out and help her mother.

“I will stay small.” Glimmer finally answers. “But I still wanna help!”

“I would expect nothing less from my little girl.”

Angella places a kiss on her daughter's forehead. Now it is Glimmer's turn to giggle. She returns the gesture, though she only makes it to the tip of her nose. "I love you, Mommy."

"I love you too, Glimmer." Angella places their foreheads together. "You have no idea how happy I am to have you as a daughter. I couldn't ask for anyone better."

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Glimmer uses her thumb to rub the mist away from her eyes. There is no need to cry at the moment. The jacket now rests against her lap, the Mizari family crest starting back at her. She debates if she should remove the pin and take it for her own or leave it for her mother. Her thumb moves from her face to the small, silver pin. She does not have much time to think when a new noise catches her attention.

She looks up and finds Adora resting in her body on the doorframe. "Hey."

"Hey yourself." Glimmer sets the jacket aside before standing to her feet.

"Are you feeling any better?"

Glimmer shrugs. "Not really sure. Sorry for snapping. It kind of just came out and I didn't mean to do that."

"It's okay. I…Did I make you angry?" Adora asks softly. Her shoulders slump as she enters the bedroom. "If I did, I'm sorry."

"No. No, Adora." Glimmer pinches the bridge of her nose. She inhales deeply and shakingly. She realizes what she felt before is a bottle stuffed with emotion that has begun to leak. One inside her soul that can no longer contain boiling anger. It singes the glass, weakening it and creating cracks. She can't let it explode. Not here. Not at someone who doesn't deserve it at all.

Glimmer swallows, forcing the anger back into its container. It protests the action, attempting to bust itself back out. However, the hunter manages to plug it up. At least for now. However, it finds other ways to torment her. Namely, in creating small quakes throughout her body.

"It's not you, Adora. I'm sorry if I made you feel like that. " Glimmer repeats through her teeth. She does not know what Shadow Weaver truly looks like, however, a large black wolf begins to form in her mind. Bright green eyes bore into her, taunting her. Slowly, the hunter removes her hand from her face and looks at her girlfriend. "I would *kill* to be in your position right now."

"What?"

"I swear I am not trying to be an asshole here. Whatever you choose is your decision and yours alone. I will stand by whatever it is you do, I promise you that. I just don't want you to live with the regret I do. The regret of 'what-if'.

"You don't know who your family is. You don't know if they are horrible or not. They can be the worst people on earth for all we actually know. But that's the thing. That's all we know– *maybe* . If you don't take that step to see who they are, you'll never get that answer. If you go and they turn out to be what you fear, then you *know.* You can leave, you have no ties other than blood. You have that *closure.* But if you don't, you'll always be left wondering."

The shaking gets worse. At first, it's only her hands. Now, however, it has spread to every inch of her body. Even as she tightens her muscles the quaking cannot be stopped. Glimmer's mind sends her back to that night when she lost her mother. Questions begin to run rampant.

What if she had left school earlier? What if she went out in the woods that night? While nervous, she had been dying to see her mother. Why didn't she go out? Why didn't she get over herself sooner and apologize to Angella long before that night? Why did

she have to explode in anger at her Mother with the last words she spoke face-to-face with her being nothing more than poison?

Why didn't she close the wound between them, one she helped create greatly, sooner? And most of all…

What did her mother think of her during that time of separation and what would she think of her daughter now?

"Please trust me when I say…That it *eats* you alive, the not knowing. Get to know those answers, even if they are shitty. That way, you'll never be left to wonder what they think of you."

Her eyes squeeze shut. Glimmer's body is so tight, she barely has the strength to breathe. Footsteps begin to draw closer. Her body becomes even tighter, making her wonder how taut she can become, not knowing what Adora is thinking. With her mind already running like crazy, the hunter wonders if she misspoke. If she came off as an asshole when her girlfriend is down. *Fuck.*

Strong arms suddenly wrap around her body. Glimmer is pressed against Adora's chest. One hand rubs the back of the hunter's head while the other keeps her body in the embrace. Glimmer finds her face buried into her girlfriend's shoulder as the blonde whispers.

"I'm sorry also. I didn't realize I have a chance you don't. But… don't forget what I said all those months ago. I stand by it and after everything you've done…After all you have helped me with… How you remain determined through all of this! I know now more than *ever* before, Angella would be proud of you." Adora's voice lowers even more. So soft, like the gentleness of a spring breeze. "I know she is looking down at you, smiling, and wishing she can be here as well."

Her bottle breaks. But not the one full of red hot anger. This one is her heavy sorrow. Like a large ocean wave, it hits her hard and there is nothing she can do to stop her tears from flowing down her face. All the while, Adora does not let go. She clings even

tighter, keeping Glimmer from falling down. The hunter gasps for air as she sobs.

“I’m sorry. T-This is supposed t-to be about you. I’m sorry.”

“No, shh. I get it.” Adora reassures. “I get what you're saying. I appreciate it.”

“I’m sorry f-for being s-such a mess.”

“You’re still beautiful to me.”

Glimmer chuckles, feeling lighter. “Dork. God, what the hell would I do without you around?”

“I wonder the same thing with you.” Adora places a tender kiss on top of Glimmer’s head. She begins to rock both of their bodies. “I still don’t really know what to do. If, or, when I see my family, where do we even start?”

Glimmer clicks her tongue against the back of her teeth. “Maybe start off with your brother? He was the one that did that interview.”

“What do we do about the whole Shadow Weaver thing? Do I really want to drag him into this? There is no way we can hide that from him.”

“Hasn’t Shadow Weaver already done so by taking you away from them?”

Adora sighs through her nose. She places her chin on Glimmer’s head. “True. I’d like to see Adam first. I still can’t believe I have a twin. It would be nice to get to know him.”

“I would love to meet him also. He might one day become my brother-in-law, so he better be an asshole or I am going to have to kick his ass.”

This gets Adora to snort. “Usually it’s the brother that kicks his sister’s partner’s ass. Not the other way around. But, I do appreciate that.”

Arms loosen enough for Glimmer to free herself. She wipes her face clean with the sleeve of her shirt. “I don’t know about you, but I think I have had enough emotions for today. Are done with the laundry? I could use something distracting.”

“I have a little bit left. We can finish it together and go from there.”

“One step at a time. Guess that is our new motto.”

Glimmer could stare at Adora all night long. Nothing is more beautiful than her girlfriend fast asleep. Her dark blonde hair has some mess to it already yet much of it falls perfectly against her cheeks. Every soft breath Adora takes makes Glimmer's heart flutter inside her chest.

However, there are things to do. Not only is her body refusing to sleep, as usual, but something else keeps her mind awake. Her laptop is open on her lap, Adam's profile staring at her. Glimmer taps her finger against the side of her chin, debating if she should contact him. The little DM box waits for her to type something in. Once something is sent, there will be no take backs.

Glimmer sighs. It has been a couple days since their little talk. In that time, Adora has become more open to seeing at least her brother. Adam is a great start. A little less scary than meeting your parents. However, hesitancy remains. That fear of not knowing what they are truly like hangs over their heads. After a little more talking a couple hours ago and getting nowhere really, well, here they are now. Though, it took a while for Adora to finally pass out.

Glimmer hates seeing her girlfriend debating with herself what to do, almost like she is at war. So why not try to get the ball rolling

herself? It can be a nice little surprise also! But she has to get over her own nerves as well. The tapping against her cheek turns into small slaps.

C'mon Glimmer. Just do it already! This is for Adora! Just do it!

Her hands over her keyboard, fingers shaking. For all she knows, Adam can be like Adora. Early to bed early to rise. It's late and who else on earth besides her would be up at this hour. He will not respond until later. Glimmer doesn't know if that is worse or better. And didn't Glimmer say to her girlfriend herself it best to do this now, before it's too late?

Fuck it!

Glimmer begins typing away. A simple message.

-Hey, sorry if this is random but I saw that Fuzzfeed Unsolved video on your sister. I might have some information for you.

The moment she hits send, she exhales the air trapped in her lungs. Glimmer runs a hand through her hair. The first step has been made and there is no going back now. Now it is a waiting game. For the time being, she can find something mindless to do until her brain finally decides to shut down for the night. However, just as she is about to close the tab on Adam's profile, a notification catches her eye.

Did he seriously reply that fast?!?

Glimmer scrolls her mouse down and clicks on the message. Sure enough, he has. Guess Adam does not share the early bird gene. The hunter takes a breath before reading what he has to say.

-You better not be bullshitting me. I get a lot of those. Tell me what you know.

Okay. Guess she's doing this. Glimmer takes a moment to think. What does she say? Does she want to go into this head on and fast, or slowly and steadily? She has to gain Adam's trust if this is

going to work. With the half assed plan in her mind, it includes meeting up with Adam (if possible). After a moment's debating, Glimmer gets to work.

-Its…complicated. I dont think I have time to get into everything, let alone writing it out in text.

Adam replies just as fast as before.

-Are you suggesting we meet up?

Glimmer can hear the scoff Adam is surely making right about now. The hunter groans. She knows what she is going to have to do. Carefully, so as not to disturb Adora, Glimmer reaches for her phone on the nightstand. Quickly, she scrolls through her gallery. It does not take long for her to find a good photo. One of Adora and her out to town, sharing a milkshake despite the colder weather outside. Bow took the photo for them.

Glimmer quickly goes to the profile on her phone, picking up from where she left off. She begins to type away and attaches the photo alongside it.

-Yes. This is why I cant tell you everything over a DM.

Her breath gets caught in her throat. Adam's fast response from before ceases to be. The seconds turn into minutes. Glimmer begins to worry she somehow messed this all up. That she went too fast or Adam is thinking this is just more bullshit. How many dead ends has he and his family been through in the search of Adora? For all he knows this photo is nothing more than a fake.

After what seems like forever, Adam finally gives a reply.

-How soon and where do you want to meet up?

"What the hell are you doing that you are up so early?" Adora asks in shock. It must be a surprise as well that while she is still in her pajamas, Glimmer is dressed for the weather outside.

“I have to run some errands. Hunter related stuff.” Glimmer replies, adjusting her jacket. “Ya know, going to see what’s up. Gonna check a neighbouring town and see if they have any information or how they are doing.”

This, at least, is partly true. After talking to Adam more, it turns out he is currently not terribly far away. In fact, the city of Eternos is settled right between Brightmoon and where Adam happens to be. An hour drive for both of them. Glimmer did not expect the ball she pushed to be rolling *this fast* but she got herself into this mess. At least Adam has agreed not to say anything to his parents yet. Not until he learns more.

A half lie is the best she can do at the moment with not much to work on.

“When did this come up?” Adora raises an eyebrow.

“Sorry, it was last minute. I, uh, got a text from someone that knew my mom. Said to come. Sorry I didn’t tell you. But,” Glimmer lifts up her phone. “Mermista has some plans.”

Adora’s eyebrow raises even more.

Knowing that Adora would want to come and wanting to keep her *from* coming, the best thing Glimmer came up with was texting Mermista. All the hunter said to the mermaid was she was heading out to get a surprise for Adora and needed someone to keep her girlfriend occupied. Mermista did not mind the idea at all, saying she doesn't have much else to do and that she will come up with some bullshit excuse. Hopefully, it works.

“I will make it up to you, I promise,” Glimmer reassures. “I might not be home until late but enjoy your day with Mermista. You two haven’t interacted much but I am sure you guys will get along just fine.”

"Okay…" Adora says, her voice small.

Glimmer sighs, her heart twisting inside her chest. She slowly walks up to her girlfriend. When in reach, she rubs a hand against Adora's arm. "I know. This won't happen often, I swear. But! I promise to bring you back something nice."

"Like what?"

"It's a surprise." Glimmer gives a wink. This gets Adora to snort and roll her eyes. At least a smile appears on her face.

"Okay. It better be good."

"Trust me, it will." Glimmer stands on the tips of her toes and places a kiss against Adora's lips. "I love you, Starlight."

"I love you too, Glitter-bug."

Glimmer gives her one more kiss before exiting. As she walks towards her car, she texts Bow. She does not want to be alone in this and Adam didn't seem to mind an additional person around. Though, she hasn't told her best friend all the details. Once she meets up with him, then she can catch Bow up to speed.

Plus, Glimmer hasn't slept at *all.* She yawns as she settles into the driver's seat. She needs someone else to drive so she doesn't fall asleep at the wheel. Thankfully, Bow will be at a nearby coffee shop. It does not take long to get there and spot him. Glimmer parks in a parking space and exits the car.

"So," Bow starts. He sticks a cup of coffee in his hand, "are you going to tell me what's up."

"One sec!" Glimmer quickly sips down the hot liquid. In an instant, she begins to feel more awake and alert. But not enough to drive a whole hour. "Okay, so we are going to Eternos."

"Why there?" He begins to take slow sips of his own coffee.

"To meet up with Adora's brother, Adam."

Bow begins to choke on his drink. He hits his fist against his chest, gasping for air. “H-Her brother?!? Adora has a *brother?”*

“Twin brother.” Glimmer smirks.

“Since when?!?”

“Since, like, five minutes after birth.”

“Alright, you *really* gotta catch me up with everything. You are not allowed to fall asleep on me until after that, got it?”

“Deal. And I promise I will drive back, I owe you.” Glimmer walks over to the passenger side. “Now let’s go get Adora’s brother!”

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated

Hey Brother

Chapter Notes

I had some trouble with this chapter but the end of it is another thing I have had in my head for so long I have waited so long to show off! I ramble about my story in so many chats i forget which one helped me figure stuff out here so sorry i love yall ^^;

anyway i dont think there are really any tw in this. you will be getting one more chapter after this for reasons so enjoy!

edit: well i posted this early by mistake and Im not deleting just to redraft it so surprise!!! enjoy I guess

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer gulps down yet another cup of joe. The effects of the last one have left her body. According to Bow, while in the car, she nearly slumped forward and hit her head on the dashboard when she momentarily slipped into unconsciousness. Despite denying she did this, the two friends have stopped at a rest area. Plus, Glimmer hasn't even had any breakfast. Apparently, neither has Bow. Both have gotten an egg and cheese sandwich. Not enough to fill them completely but enough to hold them over until they get to Eternos.

"So, Adora doesn't know about any of this?" Bow asks after swallowing a bite. "You didn't say anything?"

Glimmer shakes her head. "No. I thought of it last night so *I* barely have had time to think about it. With everything going on, and how shitty her adoptive family was, I want to give her something nice. Why not her brother?"

"Can I see a pic of him again?"

"Why? Got a crush?" Glimmer smirks.

A blush spreads across Bow's face. "N-No!" he says all too fast. Her friend begins to pick at his half eaten breakfast and refuses to keep eye contact. "I want to make sure I know what he looks like when we find him."

Glimmer chortles, enjoying this a bit too much. She quickly scrolls and taps away on her phone until she finds a photo. She taps the picture on Adam's profile before sliding it over to Bow. "He pretty much looks like Adora but as a dude."

Bow takes the phone and studies the photo. "I still can't believe he is real. He's definitely going to show up?"

"He seemed like he really wanted to. Wouldn't you? What if you had been searching for one of your brothers for the better part of two decades and suddenly, almost out of the blue, he just reappears?"

"I probably would be feeling a lot of different emotions." Bow slides the phone back. "I don't know if I would be able to sleep after hearing my sibling has been found."

"Tell me about it."

"Have you figured out what you are gonna say to him? I really hope you aren't going to wing something like this."

Glimmer remains silent for a moment, slowly chewing the rest of her food before she replies. "I have been trying to come up with something but honestly, not knowing how Adam will react, we might have to judge as we go."

Chatter turns into small talk. Something to pass the time before heading back into the car. Upon finishing, they do not automatically leave. Both Bow and Glimmer must muster the courage to complete their trip. The hunter's mind thinks of hundreds, if not thousands, of different outcomes to this meeting. Adam can either be the nicest guy on earth. Sweet as honey and a big old teddy bear. Or, he can be a total dick and make the actions Catra did look more "saintly".

Only time, a short time in fact, will tell. They shouldn't idle around any longer. With a deep breath, Glimmer pushes back the chair she sits on and rises to her feet. Bow follows suit. The world outside has turned grey. Both high above in the sky, where clouds mask the sun, and down below, where weeks of salt and being trudged through has turned the white snow a slate color. Grass continues to struggle to break through it all.

Glimmer inhales some of the cold air. *Let's go, Glim. Do this for Adora!*

She leads the way towards the car. As Bow takes out his key, spinning them around on a finger, the hunter snatches them. Her friend shouts but she quickly cuts him off.

"I am awake now. Least, enough to give you a break."

"Are you sure about that?" Bow questions. "You only had, like, two cups of coffee."

"How much longer do we have 'til Eternos? Half hour?"

"About. Just tell me if you need to switch off. No need to get into a car crash."

The rest of the drive is nothing special. Some simple eye spy games help pass the time. Somehow, Glimmer remains awake without nodding off at all. It's a damn miracle she makes it the rest of the way as such. However, as she pulls into a parking spot, that heaviness does begin to creep back into her bones. Thank god Eternos has a number of coffee shops.

Eternos is larger than Brightmoon. More buildings reach towards the sky, a few far too high to see the top. Life is busier, more people threaten to bump into one around as they jog down the sidewalk. In the short time they have been here, Glimmer has heard multiple angry honks for not moving fast enough. The word 'slow' must not exist here.

Glimmer checks her phone. Adam will be traveling by bus. If things go smoothly, he should be here in a few minutes. *If.* Another run for coffee. Many others seem to have the idea. By the time Glimmer and Bow get their own drinks, the bus arrival time has come. When the two head back outside and walk the small distance to the bus stop, it isn't that surprising that there is nothing around. Only more people walking and cars zipping by on the one way street.

So they wait. And wait. Glimmer tries to savour her coffee, let it last a little longer than normal. But, that doesn't work. Her drink is quickly finished. To keep her hands busy, the hunter begins to pick at the styrofoam cup. Occasionally, she checks her phone. She did not get the time wrong. The bus should have been here by now. Glimmer groans. To give herself more of distraction, she decides to look around the city.

There are some people putting on a performance. Some in the group sing and dance with the others play various types of instruments. In another area, people wait in a line outside to get into some restaurant. Glimmer notices two people in an argument and looks like a brawl is about to break out. Those around the pair pay little attention to it, passing them by as if nothing is happening at all.

Glimmer's mind begins to wander. She wonders what Mermista and Adora are up to right about now. There have been no text updates—not that the hunter asked for them—from the pair. Hopefully, they *are* getting along just fine. As long as her girlfriend is distracted right now and is enjoying her time, that is what matters. While thinking, it suddenly dawns on her that if Adam does not appear, she is going to have to come up with another surprise to bring home. Guess she'll have to deal with that later.

A slight yet rapid tapping against her arm catches her attention. Bow gestures slightly across from him. A bus hiss as it lowers itself to the ground, people already streaming out. One by one, strange faces appear. Some old, some young. Some hidden behind masks or glasses, some showing off all their blemishes.

There is at least one child tumbling out as they hold onto their parent's hand.

Glimmer waits with bated breath. It already has been about ten minutes since the bus was supposed to show up, this better not be the wrong one. As the stream of people becomes a trickle, the hunter's heart drops in her chest. More waiting? Her nerves are already running like crazy, why do they have to suffer more? Why does Adora have to wait more?

Just as she is about to give up, one last person appears. A man about her age. A bag rests on his back as he and the bus driver get a suitcase from the large storage area. With his mouth hidden by his orange scarf, his glasses fog up momentarily. His dark blonde hair is tied into a small ponytail. Though, while his bangs cover part of his face, there is no doubt about it. There is a familiarity Glimmer cannot mistake for anything else.

It's Adam.

"You ready for this?" Bow asks.

"Would anyone be?" Glimmer replies.

As the bus begins to leave, Adam stares at his phone for a moment. He lifts his head up and begins to scan the area. It's now or never.

"Let's do this."

Glimmer shoves her phone in her pocket and tosses out the broken up coffee cup before walking towards Adam. Bow follows her a pace behind, still enjoying his drink. Adam notices them a moment later and speaks first.

"Are you Glimmer Mizari?" he asks.

"Hm. And this is my friend Bow Reccula." Glimmer gestures a thumb over her shoulder.

“Pleasure to meet you!” Bow says.

Adam sticks out his free hand, giving a shake to the pair of friends. “The same to you. I am eager to hear what you guys know about my sister. I couldn’t sleep at all, not even on the bus ride here.”

“Sounds like someone I know.” Bow rests his arm on Glimmer’s head like an armrest. The hunter grumbles and slightly growls. “Why don’t you put your bags in the car and we can find someplace to sit and eat.”

“That sounds like a plan to me.”

Bags are put safely away in the trunk and the now trio heads to the closest restaurant that isn’t overrun but other hungry people. Thankfully, there they find a place about a block and a half away. During the whole time there, not much chatter is made. An awkwardness hangs over their heads. Outside in the open, with so many secrets to be spilled, is far from a brilliant plan. Sitting down together and keeping voices low, with music and the sounds of plates and silverware drawing them out, is better.

Not to mention, Adam wobbles slightly as he walks. Who knows how long he can remain upright.

When they reach their destination, they are led to a corner booth. The much needed talk does not occur immediately. Only after food and drinks are ordered and the waiter disappears does the ball get rolling.

"Alright," Adam starts after a sip of his coffee. "I haven't told my parents yet, like you said."

Glimmer sighs at the statement. "Thank you. I'm sorry I had to ask that."

"Tell me why I shouldn't tell them and how the hell do you know my sister. Tell me *everything.* "

The way he has the last word…The way his gaze hardens over his glasses, Glimmer has a feeling he is aware of the hidden world around him. With a deep breath, she starts from the very beginning. She realizes it has *just* been over half a year since June. Since she stumbled onto Adora in the woods just after a shift. A lifetime, maybe more than that, has passed since then.

She talks a bit about herself. How she was born into the world of hunters. Growing up to know about the supernatural world and raised to help. How her mother was killed and she has been searching for her killer and was injured herself, gaining slight werepanther powers. The chat goes onto Adora's time with Glimmer. Falling in love, searching for answers to who has been killing others, and wondering who her birth family was. Glimmer even tells about what Adora told her, those vague memories from when she was five.

Adam listens to it all. He hangs onto all the words. One hand covers his mouth in thought. Glimmer only pauses when the food comes. She continues with Adora gaining some control of her werewolf form after being unable to for so long. One of the last things Glimmer tells Adam is how Petra, someone who has been helping out, recently got attacked but survived.

"Do you know who is doing this?" Adam finally asks.

"I was getting to that. You aren't going to like it. You know how I said Adora said your dad gave her to a woman."

"Yeah. I was there. We thought she would help Adora."

"Wait, what?" both Glimmer and Bow say in unison.

"Yeah. My pops and I went with Adora to meet her. My mom had to work. I know Mom and Pa found out about her and she told them she was a hunter. After debating for a bit, they agreed to see what she could do. We thought she could help with Adora since my parents were at a loss."

Glimmer leans back in the booth, fingers running through her hair. "Jesus. You are going to have to explain everything to us. But, no, back to what I was saying. It's her. She goes by Shadow Weaver. She raised Adora and another person, Catra. She's been killing and attacking others. She…" her mouth goes dry and words become small "was the one who killed my mother."

Adam's eyes go soft. "I'm so sorry. Shadow Weaver has fucked with both of our families."

"Tell me about it."

Adam pinches his nose, his glasses lifting up slightly. "This is...well a lot! And sorry for being a bit standoffish. I...I have been waiting for this for so many years. I can't believe I actually have answers!"

Glimmer sees Adam's body begin to tremble. Tears fill his dark blue eyes. He takes deep, shaking breaths. "I'm sorry."

It's Bow who makes the first move. His hand reaches, gently landing on top of Adam's free one. Adora's brother looks up, his cheeks already becoming stained. Out of the corner of her eyes, Glimmer sees her friend smiling softly. He says, "Hey, it's okay. I know it is a lot."

"Yeah," Glimmer adds. "You don't have to be sorry about anything."

"Thanks." Adam wipes off his face. "I still can't wrap my head around this. Adora is alive…"

"I know you probably want to tell your mom and dad, but do you see why right now to keep it between us? At least, until we don't have to worry about Shadow Weaver anymore. I don't want to drag anyone else into this mess."

"No. I get it. I don't want to drag my parents into this mess. They already have suffered enough from this, they shouldn't have anything else on their plates. But since I am here, I want to help

in any way I can. I don’t know a lot about this stuff, I only was able to learn so much, but I can do something.”

“I appreciate that. What are you going to tell your parents, though?”

“Yeah, for all we know this could take a while,” Bow states.

Adam gives a small shrug. “I’ll figure something out. I have already been away from home for a bit, I can figure out some sort of lie. So…" Eyes become like puppy dogs as she speaks. "When can I meet my sister?”

“That might be a little bit of a problem right now.”

Glimmer quickly explains the situation. How she overestimated the time and how Adora will not be around for a while. Mermista currently has her busy for a few more hours. Until she gets a text saying the two are ready to return home, there is not much anyone can do. The whole surprise is to bring Adam back when Adora is at the house.

Adam snickers, a slight snort coming out of his nose. “She has no idea about this? I am even more eager to see her now because of that!” He flashes a crooked grin. “Guess we gotta find something to do.”

While they wait for the text from Mermista that she and Adora are back home from whatever they are doing, the trio explores the city of Eternos. After having a nice meal, a quick stop to a sweet shop is made. Adam makes a beeline for the sour candies, getting at least two baggies. While Bow gets his own sweets, he shows the new member of the group some of what he likes. Glimmer gets her own small bag, a mixture of different candies. What she focuses most on is getting enough chocolate to satisfy Adora’s hunger but not enough to give her a stomach ache. Once everyone has what they need, it's more finding things to kill time.

During their little adventure around the city, Adam reveals how he knows Teela. He didn’t know she was a hunter but they shared a

couple classes in college. He never told her about Adora (as even with his closest friends it is so sensitive only a handful know). This reminds him to shoot her a message soon.

The longer they wait for Mermista to say Adora is free, the less Adam is able to remain still. He either rocks on his legs or is unable to keep them still when he sits. Occasionally he asks things about his sister. What she likes and dislikes. If she still wakes up first thing in the morning. Anything little that comes to his mind he asks. Glimmer and Bow do their best to answer. It only gets him excited.

Finally, after hours of waiting, Glimmer feels her phone vibrating in her pocket. The trio has busied themselves at a cat café. Something Adam suggested they go to. It doesn't take the hunter long at all to read what has been sent.

"Adam," she says, shoving her phone back in her pocket.

"Yeah?" Adam asks. He has a huge grin on his face as a smokey-grey cat crawls on his shoulders, purring like a chainsaw.

"Are you ready to meet your sister?"

Adam's eyes go wide. He opens his mouth but no words come out. All he manages to do is give a nod.

Not much is said during the car ride back to Brightmoon. Adam's leg refuses to stop bouncing during the trip. Bow tries to make some small talk but it doesn't last long in the slightest. Glimmer feels her own nerves running wild. She wonders what Adora will think about this all. The hunter is *sure* that her girlfriend will be happy, eventually.

But this is going to be a fully loaded truck of emotions running over her. One without warning. Glimmer worries the most about Adora becoming overwhelmed. But whatever happens, will happen. Whatever Adora will need, Glimmer will do her damnedest to help, even if that means giving her space. She'll be there no matter what.

After what seems like a lifetime, Glimmer pulls into her driveway. The sun has begun to set. It has yet to paint the sky in a soft orange color—the bright blue remains strong. Her house waits for her to enter. Inside, Adora is somewhere, blissfully unaware of what is about to come crashing into her life.

"I am going to go see where Adora is," Bow says, unbuckling. "Try and get her a little prepared for this."

He disappears into the house. Glimmer looks over her shoulder at the backseat. Adam has begun to chew on his thumb. The hunter takes a long sigh. "You ready?"

"I've waited for this for over twenty years. You'd think that answer would be 'yes'. But I really don't know. But I can't back out now, can I?"

"Neither can I. Let's go."

Adora's leg bounces as she waits for Mermista to come. She exhales, letting her breath crystallize in front of her. The small cloud rises slightly before disappearing forever. After a while, she decides to bury the lower half of her face into the collar of her yellow hoodie. Adora begins to wonder why on earth she decided to wait outside for the mermaid. However, she *knows* the moment she goes back inside, Mermista's car will appear.

So she remains outside, cold air nipping at her skin. Part of Adora wants to pull her hands out of her pocket and check the time. Another part, the one that wins out, does not want her fingers to become any redder than they already are. The only thoughts that keep her occupied are hoping Mermista appears soon…and what the hell Glimmer is up too.

She cannot make any real guess as to what had her girlfriend run off so fast. Something about last minute hunter errands doesn't sit well with her. Maybe Glimmer heard about information concerning Shadow Weaver? Maybe she didn't want her to deal with more

shit from her mom. Adora can't blame her for that. Or, what if Glimmer has to meet someone that is on the dangerous side and wants to keep her from harm. This gets Adora's heart racing with the thought of her girlfriend in such a situation, even if she can care for herself.

Or maybe, her girlfriend really does have hunter stuff to do and it was last minute. Whatever the case, Adora can't wait for Glimmer to return. Whatever surprise she had in store will be nothing compared to cuddling up with her tonight.

The sound of a car's engine grabs her attention. Adora flicks her eyes towards the street and spots Mermista's blue car pulling into the driveway. She wastes no time in jumping clean off the porch, not bothering with any steps. By the time the vehicle shutters to a halt, Adora's fingers have wrapped around the freezing door handle.

"Cold enough for you?" Mermista asks.

"You can say that." Adora plops down on the passenger seat. She rubs her hands together before placing them near the vents. "What about you? Does the cold affect you at all?"

"It affects me as much as everyone else." Mermista backs out of the driveway and heads back on the road. "You ready to hang out?"

"Yeah. What do ya have planned? Glim didn't tell me much."

"Ever hear of a mystery room?"

Adora blinks. "No."

Mermista quickly explains everything. Essentially, they will be with some other people and shoved into a strange room. The one the mermaid plans to go to has you solving three rooms, each connected to the other. Apparently, it's a pretty tough one. Though, this does not deter Adora in the slightest. She is down for this challenge.

The mystery room is not too terribly far away. Fifteen minutes tops. During the trip there, Adora asks what Sea Hawk is up to. That answer is, apparently, with his brothers and sisters. They had come to visit and he could not say no to seeing them. Mermista just hopes she does not get a call and hears that she has to pick up the five siblings from the police station for starting a fire by mistake. Adora snorts, though wishes that nothing comes of it.

Curious, Adora does ask if she has any idea about what Glimmer is doing. She is not shocked at all when Mermista says she has zero idea and knows about as much as the blonde. Guess only time will tell what the hell is going on.

The rest of their conversation involves simply what they have been up to since the last time they saw each other. Which isn't much honestly. Adora doesn't bother mentioning the whole thing about her brother. Honestly, the moment Adam enters her mind, she shakes the thought away. No need to ruin a nice day with that. Though, it keeps attempting to sink its claws into her brain. Adora ends up slapping the sides of her face.

"Are you okay?" Mermista asks.

"Yeah. Don't worry about it." Adora sighs. "Just trying to think about stuff s'all."

"Well, you don't need to worry about it anymore." The car comes to a halt. Once her keys are out of the ignition and around her fingers, Mermista points out in front of her. "We are here. Hopefully this will keep you from thinking about whatever it is on your mind."

Adora stares out the windshield. They have finally reached their destination. A mall that many frequent. Though, this is the first time she has ever been here. By mall standards, this building complex is neither small nor large. Three stories tall with many stores littered about. Besides the mystery room, apparently there also is a small bowling rink and movie theater. Maybe later, after

the fun of the mystery room, Adora can go into the store to find something for Glimmer.

She follows Mermista into the building. As she enters, Adora senses start to become a little overwhelmed. As a child, she never has been in such a bustling place like this. Most malls were half this size. All around her, people are streaming in and out of stores. Some stop at the many kiosks on the open floor. Those that have food fill her nose in savour and sweet smells and makes her mouth water. Her stomach growls, begging to chow down at the candy one nearby.

Mermista gives her a small nudge, gesturing upward. The mystery room is on the third floor right above them. A quick trip on the elevator brings them straight to the top. Up here, the stores are much larger. Restaurants, multiple roomed clothing stores, and the movie theater. Pale sunlight shines through the windowed ceiling and Adora notices some sparrow chirping and flying about on the rafters. She stares up at all of it in awe, mouth agape like a child seeing magic for the first time.

After a couple turns, and taking a moment to look into some stores, the two reach the mystery room area. It is huge compared to the other stores. At least three others could fit into it just from looking where Adora stands. Pushing open the glass doors, the front area has a number of people waiting by the desk. Above it are TVs that play footage to get others pumped for the adventure ahead.

Adora feels her heart beating against her chest. Excitement flows through her veins while her nerves fire off like wild. She has no idea which one is causing her hands to shake. The urge to gnaw on something grows and her rubber sword finds itself in her mouth. So many thoughts about what will be inside and what she'll do with Mermista run through her head that Adora cannot grab hold of any.

"You aren't going to have, like, an anxiety attack on me, are you?" Mermista asks. "We don't have to do this if you are getting

overwhelmed. There is plenty else to do at the mall."

"No. I'm fine," Adora manages to get out while chewing. "I never did anything like this before. I just need a minute."

"Well, you do that. I will get tickets to go in."

Adora gives a little nod. As Mermista heads to the desk, the blonde begins to rock on her heels. She takes a moment to check her phone. Clicking the lock button, the screen reflects back a photo of Glimmer. Taken around Christmas time. She stands by one of the windows, looking out into the white, cold world. She wears one of her aunt's sweaters. It's white with purple snowflakes wrapping around the mid section. In her hands is a steaming cup of coffee. The orange light from the setting sun surrounds her in a warm glow. This single snapshot in time of a still moment is by far one of Adora's favorites.

There are no messages or missed calls from her or anyone. Adora's leg begins to bounce again. She continues to wonder what Glimmer is up to. Part of her is tempted to text her girlfriend to make sure everything is going okay. But at the same time, she doesn't want to seem like a bother. Biting a little harder on her sword, she shoves her phone back in her pocket. Just in time for Mermista to reappear.

They are set to go with the next group. Which is now actually. Mermista ushers Adora to the door with a number of other people. Most are around their age, maybe a bit younger. One of the staff members quickly goes over the rules and says to have fun and enjoy themselves. With that, the group is let into the first room they must escape.

It is not terribly big. The size of a small bedroom. Though, it is set up like a classroom. There is a black chalkboard with a math problem, riddle, and some sort of decoder message. There are desks, items hidden within and chairs waiting to be sat on. Some posters and a clock hang on the walls. Judging on how the only

other door in the room has a passcode lock on it, the answers will be number based.

Not in the mood to do algebra and with no cipher in sight (others have begun to search for it), Adora decides to tackle the riddle. Though, upon further inspection, she sees it is math based. A curse leaves her lips at the sight.

"Don't like numbers?" Mermista asks, looking at the riddle as well. It says:

I am an odd number. Take away a letter and I become even. What number am I?

Adora runs a hand through her hair. "Not really. You don't know how hard my mom was on me over math. Made me redo problems and I wasn't allowed to stop until I got it right!"

"What a bitch. Well, I suck at math also but I actually know this one. Sea Hawk sometimes likes to find random riddles online and tries to get me to guess it."

"Really?"

Mermista grabs a piece of chalk and begins writing out the number seven. Once all the letters are written out, she uses her thumb to erase the 's'. "See?" The mermaid taps the chalk against the chalkboard.

"Oh, sweet. Glad we got one of those done really quickly. Do you want to go help look for the cipher?"

"Hell yeah."

Adora and Mermista join the group rummaging around the classroom. At least half the desks have already been torn apart in the search for the elusive cipher. Adora pulls out some items but finds nothing of use. Though, as she looks up, she notices a small end table off to the side, some books underneath. No one else

has paid much mind to it. Slowly, she begins to wander over towards it.

The books yield nothing. She quickly turns to the drawer and pulls it open. After shifting around the papers, her fingers finally land on what she is searching for. Adora pulls out the cipher. A large grin spreads across her face as she races over to the group. Excited, everyone gets to work. By the time they finish figuring out the secret number, the math problem is solved. The numbers are punched in and the door unlocks. Time for round two.

This time around, the key to the lock is hidden in three puzzles. According to Mermista, it has been broken up and they will all stick together once they are found. This grabs more of Adora's attention. She grabs one of the puzzles you have to pull apart by finding the try pieces to pull. It does not take long for her to figure out what to do and have one third of the key drop into her hands. Impressed, the others ask for her help.

All the puzzles are solved in a relatively short amount of time. With the ends made of magnets, the three pieces of the key snap together and allow the group to reach the third and final room. This one is yet again another pass code, however this time around with letters. To figure out how the hell to get out, everyone must look at a set of three paintings and search for said letters hidden within. Seems simple enough but when you are looking at a city landscape or jungle or people crowding the beach, it becomes a challenge.

Adora does her best to locate any semblance of a letter. She begins thinking she finds something, however, she quickly realizes it is from her eyes begging for a break. While the past two rooms she was able to aid greatly, she ends up completely sitting this one out. Mermista ends up finding all the letters after some time. Though, she ends up asking Adora if *she* wants to punch in the code.

"Why? You solved it." Adora points out.

Mermista shrugs. “You looked bummed. And hey, you did a lot in the last two rooms, so knock yourself out.”

Adora sees the others in the group nodding in agreement. She blushes slightly at all the eyes suddenly on her. But, the thought is nice and definitely makes her feel a little better about not being able to do anything. With all the rooms complete, the same person from before greets them in the back room. They grin and congratulate the group for finishing without giving up. With that, they wish everyone well and see them again soon.

“Did you have fun?” Mermista asks as they leave the mystery room.

“Yeah! We gotta get the others to come along next time. Maybe with all of our heads put together we can solve it even faster!” Adora chirps.

“Maybe. We just have to see how everyone’s schedules are. The summer might be the best time to do it.”

“Let’s start planning then!”

The two friends spend a couple more hours seeing what else is in the mall, simple stuff. They buy themselves a couple things as well as their significant others. Mermista gets Sea Hawk some things for his hair. Apparently he spends a lot of time on it. Adora, meanwhile, gets Glimmer a CD of one of her favorite bands. She hopes her girlfriend doesn’t already have this hidden somewhere in her car or home. After getting a quick bite to eat, they decide to head home.

Back in the car, Adora checks her phone. The afternoon has arrived and Glimmer seems to be busy. Honestly, at this point she cannot wait to hear what her girlfriend has been up to. Hopefully she can stay up tonight and listen to it all.

While driving back, Mermista asks if there is anything else Adora would like to do. After some thought, the blonde suggests going back to the mermaid place. She doesn’t like the idea of being

home alone for however long it will be until Glimmer gets back. Mermista doesn't seem to care much. Actually she seems happy to have some company also.

When they get back to the mermaid's house, Adora carefully walks on the planks of the lower floor. Mermista disappears into the water for a moment, having said she needed to get something. While she waits, the blonde sticks her hand in the water and finds it is nice and warm. With the world outside so cold, winter refusing to leave, this is a wondrous feeling.

"Enjoying yourself?" Mermista asks upon popping her head out. Her blue scales shine in the pale, artificial light.

"It's like a small hot tub. You do this every winter?"

"Yeah. Can't go freezing our tails off during the winter." Mermista pulls herself out of the water. Her tail quickly disappears and feet plant themselves against the wood. Back together, the two women head to the dry second floor.

"So what do you want to do?" Mermista asks.

Adora plops down on the couch. "Honestly, I don't know." She thinks for a moment. "How have you been holding up without Sea Hawk around?"

The mermaid snorts a little. "Well, it has been a helluva lot quieter. Honestly, I always forget how much his antics have become white noise to me. At least I don't have to worry about any of the food being set on fire by mistake or on purpose. What about you? Rare to see you without Glim."

"Bored. No offense to you. I didn't expect her to leave today so I wasn't prepared to not have her around, ya know?"

"I get it." Mermista squats down near her TV. She opens a drawer full of DVDs.

"Oh yeah, might as well ask. Have you guys learned anything about underwater plants that could be used in our favor?"

Mermista clicks her tongue against her teeth. "Not yet. Sorry. Sea Hawk and I aren't the best on plants or that magic potion stuff. We'll let you know if we find anything."

She pulls out several DVDs and spreads them across the coffee table. "Why don't we get our minds off of something for a couple hours. What do you want to watch?"

Adora takes a moment to select. She ends up tapping her finger on a movie she hasn't seen in a while. An animated movie about the lost city of Atlantis. As she puts it into the player, Mermista mentions that it is, in fact, real. She has never been there but it is a huge city, the biggest one of all for mermaids. She and Sea Hawk want to travel there one day in the future.

The movie begins to play. Mermista and Adora have fun poking fun at things or making quick quips. Mermista even explains a little more about the real deal. How it used to be half in the water half above, allowing for more than just mermaids to spend their time there. How the tragedy did happen but they were able to rebuild and thrive so many millennials later.

“Sounds interesting! I hope you guys get to go soon!” Adora says.

“One day. Whenever we decide to get married, we want to go there for our honeymoon.”

“Nice.”

The climax of the movie comes. Adora forgot how much she loves this movie. Though, as the ending starts, she finds her eyelids becoming heavy. As the credits begin to crawl upward on the screen, the blonde has to shake her head clean of the sleep. She stands to her feet, yawning and stretching out her body.

“I don’t know about you, but I am getting a little beat.” Adora says, another yawn escaping her.

“I can take you home. Just give me one second.” Mermista says. She quickly types away on her phone before standing up. The mermaid snatches the keys off the table. A smile grows across her face. “This was a lot of fun.”

“Definitely was able to keep away from the boredom. Besides taking a trip with everyone to the mall, we need to find another day to hang out with just the two of us.”

Upon getting home, Adora debates on what to do. With no idea when Glimmer will be getting home, does she really want to make food and have it be cold? She can always wait to make a full meal when her girlfriend gets home. Something nice for her after her long trip. Right now, she can quickly make a sandwich for herself. While not very filling, it definitely will hold her over.

Though, as quick as it was to make her small meal, it quickly ends. This results in her not knowing what the fuck to do with herself while waiting. Watching TV? Nothing really catches her eye. Play some video games? Not really in the mood…Adora mostly ends up finding things to do for a few minutes before switching to something else.

Eventually, Adora finds herself back in her former bedroom. There hasn’t been much use for it other than storing some of her things. Her old blanket remains neatly folded on the bed, waiting to be spread out again. Some of her clothes remain in the drawers, and she keeps extra shampoo, conditioner, and soap in the bathroom. With nothing else to do, Adora decides to clean off the thin layer of dust that has settled.

Thankfully, she does not have to do this for long. As she finishes up the mirror in the bathroom, she hears the front door opening. Adora’s heart leaps inside of her chest. She drops what she is doing and begins to race over to the door. However, before she

can even make it out of the spare bedroom, she is stopped in her tracks.

“Bow?” Adora comes to a halt. “What are you doing here?”

“I, uh,” he hesitates for a moment. “I was looking to see where you were.”

“Well, I am right here! Is Glimmer with you? Did she pick you up?”

“Yeah. Yeah she is with me. She should be coming into the house at any moment.”

Adora’s eyebrows raise. “What is going on? And why are you blocking me?”

“No reason! I can’t just stand here?” Bow answers. He looks over his shoulder momentarily before returning his gaze to his friend. “So how are you?”

“Fine…Would like to know what is going on.” The sound of the front door opening once more catches her attention. “Is that Glimmer?”

“Yeah…”

“Bow…are you gonna move or what?” Adora crosses her arms against her chest.

“I, uh,” Bow looks over his shoulder again. “In a-In a minute!”

Adora narrows her eyes. She can sense his nerves running wild. Whatever he is trying to hide, he is doing a poor job at. “What did you and Glimmer do? What are you trying to hide?”

“N-Nothing! Well, not really nothing but you really can’t rush out to see it. You need to be ready.”

“C’mon. What on earth is it that I can’t handle?” Before Bow can reply, Adora quickly ducks under his arms, snaking her way

through the crack between him and the doorframe. “I also want to see Glim.”

“Adora, wait!”

Bow reaches out and snatches Adora by the wrist. But it’s too late. The blonde gets out into the open area. She can see out into the living room. She can see Glimmer standing near the front door, a shocked look on her face. She can see a figure beside her. One that she has only seen once before, nights ago in a video about herself.

Every part of her body freezes. Adora’s heart, mind, and limbs all become rigid. Adam does not budge an inch the moment his eyes land on her. Even from this distance, she can see all the similarities, so much clearer than a photo on a computer screen. Her face nearly reflects back in his. While his irises are a darker shade of blue, they are the same shape. Hell, her brother is sharing the same open mouthed expression of shock on his face.

The grip around her wrist slowly loosens. Adora removes her eyes from Adam for a moment, looking back at her friend. Bow gives the smallest of nods. When his hands fully let go of the blonde, he takes a step back. He waits for her next move. Before Adora can think, her legs decide on what to do.

Her sights return to her brother as her feet slowly shirks the gap between them. Adam has the same idea. He walks forward inch by inch. Behind him, Glimmer remains still as a statue. Her own eyes are wide and hands are clasped in front of her face. Adora swallows a lump forming in her throat. Though, it does nothing to rid it.

Adora’s mind begins to race, darting around too fast to keep track of. Why is Adam here? Is this what Glimmer’s surprise is? How the hell did she get him to come here? What went down to bring him here? Did Bow know? Did Mermista know? Did they have this all planned? And for how long?

Is this real life or is she dreaming?

When she comes into arms reach, Adora gets the answer to the last question. Adam stands a couple inches taller than her. His freckles are much more noticeable this close, far clearer than her own. Behind his glasses, Adam's eyes shimmer with tears. As Adora stares into them, more memories come to the forefront of her mind. Playing pretend, sharing secrets, seeing who could run faster, and getting excited to go off to preschool together.

Nothing stops her from propelling herself right into Adam's arms. Her brother does not miss a beat, keeping himself steady as he holds her tight. As if he never, ever wants to let go of his sister. Adora feels the same way as she clutches onto Adam, burying her face into his shoulders. Being held like this, she feels a hole inside her heart—inside her *soul*— being filled. One she didn't know she really had nor she wanted completed.

"I can't believe you're real!" Adora finds herself sobbing. Trembles over take her body and she holds onto her brother for dear life. "I can't believe you're *here!"*

"Oh god, you have no idea how long I've waited for this!" Adam cries as he buries his own face into his sister. "I can't…I can't believe you're alive! I never stopped looking for you!"

"I'm s-sorry! I didn't…I didn't know you. I c-couldn't remember…" Adora finds herself unable to finish her sentence. Words come out as nothing more than blubbering. What a way to greet your long lost twin brother. Being a sniffling, incoherent mess. Though, Adam is no better at the moment.

Any words he attempts to make fail to come out. He sobs just as hard, his trembles uncontrollable. Adam's glasses dig into Adora's collar but she couldn't care less. The pinching against her skin informs her she is not about to wake up back in her bed without a brother to her name. That this is truly and undoubtedly *real.*

She flicks her eyes, still like lakes, upward. They land on Glimmer, who remains where she was before. Through the blur, Adora can see that she too has tears. There is a gentle smile on the hunter's lips. All Adora can manage is mouthing ` *thank you'.*

The reunited siblings continue to cry in each other's embrace. They don't stop until tears can no longer form and their lungs beg for proper intake of oxygen. Adam slowly pulls away. A hand reaches up, fingers brushing against her cheeks. Adora winces, instinctively backs up.

"Did I do something wrong?" Adam asks, pulling his hand back.

"No. I…just don't like my face being touched without warning. Long story. It's fine now that I know."

Adam gives a small nod. Slowly, he lifts his hand back up. Adora allows for him to touch her face. The skin that presses against her cheeks is a bit rough yet warm. She places her own hand against his, feeling it beneath her fingers.

"I still can't believe this is real. I can't believe I finally, *finally,* get to see you again! There is so much I want to tell you! And ask you!"

Adora chuckles a little. "Trust me, I feel the same way. I…" she chews on the bottom of her lip. "I don't remember you or mom and dad much. There is so much I want to know about…about what happened!"

"Well, I think I can answer that."

Glimmer suddenly steps forward, Bow finding his own way next to her. Adam releases his sister and turns his sight to the pair of friends. "Thank you so much for contacting me, Glimmer. I'll be honest, when you first messaged me I thought you were bullshitting me. I am glad that I listened to you."

"Glad to have helped." Glimmer replies. "Anything for Adora."

“Okay, you have to tell me what the hell you did and when, Glim.” Adora says. “This is was your ‘hunter errands’?”

“Yes it was and I will tell you later.”

“How about we get some food before we talk.” Bow suggests. “No need to talk about an empty stomach.”

Adora nods, agreeing with the idea.

Chapter End Notes

comment/kudos appreciated

Straight Out of A Fairytale Part I: Bitten

Chapter Notes

> Last chapter of this batch yeah! So i will be on a 3 week break and return April 17th with 4 chapters. I have a reason for actual numbers this time, kudos to anyone who can guess why I have have dates this time.
>
> Sorry to cut this one off like I did but this was supposed to be all in one chapter but it didnt work which btw. Since Adam will be telling the others about what happened, these next two chapters are in HIS POV. Sudden but needed shift
>
> anyway big tw for blood/injury with a child + adora's first shift as a young child. idk what to tag that as other than...yeah its rough for small adora so be warned these chaps were hard at time even for me. but i still hope you enjoy and I will see you in 3 weeks with ch 23!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Do you need anything else?" Glimmer asks.

Adam grabs the tea, taking several small sips. "No, this is perfect."

Adora's leg bounces as she mentally prepares herself for her brother's story. The sword in her mouth is doing little to help ease her nerves. "I hope you don't mind telling me what happened first. I've waited, well, almost my whole life to know."

"I don't mind at all. You should know what…what happened when and after you got bit…"

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21 Years Ago

A fresh coat of snow has blanketed the town of Eternia. Heck, for miles and miles it goes, covering half the state in nothing but white. The sky remains a light grey color, struggling to become bright blue as tiny flakes continue to fall. Though, by afternoon the world shall be cast in the light of the sun. For now, the snow remains untouched. Not even deer have broken the sheet. It will only be a matter of time until children burst out of their homes and gleefully romp through the frozen water.

On any other day, Adam would be sleeping in. The warmth of his blankets coaxes him to remain inside. To not let the coldness of the world destroy it all. Though, falling asleep last night he was well aware that morning would bring a winter wonderland. This easily would be enough to pull him free. But there is something else that easily pulls him out of bed.

" *Aaaadddaaaammmm!"* Adora's voice rings in his ears. In the next moment, his twin sister jumps onto his bed. The jolt causes his eyes to snap open. He twists head, finding Adora hovering over him. Her eyes are bright and wide and she smiles from ear to ear.

"Wake up, sleepy head!" She continues to shout. Adora begins to shake Adam. "It's our birthday! We are five! It snowed!"

Adam sits up straight, so fast he nearly knocks over his sister. "How much snow did we get?"

"A lot! Maybe, like, fifty feet!" Adora begins to tug on Adam's shirt. "C'mon! C'mon! Look outside!"

Adam scrambles out of his bed. His foot gets caught in his orange blanket and he nearly collides with the carpeted flooring. He manages to catch himself at the last moment, bracing himself with his arms. While he attempts to straighten himself out, Adora frees her brother's foot. The moment he is free, the young boy races over to the window.

Sure enough, his sister is correct! There is snow as far as the eye can see. More than enough to make snowmen and snow angels for a week. Maybe he and Adora can convince their parents to take them sledding. Every time his breath fogs up the cold window too much, Adam uses his sleeve so he can continue to stare out at the new, white world. He cannot pry his eyes away. Adam feels excitement overflowing within. Unable to be contained in his small body, he begins to bounce up and down.

"Let's go see it more!" Adora suggests.

Adam does not need much convincing. The twins speed out of their room and begin to race down the hall. Neither care that their feet stomp hard on the ground or that their laughter might be heard outside. They scramble down the stairs, nearly toppling over each other. Nothing can stop brother and sister from seeking out adventure. At least, *almost* nothing. Adora, who has taken the lead, begins to open the back door. Her uncovered foot is about to break through the untouched snow when hands grab the collar of each child's shirt.

"Woah, you two!" Marlena's voice says. "You are *not* dressed for this."

"But Mommy!" The twins say together. Adam looks up at his mother. Like his sister, the sun is her friend. Her reddish brown hair has already been brushed and tied into her usual braid. Her dark blue eyes are bright, a hint of her own mischief in them as they look over her glasses.

"We wanna play!" Adora whines.

"Not in your pajamas you aren't, young lady." Marlena lets go of her son, using her free hand to shut the door. She does not let go of her daughter. "And not without breakfast."

Adam's mouth begins to water. His mother's cooking is the best in the world. Besides him, his sister begins to lick her lips in agreement. Knowing that her daughter will not be running off

now, Marlena releases her grip on Adora. She smiles a crooked smile before saying, “Why don’t you two get dressed. Think you can do that?”

Adam and Adora nod. Back up the stairs they race, making as much noise as before. They burst into their shared bedroom. Everything is a game to the siblings. Getting dressed becomes a race to see who can get out of their pajamas first. Adam digs through his drawer, wondering what he should put on. He’s a big kid after all now. After some debate, he decides to put on his sweater with a spaceship on it.

Though, somehow, he finds himself getting tangled within. One arm gets in but the other struggles to slip through its sleeve. He even has a bit of trouble popping his head out of the opening. So much in fact, he ends up tripping over himself and landing on his butt.

“Ow!”

“Are you okay?” Adora asks.

“I’m stuck…”

“Let your big sister help!”

He hears Adora walking over towards him. She helps get his stuck arm free and pulls down on the sweater. The first thing the young boy sees is his sister already dressed, having beaten him. Adam huffs a little, blowing some hair from his eyes, before standing to his feet. “You are only five minutes older than me!”

“Yeah! Five minutes! And I'm taller than you!” she makes a point by standing right by him, hovering her hand *just* above his.

Adam narrows his eyes before attempting to lunge at Adora. His sister laughs at the top of her lungs as she darts away, running out the door. This does not deter him at all. Adam quickly gives chase, catching up to his sister as she runs down the hallway. Though, their little game is cut short when their father steps out

of his bedroom. This causes Adora to run headlong into his legs. Now it is her turn to land on her butt.

"Watch where you are going, baby girl!" Randor says. He carefully places his hands under his daughter's armpits and carefully helps her to her feet. "Though, what did you mother and I say to you two about running in the house?"

"Sorry, Papa." both say.

Randor reaches out and places a hand on each of his children's hands. "Well, I think I can let it slide. After all, today is a special day! And I can smell your mother's cooking. How about we go downstairs?"

They head back down, keeping their pace to a walk. As they enter the living room, the smell of apple cinnamon pancakes fills the air. Adam spots his mother stirring the batter. His heart begins to race in his chest, dying to enjoy his birthday breakfast meal. He wonders if anyone can hear his stomach growling. Though, there is something the young boy has to do before eating.

It is his turn to feed their cat Cringer. The large, furry maine coon lies sprawled out on the counter, right above the door to his cat food. Big, bright, golden eyes watch every step Adam takes. When he begins to carry the cup of kibble towards the food bowl, Cringer hopes off the counter and follows right on his heels. The maine coon purrs loudly, rubbing up against his legs as the food is poured in.

"There you go, Cringer!" Adam beams. "Enjoy!"

Cringer chirps before chowing down on. Of course, he makes noises as he eats. With that taken care of, Adam walks back to his mother. She has begun to pour the batter onto the sizzling frying pan. Upon noticing not only her son by her side but her daughter as well, Marlena places the bowl down and grabs two small metal spoons. In a quick motion, she dips them in the batter before handing them to her children.

“Have a little birthday treat.” she grins.

Adora and Adam happily snatch the treat from their mother’s hand. As they lick the spoon, their father walks up to his wife. They embrace. Arms wrapped around each other and lips locking together. Of course, the twins make a face at their parents, tongues sticking out and noses scrunched up in disgust. Their parents ignore them.

Marlena brushes back some of her husband’s dark blond hair. “Did you just wake up, honey?”

“What can I say? I like sleeping in, Ladybug!”

"Well, better get dressed soon. After we eat, we have a full day planned!" She looks at her children. "You guys want to go sledding to start off your birthdays?"

The twins nod. Today has gone from great to amazing! Apple cinnamon pancakes and now sledding? Adam can barely sit still as he eats his breakfast. His chair rocks back and forth. Marlena, on at least two occasions, places her hand on the back to stop him from falling over. Adora nearly knocks over herself in her own excitement.

Adam should enjoy his breakfast. His parents are always telling him to slow down when eating. Yet, if he and his sister got done faster then the sooner they will be outside and racing down the hills. And besides, who said you can’t enjoy your food by wolfing it down? The moment plates are clean, Adam and Adora place them in the sink. Cleaning can and will be dealt with later.

Thankfully, Randor does not need much time to get dressed and ready. As winter boots and jackets are put on, he joins his family by the front door. Glasses no longer hide his sky blue eyes. He helps his wife finish preparing his children for the world outside. Hats and gloves cover ears and hands. The moment everyone is shielded against the frigid temperatures, everyone heads outside.

The twins immediately jump into the snow. It goes past Adam's shins, making walking quite difficult. He ends up tripping over himself at least once, landing face first into the frozen water. Adam ends up laughing at the top of his lungs even as the melting snow stings his face. Nearby, his sister romps around, laughing just as much as he is. As Adam finds his footing once more, he locates his parents. Marlena and Randor toss a couple snowballs at each other (both getting in a hit) before signaling to their children to get in the car.

Their birthday goes on. The family head towards the largest hill in all of Eternia. Many others have the same idea. This gets Adam and Adora even *more* eager. Not only can they race each other and their parents, but the other children as well. Much of the time spent there is zipping down the slopes and hiking back up. At one point, when the family of four does not want to head back towards the top, they make a snowman. Their creation stands among many others, all of different shapes, sizes, and number of balls. With no coal or carrots, some rocks are managed to be dug up and used for eyes. Any extra twigs that are found are used as well.

A little bit after finishing their snowman, it is time to leave. Onto the next adventure of the day. Lunch. Adam and Adora get to both choose where to eat and what to eat. Their parents surprise the twins with some of the staff coming over to sing 'Happy Birthday' and giving them a slice of cake each. Adora gets chocolate and Adam vanilla.

After lunch, they return home. Clothes that remain damp from the snow are stripped and changed into something warmer and drier. For the rest of the day, the family remains inside. Games are played, both board and video, and a movie is chosen out of their tape collection. As the night comes dinner is eaten and presents are handed out. As the bright, shining, full moon rises high in the dark night sky, everyone begins to settle down.

Well…almost everyone that is.

While Adam sits on the couch, waiting for his Papa to come, Adora is by the backdoor nearby. The last time he checked, his sister was pressed up against the glass. Adam is known to be the one to love space the most. He will learn everything and anything he can about the worlds far beyond Earth. However, Adora has a bit of her own fascination with the stars. At the very least, she enjoys looking up at them.

Already dressed, his sister waits to spend some more time outside. But she must wait for her mother to finish getting ready. Though, she has already waited long enough.

“Hurry up, Mommy!” Adam hears Adora shout. He pulls his upper half up against the back of the couch. His sister impatiently waits to go outside. Cringer circles her legs, purring loudly.

“I will be there in one moment, ‘Dora! Please hold on, dear!”

Adora whines. Unable to stand still, she reaches her hands up and opens the back door. Cold air blasts through the living room, sending a shiver down Adam’s spine. His sister stares out into the yard. From his position on the couch, Adam can make out some of the dark night sky littered with shining stars. The woods behind his home stare back at him. Even with the full moon shining brightly, the trees are stained black. Barren branches twist and turn into eerie faces.

In a split second, everything changes.

Cringer suddenly *bolts* outside. Adora and Adam gasp as they watch their beloved pet disappear into the dark world. However, the older twin takes action. Shouting his name, Adora runs outside after Cringer, disappearing as well.

" *Adora!"* Adam yells. His voice comes out harsh. Never before has he heard himself sound like this. He can't believe that it is his own voice.

It catches his father's attention. Randor appears almost out of thin air in the living room. A panicked expression is written all over his

face as he snaps his head around. "What happened?!?! Where is Adora?!?!"

Adam quickly points outside. " Cringer ran outside and Adora ran after him!"

“Shit!” he hears his mother hiss as she races through the house. “Randy! Stay with Adam!”

Dressed for the winter weather outside, Marlena disappears into the dark, cold world. Adam watches his mother go into the night like her sister and pet. He feels his body begin to shake and not like when he gets a sudden spook. This goes right into his *core.* It suddenly becomes hard to breathe, as if he has chewed up his own throat like a straw. Any attempt to move his body, even an inch, fails. He has become a quaking statue. Never before has he felt something like this. He hates the taste that enters his mouth.

“Adam? Son? Are you okay?” Randor lowers himself in front of the couch to become eye level with his child. A hand is placed on Adam’s shoulder.

“Is-Is Mommy and Adora and Cringer going to be okay?” Adam whispers. “Is Mommy gonna bring them back?”

“She will. Don’t you worry, alright?”

Adam can only mumble into the couch. His mind has begun to race, like one of his toy cars. But unlike them, he cannot grab his thoughts and stop them. Is his sister going to be okay? What about Cringer? Is he going to become lost in the woods? And his mommy! What is going to happen to her? Why is this happening? Especially on his birthday!

Randor shuts the door, sealing off any more warmth from escaping, and walks around the couch, settling down right beside his young son. Strong arms wrap around Adam’s body and he is pulled into his father’s chest. Hands grip his shirt. Even with the hug, Adam cannot stop shaking. Randor rubs small circles against his back, rocking gently back and forth.

Adam does everything in his power not to cry. He doesn't want to think that his sister, mother, and pet will be hurt or worse. No. Once they are all back he can cry. Cry that they are back and tell Adora how much she scared him. When everyone is back, he can forget that this whole night has happened.

He doesn't know how long time passes before there is scraping on glass. Could be seconds, minutes, or hours for all he knows. Adam then hears a muffled meow, exactly like the one Cringer makes when he wants in the twin's room. Father and son look at each before scrambling off the couch. Sure enough, Cringer is pawing at the back door, yelling at the top of his lungs.

Randor slides the door open. The feline blots in, rubbing against his family members' legs. He purrs louder than ever before. Paws are covered in melting snow and his back as tiny snowballs on the tips of his fur. Eyes stare up at the older Glenn before standing up on his hinds legs. Randor scoops up the feline.

"Where the hell did you run off too?" he asks. The only reply he gets is a soft mew.

"Where's Mommy and Adora? Are they okay!" Adam tugs on his father's pant leg. "Why aren't they back yet!"

"I don't know." Randor lets Cringer go and shuts the back door. Biting his thumb, he keeps his eyes out on the dark woods. Adam looks through the glass as well. Only the trees stare back at him. They refuse to reveal the answers he so desperately wants.

"Why don't we go out and find them!" Adora whines. "We can help Mommy find Adora!"

"No. We can't. We might get lost in the woods and then Mommy will have to find us. It's too dark out. We don't want that to happen, do we? They'll be fine. Don't worry."

Adam doesn't know what to do. Sitting down won't work with all the negative energy running through him. He tries to pace around but it does little to help him. Cringer walks up to him and

attempts to comfort him. He purrs and gives headbutts at his legs. Adam tries to calm himself with pets but like everything else, it does not help. All he wants is his mother and sister to be back.

They wait and wait. Adam has no idea how long he stands with his father, waiting to see the rest of his family break through the treeline and return home. Cringer continues his attempts at comfort, going as far as getting his favorite stuffed mouse and plopping it down at the young boy's feet. The faintest of smiles forms Adam's face at the gesture.

After what seems like hours, Randor shouts. Adam snaps his head up and races over to the back door. In the dark, he can see a figure coming out of the woods at full speed. He squints his eyes, hoping to give details to who it is. Though, he quickly realizes that it is his mother.

The fear inside of him begins to disappear, replaced by *joy!* Everything is going to be alright now! His father slides open the door, ready to embrace his wife and daughter. Adam can see his face lighting up and relief washing over him. Though, things suddenly change in the blink of an eye.

Randor quickly kneels down, arms wrapping tight around Adam. His face is shoved into his father's shoulder, vision becomes nothing more than blackness. Adam begins to struggle against the grasp, wishing to know what on earth is going on. His mother and sister are back! Why can't he see them? Why has his father done this?

"Randy, I am taking Adora to the hospital. Do you think you can keep Adam here?" Marlena says out of breath upon reentering the house. She is out of breath.

"Yeah, I can. Call me when they take Adora."

Adam struggles even more. He presses and pushes against his father's tight embrace. Randor's heart drums so hard and so fast, Adam can hear it in his own ears. Even his breathing has

changed, becoming ragged and harsh. And…Randor *shakes.* Adam cannot recall ever seeing his father like this before. He feels his own heart begin to race.

Finally, somehow, Adam pulls his head free. He gasps for air, sucking in as much oxygen as he can into his lungs. For a moment, the world is still. The family, mother, father, son, daughter, and pet are together. For a moment, Adam believes nothing is wrong. His brain forgets about the word hospital for a fraction of a second. However, everything changes when his eyes land on his sister.

Adora is cradled in their mother's arms. Her face is pale, eyes squeezed tight, and sweat forms on her brow. The right side of her jacket, at her shoulder, is torn. He can see skin. He can see *blood.* Dark, crimson, and free flowing. Marlena's sleeves are stained in her daughter's blood. Despite her attempts to keep her emotions in check, her dark eyes are full of fear. His mother is barely able to hold back tears.

Randor's arms quickly embrace Adam once more. This time, he doesn't attempt any further protest. He feels his own body begin to tremble again. A ring begins to fill his ears and he feels his stomach twisting inside of him. It's like he is about to throw up his dinner. Something burns at the back of his throat.

The front door opens and closes. Father and son do not budge from where they are. Adam buries his face into his father's chest. Tears have begun to run down his cheeks. "Papa? Is Adora gonna be alright?"

"Yeah, she will."

"She's really hurt, though! That…That was a lotta blood…What happened?!?"

"I don't know yet. But she will be okay! Your sister is a tough cookie. You know how Adora is."

His father is right. There was a time where they were at their cousins' house and they were jumping from the top bunk onto the bottom. Everything was going perfectly fine. Laughter was in the air and the band of cousins were having the time of their lives. However, when Adora jumped again, she bounced a little too hard. She landed hard on the ground, breaking her arm. Despite the injury, his sister tried to play it off until the adults came in after hearing the crash.

Adam grips the fabric of his father's shirt tight. "It looked bad…"

"The doctors are going to patch her up and she will be home before you know it!" Randor reassures. He lets go of his son, pushing him away so they are face to face. Fingers brush away tears from Adam's face. "When she comes home, though, she is going to need help. She might not be able to move her arm much. Think you can be a good brother and help her?"

"Of course! I'll do anything to help her!"

Randor softly smiles. He places a hand on Adam's head and gives a small rub. "That's my boy."

"Papa?"

"Yeah?"

"Can I sleep with you tonight?"

Adam begins to rub his eyes. Suddenly, his body feels heavy and all he can think of is curling up into bed. He wants to be with Adora. Whenever either twin has a nightmare, the other always claws into their bed to help keep them away. He doesn't have that now. At least he has his papa.

"Of course, kiddo."

Any plans they had for the rest of the night have been put on hold. Randor gently picks up his son. Adam's arms wrap around his father's neck as he rests his head in the crook. Nothing is said

as he is carried up the stairs. Heck, the whole world has become still. Adam can't hear any wind, creaking of boards, or rattling of pipes. Even Cringer is silent, the bell on his collar barely making a ring.

Adam is let go for a moment upon reaching his bedroom. Randor sets his son down as he opens the drawers to get pajamas. The young boy waits by his father's legs, staring at the bed across from his. Sheets are unmade and one of the pillows rests on the ground. There shall be no one lying sound asleep in there. He hopes that this will not remain as such for long. Or forever.

Once dressed for the night, Adam is back in his father's arms. Upon getting in the master bedroom, he is placed into bed. Randor tucks his son before lying down on top of the covers. A hand begins to brush against his cheek.

"How are you holding up, kiddo?" Randor asks.

"I don't know," Adam admits. "Scared."

"Everything is going to be okay. I promise."

"Will Mommy and Adora come home tomorrow?""

"I don't know. I hope so but Adora might have to stay in the hospital for a bit. We can go see her once we are allowed to. Would you like that?"

Adam nods. He would like that. Maybe he can bring one of his sister's stuffed animals to her. The question is, which one should he bring? Tomorrow morning, if Adora still is in the hospital, he can decide then. For now, he nestles himself against his father. Randor wraps his arms around his son, placing a kiss on top of his head.

"Try to sleep. Everything will be better in the morning."

Adam tries to listen. He shuts his eyes, hoping to speed up the morning. However, it becomes a struggle. A couple attempts, he

slips into nothingness. No dreams, not even bad ones. But they never last long. Every time he wakes,he looks up. Each time, Randor has his eyes open. At one point, he pleads for his father to sleep as well. However, he is met with a 'I'll be fine. You sleep'.

Eventually, somehow, he does fully enter a realm of a heavy, black void.

Adam rocks on his heels, arms swinging at his side. He hopes that his sister cannot see him from this angle. Adora rests on the couch, her blanket covering her body. A fresh towel lies on her forehead, having been placed there only a minute before. Even from this position, he can see Adora is pale. Not as much as the night before when in their mother's arms, but he still doesn't like how he looks. He doesn't like that his sister is stuck on the couch, unable to play with him. *Nothing* has ever stopped her before.

He can't remember either of them ever having a fever before. They have had colds but never, ever any fevers.

A board creaks loudly under his foot. It gives him a good scare, causing the young boy to jump. For a moment, Adam hopes Adora didn't hear any of that. With his papa at work and his mommy in her study for her own work, he is the only other person in the room (he's supposed to be in *his* room to let his sister rest). However, this is not the case.

Adora twists her head. Sky blue eyes blink. "Adam?"

"Hi…" he does not move.

"Why are ya standing there? I won't bite. I just have a fever."

He rocks again, thinking about what to do. Adora isn't asleep right now and she wants him over there. So, it's not like he is bothering his sister. He gives a small nod before wandering over towards her. Adora attempts to sit up, using her one good arm, but barely makes it up the pillow. Only her shoulders now show. Thankfully, her t-shirt hids most of the bandages.

“How are you feeling?” he asks.

“Hot. I don’t like it…” Adora mumbles.

“Does your shoulder hurt?”

“A little. Papa gave me some yucky medicine. He said it would help my fever and so it wouldn’t hurt as much.”

“What happened?!? Mommy and Papa told me it was a dog?”

Adora catches him off guard. She suddenly looks sad and scared. Like the time a big kid scared them during Halloween. He had a toy knife in his hands but the twins thought it was real and ran all the way to their parents. That was the only time he ever saw his sister so frightened, until now.

“I-I-I think so. I couldn’t tell. It was…big! And scary! Mommy saved me.”

Adam climbs up on the couch. “Imma happy you are okay! I didn’t know what was happening. You scared me when you ran off like that.”

“I’m sorry. Cringer scared me when he ran out.”

Adam throws his hands in the air and puffs out his chest. “So it’s all Cringer’s fault! He was a bad kitty. No catnip for him!”

He begins to giggle, knowing his pet will be upset not to have it. A smile breaks across his sister's face and she joins in on the laughter. Every time they attempt to stop their fit, eyes meet and it begins all over again. Adam finds himself unable to breathe, tears pricking at the edges of his eyes, as he continues to laugh.

They get the attention of their mother. Marlena steps into the living room, her glasses on top of her head. “Adam, I thought I told you to let your sister rest. And Adora, you should be resting!”

“I wanted to check up on her!” Adam objects.

“Adam made me feel better! I want him to stay!” Adora replies.

Marlena can only sigh. “Alright, but you two have to be quiet.” A finger rests on her lips. “Mommy has to take a call. Think you two can be quiet for me. Do you want to watch some TV?”

The twins nod in unison. Marlena turns on their favorite show, one about a mystery solving teenage gang and their talking dog. Once her children are set, she tells them if they need anything, the study’s door is open. When she disappears, Adam looks back at his sister. He sticks out his pinky finger.

There are no words needed to know what he wants. Their promise to always be together through thick and thin. A way to show they have the other to lean on no matter what is going on. Adora does not hesitate at all. She wraps her own pinky finger around his and locks them together. So tight the grip, nothing can tear them apart.

Slowly, things begin to return to normal. Adora remains in a sling for a little while, which annoys her. Unable to play or run around. Even if all the kids at their preschool they go to every couple days fawn over her, the older twin grumbles from lack of activities. Most of the time she has to sit on the side and play less strenuous things. At least, however, Adam is always by her side playing whatever she wants. Cars, dolls, whatever Adora wants.

Thankfully, she heals fast. Faster than what the doctors expected. While she is given the clear, Randor and Marlena still keep their daughter from several activities for a couple more days. This annoys the elder twin, but soon, she is free to go back to playing with her brother and friends. Adora enjoys showing the scar she now dawns on her shoulder and telling the other children how her mother saved her. When they ask if she was scared about what happened to her, Adora always replies with a ‘no’.

Adam knows that is a lie.

Many nights after the attack, Adam wakes up to the sounds of his sister crying. At first, Adora heads parents' room and sleeps with them for protection from her nightmares. Two or three times Adam (still reeling from his sister's injury) follows. Adora tells them about her dreams, how she keeps seeing a dog with bright green eyes chasing her. Randor and Marlena reassure her she is safe now and nothing will ever hurt her again. Even Adam repeats the same thing.

Eventually, she stops going to them. Adora doesn't want to keep bothering her parents. They have work and being woken up night after night does no one any good. However, she continues to wake up sniveling over that fateful night. She attempts to hide her tears by burying her face in her pillow. Adam's heart drops at the sounds.

"Adora." he whispers on one such night.

No answer.

"Adora!" he says louder.

This time he hears his sister shuffling in her bed. He can see her sitting up, wiping off her face with her arm. She sniffs before saying, "I'm sorry for waking you."

"It's okay! Did you have a nightmare again?"

"M-Maybe."

"Don't want to see Mommy and Papa again?"

"No."

"Do you wanna sleep with me? I can help keep your nightmares away!"

"You don't have to do that."

"I'm your brother! I *want* to!"

Adora debates over it for a moment before finally crawling out of bed. She quickly scurries over and climbs into her brother's bed. Adam scoots over, letting her get comfortable. She lies on her side, curled up into a small ball. The younger twin's heart twists inside his chest. He taps a finger on his chin, thinking of what he can do at this very moment. Then it comes to him. Placing a palm over his mouth, he blows straight into it. The noise made completely takes Adora off guard.

His sister blinks, looking up at Adam with wide eyes. A large smile breaks across his face as he does it again, louder. This time, giggles begin to escape him. It quickly infects Adora, who joins in on the laughter. The more he makes the noise, no matter how loud or soft, the more she laughs. Soon, tears prick at the edges of her eyes and she is begging Adam to stop.

"Are you feeling better?" Adam asks, lying down beside her.

"I am. Thank you."

"Of course!"

More time passes. Adora's nightmares lessen. By the time a month passes, the attack is almost totally forgotten about. Snow has long since turned from a white, soft, substance, into a hard, slippery sheet of ice. With spring right around the corner, the green grass and pastel flowers will make a comeback. The twins eagerly await the return of more freedom to run about outside. As life marches on outside, it does as well inside.

Work and preschool. Playing with friends and spending time with family. With Adora's injuries fully healed, the events of the past can be forgotten about. Become a bad memory that can be turned into a story for the future. Life can *continue.*

…

As night falls, stars appearing one by one in the darkening sky, Adora begins to complain of feeling sick. After playing outside in

the cold, under watchful eyes, Marlena and Randor assume it was from that. Improper dressing or too long outside. She is given some soup and crackers for dinner and begins to feel better. Though, as the world slips further into darkness, Adora finds herself feeling ill again. The best course of action is bed rest early.

Adam decides to stay with Adora in their room. Lights are off but the full moon outside helps him see in the darkness. Sitting on his bed, he watches his sister under her covers struggling to sleep. She tosses and turns, groans and whines. No matter how hard she tries to sleep or find a comfortable position on her bed, nothing is working.

"Are you okay, Adora?" Adam asks, at a loss on what to do. How can he ease his sister's suffering?

Adora shivers, teeth clacking together as if she is out in the freezing weather. Sweat forms on her brow, some rolling down the side of her face. As she gasps for air, all Adora can manage to do is give a small of her head. "I…I feel like I'm going to throw up…"

"Do you want me to get Mommy and Papa?"

"I don't wanna worry them."

"But Adora!"

Adora begins shakily pushing herself up on her bed. She groans, nearly falling back down onto her bed. She opens her mouth, attempting to form words. Adam notices in the moonlight, her canines almost looking like Cringer's teeth. But whatever his sister wants to say, it never comes out. Instead, as stated before, she throws up her dinner. Adam is about to run out of the room and get his parents when a shout freezes him in place.

His sister lets out a cry he has never heard before. One of sheer *agony.* Adam swears he hears a bone breaking. Hands slap over his ears. Adora jerks, toppling off of the bed. Her blanket comes with her. By the sound of the *thud,* it is a hard impact onto the

floor. The sound causes him to jump onto his feet, his own mattress squeaking under his weight.

Adora’s body is hidden by the blankets. He can see her moving around, occasionally hitting the legs of her bed. More sounds of breaking bones. More hearing his sister cry out in pain. Though, they begin to sound different. Like an animal on the TV shows. Adam debates on what to do. How can he help his sister like this? What the hell is even going on!

The noise and jerking stop. Silence fills the air. Adam has no idea what has happened to his sister or why she is no longer moving. He feels like his heart is about to explode out of his chest and run away. But his legs refuse to move. They are made of stone. He swallows a dry lump in his throat. Hands drop down from his head.

“A-Adora?”

No answer. Somehow, he forces himself to pull himself off his bed. He repeats his sister's name, feeling his own hands shaking. This time, he got an answer. Adora begins to move under the blankets. Adam is about to sigh a breath of relief when something pops out from the side of the blanket. Not a hand. At least, not one he is accustomed to.

It’s like someone has smashed a paw and a hand together. Nails are dark and long and dark, golden fur covers it. Slowly, whatever lies under the blanket reveals themself. No longer is his sister there. Rather, a wolf! One only a little bigger than himself. Torn clothes cling to their body as legs shake against their weight. They paint, revealing bright, white, sharp teeth. They turn their head and eyes lock with Adam. Instead of blue like his father, a yellow shade stares back. He swears there's a hint of red mixed in.

"A-Adora? Is-Is that you?"

He struggles to comprehend what is going on. His parents love to tell him and his sister stories of the supernatural. Of creatures many believe to be fake. Vampires, ghosts, faeries, unicorns, and…werewolves. Those that change by the will of the full moon. Adam flicks his eyes towards the window. Amongst the star, sure enough, is the round moon. Are the bedtime stories he is told at night true?

A hand reaches out. The wolf begins to sniff his fingers. Adam inches even closer, about to rub the creature just like he does with Cringer. However, the wolf suddenly jerks back. The hair on their back stands at attention and lips are pulled back as far, teeth are bare. Their tail is tucked between its legs. Ears are pinned back against their head and eyes dart around.

"Adora! It's me! Adam!"

Upon saying his name, the wolf's ear's stand back up and their hairs lower. Adam takes another step closer. He can feel the hot breath of the wolf against his fingers. He is almost able to touch their fur, wondering what it will feel like. However, just as he is about to find that out, the wolf snarls. It backs up as far as possible, pressing up hard against the side of the bed.

Not thinking, Adam steps closer, repeating his sister's name. The only answer he has for where his sister went stands right in front of him. Where else could she have gone? However, as he closes the gap again, the wolf opens their mouth.

Time freezes. Adam sees the needle like teeth of the wolf coming closer and closer. They are about to snap down around his hand and pierce through his skin. His eyes widen in shock and his body freezes in fear. Just as he is about to be bitten, something lifts him off the ground. The wolf lunges through air before smashing into the bed across from them.

"What the hell was all that noise?!?" Randor shouts. He steps between the wolf and his wife, who cradles Adam in her arms. "Why is there a wolf in your room?!?"

“Mommy! Papa!” Adam exclaims.

“Where is Adora?!?” Marlena asks.

The wolf shakes their head, stumbling back and landing on their rear end. Eyes blink and stare up at the family. Randor keeps his body where it is, refusing to back down. The wolf whines through their nose, lowering themself as they crawl over towards the trio. Randor tenses up, grabbing the closest thing to him. Adam’s tee-ball bat.

“Stay back!” he growls.

“No! Papa! That’s Adora!”

“What?!?” both parents say together.

Marlena turns to her son, brushing away some of his hair from his face. “You must be mistaken, baby. That’s a wolf. Not Adora.”

“No!” Adam protests. “It’s Adora! She wasn’t feeling well and she fell from her bed! And then the wolf appeared! It’s Adora! Call her! It’s her!”

Marlena and Randor exchange looks. His father does not let go of the small bat in his hands. Instead, he looks back at the wolf. They have backed up against Adora’s bed, whining. They have lowered their whole body to the ground and their tail stays close to their side. Randor clears his throat before speaking.

“Adora? Baby girl, is that you?”

Ears flick and their head lifts up slightly. Randor takes several steps closer but like his son before him, the wolf growls when he gets too close. Unlike Adam, he moves back, giving a wide breathing room between them. Randor then squats down, keeping a hand near his mouth.

“See, Papa! It’s Adora!”

Randor says nothing at all. His eyes stay fixated on the wolf. On *Adora.* Adora herself remains still, occasionally whining through her nose. Her own golden eyes—something so odd to see on her—flick around, never staying on anything for too long. Her body trembles as if she is in the middle of a strong earthquake.

"This can't be real. I-I thought they were only in stories," Marlena states.

"Ladybug?" Randor asks.

"If that's Adora…" She looks towards the window, starting at the full moon. Adam watches as her dark blue eyes widen and a darkness grows on her face. "That attack…It happened on a full moon also…It just can't be! She can't be a…a…"

"A werewolf?" Adam finishes. "Is Adora gonna be okay?"

His parents exchange looks, ones full of concern. Adam begins to squirm in Marlena's arms, wishing to be by his sister. Adora continues to shake and whine. Nails have begun to dig into the carpeting, tearing the fibers. Every part of his being screams at him to go towards Adora. But his mother's grasp tightens around him.

"We have to wait until morning. Keep an eye on her until then. I don't know if there is anything else we can do." Marlena finally says.

So they wait. And wait. Wait for the sun to break across the horizon. Adora continues to growl whenever someone gets too close to her. No one is allowed to touch her, only stay a couple feet away. While keeping an eye on Adora, waiting to see if she does anything or move an inch, Randor and Marlena attempt to put Adam to bed. He refuses, however. He cannot sleep—no, he *refuses* to sleep until he knows his sister is okay.

As the night drags on, Marlena and Randor switch off on who watches who. Sometimes, Adam stays in the room or just outside looking in, wishing to know what is happening to his sister.

Sometimes, he is in the living room. In hopes to distract their son, his parents put several different tapes of his shows in the VCR. Adam tries to watch them, tries to not bother his parents as much, but most of the time his mind finds itself back in his room.

Eventually, *finally,* the sun begins to creep out from its hiding place. Adam peers into his bedroom, seeing his sister's whines growing. Randor finally is able to kneel right beside his daughter, petting her head. Marlena stands in the doorframe, preventing Adam from getting any closer. Both his parents' faces are heavy. Lights in their eyes have dimmed and dark bags rest under them. Adam wishes to tuck them into their own bed, just like they do when he can no longer move.

As more of the stars are pushed out and oranges and light blues take over, something happens to Adora. Her whines grow as her body begins to twitch violently. Adam only is able to see her fingers beginning to grow and nails shrink before his father shouts.

"Ladybug!"

"Right!"

Marlena scoops up her son before walking out into the hallway. The moment he is set down on the ground, his mother's hands cover his ears. Adam mimics his mother, placing his own tiny hands on her ears. A small smile forms on her face and she mouths a 'thank you' to her son.

Soon, Adam sees over his mother's shoulder Randor coming out. He removes his hands from Marlena's ears and points. His mother stands and steps slightly off to the side. This allows the young boy to see his father in full detail. His shoulders are pushed down by an invisible, heavy weight. Eyes remain dark, the lights have yet to return. In his arms, is Adora. Her golden blanket is wrapped around her body as she clings to her father's neck. She is unconscious.

Marlena immediately is beside her husband. Eyes are wide and a shaking hand hovers over her daughter's face. She brushes some dark blonde locks behind her ear. Adora mumbles something but remains asleep. Marlena's hand then finds itself on her daughter's shoulder, right where her bite scar is. Her thumb brushes against exposed skin.

Adam's parents exchange looks, saying nothing at all. Frowns form on their faces and eyebrows furrow. The young boy joins his mother and father, looking up and keeping his eyes on his sleeping sister. His first thought is what eye color her eyes are.

Adam doesn't know how long he sleeps for. His mind races so fast around in his brain, he ends up tossing and turning in his bed. He thinks he is able to fall unconscious for a little bit but it does not last for long. When he wakes up, the first thing he sees is Adora lying on her own bed, still asleep. A million questions are trapped inside his brain, dying to get out. One of them is how long his sister will remain still.

Not wishing to lie around and do nothing, Adam crawls out of his bed and heads downstairs. He is careful not to cause any creaking of stairs in case his parents are still asleep. Slowly but surely, he makes it all the way down and begins to head towards the living room and kitchen. Much to his surprise, he sees his mother. She sits at the dining table, head in her hands. He would have thought after not sleeping a peep, she would be in her bedroom alongside Randor.

Stepping up to her, Adam gives a small tug of her pants before simply saying, "Mommy?"

Marlena's head snaps up from her hands. Her eyes are puffy and red. Cheeks have dried up tear stains. She takes several blinks before looking down at her son. "Adam? I thought you were sleeping."

“I thought you were sleeping!” He pauses for a moment. “What’s happening to Adora?”

Marlena runs a hand through her uncombed and untied hair. “I don’t know, kiddo. Neither does your father.”

“Is she a werewolf?”

“I don’t know that either. We are still trying to figure it out. Adam, baby, can you keep a secret?”

Adam stares at his mother. He can never recall her ever like this before. Shoulders are slouched, eyes unfocused, and it looks like her body is made out of lead. As if she were to stand, it would take an enormous amount of effort. Adam gives a small nod.

“Don’t tell anyone what you saw last night. Not your teachers, not your friends, *no one.* ” she says with a sternness Adam has never heard before. “We don’t know what’s happening, we can’t let anyone know. People…People might be scared. More than us. You remember what happens…”

Marlena pauses for a moment, biting down on her lower lip. “What happens in your stories about werewolves?”

“People don’t like them.”

“Exactly. We want to keep Adora safe. Do you understand? Can you keep that promise?”

Keep Adora safe? What type of question is this? Adora is his sister, his *twin.* Why on earth wouldn’t he want to do something like that. He answers his mother with a nod.

“That’s my boy.”

Marlena somehow manages to push herself off the chair she sits on. Adam was correct in his assumption that his mother’s body has become heavy. She drags her feet as she gets some breakfast for her son. All she manages to make is a bowl of cereal. Adam

doesn’t complain. He isn’t really in the mood for breakfast anyway. Yet, he eats some of the cereal before it becomes too soggy. His parents always told him breakfast is the most important meal of the day and never to miss it.

His mother returns to her spot at the table. She rests her head on her chin and stares out the window. Right into the woods in the backyard. In the morning light, the trees no longer look scary. Heck, starting at them himself, part of Adam wants to climb up them and see how high he can go. Once they grow in their leaves, he can take naps under their cool shade. He always loves to go exploring in there and search for any hidden treasures someone might have buried. Looking at them now causes his heart to drop inside of his stomach.

“Mommy? Adam?” a new voice enters the room.

Mother and son snap their heads around. Standing several feet away, rubbing one of her eyes, is Adora. She still has on the new set of pajamas her father put on her previously. Her blanket is wrapped around her body, held together with her other hand. She yawns before speaking again.

“What’s that smell?”

“What smell, kiddo?” Marlena asks. Adam questions this also. He doesn’t smell anything.

Adora sniffs the air. In a flash, her nose scrunches up and she sticks out a tongue in disgust. “It’s stinky. It smells like the garbage can! I don’t like it.”

“Oh. Oh! Yeah, now I smell it!” Marlena replies. “I guess your father and I have to take it out later. Thank you for letting me know.”

“I don’t smell anything, Mommy,” Adam says.

“Don’t worry about it, Adam.” She shoots him a serious look he doesn’t quite understand before looking back at her daughter.

“Are you feeling any better?”

“I am. I had a weird dream last night.”

“You did? What was it about?”

“I…I don’t remember much. I saw you and Papa and Adam. But everything was scary. I didn’t like it.”

“Bad dreams are never fun.”

Adora suddenly tilts her head to one side. She blinks, her eyebrows knitting together. “Cringer?”

Adam looks around the large, open room. He doesn’t see his cat anywhere. Heck, he hasn’t seen him since last night. Just when he is about to open his mouth to ask Adora what she means, Cringer appears out from behind the hall. The moment he spots most of his family, he lets out a high pitched meow before racing over. Upon reaching Adora, he purrs and rubs against her legs. It’s her turn after all to feed him.

“You’re loud today, Cringer,” Adora giggles. “Silly kitty.”

“Adora, baby girl.” Marlena suddenly says.

Adam turns towards his mother. The hand that rests on the wooden table has been clenched into a tight fist, knuckles turning white. He holds her body equally as much. Her face becomes partially obscured by her reddish brown hair. Adam swears if he were to touch his mother right now, she would break like the most delicate of glass.

“Yes, Mommy?” Adora asks.

Marlena slowly stands up, walking over to the older twin. She gives Adora a small nudge with her hands. “Why don’t you get dressed? I can feed Cringer today. You…You go get ready for the day and I will get you a bowl of cereal also, okay.”

“Uh?” Adora looks at her brother, confusion written all over her face. Adam says nothing, doesn’t even give a shrug. His body refuses to move. A frown forms on her face before she looks back towards her mother. “Are you sure, Mommy?”

“I am sure. Run along now.”

Adora does as she is told. The moment she disappears behind the hall and the echoes of footsteps cease, Marlena’s hands return to fist. Despite how tense her body is, every part of her begins to shake . Even her words cannot be left untouched.

“Adam…Adam, baby, don’t tell Adora what happened.”

“What? But why?” Adam protests Not saying anything to his friends is one thing. He has kept from saying this before mostly due to surprises that shouldn't be spoiled. But his sister?!?

When Marlena looks over her shoulders, it sends the coldest of shivers down Adam’s spine. Tears have returned, staining his mother’s face even more as the large rivers connect at her chin. Droplets fall down to the ground as she speaks.

“We can’t let her know yet. Not until we know what’s going on. We…It will *hurt* her. Please…Adam…Don’t tell her.”

Adam swallows a hard lump in his throat. How can he possibly lie to his twin? The one he tells all his secrets to? But how can he possibly say no to his heartbroken mother? Adam cannot figure out a reply. Instead, his gaze looks back out the window. Back out in the woods. Back to where this all began a month ago.

He wonders what secrets the trees have kept about what happened that night.

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated

Straight Out of A Fairytale Part II: Taken

Chapter Summary

I said fuck it and I'm posting today! So tw for this uh well kidnapping and like the other chapter, kid adora shifting. Some mild blood

And I can't link atm but my chapters have recently begun to be beta-ed by my good friend Aashi. Aka, here on ao3, AdAstra27

Do check her out she's working on a rwby fic and I can't thank her enough for helping

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

21 Years Ago

By the time Adora returns, Marlena already has set down a new bowl of cereal at the table. Adam hasn't finished his own, letting the small circles become nothing more than mush. His sister kneels on the chair, something their mother doesn't correct, before gobbling down her food. Adam is caught off guard by just how fast Adora eats and how she doesn't choke in the slightest.

"Woah! Slow down, Adora!" Marlena says. "It's just cereal!"

Adora swallows the food in her mouth. "Sorry, Mommy. I'm just really hungry!" She looks down at her *already* almost empty bowl. "Could I have another?"

"Uh…Okay. If you are that hungry. But please don't wo-I mean please don't eat so fast."

"Okay, Mommy."

While Marlena heads to get more food, Adora begins to drink the milk from her bowl. Adam watches her go, but she finishes it off fairly quickly. She places the plastic bowl back down on the table, wiping her mouth out with her sleeve. That's when she notices her brother staring at her. She tilts her head and lifts an eyebrow.

"What are you looking at, Adam?"

"Ah! Nothing." Adam feels himself turn uncomfortably warm. It's like needles are stabbing him everywhere. Inside his throat, the words about last night lodge themselves. "I'm just happy you are feeling better! We can play again!"

Adora beams, none the wiser. Marlena reappears and places a fresh new bowl down. Right after, she plants a kiss on her daughter's temple. As she pulls away, Adora stares at her. She blinks, watching her settle back down on the chair. Adam can see his mother struggling to remain awake. Her eyelids remain shut for a second too long and her head drops a little too low.

This time around, Adora does not eat as fast. Though, it's far from slow. Adam wonders if his sister will give herself a stomach ache later. Once she's finished, Marlena takes the dirty dishes and throws them in the sink. She remains there, unmoving. Their mother takes a long, deep, inhale before finally spinning around. A faint smile rests on her face.

"Do you think you two can go play in your room for a bit? Mommy and Papa are really tired and I need a nap. I'll keep the door open if you two need anything. I need an hour. Think you can do that for Mommy?"

Both of her children nod. They climb off their seats and follow their mother up the stairs. Adam watches as his mother dips into her own dark room. Once she is gone, he quickly changes out of his pajamas and into something more comfortable. All the while, his sister sets up their gaming console. By the time he plops down on the ground and grabs his "Player 2" controller, Adora has finished setting up the game. One that they got for their birthday.

For a brief moment, Adam forgets about everything that has happened. The events of last night are pushed to the far reaches of his mind. He doesn't have to worry about keeping any secrets or recall seeing his mother crying. For a moment, Adam gets lost in the thought of beating Adora. Maybe things can go back to normal, he thinks. Once his mommy and papa get up, life can return to normal, just like yesterday. Everything that has happened can just become a bad dream…

Reality dares to teach him lessons early in life.

"Adam?" Adora asks.

"Mad that you lost?" Adam replies, smiling from ear to ear. He looks over at his sister, ready to rub it in, when he is given pause. Adora has pulled her legs to her chest and has buried half of her face into them. The young boy does not miss a beat, scooting right up to his sister. "What's wrong?"

"Did…Did something happen last night? Why did Mommy look so sad?"

The warmth from before, though he should call it heat, spreads across his body. Adam begins to fidget, trying to rid himself of the feeling. Whatever he says, someone is going to become sadder than they already are. If he tells his sister the truth, then he will break his promise to his mother. But if he keeps his mouth closed, how will Adora feel? He doesn't like seeing her, or *anyone,* like this.

"I don't…I don't know," he answers. That isn't much of a lie. Though, this next part is. "I was sleeping."

"Oh…I thought you were still up after me."

"N-No. I wasn't. Uh, didn't you say you had a funny dream last night? What was that about?"

Adora thinks for a moment. She removes her face from her legs and places her chin on her knees. Lips purse together and her

eyebrows knit tightly. Whatever she is trying to pull out of her mind seems painful. Finally, Adora begins to speak.

"I don't really remember. It was all confusing. You, Mommy, and Papa didn't look the same. It was like…Like when we put on Mommy or Papa's glasses! It looked like that! I didn't know what was going on. It was really scary. I didn't feel like myself."

"Whaddya mean?"

Adora shrugs. "Dunno. It was a dream. But…It felt really real."

"Huh. I've never had that happen before." Adam rocks back and forth. "Do you wanna play some more games? And Mommy and Papa will be up soon. We can play with them!"

Adora lets go of her legs, letting them spread across the ground. Her face does not change, remaining downcast. "Yeah."

Adam grabs a new game for them to play, one that he knows his sister will enjoy. Right after he finishes and the screen loads, playing a familiar tune, he sticks out his pinky finger. This finally gets Adora to smile, the edges of her mouth twitching upward slightly. She locks her own finger around her brother's.

…

Somehow, Adam does not tell his sister about what happened. After getting so lost in their game again, the twins don't hear their father until he is walking right by their door. Despite the rest, the memories of last night remain on his body. Eyes remain darker and bags have not disappeared. Though the moment he spots his children, lights form in his irises.

"Hey, kiddos. Having fun?" Randor steps into the bedroom. He looks at the TV screen. With his glasses resting on top of his head, he squints his eyes as he reads. "Pokéman Stadium 2?"

"Poké *mon!"* Adora corrects.

“Right, right.”

“Do you wanna play loser?”

“Nah, I'd rather watch you two.” He plops down behind his children. Finally, his glasses go onto the bridge of his nose. “I still don’t know why you two are so obsessed with this?”

“It’s fun, Papa!” Adam retorts. “Did you play video games as a kid?”

“We didn’t have them. Least, not like this. We had to entertain ourselves with other things.” Randor leans forward, coming closer to his daughter. “How are you feeling? Any better?”

“Yeah. Adam was helping me feel better also. Are you okay, Papa? Mommy and you look tired.”

“Don’t worry. It’s nothing. Why don’t you two show me more of these funny looking guys.”

Adora and Adam nod, happily beginning to ramble on about their video game.

On the tips of his toes, Adam walks up the stairs. He knows where all the pressure points are and avoids them. Whatever sounds he might be making, his parents do not hear or they ignore. He stops at the middle landing, doing his best to remain hidden as he looks up. On the second floor, his mother leans on the banister with her back turned to her son. Adam can hear his father but only make out part of his body. Randor stands in the doorframe of the hallway leading to the bedrooms.

“What do we do?” Marlena asks. Adam can see her head lowering and being placed in a hand. Her voice is almost like a whisper.

“I don’t know. I still can’t believe this is real! That this is actually happening!” Randor replies. The floor creaks as he shifts his

weight. “There isn’t anything else to explain what happened the other night.”

“That animal attack was on a full moon. A werewolf...something out of all those fairy tales we read to the kids. The thing everyone sees as a monster.”

“A monster...A werewolf...That isn’t our daughter. Our daughter is *nothing* like that. Why did this happen to her? She doesn’t deserve this.”

Adam hears his father’s words breaking at the last sentence. He takes a long, deep inhale before sighing.

“What do we do?” Marlena repeats. Her legs give out and she begins to slide down, the back of her shirt catching every now and again against the wooden supports. “We can’t tell anyone about this or she will be taken away, be *killed!* And we can’t forget about the full moons—about what will happen to her every month! She’s only *five!* "

"I know. There has to be someone out there who can help us take care of her. Someone who can understand what’s going on. Who can help us figure out what to do! Someone…who can *help her* better than we can. There has to be someone, right?"

“We have to look. We can't give up hope, not now."

A sneeze from Adam takes everyone by surprise. Marlena jumps, so high she almost could clear the railing. Randor appears from his hiding spot. His glasses rests on top of his head. Drawing close to the banister, he squints red tinted eyes. “Adam? How long have you been standing there? I thought you were in your room with Adora.”

“S-Sorry, Papa.” Adam finishes making his way up the stairs. He shows his parents the bags of snacks he hid in his shirt. “Sorry. Adora and I got hungry. We couldn’t wait until dinner.”

Randor and Marlena exchange looks, wordlessly speaking to each other. His father then places a hand on his son's head. "We'll let it slide this time because of everything. Next time, ask us. Okay, kiddo?"

"Hm-mh!"

"Run along now, baby," Marlena says.

Adam dashes down the hallway, heading right to his door. Little fingers grasp the doorknob and twist it open. "I got snacks!" he chirps as he enters. "Mommy and Papa caught me but they let me keep 'em!"

He's excited to share the bags in his hands. A rare, rare treat for the twins. But when his eyes land on Adora, everything he holds drops to the floor. Adora lies on the ground, curled in on herself. Tears and sniffles escape her as her body shakes. Something musky fills the air, a smell that Adam does not have a name for. He freezes in place, much like the other night.

"A-Adora? Are you okay?" Adam manages to ask.

"Why…Why did Mommy and Papa call me a monster? Am I a werewolf? Is that what happened?" Adora chokes out.

"I-" Words stick to the inside of his throat.

"What happened to me? Why did Mommy and Papa say those things…They were mean!"

"It's not like that!" He shakily takes two steps forward.

"Did you know?" Adora's eyes go wide. When she blinks, there is a tint of red within her sky blue eyes. She slowly begins to lift herself off of the ground, resting herself on hands and knees. Her nails have blacken and her body trembles. "Was that dream I had real?"

She looks down at her hands, noticing the growing nails. Drops of tears drip onto her skin. Teeth grit together, revealing sharp canines. Adam feels his heart beating rapidly in his chest. His brain screams at him to flee as the musky smell grows, almost filling the room. The steps he took previously are quickly reversed.

"MOMMY! PAPA!" he shouts. "IT'S ADORA!"

In the blink of an eye, his parents appear behind him. Adam does not remove his eyes from Adora. Her shaking body has not ceased. Heck, it seems to have grown worse. When she hears the footsteps entering the room, her head lifts up. The red in her irises have grown, threatening to choke out the blue. Eyes are wide and frightened.

"Wh-What's happening to me?" She lets out a sharp gasp. "It hurts!"

There is no time to do anything else. Adora's whole body jerks violently. Her arms and knees give out as her body grows and changes. Fur, darker than the other night, grows all over her body. A tail sprouts out from behind and her face grows into a fanged muzzle. Unlike the other night, her hands do not look as if a paw has been smashed into it. Instead, her nails are sharp and long and look like one from werewolves in their storybooks. When eyes land on the family once more, they burn a *bright* red.

The fur on the back of Adora's neck stands straight at attention. Her teeth are bare for everyone to see. Adam latches onto his father's leg. Now it is his turn to shake.

"Adora," Marlena whispers. She takes a hesitant step forward and begins to lower herself. "It's okay now. You don't have to be scared!"

A low growl escapes Adora. She lunges for her mother. Marlena has barely enough time to dodge the blur of dark yellow flying at her. The wolf stumbles for a moment, her footing unsure. She

quickly recovers. Without missing a single beat, Adora turns and sets her sights back onto her mother.

“Ladybug!” Randor shouts.

Marlena jumps out of the way once more. Adam notices his mother wincing as she returns to her feet. As Adora recovers from this attack, Marlena quickly reaches the door. She shoves her husband and son out into the hallway. The door shuts just as Adora draws close. There is a hard *thud* .

“That was way too close,” Marlena groans. Putting her back against the door, she lets gravity pull her down to the ground. “What the hell was that! Why did she just turn?!?”

Randor taps Adam on the shoulder. The young boy, still shaking, snaps his head up. “Huh?”

“What happened to Adora? Do you know?”

Adam thinks for a moment. Hands play with his father’s jeans in thought. “I walked in and was gonna give Adora the snacks. But she was crying. I think…I think she heard you and Mommy. She heard you call her a monster.”

“*Damnit*!” Marlena suddenly hits a fist against the bedroom door. “She wasn’t supposed to hear that!”

Adam yelps at his mother’s outburst. He scurries behind his father’s leg, seeking shelter.

“Adam, baby, I’m sorry.” he hears his mother say. “I didn’t mean to lash out. Are you okay?”

Adam peers his head out. His mother remains on the ground but now has a hand outstretched. She does her best to put a smile on her face, even as more weight is pushed against her shoulders. Behind the closed door, Adam can hear growls, crashes, and tearing noises. Slowly, the young boy steps out from his father’s legs. “Is Adora gonna be okay?”

“She will, I promise,” Marlena replies. “We have to let her calm down. Come here, baby boy.”

Adam slowly steps forward. Once he is within arms length, Marlena pulls him close and holds him tightly against her chest. Her heartbeat, despite being quicker than normal, helps calm him. Helps him believe that she isn’t telling him a lie to make him feel better. Adam buries himself into his mother’s body.

Randor steps closer. He takes a chance, cracking open the bedroom door. When a growl fills the air, he pulls it back closed. Another *thud* fills the air. His face turns pale as he sits across from the rest of his family.

“She’s already made a mess in the room,” he states.

"We can always worry about that later. Let’s hope she calms down soon.”

Marlena suddenly hisses through her teeth. One arm removes itself from Adam. Fingers brush against her leg, causing her to wince again. Adam notices claw marks have torn his mother’s pants wide open. Blotches of red stain the fabric and it only grows. Randor notices almost as fast. Before he can say anything, Marlena cuts her husband off.

“It’s fine. She didn’t bite me,” she quickly reassures both Randor and Adam. “We can take care of it later.”

“Let me wrap it up. Don’t argue with me.”

Before she can say anything, Randor returns to his feet. While he searches the bathroom for supplies, Adam remains at his mother's side. He wishes he had one of his stuffed animals to give his mother. Something to make her feel better. To take away the scariness of what is going on. Instead, he wraps his arms around Marlena’s neck as tight as he can. He receives a kiss on the temple.

Randor reappears with a medical kit in his hands. He carefully rolls up the pant leg, doing his utmost not to bump the injury. Marlena bites down on her lower lip, hissing slightly as her husband begins to spray the wound. Blood continues to seep out. Once there is no risk of infection, he wraps a white bandage around her leg. Quickly, it becomes stained red.

“Can you stand?” Randor asks.

“Hm. I can.” Marlena releases her son. Using the door for support, she struggles onto shaking feet. Most of her weight rests against her uninjured leg. With her body pressed against the door, Marlena pauses as she listens through the barrier. Eyes narrow as she does her best to piece together everything.

Adam mimics his mother. Nothing. Dead silence. He pushes himself further, almost fusing with the door. Still he's only met with quiet. His heart skips a beat, not knowing what type of sign this means. A million questions run through his head.

Marlena reaches over her son and cracks open the door. Adam's vision becomes momentarily dark as his mother blocks the view. Creaking fills his ears as well as a soft sigh from Marlena. She pushes the door wide open, giving her son sight once more.

The bedroom is a wreck. Curtains are torn, the ends ripped into ribbons. Parts of the carpeting have been pulled clean off the floor, revealing the wooden underbelly. Some trinkets that once were on dressers now lie on the ground. Somehow, nothing has shattered. A pillow that had not been picked up from before now has been gutted. Feathers have exploded everywhere. Even a game controller has not been left untouched. Its wires are exposed for all to see.

In the middle of the room, surrounded by feathers, pieces of plastic, and stings of drapes is Adora. Flat on her back, she pants. Ripped clothes cling to her twitching body. Her nails shrink and turn pale. Eyes remain shut. Adam no longer smells the musk in the air.

Marlena steps close to her daughter, doing her best to hide her limp. By the time she kneels down on the ground Adora has become still. The only thing that moves is her chest. When her mother's hand brushes against her cheek, Adora mumbles something.

Carefully, Marlena picks her up. Adora is placed against the mattress. The golden blanket, left untouched by the outburst, is pulled over her body. Marlena sits on the edge, burying her face into her hands. Randor slowly joins her, Adam right at his heels.

"Randy…" Marlena's voice is barely audible.

Randor places a hand against his wife's back. "There has to be someone out there who can help us. Adora can't be the only one with this."

"How are we going to find someone like that? We didn't know that werewolves were real until now."

It's Adam's turn to talk. He closes the distance between him and his mother. Hands rest against her knees. Adam waits for Marlena to reveal her face before he speaks. "You and Papa are smart! You can figure it out. And I can help!"

He flashes his crooked smile, feeling his chest swell. He knows his parents will figure something out. They always do no matter what is going on. And don't all of his story books have the heroes struggling before coming out on top at the end? There *always* is a happy ending, right?

When his mother returns the smile, his heart grows. She cups his face and places a kiss against his forehead. "I am so lucky to have a son like you."

Adam turns his attention to his father. He has his own soft smile on his face as he gives a pat on his son's head.

"Thank you. Don't try to worry yourself too much though, okay? You're little and this is a big thing."

Adam nods, though he isn’t deterred by the size of the challenge.

Adora no longer is kept in the dark about what happened. After waking up from her sudden shift, Randor and Marlena tell her about everything (though, the only thing left out is her mother’s injury). She listens to everything, nodding every now and again. Adam sits nearby, chiming in when he can. His sister doesn’t ask any questions. When they finish, Adora's head hangs low as she begins to cry.

“Wh-What’s gonna happen to me? Am I a monster?” she sniffles.

“No, no.” Randor pulls her into a tight hug. “You’ll always be our daughter, no matter what. We’ll figure something out. Together!"

"It’s gonna be okay, Adora. It’s gonna be okay, I promise." Marlena rubs Adora’s back. “We will get through this. You have to try and stay calm, though, okay?”

It’s Adam’s turn. Already on the bed, he crawls as close as he can to her. “Yeah! And think ‘bout it! You have some superpowers now! You can hear and smell things we can’t. And maybe you can even see in the dark. Cringer won’t be able to sneak up on you now.”

Adora chuckles a little. “I guess that’s cool. I can see everything at night so you’re not scared anymore.”

Adam pouts, which only makes his sister laugh more. She begins to wipe off her tears. Though, she remains nestled in her father’s arms. Not much else is spoken. The family of four stay on the bed until their stomachs begin to growl. With the snacks torn to shreds, an actual meal is made. When night falls and with no one wanting to clean, everyone sleeps in the master bed, all squeezing together.

The next two weeks go by slowly to the five year old. Adam only forgets about what is occurring in his life when he is with his friends at preschool or when playing video games with his sister

(thankfully, the broken controller has been replaced). Adora doesn't talk much about it, wishing to forget also. Though, she does begin to enjoy seeing at night and describing all the smells her family cannot pick up on.

When they are not at work, Adam finds his parents huddled around the family computer. The loud, screeching noise of it connecting to the internet begins to cause Adora to slap her hands over her ears. Guess having super hearing isn't always the best. Sometimes, Adam attempts to take a peek at what his parents are doing. He sees pictures of werewolves against the screen, many of them looking scary. Even if he could read, the text is too small for him to make out any letters.

Though this is as far as he gets before one of his parents shove him away, telling him to go play with Adora and make sure she is okay. No matter how many times he tries to see or help in this way, he is told the same thing. He slinks away each time.

By the time third week rolls around, as the moon grows and grows, something occurs that piques the twins interest. While they see how Adora's sense of smell is, which involves blindfolding her and Adam finding random things for her to sniff, they hear their father return home. Their little experiment is set aside so both can run up to Randor, each clinging to a leg.

"Welcome home, Papa!" they shout.

"Hey, kiddos. I hope you were good for your mother while I was out." When he receives a nod from his children, he smiles. "Where is she anyway?"

"Over here, Randy!"

With his children still clinging to his legs like koala bears, Randor trudges over towards his wife, as Adam and Adora giggle the whole time. Marlena sits at the computer, pausing her search on the web to lean back on the wooden chair.

"Hi, honey." Marlena says. Randor walks up to her and gives her a kiss. Smiling, she continues. "What's up?"

"Well, I was at the library," he begins. Carefully, Randor starts prying his children off his legs. "Trying to find any books that could *maybe* help. And someone stopped me."

"Oh?"

"It was a woman, older than us. She said she was a hunter."

"A hunter?" An eyebrow raises on Marlena's face.

"Yeah. But not like a deer or bear hunter. She said a 'hunter' means someone who protects and helps the supernatural world. Both from humans who would…" his eyes momentarily flick down towards Adora before returning to his wife. "Ya know. And also from any supernatural beings who would want to harm others.

"She said she had heard about an animal attack here and had been tracking a werewolf that was causing trouble. Saw me looking at the books and took a shot in the dark."

"Did you tell her about Adora?!?" Marlena questions. Eyes narrow as she lets the legs of the chair connect back to the hardwood.

"Yes and no. I said I knew the person who was hurt and we were trying to find help for them. She actually gave me her number."

He begins to dig through his pocket, his tongue sticking out in thought. A scrap piece of paper sticks out between his thumb and index as he hands it to Marlena.

"Do you really think she is who she says she is?" Marlena asks as she takes the paper. Eyes scan the numbers.

"Dunno. She had scars in her face that looked like she fought some animal. And what are the chances of someone knowing what really happened?"

"I want to talk to her myself."

"What are you talking about, Papa?" Adam asks.

"Someone who might be able to help Adora." He kneels down, becoming eye level with the twins. "Your mother and I are gonna talk to her and see what she knows. Once we do, maybe you can meet her, Adora. Would you like that?"

Adora rocks on her heels. "Maybe."

"You can decide later. We have to meet her ourselves."

“Okay.”

“Isn’t that cool, Adora!” Adam suddenly shouts. “You can learn to control it and be even more super strong! You’ll be like a superhero!”

He watches as Adora’s eyes widen and begin to sparkle. “Ya really think so?”

“Yeah! Wouldn’t that be so cool!”

“Yeah, it would!”

“Why don’t you kids go off and play again?” Marlena suggests. “We have to have adult talk. You two were testing Adora’s sense of smell?”

Adora and Adam nod before bolting off, finding some enjoyment in this situation.

Whatever his parents plan on doing, they don’t tell him nor Adora. When at preschool, he knows they go to talk to this woman. They don’t say anything about their time with her. From the whispers Adora manages to hear, Marlena and Randor remain unsure about what to do. Even Adora doesn’t know what she wants. Many

nights, as the moon completes its turn, the twins remain up, talking under their fort they made about what to do.

They also talk about how to help their mother and father, hating to see them so upset and worried. They talk about how they have to keep this secret from their friends and even the rest of their family. They talk about how one day maybe Adora's powers can help others and she can be a hero like those in her favorite stories.

They talk about what will happen when the next full moon occurs. This gets to the pair the most. Adora curls up against her brother as she worries about the next shift. Not only does she fear the pain that'll come but what she'll do. Despite their parents' reassurance about not being a monster, Adora doesn't want to harm anyone. She knows if anyone gets bit by her, they will suffer the same fate, the same *curse,* she has.

While she sniffles over the thought, Adam holds her. He reminds his sister that he will be here for her no matter what. And if he were to ever get bit, then they can be superheroes together when they are older. Adora wipes off her tears upon hearing this and promises however, never to bite anyone.

Soon, that fateful night comes around. The full moon begins to rise high in the sky, shining brightly. Anxiety hangs in the air as the wait goes on. So thick it becomes, a knife *couldn't* even cut it. Time drags out, torturing the family for fun. Adora lies curled up on her bed, shivering. A bucket is nearby, already having been used. Her head rests against her father's lap. Randor's fingers brush through her hair as he whispers to her.

Marlena stands nearby, waiting for what happens next. Adam remains close by, refusing to sleep. Even if his body begs to curl up in his bed and drift off into dreams, he fights against it. He wants to be there if his sister needs anything at all. Any time he begins to nod off, he gives himself a little pinch. So hard he tries that he doesn't bother to lie on his own bed. The moment he does, he knows it will be all over.

“I don’t feel good,” Adora mumbles.

“I know, baby, I’m sorry,” Randor says. There is a mist of tears covering his eyes.

Marlena walks up to her daughter. A hand rubs against her legs. “It’ll be over soon. I promise.”

“I don’t like it.” Adora’s shivers have turned into full on shakes. Adam’s stomach twists into a tight knot at the sight. He might have to use the bucket himself.

Marlena kneels on the ground, placing a peck on Adora’s pale cheek. “I don’t like it either, baby girl. It will be okay, I promise.”

Adora groans, biting down on her lips. Like the month before her body suddenly begins to jerk violently. Randor shifts away as her teeth suddenly snap together. Adam is shielded by his parents as his sister shifts into something else. Something not human. She grows in size and limbs contour into something new. Claws, fangs, and fur. A large amount of breathing room is given as Adora’s body changes.

Her body soon settles, looking more akin to her first shift. For several long, agonizing moments, Adora lies still. Just when Adam takes a step forward, attempting to push past his parents, his sister’s eyes snap open. While the gold has returned, red lurks within. The moment they spot the rest of her family, Adora jumps to her feet. Teeth flash and hair stands at attention.

“Don’t upset her,” Randor says. He sticks out his hand, preventing Adam from taking any further steps.

“She’s not dangerous, is she?” Adam asks.

“When someone is scared or angry, when their body chooses to fight or flee, they are capable of anything,” Marlena answers. She tries to take a step forward but is quickly stopped when Adora pulls her lips back even further. “Adora is frightened, *confused.* We shouldn’t frighten her anymore.”

When it becomes apparent Adora doesn't want another living soul in the bedroom, not relaxing in the slightest until someone happens to step out of the room, everyone leaves. The door is left ajar, allowing Adam and his parents to peer in every now and again. Whenever Adam looks in, he sees his sister pacing around. Any time a tree branch taps against the window, or the wind sounds odd, or hell even a police siren blares in the dead of night, it provokes a growl. She snaps at invisible beings.

Occasionally, one of his parents attempts to check on Adora, hoping that she has settled. Each time, they are greeted with growls and snaps. There are a number of close calls, teeth coming dangerously close to skin. Adam wishes to check on his sister himself but his parents absolutely have forbidden him from stepping foot back in his room.

Whether unfortunately or not, Adam finds himself unable to stay awake. His body does not want a repeat of last month and causes his head to become like lead. Even his arms and legs are far too heavy to move. With no fight left in him, his mother picks him up and lays him down on the master bed.

"Adora gonna be okay, right?" he asks as the covers are placed up to his neck.

"She will. Don't worry. In the morning, Adora is going to be back to normal." The back of Marlena's hand strokes her son's cheek.

Adam looks up at his mother. Even in the dark and even with tiredness gripping him, he can see the wear on Marlena's face. In the course of half a night, she looks ten years older. If *he* feels like going to bed, his mother seems like she is about to collapse. Fingers grip her shirt.

"Mommy, why don't you sleep with me? You and Papa need rest also!"

Marlena shakes her head. "Don't worry about that, baby. It's time for you to sleep." She leans forward before placing a kiss on

Adam's head. "You sleep. We'll need your help in the morning, okay?"

Adam frowns before giving a nod. The last of his energy leaves his body as Marlena disappears out of the room.

"Are Mommy and Papa okay?" Adora asks. She peers through the gap between the door and its frame. Adam looks alongside her. Randor and Marlena lie on their bed, oblivious to the world around them. After ensuring their daughter was safe and their children had been fed, they collapsed onto their bed. Almost immediately they became unconscious.

Guess even adults cannot stay up all night long.

"They are just sleepy." Adam answers. He backs away from the door, Adora remaining there. "They are okay."

"Are they sleepy because of me?"

Adam shifts on his feet. When he woke up earlier, Adora had turned back to her normal self and was sleeping herself. His parents remained awake, stumbling and leaning against walls to remain standing. Adam swears he saw his father momentarily fall asleep while propped up by the hallway.

"They'll wake up soon," Adam replies. He digs into his pocket and pulls out a candy bar he snuck while eating breakfast, after seeing his sister not eat as much. Though, upon seeing the sweet, Adam swears he sees drool coming from his sister. He has been hearing her stomach growl for the past hour as well. "Eat."

"I'm not hungry…" Adora moves away from the door and plops herself down on the ground. Cringer, who was sitting nearby, jumps onto her lap and begins to purr.

"I know you are. It will make Mommy and Papa happy if you eat!"

Adora eyes flick from him, to the candy bar, and then back to him. Finally, she reaches out and takes the sweet. While she opens it up, slowly chewing on the chocolate, Adam sits down besides his sister. They say nothing. Only the sounds of Cringer purring and the plastic wrapping around the candy bar fills the air. Halfway through eating, Adora snaps off a bit of chocolate and gives it to her brother.

"Thank you!" Adam chirps, popping the bit into his mouth.

"What's gonna happen?" Adora suddenly asks.

"What do ya mean?"

"Mommy and Papa…They are hurting because of me. They have to stay up to watch me. I could hurt them or you or Cringer. I don't like to hurt everyone."

"Did you want to see that lady Mommy and Papa were talking about? She could help!"

"Maybe. Do you think she could help?"

Adam nods. "I think so! Why wouldn't she? And doesn't a hunter sound cool? She probably knows a lot and can show you awesome things!"

Adora smiles softly. "I do wonder what she knows. If it helps Mommy and Papa, I'll do it!"

"You better tell me all about it!"

"You be good, alright, Adora?" Marlena states. She shoves the yellow blanket into her daughter's bag. Something for Adora to have for nap time.

"Hm-mh…" Adora mumbles. She can barely stand as her mother zips up her backpack. The sun struggles to pull itself out of its own bed in the earth.

Adam struggles to stay awake also, yawning loudly as he waits with his father. For whatever reason this lady wanted to see Adora right away. Everyone but Marlena is feeling the effects of being pulled out of bed so early. Though, he knows his Mommy likes to get to work early on the computer. Adam could be asleep, part of him *wishes* he still was, but he wasn't gonna leave his sister alone meeting this new person.

Marlena kneels down in front of her daughter, arms wrapping tight around Adora's little body. She holds onto her for several long moments before letting go. Adam can see his mother holding back tears. Marlena cups Adora's cheeks before placing a tender kiss on her forehead.

"I love you, baby girl."

"I love you too, Mommy."

"You ready, Adora?" Randor asks.

Adora nods. She begins to follow her father out of the house and towards the car. Adam stands right besides her the whole way. No one speaks as they head to the meeting place. The sky remains dark, only silvers of orange on the horizon as the sun continues to take its time waking up. By the time they reach the tiny, one floor house, there only are hints of bright blue mixed into the sky.

As they exit, Adam holds onto his sister's hand. He can feel her trembling, almost matching his own shaking. The coldness in the air nips at his cheeks. Feet splash against the small puddles on the pathway to the house. Just as they reach the steps, the front door opens. Adam feels a shiver run down his spine.

The woman who appears before him is tall—almost as tall as his father. Her face has large claw marks against the skin and hair as black as tar. But what causes him to freeze in place and become like a statue are her eyes. *Bright,* sickly green. He swears they almost glow. Adam swallows a lump in his throat.

“Alright baby, you are gonna go with her for the day,” Randor starts.

Adora exchanges a look at her brother. He gives her a small nod and finally lets go of her.

“With her?” Adora asks, looking up at her father.

“Yes. Go on. Say ‘hi’.” Randor gives her a small nudge, pushing her forward. Her eyes remain on him before turning towards the woman.

"Hello, Deary," the woman says. She kneels down, becoming at eye level. Fingers hold Adora’s chin.

"Who are you?" Adora squeaks out.

"Beatrix Weaver. I am here to help you. I am going to take good care of you."

Adam doesn’t like how the woman smiles. When he sees it, he wants to hide behind his father’s legs. The young boy clings to Randor’s jeans, shielding most of his body. He keeps his head out enough to see his sister. Adora is looking back at both her brother and father.

Randor takes a step forward, Adam dragged along with him. He gives his daughter a hug, one tight just like Marlena’s. He too gives a gentle kiss before pushing Adora again.

"Let's go," Ms. Weaver says. "Everything will be okay now."

Adam watches as the woman takes Adora’s hand and guides her into the room. Randor quickly stands to his feet, spooking Adam just by how fast he shoots up. “You’ll take care of her, right?”

“Of course! I won’t let anything bad happen to her,” she replies. “You have nothing to worry about. She is under great care.”

Adam feels his father begin to tremble slightly. “O-Okay. I’ll see you later, baby girl. Be good. I love you.”

“I will, Papa. I love you,” Adora replies. She gives them a wave goodbye. After it is returned by father and son, Ms. Weaver disappears into the house with Adora.

Adam tugs on his father’s leg. When Randor looks down, the young boy says, “Adora is gonna come back, right? Ms. Weaver is gonna help her?”

Randor reaches down, hands placing themselves under Adam’s armpits. He is scooped up and held close to his father’s chest. Adam uses Randor’s shoulder as a pillow as he wraps his arms around his neck and legs around his chest.

“Don’t worry, son,” Randor replies, patting Adam’s back. “You’ll see her later today, I promise. I think we should get you home.”

Adam doesn’t like waiting. He doesn’t like being without his twin. This has to be the longest time he ever has been away from her. All he has to do is wait for the late afternoon to come along and then she’ll be back. Back and telling him everything that has happened. That alone makes him impatient. Adam *cannot* wait to be told all the stories Adora surely will have.

As the time drags on, the time lost from sleep this morning begins to catch up. His nap time comes earlier than expected, though Adam does not protest the sleep. Marlena and Randor lie him down on the couch, his orange blanket draped across him. It does not take long for the dream world to take over. One where he is playing with his sister.

…

The sound of glass shattering startles him from his slumber. Adam jolts awake, body shooting up right. His heart beats inside of his throat. So startled, he can feel every part of his being trembling. What on earth was that? He barely has time to answer the

questions pouring into his mind when a new sound kicks them straight out.

"What the *hell* do you mean, Randor!" Marlena shouts. Adam can hear a harsh growl of anger in her voice. "What the *fuck* do you mean they're gone!"

Adam's heartbeat threatens to drown out his parent's voices. The last time he heard his parents voice change like this, change into something frightening, was the night Adora was bitten. What is happening now? Gingerly, he crawls off the couch and tip toes towards the front door. He makes sure to remain hidden.

At the front door, which is wide open, he sees his father standing in the frame. His eyes are puffy and watery. His cellphone is held in one of his hands as he frantically speaks to his wife.

"I went to pick Adora up. But when I went there, no one was there! No car. Lights off. *Nothing!* I-I-I tried calling her but she didn't pick up! I already called the police. They'll be here soon!"

Police? Why are they coming? Adam wonders.

Marlena suddenly grips Randor's shirt. Teeth grit together as she brings him close. Despite their height difference, Adam's father having at least a head on her, it does not take much to bring him to eye level. Dark eyes burn and brim with hot tears.

"Tell me you're lying!" Marlena damn well near shrieks. She shakes her husband. " *Tell* me this is all some sick joke!"

Randor gently places his hands on his wife's shoulders. Tears now run down his cheeks as he struggles to keep his composure. Lips tremble as he speaks. "Ladybug. Marlena. I'm not. Adora…Adora is…she's… *she's* …" he cannot complete his sentence.

Hands release their grip on his shirt. Marlena steps back, almost stepping on the crystals and puddles of water on the ground. Eyes are wider than ever before. The tears that covered her irises now break free. Words come out choked as she gasps for air. "No. Not

my baby girl. Not Adora. This was supposed to *help* her! She *can't…* She can't be gone!'

G-Gone?!?

Randor steps forward. Strong arms begin to wrap around his wife. Marlena attempts to reject the embrace, pushing him away and almost punching his chest, but it is little of a deterrent. He holds her close to his chest. The moment Marlena is in his arms, legs give out. Her face buries itself into his shirt. Even muffled, Adam can hear his mother's wails.

Randor guides them down to the floor, never loosening his grip. That is when he spots his son's head peering out from the corner. He barely can keep eye contact on him. Adam sees something on his father's face he has never seen before. *Shame.* As the young boy steps out from his hiding spot, following Randor's gesture to come to him, he feels his whole body turn into ice.

Adora is gone. Nowhere to be seen. The police are coming. His mother can only sob and his father cannot look at him. Like the glass on the ground, he feels his whole world shattering around him.

Chapter End Notes

Comments/kudos appreciated

Also currently as a heads up I am out of a laptop. Its getting fixed but I only wrote up to chapter 26 before I had to send it out so due to that once ch 26 comes around idk how long the next break will be. I'll let yall know then but a heads up

Everything Stays

Chapter Notes

I did not plan for ch 24 to be posted on the 24th so fbdbbfbsa that's not why I pushed myself here but yeah uh no real trigger warning but like mild mild nudity?

Had some help with writing some stuff from my buddies at the Lancaster so fbshjdjdha

Enjoy yall

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Despite sitting down, Adora feels like she is spinning. She feels like she is being tossed, turned, and thrown around like an untethered box in a fast moving truck. Her stomach threatens to expel anything that remains inside it. The thoughts racing through her mind compete for attention, each pushing the other away before she can grasp onto them. Her emotions are no better. All fight to be in the forefront.

She finally, *finally* has the answers she has been searching for all these years. Adora can finally rest easy at night, knowing the truth about her birth family. When the time comes, when she is ready, she can *return* there. Her heart wants to explode with how much joy is flooding it. Yet, a harsh, spikey ball of rage keeps it in place. With a hand laced through her hair, her nails dig into her scalp.

What would life have been like if she had never been kidnapped? Her parents had searched for answers, for help, all for her. They would do anything to help her and in the end, they were duped. If that had not happened, what else would they have done? How many more sleepless nights would they go through just so Adora could have a semblance of peace with her werewolf side? Judging by the way Adam spoke, how his voice would crack and how his

eyes would become watery, it would have been to the ends of the earth.

Another emotion claws its way up her throat. How did she essentially forget everything about her family? How did she forget they tried to help and never thought any less of her for what happened? How did she come to believe that they only saw her as a monster and not their little girl?

Shadow Weaver, of course. That's how. Fingernails threaten to break through her skin. She remembers the first time she asked her about her family; where they were and if they were going to come back for her. Adora was alone in the back seat of the car, only her little bag to her name. Years have distorted many of her memories, however, this is one of the few that is untouched. Her recollection of that night, of looking out the window, has always remained the same.

Pitch black. No stars, no moon. Heavy, dark clouds cover the whole sky, leaving absolutely no room for light to seep through. Adora remembers how the low hum of the engine was the only noise that broke through the silence. In the rearview mirror, she can still see the bright, green eyes of her adoptive mother. How long did it take for Shadow Weaver to answer her?

"They left you," Shadow Weaver finally said.

"W-What?" Adora squeaked, shrinking into the car seat.

"They didn't want you anymore." Her voice, as always in her memory, was cold. "They didn't want a daughter who could attack and kill them at any time. They didn't want someone like *you.* Like *us."*

"But-"

Before she could retort, surely to protest that her parents did indeed love her, Shadow Weaver cut her off. "It's best to forget about them."

How many times did that conversation repeat itself, how many times did she tell Adora to forget? How long did it take for all those lies to push away and delete her true memories of her family, replacing them with falsity? So rooted in her brain that, even with Adam's truth, they remain implanted. If she were to be able to rid herself of them, under them would be *nothing.* No warm memories of their reassurance that everything would be okay. No memories of hope for the future.

There's nothing but dark shadows of hatred and rejection.

Any and all positive memories of that time are gone for good.

Adora slowly removes her hand from her head. She finds three pairs of eyes on her. Bow's brown eyes are soft and worried. His eyebrows furrow. Besides her, Glimmer's own violet ones have concern but also a dark flame of anger. The only reason her body doesn't tremble is from how *tight* she holds it. And sitting across from her, she sees Adam's dark blue eyes brimming with tears and full of tiredness. How much effort did it take him to speak his story? How much of a weight has finally come off his chest?

They all wait for her reply, her thoughts and reaction to having found her missing puzzle pieces of her life. Adora takes a brief moment to set her sights towards the window, looking out into the night world. Most of the clouds that hung in the sky earlier in the day have faded away. The waxing gibbous moon, almost finished with its journey towards full roundness, stares at her. In only a few days, she'll be torn apart, just like every month for nearly her whole life.

"I," she starts, returning her gaze back to everyone, "don't remember most of that. So much of it is fuzzy and muddled with the lies I've been told. I'm sorry, Adam."

"You shouldn't be. I'm not surprised since it was so long ago," he replies.

Adora groans, rubbing a finger against her temple. “I still can’t comprehend everything. It’s so much just for two months. I can’t believe I attacked Mom...”

The word ‘mom’ feels odd against her tongue. To her, it has such a negative connotation that it leaves a bile-like taste in her mouth. This is something she will have to get used to eventually. Adora shakes the feeling away. There are enough emotions brewing inside of her that there is no need to add to that stew.

“She never wanted to tell you and make you worry. The scar by now is really pale and forgettable. And it’s not like you bit her. Did you stick with that promise though? Not biting anyone? From what little I know, it sounds like you didn’t.”

The trio of friends react to this in different ways. Glimmer chokes on her water, slamming a fist against her chest. Bow tenses up and laughs nervously, rubbing the back of his neck. Adora, finally, coughs, clearing her thoughts and preventing any unnecessary blurt-outs. It gives her a moment to think of what to say as Adam raises an eyebrow.

"What happened after I got kidnapped? I bet nothing great.”

Adam’s shoulders slouch even further. She wonders how far they can fall. “You can say that. Pops got really quiet and almost stopped talking entirely. Mom was on edge, a lot of things set her off. Probably didn’t help she wouldn’t sleep and just waited by the phone for any calls. Starting school was difficult. There were fights and I had to stay with a family friend once until things calmed down.

“But, we did get through it. Mom and Pa stayed together. Some days are better than others but ya know,” he gives a small shrug, “life’s like that.”

“I’m sorry,” is all Adora can say.

“There’s nothing anyone can do.” Adam takes a deep breath before standing. He stretches out his arms and legs. “I really hope

this whole Shadow Weaver thing is over soon. It's taking everything in me not to tell them about what's going on."

"I don't think I am ready to see them yet anyway."

"I can't blame you. And if you just dropped in out of the blue, both of them might die of heart attacks right on the spot."

"Don't need that happening." Bow hops to his feet, doing his own stretches. "It's kind of getting late, don't ya think?"

"Yeah…What are we doing about sleeping?" Adora suddenly asks. She glances at her girlfriend.

After all the driving that has happened, Adora would be quite surprised if Glimmer would want to go out again. Not to mention, where the hell is Adam going to sleep? There is only one other bed in the house that is usable. It is *doubtful* Glimmer would allow access to her mother's room. She wonders just how far her girlfriend planned this all out.

"There's the guest bedroom and the couch." Bow points out.

"I can take the couch," Adam says.

"Are you sure about that? I can take the couch."

Adam brushes him off. "Nah. I don't want to be any more of a bother than I already am."

"You're not being a bother." Adora states.

"No, I already want the couch."

"Suit yourself." Glimmer chirps. "Let's get you boys set up for the night."

"Let me get some of my stuff out of the guest room." Adora begins to head towards the lower bedroom. When she hears her brother asking to come along, she does not protest. More hands

are better than none. Glimmer and Bow meanwhile, decide to get the living room in some sort of order.

Adora is grateful she already started to clean up beforehand. With the dusting already done, all there is left to do is get her blanket and bag of items. She does make a quick check in the adjacent bathroom to ensure Bow will have what he needs for the night. With everything set, she returns to the bedroom.

"You still have this?" Adam asks. In his hands is her golden blanket.

"Yeah. Somehow it survived all these years," Adora replies. She steps up to her brother and takes the blanket from his hands. The smell of apple cinnamon floods her nose. With the knowledge of what it belongs to, her heart skips a beat in her chest. "Still smells like her cooking. I've clung to this all my life and I didn't know why, but now I do."

"I still have mine. Mom got them so big so we could always have them with us into adulthood. Ya know when Mom and Pa found out they were having twins, people were like 'Get pink and purple!' for our colors. Ya know, cause ' *girls'.* But they were like nah, screw that and got us yellow and orange. Glad she didn't go with the former."

"I bet." Adora tucks the blanket under her armpit. "I don't think purple is your color. Orange suits you."

Adam smiles. He grabs her bag before handing it to his sister. "You probably don't remember it–it did happen just before you disappeared–but you gave me my name."

Adora's eyebrows raise. "Really?"

They begin to exit. Glimmer and Bow have either finished cleaning or have given up as they are in the kitchen. Adora's stomach begins to growl with the thought of a nice, home cooked meal. As the pair of twins head up the stairs, Adam answers her.

"Yeah. After I told you guys I was a boy, the two of us were trying to come up with a new name for me. We threw around a lot but you were the one that said ' *Adam'* because we would match. I stuck with it and never changed it, so thank you for that!"

Adora tries to recall that moment between her and her brother. No matter how hard she strains herself trying to remember the day he announced to his family he was a boy, and her giving him his name, there is nothing. Nothing but a black void. While she isn't shocked by this fact, it definitely feels like a stab in the heart, unable to remember these important parts of Adam's life.

"Well, I am glad I could do that for you! It is a cool name," she replies, faking a smile. "Ah! Here's the room!"

Adora cannot sleep. She tosses and turns, unable to find a comfortable spot on the bed. Covers stay on before she kicks them off in annoyance, only for her to pull them back up and repeat the cycle. No matter how many times she shuts her eyes, the dark heaviness never enters her body. She tries every trick in the book in her attempt to fall unconscious but nothing comes close to working. Her body *refuses* to rest.

As does her mind.

She cannot get her family out of her head. Even knowing their names and faces of her parents, she continues to wonder what they are like. Heck, what they look like *now.* How old are they anyway? They must be at least in their fifties. About half their lives have been spent wondering what happened to their daughter. An invisible force begins to squeeze her heart. She still wishes she could have done more somehow. Ease their suffering!

She feels horrible for putting her parents through that pain. Adora has to remind herself it wasn't her fault. She was only a *child* when she was taken away. Yet, that knife remains lodged in her heart.

Even if it has to be done, not telling them yet about her existence does not help in the slightest. She wishes to let them know she is alive and breathing but the thought of bringing them into this hell does not sit well within Adora's stomach. It's like a sharp razor has found itself in there, ready to rip up her insides at a moment's notice. At least Adam can be some sliver of light. Yet, that in and of itself is a problem. All she has to go off in regards to siblings is Catra.

"I'm going to take a shower." Adora suddenly says.

Glimmer snaps up. The hunter had been reading on her phone this whole time, occasionally asking her girlfriend if everything was okay and if Adora wanted to talk. Both were answered with a 'not right now'.

"Do you really want to do that?" Glimmer asks. "It's like two a.m., ya know."

"I know but maybe it'll help. I have a lot on my mind and it won't shut up," Adora tells her.

"Are you thinking about your family? Was it okay that I brought Adam?"

"Yes and yes. I can't get them off my mind but I am so, so, *so* happy you brought Adam over. It's the best damn surprise I have ever gotten in my life!" Adora can still feel her nerves tingling with excitement over the fact she finally has met someone in her family. Maybe that's another reason she cannot find sleep. "I love you for that and owe you the whole world. But…I don't know. Brain's being dumb."

"Do you want me to punch it?"

Adora snorts. "Well that might also knock me out, which I need. But nah. I'm just gonna shower."

"Okay." Glimmer quickly pecks her temple. "Shout if you need anything, alright?"

"Will do."

Adora slips out of bed. She carefully crosses the hall and into the bathroom. The moment she shuts the door, she snags a towel off the rack and sets herself up. She tweaks the faucets until the temperature is just right. Stripping down, Adora steps into the near boiling water. Steam already has begun to fill the room as she enters.

Adora doesn't bother to wash her body or hair. Instead, she lets the water massage her body. The noise of it spraying out and hitting her body, the walls, and floor fills her ears. Though, not enough to drown out the world down below. Through one white noise, she can hear another. The movement of her brother.

It's an odd feeling to have him back in her life. A piece that was missing now has settled back in its rightful place. Yet, after so many years of not having it, of being used to the void, having it filled doesn't feel right. Adora wonders how long it will take for the awkwardness to fade away. She wonders if it will *ever* disappear.

Adora buries her face into her palms, not caring about the water entering her nose. Only hours before, wasn't she crying into Adam's shoulder, overcome with seeing him in the flesh for the first time in *years?* Where did all of that go and why was it replaced with a spiky ball of anxiety? Adora dares not think about the implications of him now aiding with stopping Shadow Weaver. That is a whole different bag of emotions that she doesn't want to deal with currently.

These past few days sure have been a whirlwind, haven't they?

After some time and realizing the water is not helping her in the slightest, Adora exits. She begins to dry herself off with her towel, letting her hair remain damp. As she puts her pajama pants back on, she catches herself in the reflection of the mirror in the corner of her eye. The scars on her chin reflect back at her in the pale, artificial light. With the position she is in, body pointing towards

the door, Adora can make out parts of their twin siblings on their back. And, of course, the bite mark on her shoulder.

Adora sighs, taking a closer look at her body. How long has it been since she took a good look at herself? Too long, if she cannot recall. The scars have not changed. Always, they'll be a reminder of the nights she was attacked by those she deemed family. At least the bags that hang under her eyes aren't that noticeable. At least she doesn't look like total shit for once.

She places a hand against her right shoulder. If she never got this, she never would have these mixed feelings on her family. She never would have been assaulted by her sister. She could have grown up happy and not frightened of the moon every month. Wouldn't that be something?

Yet…what about Glimmer? What about the others like Bow, Perfuma, Scorpia, Mermista, and Sea Hawk? What on earth would her life be like if she never met them? If she never fell in love with the hunter? Adora dare not think about that reality without the love of her life.

Knock, knock!

"Adora." Glimmer's voice quietly enters the room. "Can I come in?"

"Yeah, hon. It's unlocked."

Glimmer fiddles with the doorknob for a moment. When the door opens and her eyes land on the blonde, she takes a step back. "You okay with me here?"

Adora blinks. Of course she is! Why wouldn't she be? But then her brain remembers her shirt still lies on the sink counter. Adora can only shrug. "How many times have you seen me fully naked because of the shifts? It's okay."

"Just wanted to make sure." Glimmer enters, shutting the door behind her. As Adora turns to face her reflection full on, her girlfriend stands besides her. "How was the shower? Did it help?"

“It was fine and a little? Not really? I don’t know.” Adora answers honestly. “My mind still is a mess.”

“Still thinking about your family? Like about what Adam said before?”

“Yeah. Kind of wondering about some ‘what-ifs’. And ya know, I don’t have the best experience really with siblings. What the hell do I say to him? We both have been waiting for this and what if I fuck it up somehow?”

Glimmer steps behind Adora, wrapping soft yet strong arms around her waist. Adora feels her girlfriend's lips press against the soft curve of her shoulders, calloused by the scars that littered her body. There is only a brief moment where only arms connect them. The next thing Adora knows is Glimmer pressing her forehead against her back. “I heard him before. He might still be up. Do you want to go see him? I know it’s weird, but you're gonna have to do it and he *is* your brother. That has to count for something.”

Adora leans back slightly, doing everything in her power to be as close as possible to Glimmer. Her eyes remain on her reflection. “Doesn’t it seem weird, though? I don’t know anything about him and it feels like it’s just a giant sleepover! Who has a sleepover with their brother?!?”

“I wouldn’t really know. But Bow’s down there. Though, he is probably out cold.”

Adora snorts. “I wish I could do that.”

“Do you hear Adam still? You think he’s actually up?”

Adora tilts her head, eyes shutting. With the moon near completion, everything is on high alert. Down below, she can make out the static of TV chatter. The low volume makes it impossible to differentiate the words being spoken. She strains herself. Faintly, she can hear the coffee table scraping against the floor. Eyes flutter open.

“Pretty sure he is. Do you want to come down with me if I go?”

“You should go down first, by yourself.” Glimmer whispers. “I spent a whole day with him. You need some alone time with Adam before I come down. Don’t forget what I said about knowing and not knowing. You can do this. Though, if you *really* want me with you, I’ll come.”

Adora thinks for a moment. Hasn’t she wanted this for *years?* To meet her birth family? This opportunity to start fresh(ish), have the family she always yearned for. And at least if anything were to go awry somehow, not only is Glimmer here but Bow as well. They’ll have her back no matter what happens. With a deep breath, she slowly removes herself from the hunter’s grasp. On her heels, she spins. The moment she stops, her lips softly land on Glimmer’s forehead.

“Okay. I’ll go down first. You can come down later, I’ll let you know.”

“I’m here if you need anything.”

“Thanks, hon.”

Adora pulls on her shirt and leaves. As she begins to trek down the stairs, careful of the squeaky boards, she pauses. Looking over her shoulder, Adora’s eyes land on Glimmer. The hunter rests against the wall. Her own eyes are soft and there are twinkles of reassuring lights in them. They alone give her the confidence to finish walking down the stairs. When feet plant themselves on the flooring, she takes one last deep breath.

The living room is dark, the only glow coming from the TV screen. The volume remains low, only now can she really hear what is going on. Upon stepping up behind the couch, she can see what is playing. Adam has turned on some old TV show. Adora narrows her eyes, trying to figure out what on earth he is watching.

“Is that that vampire hunting show or whatever?

Adam yelps, almost falling off the couch as he jumps in the air. Adora cannot help but snicker at the look of shock on her brother's face. He blinks, mouth agape, before asking, "How long have you been standing there?!? I didn't hear you!"

Adora snorts. "Looks like you gotta get super hearing. But no, I just got down here. I heard you, so I, uh," she rubs the back of her neck, "came to see how you were. Can't sleep?"

"Not really? I've always liked staying up. What about you? When did you become a night owl?"

"Never. I was the one who couldn't sleep."

"Do you want to sit?"

Adora gives a small nod before plopping down on the couch. She tucks her legs under her as she leans against the armrest. The show continues, leaving Adora more and more lost. She makes a mental note to ask Glimmer how much of this is real and how much isn't. A lot probably falls in the latter category.

"Have you ever met a vampire before?" Adam suddenly asks.

"Once. When I went to another town with Glimmer. Some bar with hunters and non-humans, but I didn't really talk much to them. Have you ever?"

Adam shakes his head. "No. I never met anyone like that other than you, really. I learned what I could, we all did, but Mom and Pa were pretty protective. I can't blame them for it. I tried to do more when I went to college, but school got in the way. Once I finished, I didn't know where to look."

"Glimmer could teach you some things about being a hunter. If you're gonna help us with Shadow Weaver, you should learn how to protect yourself. We don't need you to get hurt or killed in this mess."

"That would be fun to learn. I used to do some karate, though I'm rusty. I guess football counts. That's about it."

Adora only smiles, not really knowing what to say. A small bit of comfort washes over her knowing that her brother isn't entirely defenseless.

"I guess you're not used to having a sibling around," Adam states.

"Actually, no. I…I have a younger sister."

"Oh, right! Glimmer mentioned that, I forgot. Catra, was it? What is she like?"

"Complicated…"

Adora retells her brother about her sister. How she was over the moon finally having a sibling around and their promise to look out for each other. How they only had each other and did everything they could together. When they didn't want to do their school work, they'd find things to do. Sometimes, getting them in trouble. She chuckles, remembering the time they accidentally got stuck in the attic for a whole afternoon. They thought for sure they would have to spend the night up in the dark, dusty, and claustrophobic place, but when their mother returned home she rescued them–much to her displeasure.

Slowly, she gets to the messy parts. The decay of their relationship, the way Catra would blame her for minor mistakes and lash out. The one time her sister *forced* a shift on her out of jealousy and anger. How she was the one to give Adora the pale scars not only on the side of her face, but straight down her back as well. She has to pause for a moment to wipe away tears that threaten to fall.

The memory continues to haunt her.

"She came back into my life a couple months ago. Literally just knocked on the door and showed up. Gave her a good punch the

second I saw her.” Adora states.

“Good for you.”

“It definitely felt good, I’ll tell ya that. Anyway, she has been helping out. Told us it was our mother who was doing all the attacks and killings. She hasn’t tried to attack anyone or showed signs of double crossing us. Has been trying to help in any way she can actually. She’s not in Brightmoon currently. Don’t know where exactly but she is doing her own investigation.”

“That’s good at least, right? I guess a better question is, how do *you* feel about her?”

“That has the same answer. Complicated! I’m glad she got away from our mother and is trying to better herself. Without her, we might not have known who was doing all this. But…” she brushes her fingers against the side of her face, tips feeling her scars, “it’s hard.”

“I bet. I would kind of like to meet her. Get to know her myself! She was your sister for a long time, maybe I can gain a little sister also!” Adam gives a goofy smile.

“Ya know, that means you become the middle child, right?” Adora jokes back.

"Hm." Adam begins to tap his chin. "Do I want to be the middle child? You know what? I don't mind that! It would be cool having two sisters!"

He begins to laugh, snorts joining in. At first, Adora rolls her eyes. He just got one sister back in his life and now he wants *another?!?* However, she quickly rids herself of the thought. Adam's laugh becomes infectious and she joins in as well.

"We have to see if Cat likes the idea first," Adora states between laughs. "She might not be happy having two older siblings."

"That makes it even more fun!" Adam replies. "It would be fun to annoy her!"

“Trust me, I would love that.”

Slowly, the laughter dies down. Adora begins to feel sleep creep along on her bones. Try as she might, she cannot stop a yawn from escaping her lips. She slaps a hand over her mouth to stifle the sound, but it only can do so much. “Sorry,” Adora apologizes.

“There’s nothing to apologize for. Why don’t you go back to bed? I don’t know when I’ll be going to bed. We always have the morning to talk more. I bet Glimmer probably can’t sleep without you.”

“Tch. She’s not asleep. She’s like you and could stay up to the ass crack of dawn before going to bed. And I know this because she did that once. I woke up as she was going to bed.”

Adam snorts. “Good to know I’ll have a buddy when everyone else is dead. But seriously, go up.”

Adora gives a small nod. She lifts her heavy body off the couch, yawning again. Just as she is about to leave the living room and return to the warmth of her shared bed, Adam’s voice stops her.

“Adora?”

She looks over her shoulder. Adam stares right at her, leaning the upper half of his body against the top of the couch. “I love you.”

For a moment, Adora tenses up. Her brain scrambles for an answer on what to say towards the brother she forgot all about. But the three words begin to take up comfortable residence inside her mind. Her body begins to loosen and a soft smile appears on her face. The next set of words come out almost like second nature. “I love you too, Adam.”

When Bow leaves the next morning, Adam moves his things into the spare bedroom. No one knows how long he will be staying, thus, it becomes 'Adam's room'. He comes up with some lie to tell his parents and judging by what he states, they buy it. At least that is out of the way.

As the days pass, the others learn about Adam's existence. There is no point in hiding him from the others. Everyone has their own reactions to the fact that Adora has a brother. Scorpia gives one of her famous, spine breaking hugs. Sea Hawk becomes extra eager in meeting a fellow trans man. The two hit it off quite well. Meanwhile, Perfuma and Mermista are a little more relaxed in their response.

Mermista gives a simple congrats to them and is happy to know what on earth Glimmer was doing the other day when she asked for help. Perfuma is overjoyed that Adora finally is able to connect with a family member and can't wait to hear about how the twins begin to bond.

As for said bonding, Glimmer remains close to Adora as she gets used to having her brother around. Adam himself has to get used to his sister. It starts off slow, trying to find things in common. While they each like their own type of sweet, chocolate versus sour, they enjoy the fact that both have a craving for such things. There is a love for video games, though Adam has a slight upper hand and enjoys annoying his sister whenever he wins. However, Adora gets her payback in a wrestling match. The hunter can't help but laugh when her girlfriend wins.

As the days move forward and the moon inches its way closer to completion, Glimmer finds herself cleaning off her crossbow and checking over all her supplies. It's been a little while since her last overview. She makes a mental note to start setting a better schedule for herself. The sun has begun to set as she works on the kitchen island. Glimmer pays little mind to what is going on around her. Adora is somewhere in the house and Adam—

"What are you doing?"

Glimmer snaps up from her work, having just finished assembling her crossbow. Adam hovers near her, head tilted and eyes fixated on what is laid out in front of him. He brushes a hand against one of her arrows.

“Just going over some stuff,” Glimmer replies.

“Is this part of your hunter stuff?”

“Yeah. I know you said you only learned so much with the supernatural world but what about hunters?”

Adam shakes his head. “No. I told Adora it, I don’t know if she told you, but my parents were overprotective, so I never got to learn much. I wanted to, but I also didn’t want to worry my parents.”

"Do you want to learn now? You know, you probably should.”

His dark eyes light up just like his sister whenever she gets excited. Adam begins to bounce on his feet. “Hell yeah I do!”

Glimmer snorts. *Guess dorkiness runs in the family.* “Alright well, for starters,” she reaches for a vial with dark powder, “you know what this is?”

Adam takes it, giving the glass a small shake. “No. What is it?”

“A type of wolfsbane. We used to use that one to knock Adora out when she was out of control.” Glimmer gestures to other vials, filled with other types of powder. Some have begun to grow low. She’ll either have to go out and buy some, or hunt for them out in the woods. The latter definitely is a pain in the ass, especially when the weather continues to remain freezing.

Glimmer continues. “Thankfully, we haven’t had to use it in a while. Hopefully, we don’t ever have to use it again.”

Adam suddenly begins sneezing. Glimmer snaps her head up and finds that the vial is open. Her new guest rubs his nose rapidly. He

groans before turning his attention to a wide-eyed Glimmer. “That actually smells bad.”

“You did *not* actually just smell that! Why?!?”

Adam only gives a small shrug. Doing so sends a bit of powder right into Glimmer’s face. Almost immediately, the hunter begins sneezing like there is no tomorrow. She stumbles back, seeking cleaner air. By the time she regains control of her breathing, there is a slight ache in her chest and her nose itches. Glimmer mumbles a curse under her breath.

“Are you okay?!?” Adam asks. He closes the vial and places it back down on the table. “That was a hell of a sneezing fit.”

“I’m fine. I’m just allergic,” Glimmer admits.

“Huh, really? Is that because you are part werepanther?”

“Yeah. One of the more annoying things about it. Why don’t we move on? There’s a lot to show you.”

Glimmer continues her lessons. She tells Adam about her different equipment. Her long, handheld taser, the noise emitters she hasn’t used much, and her silver knife. The hunter has been meaning to add to her arsenal but, with everything going on, time has been hard to find. Finally, she gets to her crossbow. Freshly cleaned, she is eager to tell him all about it.

She has had it for quite some time. There are a number of nicks on the wood, ones she refuses to get rid of. Glimmer tells him how her mother used the same type of weapon and taught her almost everything she knows. Adam listens to it all. Once she is done, having almost gone off on a tangent, Glimmer asks if he has any questions.

He only has one. If he can hold it.

“Sure. Just be careful with her. Actually, ya know what,” Glimmer begins to grab one of her arrows. “Let me show you how to load

it.”

“You’re gonna do that indoors?”

“No one is around. And as long as you keep your finger off the trigger, it should be fine. Here ya go!”

Adam takes the weapon. He feels the weight against his palms. It may not look like it but Glimmer’s weapon is heavier than you’d think. She begins to tell him how to hold it right and how to look through the scope. Adam nods and does as he is told, twisting his torso as he looks around the room.

As he is looking around, focusing his breathing, a new noise fills the room.

“Yo,” Adora’s voice says. She appears out from a hallway, her eyes locked onto her phone. “What are we getting for din-”

Before she can finish, Glimmer’s crossbow goes off. It sails through the air at a quick speed. Adora yelps as she jumps out of the way, giving her a large amount of breathing room. The arrow implants itself in a nearby wall.

Glimmer’s eyes widened more than ever. She feels her heart stop dead in her chest at the miss her girlfriend just had. Adora's face is full of shock, her jaw almost on the ground. Though, as she turns her head to face her girlfriend and brother, she closes her mouth as her face turns into that of disbelief and mild annoyance.

Glimmer begins to turn her own head. The first thing she sees is the same expression on Adam’s face that she has on. But then, the hunter notices he is pointing a finger at her, the crossbow lowered.

“Hey! Don’t pin this on me!” Glimmer snaps.

“You’re the one that handed it to me!” Adam replies.

“I told you not to have your finger on the trigger!”

“I really want to know why both of you thought this was a good idea.” Adora sighs. She walks over to the wall and removes the arrow embedded in it. Once in her hands, the blonde joins her brother and girlfriend, slapping the arrow on the counter. She takes a glance at Adam. “Your aim needs improving.”

“Good to know.”

“You have a good teacher.” Adora turns to face Glimmer, that wide, crooked smile plastered on her face.

Glimmer feels a blush spreading across her face. She begins to pack up her gear, carefully stowing it away. Just as she is about to finish up, Adam taps on the last item on the counter. Angella’s book.

“What’s this?” he asks.

“Ah!” Glimmer snatches it instinctively. Hands clutch it close to her chest. When Adam blinks in surprise, she takes a breath, lowering her shoulders. “Sorry. It’s my mother’s.”

“Oh! I’m sorry.”

“No. It’s okay.” Glimmer sets the book back down, allowing herself to feel the worn leather against the tips of her fingers. “Hunters will write down things in their notebooks. I have one with half the pages on Adora. Sometimes, we write it in other languages in case some idiot finds it. However, she wrote it in one I do not know! Latin!”

“We’ve been trying for quite awhile to figure out what it says, but we haven’t had any sort of luck,” Adora admits.

“Oh, I know some!”

“ *You what?!?”* Both Adora and Glimmer say together.

Adam nods. He takes the book off the counter and begins flipping through the pages. “I’m not the best, I wouldn’t say I am totally *fluent,* but I know enough I could understand this. Plus, I can look up the ones I don’t know. It’s gonna take me time, but I think I can do it.”

“You sure are full of surprises,” Glimmer says. “Gonna owe you one for this.”

“No. Don’t. I am here to help, aren’t I? I can’t turn into a super powerful creature, I’m rusty on fighting, and I need to learn weaponry. If this,” he points at the book, “is how I can help, then I am going to do it!”

“Well, this is still great news! You have no idea how much this means to me!” Glimmer’s mind races with all the ideas that could be inside. Maybe there can be notes about Shadow Weaver. Hadn’t she been looking into things before her death? And what about everything else? So much knowledge hidden away that can finally be unlocked! “We have to repay you somehow!”

“Like how?”

“Well, I never got to ask what we wanted for dinner,” Adora says. “How about we make your favorite?”

“Putting me on the spot? Thanks...” Adam taps a finger against his chin. “How about some sausage and biscuits? I’m not picky, so it’s the first thing that popped into my head.”

“Delicious!” Adora hums.

“I guess I should start chipping away at this.” Adam flicks his wrist a little for emphasis. However, he ends up doing it a bit too hard and the book flies out of his hands, tumbling down onto the ground. His face turns a bright red as he forces a laugh. “Whoops!”

Glimmer pinches the bridge of her nose. “You’re definitely not touching my weapons without me watching.”

"Still like this, huh?" Adam asks. He sits on the counter, legs swinging under him. In his hands, he rolls a half eaten apple.

"Never not gonna hurt," Adora grits through her teeth. Her body shakes as she breaks out into a cold sweat. "Don't even k-know what it's like to n-not deal with it."

Glimmer runs her fingers through Adora's dark blonde locks. Her girlfriend's head rests in her lap. Every time Adora's body jerks too hard, the hunter gives a squeeze of her hand. She can only hope it takes away *some* of her pain.

Bow, having come over for the night, stands nearby, waiting to lend his aid. He has begun to have a stomach for this. Though, he remains a little pale. "At least we don't have to chain you up anymore."

"I still can't believe you guys had to do that." Adam says. "Sure, Adora got aggressive with us, but never *killer,* except that one time."

"I-I have a g-good reason why I-I d-don't anymore." Adora flicks up her eyes. The skies that are her irises are losing out to the golden suns. Even with the drops of tears inside them, Glimmer can see the warm, loving lights. Somehow, her girlfriend manages to flash her famous grin.

Glimmer returns the smile. "Glad I can help."

Adora winces as the trembles become worse. Her body curls in on itself, ready to split apart. When it finally does, Glimmer stands to her feet. She remains close by, never taking her eyes off of Adora's transforming body. The transformation, as always, is over quickly. In Adora's place is her large, furry, werewolf self. For a moment, she attempts to get onto shaking feet. However, they slip right out from under her.

"Hey! Easy!" Glimmer kneels down on the ground, rubbing Adora's back. "Don't have to get up that fast, love."

Adora whines through her nose. Her golden eyes become puppy-dog-like. She jabs her large muzzle into Glimmer’s chest, ears falling flat on her head. The hunter pats the top of Adora’s head. “Let’s go slowly.”

Glimmer helps Adora onto her large, awkward paws. She gives herself a good shake, fluffing out her dark golden pelt. The torn up clothing on her body falls off (with Glimmer helping to pull it off). Done, she spins around and gives the hunter a large, slobbery kiss. Glimmer groans at the feeling, quickly wiping off her face. “You and your kisses.”

Adora barks. Her tongue rolls out of the side of her mouth and her tail begins to wag rapidly back and forth. She begins to look around the room. Eyes go from Glimmer, to Bow, and then onto Adam. The hunter looks at him as well, seeing the surprise and awe written all over his face.

“You weren’t kidding," Adam gasps. He hops off the counter. Slowly, with some hesitancy to his movements, he walks up to his sister. A hand reaches forward, inching towards Adora's nose.

She begins sniffing every inch of his hand, going as far as forcing her nose between Adam's fingers. Her brother begins to chuckle at the sensation. That is, until Adora throws her whole body weight onto him. Adam smacks down to the ground, pinned under his sister. Glimmer and Bow burst out laughing.

"Are you okay?" Bow asks though his chuckles.

"Can't. Breathe." Adam wheezes.

"She's a big one." Glimmer states. While still laughing, the hunter walks up to the pair of twins. "Adora, get off of him."

Adora gives a woof. Her tail still wagging a mile a second, she pulls herself off of her brother. With her nose now on the ground, Adora begins to move around the lower level of the home.

"Let me help you." Bow is quickly at Adam's side, guiding him back to steady feet.

"Is she always like that?" Adam asks.

"Yup!" Glimmer answers. She sits down at the table, her hand keeping her head upright. Eyes follow the movement of her girlfriend who continues her search for some hidden treasure. "I usually stay up all night to make sure she doesn't need anything or nothing bad happens. I suggest if you are going to do the same, then find something to keep you busy."

Glimmer does so by looking up supplies on hunter websites. Adam grabs the notebook and begins his attempts at translation. While doing so, Bow sits right beside him, wishing to learn. Adam happily does his best to teach the other man words and what they mean.

At least someone is able to learn that language, Glimmer thinks to herself, smiling slightly. She enjoys the sight out in front of her.

In the background, Adora continues her sniffing. Glimmer left out bones and rope toys but none have caught her girlfriend's interest. At one point, Adora begins to head upstairs, escaping the eyes of everyone. The hunter quickly chases after her, calling her back to the lower floor. It doesn't take much of an incentive other than saying her name.

Adora quickly bounds down the steps, nearly missing one and almost tumbles towards the ground. She thankfully lands, albeit ungracefully, on the first floor. Immediately, Adora presses her body up against Glimmer's legs. Bright golden eyes stare up at the hunter. There is the softest of expressions written on her face.

"Stay down here, okay?" Glimmer smiles. She scratches the base of one of Adora's furry ears.

Adora lets out a soft moan, eyes squinting. Happy, the duo head back to join the others. While Glimmer sits down at the table, Adora returns to her sniffing. No one thinks much of all three

humans getting lost in their own things. That is, until the blonde begins to make chewing noises. Glimmer does not pay much notice to it until Adam shouts,

“ADORA! What the hell do you have in your mouth?!?”

Glimmer snaps her head up as Adam bolts off of his chair. Adora is some feet away, chewing away on something. Her brother stops short, kneeling down on the ground. He begins to put his hands on his muzzle, surely to pry her jaws wide open, when he stops.

“Is this safe?” he asks. “She isn’t gonna bite me, is she?”

“Let me.” Glimmer chuckles a little as she pushes herself away from the table and joins Adam on the ground. She removes his hands before replacing them with her own. Carefully, the hunter pulls open Adora’s mouth. Inside, she finds a dust bunny all chewed up. “Ew, gross! Adora, why on earth would you eat this?”

She reaches in and pulls out the lint. The hunter tosses it aside, hoping Adora won’t go after it again. Her attention returns to her girlfriend, who is licking her lips. Glimmer taps a finger between Adora’s eyes. “I know you are a husky right now, but I know you understand me too. Please don’t eat something like that again. Why not chew on your bone?”

Adora gives her a nudge, before sauntering off to chew on something more appropriate. Glimmer softly sighs, before returning to her spot at the table.

“You weren’t afraid of getting bit?” Adam asks.

“Can’t be afraid when she's already done so.”

“What?!?”

Adora whines, suddenly appearing at Glimmer’s side. With her rawhide in her mouth, she places her head on her girlfriend’s lap. While rubbing the top of her head, the hunter tells him about that first night. How Adora escaped and Glimmer chased after her. She

tells him how that attack she survived left her not only with slight powers, but immunity. Bow grumbles a little, pointing out how he and Perfuma had to save Glimmer's ass that night years ago.

Glimmer apologizes for the umpteenth time for the scare she gave him. She returns her attention back to Adam. "Adora definitely felt horrible for biting me, but Perfuma gave me some stuff so I didn't scar. Heck, Adora got out in December when she lost some control, and I went after her, but she didn't attack me. She actually tried to protect me from anything she heard."

"You have been through a lot with her, huh?" Adam asks. "You really care about her."

"Yeah." Glimmer bends down and places a kiss on top of Adora's head. "Yeah, I do. I don't know what I would do if something happened to her."

She is back in her dream world. Most lines are thin, barely able to contain the colors around them. When Adora isn't trying to tear through something as hard as a rock, she messes around with Bow, who loves to test her strength in a one-on-one tug-of-war. Adam sometimes wants to wrestle or throw a ball around. Other times, when she is bold about doing something, he stops her from going too far.

But of course with Glimmer, most of the time Adora is either cuddled up right beside her, pressing her whole body against the hunter's. Or, she is giving her hundreds of kisses, making her girlfriend laugh each and every time. Everytime she hears those giggles, Adora's heart bounces around in her chest. She wishes she could record the noise and play it on repeat.

However, her fun must come to an end. Adora feels her stomach twist into a tight knot. She no longer wants to have fun with her friends and girlfriend. Really, she just wants to lie down and curl up into a tiny ball on the ground. However, Glimmer guides her to someplace much more comfortable. A bed. Her girlfriend remains

with her until suddenly, a fire spreads out all throughout her body.

The next thing Adora knows is the familiar darkness. Though, this time, there are no sounds of children's laughter, the words of adults, or blurry colors running around. Heck, besides the pitch blackness that goes on forever, there is only one other shade to break it all up.

The canine from all the times before stands near. More details can be seen now. It's definitely larger and furrier than she had expected. Lines do not trap the colors inside, instead, their body is made up of like a gas. Their fur wisps away at the ends and their pointed ears stand at attention. Adora squints her eyes, realizing something new. While there are no details, no pupils, eyelids, or true irises, there is a new color where the eyes should be.

They are the same shade as the morning, spring sky.

The canine says nothing as it steps closer, the sandalwood smell filling Adora's nose. She finds herself kneeling down, curious what they want this time. Normally, they have some riddle or random thing to tell her she has to figure out. The silence is uncomfortable. What do they want?

Just as Adora reaches out, feeling tips of the wispy fur, the canine presses its head under her chin. She freezes up as they whisper " *I am proud of you."*

…

When Adora wakes, she gasps, her mind thrown right back into her body. She groans as she slowly pushes herself up, hearing the bed creak under her shifting weight. When a hand rubs an eye to clear the morning sunlight from blinding her, the fingers come back stained in tears.

What the hell?

Adora doesn't have time to think when her phone buzzes. With her ears still readjusting to her 'normal' range, the noise feels like someone is scratching at the inside of her ears and threatening to tear her eardrums apart. Adora quickly clicks the button on its side, not bothering to look at it.

She rubs a temple, trying to push out a growing headache. Adora begins to look around the room, realizing she is in the guest bedroom. At first, Glimmer is nowhere in sight. That is, until Adora realizes half the covers are hanging off the bed. Adora looks over and finds her girlfriend totally and utterly passed out on the ground, her body entangled in the sheets. And, of course, she's snoring.

Adora rolls her eyes, not surprised in the slightest. She crawls off of the bed and begins to collect Glimmer up in her arms. However, a surprise from the hunter catches her off guard. Her girlfriend wraps her arms around Adora's neck and violet eyes flutter open.

"Morning, Starlight," Glimmer mumbles.

"Good morning, Glitter-bug. Sorry if I kicked you out of bed," Adora says in her hoarse voice as she places her down. "You should rest."

"I just need a few minutes. Wake me after your shower."

"I'll see about that."

Adora pecks Glimmer on her cheek. As she begins to make her way to the adjacent bathroom, her phone buzzes again. Really wanting to take a shower before she does anything else, she clicks the button once more. Finally, Adora enters the bathroom to prepare herself for the day.

Her girlfriend has already placed a towel on the shower railing and has a set of clothing ready on the sink. Adora quickly washes off the smell of wolf from her body and allows her brain to fully reboot. She begins to wonder where Adam and Bow are, as she has taken up this room. Guess she'll find out soon enough.

When she is clean and dressed, Adora enters the bedroom again. Glimmer is curled up on the bed, her pink and purple hair a mess. After a moment's debate, she decides to do as she is told. Adora walks up to the bed and gives her girlfriend a shake.

"Get up, sleepy head. I'll make you coffee." Adora says.

Glimmer grumbles but cracks open her eyes. "Give me the biggest cup. I'll be out in ten."

Adora laughs. She exits the room, leaving the door cracked open. She finds Bow has already beaten her to making the coffee and upon spotting her, gives Adora a wave and a smile. The blonde finds her brother sprawled out on the couch, dead to the world. She wonders if by the time the coffee is ready and the smell fills the air, if it will wake him up. Whatever the case, she joins Bow in helping set up for breakfast.

Chapter End Notes

Comments/kudos appreciated

Tick Tock Goes The Clock

Chapter Notes

> got one more chapter after this heh :3. That being said i still have no word on my laptop so after next week yeah idk when I will be posting again we will see but please enjoy this and then the next. This chapter is a bit of a doozy with tw of blood, injury, nightmares, and death/injury/blood within said nightmare and some self hate. ENJOY

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Think they will wake up once they smell the food?" Adora asks as she flips her pancakes. The side that stares up at her is a rich, golden brown color. Beside her, Bow works on getting the bacon at just the right crispness. With all the smells filling the air, the blonde's stomach growls *loudly,* begging her to fill it. It has to be patient.

Bow gives a small shrug. "Maybe. Didn't you say Glimmer was already awake?"

" *Half* awake. They better get up. I'm starving and I might just eat their breakfast."

"Save some for the rest of us," Adam suddenly says. Adora and Bow turn their heads, spotting the other twin only a couple feet away. He yawns, rubbing the back of his head. His hair sticks up all over and his glasses are nowhere in sight. "Your appetite can't be that big."

"It can be. It takes a lot of energy to shift. Now you can either sit down and wait, or help us out," Adora tells her brother.

Adam decides to wait at the table. Adora and Bow continue to finish up their cooking. As they begin to wrap up, placing the food on several plates, Glimmer finally saunters out. Just like Adam, her hair is a total mess and invisible chains cause her feet to drag.

She gives a grunt as a *'good morning'* before heading right to her coffee cup. Adora pecks her girlfriend on her cheek as she passes by. The hunter sits down at the table, drinking her black coffee.

Food is brought and everyone begins to chow down. Adora does her best to hold back from totally wolfing down on her food. No matter how much she swallows, her stomach continues to growl and beg for more. Not being satisfied, she decides to rummage around in the fridge. Pulling out the vegetable drawer, she finds some bananas (gross), a few apples, and some oranges. Adora decides to grab the last on the list. Fingernails break through the skin and she begins to peel it off.

As she tosses the skin into the trash, the ringtone from Glimmer's phone blares in her ears. Adora winces, guessing her senses do not want to settle. With one hand holding onto her food, the other slaps over the ear closest to the noise. Twisting her head slightly, she sees Glimmer checking her phone. Violet eyes suddenly widen, any sleep inside them disappearing in an instant. With bacon still in her mouth, the hunter answers.

"Hello?" she asks.

Not thinking much of it, Adora returns to peeling her food. Now it's time to eat the small, juicy wedges. She rejoins the rest of the group at the table, though remains standing. "Sorry you got kicked onto the couch again, Adam. Though, how much did you guys sleep anyway?"

"I went to bed a couple hours before dawn, I couldn't make it," Bow states. He had slept in the living room in the sleeping bag he brought from home.

"I dunno how long I slept. Maybe like an hour. I'm used to all-nighters though," Adam adds. "I didn't realize how much of a handful you were gonna be."

"Tch. Thanks. Here's something neat to show you. Bow! Real or not real, did I try eating someone's shoes?"

“Not. It was some dust bunnies.” Bow replies. "Glimmer reached into your mouth to get it out."

“So you’re still having those ‘dreams’, I take it.”

“Might not seem like it, but I am pretty sure that I am getting better at remembering!”

Adora has her mouth open, ready to say more, when Glimmer suddenly stands, cutting her off. The force of her movement knocks over her chair, which smacks hard against the ground. A hand slams on the table, causing all the silverware to jump and shake. “Slow down! Where the hell are you?”

Adora, Adam, and Bow all exchange worried glances with each other as they listen to Glimmer’s side of the conversation.

“Can you turn on your location?” … “We can’t find you without it!” … “Okay. Okay, we will get there soon.” … “Just don’t die on us! Call again if anything else happens.”

Glimmer removes the phone from her ear. Fingers quickly type away on the screen. Without looking up, she says, “We have to go. *Now* !”

“Why?” Adora asks. Her heart begins to race. Glimmer is oozing out the smell of anxiety and fear. “What’s going on?”

Glimmer slowly looks up from her phone. A frown has formed on her face and her eyes are glistening with concern. “Adora. It’s Catra. She’s been trying to contact us all morning.”

“What? Why? Is she okay? Did she find more information? What the hell is going on? I thought she was at Crimson Valley?”

“She is, but,” Glimmer bites down on her lip, “Adora…She got attacked by Shadow Weaver.”

“What?!?” Adora gasps. A hand shoots out, gripping the table as her legs suddenly lose their balance. She neither expected to hear

something about her mother this fast nor expected to hear that her sister was hurt. Her mind spins around, trying to understand everything that has happened. Despite knowing who her mother is, despite knowing how she had little care for Catra, the fact that Shadow Weaver attacked her own daughter sends *chills* down her spine.

Why?

'Why' is the million dollar question to a lot of her mother's actions…

"Adora? Are you okay?" Bow's voice enters her ears. She can see him out of the corner of her eye, yet he sounds like he is upstairs. When fingers brush against her shoulders, Adora jerks away. The touch is like tiny needles have been shot right through her.

"D-Don't touch me. Please," Adora requests.

"Adora, you are pale. You should sit." Adam says.

Adora shakes her head. She feels if she were to sit down, the spinning would worsen. As she continues to struggle to understand what is happening, one thought finally sinks its claws into her brain long enough for it to be coherent. Glimmer's words begin to echo.

'She's been trying to contact us all morning.'

Her legs begin to move without her command. The next thing she knows, Adora is in the guest bedroom, fingers fumbling for her phone that she left on the nightstand. Unlocking it, sure enough there are messages all from a number she doesn't have saved. All from Catra, all telling her to *'pick up the fucking phone'* .

And, there are three voicemails. Adora types away her password and listens to them.

New Message: *Yo, Adora. Mind picking up the phone? You have to be waking up by now. I…I ne-...Help would be nice right about*

now. You're gonna laugh at it! Call me back or answer your text.

New Message: *Adora! You cannot still be out cold, I know you have some control! Pick up! It's colder than a witch's tit out here! I don't know if I am gonna die of blood loss, or hypothermia, or both! Oh right yeah, Mom fucked me up. So call me the fuck back already.*

The final message has Catra's voice small like a child's and filled with tears.

New Message: *Adora… **Please** pick up! I need help! I…I need **your** help. I'm gonna try your g-girlfriend but my phone is low! I have…I have to save battery. P-Please. Please come…*

The automated voice telling her there are no more messages is barely heard in her ears. Instead, Catra's broken and small voice rings, drowning everything out. Adora's body begins to tremble. It starts at her hands, spreading to her arms, then her torso, and finally to her legs. A million and half images flash through her mind of her time with her sister. The good, the bad, the brilliant, and the ugly. Their playful and hateful fights. Their time spent in their forts and all the doors slammed in the other's face. The night the werepanther assaulted her, pinning her to the earth as she scarred her with venom in her words. And the day Catra first entered her life.

'Sisters forever? Promise?'

'I promise, Adora.'

Fuck!

Everyone races to get ready as soon as possible. Breakfast is canceled. Any food that is left on the table is shoved into mouths before everyone bolts out of the house. They pile into the car, Adora in the passenger seat and Glimmer in the driver's seat, while Bow and Adam jump into the back. The hunter wastes no time at all booking it out of the driveway.

As Glimmer zips down the street, she tosses her phone to Adora, telling her how to check Catra's location within an app. Fingers struggle to type. She nearly drops it several times in her attempt to find her sister. Somehow, after a couple of attempts, Adora is able to begin finding the location of her sister. The screen in her hands buffers for several moments before giving her the exact pinpoint.

Sure enough, she is in Crimson Valley. A forty-five minute drive normally (give or take), just past Bow's hometown. Though, with the way Glimmer is driving, as long as they do not get pulled over, that time will be cut maybe in half. The sooner they get there, the better. With Catra's phone low on battery, Adora wonders when this blip on her screen will disappear. Judging by the position, she is a good distance in the forest. Without this, one wrong step will lead down the wrong path. Which leads to the next, and most pressing issue.

The sun continues to rise in the sky, barely giving an inkling of warmth. While some has begun to melt, snow still coats the earth in its frozen substance. Even when the world fully wakes up, the temperature is not expected to reach above freezing, or hell, even freezing itself! Back in her human form, with no fur to her name, Catra might become a popsicle. And then there is her mention about being hurt. Seeing how badly Petra was beaten after their encounter with Shadow Weaver, what the hell is Catra going to be like?

Adora attempts deep breaths. Attempts to slow her racing heart and mind. Attempts not to think of the worst possible cases; that Shadow Weaver is lying in wait for the others to come. Even if she is in her human form, who knows what she has up her sleeve. Then of course, the thought of Catra dying. Of being too late in reaching her. Despite their current relationship status, one where Adora has her sister at arms length, and is not ready to lower her arms, the last thing the blonde *ever* wants is for her sister to be *murdered.*

A soft hand settles on her thigh. All thoughts stop in their tracks, skidding to a halt. Even her heart refuses to move an inch. The only thing that doesn't want to settle is her hand that clenches her girlfriend's phone. It's so tight in her grasp, she swears she could shatter it. Looking down, she spots the hand that has landed on her. Following the arm attached, she sees it belongs to Glimmer. Her eyes remain on the road as she begins to rub her thumb against Adora's jeans.

"What a way to start our morning, huh?" The hunter says with the slightest of chuckles.

"Tell me about it!" Adam sticks his head between the gap of the front seats. "Are mornings after a shift always filled with shit happening?"

"Not always. Though, the quiet stuff isn't always good." Bow answers. "Kind of scary when we don't know what is going on."

"We will always figure something out, right?" Glimmer states. "Shadow Weaver hasn't stopped us yet!"

Adora can smell the fear and anxiety filling the car. It is almost *suffocating* . She is barely able to breathe with everything pressing down on her. However, mixed in, there is the scent of comfort. Everyone's nerves are running wild, everyone knows the severity of the situation, and everyone knows what it means for *her.* Yet, despite it all, the others are trying their best to give her some semblance of reassurance.

She takes a deep breath, which does little to nothing at all. Adora doesn't bother to force a smile but still says, "Thanks guys."

"Catra sure likes to be a pain, huh?" Glimmer continues to joke. She removes her hand from Adora's thigh and places it back on the steering wheel. "Depending on what she did, I might have to chew her out. Like say, if she went after Shadow Weaver on purpose. She knows how dangerous she is, and I'll definitely get after her for giving you a heart attack."

“Same!” Bow and Adam say in the back.

This time, Adora *does* smile. It’s not forced at all, but it remains small. The corners of her lips barely twitch upward, but it’s better than nothing. Leaning back in her seat, she stares out the window. Her leg bounces as the world zips by, the scenery becoming different from what she is used to. Every now and again, she checks the phone in her hand. Catra has not moved, nor has the dot of her location disappeared. As long as it remains there, the smallest of weights remains off of her chest.

After what seems like forever, as if a whole lifetime has passed her by, the group makes it to Crimson Valley. Adora must wait for several more minutes to reach the area, roughly, where her sister is located. The longer she remains in the car, the faster her leg moves. It could rocket off her body at the rate it is going. After several more long, agonizing minutes, they come within range.

The moment the car comes to a halt, Adora throws open the door. She stares at the forest entrance, mere feet away from her. With all the hemlocks and pines bearing green needles, it looks nothing like the bare trees of the Whispering Woods. Adora doesn’t think she sees any deciduous trees anywhere. Their branches, some low to the ground, conceal what secrets it hides inside. Somewhere in there, Catra is hurt and fighting off hypothermia. Somewhere, she is fighting off death. She wonders if *also* hidden within, is her mother.

Adora gulps at the thought of having to come face to face with Shadow Weaver. Missing her when she attacked Petra was already too close of a call. Even if one day she will have to stop Shadow Weaver, this is far too fast, far too soon. Hands curl into tight fists.

“Do you think we should split up?” Adam asks, as he steps up to his sister.

“Not until we get closer,” Glimmer replies. “We don’t want someone else getting lost here.”

After checking the phone one last time, everyone darts into thick forest. Being the fastest, Adora leads the way. She pushes away the branches that threaten to smack her in the face, warning everyone about them in turn. Some hidden roots threaten to trip and cause someone to face plant into the ground. Somehow, no one does as such. At most, there are only a couple stumbles.

Things begin to fall apart when Catra's location suddenly disappears from the map. Despite having grown quite close, the fear of becoming lost truly sets in. If they guess wrong, that will be it. Catra will be dead, and they will be lost. Adora curses and kicks up a bunch of ice and snow. After some debating and judging by what they saw last, the group heads off in one direction.

Somehow, *thankfully* , they guessed right. The strong, musky smell of two different werecreatures, and the metallic scent of blood fills Adora's nose. Many emotions hang in the air. Anger, hate, terror, and confusion. Out in front of her is a mess. Snow and ice are broken up all over the place. So much so, that some of the dead grass is exposed, and dirt mixes into the mess. Slashes bore deep into tree bark, and several branches and green needles sprinkle the ground. Blended in all over is the bright, crimson red of blood. A good amount of it. Adora cannot tell who it belongs to.

Now it is time to split up. Adora begins to shout for her sister. No answer. With so many different scents all around her, she cannot locate Catra's at all. No matter how hard she attempts to focus, she cannot differentiate between everything to tell what is hers. The only thing she knows for sure is there is not the scent of death in the air. At least, not yet.

The others disappear from sight, but not from hearing range. Adora listens as they trudge through the snow or call out Catra's name. Still, there is not a peep nor sighting from the werecreature. Any and all tracks are impossible to make heads or tails out of. Everything is a mess, just like Adora's insides. She begins to wonder if her mother didn't kill Catra on purpose, just

so her daughter could suffer. The blonde wouldn't be shocked if that is the case.

Suddenly, Adam shouts, calling out to his sister. Adora wastes no time in racing over. Feet struggle to find traction for a moment before they are able to send her through the gaps between trees. She cares little for the branches smacking her in her face and the needles that must find their way into her hair. By the time she crashes through into a small opening, she is almost out of breath.

Adam stands under a large fir tree, his back turned to his sister. His jacket has been stripped from his body, leaving him only in a long sleeve shirt. Said article of clothing now lies on the person perched up on the base of the tree. Catra.

Even with the jacket covering her torso, wounds are all over Catra's body. Her arms, legs, and even face are cut up. The worst are the claw marks on her right eye. Both of them are shut at the moment, but the blonde has a feeling that whenever her sister tries to open them, only her amber eye would be able to do so. With the slow movement of her chest lifting the jacket, at least she is still breathing. She is still alive.

"Cat!" Adora runs over towards her sister. As she nears, she falls to her knees, letting momentum guide her the rest of the way. She comes to a halt barely half a foot away. The moment she stops, she can't help but give her sister a quick, yet tight, squeeze. "I can't believe we found you!"

Adora hears Glimmer and Bow entering the area from behind as she lets go of her sister. She doesn't turn, keeping her eyes on her sister as she says, "Catra! Can you hear me? Can you wake up?!"

Her sister suddenly groans. There is a roughness to her voice as she speaks. "Jesus, do you have to be so loud?"

"Oh, thank god," Adora breathes out.

Catra shifts slightly, pulling her head into an upright position. For a moment, both eyes open. However, the blood from the injury to

her right forces it closed. Only an amber color scans the area, taking in everyone that stares at her. When it lands on Adam, it grows wide. Back and forth, Catra goes between the twins.

"Did Mom give me a concussion? Why the fuck do I see two of you, Adora?"

"That's my twin brother. I kind of only recently found out he existed." Adora answers.

"Ah, great! Now I have two idiot siblings?!? One of you was bad enough to cause trouble!"

Adora can't help but snort. The tone is far from harsh. More of an annoying tease. Catra even rolls her good eye at the revelation. This causes Adora's snorts to turn into a small bit of laughter. Some tears from both her chuckles and her relief begin to roll down the sides of her face. "You're one to talk!" Adora retorts. "Have you seen yourself? And *I* cause trouble?"

It's Catra's turn to laugh. "You got me there!" Suddenly, she shivers. "Fuck, it's freezing out here!"

"We have a car, that'll warm you up." Glimmer says.

"I live, like, fifteen minutes away from here. We can go to my house and get you cleaned up," Bow offers.

Catra shakes her head. "I appreciate that, really, but…There is somewhere closer. Like, five minutes or so away. Someone I know lives here, and I have been staying on their couch the past couple days."

"Really, who?" Adora asks.

"A minotaur named Huntara. Met her a little after I left Mom. Knocked some sense into me and taught me some shit. Hardass, but a good hardass."

"Let me help you up."

Adam scoops her up. Catra does mutter a '*My legs aren't broken'*, but doesn't truly protest being carried. It barely seems like she is able to keep her good eye open. Everyone begins to follow the path previously made, not saying much to each other. Not even Catra has any other quips to say. As they walk, this time Adam being in the lead, Adora holds both Glimmer's and Bow's hands in her own, squeezing them tight. They stay by her for the whole trek back.

When they reach the car, Adora and Bow switch places per request from the blonde. He hesitates at first, wanting to make sure she is alright with this idea. Adora reassures him it is okay, and that she does indeed want to sit in the back seat. With no time to waste, no one argues with it anymore. Everyone piles into the car. Catra remains coherent enough to tell Glimmer the address of Huntara. She plugs it in and drives off.

Adora digs through her bag. Only having a slight knowledge of what was going on, it was guess work to bring things. Thankfully, inside her backpack is some cloth. She rips it up into a more manageable state before pressing it on her sister's eye. The werepanther hisses at the touch.

"Fuck! That hurts!"

"It's either that, or letting it continue to bleed. I don't think you want to fall unconscious from blood loss. I sure as shit don't," Adora replies. "Can you hold this on your eye?"

"I think so?" Catra does not sound totally confident in her response. Yet, she manages to place a hand over her eye. "Hey, Glimmer. I am sorry that I am bleeding all over the place."

"You can make it up to me by cleaning up later. Let's just get your ass to Huntara before we worry about anything else."

On Catra's other side, Adam attempts to patch up what he can. The werepanther continues to hiss and even curse a bit as he works on her. At one point, Catra even glares at him. This earns

Catra a glare from Adora. The werepanther apologizes but remains tense as her wounds are pressed down on.

Finally, Glimmer pulls into Huntara's driveway, parking next to another car. Somewhat more coherent, Catra attempts to walk herself but is quickly stopped. Much to her displeasure, Adam carries her once again. Catra lets the others know that the door *should* be unlocked. Sure enough, it is. Upon entering, Glimmer calls out to let this Huntara person know they are here. The sound of footsteps quickly fills the air. Out from a corner appears an older, middle-aged woman. Presumably, this is Huntara.

In her human form, she is quite tall and muscular. Platinum white hair is shaved at the sides like Scorpia, however, the rest of her hair remains long and tied back in a ponytail. Not only does she have several battle scars on the exposed parts of her skin, but there is a tattoo on the left side of her head. At first, her eyes are narrowed with suspicion, but they quickly widen with surprise.

"The hell happened to you, Wildcat?!? No wonder you weren't answering your damn phone." Huntara states.

"Do you have anything to patch her up?" Adora asks.

"Yeah, bring her into the bathroom. I'll show you where it is. I'll get some clothes for her."

The tiny group follows the minotaur down the hallway, guiding them right to the bathroom. As Catra is settled onto the toilet lid, Huntara disappears for a moment only to return with a fresh set of clothing. Breathing room is made. Only Huntara and Catra remain in the bathroom while everyone else hovers by the open door. The werepanther is quickly patched up, Huntara spraying ointment on wounds (which Catra hisses at) before wrapping white bandages around them.

Catra's eye is the last to be patched up. Huntara mentions that she shouldn't lose her vision and only will get some scarring. The

werepanther mumbles something of annoyance as she dresses herself.

"Go rest. You can tell us/me whatever the hell happened to you later. You got the shit kicked out of you, and I am not in the mood to deal with your ass if you collapse suddenly." When Catra opens her mouth to protest, Huntara cuts her off. "Don't. You probably would have a better time explaining everything when you reset yourself. Now, go."

Huntara begins to step out of the bathroom, ushering the group away. Everyone begins to move, not knowing where they will be brought to, when Catra steps out. "I need to talk to Adora."

"What?" Adora stops, twisting her head over shoulder.

"Look, I'll rest cause honestly I do feel like shit, but I need to talk to her." Her amber eye flicks to Adora. "I need to talk to you about Mom. It's…It's important."

Adora gulps around a dry lump in her throat. She has not spent much time with her sister alone since coming back into her life. How long is this going to take? The fact that she wants to talk about their adoptive mother doesn't sit quite well in her stomach. Her mind continues to race over what Shadow Weaver has done. Her blood runs cold at the thought of thinking even more about the woman who raised her.

Glimmer's hand finds its way onto her shoulder. The hunter gives it a small squeeze. "Do you want to do this? I'm right here if you need me. We all are."

Adora keeps her eyes on her sister as she listens to her girlfriend. The amber eye of her sister shows no hints of ill-will. She can only see worry and concern. With a sigh, Adora finally faces Glimmer. "I'll be fine. It'll be quick." *I hope.* "I'll be back before you know it!"

"Okay. Shout if you need anything." Glimmer gives a small peck against Adora's lips before leaving with the rest of the group.

Adora takes a deep inhale before spinning on her heels. “Okay, Cat. What is it?”

Catra gestures with her head for Adora to follow. She does as she is told, letting herself be led into a small bedroom. With the curtains drawn, the room is shrouded in darkness. Catra doesn’t bother to turn any lights on, but it’s not like either of them need it after a full moon, and sits down on the bed. She leans back and sighs.

“So,” Adora starts, remaining on her feet, “what do you want to talk to me about? What the hell happened with you and Mom?”

“Well, she caught me totally off guard, for starters.” Catra shuts her eye as she begins to think. “I was just out in the forest doing whatever. I like being out there at night, can stretch my legs and what not. And then well, she pounced! Pinned me straight to the ground.”

“Jesus. You didn’t hear or smell her coming?”

“Sadly no. I wasn’t paying attention, I didn’t think she would be there, so I didn’t sense anything until the last moment. But that wasn’t the scary part…”

Adora shudders. “What was?”

Catra reopens her eye and stares directly at her sister. “You never really saw Mom in her werewolf form, but she looked just like a normal ass wolf. Just huge and a bit scary. She wasn’t like you when you couldn’t control it. But, like how you have changed your form, so has she.”

“I don’t know how to explain it but, imagine her normal wolf self but…” Catra has to think for a moment. “Okay, put it like this. Where you looked more like a stereotypical werewolf on steroids, Mom still looks like a wolf, but also on steroids. Does that make sense?”

Adora shuts her eyes, trying to imagine the sight. As she does, the image of the wolf that attacked her flashes before her. Another shudder. She doesn't like to think about the possibility of who that really is, even if she might know it. But slowly, she begins to form the image in her mind. A large, black wolf with muscles and sharp teeth and claws.

"Do you think it has anything to do with her attacking others and stealing their powers?" Adora asks, reopening her eyes.

"Probably. But that is not the reason I wanted to talk to you. I can explain more of what happened later but…while she had me pinned, there are two things she said. One of them was wondering what happened to you."

"Good to know she still wants me to be her little puppet." Adora scoffs.

"Tell me about it. Said she was still pissed about you leaving. Said ` *Maybe she has learned her lesson and will come back to me'."*

Adora laughs darkly, which makes Catra smirk. "I had the same reaction. But…she did question me if I knew where you were. Tried to get out of me what I knew, but I pretty much told her to go fuck herself and choke. That is when she slashed my eye."

"Oh. Well…Thank you for that." Adora rubs the back of her neck, not really knowing what else to say. Her mind begins to think how ` *surprising'* and ` *shocking '* it is that her sister didn't sell her out. She slaps the sides of her face at the thought, reminding herself that Catra has shown she is no longer someone who would do such a thing.

"Won't be surprised if you still hate me after that."

"I don't *want* to hate you, Cat!" Adora admits. "You are my sister. We grew up together. Hell, you and I were together longer than Adam and I were! But…While I am more than happy you didn't sell me out to Mom…I'm still hurting from what you did before."

"I wasn't the best sister, was I?"

Adora doesn't answer. "I see you are trying to do right by me. I want to give you that second chance. I'm trying to give you it. But…it can't fully make up for what happened. I'll always have the scar—that *wound*—inside of me. I thought…I thought it had healed when I got away. When I was able to get you out of my life. I thought I could forget about it all. But it never did heal, did it? I can't just pretend it doesn't exist."

Silence. Even now, speaking about the wound aggravates it, ripping open the scab that had just begun to form inside her, leaving it raw again . Catra lowers her gaze and fiddles with her fingers. Her mouth opens to speak, but Adora cuts her off.

"You coming back into my life has reopened it, among other things. I'm not gonna sugarcoat that. But maybe…maybe now that you are here and we can talk and try to fix things…maybe it can heal properly this time so it doesn't hurt as much. So when I feel it, I can say it has no more power over me."

Adora clutches the center of her shirt, feeling the fabric between her fingers. "It's starting to heal, I will admit. But…I don't know."

"Fair enough." Catra suddenly yawns. "Man, Mom did a number on me."

"What was that other thing she said? You said there were two things, right?"

Catra bites her lip before speaking. "You aren't gonna like it. There is a reason she left me alive. She damn well could have killed me, but she didn't. I didn't sell you out, but I did tell her that you and the others were trying to figure out a way to stop her. She laughed in my face, and then she said…"

Adora takes a step closer. "Said what?"

Huntara snaps her fingers. In a flash, her head turns into that of a horned bull with platinum white hair. Her legs become covered in the same fur, and her feet become cloven. To top everything off, she sports a cow's tail.

Beside Glimmer, Adam stares at Huntara. His eyes are wide and bright as he says, "Wow! You can do that on command?!?"

Huntara crosses her arms, puffs out her chest, and smirks. "Yes I can! Us older folk have long since figured out tricks and whatnot on how to look human or our true selves. Plus, I am not tied to the moon like Wildcat is. I can do it whenever I please."

"That is amazing!"

"He really is Adora's brother," Bow whispers into Glimmer's ear.

"Tell me about it," she replies. Glimmer watches as her best friend turns his sights back on Adam. She holds back a snort when a twinkle appears in Bow's brown eyes.

Another snap, and Huntara returns to her human state. She plops herself down on an empty chair. "I am going to take a guess since Catra called you guys, that one of you is Glimmer, another is Bow, and someone is Adora. I don't know who this fourth person is."

They explain as quickly as they can. Who is who, and a little bit about themselves. Huntara replies with a bit about herself–how she has lived in Crimson Valley for a couple decades–and how she has known Catra for a couple years. How she took her under her wing so when she returned to town, Huntara didn't mind her crashing. In fact, the werepanther has told her a little bit about what's been going on.

"Catra told me how much of a bitch her mother was. Didn't expect her to actually be so much of a bitch that she'd attack her own kid."

Glimmer leans back on the couch. "She definitely won't be winning any awards for being a great mom anytime soon."

She then turns her gaze to the hallway she exited shortly before. Glimmer wonders what on earth Adora and Catra are talking about. Her girlfriend must be holding her own and/or the talk isn't something terrible. Most of her body is begging her to go see what is happening and make sure Adora is okay.

To distract herself, she joins back in on the idle chatter going on. It's mostly just getting to know each other a little bit. The conversation only goes so far before Adora appears. She drags herself down the halls and into the living room. Glimmer's heart jumps in her chest at the sight of her girlfriend. However, her heart suddenly stops in its tracks.

Adora's face is pale. Her shoulders are pushed down by an invisible force. She says nothing as she sits down on a small, cushioned chair near the couch. Her head goes into her hands. Everyone glances at each other, wordlessly asking what is going on. Eyes land onto Glimmer. The hunter does not protest, pulling herself off the couch and walking over to her girlfriend. A hand is placed onto Adora's back.

"'Dora?" Glimmer softly asks. She rubs her hand up and down her girlfriend's back.

Adora slowly lifts her head. She remains pale. Her eyes are somewhat distant. Not totally aware of those around her. Glimmer has to give her another shake to snap the blonde back into reality.

"Sorry…" Adora mumbles.

"Are you okay? What did Catra tell you?" Glimmer asks.

"I…She told me something that our mother told her."

"What was that?"

Adora swallows. She opens her mouth to say something but fails to do so. Her girlfriend leans back against the chair, bouncing her

leg rapidly. After several moments, she finally speaks. “Mom gave her an ultimatum. Deadline. Whatever it is.”

“What?”

Everyone stares at Adora, who keeps her eyes averted from the group. The bouncing of her leg grows worse and a hand covers her mouth. “Catra is alive because Mom needed a damn messenger pigeon, not for any goodwill of being her child. Told her that she knows we have been digging into things. She said…” Adora suddenly growls.

“Take your time, Starlight.” Glimmer reassures. Even with her limited sense of smell, the anxiety and anger coming from her girlfriend floods her nose.

Whatever is bottled up inside of her comes out by Adora shooting to her feet. She begins pacing around the living room, almost immediately creating a trench. The blonde takes several harsh huffs. She begins to fume as she talks.

“She told Cat she would stop killing, but under one condition.”

“Which would be?” Adam asks from behind, worry in his voice.

Adora continues to be unable to look at everyone. Fists are clenched so tight, her knuckles turn white. “The quote from Catra is this. ` *I will stop killing for the next two months. That is all you get. Come May, face me in the Whispering Woods during that month’s full moon. Try and stop me. If you don’t or if you fail to win, then I’ll continue what I’ve been doing. Showing others what true power and fear is. And I will start with causing terror in Brightmoon’.”*

The air becomes thick . Glimmer feels her body turn to ice as blood rushes to her ears. Her brain struggles to comprehend what Adora has just said. Her mind races with thoughts.

There is a time limit now? And a short one at that? Only ***two*** *months! How the hell do we prepare for that? We barely know*

what the hell we are doing! This isn't going to end well at all!

Glimmer feels her legs almost giving out. She braces herself against the nearby couch. Taking a look behind her, she sees Bow and Adam pale and in shock. Huntara does not give any hints to what she is feeling, but she is rubbing her chin in thought. Turning to look back in front of her, Adora continues to pace around.

"W-Was there anything else?" Glimmer hesitantly asks. She swallows some bile tickling the back of her throat, almost instantly regretting the decision.

Adora sighs. "Yeah…There was another part of the message. One…One directed at you, Glim."

Only the couch can support Glimmer's weight. "I'm not gonna like it, am I?"

Adora shakes her head. When she turns to face her girlfriend, her sky blue eyes are glistening with tears. "Shadow Weaver also said, and I quote from Catra, ' *And tell that little hunter girl she'd better put up a stronger fight than her pathetic mother'.*"

The next thing Glimmer knows is that she is staring up at the ceiling. She swears she is seeing stars. Then, in a blink, four sets of eyes stare down at her. The back of her head throbs.

"Glimmer?!? Are you okay?" Bow asks.

"Super!" Glimmer groans back. With the help from others, she gets into a sitting position. "Sorry. That was a lot of information at once. I guess my brain couldn't handle it all."

"I should have waited until later to tell you that last bit. I didn't think you'd react that extremely," Adora apologizes.

"It's okay. Neither did I. I was asking for it when I told you to tell me more."

Glimmer takes a moment, a true moment, to process everything. Shadow Weaver is ready for a fight. She is willing to stop what she is doing for what? To taunt everyone? Rub it in their faces about how ill-prepared they are for this? Knowing no one will be harmed for the next two months is comfort, but only *some.* An anvil of anxiety hangs over her head, just waiting to be cut and come crashing down on top of her.

"You kids should try and relax," Huntara says. She jumps to her feet. "I will make you guys some tea, I am sure you are hungry. I know taking it easy won't be, well, *easy* , but there is no point in worrying right now. When Cat wakes up, maybe then you can talk more. I'll get some ice for that head of yours, also."

Without saying anything else, she disappears. Adora helps her girlfriend to her feet. Glimmer brushes herself off before rubbing the back of her head.

"Man, today has been insane," Glimmer says.

"Guess we are stuck waiting for Catra to get up." Adora sits down on the couch's arm rest. "She might be out for a while. Dunno if I like waiting…"

"Huntara has a point, though," Adam says. His eyes grow a little dark as he speaks. "Trust me. Running on emotions when trying to figure something out is not going to end well."

"What do we tell the others? They have to know." Glimmer mumbles. "We can't leave them in the dark."

"Sleep on it?" Bow suggests. "Doubt we can get everyone together today. We can try tomorrow or the next day."

"Okay…"

Glimmer lies in a bed of colorful roses. Petals in different shades of either gold or lavender surround her. The soft smell that seeps from them creeps into her nose, making her whole body melt into

the ground. But something else floods her nose, overpowering the flowers. Rich sandalwood. The owner of the scent hovers over her. Sky blue eyes stare down, locking with her own lilac ones, and are full of nothing but love and affection. Lips suddenly brush up against her own, as if a butterfly has landed. Glimmer sucks it all in.

When Adora pulls away, she rests her forehead on the hunter's. Eyes flutter shut as her hands cup Glimmer's face, thumbs gently brushing against skin. "Have I told you how much I love you?"

"Everyday, love," Glimmer replies, a chirp in her voice.

"I hope you never get sick of it, because I am going to keep saying it! I love you so much, Glitter-bug! More than anything else in the world. I love you! How did I ever get so lucky to have you as my girlfriend? Did I win the lottery or something?"

Glimmer burst out laughing, her heart growing large inside of her chest. "You are such a damn dork!"

"I am your dork, ya know! Your big, fluffy, werewolf dork of a girlfriend!" Adora suddenly begins rubbing her cheek against Glimmer's. Mixed in with her sandalwood soap, the hunter can smell the hint of musk from the wolf. Whatever the case, she doesn't care. Having Adora's warmth so close to her, she is almost able to hear the blonde's strong heartbeat in her ears. With the sun beating down and encasing Adora in a halo of light, what more can Glimmer ask for?

This moment is picture perfect, and the hunter wishes to take a photo and keep it forever and ever. If only time could be frozen.

However, despite the warmth of Adora and the sun, a sudden cold wind sends a shiver down Glimmer's spine. For a moment, she snaps her eyes shut as her body shudders and her teeth clack together. The hunter wonders where the fuck the cold wind has come from, and why it has run all the way down her back. Once

the sensation disappears, she opens her eyes. Upon doing so, another shiver blows right through her.

Adora no longer hovers over her. Glimmer quickly jumps to her feet, snapping her head every which way in her fright. Nowhere can she find her girlfriend. To make matters worse, the sky has darkened and no sun hangs above. The flowers she just was lying in have lost all their colors as they wilt. Legs begin to move, the only thought given is finding Adora.

The world shifts around her even more. Dark trees sprout from the ground, their trunks thickening and branches almost tearing into the blackened sky. Wilted roses turn into dead leaves that crunch so loud, they echo through the cold air. Any light that there once was, ceases to be. Glimmer stumbles around blindly, only the adrenaline coursing through her leading the way. She attempts to call out to her girlfriend, locate where the hell she has vanished to, but the words stick to the inside of her throat and refuse to remove themselves.

Suddenly, something catches Glimmer's ankle. It's a tree root, yet it feels as if long, sharp fingers have wrapped around her. Whatever it is sends her face first into the hard ground. The hunter spits out leaves and dirt as she pulls herself onto her elbows. She begins to blink, attempting to adjust to the black world. Some shapes come into focus. Human-like they are. Glimmer's heart leaps inside her chest at the thought that she has finally found Adora.

Once they come into full detail, she wishes she never adjusted to the darkness.

Her mother. Sprawled out on her back, her body covered in crimson blood. Wide, bright, lilac eyes stare at Glimmer. Tears stream out of them as her mother reaches a hand out. "Why didn't you come back sooner?"

Glimmer is frozen in place. She squeezes her eyes shut in a feeble attempt to block out what is in front of her. Yet, the image has

already been seared into her mind. Tears run down the sides of her face. "I did! I did come back! We were gonna make this right!"

"Why didn't you come after me in the woods?"

Glimmer begins to choke on her words. "I-I didn't mean to! I-I thought I was gonna see you again! Th-That nothing was gonna happen! How could I have known this was going to happen?!?"

"Why didn't you stay? Why did you leave me to die?"

"I'm s-sorry, Mom! I'm s-so fuckin' sorry!" Sobs have overtaken her. An invisible noose twists tight around her neck, making it near impossible for her to breathe.

"Why were you so ***weak*** *?" Angella's voice comes out wrong. Like two voices, hers and someone else's, have overlapped.*

"W-What?"

Through the blur of her tears, some of the shadows take shape. A large wolf with bright, glowing green eyes stares back at her. They flash a sharp tooth grin before speaking. "You are such a weak hunter! Couldn't do anything to save your mother. Couldn't do anything to stop others from being harmed."

Suddenly, Petra appears to her left. The werebear lies unconscious in their human form, broken and bleeding. Glimmer calls out to them, but they don't so much as twitch. Her body remains motionless, even her chest is still. Glimmer wonders if she is dead.

To her right appears Catra. Unlike Petra, the werepanther is alive. She gasps for air, shouting out every curse under the sun. Like her mother and Petra, crimson blood surrounds her. So much, it could drown Catra. Glimmer shouts for the werepanther but like before, there is no answer.

*"So many people are dead or injured because of your own weakness. Hunters are supposed to help and protect others! Yet, you have **failed."** the wolf taunts.*

"Shut up!" Glimmer growls. Tears become hot as she turns to face the mysterious wolf. Her blood begins to boil and she really wants to sucker punch the creature. However, the world freezes in place as her eyes land on them again.

The wolf has changed. They remain shrouded in shadows, but now look like a tall, slender woman. But that is not what catches her eyes the most. It's the fact that Adora has reappeared.

The woman holds her girlfriend by the throat, fingernails already drawing a small amount of blood.

Adora's face is twisted into pure horror. Eyes are wide and frightened. She twists and kicks, trying to break free from her prison. Hands claw at what grips her throat, but it is to no avail. The harder she struggles, the tighter the grip becomes. More blood trickles down her neck, and the harder she gasps for air.

*"Don't hurt her!" Glimmer cries. Her body has become one with the ground. No matter how hard she tries, she is unable to move. The only thing she can do is watch in terror and plead. "Don't hurt her! **PLEASE!** You **can't** hurt her!"*

The woman laughs. "Like I can't hurt everyone else you love? Like your mother? Your friends? Those you are sworn to protect? And what about your girlfriend's sister? All those people you failed to protect, and it will be your precious little girlfriend next!"

"Nonononononono!"

Adora gags at the grip tightens even more. She continues to fight, not giving up in the slightest. Yet, even she cannot stop the river of tears from escaping her eyes. Somehow, the blonde manages to squeak out one single word. "G-Glimmer!"

*"You will **fail** ," the woman continues, "and there is nothing you can do to stop me!"*

Glimmer cannot even scream as the bright, crimson red spilling out of Adora fills her sight.

Glimmer wakes up violently. Her body flings forward, arm reaching out for something not there. All the air has been sucked clean out of her lungs, leaving her in her own vacuum. The world is both familiar and unfamiliar. She knows the things around her and knows they have importance to her. Yet, no name sticks into her mind. An invisible force continues to grip her throat, causing her breath to come out ragged.

The hunter scrambles, not knowing where to go. Her mind is nothing more than static. However, entangled in her sheets, Glimmer slams down onto the ground. This is able to jostle her thoughts free. She realizes she is in her room. She is in Brightmoon. She is safe and sound. None of these facts ease her mind, however.

She scrambles even more. Hands cling to the bed sheets and pull her up. On the other side of the mattress, there is no life. Glimmer's brain attempts to remind her about Adora's habit of waking up at the crack of dawn. Yet, the remnants of her nightmare clings onto her brain. Every part of her screams to locate her girlfriend. To know she has not just had her throat slit.

More scrambling. Glimmer begins racing out of her room, through the hall, and down the stairs. She nearly trips, but catches herself at the last moment. The hunter's lungs burn as she enters the kitchen, seeing no one in sight. "Adora?!?"

A smell enters her nose. She takes several sniffs, trying to pinpoint it, and realizes it is metallic. Fearing the true name to the scent, Glimmer enters the kitchen. There, on a cutting board by several different veggies, is some blood. Looking down, on the tile

is several drops as well. Glimmer feels her body turn to ice. What the fuck is going on? What is happening?!?

Just as fear fully takes hold of her, Glimmer feels her legs about to give out, a soft voice fills the air.

"Glitter-bug?"

Glimmer snaps her head up. Standing a couple feet away is Adora. Her face is full of color. Some of her dark blonde hair has been tied back into a half ponytail. A jacket is tied around her waist, leaving her only in a t-shirt and jeans. Sky blue eyes are bright and eyebrows are furrowed. There are no signs of terror anywhere.

"Oh, thank god!" Glimmer propels herself at Adora. The moment she is within reach, arms wrap tightly around the blonde's body and her face buries itself into Adora's chest. Glimmer is unable to stop herself from sobbing. "You're okay! You're alive!"

"Woah!" Adora gasps. She begins to rub small circles against the hunter's back. "Y-Yeah! I am, Glimmer! I'm okay. What's wrong?!? Wait. Did you have a nightmare?"

"Hm-mh. I-I dreamt S-Shadow Weaver had you. I-I-I saw my mother, Petra, and Catra all dead or near dead! Shadow Weaver was t-taunting me, and-and she-she killed you right in f-front of me! Y-You died! Y-You *died* , Adora!"

Adora holds her tight, pressing her so hard against her chest they almost become one being. "Christ, that must have been horrible," she whispers in Glimmer's ear. "I am alive, though. Shadow Weaver hasn't gotten me. I'm okay! You're okay! We both are okay! Breathe, hon. Just breathe."

Glimmer does as she is told. She takes long, deep, but shaking breaths. All the while, Adora continues to hold her close and rub her back as she lets everything out. The images of her nightmare threaten to reappear, but with the sandalwood smell of her

girlfriend as well as her strong heartbeat, it pushes it all away. Eventually, Glimmer can push herself away.

"Thank you. I'm sorry if I worried you."

"Hey, it's okay! You know that I know how much nightmares suck ass," Adora replies. She wipes some tears off of her girlfriend's face. "I can't blame you for having something like that. While I didn't have any last night, what we learned still didn't sit well with me. Instead, I had one of those black, heavy, nothingness. Woke up feeling like shit."

"Good to know. Gotta ask Adam how he slept. You know if he is still out cold?"

"Nah, he's in the shower. Will be out soon. I was cooking lunch for us while I waited for you two to get up."

"Wait!" Glimmer looks back at the cutting board before returning to Adora. "Why was there blood?!? What happened?!?"

"Oh, that?" Adora lifts up her left hand, pointing at it. Her palm is wrapped in a white bandage. Part of it has turned a bright red color. "Cut it while cooking. Actually, I got myself pretty badly so I went to clean it up. Tried not to bleed on everything, but I guess I still did. Should heal by tomorrow."

Glimmer can't help but sigh, and she rests her head back on Adora's chest. "I'm just so happy you're okay. I…I don't know what I would do without you."

"I can say the same thing about you. Everything is okay, though, right now. You're awake, the nightmare can't hurt you anymore."

Glimmer shuts her eyes. Even with the fog, she can make out the broken bodies of her mother, Petra, and Catra. She can still see red pouring out of Adora as life leaves her eyes. While this all was just in her head, something her brain created to torture her with, there are many truths. The death and injury of others, and the

possibilities of what can happen in only a couple months time. She might be safe now, but for how long?

And how long will Adora be safe from her mother? For sure, the blonde will be Shadow Weaver's main target. Who knows what she will do to her daughter that she wanted to mold into something like her, only for Adora to run off. She already attacked her other child, and only spared her to give them a message. Why would Adora be different if she deems her of no use anymore?

Glimmer gently grabs Adora's shirt, keeping her head against her chest. "Yeah…Yeah, you're right. Thank you, love."

I won't let that nightmare become a reality…I won't let Shadow Weaver harm you!

Chapter End Notes

comment/kudos appreciated and a shout out again to my buddy dorku (i cannot wait to link again lmao) for helping me figure out what Huntara should be

What Plan?

Chapter Notes

sorry for the delay in this chapter but, woooo ch 26. And I broke 200k! The whole reason I pushed myself with this batch of chapters was because I got to post ch26 on my 26th birthday!!!! heh

Anyway this is the last for a bit. I still am out with a laptop so I'm using my mom's but yeah its going slowly + with the fact this is endgame territory, I want you figure out how I will go about posting the last couple batches

Anyway don't think there are tws so enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer barely musters up the strength to eat. A large part of her wants to curl back up in bed in the smallest of balls and sleep for…a long ass time. The thought of having another horrific nightmare however, keeps her from doing as such. So, she eats the lunch Adora has made. Every bite she takes is bland and tasteless. Like she is eating cardboard. It is no fault of the blonde's. She knows Adora's cooking is amazing. After many months of tasting and enjoying it, Adora's cooking has become her favorite. Today, however, her taste buds refuse to work.

While she eats, Adam appears. He has on his Grayskull Academy sweatshirt and sweatpants. The name of the college is plastered on his chest and the side of his legs . What looks like it should be an exc;amation mark at the end is instead a sword. He yawns quite loudly, apologizing for it, and sits down at the table. "Damn, lunch for breakfast?"

"You're the one who slept in," Adora replies. She remains standing by the table, arms crossed, and not taking a bite out of anything.

"You gonna eat?" Glimmer asks.

“I ate before you two woke up,” Adora answers. Though, her eyes do not look directly at Glimmer. Not to mention, the blonde scratches the side of her face. “Both of you eat. Don’t forget, we have to meet the others.”

Right, Glimmer thinks to herself. After the events of yesterday, another little meeting has been made. With the short notice, to no one’s shock, not everyone will be back to make it to their get together. It will be the three of them, Bow, and then Perfuma and Scorpia. Mermista and Sea Hawk are busy and will have to be brought up to speed later on. Petra and their siblings will also be notified later. It was agreed upon to get some things in order before telling the werebear. With everything so new and barely digested, no need to give her the same issue.

Catra will remain at Huntara’s place for a couple days to recover. This is not only because Huntara wanted her to stay and not strain herself, but Catra herself decided on it. Said she didn’t want the others to see her as a total mess, and she needed time by herself to think about what her mother said. Glimmer cannot blame her for that. After she got attacked, which seems like a lifetime ago, the hunter didn’t want to do anything but lie in her bed.

Some food is left on Glimmer’s plate. Her stomach no longer wants to take in the tasteless food. By the time she has tossed what's left in the trash and puts the plate in the dishwasher, Adam finishes up his meal. He cleans up and puts himself in some sort of better order —t hat being, patting down some loose strands of hair. Some still refuse to fall against his head. He remains in his sweatshirt and pants. Now, only Glimmer needs to get ready.

She drags her heavy body back upstairs, boards creaking under her weight. Glimmer pushes open her door. Her sheets remain on the ground in a messy pile. For a moment, she debates whether she should make up her bed or not. Rocking on her heels, she decides to do it later. There is only enough energy in her body to dress herself. Glimmer takes a bit of time to do so. No need to rush into this meeting.

Glimmer slips on something warm for the cold weather. Normally, she would be dying for winter to end and spring to come. The hunter misses the warmer months and so does her body. Up until yesterday, this was the case. Now, with a deadline looming to figure out a way to stop Shadow Weaver, she wishes for time to stop. Freeze, just like the world outside. She swears she can hear a clock ticking away in her mind.

As her head pops free from her jacket, her eyes land on the portrait of her mother on her dresser. With a deep sigh, Glimmer begins slowly walking over to it. With each step that lands on the carpet below, an invisible knife slowly sinks itself further and further into her heart. It's hot, as if it has been freshly taken out of the forge. It's sharp, having thousands of tiny teeth on its edge. It's heavy, no way could she pull it out with ease. By the time Glimmer is at the dresser, she swears the knife has pierced straight through her heart.

Hands reach out and grab the frame of the photo. She rubs the glass with her sleeve, clearing it of any smudges and dust that have collected on it. All clean, her mother stares back at her. It takes everything in Glimmer not to cry. Not to let any teardrops plop down onto the photo below. Instead, her body trembles.

"What the hell would you do, Mom? I am going to be facing the person who murdered you soon! And I don't know what to do!" Glimmer talks to herself. She struggles to breathe. Invisible fingers grip her throat tight. Words come out ragged. "What did you do before? How did you slow down Shadow Weaver? I've waited to finally figure out who took you from me and give you peace. But now…I'm scared! Confused! I-I don't know what to do!"

"...I really wish you were here…I need you, Mommy…"

Glimmer takes a moment to reset herself. She places her mother's photo back on the dresser before leaning against it. The hunter continues to blink back tears, not wanting her eyes to turn red and puffy. With everything going on, there is no need to worry any of her friends or her girlfriend. This deadline is already

causing enough issues, and this will only cause more! She takes several long, deep breaths. Fingernails dig into the wood as she struggles to regain control of her body. If she cannot do this fast enough, Adora will begin to fret at how long she's been gone.

Get yourself together, Glimmer!

She slaps the sides of her face, a little hard if she is being honest, before walking out. At the top of the stairs, Glimmer takes one last deep inhale. She hopes that she doesn't somehow look like shit. One by one, the hunter hops down the stairs. By the time she reaches the bottom and enters the living room, Adora and Adam are waiting by the door. Both twins' eyes land on her as she draws closer.

"Are you ready, hon?" Adora asks.

"Are you?" Glimmer replies. She zips up her coat and throws on a scarf.

"Fair point." Adora grabs the keys off the nearby counter and is the first to head out.

The frigid air blasts into the house. For a brief moment, as an icy chill runs down her back, Glimmer once more wishes for spring and summer. Wishes for the melt and the sun. She quickly remembers what and who she must go through to get there. With a small groan, the hunter follows her girlfriend and Adam out the door.

Everyone will be meeting at Perfuma's little store. Hopefully, no one shows up to bother them while they are having their talk. If it comes to that, the faery will scurry out to deal with the customer(s) before coming back. She'll be filled in on what she missed afterwards. Glimmer tries to think of what she wants to talk about. However, Adora probably will take up most of the air time. She has most of the information from Catra.

While driving, Glimmer struggles to keep her eyes open. The steady vibrations of the engine, the warmth of the heat seeping

from the vents, and the soft beats of the radio begin to drag her back into the world of slumber. She fights against it, not yet ready to return to her nightmares. She tries to keep her eyes busy and force them to focus on something. The moment they get into town, she gets lucky. The town is alive with people going about their days. She watches people walking on the sidewalk.

Many are humans, many non-human. All can be in danger if she and the others fail to stop Shadow Weaver. Adora's adoptive mother only wants to make the lives of others be full of suffering and pain. To cast a dark shadow over the world, and make those around her fear her power. Everyone that walks down the concrete sidewalk, in and out of buildings, and across the street are at risk. Shadow Weaver will not care about the effects her actions will have on others, only how others will react knowing she is a threat not to be messed with.

When Adora brings the car to a stop at a red light, familiar faces appear. Bundled up in winter coats and scarves, Edgar and Alvin walk down the crosswalk, their father right behind them. When the pair of brothers spot Adora and Glimmer in the car, wide grins spread across their faces and they wave. The two wave back. Glimmer cannot help but smile a little herself.

"Who's that?" Adam asks from the back seat.

"Edgar and Alvin Whitewood, and their father," Adora answers. Once the light turns green, she moves the car once more.

"They are all wyverns," Glimmer adds. "We have helped them out a couple of times. They are good kids."

She twists her head, catching the last glimpse of the little family walking down the sidewalk. Glimmer swears she sees one of the brothers blowing a small bit of smoke in the other's face. There is such an innocence to their childish, sibling teasing. Glimmer's fingers begin to grip her armrest at the thought of the young boys losing that. They have no idea of the threat that looms ahead, nor

should they know. The hunter does not want that to happen to them. More reasons to stop Shadow Weaver in her tracks.

They finally reach the area where Perfuma's store is. Adora finds a parking spot and switches off the car. She leans back in her seat before looking at the other two occupants. "Time to get this over with…"

Glimmer unbuckles her seatbelt and opens her door. "Let's go."

They all exit and quickly head towards the store, getting away as fast as possible from the cold. Glimmer is the first to push open the door and step into the clothing area of the store. She lets a shiver run down her spine, causing her body to tremble momentarily, before saying," Yo! Perfuma! You in the back?"

"Yes! Come on in!" Perfuma's voice echoes in the distance.

Glimmer leads the way. She walks past all the hanging clothing, down a hall, and towards a door. She gives a knock, making sure it's the right one. When the voice of Perfuma enters her ears once more, thehunter pushes it open.

The back room is not much to marvel at. It's pretty much your average break room. A table and some chairs. A little fridge and a microwave. A while back, Scorpia brought her old ass portable TV that still works. Glimmer *swears* someone non-human–she doesn't know what type of creature–has used magic or something to jury-rig it to get channels it shouldn't.

The main difference here however, is that when Perfuma isn't at home or out at the front desk, she is working on her magic and potions here. There's a large bookshelf filled to the brim with books on plants, magic, and medicine. Some of it is written in either a totally different language, or using words and grammar that makes Glimmer's head hurt. And she thought Latin was bad enough!

Besides that, there are several different plants in the corner, soaking up the sun that streams through the windows. Buds

remain shut tight. Though, it looks like at any moment, that with the smallest of touches, the flower petals would burst free. Glimmer warns Adora not to go sniffing a few of them as they are a part of the wolfsbane family. Finally, scattered on the table are some bottles. Some filled, some not. There is also a small device —an alarm for when the door opens.

Perfuma doesn't sit on any of the chairs that are scattered around, and neither does Scorpia. Rather, the couple sits on a small couch, watching something on the old TV.

"Slow day, I am guessing?" Adora asks as the trio steps up to them.

“You can say that,” Perfuma answers. “No one really wants to come out in the cold. Can’t blame them.”

Scorpia hops to her feet before wrapping her arms around Adam. Prepared for the embrace, he wraps his own arms around the taller woman. Glimmer wonders who has the stronger bear hug of the pair.

“Nice to see you again, Adam! How is the Brightmoon life treating you?” Scorpia asks. She releases him.

“It’s going good!” Adam replies. He looks around the room. His mouth creases in a small frown. “Guess Bow isn’t here yet?”

Perfuma shakes her head. “Not yet, but he’ll be here soon. He’s on the way.”

This makes the small lights in his eyes twinkle and grow. While they wait for the last member of the group to appear, they settle down to watch whatever is on the TV. Despite the work that went into the TV, there remains a small bit of static on the device. Glimmer wonders if moving the antennas would do any sort of good or if they are only there for show.

Only once does the alarm go off, and it is not Bow. Perfuma quickly darts out to help whoever is outside before entering the

back room. The second time it goes off, Bow's voice follows. He is called into the back room. In only a few short moments, he appears. He greets everyone and gives Adam a high-five. Both men grin widely and sit down beside each other. Now that everyone is here, the TV is turned off and everyone gets settled into place.

After taking a pause to gather thoughts, they begin their story at the start of yesterday morning. How they were doing the normal routine after a shift–getting up and slowly getting ready for the day. Breakfast was being eaten, and plans were not yet made when Catra called. The race to get to Crimson Valley before anything bad were to happen, and not quite knowing what they would get into. Finding her beaten and bloody, but alive. The trip back to Huntara's place.

Adora takes over the role of speaking. She takes her time telling them what her sister told her. A couple of times, the blonde has to take a moment to breathe. Her face becomes strained the more she talks about what her mother told Catra. Glimmer rubs a hand against her girlfriend's back, reassuring Adora she can take all the time she needs and that if she wants to stop, the hunter can take over any time.

Finally, Adora does ask for a break. Perfuma gets her a glass of water. The blonde quickly sips it down, her hand causing the glass to shake. Her leg bounces a mile a minute. Adora takes a deep breath as she pinches her nose.

"I still can't believe my Mom has given us a deadline to figure shit out."

"Two months to figure out everything. Gotta check when May's full moon is." Perfuma states. "I am gonna guess translating the book is still going slowly?"

Adam gives a shake of his head. "I am making progress, but there hasn't been anything I think would be of use to you guys. A lot of the stuff Glimmer's mom has written is just simple journal stuff.

Like, ‘Oh, I talked to this non-human today. I am glad they are doing well’.”

"Did Catra say anything else?" Scorpia asks.

Adora looks at Glimmer, Adam, and Bow. The three look at each other, mumbling amongst themselves before deciding on who will talk. It falls on the hunter. She takes a deep breath and gathers her thoughts.

"Yeah. After she slept for a while and came back, she told us more about the attack. You already heard how Shadow Weaver looks now."

"That still gives me chills," Scorpia states.

"Catra said that it happened a couple hours before dawn. Shadow Weaver beat her up so bad that she couldn’t move far from where she was attacked and she passed out at least once. When she shifted back, it took a while to get her bearings, so she thinks with the shift she passed out again. Once she woke up again, that is when she started to call us.”

"While waiting, she didn't know if her mom was lurking around somewhere. Every noise spooked her, but thankfully she never reappeared. She nodded off from exhaustion for a little bit before we finally found her. Catra has no idea how the hell she didn't freeze to death or bleed out."

"Before you ask," Bow cuts in, "she didn't say anything about losing her powers like Petra. She didn't feel anything like that."

"She got lucky in more ways than one, it seems," Perfuma replies. "How long do you think it will take for her to heal?"

"Who knows? She's staying with Huntara, and Huntara definitely is going to keep her from doing something stupid. Hopefully by the next full moon she should be all better," Glimmer answers.

"Have you told Petra and her siblings yet?"

"No," Adora says. "We were hoping to try and figure something out first, even if it's little, before we told them anything."

"Two months…" Perfuma drums her fingers on the table. "I doubt that doing a full offensive will do any good."

"No." Glimmer grips her arms tightly, nails almost threatening to break fabric and skin. She can barely hold back a growl that tickles the back of her throat. "That is out of the question!"

"Glim?" Adora softly asks.

Eyes land on her girlfriend. Adora's eyebrows are knitted in concern and confusion. Sky blue irises are almost like a puppy. Adora's hand then lands on Glimmer's kneecap, her thumb slowly rubbing against her jeans.

"Sorry," Glimmer replies. She didn't realize how tense her shoulders were until she relaxes them. "We shouldn't just *attack.* We shouldn't have any more unnecessary injuries or…" She swallows a hard lump in her throat, "or death."

“She has a point,” Adam says. "From what I have heard, enough blood has been shed."

Perfuma climbs to her feet and travels to the bookshelf. Fingers brush against several different spines before she pulls one out. It's leather bound. The once gold text on the cover and side has faded, making it hard for Glimmer to read from this distance. When the faery begins to open it, there is a long *creak* as the spine protests being open. Even the yellow, sun-faded pages don't like being turned.

Perfuma sits back down near Scorpia. Dark eyes scan the pages. "I still have been looking for any plants that might help. There are many different types of plants that cause different effects. However, I don't know any combo that had the effect I was told. Nothing in here about messing with a werewolf for years. The effects either go away fairly quickly like when we used it on Adora, or straight out eventually kills them."

"And there is no way in hell we can test any of these." Glimmer sighs.

"For now we should come up with back-up plans," Bow suggests. "If we run out of time and have not figured out what Angella used, we can have something to fall back on. Even if it's something small, it's better than nothing, right?"

"I'll see what I can make up. Some stuff I won't have ready for a while since they are still growing. Should be ready before May."

"We'll tell Petra eventually. I just want to think a little more about it." Glimmer rubs a temple. "Do you think you can send me over some plants and stuff you were thinking about? I can send it to them so they can take a look themself and see if they have any suggestions."

"Yeah, sure. I'll send them over tonight."

They try to come up with more things, more plans, however it leads only to dead ends. None of the spitballing comes up with anything useful. When the ring of the alarm fills the air, it breaks everyone out of their little trance. Upon Perfuma's return, the TV is turned back on and some popcorn is tossed into the microwave. There is no point in going back home right away. After about an hour and a half or so, the store begins to pick up some traffic. With this, Glimmer, Adora, Adam, and Bow decide to head out. No need to be in Perfuma's and Scorpia's hair any longer.

Bow is asked if he wants to come back to Glimmer's place, but he politely declines. He'll hang out another day. He gives everyone a ` *Catch ya later!'* before heading back home. Left alone, the trio debates for a moment what to do before coming to a conclusion. Head back home and relax there for the rest of the day. As they walk back to the car, Glimmer begins to trail behind. She buries her face into the collar of her jacket, and lets her legs move without any thought.

Her mind is static as she looks off into the distance. The only thought that can penetrate the thick fuzz of her mind is that of Shadow Weaver. Her nightmares, hours old now, still haunt her waking presence. They seem to just be *waiting* for her to fall back asleep so they can torment her once more. She bites down so hard on her lip at that thought, of being plagued again by any horrors her brain can make up, she nearly breaks skin. Something stops her, however, before she can have a copper taste fill her mouth.

"Glimmer, are you doing alright?" Adora says, low and softly.

The hunter looks up. Her girlfriend has slowed down her steps to match Glimmer's own tempo. Worry is written all over her face again. Glimmer actually doesn't know if it had left Adora's face at all. Her eyebrows remain knitted together and there is not a trace of that crooked smile the hunter has fallen in love with. Out of the corner of Glimmer's eye, she can *just* make out Adam looking over his shoulder. There isn't a doubt in her mind that the younger twin is looking on with concern as well.

"I'm fine," Glimmer says rather bluntly. Adora's face does not change in the slightest. Honestly, Glimmer swears her girlfriend's eyes grow darker. She keeps her slow pace.

"That was a bit of an outburst before. I could smell how angry you were. I don't think I've ever heard you use that tone of voice with Perfuma before."

Glimmer sighs. "I don't want anyone else to get hurt. You've seen what Shadow Weaver has done."

"Tell me about it. I do feel you. I just want to make sure you are okay. You've been off all day since your nightmare. Is there anything I can do to help?"

Glimmer pauses in her tracks. She keeps her eyes on Adora, who also stands still on the pavement. Just looking at her girlfriend makes her heavy heart a little lighter. Far from a feather, but a bit

of lead has been chipped away. What *is* there really that Adora could do? She can't just stop Shadow Weaver with a snap of her fingers. She can't bring back Angella. She can't turn back the clock and erase all the pain and suffering that has occurred. Everything that hangs over their heads, waiting to be dropped down to crush everyone, is *far* too heavy for her to hold alone. Though, Adora would try. Glimmer does not wish for her to do that. Glimmer wants so desperately to shove her away from that impact zone, keep her from ever having to suffer any more.

But…there is one thing Adora could do.

Without uttering a word, Glimmer steps forward. Even with the hunter's hands shoved into her pockets, she doesn't need to give any body language cues to signal what she wants. Adora knows. This part of Glimmer's mind she can read, and Glimmer allows her to. The moment she is in arms reach, the blonde opens her arms wide. Glimmer rests her head against Adora's chest. Despite the coat and her body protecting the blonde's heart, she can hear it clear as day.

Adora wraps her arms tight around Glimmer's body. Her squeeze can rival that of Scorpia's. She knows the blonde is trying to suck up all the negative energy bundled up inside Glimmer's chest. The hunter refuses to let it be transferred. Anything to protect her girlfriend, even if that means adding more bottles to her insides.

For now, however, she lets Adora protect *her.*

The ten sets of numbers stare back at Adora. They wait for her to click the button below, to start the call. As they bore into her, she paces around the front deck. Teeth gnaw on her stim sword, her tongue tasting nothing but the rubber. Inside her chest, her heart does laps as if it is at the racetracks vying to win gold. Despite a rare, non-freezing day in the dead of winter (around forty degrees), her body shivers. Nerves run wild and do not show any signs of turning off anytime soon.

She groans, trying to muster up the courage to talk to her sister. After what Catra went through, why wouldn't Adora call her up? It would be cruel not to do so. Yet, that part of both her brain and heart that remains scarred doesn't want her to. They want her to keep an arm's length distance from her. She could always try calling Huntara, since everyone exchanged numbers with the minotaur. Yet, that does not sit right in her stomach.

"Hit call already!" Adora mumbles to herself. With a deep inhale, she lets her thumb hit the large, green circle on the screen.

There is no turning back now.

Bringing her phone to her ear, Adora waits, listening to the ring.

Ring!

Adora wonders if this was a bad idea. Catra could be sleeping.

Ring!

She wonders if Catra even *wants* her acting like a big sister right now.

Ring!

She begins to think this was a bad idea.

Ri–

"Yo."

Crap, she actually picked up! "Hi."

Silence…

"So, did you call me by mistake or what?" Catra asks.

"No. No, I didn't." Adora continues to pace around. With her free hand, she rubs the back of her neck. "I wanted to check up on you. How are you?"

"Been better. Still healing. A few of them have healed completely, but not everything. I have to be careful not to reopen some things and bleed all over the place. Huntara's been keeping an eye on me and helping me clean wounds again."

Adora decides to stop walking around. She takes a seat on the top step. Leaning back, she watches some fluffy, light clouds float through the bright blue sky. "How's the eye?" she asks.

"Still healing. I still have to have the stupid bandaging around it. I want my depth perception back!"

Adora snorts. "You know we can get some stuff from Perfuma to help. Could prevent scarring. Helped with Glimmer when I took a chunk out of her."

"Nah. I'm good. Part of me *wants* it to scar, just to remind myself I survived Mom attacking me. I want to keep it."

"Good for you."

More silence. Adora hears some birds chirping in the distance. She wonders when the robins will come back. Though, they signal spring, don't they? They'll be an indicator of the final days before her mother's date draws closer and closer. For now, she is happy to watch the black-capped chickadees hopping from bare branch to bare branch.

"Can I ask a question? You might not like it, though." Catra breaks the silence.

Her tone is serious. There aren't any hints of joking around or sarcasm. Adora does not like how her sister is speaking. The fact that Catra has given a warning about it being not so good does not help either. Swallowing, Adora asks, "What is it?"

"I know you guys are trying to figure out some plan of attack. I have jack shit in that department, but there is one thing. There'll be one problem that will throw a wrench into any plan that is drawn up. What are we going to do with *you?"*

“What?!?”

“I’m not trying to be a dick here, trust me. I’m being dead serious. Mom’s final date is on a full moon. You being a huge ass husky or a blood hungry beast probably isn't good. Even if we don’t have to watch you, we don’t know how you will react because *you* don’t know how you will react.”

“Judging by your reaction, no one has brought this up. Again, I *really* am not trying to be mean, I don’t want to say it, but… Adora…”

Adora clutches her phone tight in her hand. Catra’s right. What good is she going to be if she is either going to be distracted every five minutes, or out to kill anything that breathes? She’ll only be a hindrance, and possibly make things worse. She knows what her sister is about to say. She knows that Catra is going to pull that thought straight out of the back of her mind where it had been placed. The preparation for it does not make it any better at all.

“You *have* to learn control by May,” Catra finishes.

“I-” Adora’s tongue sticks to the inside of her mouth. Words refuse to leave their place in her throat.

“I’m sorry, Adora. Maybe I shouldn’t have said anything…”

“No. No, Cat,” Adora sighs. She pinches the bridge of her nose. “You are right. But I…I don’t know what to do! Do you know how many times I’ve wished that I could control it like you or Petra?!? Saying that over and over again has done jack shit. And I only just *started* to get some semblance of control after years of wanting to maim and kill others!”

“Has Petra ever said shit to you? They seem to understand this shit the most.”

“Only that I have to *‘want’* it. She never told me more, and I doubt she will. She doesn’t seem like the type to give answers.

They would rather let me figure it out myself.”

“You’re gonna have to figure it out soon, Adora. Whether you like it or not, this thing is a part of you, and you have to get control, even if it's just for one moon.”

Adora doesn't give an answer. She bites down on her lip, struggling to take everything in. For every bit that moves forward, an inch is pushed back, her mind refusing to accept this fact. Within all the confusion and refusal, some anger bubbles up. Anger that she has never ever gotten control. How can she even do that, when all her life, this curse has been just that.

A curse—something that has always caused her suffering.

Adora wonders how much of her emotions Catra can feel through the phone. Her sister says, "I'll stop talking. If I ripped off a bandaid, I'll find a way to make it up to you somehow. Are you gonna be okay?"

"I don't know…"

"I'll get out of your hair then. Thanks for checking up on me. I'll catch you later."

"Yeah. Catch ya later, Cat."

There is a click. Adora brings her phone in front of her, watching the last moments of Catra's number staring at her before it returns to her home screen. The same one as before of Glimmer staring out the window during sunset. Adora smiles softly at the photo. Staring at this, she can feel her heart slowly return to a normal pace.

She wonders how long that will last.

Adora shoves her phone in her pocket and rises to her feet. She gives a little stretch before slowly wandering back to the front door. Catra’s words linger in her mind. Adora attempts to shake them free. Smack them out of her head through her ear. Yet they

remain clinging on, refusing to be removed. Adora groans slightly as she steps back into her home.

Inside, Adora sees Adam hard at work trying to translate Angella's notebook. He sits on the ground, legs crossed against each other. On the table lies two books–One being said notebook, and the other, a brand new one. His glasses remain on top of his head as his eyes jump back and forth between the pages. Every now and again, Adam scribbles something down in his notebook. Sometimes, however, he looks at the open laptop near him, typing something away.

Glimmer is nowhere in sight.

Adora walks up to her brother, staying on the other side of the table. She attempts to read upside down, but struggles to do so. Partly because Adam's handwriting is horseshit.

"How did you ever get through your Master's with handwriting like that?" Adora asks bluntly.

Adam taps the end of his pen on the laptop. "I had this bad boy helping me out. Still have a lot of my papers and projects on it. Tell me if you ever want to check them out and I'll let you check them out!"

"Maybe after all this shit is done with." Adora tilts her head in an attempt to read better. "Got anything new yet? Anything interesting?"

"No. Though, Angella has a lot to say about Glimmer. She seems to be missing her a lot. Did Glimmer go off to college or something?"

Adora sucks on her teeth. "You can say that. It's not my place to say everything, but…They had a fight and Glimmer never got to apologize before Angella was killed."

Adam's face falls and he shrinks slightly. "Oh. Damn. That's horrible." He looks back at Angella's notebook. Eyes narrowing, he

stares down the Latin letters. “I should get back to this. I want to finish this before, well, ya know.”

“Right. Hey, do you know where Glim is? She still in the house, or did she go out into the woods?”

"I think she went into the attic to look for some stuff. She's actually been up there for a while now."

"Alright. Thanks. Have fun with the translation."

"Have fun being up in a dark, creepy ass place," Adam retorts.

Adora travels upstairs. She sees the feet of the ladder planted on the ground. The rest slowly reaches into the darkness of the attic. Adora travels up the rickety steps, using her hands to propel herself upward. When her head passes through the wide opening, she takes a moment to scan the area.

There are only two sources of light. One comes from the single, dusty window on the far side of the attic. The light that streams through reveals just how much dust dances in the air. While it allows for a good chunk of the attic to be visible, it cannot touch everything. That is where the other light comes into play.

On the complete other side of the attic is the new source of light. It comes from the little camp light set on top of a closed up, cardboard box. While the sun provides a pale yellow light, this one gives off a bright white. If Adora stares at it for more than a second, she swears her retinas will burn.

Close by, shuffling through other boxes, is Glimmer. She has yet to notice her girlfriend.

Adora finishes pulling herself into the attic. Carefully, she walks against creaking boards. When she gets close to the camp light, Adora decides to move it over a little. "I think the aliens on Mars can see your beacon."

Glimmer snorts. "Guess we should ask Adam if Martians are gonna invade to break it just so they can sleep." The hunter pulls herself out of the box and kneels on the ground. "How did your call with Catra go? Everything okay?"

"Yeah. Catra is doing good. The call went well…for the most part…"

This causes Glimmer to raise an eyebrow. "For the most part? What does that mean?"

Adora begins rocking on her heels, causing the old floorboards beneath her to groan in protest. She swings her arms in tempo with her legs. A fist hits her other palm as they come together in the movement. She debates where to start or even if she should tell her girlfriend what Catra said. Is it worth putting more onto Glimmer's already full and almost overflowing plate? She already is wound up enough with this (Adora can still smell the frustration from the other day coming off of Glimmer). Why should she add more?

But at the same time, she doesn't want the thought to remain in her mind. If she keeps it to herself, it will only implant itself further into her brain and make it harder to remove. Each day that passes will worsen it. And…if she doesn't tell…it might harm everyone in the end.

Adora leans against a stack of boxes. Fingers begin to pick at bits of cardboard. Not only is there a weight to her heart and shoulder, but to her words as well. “We talked a little about what to do. How to stop Shadow Weaver. But…She brought up a big problem in anything we were to come up with.”

“What? We barely have thought of anything.”

“I know. *She* knows. She said the problem…The problem was with me. *But!”*

Adora lifts a finger, cutting Glimmer off right away. The hunter’s mouth is open wide and there is a spark of anger in her lilac eyes.

“Don’t kill her. She’s right. We have two months to figure shit out before the May full moon. What are we going to do with me when that comes around?”

Glimmer blinks, realization slowly trickling into her brain. Her own fingers find things to fiddle with, that being themselves. Glimmer opens her mouth several times with no words coming out. Eventually, after a lot of internal debate, she does finally say something. One simple word.

“Shit.”

“My thoughts exactly.”

“I honestly forgot about that. Man.” A hand now runs through her dyed locks. At the very top of her hair, tips of raven hair have begun to make a comeback. Adora wonders how long it will take for her true color to begin pushing out her unnatural locks.

“The only thing that wouldn’t totally fuck things over is if I get control. I have no idea how to do that in two months!”

“Do you want to talk to Petra more? Or any of their siblings?”

Adora rips a large chunk of cardboard. “And have them tell me what? To ‘want’ it?” She can’t help but force out a laugh at that statement.

“There has to be a way, right?”

Adora feels something bubbling up inside of her. It burns her chest and spreads throughout her body. “Even if there is a way, why the hell do I have to?!”

“What do you mean?”

Given a form of permission, Adora lets loose. Hands slam down on the top of the box, stopped by whatever has been jammed inside. She feels her whole body become tense as she grits her teeth.

"Why do I have to learn to control it? Why do I have to deal with it? Why the hell was I bit?!"

"'Dora…"

"Like hell I would want my Mom to take it away from me. I don't trust her and I don't know if it would kill me, but!" Adora looks down at her hands. Her *human* hands. There are no hints of dark claws or thick fur. With the moon slowly turning into nothing in the sky, she can feel less of the wolf inside of her. Her dulling senses remind her that, for most of the time, she is in fact a human being. However, she'll never *fully* be one.

Adora continues with a growl. "I don't know, Glim! How can I want something like this, when only up until recently it hasn't caused suffering?!? Either I am out for blood and ready to kill anything in sight, or I am a stupid ass dog! I'll always feel the pain when I shift. It's horrible, Glimmer! It fuckin' *hurts.* "

"Shadow Weaver only ever told me people would see me as a monster. I have you, Bow, and now Adam and everyone else. I know I am not. I know because of you I have been able to not want to kill others! Yet, I hate it. I've been a werewolf all my life, I don't know what it's like to *not* be one. Yet, I just… *fuck!"*

Adora swipes suddenly at the closest thing to her. A small box goes flying, sailing a good distance in the air before colliding with the ground. Contents burst free and spill out all over. Clothing, toys, books, and who knows what else are now scattered on the ground. She has no idea where that explosion of anger came from. It was sudden and fast, like a thief in the night. When was the last time she thought about Shadow Weaver's taking away powers ability in regards to taking *hers* away? It's always been a painful experience, the shifts, and it's something she knows to expect and always brushed off as 'being used to it'. Yet, having your whole body twist and rip into something else never, *ever,* gets easier. Not to even mention the fear of hurting someone again!

As fast as the anger spreads over her, it disappears. A hollowness replaces it. Her tense body loosens and begins to tremble. Tears slip out of her eyes and roll down her face. Adora gasps for air as she finishes speaking. “Fuck, Glim, I just don’t know. Not only do we have to deal with trying to figure out how to stop my mother, but now we have to deal with me? Again?! Why not just chain me up again so then I am at least out of the way and not causing problems?!”

Boards creak from behind. Adora peers over her shoulder, finding her girlfriend only inches away. She spins around to get a better view of the hunter. The moment they are face to face, Glimmer’s arms wrap gently around Adora’s neck. There is no protest from the taller woman as she is being pulled forward. Foreheads touch together. This close, the scent of flowers flood into Adora’s nostrils.

Adora wraps her arms around Glimmer’s waist and lets her eyes flutter shut. She focuses all of her senses onto her girlfriend, who begins to speak.

“You know I am here for you.”

“I know. And I am for you.”

“We aren’t going to tie you up again. Not unless we have to. You won’t be in the way. I…I don’t know how I can help you get control. That’s not something I ever learned. But know that whether you're a werewolf or human, or scary werewolf or the dumbest one, I'll love you no matter what."

Adora sighs softly. She clings to the words of affirmation by Glimmer. "Thank you. And it's okay you don't know. I’m sorry for bursting out like that. I really hope I didn’t break anything in that box.”

“It was junk anyway. Don’t worry about it.”

Adora opens her eyes. Sky blue stares right at lilacs. The blonde can see the worry in them that Glimmer is desperately trying to

hide. Her hands begin to move upward, landing right on her girlfriend's cheeks. Adora does not waste any time in pulling Glimmer as close as possible. Their lips lock together. The warmth that spreads out from the kiss pushes out all her worries and fears. Even if the moment they pull away, everything comes crashing back, Adora doesn't care. She soaks up every ounce of her girlfriend's love.

When they pull apart, Adora places her forehead back on Glimmer's and says, "What are we gonna do?"

"I don't know, love." The grip around her neck suddenly tightens. Like it has become a death grip. "I won't let anything or anyone hurt you. I'll protect you. I can promise you that."

A smile creeps across her face. "You are the hunter. Isn't that your job after all? To protect things like me?"

"Yes, but I am also your girlfriend."

"I'll keep you safe too. I refuse to let Shadow Weaver harm anyone else. Especially those I care about."

Mixed in with the lilac scent, Adora swears she smells the hint of… sadness? Adora can't quite tell, but it's heavy and pricks at her nose. The blonde can't blame her for feeling like that, however. Adding this on to an already messy plate might not have been the best idea. Yet, Adora has to admit it feels good to have it off her chest.

"Let's stop talking about this," Glimmer says.

"Right." Adora lets go of her girlfriend and takes a step back. "You were looking for something, weren't you?"

"Hm!" Glimmer returns to digging around within a box. "I was trying to see if there was any old junk up here to use. You know, more noise admitters, tasers, what have you. I want to see what is good, what I can salvage for parts, or what I can trade for something. Need to compare my gear and get some new stuff."

“Where do you even get all your hunter crap?” Adora asks, realizing after all this time, she has no idea.

"Places like Perfuma or that bar we went to, of course. Might have to go out to one soon. Ah! Here's something!"

Glimmer pulls out a flare that is covered in a fine layer of dust. She wipes it clean with her hand. The hunter gives it a small shake. "Wonder if this thing still works…"

"Why the hell do you have a flare?!?"

"Sometimes you need to signal others, but also there is a special powder in these. Wanna guess what it is?"

"Wolfsbane?"

"How did I ever get so lucky to have a girlfriend as smart as you?" Glimmer says with an affectionate smile. "But yes. So when it burns, it gets in the air. Definitely don't suggest inhaling any of it."

"I'll keep that in mind. Do you need any help digging? I have nothing else better to do."

"Sure."

Days pass by slowly. Adora cannot tell one from the other. But as the days pass, it comes time to tell Petra and their siblings about what they have been told. During a day when all the Maritimus siblings are home, Adora, Glimmer, and Adam gather around a phone as they recount the events. Each time Adora tells this story about her sister and mother, it does not get *any* better. It feels like she is being punched in the gut by someone with brass knuckles, and someone is trying to twist and snap her heart off its arteries.

"So, two months, huh," Petra says. "Her not killing or attacking anyone seems awfully generous."

"Be happy she gave it to us!" Brooke retorts. Adora can hear the annoyed huff in her voice.

"When is May's full moon anyway?" Drake asks.

Adora gives him the answer. The moment she found out about the date, it seared its way into her brain. "It's May 3rd."

"Hey Petra. How are you doing anyway? Catra said she has been healing."

"Well, I can move around more now without tripping up," the werebear replies. "Having shifted for February helped heal a lot of things, but not all. But I'm fine."

"She's definitely not back at full strength. They won't admit that." Zephyr says.

Petra ignores their older brother's comment. "You said Adam was there? You're Adora's brother and the one who is trying to translate Angella's book?"

"Correct," Adam replies.

"Good. At least that might come in useful. I don't really have anything else to say, other than don't get killed during this time. Guys?"

Her siblings all agree. Saying to remain careful. If any of the four were to come up with something for a plan, no matter how small it is, they'll call. By some miracle, Petra doesn't bring up Adora's "problem". Either she simply forgot, figured Adora already knew, or is still fucked up like Zephyr said and it didn't cross their mind.

After they say their goodbyes and hang up, Glimmer shoves her phone back into her pocket.

"Least that is over with," she mumbles. "Everyone's on the same page now."

Adam jumps to his feet and begins stretching and twisting his body. “You guys gonna do anything today?”

Adora raises an eyebrow. “What do you mean?”

“It’s Valentine’s day?”

"That's today?!?" With everything going on, it had totally slipped her mind what today was. *Shit! I could have gotten Glimmer something!*

"Yeah. Right?" Adam quickly checks his phone. "Yeah. It's the fourteenth! Did you guys seriously forget? I would have figured you'd still remember today's date."

"Says the one who is single," Glimmer shoots back.

"Hey! I at least know when Valentine's Day is for whenever I get a boyfriend."

"You know Bow is free," Adora teases. This makes her brother turn a bright red. He snatches the journals from the table.

"I'm going to work on these." Is all he says before darting off into the guest bedroom. Adora and Glimmer both can't help but laugh.

Though, he is right. How the hell did she forget about today? Adora turns to her girlfriend. Resting her head on a hand, she asks, "Did you want to do something?"

"Do you?" Glimmer asks back.

"M-maybe," Adora admits. She never got to celebrate the holiday. Glimmer is her first girlfriend, so she doesn’t really know what to do on this day. Some of her cartoons growing up showed kids handing out cards and candies to their classmates. Adora was always jealous, wishing she could do something like that and get her hands on some chocolate.

The closest she came to celebrating the day was her and Catra making cards out of printer paper and any drawing materials they had, and exchanging them. That only lasted a few years, however. Those cards are long gone, both torn from anger, and lost in all the moves she has gone through in her lifetime.

"K-Kind of?" Adora admits. "I want to get my mind off of things, especially with the whole 'needing to get control' thing. But, it would also be my first Valentine's Day in, well, general! Did you ever celebrate it in school at all?"

Glimmer gives a small nod. "Yeah, we did that whole trading cards thing and bullshit. I always found it a little weird and never knew what to do with the cards I got. The free candy was nice though."

"Then let's do it! I don't know what, but we can do something, right?" Adora honestly feels a little lighter at the idea. "Are there any good places in Brightmoon you think we could go to?"

"That's a good question. Some places might be packed with couples. It *is* lunchtime right now." Glimmer begins tapping her finger against her chin. "Is there any stop in particular you want to go to? You've lived here long enough to know places."

Adora takes a moment to think. While this is true, she still hasn't seen *all* of Brightmoon. Many places remain a mystery to her. Not to mention the outskirts. Though, that gives her a little idea.

"Isn't there a little sweetshop just outside of Brightmoon? I think I saw it once when we were leaving town for the day."

"Oh yeah, I know that place. My Mom and Dad used to take me there a lot. That would be great. I bet they are having a sale on chocolate. Though, that doesn't mean you can drain your bank account there."

Adora rolls her eyes and gives her a playful shove. "It's my money, and I can do whatever the hell I want with it. But, I will only go there on one condition."

“What might that be?” Glimmer asks with a smile. Before Adora can answer, her girlfriend places a quick, yet tender kiss on her lips. “Is that what you needed?”

Adora grins from ear to ear. “Hmmm. *Maybe.* I could always use more. But no, no, it wasn’t that. I was going to say I will only go there if we then go somewhere for you. I want to see one of your favorite places. Does that sound like a deal to you?”

“My favorite place, huh…” Glimmer thinks for a moment before saying, “Okay. Deal!”

They quickly get dressed, throwing on boots and jackets. Adora shouts to her brother that they are going out and won’t know when they will be back and for Adam not to burn the place down. Adam promises not to only if the pair brings him back some sour candy. They agree and head out to the car.

Most of the snow has melted away. Only large, iced-over and greying piles remain stubborn. While the grass lacks the vibrancy of spring and summer, it is nice to see the green shoots again after nothing but solid white. As they drive through the heart of Brightmoon, Glimmer is right about places being packed. Through the windows, Adora can see restaurants have all their tables full, some even have a few waiting to be let inside. Part of Adora is happy that they are not going any place like that.

While they drive towards their destination, Adora begins to wonder what Perfuma and Scorpia, as well as Sea Hawk and Mermista are doing. Hopefully, they are having fun themselves. Maybe next Valentine’s day, they can all go out together.

Just have to make it through the spring…

They soon reach their goal. The shop is made up of wood, making it give off an air of quaintness. There are a few cars around, but they are far from packed. Perfect. Adora eagerly gets out of the car, ready to chow down on anything that catches her eye. She

does wait for Glimmer though, rocking on her heels. The moment the hunter is by her side, they jog inside.

The single-story building is full of life. Candies line the walls and rest in baskets in the middle of the store. Most of the people inside are couples, but a few have small children racing around. Adora feels her inner child bouncing around her own chest. She looks at Glimmer with bright, wide eyes. Her girlfriend gives a small nod. With that, Adora grabs a bag and begins to fill it.

Whatever she can get her hands on, she shoves inside. Most are chocolate or chocolate-covered things, but she gets a wide variety. Sour candies (plus extra for Adam), gum drops, small lollipops, whatever you can imagine. By the time she finishes, her bag is about to burst apart. Meanwhile, Glimmer's bag is about half that.

"Think you have enough?" Glimmer playfully asks.

"No. I could keep going," Adora replies.

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Well, enjoy having a stomach ache. Let's go check out."

With their bags paid for and a whole day left to go, they exit. Adora nibbles on some chocolate-covered pretzels before asking, "So, what is it you want to do?"

"I'm already doing it," Glimmer grins. "Anywhere with you is my favorite place to be."

"And you call me a dork! Seriously, though. You pick where we go next."

"Movies?"

Glimmer rubs her tired eyes. Even with the brightness turned all the way down and the blue light filter making her screen look

more orange then the fruit, they beg for her to stop looking at her computer. They beg her for sleep. Glimmer ignores it all. She gives herself a sharp pinch, snapping herself back awake before continuing to click away.

She scrolls through article after article of anything that could help in this plight. Articles about plants toxic to werecreatures, their weaknesses and strengths, what to use and when, and also when to incapacitate versus outright killing. So much of this she already knows from her years growing up. She has yet to find anything about weakening a monstrous werewolf to the point where it fucks them up for two years.

Hell, there isn't much on werecreatures stealing powers from others and becoming more monstrous. Maybe she needs to change how she searches. Different keywords, or something of the sort.

The twins sleep blissfully unaware. Adam remains downstairs. Hopefully, at this hour, out like a damn light. If his inner clock is anything like hers, he probably has listened to it. Adora is down the hall in their shared bedroom. Thankfully, when Glimmer snuck out to travel to her mother's room, she did not disturb her girlfriend's slumber. Here, she can be alone. Alone with her thoughts, and with her ghost.

I'll keep everyone safe, Mom, Glimmer thinks to herself as she continues to force herself to look at her screen. *I won't let anyone else die! I'll stop Shadow Weaver, no matter the cost for myself. I won't let you die in vain…*

Adora is quite surprised to find the other side of her bed devoid of life. Placing her hand on the small dip in the mattress, she finds it is cold. She knows for a *fact* Glimmer went to bed last night. Adora had snuggled up with her girlfriend nestled in her arms and used her body as a soft pillow. When the hell did she leave?

Adora slowly rises up, looking around the room. Nothing is out of place besides the empty space. Wherever Glimmer had gone, she had shut the door behind her. Worried, Adora slips out of bed. She doesn't even bother to stretch out her tired muscles as she exits the room. Scanning the hall, Adora finds the bathroom door shut.

She checks there first, using a knuckle to knock against the wood. "Glitter-bug?"

No answer. Pressing her ear to the door, no sounds can be heard. Adora makes one last check by opening it. The bathroom is unlocked, and there is no life in sight.

Huh…

Adora spins on her heels. Her eyes quickly land on something out of place. Angella's door is ajar. She knows for a fact the door would never be like that. Slowly, Adora steps towards the other room in the hall. Like before, she gives a small knock.

"Glimmer? Are you in there, hon?" Adora softly asks.

Again, no answer. However, this time, Adora can make out the sound of snoring.

Pushing the door open, Adora is greeted by her passed out girlfriend. She is at a small desk in the room. Her upper body is resting on the table top, the lower half of her laptop and her arms being used as a pillow. As she draws closer, Adora can see Glimmer is drooling a little.

What the hell were you doing in here? Adora wonders. The laptop screen is black, and Adora isn't about to go snooping. Instead, she quickly leaves the room, heading back into their shared one, before coming back. This time, she has a blanket in her hands, which she drapes over Glimmer's body.

"Rest up, hon," Adora whispers into Glimmer's ear. She places a kiss right below her girlfriend's temple. This causes the hunter to mumble something, making Adora's heart flutter.

"I'll see you when you wake. Love ya."

Before leaving, Adora pulls the shades, blocking out the orange from the new morning's light. The room is casted in shadow. Hopefully, this will allow Glimmer to get all the rest she needs. With that all said and done, Adora exits. She does, however, leave the door cracked to allow a sliver of light to creep into the darkness.

Chapter End Notes

Comments/kudos appreciated

March's Struggle

Chapter Notes

> And I'm finally back. I didn't expect to be gone from this from so long but life happened. While I do have them all done, they all still need to be edited so I'll be posting as they get done.
>
> Thank you for being patient and I can't wait to show the rest of this to yall
>
> Uh tw for minor flashback? Not much for tws

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora rubs her shoulder. Beneath her fingertips is rough, scarred skin. They have not changed in color, shape, or feeling in all these years of owning them. The ones Catra gave her many years ago have faded, though only to the smallest of degrees. *These* however, remain nearly as fresh as the night she got them. Letting her eyes flutter shut, Adora lets herself — no… *forces* herself to remember that night. Her brain screams at her to stop, to not send herself there. She has spent so long burying that night in her mind, and now here she is, digging it back up.

While her body quakes with every passing second, she steps back into that dark, freezing, snowy world. The black trees around her lack their crisp lines and nearly blend in with each other. Thick clouds of crystals form with every breath she takes. She can still feel the cold wind against her skin. Staring out in front of her, the world ends only a few feet away. Snow and trees are cut in half against the thick blanket of darkness. The further things get away, the more blurry they are. Only one thing is not affected by the wear of time.

The January moon shines bright and white. This is the last time she had gotten to see it without the dread of the wolf inside of her clawing and tearing its way out of her body.

Adora wonders if her memory is serving her right—that the moon truly is a sight to marvel at. Normally, she would rather avert her gaze away from the thing that has been a thorn in her side for so many years. Now, she finds her breath almost taken away and is nearly unable to turn around.

Nearly is the key word, however.

Adora turns her attention elsewhere. Spinning around on her heels, she prepares herself for her lifelong nightmare. There, in the center of a small opening, she spots a small body pressed against the snow. The white, frozen water is stained a bright crimson. Adora momentarily turns herself away from the image in her mind. Her body screams even more, almost drowning out everything else. Her brain begs the blonde to reopen her eyes, to rejoin the world of reality–but she knows she can't. Not yet.

She looks back, knowing who the small child is. There is nothing she can do in this memory–nothing other than stare at the scene laid out in front of her. So, instead of keeping her eyes on her younger self, she flicks them to the shadows hovering above the child. As always, the wolf that attacked her is just that–shadowy and lacking a solid form. With shaking feet, she steps closer and closer. Adora chews on her lower lip, almost making it raw.

Just as she comes within arms reach of the werewolf and her child self, the shadowy creature snaps its head around. Sharp, white teeth are stained red and are bared for all to see. Familiar, bright green eyes bore straight into her soul. Hundreds of thousands of images — *memories*— flash through her mind before her body and mind can no longer take it.

Eyes snap open wide. Her whole body breaks out into the coldest of sweats. Fingernails that threaten to darken scratch against the marble sink top. Her breaths come out harsh and ragged, barely able to intake any sort of oxygen. She feels not only the burning acid of bile tickling at the back of her throat, but the sharp claws of the wolf. One hand releases its grip on the sink and finds itself

on her mouth. Everything about to be thrown up out of her is forced back down against its will.

The green eyes she grew up with burn in her mind.

Hands fumble for the faucet. She misses it at least once and she curses under her breath. The second time around, her fingers manage to grasp the smooth metal. With a quick flick of her wrist, cold water begins to pour out of the spout. She cups her hands under the flowing water and once a small pool has formed, she splashes it against her face. Almost instantly, the cold water begins to calm her nerves.

Adora repeats the process several times. She would continue if her face didn't begin to sting from the coldness. With her heart settling and her breathing at a steady tempo, she cuts off the water before leaning back against the sink. Adora wonders why on earth she did that to herself. She knew what was waiting for her when she stepped foot into her memories. How long did she push the thought of who bit her into the back of her mind? All she has to go on are those eyes and now knowing Shadow Weaver showed up shortly after.

Her head begins to ache.

Adora groans. This isn't the best way to start off her morning. Though, is it the worst one? She decides not to think of anything anymore. The blonde sighs deeply before exiting the bathroom. With Glimmer probably going to be sleeping for the next couple hours or so and Adam most likely doing the same, she'll have to find ways to entertain herself. Though, just as she begins to think of things to do while the rest of the house sleeps, something stops her.

"Hey, how are you guys?" Adam's voice echoes from the living room and up into the second floor.

Adora tilts her head and slowly makes her way to the small balcony. She doesn't want to spy, yet something keeps her in

place. Not only due to the wonder of why her brother is already up, but because other voices capture her attention–like when you hear an actor's voice in a new show and cannot put your finger on who they are. Instead of annoyance at the lack of a name, she feels her stomach twist with remorse.

"We are fine, kiddo," a deeper, gruff voice says.

"Still not going to tell us what you are up to?" a softer, light voice adds. It doesn't take much guesswork for Adora to know who he is talking to. Adam only confirms her suspicions in his next sentence.

"No, Mom. I promise I have a good reason for it!" Adam replies.

"We just want to make sure you are okay, baby."

"I know. I promise I am."

"Are you at least making friends?" Randor asks.

Adora can hear the smile in her brother's voice. "Yes I am! Lotta 'em actually! I hope you can get to meet them soon. I definitely want you to meet one—you're gonna love them!"

A soft smile spreads across Adora's face, along with a sharp stab in the heart.

"Can't wait," Marlena's voice says. "Call us again soon, okay?"

"Will do. Love ya guys."

"We love you too."

Silence. There is some shuffling as Adam moves around. Adora rocks on her heels as she debates what to do. Her stomach isn't really in the mood to eat. She had planned on going downstairs to find things to do while everyone slept. With her brother out of his bedroom, that went out the window. She knows if she goes back to bed, her heavy limbs will refuse to lift her up again.

She drums her fingers against the banister for several seconds before deciding to head down. When her feet land on the flooring of the first floor, it does not take long at all for her to locate her brother. He is stretching out his body and letting his bones pop back into place. Upon noticing his sister, he doesn't stop but simply says, "Hey."

"Hey. You're up early," Adora states.

Adam holds up one of his legs behind him as he speaks. "Don't get used to it. I just had some stuff to do."

"I heard." Adora pauses for a moment, rubbing the back of her head. "Was that Marlena and Randor — I mean… I mean, Mom and Pa?"

He gives a small nod. "Yeah. Been doing my best not to spill what's happening. Honestly, I still have no idea what I would tell them about you. Anyway, how are you feeling?"

"Do you really need to ask? What about you? How did you sleep?"

"Probably only slept like an hour or so. Tried to find something to do, like working on the book, but my eyes started to get tired. I was going to make some breakfast. What do you want?" He begins walking away.

Adora grips her stomach. "Not hungry."

Adam stops dead in his tracks, one leg still mid-air. He stares at her over his shoulder. "You *have* to be hungry. I actually don't think I saw you eat last night."

"Not hungry." Adora reiterates. "You don't have to baby me."

"I'm going to baby you if you are gonna act like this."

Adora scoffs. "I'm fine, Adam."

Adam juts a finger out, ready to poke it between her eyes. His face is twisted into a serious look. “You’re eating. Do I need to wake up Glimmer and have her tell you to eat?”

Any words Adora is about to say stick to the inside of her throat. She snaps her mouth shut. No. She doesn’t want that. Glimmer looked peaceful, why should she disturb that? Plus, she sure as hell doesn’t need two people trying to get her to eat.

“Why are younger siblings so annoying?” Adora sighs.

“That’s our job!” Adam quips back. “You don’t have to eat a whole meal, but at least make some toast.”

While Adam makes his own breakfast–a hearty looking omelette–Adora makes her toast with butter. All the while, the older twin notices her brother keeping an eye on all her movements. He only ceases when Adora rips a piece of the bread and pops it into her mouth. His eyes turn back to his food.

Adora forces herself to eat the rest of the single slice of toast. Her stomach grumbles at her, not totally pleased by the food. She hopes that she doesn’t end up in the bathroom later, throwing up the small breakfast. Though, even if it’s annoying, Adora has to admit she feels a little better. She can lift her shoulders a little higher. Honestly, she could make some more, but a pang from her stomach tells her not to go overboard.

After getting her small fill in, Adora decides to get in some sort of order for the day. As she heads towards the upper bedroom, she takes a small detour. The blonde takes a peek into the other bedroom. Glimmer remains asleep, having not budged an inch. Even the blanket is in the same position. Adora lets her be for now.

The soft, tender brush from an unknown source disturbs her dreamless slumber. Despite the hint of roughness, it feels like the kiss of a summer’s breeze. Glimmer mumbles something, pressing

herself further into the unknown source. All around her is nothing but a thick sheet of darkness. She clings to every ounce of the touch.

The breeze turns into a gentle whisper. “Glitter-bug. You awake?”

Another mumble. Glimmer slowly opens her eyes. With the only source of light coming from the hallway, everything around her is dark and unfocused. After several blinks, the face of her girlfriend becomes crisp and clear. The sight of Adora pushes away the rest of the darkness from her field of view. A smile creeps across the hunter's face as she lifts her heavy body from the table.

"I'm awake now," Glimmer yawns.

"Good." Adora places a hand on her girlfriend's back, rubbing small circles. "Are you alright, hon?"

“Do you really have to ask?”

“That’s not what I mean. Do you know what time it is?”

“No?”

“It’s almost one in the afternoon. You've never slept this late. Are you okay?” Adora begins to turn her head, eyes falling onto the laptop. From Glimmer's slight movement, it too has been awakened. “What the hell were you looking up?”

Glimmer reacts without thinking. Her arms shoot out in front of her, hands forcing the laptop to snap shut. She swears that she must have cracked the screen from how hard she closed it. Her heart leaps into her throat, almost cutting off her access to oxygen. Out of the corner of her eye, Glimmer sees the stunned expression on Adora’s face. The blonde takes a step back, hands held up slightly in front of her.

“Sorry?” Adora says, unsure.

“No, I am. Didn’t mean to react like that.”

“Can I ask why you did? Not to be nosey.”

“Uh…” Glimmer pauses for a moment. She clicks her tongue against the back of her teeth before saying, “I was just looking stuff up for when we have to deal with, ya know. I guess I’m just jumpy from nerves.”

She forces a smile, hoping Adora doesn’t see straight through her lie. Adora raises an eyebrow.

“Do you want to talk about it?” the blonde asks.

“Nah. Not right now. And you said it’s one, right? I should probably get ready for the day, shouldn’t I? Let me get changed and I will meet you downstairs. Sound good?”

“Okay. I was going to go for a walk for a bit. Came up here for both my jacket, and to check on you.” Adora steps closer, closing the gap between them and placing a soft kiss between the hunter’s eyes. Glimmer sighs at the touch. It’s like a butterfly has landed on her head. “I’ll see ya in a bit, ‘kay?”

"‘Kay! Have fun!”

Glimmer watches her disappear. Once her girlfriend is gone, when the footsteps fade away and the front door is heard opening and then closing, she turns her attention back to her laptop. With a heavy sigh, the hunter reopens it. When the screen lights back up and reawakens (again), the article she had been reading stares her dead in the face.

Ways To Stop A Werewolf.

Glimmer bookmarks the page before closing her laptop, this time gently. Standing, she stretches out her aching body. It takes effort to lift herself off the chair and dress herself for the day. With how much time she spent asleep, part of the hunter is tempted to remain in her pajamas. Somehow, she musters the willpower to change into something presentable, even if that is just a

sweatshirt. Being *Adora's* sweatshirt, it's too big on her but at least she can bury herself into it when she needs to.

There is no time to think about what to do with herself now that she's awake when Adam practically teleports in front of her. Glimmer yelps and stumbles back. It takes everything in her to not sucker punch him in the face. "Adam!"

"You're eating," Adam sternly says.

"Excuse me?"

"If you are anything like Adora, you're gonna say you aren't hungry when you should eat. Plus, you've been sleeping all day. Either eat something, or I will shove it down your throat."

"Since when did you become my mother?"

"I know what you are probably feeling. It sucks. Trust me when I say it's better to have a little something than nothing at all. I already got Adora to have some food, now you."

Glimmer crosses her arms and raises an eyebrow. "What are you going to do about it if I don't eat?"

Adam grins from ear to ear and leans forward. "I'll tell Adora you haven't. Maybe even Bow. I know he worries about you too."

Glimmer holds her jaw tight. She remembers how long it took for Bow to not fret after her attack. And what about Adora? Glimmer narrows her eyes at Adam.

"You know you are a pain in the ass, right?" Glimmer grumbles.

"Yes, I know. So what's it gonna be?"

Glimmer huffs and follows Adam into the kitchen. She notices the bread has not been tied back with the clip but rather into a knot. For her fuel for the day, she chooses a simple bowl of cereal. Nothing flashy at all. Adam must have eaten already (or he is a

hypocrite) and is typing away on his laptop. The *clicky-clack* of the keys and the noise of Glimmer eating are the only sounds that fill the air.

Deciding to not be in this awkward state, Glimmer sips the milk in her bowl, chucks it in the sink, and walks over to the table Adam sits at.

“Wanna get in some crossbow training?”

“What?” Adam blinks.

“I don’t know what else to do, so why not make sure you don’t die? Unless you have something else in mind while Adora is out.”

"I got nothing. Least this gives me something to do.” He shuts his laptop and pushes his chair away from the table. While he puts on his shoes and jacket, Glimmer heads up into the attic to grab the targets her mother trained her with. They lie in a corner, gathering nothing but dust. She blows it all away in one breath before carrying them down, somehow without dropping them.

With Adam’s help, the two quickly set up the targets. Once everything has been secured, Glimmer gives her friend another rundown about loading a crossbow. She lets him load his own arrow and fire it off. Pleased, the hunter leaves him to it. At first, Glimmer stands nearby, making sure Adam doesn’t do something completely stupid. However, as he begins to lose himself in the training, she lets a distance grow between them until she becomes hidden within the trees.

Glimmer watches him from afar. Adam does not have the correct posture for holding a crossbow, though, to his credit, he hasn’t hit any bark yet. Sure, most of the arrows he fires off are in the white edge of the targets. Anything is better than nothing. With another shot, Adam manages to get in the next color. A huge, shit-eating grin spreads across his face. With a skip in his step, he heads off to the next target… and fails to look around.

Seeing an opportunity, Glimmer slowly stalks Adam, waiting to see if he picks up on her presence. With so few arrows left, they need to be used sparingly. However, Adam does not quite have this memo in his head. As the hunter draws closer, her friend finishes off his ammo. Instead of worrying about being defenseless, Adam puffs out his chest in pride at his handiwork.

It's time to strike.

Glimmer closes the gap between them. Icy-snow crunches loudly under her, alerting Adam. However, he does not spin around in time. The moment he is settling from his spin, the hunter places her hand against his chest and shoves him. Her friend falls flat on his back. With a groan, he pulls himself onto his arms, giving Glimmer a ` *what the fuck´* glare.

"If this was real life, you'd be dead." Glimmer replies before sticking out her hand. "You're doing good, though."

Adam steadies himself out. He brushes the melting snow off his body. "This is only my second time. Do you really think that?"

"I do. You have a long way to go, but I think you can become a good shot. Do you want to try another round? You're not too cold, are you?"

Adam shakes his head. "I can go another round. Though, you mind *not* pushing me flat on my ass?"

Pursing her lips, Glimmer taps a finger against her chin. She hums slightly as she thinks about this request. Upon seeing Adam's pout, she chuckles and agrees. After gathering up the arrows and adjusting some targets into new areas to keep Adam on his toes. With everything set up, they repeat the cycle–minus Glimmer jumping Adam.

This second time around, Adam does a smidge better. While a few more end up in the black, he does end up missing a couple. Because of this, upon finishing, collection becomes a pain in the ass. The arrows that did not make their mark on the target have

lodged themselves deeply into the thick tree bark. Unfortunately, one of them snaps in two, with the sharp end now forever stuck in the oak.

With noses and ears red, it's time to head inside. Adora has yet to return from her walk, continuing to leave the two to their lonesome. Keeping up with training Adam, Glimmer decides to show him a few more tricks of the trade. Not wanting a repeat with the wolfsbane, she grabs her other equipment.

"Will this stuff work?" Adam asks. Currently, he is studying the noise emitter. Glimmer has already warned him not to set it off. "Ya know, in stopping Shadow Weaver?"

"I want to get some new things. Thinking of going in a couple weeks after I finish doing inventory. As for will it stop her? I hope it will at least slow her down enough to keep her at bay. The only problem is what Catra said. If she really is some *beast,* that's a problem. I already ran into that when Adora first escaped."

"What happened?"

Glimmer reaches for her taser. She runs a hand against the smooth, cold metal. The memory of that night claws its way into the forefront of her mind. Adora's burning red eyes, the snarl that bared her sharp, snow-white teeth, and the thick tension of danger in the air. The hunter sighs deeply before saying, "It was right before she bit me. I tried to stun her with this. It should've worked, but it didn't affect her."

"If anything, it just pissed her off. That is when she bit me. If it wasn't for Bow and using wolfsbane on Adora, I'd probably be out of an arm, or dead."

"What about–" Adam starts.

"No," Glimmer cuts him off, "I don't think that same wolfsbane would work. I mean, it *might.* It did for Adora but… I don't want to risk it not working. I'd rather know what my mom used and go off that."

“I still haven’t found anything yet.” Adam rests his head against his free hand. “I really hope she wrote it down.”

“Same here. But for now, this is all we got.” Glimmer grips her taser harder in her hand. Her knuckles begin to turn white. “If this cann–couldn’t stop Adora, I have something in mind that will. Just have to find a store with it.”

Just then, the front door opens. Adora appears. As she shuts it, Glimmer notices a shiver running down her spine. “Man, it’s cold,” the blonde says. She keeps her jacket on as she walks over to her girlfriend and brother. “What are you two up to?”

“Just making sure Adam doesn’t die,” Glimmer states.

“Ah!”

"How was the walk?” Adam asks.

“Cold, fine. I’m going to make some hot chocolate. You guys want some?”

“Sure,” both say.

Breathe in, breathe out. In for four… out for four… In for four… out for four…

Adora times her breathing, keeping up with her thoughts. She keeps her body relaxed… as best she can. Every part of her wants to bounce her leg to burn off all of the excess energy bottled up inside of her. It’s like an annoying itch she cannot scratch, and it only grows worse and worse, like a rash. The blonde grits her teeth as it crawls up her throat.

She resists, however. Her slow, steady breathing continues. Adora does her best to focus on *that* and nothing else. This is the only idea she has at the moment. The only idea she has for control. After all, doesn’t keeping calm help her from shifting in dire

situations? Can doing these techniques before help her during her actual shifts? Hopefully… Maybe…

Adora even tries to tell herself that she will gain control the next time. It never worked when she was a child, no matter how hard she tried. Maybe if she just tries harder , then this time, she can be of use and not a burden. The blonde takes another deep breath, calming her heart.

CRASH!

Adora's heart leaps straight into her throat. Her body nearly follows suit as it flies off of the couch. The loud, metallic noise almost causes her to shoot through the second floor, attic, and roof. She scrambles to her feet, wondering what on Earth caused that noise.

"What the hell was that?" Adora shouts. She quickly looks towards the direction she heard it.

"Sorry!" Adam and Bow apologize. Both men had been looking at the notebook together. Her brother disappears for a moment behind the island before reappearing with a large cookie tray in his hands. There is a frown on his face.

"I knocked this over by mistake," he admits. "Lost the rest of the cookies, which sucks. I wasn't paying attention."

Adora sighs. Her hand finds her chest as her heart continues its laps. "You gave me a heart attack."

"Sorry for messing up your concentration," Bow says. "How do you think it was going anyway? Do you think it's gonna help?"

Adora rubs the back of her neck. There is no point in sitting back down, so she walks over to the pair. Adam has returned to the floor and is picking up the soiled cookies. She decides to help out as she speaks.

"I don't know. We won't know until later. I hope it does…"

Bow places a hand on her back. "You got this. I know you can do it."

"Yeah!" Adam chimes in. "If you're anything like me, you'll be smart enough to figure something out."

Adora rolls her eyes. "Yet you aren't smart enough to not knock over a tray right in your line of sight. But… Thanks."

Please work….

---

*Breathe in, breathe out. In for four… out for four… In for four… out for four… You **will** get control. You **HAVE** to get control.*

Adora feels the wolf prickling at her skin. She does everything she can to bite back the pain. She knows what is to come and prepares for the pain. All her focus, however, is not on powering through that. No matter how much it feels like her body is having hundreds of needles bore into her muscles, she ignores it. Her mind remains solely on her thoughts.

Breathe in, breathe out. In for four… out for four… In for four… out for four… You can get control.

Adora's body begins to curl in as it struggles to remain intact. The pain is worse than the itchy feeling from the other day. She continues to ignore it. If this fails, there'll only be one more chance to succeed. Failure is *not* an option.

Breathe in, breathe out. In for four… out for four… In for four… out for four…

She reminds herself that Glimmer and Adam are here. Bow is not terribly far away either. The others are a phone call away. No matter what happens, they are there. Her mind wanders back to so many months ago. How Glimmer said she wouldn't leave. She never has.

Breathe in, breathe out. In for four… out for four…

Her teeth break through the skin of her lower lip. The hot iron sticks to the roof of her mouth and every inch of her tongue.

Breathe in, breathe out.

She feels her body becoming heavy. Something pushes herself out of the steering wheel of her brain. The world spins out of control. Colors blend together like used paint on a palette.

Breathe.

She forgets how to breathe.

…

When the world comes back to, she stares through a frost covered window. Shapes are indistinguishable. They are simply dark, blobs nearly featureless. Her eyes only pick up on the hints of cool purples on the smaller figure, and the splash of warm oranges on the taller figure. Everything she looks, she's unable to give a name to. She can barely remember *her* own name of Adora.

Red blends into her sights.

Glimmer watches Adora growl and pace around the living room. The muscles on her large–albeit smaller than way back when–near-monstrous wolf twitch with anger. Dark fur bristles on her flanks. But what the hunter narrows in on are her girlfriend's eyes. Golden, yet with a tint of red.

"Adora?" Glimmer kneels down. She sticks her hand out towards her girlfriend, who quickly notices the gesture. She begins to sniff the hand. Knowing there is no threat hanging in the air, the hunter moves her hand upwards and places it between Adora's ears.

“It’s okay…" Glimmer tries her best to smile for her girlfriend. "We always have next month.”

A small growl slips from Adora’s lips. Her teeth flash for a moment before she suddenly pulls away. In several strides, she is at the back door, pawing at the handle. It’s to no avail.

“What is she doing?” Adam asks.

Glimmer watches her. Adora falls back to her feet, pacing even harder. Her girlfriend continues to let out small, annoyed-sounding growls. The hunter can see how tense Adora holds her body, like the touch of a gnat could break the camel’s back. Ears strain as they are pulled all the way to the back and her hand hangs low.

Slowly, she walks over towards Adora. “Can you understand me, love?”

Adora pauses and looks up at her.

“If I open this door, I am not about to go chasing you for a third time, correct? I really don’t want to do that.”

She receives her answer in a chuff. With that, Glimmer throws open the door. Instead of darting out, Adora speed-walks out. Once out, the hunter watches her girlfriend enter the backyard and start up her pacing once more. Occasionally, her paw swipes at the parts of snow that stubbornly remain on the ground. Glimmer’s heart not only twists inside her chest, but drops to the bottom of her stomach.

Saying nothing more, she shuts the door, but leaves it ajar enough for Adora to push it open with her nose.

Tonight will be long…

Chapter End Notes

Kudos/comments appreciated

The Silver Lining

Chapter Notes

> i dipped again lmao sorry. Life is life and my brain has latched onto something else but i will finish this. energy to finishing proofing is what i need so just be patient even if you see me writing other stuff. But as always enjoy uh dont really think there are any real tws for this

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer's eyes fixate on the window. The full moon illuminates the Whispering Woods in a pale, silver outline. From her position within the house, she is unable to see Adora. She attempts to hone her hearing, hoping to pick up on the pacing and chuffing. Her ears fail her. Nothing catches her attention. She doesn't bother trying any further. No need to strain herself. The hunter's body already is protesting enough as it wishes to catch up on proper sleep.

With the night still young, she decides to take some cues from Adam. Glimmer digs through her bag, pushing her belongings aside before grabbing what she needs. Her trusted notebook. Instead of settling down on a chair or couch, she remains on the ground. Though, Glimmer crawls a couple feet to rest herself on the back of the sofa. A thumb pushes past filled up pages until reaching the newest one. There are some notes scribbled on the paper with some of the information Catra gave. Plus, her best attempt at a drawing of Shadow Weaver's monstrous form.

Ignoring her previous notes, Glimmer jots down today's date and begins writing.

Adora is still in husky-like form. Though, reverted slightly.

Didn't attack, blowing off steam in the backyard.

Dunno what is going to happen in a couple months…

She begins to sketch out the image of Adora's werewolf form. After so many months of doodling her girlfriend, Glimmer could do this with her eyes closed and her left hand tied behind her back. In no time at all, the bust of a werewolf is made. Downcast eyes, ears flat, and a solemn look on her face. Looking back at all the others she has doodled—the dopey ones of her previous transformations, the monstrous one of a couple months ago, and everything else she drew at random in between—this by far is the saddest.

Glimmer feels a weight attach itself to her heart. A thumb brushes up against the fresh drawing. The drying ink smudges on the paper. Regardless, she continues, wishing to be able to help the real thing. Eyes turn to the cracked open back door, letting in the cold air that nips the air.

How long is she going to be out there?

Glimmer checks her phone, making a mental note to check in on Adora if she does not come in soon. Setting it back down on the ground, she continues to scribble down notes—more thoughts about the days ahead—and doodles. Most of which continue to be Adora.

After about a half hour or so of working in her notebook, she snaps it shut and slowly rises to her feet. Despite sitting on the ground for a relatively short time, her back groans with dull pain. Her tailbone especially is not happy with the hunter. Rubbing it in hopes of calming the nerves, she ventures over to the window.

She presses her face against the cold glass. Squinting her eyes, it takes her a moment for her sights to hone in on Adora. The werewolf has ceased ripping up the earth and now lies curled up on the ground (snow and dirt all around her). Her back is turned towards the house, obscuring her face.

Glimmer sighs, her hot breath fogging up her sights. Rocking on her heels, she thinks on what to do. After some internal debating,

the hunter decides to leave well enough alone. From one twin to another.

“What are you up to?” Glimmer asks as she draws close to the couch.

There is no answer. Adam doesn’t so much as *twitch* at the sound of his name. Raising an eyebrow, Glimmer repeats herself, a little louder and closer. *Still* he does not hear. The younger twin's nose is buried so deep into his notebook, Glimmer swears he could become a part of its pages.

A little annoyed and a little curious, Glimmer gets as close as possible to Adam. Pursing her lips, she blows a small yet strong stream of air to the back of his neck. Now *this* gets his attention.

Adam’s book goes flying in the air as his body jerks from the unsuspected sensation. He spins around, barely able to keep himself on the couch. With a hand slapped over his neck, he finally turns his sights on the hunter. His eyes are wide, as if he is a deer in headlights. She can see the gears turning in his head.

“What the hell was that for?!?” he finally spits out.

Glimmer snickers, barely able to hold back a snort. “I called your name! What else was I supposed to do?”

“Not that?” Adam huffs as he snatches his open book from the ground. He blows off any dust that might’ve gotten on the cover.

“What got your attention so much?”

Adam hesitates. He chews on his lower lip, eyes diverted towards the ground, as he stands up. With slow, heavy steps, he walks over to the hunter. Glimmer feels her heart skip a beat in her chest, startled. The air around them grows heavy.

“Well,” Adam starts. He begins flipping the pages. “I had been skipping around with the translation. Some sections are easier

than others and hopefully I can still match the pages up…Anyway! I went to the last pages your mother wrote."

He pauses and stares down at the open section of his notebook. With a deep exhale, he spins the book around and sticks it out towards the hunter.

"I don't know what happened, and I won't ask. But, Adora told me you and your mother had some troubles at…the end. And well…here. Just read it yourself. She talked about you a lot but this is something…extra special."

Glimmer stares at the book in Adam's hand. Everything inside is the translation of her mother's words. Her secrets that she kept hidden even from her daughter. Answers to this nightmare everyone has found themselves in lies within, waiting to be uncovered. Now, she has learned her mother's own thoughts about Glimmer *herself* is waiting to be read. Angella's last words to her only child and daughter.

Shaking hands become clammy. Her heart has moved from her chest and into her ears, drowning out the world around her. Legs threaten to give, only hanging on by the smallest of threads. Carefully, she takes the book, feeling the weight against her palms. The page in question is dog-eared and waits to be opened. Eyes find Adam. His dark blue eyes are covered in a layer of mist. He gives a nod.

With a breath, she looks at the pages in her hands. Adam has done his utmost to write the translated words as neatly as possible. It takes up a little over two pages. Several times she needs to read the first words and get her brain to comprehend everything. Finally, her brain works.

Tonight shall be a special night. Glimmer will be home for the first time in years. I have dreamed of this night so many times I have lost count. I believe that I could still be dreaming at this moment as I write! There is much I want to catch up on and tell her. Though, before any of this can occur, I must go out to hopefully

track down a troublesome foe. In case things go wrong, knowing what has been left unsaid, I shall write in here.

Glimmer, if you have learned to read my secrets, or have had a translator, and you are reading this, I am sorry. I'm sorry I could not return home and see the wonderful woman you have become. And I am sorry for my actions in the past. My intent never was never to harm you. All I ever wanted in my life was to protect you and see you grow. After longing for a child for years, your arrival was the greatest celebration of my life and I couldn't bear the thought of something happening to you. I wanted you to take on our family name yet the dangers always gave me nightmares I couldn't even tell your father.

But I know now I was wrong. You always have been so strong, brave, and smart. Your skills as a hunter I know will surpass mine and many others. Whatever you do in your life, you will leave the brightest of marks on this earth. So many years ago, you would look up with me with those big, bright, violet eyes. Now, I find myself doing the same. Even if I am no longer with you, if my time has come and I am unable to destroy this note,, I want you to know…

*I am so **proud** of you, Sweetheart. Nothing you ever could do will ever change that. I always have. If the reality I fear comes true, I will be watching you from Heaven with that same pride I feel now. My only hope for you is that you continue to be that wonderful woman I know you are. Kind, smart, brash, bold. Someone who fiercely loves and isn't afraid to let the world know that. And one who protects those that cannot protect themselves.*

Though, no matter who or what you become, as long as you are happy, then I am happy.

I love you, Glimmer. Always have. I only wish I could tell you that again.

Please remain safe, Sweetheart.

Love, Mom.

Droplets begin falling onto the paper. At first, one by one, they stain the pages with their salt. Then, it picks up speed, becoming like a small summer's storm. Words become trapped under the puddles and blur from the lakes in her eyes. The shaking from before spreads throughout her whole body. Even her breath becomes uneven and harsh. Glimmer opens her mouth, wishing to say something… *anything,* but no words come out. Only choking sobs.

Her body crumbles to the ground. Her arms clutch the books so close to her chest, it could become a part of her very being. Glimmer refuses to let go of this sudden lifeline. The years of wondering, the years of regret, the years of wishing have now been answered. Despite everything that happened between them, despite the words she threw at her mother and used to twist a knife in her heart, Angella never hated her. She loved her and nothing *ever* stopped that.

Glimmer struggles to breathe. Her sobs choke her. The words of apology and love towards her mother are unable to break through her nearly closed throat. Her world shrinks around her. When Adam wraps his arms around Glimmer, the hunter can barely register it. No matter how hard she tries to calm herself, to regain some semblance of her body, she fails. The floodgates have been busted wide open and nothing can stop it.

A new sound enters her world of sobs. The back door opens and floorboards creak under someone's weight. Glimmer can just make out the sight of Adora lumbering into the living room. As she draws closer, lips lift slightly, showing off the front row of teeth. A low rumble fills the air as her eyes narrow at her brother. Adam gives a small signal to be quiet.

Glimmer pulls away from Adam, shifting her sights towards her girlfriend. She finally lets go of the notebook. Adora stares at it for a moment, ears suddenly snapping to attention. Eyes grow soft as her head tilts to the side. Gingerly, the werewolf steps closer,

nudging her muzzle into Glimmer’s now free arms. The hunter wastes no time in burying herself against Adora.

Thick fur tickles her nose. The musky scent of Adora’s wolf self floods her scenes, though it cannot drown out the smell of sandalwood from her. Sobs and tears continue to pour out of Glimmer. Adora begins to wrap her body around the shaking hunter, keeping her so close that Glimmer can hear her girlfriend’s heartbeat. Slowly, her body settles.

The trembles cease to be. Tears no longer flow from her eyes, causing them to burn from the growing dryness. She gains her ability to breathe, though each breath stings from her raw throat. Her chest will ache for the next couple days, there is no doubt about that. Here, nestled against Adora’s warm body she can forget about all pain she feels.

“Are you okay?” Adam’s voice breaks apart the heavy atmosphere that has been created.

“Yeah,” Glimmer replies, finding her voice hoarse. Before pulling away, she inhales deeply. The smell of her girlfriend fills her and gives her the push to sit up straight. What tears are left on her face are wiped away with the hem of her shirt. Any and all energy she might have had has evaporated. The thought of standing to her feet fills her with dread.

Adora presses her muzzle against Glimmer’s side, regaining her attention. Eyes remain the same shade as before but are full of nothing other than tender love. She presses her head against the hunter’s, making a soft moan. Glimmer chuckles lightly and wraps her arms around the wolf’s neck.

“I’m okay now, Starlight. I’ll tell you everything later when you have your brain back.”

Adora answers with a slobbery lick to the face.

“Ah! Gross!” Glimmer jerks back, groaning. She uses the collar of her shirt to rid herself of Adora's spit. "My mouth was open!"

Adora can only bark happily. Her tail begins to wag, accidently sending the notebook to the other side of the room.

At least you are feeling better, Glimmer thinks to herself. Some good to take away from this night. How many more hours are left until the morning? Far too many.

"Uh, Adam?" Glimmer says.

"What's up?"

The hunter looks over herself for a moment. "I don't think I can stand up. My legs feel like jell-o. Do you mind helping me out?"

"Yeah."

Adam rises to his feet. He brushes off any dirt and dust that has hitched a ride on his pants. Sticking out his hands, he uses all his strength to bring Glimmer to her feet. However, her feet refuse to keep her weight. Anything she puts on her soles, even the tiniest of pressure, her knees bend sharply. The hunter must use her friend for support. With Adora's help, who keeps Glimmer from falling backwards, she is guided to the couch. Her body flops against the cushions.

Her whole body feels like it has been hit by several trucks. Her eyelids are weighed down by an invisible force. Glimmer attempts to fight it, to remain awake for Adora. However, the moment Adam places a blanket on her body, she knows the battle is lost. With the last bit of her energy, Glimmer reaches for Adora, who now lays on the floor beside her. By some grace of God, she slips into a dreamless world.

When Glimmer comes too, the first thing she hears is a moan. She is jerked by a kick to the couch. With blurry eyes, she leans over and looks down at the floor. Adora has flipped over in her own semi conscious state. Eyes are half open and half lit. They barely are focused as they stare up at the hunter.

“Good morning, love,” Glimmer says. “How are you doing?”

Glimmer watches the gears in Adora’s head turn. After a couple blinks and a few seconds, she gives her girlfriend a thumbs up.

“Are you comfortable down there? Do you want to get up or do you want to stay naked on the ground?”

Adora grunts. An answer only Glimmer can interpret. She stretches herself out first, getting the blood flowing through her body. Her limbs remain sluggish as she rolls off the couch. The hunter straightens herself out, popping some bones back into place, before aiding Adora into a sitting position. Lights in her sky blue eyes have begun to grow.

“Can you stand on your own?” Glimmer asks, rubbing a hand on her girlfriend’s back.

Adora places half her body on the couch and begins pushing herself upward. Halfway up, she signals for Glimmer for aid. Once on her feet, the blonde takes several shaking steps forward. Glimmer remains at her side as she steadies out. Even knowing that her girlfriend can make her way up the stairs, she refuses to move. Not until Adora blocks her entry to the upstairs bathroom.

“I can shower by myself,” Adora grins.

Glimmer scoffs, rolling her eyes. “Holler if you need anything.”

Adora closes the door. The hunter waits until she hears the water to turn on to spin on her heels and head down the hall. Instead of entering her room, Glimmer makes a quick detour into her mother’s room. Feet guide her towards the photos that line her table. She gingerly takes the one of her newborn self, being held by her mother. Through misty sights, she brushes her thumb against the image of her mother.

“Don’t you worry about me,” Glimmer whispers. “I’ll finish what you started.”

Glimmer holds the photo close to her chest. “I love you, Mom.”

Adora strains to recall her night. The fuzz she has become accustomed to has grown into a near full blown static. Like that of an old TV on the wrong channel. Yet, there are the outlines of images. Sometimes, if she is lucky, she can spot blotches of color. With a deep breath, the blonde reaches through the static and latches onto something.

“Real or not real,” she begins. Eyes look at her girlfriend, who nibbles on the plastic straw from her drink. Glimmer waits for the question. “I made some forts outside.”

“Probably not. You went outside to blow off steam after you transformed so maybe you were just digging or swatting at snow mounds.”

Adora picks at her sandwich. Guess all that deep breathing and telling herself she has control was worthless. She takes a moment to stare outside the restaurant window. Life continues on despite this setback. Though, if one good thing came out of this night it is Shadow Weaver has kept her promise. As far as anyone can tell, no one has been slaughtered.

“Okay, how about this. Real or not real?” Adora looks back at her girlfriend. She does take a moment to take a bite out of her lunch. “You were sad last night. I was comforting you.”

Glimmer takes a long, deep inhale. Her eyes flutter shut for a moment and her body leans against the booth’s back. Adora watches as shoulders become heavy and Glimmer’s face turns into a small frown. While clouds block out the bright sun, in the light of the day she swears she sees a single tear roll down her girlfriend’s face.

“Yeah. Last night…Last night was rough…”

Adora swallows a lump in her throat. A hand reaches out without pause. Fingers wrap around Glimmer's palms, squeezing it tight. This causes the hunter to open her eyes. There is a thin layer of mist covering dim lilac irises. Her thumb begins brushing against soft skin.

"Did you want to talk about it? I'm sorry that I can't remember what it was."

"I didn't tell you last night, you have nothing to apologize for. Adam was working on my mom's book more and was skipping around. He did the last couple pages and…It was a letter to me. From my mother. She…She…"

Glimmer struggles to get the words out. Her voice quivers as she struggles not to shatter. Adora squeezes her hand tighter, hoping to keep the cracking pieces in place. The hunter continues.

"She was going to go out and deal with Shadow Weaver and wrote the note just in case something happened to her…The letter was telling me how proud of me she was. She was sorry about not letting me do more and that she loved me. She couldn't wait for me to come home…Fuck, I'm sorry…"

Small streams of tears run down her face and her eyes have dimmed. Glimmer attempts to rid her cheeks of them but they continue to flow. Adora reaches her free hand towards her girlfriend, her palm landing gently against her face. Glimmer presses her face into the blonde's hand, sighing softly as a thumb brushes away one of the rivers. The hunter begins to softly whimper.

Adora wonders what words of affection are written on note. She wishes to read them, to understand Angella even more and her love for her one and only child. What did Adam feel as he translated the notebook? Knowing that he held in his hands something so precious and so heart-wrenching? How much did she miss while stuck in her wolf form?

Glimmer's breath begins to settle and her tears finally cease slipping out of her eyes. Adora lifts herself up from the booth, leans over the table, and brushes her lips against the hunter's forehead. When she sits back down, the lights in Glimmer's eyes have grown.

"Thank you," the hunter says.

"Feeling any better?" Adora asks.

"A little." Glimmer pushes her half full plate away. "I think I'm done."

"Are you sure?"

"Yeah, I am. What about you?"

"I think I am good too. Let's go meet Catra."

They pay for their food and collect themselves before leaving. After showering and preparing for the day, Adora received a call from her younger sister. Apparently, she has healed enough to allow others to see her. With nothing else to do, Adora agreed to see how she is doing. Glimmer has, of course, tagged along. Adam said he would but he barely could get out of bed, so he has been left to sleep.

The world they step out into is mild. Barely a nip in the air. One still must dawn a light jacket and jeans to prevent shivers. Even Adora, a walking furnace, keeps her body covered from the elements. All around her, hints of the upcoming spring are beginning to poke their heads out from the melting frost. While the robins have yet to migrate back to their birthplace, other creatures have started to wake from their slumber.

More squirrels scurry about, searching for their hidden treasures. With the earth softening, they easily dig their claws into the dirt. The birds that are around bask in the warming sun, singing their little lungs out. Adora swears when she looked out the window, she saw some deer peering out from the forest, looking at her

with their dark eyes. Meanwhile, some green shoots fight their way through the last snow piles. If looking close to the bare tips of trees, buds have begun to grow.

Even people have started to crawl out of their homes. The once bare sidewalks have taken on a new life. A couple of times, Adora and Glimmer must move out of the way to avoid those jogging down the concrete. Spring is only a couple weeks away. The season of new life, renewal, and hope the better.

Adora starts to chew on her rubber sword.

The designated meeting spot is not terribly far from the restaurant Adora and Glimmer ate at. About five or so minutes from there to the library. Apparently, Catra needs to return some books or get slammed with some late fees. To quote her sister ` *Kill two birds with one stone'.*

The library comes into view. Two stores high with windows showing hints of the world inside. Someone has been lazy with the decorations. Half hanging are hearts and a couple of cupids. The other half are shamrocks and pots of gold. Even stepping inside, the inside is made up just the same. Guess it's time to celebrate Valen-rick day.

Adora and Glimmer slowly climb up the stairs, keeping their eyes peeled for Catra. It takes about a minute for them to locate her. In a far corner of the building, away from most of the prying eyes of strangers. Her nose is buried into a book, completely unaware of the new beings coming towards her.

Most of the bandages previously on Catra's body have been removed. Only a few are left on her left arm. Both eyes can be seen scanning the words on the page below her. The injury to her right has left scars. They are fresh—bright pink skin easily identifiable in the fluorescent lights. Adora wonders how many more are hidden under her clothing. She swears she can see at least one picking out from the collar of her shirt, by her shoulder.

“Glad to see you are looking a little less shitty,” Glimmer smirks. She plops down across from the werepanter.

“You are looking almost as bad as me,” Catra retorts.She snaps the book closed, revealing the cover. Adora recognizes it as a book about lesbian necromancers. “The fuck have you two been doing?”

“Whatever we can,” Adora replies. She sits across from her sister. “Huntatra finally let you out of her sight?”

“For now.” Catra’s eyes flick from Adora to Glimmer a couple of times. “I assume it has been a rough night?”

Adora rubs her temples. “You can say that. Didn’t have luck with my transformation.”

“Ah. That sucks. There’s always next month.”

“Is that all you wanted to say or was there another reason you asked us to come here?”

Catra gives a nod. She begins to dig around in her bag. Her tongue sticks out in thought until she finds what she has been searching for. She slaps down a bundle of arrows. All the tips have different colors and shapes. Adora’s jaw nearly hits the table.

“I…” Adora pinches her nose so tight she could snap the bone inside. “Do I even *want* to know how the hell and why the hell you brought those into the library?”

“No, you don’t,” Catra replies. “Huntara gave me these. Didn’t know if you needed them.” Her sights turn to the hunter. “If I recall she said a couple will shock others, a couple flashing ones… I think one of them has a net in it! How the hell did you fit that in there?”

Glimmer (carefully looking that no one else is around) takes one of the arrows with a bright yellow, metal tip. She rolls it between

her fingers. “It’s a secret. These are great. Thank you for bringing them and give Huntara my thanks for getting them for me.”

“Just don’t shoot me in the ass with them.”

“If you don’t get in my way, I won’t.”

Glimmer shoves the new weaponry into her own bag. The trio chats a little about nothing in particular. Catra tells Adora and Glimmer a little bit about her healing. How slow it has been and still is. When there is nothing else to talk about and with the grey clouds darkening, the three decide it is time to leave. However, when they stand, Adora notices her sister wincing. The werepanter hisses through her teeth and clutches her side.

“Are you alright?” Adora asks. For a moment, her mind flashes back to finding her sister beaten and bloodied in the middle of the snow covered woods.

Catra waves her off with her free hand. “Stood up too fast. It’s nothing.”

“And you say I look like shit,” Glimmer jokes.

“I still am better lookin’ than you!” Catra’s shit-eating grin goes from ear to ear. She hisses again, her body curling in slightly. A curse slips out of her lips.

“Are you sure you are okay?” Glimmer asks. “Perfuma’s store isn’t that far away. We can stop and get you some stuff that might help your wounds.”

“I really don’t need anyone’s help.”

Adora takes a deep sigh. She slowly closes the gap between her and Catra. Before her sister can say anything, the blonde flicks the other woman right between the eyes.

“OW!” Catra jerks back, rubbing her forehead. “What the hell, Adora?!?”

“Just get some potions from Perfuma. Stop being so stubborn.”

“And what if I don’t?”

“I’ll keep flicking you in the face. And, I’ll tell Huntara to get on your ass about it.”

“God, you are annoying. Fine! I’ll take that stupid potion. Only because I don’t want Huntara all over me again!”

When Catra huffs and begins to walk away, both Adora and Glimmer chuckle a little.

Glimmer watches her two friends hard at work. Both Bow and Adam have not only the notebooks sprawled out on the table, but both their laptops and several pieces of scrap paper (some of which are crumpled up into balls). Their eyes barely leave the pages or the screen as they scribble down word after word.

Apparently, Adam only has a few more pages left. He has enlisted Bow’s help to speed things along and help ease his tiring eyes. The hunter wonders how much longer it will take. Hours? Days? How long does it take to translate latin to english anyway?

Excluded from this endeavor, Glimmer attempts to distract herself. By the time she is done cleaning off her crossbow it will be sparkling! Though, she does not make it far before there is a tap on her shoulder. Looking up, she spots Adora hovering over her, a soft smile on her face.

“What’s up?” Glimmer asks.

Adora points a thumb over her shoulder. “With the boys busy, do you wanna do something?”

“Like what?”

Adora gives a small shrug. “Dunno. It's kind of nice out. We haven’t sparred in a while. Wanna do that?”

“So you want me to kick your ass again?” Glimmer says with a grin.

“Hey!” Adora scoffs. “Don’t count your chickens before they hatch.”

Glimmer sets aside her weapon and jumps to her feet. Adam and Bow take no notice of her and Adora leaving the house. The hunter does attempt to let them know where they will be and only earns a small grunt from Bow.

Outside, the pair of girlfriends walk out to the middle of the backyard. The sun shines in the cerulean sky with only a handful of clouds passing by. While the rays are stronger than before, stubborn clumps of grey snow clings to the green earth.

Upon reaching their destination, Glimmer recalls her training. Plant her feet, take a deep breath, and focus her attention on her target in front of her. Adora waits for her signal to begin their spar. The blonde does some stretches, preparing her body for whatever blows might come her way. With the warmer weather continuing to melt the world, her girlfriend has *finally* decided to say fuck it and removed her outer layer of clothing, leaving only her t-shirt.

Staring at her makes Glimmer want to strip off her jacket.

Shaking her head, the hunter cracks her knuckles. She refuses to lose this sparring match. Nothing other than pride is on the line. With the slightest of nods, Glimmer allows the fight to begin. Adora does not waste a moment and lunges forward.

Glimmer barely has enough time to jump out of the way from her girlfriend’s attack. Her feet keep her steady. As Adora attempts to recover from her miss, the hunter uses this opportunity. She swings an arm towards the blonde, seeking to make some sort of contact. While she does that, it is not how she intended.

Adora recovers quicker than Glimmer expects. Before her punch can land, the blonde throws up her arms and blocks the attack

from making its mark. With a smile on her face, Adora pushes Glimmer back. Not deterred in the slightest, the hunter readies herself for another attack.

She does not allow Adora to make the first move again. Instead, Glimmer throws herself forward. At first, she begins to gear up for another punch. Adora begins to block herself from a sock to the face but at the last moment, the hunter lowers her arm and switches to a kick. Adora gasps as she stumbles backwards, barely missing being swiped in the stomach. Hoping to get her girlfriend on her ass, Glimmer attempts another kick.

Somehow, Adora not only manages to block the blow but remains on her feet. Though, the last part is just *barely.* She wobbles for several seconds before her feet finally find solid earth. The two jump back, giving some breathing room. Neither breaks eye contact.

Glimmer mind struggles to think of what to do. Hell, she can feel her body already wanting to give up the fight. Her lungs burn, wanting oxygen, and her body wants nothing more to lie down for a couple minutes and rest. She shakes the feeling and forces her breath to remain steady. Adora cannot see a moment of weakness in her and use this against her.

She thinks for too long, anyway.

In a blink, Adora is inches away. Glimmer's brain is slow on the uptake. By the time it realizes the threat and alerts the rest of the hunter's body, it is too late. Adora takes out Glimmer's legs. Feet are thrown from their connection to the earth. The world flips upside down as her body momentarily is in the air. Glimmer's back connects with the earth a split second later, her sights now staring up at the bright sky.

"Told you not to count your chickens before they hatched!" Adora smirks.

Glimmer answers with an annoyed groan. If her body didn't hate her before, it sure as shit does now. With shock running through her, her legs already are screaming at her not to get up. Her head spins and she swears she can see canaries floating above her head and laughing at her.

"Hey…You okay?" Adora kneels down. Worry is etched into every corner of her face. "I didn't hit you too hard, did I?"

"No. You're fine. I, uh, got the wind knocked out of me a bit." Glimmer gives herself a moment to think. "You won fair and square. But do you mind helping me up?"

"Of course."

Carefully, Adora's strong arms snake under Glimmer's body. They first get her into a sitting position before attempting to rise to feet. The hunter uses her girlfriend as a crutch as she stands up, letting her legs find themselves on the ground. The blonde keeps her arms wrapped around the hunter. By the time she finds her stability, Bow bursts out from the house and races towards them.

"Co-Come in-inside!" Bow wheezes.

"What the hell has gotten into you?" Glimmer asks.

"Just come with me!" Bow grabs her arm. The hunter has no time to react before she is yanked towards the house. Adora stumbles right behind, shouting in confusion. Halfway there, Glimmer moves on her own. Removing her arm from her friend's grip, she enters her home, herself now out of breath.

Adam snaps his head up the moment everyone enters the house. Before Glimmer can get any words out of her mouth, the younger twin slams his notebook down on the dining table. Eyes are wide and his face has lost some of its color. "I finished."

"What?!?" Glimmer and Adora say in unison.

“Yes.” Adam decides to take the book back in his hands. “I made sure to triple check everything. I looked it up and it’s a really rare plant. It’s called *Silverlace.* It took your mother *forever* to figure and find out about it. It says here:

“*Silverlace. A rare variation of wolfsbane. Due to not only blooming once every nine years but since they only grow high up on rocky mountains. Taken as is, the effects it has on werecreatures are akin to* ***pure*** *silver. Diluted, the uses are near endless! Only a few shops sell such a plant but I was able to track down one in the city of Blackmoor. This will cost an arm and a leg but it will be worth it to finally stop this threat.*

“There is a bit about the store she got it from and how she mixed it. But this is it! This is how we are going to stop Shadow Weaver!”

Glimmer steps forward, somehow feeling both the weight of the world land on her shoulders and having another be lifted. Hands reach forward, fingers gripping the binding of Adam’s book. The hunter reads and rereads the words scribbled on the page, unable to comprehend what has been said. The word bounces around her head, finding something to cling to. In the corner, her mother has doodled a flower. The petal’s look as if someone has carefully stitched it together in moon-like patterns.

Finally, the words on the page land.

Silverlace.

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated

Blackmoor

Chapter Notes

> another chapter woo. okay the next two weeks I won't post for reasons but then I will post 30 and then 31, week off, then 32, 33, and then finally 34. So this will end in late june. Also i was really tired when I proof so sorry for anything. dont think there are really tws in this so enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

" *PERFUMA! PERFUMA!"* Glimmer barrels through the door, nearly knocking it off its hinges. Scorpia nearly shoots through the ceiling at the sight. She fumbles with the hangers in her hands, barely able to keep them together. Eyes are wide and alert.

"I-Wha… *Glimmer?!?"* Scorpia gasps.

"Where is Perfuma?!?"

"I-I-She's in the back?"

Glimmer speeds off, not listening to Scorpia, nor Adora who shouts from behind. The hunter throws open the back door, stumbling headfirst into the other room. While gasping for breath and regaining her footing, it takes her a moment to locate her friend. She is in her faery form, fluttering near her bookshelf.

The faery that stares back at the hunter is barely bigger than her hand. Pale, pink wings flutter rapidly, keeping her up in the air. A small, pink dress flows down her body. On her arms are vine-like markings, going all the way up to her shoulder. A soft, green glow surrounds Perfuma.

"Jesus Christ, Glimmer!" Perfuma says. "Can you not break down my door?!?"

"'Fuma!" Glimmer wheezes. "A-Adam and B-Bow figured it out!"

“What?”

Adora stumbles in, having a little more breath. Moments later, her brother and Bow appear.

Perfuma sighs. She puts down what she was doing, something involving a couple of small vials, before turning into her human form. Wings, glow, and vines disappear. She hurries over to the fridge. Upon pulling out a handful of water bottles, she hands them out to the group.

“Why the heck are four out of breath?” Perfuma questions.

“Parking sucked,” Bow replies after taking several big gulps.

“Can either of you tell me what’s going on without dying?”

Glimmer chugs half her water in one shot. Her stomach does not like this in the slightest. It threatens to spit it all back up. The hunter forces the tickle down and says, “We know what my Mom used against Shadow Weaver!”

Perfuma freezes. *Totally* freezes. None of her muscles twitch and her eyes don’t so much as move a centimeter. The gears in her head slowly turn. When they begin moving faster, the faery finally opens her mouth. Though, it takes her several moments to finally say anything.

“What is it?”

“Silverlace. Have you heard about it?”

Perfuma clicks her tongue. “Once, maybe.”

She heads over towards the bookshelf. Glimmer follows closely behind, watching her friend search for the book. Perfuma’s hazel eyes scan each book binding, sometimes pausing before continuing on. Eventually, her fingers grab a small book that the hunter didn’t even notice. It sits between two tall, fat novels. It barely spills over her hands upon opening it.

Perfuma mumbles something as she flips through the pages. Finally, she finds what she is looking for. “Here. There isn’t much about it. Just-”

“That it takes forever to bloom and is in hard to reach places?” Glimmer cuts in.

“Yeah. Exactly. I guess your mom figured that out on her own. I don’t think I have ever seen silverlace before.”

“Do you think you could work with it? My mom said she found a shop in Blackmoor.”

Perfuma scoffs. “‘Course I can work with it. But Blackmoor? Do you know how far that is?”

“Pretty damn far, if I recall.”

“It’ll probably take a day to get there.”

Glimmer runs her hand through her hair. A good amount of time to be eaten up. Her mind begins swirling with ideas on how to get to Blackmoor the quickest. All the things they will need to *get* there and how to get back home. With the years that have passed, would this even work or just be a complete waste of time?

“We need to leave as soon as possible. Perfuma, are you able to come with us?” Glimmer asks.

“I believe so. I would have to tell Scorpia but she can hold down the fort for a couple days.”

“I want to come too!” Bow says. “If this place has more hunter areas, I can go gather some supplies.”

Glimmer takes a look at Adam, raising an eyebrow at him. The younger twin gives a small shrug. "I'll come along. Will it just be the five of us?"

"We should bring Catra." Adora says.

All eyes land on the blonde. Adora looks at all of them, her face remaining serious. “We were raised by the same woman. She *has* to come. The more the merrier, right?”

“Okay,” Glimmer takes a deep breath. Collecting her thoughts, she runs a rough draft of an attack plan in her mind. Collect everything they need for their trip. Get everyone to head off to Blackmoor. Hope and pray to every god that they’ll be able to get the silverlace without issue.

Then of course returning home, hoping Pefuma can turn the plant into something useful before May, hope that it works…

The hunter shakes her head before the thoughts can drown her. “Okay, fine.”

“Go home,” Perfuma says. She places a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder. “Rest up. I have to tell Scorpia about this and have the shop set up for just one person running it. Call Catra. We can leave the day after tomorrow.”

“I would love to get on the road right away.”

“Glim, it’s late in the afternoon,” Bow tells her. “There is no way we can leave tomorrow.”

Glimmer groans and chews on the bottom of her lip. She swears she can almost feel copper filling her mouth. He isn’t wrong. “Fine. But we leave first thing in the morning.”

Adora rolls out of bed, careful not to disturb Glimmer. She hopes that her girlfriend is actually asleep. And if she isn’t, well, she can’t blame the hunter for that. Adora barely got any rest at all over the past day and a half. Some hours of rest was found the day before but she probably could count on one hand how much

she found today. Doesn't help much that she has gotten up earlier than expected for today.

A quick rinse of her face in the bathroom and changing out of her pajamas before heading downstairs. There are no signs of anyone else alive. The door to the guest room remains closed, hiding Adam and Bow. On the couch, Catra snores away. Adora is a bit surprised that she didn't hear her noises when she was upstairs. She takes extra care not to step on any creaking boards and snap her sister wide awake.

Adora does a quick check of all the suitcases waiting to be loaded into the cars. It'll be split between Glimmer's car and Perfuma's. The faery will be here when the sun finally peaks its head out of the horizon. Checking her phone, it looks like she'll be here in about an hour and a half. Enough time for her to nibble on something. Quietly rummaging around, she begins to pluck bits off of a corn muffin.

One by one, the others begin to stir. First Bow, who is just as awake as Adora. He grabs his own muffin and powers on the coffee maker. Just in time for Adam to zombie-stumble out of the room. He does not greet anyone, his half closed eyes only on the brewing coffee. Bow happily pours a cup for him, plopping in two sugar cubes.

Glimmer is next, trudging her way down the stairs. Adora hears her tumble at the last one but somehow manages to catch herself. When she appears, her hair is a total mess. The hunter stops by her girlfriend, resting her head against Adora's chest.

"Did you sleep?" Adora asks, rubbing Glimmer's back.

"A little," Glimmer mumbles.

Adora places a peck on the top of her girlfriend's head. "Eat something. It's gonna be a long car ride."

Glimmer grunts, refusing to remove herself from her girlfriend. Adora pries the hunter off of her and gives a nudge. With a groan,

Glimmer trudges off to get something. The blonde watches her with keen eyes, not removing them until she sees her girlfriend swallow. Now there is only one more loose end.

Adora strolls over to the couch. Catra still is dead to the world, though at least her snoring has stopped. The blonde debates for a moment what to do, so many options are laid out in front of her. She taps a finger on her chin as she goes through each one of these. In the end, Adora decides to be nice towards her younger sister. A hand reaches down and gives her a shake.

Catra groans, burying herself deeper in her blanket. Adora keeps at it, shaking her until an amber eye stares up at her.

"Couldn't you give me five more minutes?" Catra complains.

"You can sleep more in the car. You have to get up and I am not carrying you into the car."

Catra mumbles something under her breath before rolling off the couch. She keeps her blanket draped on her body. With everyone now up (relatively speaking) Adora does one final check of the belonging. With everything in order, she decides to take a swig of her own coffee.

Soon, the sun begins to pull itself out of its own bed. The stars and the moon begin to disappear, slowly heading to their own beds. Right on time, Perfuma arrives. With a knock on the door, she enters the house, bright-eyed and bushy tailed. Adam, Glimmer, and Catra all stare at her with some jealousy.

Once all food has been eaten and coffee drunk, cars are loaded. With Perfuma driving and Adora and Glimmer going together, it's a question of where the other three shall go. There is some back and forth before the werepanther pipes up.

"Well, I want to sleep more so I don't care who the hell I am with. So long as whoever's driving isn't loud," Catra yawns. She pulls her blanket tighter around her body. "Don't Tweedledee and

Tweedledum want to be together.” Catra points at Bow and Adam.

The two blush slightly and look away from each other. Perfuma is the one to step in and make the decision. The faery agrees with Catra's suggestion, partly since it is the only one out in the open. Catra does not wait for any time of protest or other suggestions. She quickly dips into the back of Glimmer’s car. With the decision made, everyone else splits up and heads into their respective vehicles.

Adora takes the first shift driving. She follows right behind Perfuma as they head onto the highway. Glimmer and Catra promptly pass out, both snoring. The blonde can’t help but chuckle at the sight of both of them. Having figured that both of them would not keep her entertained for a couple hours, Adora has her phone set up already for a podcast. With a quick hit of play, it begins.

The sounds of people talking about a DnD-esce game fills her ears. After accidentally stumbling on this, there is a lot of catching up to do. With miles and miles of road ahead of her, that isn’t much of a problem.

Most of the car ride is nothing of note. After reaching their first pit stop to stretch legs and refuel, Glimmer and Catra remain awake. Adora keeps her podcast on for something to fill the air. At least her girlfriend and sister seem to enjoy it. The werepanther even recommends another one to listen to.

After driving for so long, Glimmer switches out with Adora, letting the blonde relax. She watches the landscape change from sliced through mountains, their faces still bearing the scars from explosions from decades ago, to forests thick with trees. Some buds look ready to pop at any moment, waiting for one more good burst of warmth.

State lines are crossed, one of which Adora misses as she drifts off into slumber. Adora is woken up by a shake of her shoulder.

She blinks back both the blur of sleep and the bright spring light. It takes her a good moment or two for her brain to reboot. When it finally does come back to life, she realizes they have reached the outskirts of Blackmoor.

"Better get ready, love," Glimmer says. "We will be at the hotel soon."

"Right." Adora groans as she stretches out her body. Rubbing her eyes, she lets herself take in the sights of the city.

There are plenty of little Mom and Pop like stores around, making Adora wonder which are human owned and which aren't. The blonde looks for any little symbols that might be clues. There's a theater, park, a college, and what looks like signs that lead to a lake. Adora notices they pass several hotels until they finally reach theirs.

It's not the biggest of any. Hell, it is only about three stores high. Though, based on the amount of cars that are in the parking lot, it isn't that dead. When Glimmer pulls into the parking spot, only a couple down from the other's car, Adora quickly jumps out. Her legs are eager to get the blood flowing back. After doing so, she leads the way in gathering the suitcases and heading towards the front doors.

Check in, get the keys, and head up to the third floor. With two keys in their hands, it's simply decided that car buddies will share a room. With it only being a couple of nights it shouldn't be that bad. Adora, Glimmer, and Catra enter theirs, throwing everything on their respective beds. Adora won't lie, she is a little jealous her sister gets a whole ass bed to herself.

"So," Catra asks as she places her suitcase away. "Do you guys know where the store is or are we going on a wild goose chase for it?"

"No. Adam said he did see a name in the book, right?" Adora asks, looking towards Glimmer. "What was it again?"

"Uh, I think it was called ' *Bane's Garden'.* I don't really know how far away it is from the hotel. This was the cheapest place to get for the six of us."

Catra digs through her pocket pulling out her phone. Taps fill the air and her eyes scan the screen. Adora watches as those amber and cyan colored iris grow large.

"Well, first off, we would have to take the car there but second and most importantly, the place is closed."

"Excuse me?" Glimmer asks. "What did we miss the closing hour?"

"No. No that's not it. It's closed on Sunday." More tapping. "Apparently a lot of stores are. This area has 'Blue Laws' and more or less, yadda yadda, shit is closed on Sundays."

"Who the fuck has *Blue Laws* in this area in this day and age? God damnit!"

Adora watches her girlfriend begin to pace around. With a single sniff, her nose is flooded with a range of emotions. The one in the forefront is a sharp frustration. She nearly recoils from the sting against her nostrils.

"Hey, Glim," Adora says softly. She slowly steps up to her girlfriend, placing her hands on the hunter's shoulders. Carefully, the blonde snakes them down and wraps them around Glimmer's torso. "It'll be okay. We…We can scoop out the area and make a game plan for tomorrow."

Glimmer leans against Adora's chest. "We already wasted time getting here…"

"We can't do shit right now," Catra states. "Adora is right. Tomorrow we can go willy-nilly finding stuff to stop Mom. Unless you want to do some breaking and entering, I ain't gonna stop you. But I also don't want to deal with you being all huffy and puffy."

“Jeez, thanks…”

“Well, I am gonna go check shit out. If you wanna come, I’ll be down in the lobby waiting for my entourage.”

The werepanther gives them a small salute before exiting the room. Adora listens to her sister’s footsteps disappearing down the hallway. When silence fills the air, she lets go of Glimmer.

“Are you alright, hon?” Adora asks.

“I’m fine,” Glimmer huffs. “I just…Don’t want anyone else to be harmed.”

“Trust me, I know.” Adora scratches the side of her face. It’s taking everything inside of her not to have a panic attack. Sometimes, keeping a raging beast from tearing itself out of her body when it's not a full moon is a good skill to have. Still, the thoughts that linger in the back of her mind threaten to kick start her heart into full drive.

“Maybe we should go break in,” Glimmer says.

“Hon, as much as I would love to be your partner in crime, let’s not get arrested. At least, not until we deal with Shadow Weaver.”

Glimmer burst out laughing, warming Adora’s heart. That frustration remains in the air but has been dampened a degree. Her girlfriend wipes a tear from the corner of her eye. “I will keep that in mind.”

“Let’s go break the news to the others and see what Catra wants to do before she does her own criminal activity.”

Scooping out doesn't take fairly long. After a quick drive to the downtown area, the group marks the places they want to hit up. *Bane's Garden* is tucked away in a corner. The only hint it is hunter and non-human friendly is the moon marking seen at the bar many months ago.

It does take a little while, though, to find other shops of use. An armory, bookstore, and an electronic store are among those jotted down on the list. After everything is all said and done, and with nothing else to do and stomach growling, it's dinner time.

By the time they get back to the hotel, the sun has gone to bed. With the lack of charge for batteries from all the travel, no one argues over the idea of turning in for the night. Glimmer decides to take a shower, leaving the pair of sisters alone. While her body is tired, pretty much *begging* Adora to sprawl out on bed, her mind remains awake. The blonde groans with frustration.

Thankfully, Adora doesn't have to attempt thinking of anything to calm her down. Catra pulls out a deck of cards from her bag and waves them in the air. Not wanting to chicken out of a good game and to kick her sister's ass, the blonde happily agrees to a game. That game is gin rummy. Despite being simple and fairly easy, something for *children* to play, Adora and Catra go all out in their fight to win. By the time Glimmer comes out, a towel draped over her head, the sisters have already played several games and have tied.

"You two alright?" Glimmer asks. She drops her towel on top of Adora's head. The blonde is barely fazed by the new sensation. Far too focused on the cards in her hands, she simply moves it out of her eyes.

"Yeah. Trying to beat Cat, s'all," Adora states.

"Which, by the way, she won't," Catra smirks. She drops down her cards on the table. Adora's eyes widen and it takes everything in her not to flip the table in defeat. Instead, she grumbles and tosses her own cards on the table.

Catra chuckles. She leans back on her chair. "So what do I win?"

"Choice on what we listen to on the way back," Adora decides on the spot.

Catra seems to like this idea. "I can't wait to torture you two!"

Adora rolls her eyes. The sisters pick up the cards and stack them to the side. Adora finally finds herself yawning and crawls into bed. Glimmer lies down beside her, pressing her damp head under Adora's chin. The blonde takes a deep inhale of the scent that comes off of her girlfriend.

"Hm, you smell good," Adora hums.

"I used the little bottles that the hotel gives. How great do I smell?" Glimmer questions.

"You just do." Adora lets her eyes flutter shut. "You always smell better than my wolfy behind."

"I like the smell of wolf." Glimmer presses closer to Adora. Her own arms wrap tightly around the blonde, holding her close.

Slowly, Adora falls asleep. Though, it's not for long. It feels as if she simply has blinked, no dreams and no drifting off, before she wakes up. All that stares back at her is a heavy blanket of darkness. She jerks at the sight, her brain unable to tell if this is reality or not. After several blinks, eyes begin to adjust and reveal outlines of everything in the hotel room.

The first thing that comes into focus is the pale wallpaper of the room. Then, the typical photo that hangs in every hotel she has been to. Looking around slightly she spots the dresser and the unlit lamp. Across from her on the other bed, Catra is passed out. Remembering the other living being in the room is besides, she looks over her shoulder.

Glimmer has her back turned towards her. Lifting up her head slightly, Adora can see the hunter's eyes are shut. There is no snoring from Glimmer (and even Catra is quiet), only soft exhales. Adora honestly could watch her sleep all night long, however, the fresh, night air beckons her. She slips out of bed and tiptoes into the outside balcony.

Even with the moon about half lit, it is almost blinding. If the power would suddenly be cut, the city would not fall into complete

darkness. Looking at the city lights, she becomes a little mesmerized by them all.

To her, it looks as if they mirror the stars above. Like when you look at a lake and the world above can be seen in its sparkling waters. Adora leans against the railing, closes her eyes, and tilts her head slightly. The vibrations of cars, the rumble of a small thunderstorm in the distance, and the sounds of some people chatting down in the parking lot fill her ears. Along with footsteps.

"So, were you not sleeping at all?" Adora asks, twisting her head over her shoulder.

"No," Glimmer chirps, leaving the sliding door open as she joins her girlfriend. "I was trying to but I heard you getting out of bed. When I realized you weren't going to the bathroom, I wanted to see what you were up to."

"Eh, not much. Just admiring the skyline." Adora looks back out on the horizon. Lights continue to twinkle. "Needed a little fresh air, ya know?"

"I know."

Adora takes a glance at her girlfriend. Out of the corner of her eye, she can get a fairly good look at her. The hunter has dark bags under her eyes. Those irises have lost some of their sparkles and have dimmed. They stare off into the distance, not really focused on anything in particular. Granted, it is the middle of the night, Glimmer looks a little more unkempt than usual.

She wishes she could crack open the hunter's body and see what is going on in there. See if there is anything she can do to help ease what might be gripping her. Unable to do any of this, Adora does the next best thing. With her shoulder, she gives Glimmer a nudge.

"I love you, Glitter-bug."

“I love you too, Starlight.” The hunter stretches out her body. “We really need to plan another date night for ourselves.” She steps closer, wrapping arms around Adora’s neck.

The blonde takes the hint, wrapping her own strong arms around Glimmer’s waist. Their foreheads connect as they sway their bodies together. “Well whatever we plan,” Adora starts, “we really need to have an actual normal date when we don’t have to worry about murders going on.”

“That would be a nice idea. I’d love that. Any places you had in the wonderful head of yours?”

“Not really sure. You’re the one who knows more about the good spots around Brightmoon.” Adora begins to spin the two of them around…as much as possible on the small bit of concrete hanging feet above the ground. “I can lead the dances and you can take the lead on the dates. Does that sound like a deal, hon?”

“I’m not always the most romantic person, love. You really want me to plan most of the dates? I might just enjoy a good movie and dinner, ya know.”

Adora chuckles. “That is more than fine by me! Didn’t you say anywhere with me is your favorite place. Well the same goes for me.”

“Stealing my favorite things I see. How could you!” Glimmer fake gasps.

“Didn’t I already steal your heart? What’s some more thievery?”

Glimmer scrunches up her nose and sticks out her tongue. Adora sticks out her own and makes a small face in retaliation, causing her girlfriend to snort.

“Maybe I should’ve left your naked ass out in the woods all those months ago.”

“Your life would be far less interesting without me in it. I sure as shit know my life would be boring as hell without you, among other things.”

“This is true.”

Suddenly, the rest of the door slides open. It hits its partner with a harsh slam. Both werewolf and hunter snap their heads around to see Catra standing on the threshold. “Ya remember I have super hearing, right? It’s three in the morning, can you two please keep down the mushy shit. I’ll lock you out of the hotel room if ya don’t!”

“Sorry, Cat!” Adora says, stifling a chortle. “We’ll go back to bed soon.”

“You better.” Catra huffs before sauntering off back into the darkness of the hotel room.

Adora and Glimmer decide maybe it’s best not to bug Catra anymore. With a kiss on the lips, the pair head back into the hotel room. They return to their bed, curling up against each other again. This time, when Adora falls asleep, she remains asleep until the morning.

Adora steps out of the car, shutting the passenger door behind her. The sun that hits her needs to be blinked back before the city streets can become visible. Once sight no longer hurts, the blonde steps up onto the sidewalk, waiting for the rest of the group. Remaining by the car, Glimmer stared at her phone, surely looking at a map.

Once the hunter is done, she joins everyone else. “So,” Glimmer starts, “have we figured out the groups yet or what?”

With so much to do, the best idea is split up. Glimmer already made it clear that she will be heading to get the wolfsbane. There isn’t much of a question where Perfuma will be heading. Everyone else has yet to be decided on.

“I kind of want to go check out this wolfsbane store,” Catra says. “Sounds really interesting.”

“So does that mean Adam and Bow will go elsewhere?” Adora questions, raising an eyebrow.

“No. We should stay in groups of threes. I’ll give go with Perfuma and Catra," Glimmer suddenly states. “You, Adam, and Bow go together.”

“Wait, what?” Adora steps close to her girlfriend. “Are you sure about that? Why?”

“Just…Just because.” Glimmer does not make eye contact with her girlfriend. Adora goes onto alert, not understanding what's wrong. The tone of the hunter has dropped an octave since this morning.

“Do ya want me to switch out?” Catra interrupts. “I can always check out the store later.”

“No.” Glimmer takes a deep breath. Adora sees her fist close tightly for a moment, knuckles during white. Then, fingers unfurl and she begins to dig into her pocket, pulling out a torn piece of notebook paper. “No. Go with your brother and Bow. Here is a list of stuff I need. I don’t need you to be sneezing your brains out there with the wolfsbane.”

The hunter shoves the paper into her girlfriend’s hands, pushing Adora’s callus fingers around it. Whether by mistake or on purpose, Glimmer's lilac eyes meet that of Adora's sky blue ones.

There is a fog to them, one with a hint of darkness to them. The bags she saw last night seem to have grown and the lights inside struggle to twinkle. Adora begins questioning if the hunter slept at all. When she herself woke up, Glimmer had her eyes shut. But was that another ruse?

Glimmer sighs and places a tender kiss between Adora's eyes. Pulling away, the hunter says,

“Trust me, okay? Spend more time with your brother.” She then leans forwards, keeping her voice down so only Adora can hear. “And keep the boys out of trouble. Who knows what they’d do alone.”

Adora snorts. “I can try but no promises…Wait a second.” She looks over Glimmer’s shoulder. “What about Cat? She’s going to be affected by any wolfsbane too.”

“I-” Glimmer starts. For a moment, she looks like a child caught red handed stealing cookies out of the jar.

“Don’t worry your little wolf tail off,” Catra interjects. Adora catches a side-eyed glance at Glimmer by the werepanther. Though, those dual eyes turn away after Glimmer blinks. She continues, “I’ll be just fine. If I start to have a sneezing fit, I’ll just do it on Glimmer.”

“Jeez, thanks.”

“Go on, Adora. Don’t worry about us.” Catra bumps the hunter with her shoulder. “We will be fine. Plus, Flower Power over here will keep us in check.”

Adora looks back and forth between her sister and her girlfriend. She even glances over at Perfuma. The faery steps forward, giving a small nod. With this, the blonde’s shoulders lower and she gives a soft sigh.

“Okay.” Adora places a kiss on Glimmer's temple. “I’ll see ya later.”

She walks down the street with Adam and Bow. There is a moment where the blonde stops and looks over her shoulders. Glimmer gives a small smile and a wave. Adora hesitates to disappear behind the corner, her heart almost screaming to run back to her girlfriend. But a tug from Bow makes her do otherwise.

“The hell was that about?” the werepanther asks.

“None of your concern,” Glimmer quickly snaps back. “I just…I just thought it would be better for her to be with Adam and Bow.”

“How much did you sleep last night?” Perfuma asks.

“Enough. Can we not integrate me? I really want to get the silverlace and go home and get this all over with.”

Before either can answer, Glimmer begins marching off. Her mind begins to race around, wondering if this was a horrible idea. Separation from Adora is one thing but pushing her away is another. The hunter reminds herself doing so will work out in the end. And, not to mention, she is right about the whole wolfsbane thing. Glimmer really doesn’t know what she is going to do with Catra when they get there but that is something for *future* Glimmer to worry about.

Just like everything else…

To avoid any more questions, Glimmer keeps several paces away from Catra and Perfuma. Every time get close, she picks up. After a couple times of this, the werepanther and faery keep a bit of a distance, along with her thoughts.

Using her map on her phone, she makes a couple twists and turns before finding the store once more. This time, when stopping by the front door, she allows her friends to catch up. Together, the trio enters the shop.

The store is bigger inside than out. Like Perfuma’s store, there is a disguise to it all. Though, they are much more lax compared to what the faery does. The owner keeps the whole plant theme… maybe a little too much…Many pots sit on shelves near the window waiting for what's inside to burst free. Some do bloom, showing brilliant rainbows of colors.

Packets of seeds sit on little end caps, alongside tools for gardening. Glimmer can recognize many are made out of silver. In

some upper areas, ones that the hunter cannot reach by herself, there are vials, some filled with different colored powders and some empty. Behind the front desk is a closed door. Glimmer raises an eyebrow.

Two people stand behind the counter. One is a shorter man with dark hair with silver wisp mixed in. He has grey stubble growing on his face. He watches something on his phone, totally ignoring the three customers in the building.

The other is an older, taller woman. There are scars all over her body and her black hair is tied back into a high ponytail. An eyepatch covers one of her eyes. While her coworker is on his phone, she is reading a book and is the first to notice Glimmer walking up to the counter.

“Hello,” she says, shutting her book. “Welcome to Bane’s Garden. How may I help you?”

The way she says the greeting is not so enthusiastic. The man is much more peppy.

“Don’t worry about my friend, Leone. She ain’t much of a people person. Name’s Wyatt! What can I help ya with?”

“We are looking for a certain type of plant. We are wondering if you got it,” Glimmer states.

“Depends on who you are.” Wyatt leans against the table, a smirk on his face.

“Glimmer Mizari. Hunter.”

“Catra Britt. Werepanther.”

“Perfuma Scheimer. Plant Faery.”

“Mizari?” Glimmer catches Leone whispering under her breath.

“What are you two?” Catra asks. She has begun to scratch her one arm, nearly making it red.

“I’m a griffon and my friend here is a sphinx. So what is a ragtag group like you looking for?”

“Silverlace.”

All eyes turn to Leone. The sphinx’s one earth brown eyes lock onto Glimmer. So tall she is, the older woman has to bend forward and rest her palms on the counter to make eye contact. A chill runs down the hunter’s spine. Her eye studies every inch of Glimmer’s being.

“Silverlace?” Wyatt’s green eyes are like saucers. “The hell you need that for?!?”

Leone is inches away from the hunter. Glimmer can see the sharp teeth peaking out of her lips. “I remember someone just like you coming here a couple or so years ago. Was lookin’ for the same thing. Angella was it?”

Glimmer puffs out her chest. “That was my mother.”

“I’m gonna ask you the same thing I asked her. Why are you asking for silverlace? You know what the stuff can do to not only weres but some non-humans?”

“I am aware. And I will give you a similar answer I’m sure my mother gave you. There is a bastard werewolf out killing a bunch off fuckin’ people out there.”

“That is what your mother said, though, less crude. Why are you back then?”

Glimmer feels her nails dig into her palm. “My mother was murdered by her. She used the silverlace and was able to stop her for a while but she’s back. We need it to stop her again and for once and for all.”

Leone does not back down. Hell, it seems she has grown. Wyatt has shrunk back to the other side of the counter. An arm from the sphinx transforms into a furry, clawed paw. The air becomes thick. “How the hell do I know you aren’t gonna go killing? I don’t give this out just to anyone. Got burned once, I won’t let anyone else suffer.”

Glimmer feels a growl tickling the back of her throat. Hands slam down on the counter and teeth grit together. “Because, my mother is fuckin’ dead because of this woman. She has done more shit than you can even know. I’m not about to let my mother's death be in vain and I’d die trying to make sure of that!”

The world becomes still. There is no ticking of any clock, there barely is the sound of breathing, and even the hums of fluorescent lights go quiet as they watch the stare down. Glimmer doesn’t so much as *blink* as she leers at Leone. The sphinx doesn’t budge—there isn’t even a twitch of a facial muscle. The hunter begins preparing herself with a woman over twice her size.

However, the tension is broken when Leone laughs. It is a loud, belly one, catching everyone but Wyatt off guard. “I like you,” Leone says. “It takes guts to stand up to me. Your mother had the same determined look in her eyes when I pressed her. Still though,” she shows off her claws, “don’t make me regret this.”

“I won’t,” Glimmer replies, hardening her face again.

Leone gives a small nod before walking towards the closed door. As she disappears, Glimmer catches the glint of light coming off of a metal leg.

“Y’all can look around while Leone digs for the silverlace.” Wyatt’s eyes shift towards Catra. “So, you’re another feline non-human.”

“Yeah, I am.” Catra now scratches her back.

“I think I might have some stuff for that.”

As Wyatt begins digging around under the counter, Glimmer begins walking around. Perfuma is completely enthralled by everything around her. The hunter uses a nearby stool to take a peek at the vials hanging out of reach. After studying some of them, she decides to take a few and some empty ones to restock. Before stepping down, she notices something off to the side.

A hand reaches out, fingers wrapping around a smooth, cold metal. Pulling it close to her, Glimmer realizes it is a taser. Similar to what she has. Though, there is more to it than her run of the mill one at home. Besides the fact that it is brand new, not a single scratch on it, there is a small door between the prongs at the top. Glimmer raises an eyebrow.

“Here’s the silverlace.” Leone’s voice enters her ears. Glimmer twists her head and sees the sphinx coming towards her with a small potted plant in her hands. The steam is long with many offshoots. However, all the buds are shut tight. “Don’t have the powder like with your mother but they should bloom soon.”

Glimmer reaches out and touches the plant. The moment she does, her fingers begin itching.

“Jesus,” Glimmer mumbles, pulling her hand back. “That shit is strong already.”

“I thought you were a human?” Leone's eyes narrow with suspicion.

“Long story short, I got attacked once and it left me with some minor were-DNA.”

“Ah.” She turns her eyes to the taser. “If you are going up against a strong foe, that definitely packs a hell of a punch.”

“What’s this for?” Glimmer points at the door

Leone motions for the weapon. She sets out the plant as she takes the weapon. She then grabs a vial off the shelf, opens the door, and pours a small amount into the opening. Glimmer

watches as the prongs change color. “If electricity isn’t doing it for ya, then a bit of wolfsbane will. Add as much or as little as you want and when you press this up against someone, it will inject that into them.”

“Huh…” Glimmer’s eyebrows furrow. “Can it work in either form?”

“Yes. If you’re lucky enough to catch that bitch in her human form, let it rip. So, do you want it?”

Glimmer ponders over it. Her mind travels back to July, when her taser failed to knock Adora out. The thought alone makes her arm ache. That taser back home won't be a match for what is to come. This…This could work amazingly. It could knock *her* out. It could work…

“Yeah. I’ll take it.”

Adora scribbles off another item on the list in her hands. There are a couple more needs staring back at her. Batteries for gear, a new flashlight, and some silver arrow tips. With a sigh, the blonde shoves the paper back in her pocket and catches up with her brother and Bow. They both are looking at the archer’s map for the next store.

“Did ya find it yet?” Adora asks, looking over their shoulders.

“Yeah, it’s just up the street,” Bow answers. He begins leading the way. Adora trails close behind. She rubs a thumb against the puncture hole that was created a couple minutes ago. Getting it fixed is at the bottom of her list of worries. It takes everything in her not to chew on the collar of her shirt or, worse, her hand.

Her mind is a mess, wishing to reunite with her girlfriend as fast as possible. Adora keeps repeating over and over again in her head Glimmer can take care of herself and stress is getting to everyone but something in her gut tells her otherwise. No matter

how many times she attempts to undo the not and settle it, but all of it is in vain. Hell, it only *tightens.*

She'll be fine. It's nothing. When you get back to the hotel, just make sure she ***actually*** *fuckin' sleeps. Glim'll be fine once she gets some rest.*

The store comes into view. Adora, Adam, and Bow all enter. The store is full of what looks like camping gear at first glance. Tents, bags, flashlights, and survival gear. Each member of the trio takes an item to locate. Adora takes up finding some batteries, which takes no time at all to locate. Bow finds the flashlight almost as fast. However, Adam needs to call for assistance to find actual silver tipped arrow heads.

"How are you holding up without your sword?" Bow asks.

Adora rubs the back of her neck. "I'll be fine."

"Glimmer has been like this before. After Angella died, she ran off and nearly got killed." Bow tells her. "She'll be fine."

"I hope so. I don't like smelling all that anxiety coming off of her," Adora sighs. "Honestly, I've been smelling it a lot lately."

"I bet. At least now we know how to stop your mother once and for all."

"Right…" Adora's mind refuses to come up with anything to say. All she can do is hold herself. She really doesn't want her brain to think of all the possible outcomes that are laid out in front of them. Thankfully, she doesn't have to worry about that happening.

Adam suddenly comes over, showing off his handful of arrow tips. "Finally got some, I think. This is them, right?"

"Yeah it is. Glimmer texted me before saying they got their things," Adora states.

“Sweet. Let’s go catch up then!” Bow chirps.

Adora smiles slightly, happy all the ingredients for the final attack are now in their hands. She quickly texts her girlfriend, letting her know they will be back at their meeting spot soon. Before locking her phone completely, she stares at her wallpaper of Glimmer, giving herself a sense of hope.

Throwing their things in a bag, the trio head back to the designated meeting place. This time, Adora takes the lead, keeping at least three paces ahead of her brother and friend. When everyone does meet up, the first thing the blonde does is give Glimmer a tight squeeze.

"I missed you too, Adora," Glimmer chuckles. "Got everything on the list?"

"Yup! Got the silverlace okay?" Adora asks.

"Yes but it cost an arm and leg. Got some other things too. We can sort everything once we get back to the hotel."

"If we are staying the night, I'm not staying with you two again!" Catra suddenly says. "I want to sleep. Perfuma, switch with me!"

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated

No Rest for the Weary

Chapter Notes

> almost forgot to post this, going thru it lads. anyway tw for panic attack really sorry if the edits are bad like i said going thru it so my brain aint working

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“How’s it going?” Glimmer asks. She adjusts the phone resting between her head and shoulder. With her hands, she works on cooking lunch. The smell of frying food nearly makes her mouth flood.

“The same as yesterday, Glimmer,” Perfuma replies. “There is nothing else I can do.”

Glimmer sighs. Ever since returning home a few days ago, the hunter has waited impatiently for any sort of updates on the silverlace. At the slightest of vibrations for her phone, she leaps for it. Most of the time, it is just a notification from one of her social media apps. Other times it's spam calls. The hunter was damn near close to picking up one of those calls and telling them to leave her the fuck alone.

Finally, she has said fuck it and has been texting and/or calling Perfuma.

“Sorry.”

“I know you are anxious. I am too, but there is nothing I can do to speed it along. If I could, I would. We have to keep waiting.”

“I really hate that.”

“Same here. Anyway, what are you, Adora, and the boys up too?”

Glimmer rocks on her heels. "I'm just cooking lunch. Bow's showing Adam around town some more and Adora…"

The hunter looks out the window. With spring practically here, the world has warmed up considerably. Today has become the warmest day of the year. Adora has decided to enjoy the weather and currently is basking in the sunlight. Guess that is what happens when you are raised alongside a werepanther for a large chunk of your life.

"She's outside enjoying the weather. What about you? Besides the whole silverlace stuff."

"Not much. The usual. Running the shop and what not. Oh, a customer just came in. Gotta go. Talk to ya later. Try not to call me too much, please."

"I'll try not to. Say 'hi' to Scorpia for me."

"Will do."

Glimmer hangs up and places her phone on the counter. She pinches the bridge of her nose and inhales deeply. Her other hand grips the pan's handle tight. The hunter bites back anger boiling up inside of her and crawling up her throat. Perfuma doesn't deserve that. All anyone can do is wait…and wait…and *wait…*

Pulling teeth is less painful and faster than this.

The smell of burning food enters her nostrils. Glimmer swears as she scrambles to turn off the stove and save the food. Upon it being tossed on the plates, she waves away the small, dark cloud that slowly rises up. Somehow, only the ends have turned into a shade of black.

Great… Glimmer sighs. She throws open the window and sticks out her head. Adora still lies on her back, soaking up the bright sunshine. The hunter gives a whistle, alerting her girlfriend. Adora snaps straight up, her head quickly turning to face the house.

Glimmer signals for her girlfriend to come in. Which Adora happily does. It only takes a matter of *seconds* before the blonde is inside.

"I thought I smelled something burning," Adora smirks.

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Just pick apart the burned parts Though, it won't kill you if you eat it. Even with your tastebuds."

To prove her point, the hunter takes a bite out of the burn side of the food. Even though it tastes like shit, Glimmer swallows it. Adora is smarter and removes those bits from her food. She attempts to give them to her girlfriend, smiling right at her. Glimmer can only give a small, half hearted laugh.

Adora's smile fades away. She opens her mouth to say something but is stopped when Glimmer shoves food into her mouth.

"Eat up. Your next shift is coming up, you need it."

Adora chews and swallows. "What about you? Ya gotta eat too."

"I'm going to, I'm going to!" Glimmer waves her off. She puts some food in her mouth and forces herself to swallow. At least it doesn't taste totally like a piece of cardboard. Out of the corner of her eye, she sees Adora form a thin line on her face, displeased.

"You better eat all of that."

"Okay, *Mom* !"

Adora huffs but says nothing more as they settle at the dining table. She does, however, keep her eyes on her girlfriend. Glimmer eats everything, not even leaving a spec of crumbs. Adora seems a little more happy.

"I'm going to go out with Catra today," Adora suddenly says.

Glimmer nearly chokes on her spit. When the hell did that happen? All the hunter can get out through her sputters is,

“What?!?”

Adora takes a moment to take a swig of her drink she got herself. “I want to ask her some stuff, like about our mother and what not. And…” she rolls her glass between her hands, “I want to go alone.”

“Why?”

“I just want to try to be alone with her for a longer period of time. I can leave if I want to and if I need you for anything, I will call you.”

“Are you sure, Starlight? I can come with you, if you like. You don’t have to do it alone.”

Adora responds by standing to her feet. She stops right beside the hunter and places a kiss on her temple. The back of her rough and warm hand stroke’s Glimmer’s cheek. “I’ll be fine. Don’t worry. You should rest. You look like you need it.”

Glimmer watches as her girlfriend takes the plates off the table and brings them to the sink for washing. The hunter remains seated in her chair, cupping cheek. She can still feel the tender touch against her skin.

Adora finishes cleaning the dishes and begins to wipe off her hands on the bottom of her shirt. “I was going to go. Catra wanted to meet up soon. I’ll bring home dinner to make up for dropping this on you. Text me what you want and I’ll get it.”

“Yeah…Yeah, I’ll let you know. Don’t forget to take a jacket when you leave. It might downpour later in the afternoon.”

“Tck. I think I’ll be home before then. And even if not, a little rain hasn’t hurt anymore.”

Glimmer huffs before grabbing a jacket off the rack. A soft, golden and white one Adora recently got (the hunter has learned her

girlfriend loves to horde them). She shoves it against the blonde chest, keeping her hand on the center of Adora's body.

"I don't want you catching a cold. Plus, I don't need the smell of wet dog in the house."

"What?" Adora snorts and raises an eyebrow, "You don't like my smell?

Adora begins getting ready for her afternoon out. Glimmer must remind, or rather *force,* the blonde to take a jacket. Even if the weather is nice at the moment, there is a chance of a rainstorm later on. Adora brushes it off, thinking that she'll be home before it hits and even so, a little rain has never hurt anyone.

Glimmer keeps asserting to take it just in case. After a bit of back and forth, Adora *finally* caves and grabs a jacket, wrapping it around her waist. Before leaving, the blonde leans forward, placing a kiss on Glimmer's lips.

"Take it easy." Adora says this in a somewhat serious tone.

Glimmer nudges her under the ribs with her elbow. "Don't you worry. I promise I won't get into any trouble without ya!"

When Adora smiles, it's a soft one. Her sky blue eyes are warm. Glimmer lets her shoulders relax. She watches her girlfriend exit the house. Once the sound of the car leaving disappears, she heads into the lower bathroom.

Glimmer stares at herself in the mirror. She thought that this morning, she did a good job making herself look presentable. Her hair has been brushed and any loose strains have been carefully pressed down. The hunter has taken care to have her clothes all straightened out, nothing left out of place.

But she can see what she has failed to hide. Despite her best efforts, she can still see the dark bags under her eyes. Hell, she can see it *in* her eyes, the tiredness. Whatever sparkles that once were in them are gone.

"Fuck," Glimmer grumbles, running a hand through her hair. *Not good. Can't let Adora see me like this.*

Glimmer turns on the faucet, letting the cold water pool in her hands before splashing it against her face.

“You still like your coffee with cream, right?” Adora asks. She places the steaming, styrofoam cup in front of her sister before sitting down across from her.

The werepanther pops off the lid with one hand and with her other, grabs a packet of sugar. “You forgot about the sugar. But otherwise, yeah. I still do.”

“Good to know.” Adora takes a moment to sip her own coffee. Turning her gaze outside, she can see grey clouds off in the distance. She wonders how long it will take for them to over take the crystal, clear sky. That is the least of her worries at the moment.

Turning back to Catra, she asks, “Tell me.”

Adora had gotten a text from her sister shortly after they returned home from retrieving the silverlace. The blonde remembers her phone vibrating after stepping out of the shower.

Yo, Catra had texted, **we need to talk about Glimmer**

What do you mean? Adora replied back after drying her hands.

You saw how she was Blackmoor! You really are gonna tell me you didnt see it also? She also smelled weird

Adora had bit her thumb reading it. She didn’t know how to respond to that, knowing her sister was correct. The blonde told herself what she had been for a while. Stress! It had to be stress, right?

Catra was impatient. **Are ya still there?**

Yeah.

I rather met up somewhere. Dont wanna explain everything over text ya know? You can pick the place.

Now here they are. In a little café on the other side of town, sitting in the corner booth away from everyone else. Catra picks apart some bread she has and pops the small balls in her mouth.

"Well, like I said, I think something is up with Glimmer. You know her a lot better than me."

"She definitely has been acting odd. Ever since you dropped that bomb shell, I've been having to reminder her to eat," *Though I have to remind myself also.* "I don't think she has been sleeping like she should. She looks like she's been hit by a truck over and over again! I remember her getting a little panicky when I almost saw something on the laptop.

"She's not herself and I am worried. I want to say it's 'cause of everything going on but…" Fingers grip the cup in her hand tight. She barely stops herself from breaking it apart and spilling out the hot contents. "I want to know what's wrong with her. I know if I try asking her what's up she'll brush it off. I know I should ask but I don't want to press and have her close herself off or disrespect her space."

"So she *is* acting more odd. It wasn't just at Blackmoor."

"What was she like when you were with her?" Adora finally eats some of her own food. A small, butter croissant.

"Well, when she told you to go with Adam and Bow, I smelled something different. Did you notice?"

"Wasn't paying attention to smell at the time."

"How do I put it?" Catra rubs her chin in thought while drumming her fingers on the table. "There were a *lot* of things mixed in.

Anger, regret, sadness maybe. I think there was some confusion? Or debate? No! Conflict!”

“Conflict?” Adora raises an eyebrow. What on earth is Glimmer conflicted about?

“I’m not the best with advice for this type of stuff but you probably should figure out what the hell is up with her.”

“I know, I know.” Adora leans back in the booth and takes a deep breath. “There’s so much going on! I can barely keep up with myself sometimes!”

“That’s all I really got. Do you want me to try and talk to her? Why not get one of the others from your little group?”

“Everyone’s got their own problems to deal with. Plus, I think only I or Bow could get her to open up like that.”

“Sucks to suck I guess.”

Adora shoots her a glare, which her sister only shrugs to. She begins to rub a temple. “I’ll figure something out…I hope. “

“You’ve always been the smart one of us. If you can’t figure something out then, well, one, I think pigs will fly.” Catra pauses for a moment, a smile spreading on her face. Adora can’t help but snort. Her sister finishes, “And two, you got the others and even me if you want to help out.

“Maybe once we kick Mom’s ass back to the stone age she’ll be her old self. Now,” Catra suddenly slams her hands on the table. Not only do the dishes rattle, but Adora does as well. She feels her heart leap into her throat at the sudden surprise.

Before she can say anything, Catra cuts her off. “If you are feeling like dog-shit, why don’t we take a stroll through town or some shit before you go home. My treat!”

“Are you serious about that?” Adora asks, dumbfounded.

"Yeah, I am. I mean, I have nothing better to do anyway and honestly, I need to get my mind off of shit too. I don't want to think of the possibility of being mauled by mom again, ya know?"

"I don't want that either."

"Sweet. Let's go!"

Catra grabs her coffee and the rest of her food before suddenly bolting out of the corner. Adora shouts at her sister, telling her to wait up. The blonde throws some cash on the table for a tip before grabbing her things and booking out of the café.

Her sister is already at the corner of the street, hanging off a streetlamp and waving her arm wildly. "C'mon ya slow poke! Hurry up!"

Adora rolls her eyes and scoffs. Thankfully, Catra waits for Adora to catch up this time, even as the light remains green. The pair of sisters quickly book it across as the light turns yellow. With that out of the way, they stroll around Brightmoon to burn some time together.

Adora shows Catra some little spots that she and Glimmer sometimes go to. Little hidden gems that only the locals would know how to find. Catra seems to enjoy learning about these places, her dual colored eyes becoming bright. At one point they stop at a small street car, getting some churros. The blonde gets one in a little bag to bring home to her girlfriend. By the time she packs it away, Catra has gobbled up her snack.

More exploration. While taking a quick walk through the park, Adora gets a pleasant surprise. Edgar and Alvin Whitewood. The young boys are taking a liking to the warm weather, running around and wrestling with each other. When the brothers spot her, they waste no time in racing over to Adora.

Catra is taken aback by the sudden barrage of questions and statements. *Who are you? You're Ms.Mizari's sister? You're a*

werepanther? That's so cool! We are wyverns! Have you ever met one of us before? Or are we your first meeting of wyverns?

"Easy, boys!" Adora says. She picks up Alvin by the armpits and moves him away from Catra, who clearly does not like her personal bubble being popped by a pair of curious children.

"I didn't know you had a sister!" Edgar says, a bit hurt by this fact.

Adora chuckles. "I have a sister *and* a *twin* brother."

"Is he a werecreature like you?" Alvin asks. "Or a non-human?"

"No. He's a human."

The low rumble of thunder catches her attention. Adora snaps her head up. There no longer is a spec of blue anywhere in the sky. All above is grey, ranging from a light shade like a stone to a darker shade like the pepper in a shaker. The hairs on the back of her neck stand at attention.

"You two should go find your mom and dad. No need for a bunch of drowned wyverns," Adora states.

"Can dragons even swim?" Catra asks.

" *Wyvern!"* Alvin corrects. He puffs out his chest. "And yes I can! We both can!"

Catra throws up her arms. "Alright, hotshot."

Edgar grabs his brother by the collar of his shirt. As the brothers disappear, they give a wave. When Adora brings her hand back down to her side, she feels the first small droplets against her cheeks.

"We better go before we become a drowned wolf and panther." Catra points at Adora's waist. "Good thing you have that."

Adora looks down at the jacket wrapped around her. A small smile spreads across her face, her fingers brushing against the soft fabric. She strips it off her body and slips it against her torso. Zipping it up and burying her face in it, she can smell the hints of the warm fabric softener from when Glimmer washed it.

"Yeah…" Adora sighs. "I'm lucky someone made sure I brought it."

The sisters go their separate ways, planning on seeing each other on the night of the full moon. Though, Adora doesn't make it back to the house before the rain comes pouring down. When she enters, her clothes stick to her body and weigh her down. The blonde wonders if her sister is just as drowned as her.

She barely makes it a couple steps in when Glimmer suddenly appears in front of her. The hunter does look a *little* better thankfully.

"Why are you soaked to the bone?" Glimmer asks.

"It's raining," Adora retorts.

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "I couldn't've guessed! Though, I guess that jacket didn't do anything."

"It did a little bit."

"Well, go get in some dry clothes. I don't need you to catch a cold."

"Don't worry, it takes a lot more for me to get sick. Oh! Before I forget." Adora digs through her bag and pulls out the churro. "You might need to warm it up but I got you a treat!"

"Oh, thank you! I haven't had one of these in ages."

Adora grins from ear to ear.

Adora groans. Both from her stomach flipping around inside her and from Catra trying to help. Despite her best efforts, it isn't really doing much.

"You can do this," Catra says. "You're smarter than me, right? You can figure this out!"

"That is not helping like you think it is," Adora grumbles. Fingers grip the carpeting of Huntara's living room. The minotaur has left a couple days and told the others they were free to come over and deal with shifts there. Get a bit of a change of pace. Why the hell not?

Another groan escapes her lips. Adora lies on her side and curls up into a tight ball. The usual begins happening. Cold sweat, shivers, teeth chattering, and feeling like her insides are ready to tear her apart. There is not enough willpower in her body to roll onto the colder hardwood.

"I don't…" Adora manages to squeak out, "I don't think this is gonna work…"

"You can still try." Catra groans herself. "I'll be back."

"You're not gonna stay?" Adam asks.

"I don't y'all to see me like that. I'm not comfortable with it."

Catra says nothing more before disappearing behind the corner. Adora buries her face further into the soft fabric below her. It tickles her cheeks. She struggles to keep her thoughts together. She struggles to keep *herself* together. This is the last real chance to get control of the wolf inside of her. If she doesn't, then she'll be near useless in the upcoming battle. She *has* to do this.

She can't let the wolf *win.*

The pain rips across her body. She winces and bites down hard on her lip, silently screaming at herself to keep control. If she

doesn't, everyone's life will be in danger. Over and over again, she tells herself she can do this.

'Stop fighting it.' a voice whispers in her ear.

Adora tempts to look and see who just spoke. She knows the voice but the owner's name isn't even on the tip of her tongue. The only thing that *is* on her tongue is hot cooper. Then, the dream-like state comes over.

Everything is fuzzy and many noises sound like white noise. She suddenly feels angry. A growl escapes her lips. What the hell did she do wrong here? Instead of getting angry and lashing out, she lies on the ground and curls up. When she feels a soft hand brushing against her back, she twists her head to see who it is.

Adora whines through her nose. Her golden eyes are wide and sad. Glimmer moves her hand from her girlfriend's back to her head, stroking the base of her right ear. Adora rests her large head on Glimmer's lap, letting her eyes flutter shut.

"It's okay, 'Dora," Glimmer softly tells her.

"We still have one more try, don't we?" Adam says, leaning back on his hands.

Glimmer doesn't answer right away. The hunter does not look at Adam as she speaks. "Maybe it's for the best."

"What?"

"If she doesn't get control next month she won't have to fight her own mother. She can stay away from that, ya know?"

Adam rubs his stubble chin in thought. "I dunno. I guess we have to ask Adora when she has her brain back. We should get that squared away before May comes I guess."

"Yeah. You're right. Just gotta remember it."

The creaking of boards catches their attention. Catra comes sauntering in. She is smaller than the last time Glimmer saw her. The werepanther still looks to have a mane on her neck and her stripes on her back and legs remain. Her dual eyes take one good look at Adora.

“Well, shit. Still a husky, eh?” Catra states.

“Yeah.” Glimmer says. She gently moves Adora’s head off her lap and stands to her feet. “Guess it will be the usual tonight.”

“Why not make it different?”

“What do you mean?”

Catra walks up to her sister and gives her a nudge with the paw. Adora’s ear’s flick to attention and she tilts her head towards one side.

“Adora, ya wanna spar together? If you are gonna be stuck in this form next month, we can least get some practice in. Can you even understand what I am asking?”

Adora rises to her feet and gives a small woof. She prods her nose into Catra's ribs. The werepanther swats at her. “Don’t annoy me. Do I take that as a ‘yes’ then?”

Another woof. Adora turns around and in a few strides, is at the back door. She begins digging, begging to be let out. Glimmer quickly opens it for her. Her girlfriend leaps and bounds out, eagerly waiting for Catra to come out and join her.

“You better get out there before she gets upset,” Glimmer tells Catra.

The werepanther scoffs. “What is she gonna do? Poke me more?”

With that, she jumps out into the dark backyard. Glimmer watches Catra attempting to get Adora to settle down long enough to begin whatever she has planned. The hunter can’t help but

chuckle a little as Adora chases her sister around. Eventually, Catra is able to get ahead of Adora and trips her. The blonde tumbles over herself but her tail keeps wagging.

With the spring night being nice, there is a cool breeze in the air and the faint smell of wet grass, Glimmer decides to sit out on the back deck and do her work. She steps back inside momentarily to grab some of her gear, like her new taser, before settling down on the wood.

She runs a hand against the smooth, cold metal of her new taser. Glimmer has yet to figure out what wolfsbane to put in it. So many to choose from, so many combinations she could use, but what would work? Something too weak is no good, probably will only cause annoyance. On the other hand, something too strong isn't great either, no need for death. Glimmer needs the perfect amount for a good knock out.

Glimmer takes a moment to look at the handful of vials in her bag. The ones she received from Blackmoor. There are many uses she can do with them alone. Yet, nothing she finds online satisfies her needs and wants. At this point, the hunter might as well just make up her own stuff and simply hope it works. If only the silverlace would finally produce the much needed wolfsbane.

While taking a break from scrolling around on her phone, Glimmer looks up and catches out what the band of sisters are doing. Adora has finally stopped chasing Catra around in play and now the two truly practice their skills. Now it's more of a game of catch.

Adora does her best to get a jump on her sister. However, the werepanther is swift. Catra leaps in the air with grace while Adora face-plants straight into the ground, eating shit. Though, to her credit, the blonde quickly gets back on her feet and makes another move. It still ends the same, however.

"How are they doing?" Adam's voice enters her ears.

Glimmer cranes her neck to stare up at the younger twin. His eyes do not move away from the werecreatures out in front of him. “They aren’t going to kill each other, are they?”

“I don’t think so,” Glimmer replies. “Least I hope not. Be interesting though to see who wins.”

Adam gives a small shrug. “I still don’t know much about werecreatures and what not so I am not gonna bother trying to figure out who to place my money on.”

He plops down on the step of the deck, resting his body against the railing. Glimmer places her things to the side and puts her full attention on them. More games of cat and mouse (or cat and wolf). More Adora trying to pin Catra. When she finally does, the roles become reversed. Her girlfriend isn’t that bad at staying away from her sister.

Glimmer’s mind begins to wander. Try as she might, her focus shifts away from what is out in front of her. Adora remains in her thoughts but Catra begins to be pushed away. Instead, Shadow Weaver enters. The hunter’s mind comes up with what she looks like. Large, menacing, and out for nothing more than blood. When Catra leaps, all Glimmer sees is her mother’s killer.

The way Glimmer grips the top step, the wood threatens to impale tiny splinters. The world around her changes. Adam no longer is around and neither is the warmth from the house. There only is a frigid cold wind and dark, featureless trees around her. Her nightmare form many weeks ago now plays out in front of her.

Shadow Weaver’s dark form leaps onto her girlfriend. Glimmer’s heart pounds in her chest and her ears ring as she watches Adora fight to claw out of her mother’s grip. The hunter’s body is frozen shift, she cannot move to reach for any of her weapons. All she can do is watch Shadow Weaver’s jaw slowly wrap around her daughter’s neck.

The air in Glimmer’s throat disappears, as if it never was inside her lungs. Is this what happened to her mother? No one was around to stop the assault. *Glimmer* wasn’t around all because she decided to sleep rather than go out. Had she gone out maybe Angella would still be here.

Move, Glim, move! she screeches at herself. Her body remains locked. Stiffer than any statute.

Damn it, move! she nearly cries. *Don't let someone else die! Don't let* ***her*** *die!*

Suddenly, whatever hidden force that keeps her in place releases their grip. Glimmer lunges forward, her arm outstretched. The only thought in her mind is to protect Adora. One single word escapes— *tears*— out of her mouth.

" *STOP!"*

A hand lands on her shoulder. Snapping her head around, she finds Adam having pushed through the darkness. Through his glasses, she can see the *worry* in his dark eyes.

"Glimmer." Is all he says. Soft, reassuring, yet concerned.

Slowly, colors begin to seep back into reality. The trees regain their brown and green hues, illuminated by both the pale white light of the full moon and the yellow of her home. She feels the soft, early spring wind against her cheeks. Glimmer swears she can hear the songs of crickets filling her ears. That and the whining of Adora.

“What was that all about?” Catra asks. “Why do you want us to stop? Ya know we are supposed to be training.”

Adora slowly walks forward, pressing her wet nose against Glimmer’s hand. The hunter sighs before running a hand against the top of her girlfriend’s hair.

“Sorry. I…” Glimmer’s mouth goes dry, not knowing what to say. After a moment to think, she takes a deep breath and says, “I thought I saw something. That Catra was really Shadow Weaver and…”

She doesn’t let herself finish.

“Are you still not getting enough sleep?” Adam asks. “You should go inside and rest.”

“I want to stay and keep an eye on Adora. I always have done that.”

“She is a big wolf,” Catra huffs. “She can handle herself just fine. And what are we? Chopped liver? We can keep an eye on her.”

Adora responds with a woof. Glimmer swears she sees her girlfriend puff out her chest.

The hunter takes a deep sigh. “I can stay up. I’m a night owl after all. I can sleep in the morning.”

Adam grips tightens ever so slightly. “Go lay on the couch or something. We can be in soon, right guys?”

Both Adora and Catra give a nod. Still, Glimmer remains unconvinced. She already slept a little before, what’s the point of doing it now? She’s *fine!* So what if her legs are a little unsteady and it feels like there is a fog covering her brain?

Adam gives her a small push. “Go, will you? Sit in a chair and watch us from the damn window for christ sake! Just go inside already, okay?”

Glimmer mumbles under her breath, annoyed. This is a battle of wills and she would love to dig in her heels and win out. However, a three against one isn’t in her best favor. Without saying anything else, she sulks back into the house to grab herself a chair. Though, the moment she sits down, her body suddenly feels like it weighs a ton.

It has been quick a while since she last had a friendly spar with her sister. Adora honestly cannot remember when they last did something like this. Maybe when they were teenagers? Part of her has missed this. Though, she doesn't remember Catra being this fast and nimble. It wasn't *this* hard to catch her.

Adora plants her feet into the ground and prepares to launch another attack. All she has to do is sweep Catra off her feet. Just one good hit is all she needs. Ready, she races and throws herself forward. Her sister is ready for her attack and swiftly dodges. Annoyed but not deterred, she tries again.

This time, Catra does something unexpected. She leaps straight into the air, shocking Adora, before landing directly on Adora's back. The blonde jerk, quickly *throwing* her sister off. She spins on her heels and glares down Catra.

"Don't do that," Adora nearly growls. "Tell me if you go for my back."

Catra throws up her arms. "Sorry. I won't do it again."

Adora sighs, lowering her shoulders. She takes a moment to look around. The world around her remains…odd…There is a fuzz to everything. Nothing is crisp and clear. Even herself, looking at her hands, it's like someone made a camera out of focus. Above her, the sky is *blank.* No stars, no moon, nothing.

A yawn escapes her lips. Whatever time it is, she is exhausted. All this training has her beat. With a stretch, popping her bones back into place. "I think I am going to turn in for the night. Feel free to follow me if ya want."

Adora doesn't wait for an answer from her sister. She begins sauntering back inside, ready to curl up in bed and sleep for the rest of the night. As the back deck draws closer, Adora notices Glimmer resting on a chair. Her head dips slightly before suddenly

snapping up. Her violet eyes struggle to remain alert. It looks like the hunter is about to slump over at any moment.

She gives her girlfriend a nudge. "Let me carry you back inside."

"What?" Glimmer asks, confused.

Adora turns so her back faces Glimmer. "Are you that tired you don't understand me? C'mon. Get on my back!"

It takes another moment before Adora feels Glimmer climb onto her back. She needs yet another one to get into a comfortable position. When her girlfriend finally settles, Adora enters the house. Not feeling like heading all the way upstairs, she makes a quick trip to the couch. The blonde feels her girlfriend slide off her back.

“Get some rest, will you now?” Adora softly asks. She kneels down to become face to face with the hunter.

Glimmer says nothing. All she does is reach a hand out. Her palm lands on top of Adora’s head, her fingers lacing through her golden hair. The sensation feels so good, Adora’s eyes flutter shut. She presses her head closer to her girlfriend’s hand. When Glimmer finally stops, Adora gives her a kiss goodnight, causing her to giggle.

The night blurs together. One moment, she is bugging the hell out of Adam and then, she is trying to occupy her mind playing with whatever she can find. Every now and again, she checks up on Glimmer. Sometimes, she is asleep, sometimes she is awake, her eyes following Adora's movements.

Eventually, Adora is forced to stop. Against her own will, her body begins to ache. She wants to puke. Even Catra looks worse for wear before disappearing. Glimmer is unconscious again and no one wants to wake her up. This leaves Adam alone to comfort her. She can *smell* the awkwardness seeping off him.

When the world turns black, she becomes more aware of her surroundings. Or, lack therefore of. Adora sighs, folding her arms against her chest and taps her foot.

“Where are you?” Adora asks, searching for any signs of life. “I know you are here. Why else would I be here?”

She looks around, seeing nothing but the endless void of darkness. Adora’s frustration grows. A growl escapes her lips. “Are you seriously gonna keep me waiting? Or are you just fucking with me right now?”

Finally, after spinning around a couple more times (yet not getting herself dizzy) before she finally finds them. The canine has their back faced away and their head hangs low. The distance between human and beast is wide.

Adora tilts her head to the side. “What are you doing way out there? Usually you are a bit closer, aren’t ya?”

She begins to walk forward but she is surprised to find her steps barely do anything. When she should have already reached the canine yet, she only has moved a couple inches. Adora freezes in place, wondering what on earth is going on. Reaching her hand out, she doesn’t find an invisible wall or anything of the sorts.

“Hey!” Adora shouts. “Hey, can you hear me? Are you listening to me?”

The canine slowly turns their head around. Ears are pinned back to their head and the blue that makes up their eyes looks dimmer. When they speak, it is soft. Adora must strain her ears to understand them.

“ *I should ask you the same question.”*

“What?”

“ *You are harming yourself. Control isn’t the answer.”*

“Then what is?!?” Adora snaps back.

“ *Don’t you remember what I said? What is it you want? Do you remember what you told me?”*

“That I didn’t want to be cursed. You said pretty much there was nothing I could do about that.”

“ *Yes.”*

“Then what?!? What do you want from me?”

“ *Why do you hate* me? *Why do you reject your* past? *What do you want!”*

The last words shoot through Adora’s core. She feels her legs turn into jelly and she falls to her knees. Eyes remain locked onto the canine, staring right at their own sky blue eyes.

“I never wanted this. But, it brought me to Glimmer, didn’t it?”

“ *Yes.”*

“I’ve been a monster my whole life until her and the others.”

This time the canine does not answer. Instead, they lower their head more and tuck their tail between their legs.

Adora sighs, hanging her own head. There are trickles of tears that run down the sides of her face. “I want not to deal with this all. I especially want that no one else was dragged into the hell that is my mother…”

“ *You can only help them if you help yourself.”*

When Adora looks up, the canine is inches away from her face. They bow their head, almost asking for her to touch their wispy body. Invisible strings tug at her heart, pulling her to do as such. Yet, she cannot muster the will to do it.

“ *Stop hating* me.”

“I’m sorry…” is all Adora can say.

…

Adora groans as she comes back into reality. She grips the side of her head in an attempt to quell her pounding headache. Through squinted eyes, she pushes out a blinding light (which isn't helping her head). Staring back at her is an unfamiliar, pale ceiling. A fan twirls above, making a soft hum. *When did we get a fan in the guest bedroom?*

…Right. We are at Huntara's…

Adora remains on the ground, watching the blades move around at a steady movement. The wind gusting down against her face is soft. She moves her toes, feeling the soft carpeting below her. She should get up and begin getting ready for the day. Shower, eat, see what the others are up to, and whatnot. Though, it is comfortable down here on the ground. It feels like she isn’t *quite* back into her own body yet.

She could honestly go back to bed right about now.

However, a soft knock at the door followed by a small creak catches her attention. Adora lets her head roll to the side.

“Adora,” her brother’s voice enters her ears. The door barely cracked open. “I heard something. Are you finally awake?”

“Yeah?” Adora says in a hoarse voice.

“Oh good, finally. I have been checking up on you every now and again.”

“Have you just been standing out there?”

“Well, I am not going to just peek in to see you like that! I was lucky just to get you in another room before you shifted back.”

“Where is Glim?”

“Still sleeping. I wasn’t about to wake her up.”

“Thank you.” Adora props herself up on her elbows with effort.

"Do you want an update on how you were last night?"

"I guess the same as I have been for a while. Real or not real, Cat beat the shit out of each other in sparring."

Adam snorts. "Not. You guys had your fun but I wouldn't go as far as saying you beat each other up. Now, get dressed. I'll make breakfast."

When his steps fade away, Adora pulls the rest of her body off the ground. When she realizes there is no bathroom attached to this bedroom, that it is across the hall, she simply decides to get dressed. A shower can wait. This isn't the first time she has done this, though the blonde forgot what that was like.

After digging her clothes out of her bag and brushing out her hair, Adora exits the bedroom and quickly joins her brother in the living room.

Adam stands near the toaster, checking on the pieces of bread inside. Catra sits haphazardly on a couch, flipping through the stations. She keeps it low enough to hear but not wake up the sleeping hunter on the couch. Though, it would take a lot more to wake Glimmer up then that.

Speaking of which, Adora stops at the couch. Glimmer is curled up in a small ball, snoring and drooling. Every bone in the blonde's body *begs* her to place a gentle kiss on her girlfriend's temple. But, while a heavy sleeper, Adora doesn't want to risk anything. Instead, she carefully removes the blanket that rests on the top of the couch and gingerly drapes it against Glimmer's body.

"You trying to make sure you don't burn the place down?" Adora asks as she walks up to her brother.

Adam shuts the toaster door, again. "I'm not used to being up this early. Give me a break."

Adora gives him a small nudge. "You want me to take over?"

"If you want to make something else, feel free. These are almost done anyway."

"Huntara has some frozen breakfast burritos in the freezer," Catra says from the other room. "Nuke 'em if you want. They're good!"

"Thanks!"

It does not take long for Adora to find them. Following the directions, she throws four of them in the microwave. They finish shortly after Adam finishes buttering the toast. As the twins enter the living room, both are a bit surprised to see Glimmer sitting up.

Her hair is a mess and sleep is still written all over her face. When she spots Catra, an eyebrow raises. "Catra?"

"Morning Sunshine," Catra replies.

Glimmer's gaze turns towards the twins. She blinks several times before coming too. "Shit! I missed you shifting back!"

"Don't worry, hon," Adora reassures. She gives Glimmer a plate of toast and burrito. "Adam had you covered."

"Still. I would have woken up for you!"

"Easy. You need the rest."

"More than you know. She didn't sleep until after you came inside last night," Adam pipes up.

"I can attest to that!" Catra adds.

Glimmer glares and both of them. "Thanks…"

"Glimmer," Adora kneels down in front of her girlfriend. "It's okay. You've been stressed out a lot. I get it but please."

She reaches a hand out and places it on Glimmer's thigh. "Can you take it a bit easy? For me?"

Glimmer lowers her head, her face partially obscured by her bangs. "I'll try. I can promise, 'Dora. Not with everything going on."

"Trying is enough for me." Adora leans forward and places a tender kiss on Glimmer's forehead. "Eat up, you need strength."

Glimmer snorts. "That's my line, ya dork." She pauses for a moment, sniffing the air. “Jesus, did you shower? You still smell like wolf!”

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated

My Escape

Chapter Notes

didnt know how to end this one and i never did lyrics before so :,,,,))

anyway next Sunday is an off week. After that I will post the last three chapters every sunday. don't think there are really any tw so enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer throws back yet another swig of coffee. Her throat burns from the hot liquid that keeps being poured down it. Her brain sparks to life. It won't last forever, that's for sure. The hunter cannot recall what number cup this is. She doesn't care. If it takes a hundred more to keep the heaviness of sleep away from her body, then Glimmer will do it without second thought.

The rest she got a number of days ago did not last long. By the time the afternoon rolled around, her body wanted more. Like the coffee in her hands, Glimmer has no clue how much she has gotten. As long as she can fake it, that's all that matters.

Glimmer finishes her drink, taking in every drop.

She places her cup in the sink among the sea of others. The dishwasher needs to be unloaded before the sink overflows. The hunter makes a mental note to do so, sticking it on the corkboard of her mind. It joins the clutter and surely will be swallowed whole. With her battery charged slightly, Glimmer gets to work.

Every day, no…every little *moment* that passes brings the date with Shadow Weaver closer and closer. Inch. By. Inch. Perfuma has stated that the silverlace is days away from completion. Glimmer has checked over all her gear and prepped multiple times. It's getting too repetitive. The distraction has become an

annoyance. She needs something new. Yet, the only thing she can think of is not…the best.

It’s the only idea she has.

“‘Dora, I’m just going for a walk!” Glimmer shouts.

Her girlfriend peaks her head out from the guest/Adam’s bedroom. The twins are spending some quality time with each other. To keep their own minds occupied, they plan out about what to do after May's full moon. Something about when and how to meet Randor and Marlena.

“Okay! Call if you need anything,” Adora says.

Glimmer gives a thumbs up before heading out the back door.

The cool spring air blows gently against her cheek and petrichor fills her nose as she steps off her back deck. Dew that remains on the tips of the green blades glisten from the bright sun that warms the world. Between the melting snow from before and a couple of rainstorms, the ground below her feet is unstable. Each step Glimmer takes, her boots sink and need force to be lifted free from the trap.

Thankfully, by the time she reaches the woods, the mud becomes less of a problem. Instead, leaves from the previous fall stick to her soles. Glimmer sets her sights on her own, invisible path. One she hasn’t even shown or told Adora about. It’s the way towards the spot where she shattered her mother’s ashes.

It is about a ten minute walk to the area. Not terribly far from the house but deep enough into the woods that her phone struggles to get a bar of service. Despite the depth, Glimmer hears no birds chirping in the trees or deer sauntering through the brush. The only company she has in the woods is the babbling of the rushing brook.

Glimmer stops at the mouth of the water. The tips of her shoes nearly become wet. One false move and not only will they be

soaked, but her socks as well. With a sigh, the hunter looks up at the canopy. The sunlight trickles through the leaves, creating bright, yellow lights that land on the ground below.

She doesn't know if she believes in the afterlife or not. Maybe there is something and maybe there is something out there watching over others. Be it God or something else. Glimmer honestly doesn't know and partly doesn't care at the end of the day. What does she care about, however, is if her mother is somehow still around.

Is she watching from whatever afterlife there might be? Or is she really just ash that has been scattered across the Whispering Woods. Are there things like spirits or ghosts? Glimmer sure has shit never seen any and if there is, why wouldn't her mother visit her by now? Maybe it's payback from all the years of Glimmer herself giving the cold shoulder. The hunter can't help but laugh at that thought.

She doesn't know if she should say anything. It's not like if her mother could hear her she could reply. Glimmer came here partly to avoid Adora and Adam asking her who the hell she is talking to. Any courage she had suddenly has evaporated. It all makes her want to laugh her ass off.

So, instead of talking she lets her brain do all the work.

Hey, how are ya doing Mom?

…

I'm fine…Well okay that's a lie but can you blame me? Shit is about to hit the fan and we still are running around like a chicken with its head cut off. Gonna take down Shadow Weaver hopefully! We learned about the silverlace you used.

…

That shit is powerful. Wish I knew about it before but better late than never, right!

…

This is idotic why am I trying to talk to you? You can’t hear me, you’re dead. You’re dead and I am alive…

Glimmer runs her hand through her hair.

I’ll finish what you started. I promise you that. But, the one thing I want you to promise me, if you really are listening, is to protect Adora for me. I don’t know if I can when we fight her mother but you have to protect her, and the others.

A gust of wind blows through the woods, shaking up the growing leaves from above. Some droplets that failed to disappear under the sun sprinkle down and land on her face. Glimmer grumbles as she wipes off her face. She feels that that is her cue to begin heading back. With one final look at the stream and the woods ahead of her, the hunter spins on her heels and walks home.

Adora lies on the hardwood floor, staring at Adam’s phone in her hands. Her index finger flicks through the photos of her parents on their social media. What currently stares back at her is from a few years ago. From the description and tags at the bottom, it's from an anniversary date. Marlena has her crooked smile plastered on her face as Randor makes some unknown joke or statement.

Both their blue eyes are bright and full of love and life.

She flicks her finger across the screen again. This time, the photo is more recent. Dated only a few months ago. Around Christmas actually. On the side, partly cropped out is a lit fireplace. The whole photo is cast in a soft, orange glow. Red and green decorations hang all over the place. In the center is a large, full, pine tree. Ornaments and pale, white lights hang on the branches. At the top is a bright star.

Presents already are resting under the tree, waiting to be torn open. Randor is setting more underneath. There are wisps of grey in his dark blonde hair and he has stubble all over his face. Marlena, meanwhile, simply watches him. She is nestled under a knitted blanket and in her hands is what Adora presumes is hot chocolate.

Adora smiles softly, loving the photos of her parents. Everything she has seen is nothing but love from the two. Even the ones where Adam is in, there is nothing there to say they do not love their son. Nothing to make her think he had to deal with anything like she did. Some of her anxiety about the eventual meeting of her parents slowly disappears. Enough that it doesn't feel totally suffocating.

She is about to lock the phone and toss it back to Adam when a simple brush causes a new photo to slide across and come to the forefront. Adora's heart skips in her chest and nearly lands in her throat.

Looking back at her is her much younger self. Maybe around four years old, before the bite. Younger Adora smiles widely as she sticks her hand in a carved out pumpkin. Orange guts are in her hair, her shirt, and all around the table. Bellow is the attached message:

Over twenty years later, still searching for you. Hope wherever you are, whoever you have become, you are doing well. Hope to see you again, baby girl.

-Love Mom and Dad

Adora quickly locks the phone, not wishing to see anything more. She slaps it on the ground before sitting up. Adam, who has been rereading his translated book, snaps his head up. "You alright?"

Adora pinches her nose and sighs, her shoulders lowering. "Yeah. I'm fine. Just saw something about me, 's all."

"I warned you."

“I know.”

“I know you know that I warned you.”

Adora does not hold back her *groan.* “Please don’t give me a headache.”

“Sorry,” Adam chuckles. He marks his book by leaving his pen in the dip in the page. He tosses it on the bed before standing to his feet. “Is Glimmer still out?

“I didn’t hear her come in. Why?”

“I just wanted to get out of the house. Itching to do something that isn’t being surrounded by these four walls. Ya know? I need one of you two to come with me so I don’t get lost.”

Adora snorts. She decides to tag along with her brother to Brightmoon. He has a point about needing a change of scenery. Not knowing how long Glimmer will be gone, she sends her a quick text about her and Adam’s plan and to let her know if she wants anything, as they will be stealing her car.

The first thing the twins do is grab a quick bite to eat. Adam is the starving one and gobbles down a loaded cheese burger. Adora only gets half through her own burger (which isn’t loaded to the brim with everything extra) when Adam finishes his meal. She decides to push her partially eaten curly fries towards him.

After having their fill — Adam thankfully did not vacuum eat her fries — they decided to stop at Perfuma’s shop. Adam wants to get a few things and why not see what Perfuma is up too. Someone else seems to have the same idea.

“Catra? Surprised to see you here," Adora remarks as she opens the door.

Her sister currently is near a set of clothing. A black, leather jacket is in her hands. When the words reach her ears, Catra

snaps her head up. She gives a half smile before tossing the jacket on her shoulder.

“Shopping! Isn’t that the whole point of this ruse?” Catra says. “Flower Power and her girlfriend really have a nice selection!”

“You came all here to just shop?”

“Yes. Though not just for clothing.” Catra points to some packets of seeds, glass bottles, and on the front desk. “Leone and Wyatt wanted me to get some stuff from Perfuma. So I figured I’d go shopping for myself.”

“You really like them, huh?”

Catra nods. She goes off about how she has been in contact with the two since they left Blackmoor. Having not been around feline non-humans for a large portion of her life, she has hit it off well with the other two. The werepanther eyes light up when she speaks how she loves to annoy Wyatt, who in turn annoys her back.

“Leone says I can work there! I took her up on the offer but after I dealt with all this mom shit. Huntara will help me move to Blackmoor!

Adora smiles softly. She can feel her heart lighten. Knowing the shit biological family Catra came from and living under Shadow Weaver, having a place to land is the best thing to happen. The blonde is one to know. Seeing the twinkle in her sister’s eyes she knows that Catra is going to be okay.

Everyone’s attention is drawn by the sound of footsteps. Perfuma appears. A book is in her hands and with a finger, quickly reads through the pages that flips by. Upon reaching the front desk, she snaps it shut and places it on top of the pile. “This is the last one. Make sure your friends read it carefully. It’s written using faery math.”

“I don’t know what the hell that is but I’m sure Leone does. How much do I owe ya?”

Perfuma tells her the price. Her eyes flick to the side, landing on the twins. “What’s up you two? Surprised to see you without Glimmer, Adora.”

Adora gives a shrug. “Needed to get out of the house and Glimmer had her own things to do. Adam wanted to come out also. Figured we stopped here.”

“How’s Glimmer doing?” Perfuma finishes checking out Catra and hands her her bagful of things. “Haven’t heard from her in a couple days.”

Adora rests her upper half on the counter. She brushes a finger against a flowering aster that Perfuma has in a small pot, decorated in little scorpions. “She’s doing as great as the rest of us. Worried about her. She’s definitely gotten the least amount of sleep out of all of us, which is what is bugging me.”

“I had to nearly fight her to sleep during Adora’s last shift,” Adam adds on.

“I knew she was having trouble. I didn’t know it was that bad,” Perfuma says.

“I can always punch her to knock her out,” Catra jokes.

“Please don’t,” Adora replies.

Perfuma lifts a finger before ducking behind the counter. Adora hears the opening of a door, followed by the clinking of glass bottles together. The faery mumbles something as she continues to shift through the cabinet. Finally, just before the blonde is about to peer over, Perfuma reappears.

The faery places two bottles on the counter. Inside the glass, a light blue liquid sloshes around. Adora raises an eyebrow as she looks at her friend.

“How many colors do these things come in?”

“All. This one’ll help Glimmer sleep.”

Adora takes one of the bottles, studying it in the light that pours in from the window. It’s almost as blue as the sky and the glass is warm to the touch. Part of her wants to take a sip right now.

“I’m giving you two so you can have some spares. That stuff is *potent.* You only need a couple sips to sleep for a few hours.” Perfuma tells her. “I can’t promise a good night’s sleep, that always is up to chance like a normal night’s sleep, but at least it’s some shut eye.”

“Do you really think this’ll help her?”

“Maybe. I hope it does.”

“Thank you. I owe you one.”

Adora stuffs the bottles into her bag. Even through the fabric she can feel the warmth from the potion. Adam decides to look around the store, seeing if there is anything of interest. Catra decides to go back to shopping as well. The oldest of the siblings watches as her younger ones end up seeing who can find the tackiest shirt. Adam and Catra finally settle on a button-up shirt that is covered in the blue and purple zigzags. Adora can only roll her eyes as her brother buys it.

With everything now set and in bags, the trio wishes Perfuma well and begins to head home. Catra decides to tag along back to Glimmer’s place. She wants to kill some time in Brightmoon before returning back to Huntara’s place. When the minotaur isn’t around, the place is pretty boring.

It takes a couple moments for Adora to find her girlfriend. Glimmer is up in the attic. Adora climbs the shaking stairs and pokes her head in. "Glim! I'm back!"

She only hears Glimmer's voice. "I'll be down in a sec! Just seeing if there was anything else useful here."

Adora slides down the stairs, bouncing slightly as the soles of her feet hit the hardwood. She treks back downstairs, joining Adam and Catra in the living room. There is the sound of Glimmer climbing down the stairs, shutting the attic door, and hopping down the second set of steps.

“How was your trip into town?” Glimmer asks. She brushes away some cobwebs that have gotten into her now three-toned hair. “See you picked a stray.”

“Nice to see you too,” Catra says, flipping her off. Glimmer laughs.

“It was fine. I actually got you something.” Adora digs around in her bag before pulling out the bottles of potions. She places one on the table and keeps the other in her hand.

Glimmer takes the bottle from her girlfriend's hands, studying it closely. “What the heck does this one do?”

“It’s to help you sleep. Perfuma said you only need a couple of sips to sleep.”

“I don’t need Faery NyQuil.”

Adora stops her from putting the bottle down. Fingers wrap around the hunter’s wrist and eyes lock onto her violet ones. Her voice becomes soft and she keeps her shoulders low.

“Glitter-bug…Please take it. I plan on taking some tonight to sleep but I’m begging you. I hate seeing you like this. I hate hearing the others had to almost force you to sleep before. You’re hurting yourself and I can’t stand it!”

Adora must keep her voice together. She cannot, however, keep the blur from escaping her eyes. Continuing her plea takes both a

inhale and a moment to gather her thoughts. “Glimmer… *please.* I want to help you. *Please* take it.”

Her grip on Glimmer’s wrist loosens. If her girlfriend wanted to break free, she easily could. Yet, instead, the hutner’s makes no attempt to pull away. Glimmer’s face softens and her eyes flick down to the ground. “I’m sorry, Adora.”

“Will you rest?”

Glimmer shifts her weight in thought. Finally, she pulls her arm away, keeping the bottle in her hand. “You guys aren’t going to let me off the hook still, huh?” She rolls the potion in her hands for a moment before pulling out the cork.

Adora sighs in relief. She watches Glimmer take a couple of sips. Almost immediately—the second after her girlfriend’s lips leave the glass—the potion takes effect.

“Oh, wow…” Glimmer collapses on the couch. She yawns, “That stuff works fast.”

Adora guides her into a lying position before taking the potion away. "Don't fight it."

"Okay, Mom."

Glimmer eyes flutter shut as she nestles herself into the soft cushions. Adora drapes a blanket over the hunter before placing a kiss on her temple. "Sweet dreams, Glim. I love you."

"I love you too," Glimmer says in a soft whisper.

Adora sighs in relief as she hears Glimmer's breathing become slow. The blonde plugs up the bottle and sets it on the table, only to find the other missing.

"Catra?"

Her sister shoves the other bottle in her bag. "What? You're not the only one who has to deal with insomnia. I'll pay you for it."

“Where’s the rest of your little pack?” Petra asks. She settles down on the wooden seat on the other side of the table.

“Busy or asleep,” Bow answers.

Glimmer takes a sip of her coffee. Even after drinking so much that her blood must be seventy-five percent caffeine, the taste has never gotten dull. Her mind goes back to this morning, finding Adora passed out cold on the bed. Judging by the amount of potion in the bottle, either she overestimated what she needed or wanted to be knocked out cold. Before leaving to meet Petra, she tucked her girlfriend in.

“Long as everyone is on the same page.” Petra takes her own sip of her tea.

Seeing them in the flesh, Glimmer can see that the werebear has fully healed. There are new scars on their body but there are no hints of long term injuries. After being pretty much *mauled* it’s amazing how well Petra has healed, even for a werecreature like herself.

There are good things and bad things Petra brings up. The bad: she and her siblings cannot be in Brightmoon on the night of the full moon. While Petra is the leader of the band of siblings, all four have their own jobs in keeping tabs on their own section of woods. It’s not easy to abandon and go somewhere else. Especially with the distance.

The good: Petra has some connections. If everything goes according to plan, if Shadow Weaver is stopped, the werebear knows people who can take her into custody. There will be no worry about what to do with Adora’s and Catra’s mother when the sun rises in the morning.

“Do you really think we will be fine by ourselves?” Glimmer asks.

“I believe in you guys. You know what your mother used before, you got two werecreatures with you, and how many of you are joining to fight?”

“Me and Adam are going to do our best to help,” Bow answers. “But the others can’t due to being away or busy. So…just the five of us…”

“Well, you know what you are up against and know how to stop her. You can do it.”

Glimmer doesn’t know how much she believes in that herself. But like her coffee, she swallows the feeling back. She leans back in her seat. “Well, if we aren’t dead after it all, I’ll let you know. If we are, I’ll haunt you in the afterlife.”

“Good thing I don’t believe in ghosts.” Petra smirks slightly as she takes a sip of her own coffee.

“I’ll still find a way.”

“Trust me, she *will,”* Bow states.

“Well, I’ll just make a bet with Drake. He loves that shit.”

The three talk a little bit longer, having not planned on staying for long. Petra gives them a couple of things like extra wolfsbane, batteries, and some brownies Brooke made. There still is some warmth to the pan.

Glimmer and Bow give Petra their thanks before heading out. Stepping outside, the world is slightly cold out. Spring has decided to take a nap and won’t be back for the next couple of days. The hunter is happy that the brownies are still warm, as she has no gloves on at all.

“Think Adora will wake up any time soon?” Bow asks as they get closer to Glimmer’s car.

"Maybe," Glimmer shrugs. "Whenever she *does* wake up, I'm sure she is going to be surprised by how late she has slept. I'm sure she is going to like these brownies. I know I can't wait to eat some."

"You and Adora better not eat all of them. Adam and I need some. These are a great way to take a small break."

"Yeah, sure…It would be great to do something nice with Adora again."

Bow pauses for a moment. At the car now, his fingers are wrapped around the door handle. "Why don't you two go out on a date? When was the last time you guys did that?"

"Huh?" Glimmer blinks. She taps a finger against her chin. "Probably not since February. Do you really think going out on a date is a good idea?"

Bow opens the door, placing himself in the passenger seat. "Why not? With everything going on, why not try to unwind a bit? If you guys can. There's no use in staying anxious. Get your mind off of things. I was actually thinking of asking Adam. To see if he wanted to do something."

Glimmer snorts as she takes the driver seat, placing the brownie's on her friend's lap.

Bow ignores her 'comment'. "If I ask him, will you ask Adora? It's only fair, isn't it?"

" *Fine!"*

The whole ride home, Glimmer tries figuring out what and where to bring Adora.

Glimmer finds Adora lying on the kitchen floor, staring up at the ceiling and showing no signs of getting up. The hunter squats

down, tilts her head, and raises an eyebrow. “So…do I want to know why you are on the dirty floor?”

“Is it against the law to do so?” Adora replies.

“No.”

“I slipped and didn’t want to get back up.”

“Are you okay?” Bow asks from behind.

“Don’t worry. My head already is feeling better” Adora finally sits up. “How was Petra? Sorry I couldn’t make it.”

“Fine. Sadly she and her siblings couldn’t come during the full moon, which, ya know, sucks.” Glimmer states. “Brooke made us some brownies, though.”

This gets Adora to leap to her feet. As she begins to eat a piece of the chocolate sweet, Bow gives Glimmer a nudge under her ribcage. It takes everything in the hunter not to jump straight through the roof at the sensation. She gives a glare.

Ask her Bow mouths.

I’m going to Glimmer replies.

Do it! Bow gives her a push.

Glimmer stumbles forward. She holds back a yelp of surprise and snaps her head around. *I hate you.*

Love you too! Bow gives a two thumbs up.

“Adora,” Glimmer says, clearing her throat.

The blonde looks over her shoulder, some brownie crumbs on her chin. Adora wipes it off before speaking. “What’s up, hon?”

“Well, I was thinking…Did ya wanna go out? M-Maybe tonight?”

“A date? Tonight?”

Well I would rather be working on not getting killed. “Yeah. Just have a night to ourselves before shit hits the fan. I know a great place where we could get some dinner and just…relax."

"Is that even possible?" Adora says with a slight laugh. But then her face tints red. She scratches the side of her face. "But that would be nice. I'd love to do that, Glim."

"Can't wait."

The rest of the day and afternoon goes by slowly. Not quite a snail's pace but more or a slow moving cargo train. By the time the sun begins to lower and stomachs start to growl, Glimmer gets herself ready for the night out.

She must dig through her closest to find something a *little* nice. With the spur of the moment, the first place that popped into her mind was heading to a small restaurant that Bow once went to with Perfuma. He said most people there wore something more than their everyday clothes. Plus, apparently, they occasionally have music to dance to.

She kicks herself a little, wishing that she thought of a place that was a little more casual and not a thirty minute drive away. It’s too late now.

Finally, she finds a simple, lilac dress. Towards the end, its frills slightly and has hints of sparkles. Glimmer quickly switches out of her everyday wear. Stopping at the bathroom, she brushes out her hair. Her roots desperately need to be dyed. Yet another thing to get lost in her cork board in her mind.

Glimmer splashes some cold water on her face before heading downstairs. She is not entirely surprised to see Adora already ready for their dinner date at the bottom of the staircase. Her girlfriend wears a vest and a pair of slacks Adam let her borrow. Her hair is tired back and kept out of her face.

Glimmer misses the last step of the stairs.

“Are you okay?!?” Adora asks. Her arms have broken Glimmer’s fall and help steady her out.

“I’m fine,” Glimmer half lies. Her heart is not racing from her nearly eating shit. “So how do I look?”

Adora smiles softly and her eyes are bright and warm. “Like a queen,” she says, her voice tender. She brushes the back of her hand against Glimmer’s cheek.

“You know…” Glimmer starts, leaning into the touch, “you look like a king then.”

Adora’s blush runs from ear to ear. She clears her throat before bowing and sticking out her hand. “Well then. May I take my queen out on this date?”

Glimmer chuckles before taking her girlfriend’s hand. “Yes you may.”

Despite this, Glimmer drives. Adora happily takes the passenger seat and control of the radio. They chatter a little, passing the time to the best of their ability. By the time they pull into a spot in the parking lot, both women are laughing over a joke. Glimmer leads the way inside.

The inside of the restaurant has several other people enjoying the night out. Lights are low and a soft song fills the air. Glimmer sees on each table not only a blooming flower but a lit candle. So many smells fill her nose, the hunter cannot tell one from the other.

“How’s the nose?” Glimmer asks as they wait.

Adora rubs it. “Well, I can tell you this. All the candles have different scents. I wonder which one we will get.”

A young woman appears and guides them to their table. It’s closer to the small dance floor, which currently no one is on. She

lights the candle, filling the table in a vanilla scent. Once the waitress leaves, Glimmer does her best to find something to eat.

Adora peers over her menu, checking on her girlfriend. She is happy to see Glimmer is at least reading it. She returns to her menu, which is a struggle. Having never really been into something of this caliber before, it's hard to make a decision. She chews on her lip in thought. After some (a lot) of back and forth, the blonde decides on a salad.

"See anything you like?" Adora asks, setting her menu to the side.

"Thinking about just getting a chicken parm dinner. Did you find something to eat?"

"Yeah. I hope the food here is good."

"Bow and Perfuma say it is."

"Can't wait."

Adora takes a moment to look out a nearby window. There is a patio outside with bright lights, blocking out some of the dark night sky. Yet, she can still spot the almost full moon. Each night that passes, it grows to completion. She dreads the thought of how she can almost count on both her hands how many days are left until the deadline. Her heart suddenly picks up in her chest.

C'mon on, Adora! You're having a night out with Glimmer! Don't think about that!

She looks back at her girlfriend, hoping to get her mind off of things. Adora finds Glimmer staring off into space. The hunter absentmindedly picks at the bread someone has brought over. Quickly thinking, Adora grabs her own piece of the warm starter and flicks a piece of its inside at Glimmer. It hits her girlfriend just above her eyebrow.

“Hey!” Glimmer shouts.

Adora grins from ear to ear. “What are ya thinking about?”

“Nothing really. Just spacing out.”

“What do you think the boys are doing? Think they are making their own dinner?”

“If they are and they eat all my food, they are going grocery shopping.”

Adora can’t help but chuckle a little. “Maybe when we get home, all there’ll be are pizza boxes.”

“Maybe…” Glimmer sighs. “Adora…do…do you think everything is going to be okay? Petra said she believes in us but…” she trails off.

Adora doesn’t know quite how to answer. Does she answer honestly? That she doesn't *know* the answer to that? Or does she give something reassuring, even if she knows it won’t work. She rubs the back of her neck. Something pops into her mind.

“I can only hope so. Cause if we don’t, then how can we go on more dates like these, right?”

There is a soft smile that forms on Glimmer’s face. “This is true… Can you believe it's been almost a year since I first found your sorry ass in the woods. It feels like such a long time ago.”

“Huh…I forgot all about that…”

Suddenly, the sound of music catches Adora’s attention. She recognizes the song on the first beat. The same one she danced to with Glimmer so many months ago in October. The one that her parents would always do the same. A new idea pops into her head.

She stands to her feet, brushing herself off. Adora then clears her throat, gaining Glimmer's attention. The hunter snaps her head up, breaking out of whatever trace her thoughts put her back in. Without saying anything, the blonde sticks out her hand. Glimmer remains silent as well as she takes her girlfriend's hand. Just before the lyrics of the song begin to stream out of the speakers, Adora finds the perfect spot to lose herself in her girlfriend's presence.

Glimmer wraps her arms around Adora's neck while Adora wraps hers around Glimmer's waist. The two keep each close, neither wanting to pull away. The hunter's fingers are locked tightly against the back of Adora's neck. They begin to move, the blonde leading the way, as the lyrics finally begin.

The moment our eyes met/I will never forget

You entered my life without warning/But now I can't wait to see you in the morning

It hurts when we are apart/For you have my whole heart

Adora shuts her eyes and rests her forehead against Glimmer. Being found in the woods by the hunter and Bow is nothing more than a blur of colors and sounds. However, their first talk still appears clear in her head. How Glimmer had her walls yet still brought her out to town to keep her on her feet.

If it wasn't for her girlfriend, who knows where she would be? No money, no clothes, no belongings at all other than her blanket. Adora could be dead for all she knows. Yet, here she is, dancing with the woman that stole her heart and helped tame the wolf inside of her.

When your lips met mine/I was on cloud nine

Even during our fights/All I wanted was you at night

We always come back stronger than ever/Please stay with me forever

Glimmer pulls her head away and rests it against the blonde's chest. Adora shifts so her chin rests against the black strains of hair that stick out of her hair. They have been through a lot, haven't they? Shadow Weaver, figuring out who Adora's family is, Catra, that very first shift where Glimmer was nearly mauled and the time Adora ran away into the woods.

And what about figuring out how Angella felt about her daughter in her book, stepping into Glimmer's mother's room for the first time in years, and Adora doing her best to ease any pain and suffering her girlfriend might be feeling. Like now.

My brain can be full of plight/Your smile continues to make the world bright

I will do all in my power to protect it/Even if I must take a hit

But for now hold me tight/And I will let you be my knight

All Adora can hope for is that this moment lasts forever, that time doesn't keep marching forward, and she can simply *hold* Glimmer until the death of the universe. She struggles to keep out the thoughts of her mother, of all the things that could go wrong. Of what could happen to Glimmer.

After everything her girlfriend has done for her, essentially saving her life, she can't let Shadow Weaver lay a finger on her. Adora *refuses* to allow that outcome to become the reality.

When the day has come to an end/And our wounds have mend

I want to lie with you in bed/To look at the world ahead

No matter the setback/I love you to the moon and back

Adora shifts, placing her fist under Glimmer's chin and lifting up her head. The blonde's heart warms as she sees the hints of the return of sparkles in her violet eyes. They are still tired, just like her own must be, but in the haze there still is the glint of love. One of the many things Adora fell for.

She leans forward, placing their lips together. Glimmer tugs against her neck, pulling them in deeper into the embrace. Adora sucks all of it up. The taste of the hunter’s strawberry chapstick, the scent of her lavender shampoo, and the warmth of her skin against her own.

Tomorrow is not a given.

Yesterday is finished.

All there is, is today.

Chapter End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated

A Shocking Conclusion

Chapter Notes

heh

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Two days…

Two days left until the full moon. May has finally rolled around. The flowers known for this month bloom in all colors of the rainbow and in almost all shapes one can imagine. There will be more and more chicks hatching from their eggs and fawns prancing around as they get used to their new legs.

At least…This is what Adora believes the outside world is like. After all, it is only a minute past midnight on May 1st. The blonde did not intend to be up this late, her body is *begging* her to shut her eyes and not open them until the sun rises above the horizon. Yet, her brain wanted to see this moment. Now that it is here, she cannot close them.

Her brain remains unease.

It doesn't help that she is sleeping on the couch currently. Glimmer kept tossing and turning and kicking in the bed. She too couldn't keep her eyes closed and decided to crack open her laptop. She did ask her girlfriend if that was okay and Adora didn't mind. Though, after a while she decided to head downstairs in an attempt to sleep. She wonders if the hunter has found any sort of sleep.

Adora rolls over, turning away from the electronic clock. She can feel heaviness beginning to drag her into the murky, darkness. Limbs are hard to move and her mind becomes like the TV static behind her. For a moment, she thinks she has finally slipped into unconsciousness. However, when she opens her eyes and takes a

moment to look over her shoulder at the clock, only an hour has passed.

Fuck me.

Over and over this goes. She is able to get some shut eye before being thrown awake once more. Only once does she get lucky and rest for two whole hours! That's a damn miracle! By the time the sun wakes up, Adora can count on one hand how long she slept. Groaning, the blonde snaps up and decides to make breakfast.

Carefully, as to not wake anyone, she pulls out the pans. One nearly slips out of her hands as she searches for the right one. Somehow, at the last second, Adora catches it before it collides with the ground. She sighs in relief and places the right one on the stovetop. Omelettes are on the menu for this morning. With three different palettes, Adora trots over to the fridge to check what is inside.

Just as she wraps her fingers around the handle, something catches her attention out of the corner of her eye.

"Hm?"

Adora blinks. She notices Glimmer's hunter bag lying nearby, open and exposed. A couple of her things are hanging out of the opening, half resting on the ground. She takes a breath before deciding to zip it all up. Carefully, Adora puts away some arrows, using a rubber band at the bottom of the bag to wrap it up. As her fingers wrap around Glimmer's taser, she feels something gritty beneath her fingertips.

Her skin breaks out.

"Son of a bitch!" Adora winces, snapping her hand to her chest. After a moment she shakes out the rest of the pain in her hand. The fingers that touched the taser are red and itchy. Not wanting to have a full on break out of hives, Adora grabs a paper towel and uses it to safely put away the taser. At the bottom of the bag, she finds the culprit. An open vial of wolfsbane.

Gotta be more careful, hon. Adora thinks to herself. *Enough of that. Breakfast. What does everyone like again?*

She gets back to work. Spinach and tomatoes for Adam, ham and cheese for Glimmer, and finally country style for herself. The smell of frying eggs, meat, and oil wafts through the air. There are creaks of floorboards coming from Adam's room. He comes out of the room, yawning and scratching his bare chest.

"Smells good." Adam says. He grabs his plate and travels over to the couch, saying nothing about the signs someone was there most of the night.

The smell must have reached the second floor. Quietly, Glimmer appears. Adora only realizes she has joined her and her brother downstairs by a small sneeze.

"Bless you," Adora says.

Glimmer mumbles something before grabbing her breakfast. She plops down on one of the chairs and begins eating, her eyes only half open. Adora snorts at the sight. After tossing the dirty cookware into the sink, the blonde begins chowing down on her omelette. She cannot lie, she did a hell of a good job on the food today.

No one says much. Glimmer remains half dead while Adam flips through the TV until he gets to some news station. It's kind of peaceful, if Adora is being honest. She kind of likes it…

It doesn't last for long, however.

Adora is putting her dish away when her phone rings. It's Perfuma.

"Hey, what's up?" she asks.

"Is Glimmer up? I didn't want to call and have her miss it," Perfuma says.

"Yeah, she is. We all are."

"Come over as soon as you can. I finished the silverlace."

Adora needs a moment to process this. The words bounce around in her head like a DVD screensaver until her brain finally latches onto it. The silverlace is *done?* With barely any time to spare? Adora is dangerously close to pinching herself hard to ensure she is not dreaming.

"Are you still there?" Perfuma asks.

Adora shakes her head. "Yeah, sorry. I am. We'll be there soon."

"Okay, see you soon."

Adora hangs up. She remains in place, her legs suddenly becoming heavy like lead. Hands shake and she struggles to keep herself together. Ears ring and she swears that the world is starting to spin. Adora grabs the counter with a hand, steadying herself out.

Pull yourself together, Adora!

She inhales deeply, holding the breath in her chest for several moments before exhaling. Adora spins on her heels.

"Who was that?" Adam asks.

"Perfuma. She finished the silverlace." Adora takes a moment to look at her brother and girlfriend. Adam's eyes are wide and his mouth is slightly agape. Glimmer has fully awakened, her eyes wide and alert.

Adora finishes. "She wants us to come over. We can go after you guys are done eating."

"I'm pretty much done," Adam states.

“I’m done.” Glimmer stands to her feet. As she walks by, Adora notices the omelette is only half eaten. She gives her girlfriend a look.

“It was good, I promise. Just…really filling,” Glimmer replies.

Adora shifts on her feet. “I’ll make it smaller next time. I’ll finish cleaning while you two get ready.”

Glimmer takes a deep breath, barely able to calm her racing nerves. She follows behind Adora and Adam as the older blonde opens the door to Perfuma’s store. Inside, the faery is checking someone out, making some small talk with them. She gives a small wave to the group as she wraps up.

The hunter studies her friend from a distance. She can see the dark circles under Perfuma’s eyes and how her friend does her best to remain standing. The faery could damn well collapse at any moment. As the customer leaves, Perfuma yawns and stretches out her arms and upper body.

“You doing okay there, ‘Fuma?” Glimmer asks as she walks up to the counter. “Looks like you need an energy potion.”

“I have to get one from another faery. Mine won’t work on me.” Perfuma reaches for a cup of steaming coffee and takes a sip. “This works just fine, however. Now, wait for one more minute. I will be right back.”

Without another word, Perfuma disappears down the hall. There is the sound of her opening the closet and rummaging around. Something falls, causing her to swear. Glimmer, Adora, and Adam exchange looks at the racket. Several more moments pass before Perfuma returns, a mason jar in her hands.

“Had to stay up all night to finish this up. Scorpia too, though she is down for the count right now,” the faery states.

She places the small jar on the counter for everyone to see. Inside, filled about half way, is more than enough silverlace. In the powder form, it lives up to its name. It looks as if someone has taken the element itself and grounded it up in the glass. It shines in the fluorescent lights that hang in the store.

Glimmer's breath gets caught in her throat. Her heart stops *dead* in its tracks. Time freezes and everyone else in the room disappears. All that there is is herself and the wolfsbane. Her hand slowly inches forward, itching to finally have the silverlace in her grasp. After so long, it is finally here. After so long, this nightmare can *finally* end.

After so long, she can finally help keep everyone safe.

Perfuma suddenly slaps her hand away. "Please be careful with this, Glim. This is strong enough to affect you and could do a number on you if you're not careful."

Adam takes this as a cue to take the jar. He shoves it in his knapsack.

"Do you know how you're gonna use it?" Perfuma asks.

"The usual," Glimmer quickly answers. "I have a new taser to try out with it. Honestly, I'll use it on anything that'll help stop Shadow Weaver."

"Just be careful, okay? I don't wanna hear about any of you guys' obituaries." She eyes Glimmer. "You already gave me a massive heart attack once."

Glimmer opens her mouth to say something else but Adora cuts her off with a nudge to the ribcage. The hunter jumps slightly before her girlfriend speaks. "Don't worry, Pefuma. We'll keep her safe."

Perfuma sighs through her nose. "You better call in the morning or I'll bust down your door."

Glimmer rolls her eyes. Despite Perfuma insisting there is no need, the hunter gives her friend money. After some back and forth, the faery gives in and takes the money.

"If you're not dead in the next couple days, I'll buy you lunch with this," Perfuma states.

Glimmer says nothing, only giving a small nod. She is eager to get home and begin finalizing everything. However, there is some talking before any of that takes place. Perfuma tells the curious twins about how she created the wolfsbane. With some other leaves, she grinds them up, uses a bit of magic, and adds some other plant bits. The faery mentions she has to let it sit for a few hours to allow everything to mix together.

Both twins watch with eager eyes, making Glimmer smile softly.

When the time comes to leave, there is no 'good-bye'. Instead there is 'see you later'. Adam even says as they begin leaving the store they can all hang out on the fourth. Perfuma nods in agreement. Glimmer catches a flash of nervousness in her friend's eyes before turning away.

One day…

Glimmer groans as she rolls over in bed. Her back presses against Adora's, who is lucky enough to be asleep. It's restless, the hunter keeps hearing her girlfriend mumbling and twitching, but at least it's *sleep.* Glimmer won't lie, she is a little jealous.

Her eyes stay fixated on the half empty bottle resting on her nightstand. Perfuma's potion has done jack for her this time around. Part of Glimmer wonders if she should drink more to fall asleep or if it will just make her sick. Not wanting to be throwing up, all she can do is stare at it.

Come later today, Catra will come over to finalize everything. Whatever plans anyone has come up with will be said and see what will and will not get the group killed. Glimmer feels her

stomach twisting into a tight knot at the thought. The day after will mostly be starving off the anxieties of what will come. Then, maybe, there will be another day to see…

Glimmer bites back a groan. She really wishes she could sleep right about now and not feel like she is drowning. Her chest aches with worry and some invisible force crushes her chest. Fingers grip her sheets.

What did you do mom? Were you just as nervous as me? Or were you not worried at all?

Suddenly, arms wrap around the hunter's torso. Glimmer jerks at the sudden sensation before she realizes it is only Adora. The blonde buries her face between her girlfriend's shoulder blades and sighs in her sleep.

Glimmer's body relaxes. She gently grabs one of Adora's hands and places a kiss on the back. *Thank you, Adora.*

She attempts to close her eyes, knowing it most likely will do nothing. *At least you'll be okay.*

Glimmer hisses through her teeth. Already her fingertips do not like the silverlace. So much for getting her arrowheads ready. The hunter pushes it away, not wanting to deal with hives currently. Instead, she takes her good old wolfsbane and gets to work.

She sits on the ground between the couch and table. Catra and Adam sit across from her. The younger twin watches Glimmer do her work. Meanwhile, Adora and Bow rest on the couch.

Glimmer can hear Bow's wrist watch ticking away. It's almost like a gnat but worse. She doesn't need the reminder.

"Do you feel comfortable shooting?" Glimmer asks Adam, distracting herself.

Adam gives a small shrug. "As ready as I'll ever be."

“As long as you don’t hit one of us, you should be fine. Now, onto the game plan.”

After all this time, they have come up with something a little more than ‘try not to die’. Glimmer and Catra will lead while Bow and Adam bring up the rear. As possibly the weakness link, Adam will stay mostly in the shadows and away from Shadow Weaver’s path.

Adora, of course, is the biggest question. After the two failed attempts from before, there is a high chance of her keeping her dog brain. What everyone has agreed upon is that Adora *should* come along. At home, she’ll be nothing more than a sitting duck. With the others, she’ll be protected and can still fight and listen to most commands.

As for how everyone will take down Shadow Weaver, *that* is still up in the air. Ideas are thrown around, hoping something will stick. After about an hour of back and forth of frustrations and a number of crumbled up balls of paper thrown on the grown, something is decided on.

Glimmer and Catra will do their best to keep Shadow Weaver’s attention. While they keep her distracted and hopefully weaken her, Bow and Adam will launch a surprise attack. As for Adora, it’ll depend on her mind set. At the current moment, it is leaning towards being with Glimmer and Catra.

The werepanther drums her fingers on the table. “Mom’s not going to be easy to beat. We have to play extra smart if we are going to get the upper hand.”

“Do you have any other ideas?” Glimmer huffs.

Catra scoffs. “No. I’m shit out of ideas just like you.”

“Do you think there is any way to find Shadow Weaver first?” Bow inquires. “That’ll help us a lot.”

“Scent?” Adam asks. He looks at his sister and Catra. “Do you guys remember what she smells like?”

Adora shrugs. “I might recognize it if I smell it but it’s not like I *want* to.”

“I do but who knows if she will mask it,” Catra adds. “Which is a good idea for us now that I say it…”

“Whatever the case, we all agree to meet just before the full moon takes effect, right?” Glimmer asks as she begins to pack up her gear. Everyone gives a nod. The plan is now all set in stone. Adam, Bow, and Catra will get some last minute things before arriving and then the fight will begin.

Hopefully there are no hiccups… Glimmer thinks to herself.

Today is the day…

Adora leans against the railing of the porch's roof. The rain drums against the canopy in a steady tempo. Despite the heavy clouds that coat the night sky, she can feel the presence of the moon *just* barely full. The wolf inside her claws at the inside of her chest, gnawing to get out. They are extra desperate to break free today.

Adora grasps her shirt tight between her fingers. She swallows, hard. *Don't you dare.*

The wolf backs down, though only slightly. Adora sighs, letting her hand fall back to her side. The rain continues to drum against anything it hits. The blonde yawns. Maybe she should try going to bed…

“You’re gonna catch a cold standing out here without a jacket, ya know,” Adam’s voice says from behind.

Adora turns her head just as Adam shuts the door behind him. He settles against the other railing.

"I'll be fine. It'll take a lot more than that for me to get a cold. And you're one to talk."

She looks over him, only in his pajamas. Which consists of a tank top and pants. At least Adora has *socks* on!

Her brother waves her off. "I don't plan on being out here all too long. I heard you go out and I didn't hear you come back in. You doing okay?"

Adora sighs through her nose. "You know the answer to that already." She pauses for a moment. "I hope I don't fuck anything up."

"I don't think you will."

Adora remains silent. She watches the rain droplets land on the puddles in the front yard. The ripples start off small yet large, creating small waves. They spread out, thinning and shrinking as they slowly change the shape of the puddle. The rain continues to fall, changing the water below even more.

Adam scratches the side of his face. "Can I ask a question?"

"What is it?" Adora raises an eyebrow.

"What do you think life would've been like if, ya know…you never were bitten?"

"What brought this up?"

"With everything going on, it made me think about it. It was Shadow Weaver who bit you and now we are about to face her. You don't have to answer if you don't want to."

"Hm…"

What *would* her life be like? It's not like she has anything else to go off of. Had Adora never darted out that night and avoided the bite, her life would be vastly different with so many 'whats'. What

would it have been like to go to school and be with other children? What would it have been like to be raised with a twin brother? What would it have been like to have two loving parents who supported her. Even if she *was* still bitten, what would have been like if she never was kidnapped? If her parents' desperation was never used against them?

But of course, what would life have been like without Catra? There *were* good moments. She probably would have never met Glimmer or Bow or Perfuma or anyone else for that matter. Where would she be if none of this had happened to her?

It's a life she doesn't know.

"I don't know, honestly. I barely remember you and Mom and Pa," Adora starts. "Part of me always wishes I never had been bit. Besides the whole… *everything…* the shifting sucks. Besides not having memories, the pain is awful. Sometimes it makes having a period look like a cake walk."

This makes Adam snort.

"But…I don't know. I don't know any other life and I don't know what I would do without Glimmer. I'm not saying I am happy with what happened to me. I wouldn't wish it on anyone! It's…if I could wish to do everything again and not have all this happen to me, I don't know if I could do it.

"My relationship with Catra is complicated but there was a time before things got horrible, we were close. She was the only sibling I knew before you came back. I can tell she is trying and that she has changed. I'm proud of her for that."

Adora pauses for a moment. She sticks out her hand, letting herself feel the cool water roll against her skin. "What do I even need to say about Glimmer? As nerve-wracking as meeting Mom and Pa is going to be, I can't wait for it. I can't wait to tell them everything and to hear more stories.

"I don't know if I am making any sense. I like where I am now. I don't know who I would be without all those things that happened to me. There's nothing I can do to change the past, it'll follow me around like my shadow. But I have the power to keep my path in life bright."

The gnawing feeling of the wolf against her chest settles further.

Adam walks up to her and gives her a playful punch to the arm. "I'm happy for you, ya know? And to have you back in my life."

"The same to you… *little bro."*

Adam now gives her a shove. "You and your five minutes." He then lets out a long yawn. "We probably should get some sleep. You going to come in?"

"Yeah, right behind ya."

The twins return to the dry living room. Adam stops at his door. "Good night, Adora. Love ya."

"I love you too, Adam. See you in the morning."

Adora makes her way up the stairs. Even with her night vision, she turns on the hall light. Adam's yawn has become contagious and there is no need for tripping. Her bed and sleep sounds so appealing right about now. She can nestle back against Glimmer (hopefully she finally fell asleep) and simply let herself forget for a short period.

However, she gets stopped in her tracks. Her eyes pick up on the ajar door of Angella's room. As far as she can remember, it was closed before. Adora quickly checks the other rooms, all of which lack Glimmer.

What is she doing?

Slowly, she makes her way to the bedroom of Angella. She hesitates for a moment.

“Glitter-bug?” Adora whispers. She gently pushes open the door, letting the light of the hall stream in. It stops just short of the hunter, who has her back turned towards her girlfriend. Adora is both surprised and not surprised that Glimmer is in her mother’s bedroom. The string that is holding back the threat of Shadow Weaver is about to be severed in less than twenty-four hours, how can she blame her for being here?

Adora steps into the room, remaining in the light. Angella’s room is pitched black besides what comes from the hall. Shades are drawn and no lamps or phone’s flashlight are on. When she reaches her girlfriend, Glimmer finally looks up. The hunter has seen better nights. Shoulders are slouched, eyes are dark both inside and under. No twinkles are in her irises. Adora wonders how much effort it would take the hunter to smile.

“What are you doing?” Adora asks.

“Prepping for tomorrow,” Glimmer mumbles. "Or later today? Whatever it is."

Adora looks at the mess laid out in front of her. The contents of Glimmer’s bag are spilled all over. Bottles of wolfsbane (one of which is open), her new taser, noise emitters, some flares, and a number of arrows to name a few are laid haphazardly on the ground. As she takes a closer look, she notices Glimmer scratching one hand with the other. Both are a bright red.

“Woah! What happened to you?” Adora quickly kneels in front of her. She takes her hands in her own. Skin is hot and angry. Adora feels her own skin becoming aggravated.

Glimmer sighs. “Bad reaction to that new wolfsbane we got. Perfuma tried to warn me. I put it in my taser so…ya know. Both a shock and a bit of stuff to help knock someone out. Double whammy.”

“I thought you'd just have a bad sneezing fit!”

“Guess this one didn’t agree with me touching it. Don’t worry, it’s not that bad.”

“You already have broken some of the skin. Stay here.”

Adora darts out of the room and quickly enters the bathroom. She searches for anything of use. There is an anti-itch cream, some antibiotics, and bandages to wrap around Glimmer's hands.

Hopefully this'll do the job.

Without missing another beat, Adora heads back into Angella's room. Glimmer has not budged an inch. When the blonde kneels on the ground, her girlfriend sticks out her hands, showing no resistance. Adora gets to work. Rubbing the cream in helps her own itchy hands. She is careful not to put the bandages on too tight.

“There.” For good measure, Adora places a kiss on both her hands. “Hopefully that will go away tomorrow.”

“Yeah…” Glimmer’s eyes remain on the ground, staring at all the equipment on the ground. “I’m sorry…”

“For what?”

“I…” She fails to finish, letting herself trail off.

Adora wraps her arms around Glimmer, pulling her close to her body. “I’m nervous too, hon. If you can't tell, I couldn't sleep tonight! Dunno if I will be able to. But I don't like seeing you hurt yourself. Why don't you stop and come back to bed with me?"

“When did you become less of a nervous wreck?” Glimmer snorts.

Adora chuckles. "I did just have a talk with Adam about stuff but I'm sure once I lie back down, everything will crash down on me."

Glimmer’s own arms snake around Adora’s body, fingers digging into her shirt. The hunter buries her face into Adora's chest,

taking a deep inhale. “I’m sorry, Adora. I love you.”

Adora raises an eyebrow at the first statement however, she ignores it in favor of saying, “I love you too.”

Adora sighs in relief at the sight of her girlfriend’s hands. They are no longer raw and have returned to their normal state. Even the small cuts look far better. However, just in case, she puts on another layer of lotion. Glimmer doesn’t protest and even mutters a ‘thank you’ in her half asleep state. Adora has no idea if her girlfriend had any sort of sleep but she looks slightly better. There are hints of lights in her lilac eyes.

“Are you hungry?” Adora asks as she puts everything away.

“Are you?” Glimmer quips. There is a small smile on her face.

Adora rolls her eyes. “I think you know the answer to that question.” She takes a moment to sniff the air. Sausage frying in the pan and toast fills her nose. “But I think Adam already has decided for us. Come on.”

Adora leads Glimmer down the hall and stairs. She has to slow her steps to allow Glimmer to keep pace. The hunter rubs her eyes, struggling to rid the sleep from them. By the time they reach downstairs, Glimmer looks ready to curl back up in bed.

Adam places plates of food down on the table. “Should I even say ‘good morning’?” he asks.

“I’m not stopping you. The food looks good,” Adora says. “What time are you and Bow getting Catra?”

“I’m going to meet up with Bow in the afternoon. He was going to text me when he was ready. We were going to get Catra right after. We should make it back before the full moon.”

“Just tell us when you are on the way back,” Glimmer states. She uses her fork to cut the sausages into tiny pieces.

“Will do.”

Adam sits down at the table, slowly eating his own breakfast. Any chatter there usually is during breakfast has become non-existent. The only noises are the sounds of chewing or metal scraping against the plates. Adora finishes her breakfast first and takes a moment to look at the outside world.

The clouds are slowly dissipating, letting the soft blue sky return. By tonight, there will be nothing to block out the moon or the stars. Looking outside right now, the world looks beautiful. Flowers continue to bloom and trees have gotten their lush green leaves once again.

In a matter of hours, in those exact woods, she will come face to face with her adoptive mother after many years. Maybe Shadow Weaver is already waiting for everyone to arrive. Why wouldn’t she already be doing everything in her power to get the upper hand.

Adora shakes her head, trying not to think of that thought. However, it’s not that easy. To distract her, she stands up and heads to the skin to wash off her plate. When the others finish, the blonde takes it upon herself to wash them as well. Anything to keep the thoughts away. Eventually, there is nothing left to clean.

Time moves at a snail’s pace. The trio try to find things to pass the time, anything at all. Watching TV, more prepping (which Adora makes sure Glimmer doesn’t get another reaction), or mindlessly scrolling on the internet. All of them combined barely do anything.

Adora can smell all the anxiety in the air. It’s damn near suffocating. Her own heart races in her chest. Scrolling becomes a chore as her palms become sweaty. After a while, she decides to check up on Glimmer and see how the prepping is going. When she gets close to her girlfriend, she notices she is once more working on the taser.

“You really invested in that, aren’t you?” Adora says, looking over her shoulder.

Glimmer damn nears jump out of her skin. She grabs the taser, bringing it close to her body. “God, you gave me a heart attack.”

“Sorry! I didn’t mean to scare you!”

“It’s fine,” Glimmer sighs.

“Have you had enough of working on that?”

Glimmer doesn’t answer right away. “I’m just triple checking.”

“Fair enough. You want me to help you with anything? I really need a distraction.”

“Hm…check over the arrows. Counting can be a good distraction, right?”

Adora agrees.

More time passes, still at the same rate. Adam eventually leaves, promising once more to let his sister and Glimmer know when he will be on the way back. Left alone, Adora watches the sun slowly dip behind the horizon. The wolf inside of her begins to become agitated once again.

Glimmer keeps herself busy with her taser and wolfsbane. Adora leaves her be. Counting has become a bore and she ends up simply pacing around to burn off all the excess energy bubbling off of him. Afternoon turns into evening with no signs of Adam, Bow, or Catra. After a quick text she gets an answer.

Adam: *Sorry. Construction. We will be there soon, I promise.*

Adora shoves her phone back in her pocket. Her nerves continue to go off like the last hoorah of a firework show. Loud and annoying. She takes a deep breath in a vain attempt to calm herself. Behind her, she hears Glimmer pushing back against the

chair and standing up. Even unable to see her girlfriend, she continues to smell the nervousness seeping off of her. Along with something else she cannot put a name to.

"The others will be here soon. Construction threw them for a loop." Adora chews on her thumb. "I really hope we can do this. We only get one shot."

"Yeah," Glimmer replies, her voice low. Adora hears the creaking of the boards as the hunter draws close. "One shot…"

Adora starts to ramble as she paces. "I want to hope we can do this. I know everyone is saying that probably because they don't want to think of the worst. I want to believe it too but I don't really know. I *think* we can do it. We out number her and with what your mom left behind, we could have the upper hand! But it's Shadow Weaver. So many things can go wrong…"

"And that's why I am sorry for this."

Adora begins to turn, mouth open to ask what she means. The words never get a chance to leave her lips. The next thing she knows, something sharp digs into the smalls of her back. Not even a *split* second later, hundreds of volts of electricity are sent through her. Adora only is able to gasp as her body tenses up, bracing itself against the sudden onslaught. Her jaw clamps shut and she can feel the volts coursing through her muscles.

Then, as quickly as it began, it ends.

Legs give out and she crumples to the ground. Her limbs twitch, continuing to feel the effects of the electricity. She gasps for air and feels pain radiating from the back of her head from where it connected with the floor. Black specks dance around in her vision as shapes begin to lose all meaning. Colors become dull. Adora knows this is not *just* a simple electrocution.

What just happened?

Fear sets in.

“I’m sorry,” Glimmer croaks, voice shattered.

What?

Adora manages to turn her head, eyes looking up at the hunter. Glimmer’s violet eyes swim under a lake. Tears stain her cheek and drip from her chin. They land on Adora’s own cheeks. In her hands, knuckles a bright white white, is the taser she bought previously. Adora attempts to speak and ask her girlfriend what is going on. Ask her if she is *okay!* But her throat and tongue refuse to work. Numbness is spreading all throughout her body.

“I’m sorry.” Glimmer repeats.Her body shakes as she hides her face. Her voice remains broken. “I *can’t* lose anyone else! I can’t let Shadow Weaver kill and take away anyone else I care about! I *can’t* afford to lose *you!* I’m sorry. Please… *Please forgive* me.”

“G-Glim!” Adora somehow squeaks out. All her strength is poured into flipping onto her stomach and reaching an arm out. Fingers brush the cuff of Glimmer’s jeans. The hunter quickly backs away. She spins on her heels and begins to make an exit for the back door. Right into the woods where the most dangerous creature lies in wait.

“I’m *so* sorry.” Glimmer repeats, barely loud enough for Adora to even hear.

Glimmer! Don’t! Please! Adora cries in her head. She feels her own tears dripping down her face, mixing with the ones fallen from Glimmer. There is nothing she can do as her body goes limp and darkness overtakes her. The last thing she sees before losing sense of reality is the back of her girlfriend disappearing.

Chapter End Notes

comments and kudos appreciated

Papermoon

Chapter Notes

> And the chapter everyone has been waiting for lmao. Still not great at fight scenes so hopefully its all good! Anyway I had my friend Atheos help proof this

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It's too late to turn back.

Glimmer's hands shake with the realization of what they did. Her grip on the taser has become unstable as the trembling spreads throughout her body. She has *electrocuted* her own girlfriend. She has *left* her unconscious body on the floor. Her brain berates her actions, wanting to know why and how she could do that to Adora.

Pull yourself together! Glimmer screams at herself. *It was the only thing you could come up with to protect her!*

She reminds herself Adam, Bow, and Catra will be back soon. Thank god for that detour. They will tend to Adora before coming out searching for her. The hunter isn't stupid. She *knows* the four of them will chase after her and join the fight with Shadow Weaver. But this way, she'll have a head start. Glimmer attempts to stop the thoughts of regret and guilt by reminding herself *why* she did that.

The hunter takes a moment to let herself crumble. She chokes on her tears and needs the frame of the back door to support her weakened legs. A hand slaps against her mouth, stifling her noises. Glimmer repeats over and over in her head an apology towards Adora. She even gives ones to the others.

Glimmer slowly takes deep breaths, allowing herself to regain control of her body. She begins walking forward, forcing her

shaking legs to work. She wipes tears from her face and adjusts her bag strap resting against her chest. It's now or never.

The moon shines brighter than ever before, even as it remains low in the horizon. Pale white light pushes out the surrounding stars, preventing any other celestial being from taking center stage. Even the setting sun seems in awe of it. The Whispering Woods remain dark, however, hiding the danger that lurks inside. It waits for her to enter. Waits for her to come face to face with the monster that has caused so much suffering and strife. Waits for her to confront the woman who not only stole Adora and her childhood, but who took away *Angella.*

Glimmer stops at the threshold between her backyard and the forest. The Whispering Woods beckons her in.

This is it.

Adora lies unconscious in their home and will be for an unknown amount of time. For all she knows, her girlfriend will remain out cold even after she shifts. But she is *safe.* No harm will come to her as long as Glimmer gets to Shadow Weaver first. The others will be here soon enough and will take care of Adora and any possible injuries she has sustained from her electrocution.

She takes another deep breath. Her heart slowly picks up its pace inside of her chest while her blood begins to boil. Hands grip her crossbow so tightly, the wooden frame threatens to splitter under her fingers. The way Glimmer grits her teeth, they could shatter. Through the leafy branches, she glowers at the rising moon.

Had she been bitten and not nearly gutted, she would have shifted long ago. Most likely, into a werepanther or some sort of feline. Glimmer wonders what she would look like. Her fur would be as black as the night. In only a short amount of time, she would begin to feel her teeth sharpen and become able to pierce almost anything. Her hands would begin to turn twists into claws capable of turning living things into ribbons. She could easily sprint through the woods and towards her destination in the blink

of an eye. It would be *painful,* the shift. Feeling her body tear itself apart only to stitch it back up just as quick.

Yet that pain surely is *nothing* compared to what she has been through since her mother's death.

Part of her wishes that she had that power. The power of a creature of the night. Yet, she is only a human. Weak and powerless to stop any of the horrors that have played out the past year and beyond. However, there is something she can tap into. Something that takes over werecreatures with no control, and those that are not careful.

Her blood burns inside her veins. Her heart races uncontrollably in her chest as her sights narrow and glow red. Her brain imagines what the last moments of her mother's life were like. She can see Angella's broken and bloody body as Shadow Weaver stands over it, eyes glowing a toxic green. She can hear Shadow Weaver *laughing* at the death of the hunter.

Her body tightens so much, a simple breeze could shatter her.

Glimmer allows for that to happen. The bottle inside of her, everything she shoved down for so long, explodes. The invisible shards of glass slice through her, allowing the searing rage to flood into every ounce of her body.

As she steps through the threshold and into the darkness, tears streaming down her cheeks, she shouts. Glimmer doesn't care that her presence will be known. She wants every goddamn living creature, friend or foe, to know *exactly* how she feels. She wants to see Shadow Weaver face-to-face and permanently remove any smirk the werewolf might have on her face. She wants her to know the same terror Angella might have felt when she knew the battle was lost.

She reaches down and uncaps a flare, making her presence even clearer. Sparks fly out of her hand in a stream, almost listening to her command. Heat licks against her cheeks and illuminates her in

a harsh, red glow. The fire that burns out of the tube is cooler than the one that eats away at her insides.

" *I'M COMING FOR YOU, YOU BITCH!"* Glimmer seethes. " *I'M GOING TO MAKE YOU REGRET* ***EVERYTHING!"***

The darkness spreads all around her. Adora cannot tell if she is falling down to the ground or floating upwards into the starless sky. She sticks out her hand, seeing her long, dull, human fingers. Her body is the only thing she can see. Everywhere the blonde looks, there is nothing but endless darkness. *Familiar* endless darkness. Why is she the only one here?

Adora twists and turns until she ends up straightening her body out. Her feet finally brush against an invisible flooring. The moment her soles meet the ground, gravity returns. She takes a moment to look around. Adora remains the only presence in the strange world. She grumbles and rubs her head. For some reason, it throbs.

She begins walking, her footsteps echoing through the void. Adora has no idea if she is making any progress or if she is on a treadmill. Picking up the pace does nothing, only making her frustrated. After who knows how long, she kicks at nothing. What the hell is she doing here? Why *now?*

Adora shuts her eyes, trying to recall what on earth is going on. Her hand brushes against the bump on her head. Slowly, things begin to trickle back into her mind. She recalls the anxiety of the full moon. The dread of waiting to face Shadow Weaver. Her brother, sister, and Bow running late. And then, the shock of not only the taser but Glimmer's sudden action.

The last image her mind conjures up is of the hunter, face stained in tears, disappearing out the back door.

"Shit! Glimmer!" Adora shouts. "I gotta do something! I gotta stop her! I gotta-"

"You must stop fighting…"

There is a sudden, sharp pain that stabs her in the chest. Adora gasps, clutching her center. Her legs cave, refusing to hold any sort of weight. She barely has enough time to break her fall with her free hand. The blonde wheezes for air and her vision blurs for several moments. She comes close to dry heaving before the pain finally subsides.

The sound of footsteps draws her attention upward. She sees the same canine she has seen time after time. They lower their head, blue eyes watching Adora intensely.

"What do you want?" Adora asks, annoyed. "I have more important things to deal with right now than figuring out who you are."

" *I only want to help. I mustn't fight or you will lose. You will lose her."*

Adora stands to her feet. "What the hell are you talking about? You still can't give me a straight answer? How can you help me?"

" *You answered that question already. The past cannot be changed but the future can. Neither of us know a life without the other. Neither of us asked to be here, but it brought us to where we need to be, hasn't it?"*

"What?" Adora narrows her eyes, trying to understand what the canine is saying. Something begins scratching at the back of her head. Tilting her head, she finally realizes what canine stares at her. Neither dog nor fox nor coyote stare at her. Rather, a wolf does.

Adora clutches her chest once more, recalling the night before. She felt them inside of her, only to be calmed after she answered Adam's question.

"You want to help?" Adora asks. She kneels down, allowing the wolf to come closer.

" *It’s all I ever wanted to do. Help and protect.”*

Adora hesitantly reaches out. When her fingers brush against their cheek, the wolf flinches. They back up, ears flat against their head. A soft whine escapes through their nose. It's then and there she puts the pieces together.

"You don't like your face being touched either, huh?" Adora softly sighs.

The wolf nods, letting her ears perk up slightly. " *We are one and the same* ."

"I should have figured that out before…You are a part of me, for better or for worse."

" *Do you still hate me?"*

Adora takes a moment to answer, gathering her thoughts. "I don't think so, now that I know who you are. I shouldn’t hate myself."

" *Even though I will always cause you pain. Even though some days I might make you lose control in my attempt to help?"*

"Even the best of us have bad days. We can't always walk in a straight line. As for the pain…I don't like it, I will admit it, but I'm used to it. And I have others who can help lessen it."

The wolf steps closer, looking up with the haze of blue. " *I'll ask again what I asked months ago. What do you want, Adora?"*

Adora stands to her feet. In the darkness she begins hearing her brother, sister, and Bow. All shout, *plead,* for her to wake. She can hear Catra cursing and asking where Glimmer is. The face of her girlfriend made before running off remains burned in her brain. The regret and apology.

Adora shuts her eyes. Only a year ago, she was still by herself, just trying to get by. One by one, the memories of the past almost twelve months flood her mind. Bow’s kindness when she first

woke. Glimmer bringing her to Perfuma’s store to get new belongings. The warmth she felt meeting Perfuma, Scorpia, Mermista, and Sea Hawk. Seeing the fireworks, getting potions to aid her shifts.

The birthday parties and holidays, falling head over heels for Glimmer, Scorpia helping her through her fight with Glimmer, the day out with Mermista as Adam came back into her life. Catra’s apology and defending her from Shadow Weaver, risking her life in the process.

So much floods her brain, she can go on forever. Huntara, Petra and her siblings, and even Ed and Al. If she told herself a year ago about all of these things, her past self would not believe in her.

Adora knows the answer.

"I want to protect my friends and family.” she opens her eyes, staring right at the wolf. “They helped and I want to help them! I longed to know who my family was and not only do I know who they are, but I have made my own.

"I want them! I want to be with them and I want to stop Shadow Weaver so she can never hurt anyone ever again. And…"

Adora reaches down and places a hand on the wolf's head. The moment she does, fur erupts from the misty form. It’s as bright as the golden sunrise. The wolf before her is long-legged, lean, maybe twice the size of a normal grey wolf, and covered in soft fur. On her chin and back, there are rough patches and hints of scarring. Her eyes are as soft and blue as the spring sky. They are the same one’s Adora sees every day in the mirror.

Adora smiles softly. "I want you."

" *Even knowing everything I stated before. It's going to hurt* ."

"Life hurts. No one gets away without suffering, unfortunately. But, the love from others, from yourself, and even the world

makes it worth it. I know who I was without them, alone, thinking I was nothing more than a *monster.* But with them, I know who I am. I know I am loved.

"And…for Glimmer, I'll go through the depths of hell and back a hundred times over to see her smiling in the end."

The wolf smiles. Adora kneels to the ground again, becoming eye level.

"You are a part of me. I don't know life without you. It's going to hurt. There will be days I will wish again not to be you but…at the end you are me and I am you. Like you said, we are one and the same. So, let me ask you a question. Are you ready to save Glimmer and kick Shadow Weaver's ass?"

The wolf nods. " *I am here to help, I always have. Even if I did it wrong many times."*

"We learn together." Adora reaches over and hugs the wolf tight. The smell of sandalwood fills her nose and the soft fur tickles her nose. Though, she can feel the pain of the shift beginning to spread across her body.

" *This will hurt. But it will be worth it in the end, I promise."*

"I'm ready."

The pain reaches every part of her as the darkness encases everything. Adora feels herself become detached from a limp body. Besides the pain and waves of nausea hitting her, someone is shaking her. She can only see black and hears anxious mumbles. Slowly, they become discernible, even if far away.

“Adora! Wake! Up!” one says in a panic.

“Adam! Stop shaking her!” another scolds. Though, they sound equally as worried.

“What else am I supposed to do, Bow?!? She hasn’t budged since we found her! Can you still not get in contact with Glimmer?”

“No, I haven’t. It keeps going to voicemail.”

“Both of you shut the hell up!” a new voice says. They sound uncomfortable. “If the shift doesn’t wake her *then* worry. We got other problems!”

Glimmer… Adora thinks. She has to find a way to get to her. If only her body wasn’t totally out of whack. The pain is almost unbearable. She grits her teeth tight. They, too, feel weird.

“Adora?” Adam asks. “Can you hear me?”

Adora tries to answer her brother. Her mouth is dry and her throat doesn’t want to listen to her commands. A shiver runs down her spine. Some invisible force punches her in the gut, causing her to gasp. Her body feels like it is on fire.

There is a *groan* in the distance. She hears Bow asking Catra if she is okay. Whatever her sister says, Adora cannot hear. All of her thoughts are on Glimmer. It’s the only thing that drowns out the pain. She *has* to wake up, *move,* and save her girlfriend.

“ *ADAM!”* Bow shouts.

Adam lets go just in time for the pain to become unbearable. Adora snaps awake as her body twists and turns into a new shape. She doesn’t resist it, however, she lets the pain roll over her. It hurts a lot, but slowly, it begins to subside. She gasps as the last parts of her body twitch.

Adora groans. Blinking, the world comes into focus. Granted, there still is a spin but with a shake of her head, everything steadies out. The first thing she focuses on are on the legs off a nearby chair. The next of Bow and Adam. Her friend stands a couple feet away, eyes wide. Adam is closer, sitting on the ground. He tries to say something but all that comes out are stutters.

“Adam?” Adora asks. Her head throbs. She reaches to ease the pain, yet something feels off. Her hand doesn’t feel right. Pulling into her sights, she gets the surprise of her life. Instead of her hand, a large paw stares back at her. Nails are dark and sharp and a thick, golden fur covers them. For all intent and purposes, it looks like a normal wolf’s paw. However, besides the sheer size, her thumb/dew claw looks like it could semi-work.

“Damn. Ya finally figured out how to get control,” Catra says.

Adora snaps her head around towards her sister. Her panther form is large and sleek. Rising to her feet, the blonde can tell she is taller and heavier than her sister. Though, Catra definitely has balance on her side.

Legs shake as she takes a step forward. Consciously walking on four legs is harder than it looks. *You better be a fast learner, Adora.*

“I can’t believe it either,” she says before tripping. Adora curses as she returns to her feet. “But we can’t worry about that. I saw Glimmer leave!”

“You did?!?” Bow and Adam say in unison.

“She shocked me and ran off. It seemed she wanted to stop Shadow Weaver alone. We have to stop her.”

More steps forward, more tripping. Each time, though, she gets a little further before eating shit.

“Wait, Adora!” Bow runs over towards her. “You can’t go out like that!”

“There is no time!” Adora snaps back. Her heart races in her chest as a million images of Glimmer being seriously injured or dead flood her mind. “You and Bow get ready. Catra! Can you guide them when they are done and protect them?”

“Go save your idiot girlfriend,” is all her sister says.

Adora bolts out of the house. She stumbles at the change of texture under her feet and nearly eats shit when jumping off the deck. The uneven ground doesn't deter her from her goal. In only a few strides, Adora reaches the mouth of the Whispering Woods. She makes in several more feet before skidding to a halt. A sneezing fit breaks out and she paws at her newly formed muzzle.

Her eyes water, almost *burn,* and every part of her body itches. She blinks back the tears and resists the urge to roll around and scratch her irritated skin. *Gotta get to Glim!*

Adora staggers forward. With her nose to the ground, she searches for any signs of her girlfriend. More sneezes, more stinging of her eyes. Her nostrils feel on fire and she begins to wonder if she'll be able to smell after this. Slowly, new scents trickle their way in. Nothing she wants, however…

The damp dirt, a deer with newborn fawns, and a kill from a coyote hours old. Adora growls under her breath. She presses her nose hard into the ground, attempting to pick anything else up. Her mind races with thoughts upon thoughts of what could happen to her girlfriend. She doesn't want to think of finding her dead. She doesn't want to think about finding her injured. She doesn't want to think about Shadow Weaver using Glimmer against her.

New tears begin to prick at her eyes.

Another long minute passes before a new smell fills her nose. The floral scent of a field of lilacs. Adora inhales deeply, taking it all in. She is taken aback by the hot anger that is attached to her girlfriend's shampoo. If she didn't know Glimmer so well, it would be the only thing to follow.

Glimmer…Hold on. I'm coming for you.

She bolts ahead. Slowly, Adora adjusts to her new feet. It's as if she has been doing this her whole life. If shit wasn't hitting the

fan right about now, she would be enjoying the hell out of this. The feeling of the wind on her face, the speeds she can reach, and everything she can see in crystal clarity.

Adora continues to follow the scent of her girlfriend. It grows stronger and stronger. She can *see* the vibrant lilac flowers in her mind. Adora runs as fast as she can, straining the muscles in her body. Her breath begs for oxygen. She ignores everything.

There is a small brook she darts through. Nearing the edge, Adora is forced to stop short. Her sneezes return. Her eyes become puffy and her nose runs. She staggers out of the water, trying to regain her bearings. After several steps, she places her nose back on the ground. However, she can no longer locate Glimmer's scent.

Shit!

Adora searches everywhere to pick up the scent again. Nothing. She can't even locate any deer that might have wandered on by. A growl tickles at the back of her throat. Any time waste will not be in her favor. Her frustration grows, blinding her senses more. Adora snaps her head around in all directions. Still *nothing!*

"Fuck, where are you, Glimmer?" Adora asks herself. The tears in her eyes this time come from her heart. "I have to find you…"

Don't give up. Go left…Save her…

Adora snaps her head up, ears at attention. She looks around, wondering where that voice came from. It's soft, warm, and familiar. Not only that, there is a tinge of concern. Maybe she is hearing things…Whatever the case, the blonde listens to her gut, which tells her to head left.

Her ears ring, drowning out the drum of her heart. Sights are narrowed onto the invisible path ahead. Glimmer clutches her crossbow tight, both from her boiling blood and the sweat that

has accumulated on her palms. Breath comes out harsh and uneven. Each of her steps threaten to break the earth.

There is only one thing on her mind.

Glimmer tightens the string of her crossbow. Her arrow is eager to be set free. It must wait. Her target mustn't be missed. The rest of her gear sits in her bag, ready to be pulled out at a moment's notice. Above her, the moon watches. The light shines through the canopy, revealing a soft fog that begins to form. Everything around her is still.

She continues her trek, stopping for nothing. Glimmer must be deep into the woods by now. If the others have begun their chase, it'll take time for them to catch up. There'll be plenty of time to complete her own plan of attack. If only she can find her damn target!

The hunter pauses in the middle of a clearing. Glimmer searches high and low for Shadow Weaver. She focuses all of her attention on her hearing. Wind barely moves. There is the rustling of deer mice. Glimmer even picks up the faint and distant call of a great horned owl.

…

Snap!

Glimmer spins on her heels. In the darkness and fog is a shadowy figure. The only color in the black is a glowing, bright green. The hunter does not waste even a split second in firing her crossbow. It hits a tree based on the *thunk.*

"Not the shot your mother was, are you?" a sinister voice says. "Barely even felt the wind on that."

"At least I am not a fuckin' coward!" Glimmer hisses. "You're the one hiding! Are you going to show your face or what?"

A laugh fills the air. It’s cold and wicked, sending a shiver down Glimmer’s spine. She digs her heels into the ground, refusing to yield. With her crossbow pointed at the shadows, finger on the trigger, the hunter watches her foe step out into the moonlight. Glimmer’s breath gets caught in her throat.

Shadow Weaver is large. Only slightly smaller than Adora the first night Glimmer saw her wolf form. Despite that, her form is much more menacing. Teeth are sharper, peeking out of her lips. The muscles look like they can easily snap an oak tree as if it was a twig. Shadow Weaver’s claws could through metal. Instead of an ugly shade of yellow like Adora’s first form, Shadow Weaver’s fur is as black as the void.

Glimmer grits her teeth, and grips her nails deep into the wooden frame of her weapon. Her free hand reaches for a fresh arrow. All the while, her eyes remain on her target. Shadow Weaver remains still, waiting and watching.

“Do you think you can stand up against me?” Shadow Weaver smirks. “You are so much like your mother. I wonder if I’ll be able to send another Mizari to their grave. I’m sure your mother is awfully lonely without her precious daughter.”

"Don’t you DARE talk about my mother!”

Glimmer fires her arrow. Shadow Weaver only tilts her head to the side. Only the wind touches her. The wolf smirks from ear to ear.

"And here I thought you'd be harder to defeat than your mother. Such a shame…”

Glimmer growls. She places her crossbow at her side before pulling out her silver knife. She prepares herself for her next attack. Shadow Weaver raises an eyebrow, taken aback. Yet the smile does not fade from her face. Without wasting another beat, Shadow Weaver propels herself forward.

The hunter rolls out of the way from the oncoming attack. She keeps her knife out, hoping to land a hit. Her knife’s tip slashes

something. Glimmer comes to a stop and rises to her feet. The tip of her knife has a spot of red with a couple strands of hair. Shadow Weaver looks at her shoulder where a faint cut resides.

“So you *do* have some spunk. Though,” Shadow Weaver clicks her tongue, “will it be enough to protect my *daughter?* ”

Glimmer sees red. The hairs on the back of her neck stand at attention. No words come out of her mouth. Only something between a scream and a growl escapes. Her sights have become so narrowed the only thing she can see is Shadow Weaver, No trees, no moon, no ground. Just, Shadow Weaver.

She reaches down into her bag and pulls out a new arrow. Like before, she fires at Shadow Weaver with no second thought and just like before, Shadow Weaver only moves her head out of the way. This time, however, a blinding light encases the area. Glimmer has enough sense to shut her eyes before the lights can stun her. When the heat dies down, she quickly reaches for another arrow. This time, the arrow plants itself into Shadow Weaver’s shoulder.

Shadow Weaver half growls, half shouts. She reaches her hand upward, ripping the arrow out. Blood flows from the wound, coating the black fur. Shadow Weaver snaps the wood with ease. Hackles raise and her lips are piled all the way back.

"You are getting annoying,” Shadow Weaver growls. “Time to end this.”

Glimmer jumps out of the way once more as her foe charges at her. Shadow Weaver quickly turns on her heels, barely giving the hunter time to react. She staggers to return to her feet. There is no way she can keep this up and must end this sooner rather than later. With so little silverlace, she cannot risk anything.

In the brief moment she has between attacks, the hunter grabs her taser. This time, Glimmer decides to charge first. Shadow Weaver is caught off guard and is nearly electrocuted. However,

she jumps out of the way before Glimmer can press her prongs against her body.

Glimmer stops just before a sudden dip in the forest. She spins around, ready to try again. Shadow Weaver is quicker this time around. The taser is slapped out of her hand, disappearing into the dark and fog. Glimmer hisses as her hand throbs. She stares down Shadow Weaver, feeling her whole body dense with anger.

"I'll enjoy telling Adora how weak you were," Shadow Weaver mocks.

Time comes to a crawl. Glimmer watches as Shadow Weaver's claw rises into the air. At the same time, the hunter reaches for her knife. It'll be a matter of *seconds* to who will win. Glimmer feels her fingers brushing against the handle as the shadow of the claw reaches the corner of her eye.

However, something hard slams into her side. Glimmer gasps as her feet are lifted from the ground. Her body tumbles down the hill. Sticks and rocks hit against her skin and dirt enters her mouth. She tastes copper as she bites her tongue. By the time she reaches the end, her body aches and feels like a truck has run her over. Glimmer quickly scrambles to her feet, gearing to climb back up the steep hill. Shadow Weaver has disappeared. Having the high ground, she could be anywhere. Her fingers dig into the dirt.

Something grabs her by the hem of her shirt. Claw marks are dug into the ground as she is dragged down. Glimmer realizes that what holds onto her are a set of teeth. A shiver runs down her spine. She quickly spins around, the fabric of her shirt tears. Her knife slashes air. Whoever has her has loosened their grip. Glimmer expects red or even green to stare at her.

Instead, it's blue.

Adora keeps her body standing over Glimmer. If she escapes, the blonde knows for a fact that her girlfriend will bolt back towards Shadow Weaver. Her ears flick around, picking up at the sounds of her mother stalking above, waiting for the right moment to strike. Adora bites her lip, knowing she is at a disadvantage.

But there is a second reason. Looking down at Glimmer, Adora's heart sinks. Her girlfriend's face is *dark.* Glimmer's eyes are full of a rage and flame that she has never seen before. Adora can still feel the wind created by the knife against her chin. If she was only a second later, Glimmer might have had her throat slit. Adora's heart races with that thought.

She wishes she knew sooner…

"Glimmer!" Adora says, almost pleading. "Glim! Calm down!"

"Let. Me. Go!" Glimmer hisses. She struggles under Adora.

"No! If I do, you're just going to get yourself killed!"

"I'm going to kill *her.* For *everything* she has done! You can't stop me!"

"I can and I will!" Adora's voice begins to raise. Hot tears prick at the edge of her eyes. "I want to stop her too! But I won't let you kill yourself! That will help *no one!"*

"I can't let her kill anyone else!" Tears stain Glimmer's own face. " *I can't lose anyone else! I can't afford to lose* ***you!*** "

" *I can't lose you, Glim!"*

Adora's and Glimmer's faces nearly touch. The blonde feels her hackles raise and her body holds tight. The two stare town at each other for several long seconds before Adora relaxes.

"I can't afford to lose you either," Adora now whispers. She rests her forehead against her girlfriend's. She inhales the lilac scent of

Glimmer. “I don’t know what I’d do without you. *Please* calm down. I love you. You don’t have to do this alone.

“You saved my life a year ago, and now I’m saving yours. Had you not come into my life, I still would be turning into a bloodthirsty beast every month, scared of hurting others. Let me return the favor. Don’t do this out of hatred. Let me help you, Glitter-bug.”

Glimmer lets out one last frustrated growl, stabbing the ground with her knife. Her breath slowly becomes stable and the dark flame in her eyes becomes duller. “I wanted to protect you. I wanted to protect everyone. I didn’t want to hurt you. How are you not mad?”

“I know you would never hurt me intentionally. I came after you because I love you and because I can’t let you have all the fun kicking Shadow Weaver’s ass.”

This gets the smallest of chuckles out of Glimmer. She sniffs before wrapping her arms around Adora’s neck, burying her face into her thick fur.

“I’m so sorry, Starlight.”

Adora sighs in relief. She rests her head on Glimmer’s shoulder. Her heart begins to settle in her chest. One thing done…

“Wait a minute…” Glimmer jerks back. Her eyes are wide. A hand rubs against her muzzle, tickling her. Adora resists the urge to sneeze. “Adora! Are…Are you in control?!? How?!?”

“Let’s just say, Petra was right. I had to want it. Anyway,” she finally steps off of her girlfriend and turns her sights towards the top of the hill. “We need to deal with Shaowder Weaver.”

“Where are the others?”

“They should be here soon. I ran ahead of them. I hope they don’t get lost. Any ideas on how not to die?”

“You’re really asking me that after all this?” Glimmer runs a head through her hair. Her tongue clicks against her teeth in thought. She turns her attention to her bag, digging through it until she pulls out an arrow Adora has never seen before.

It looks ordinary at first but upon closer inspection, there is a small, metal bump near the base of the arrow. Adora tilts her head, blinking at Glimmer. The hunter gestures for her to come closer. When Adora leans, her girlfriend whispers into her ear.

“This is one of my sound arrows. Bow made it for me. Once it hits its target, a loud sound will emit from it. We can use that to hide our steps. What do you think?”

“I honestly have nothing else. Let’s do it!”

Adora follows closely behind Glimmer. Both are careful where they place their feet, watching for any twigs or leaves. The adrenaline from before has worn off slightly, making the blonde realize the tumble down the hill will hurt in the morning. That is at the very bottom of her list of things to worry about. She flicks her ears around, listening for anything out of the ordinary.

When they reach closer to the top to see the barks of the trees, they stop. Glimmer slowly puts the arrow on her crossbow and takes a deep breath before firing. Adora prepares herself for the noise. A second later, the air is filled with a high-pitched noise. It sounds like nails on a chalkboard.

“Let's go!” Glimmer says.

Adora pushes through the pain and races up the rest of the hill. The sound continues to reverberate when they reach the top of the hill. There is no Shadow Weaver in sight. Adora turns her nose to the air, hoping to pick up on something. As she begins to inhale, the sound from the arrow dies off, leaving everything in an eerie silence.

Adora’s nose is filled with the wetness of the ground, the sharpness of anxiety from herself, the heat from the lingering

anger from Glimmer, and…the bitterness of hate. Adora snaps her head towards that direction, quickly spotting the glow of green staring back at her.

For a moment, her whole body freezes. Adora becomes like a statue. Even her eyes are unable to move, remaining fixated on the bright green within the shadows of the trees. The same ones she saw day in and day out for most of her life. The ones that were supposed to protect and care for her but only wanted a puppet to control. All those memories of moving, of being forbidden to be a child, of thinking that she herself was a monster, come rushing back to her.

Adora swallows a hard, dry lump. Her mouth has gone drier than the desert. Can she do this?

There is a nudge at her shoulder. Adora finally snaps her eyes away from Shadow Weaver and looks up. Glimmer has her own sights ahead of her and her crossbow raised. The hunter's face is hardened with determination. She shifts her foot so the sole of her boot rests on Adora's paw.

No…She *can* do this. With Glimmer by her side, there isn't anything she can't do.

"My, my, my," Shadow Weaver hums. She steps out into the moonlight. There is a smirk on her face. "My little girl has finally returned to me. How many years has it been since you left me?"

"Screw you," Adora snaps. "You don't scare me."

Shadow Weaver scoffs. "I don't believe that. You can't mask the smells coming off of you. Why must you hurt me like this?"

"Oh, shut up and stop playing victim!" Glimmer growls. "I'm going to wipe that stupid ass smirk off your face. You're gonna pay for everything. This ends here."

Shadow Weaver laughs. "You're cute. But I doubt you can win. You can't stop me."

“We’ll see about that.” Glimmer releases an arrow. Shadow Weaver jumps out of the way. Both the hunter and the blonde jump in two different directions. Adora notices that her mother has her sights on Glimmer. Without second thought, she spins on her heels and bolts forward.

Adora headbutts Shadow Weaver on the side, using all of her weight. Both werewolves tumble onto the ground. Adora barely is able to scramble to her feet ahead of Shadow Weaver. She bolts away, reuniting with Glimmer. In the next moment, an arrow flies into the air, slicing through the shoulder of the werewolf.

Shadow Weaver growls before charging. Adora and Glimmer move out of the way once more, both starting to feel the tiredness in their body. Both duck behind a tall, thick tree, hoping for a moment’s break.

“When are you going to use the silverlace?” Adora asks.

“I don’t want to miss. We need to slow her down,” Glimmer replies.

“We gotta hold out until the others come. Think we can do that?” Adora puts on a half hearted smile.

Glimmer returns the gesture. She loads another arrow and quickly jumps out from behind the tree. The hunter whistles, alerting Shadow Weaver to her presence. The werewolf gives chase. When she becomes close enough to Glimmer to scare Adora, that is when the arrow is released. Another high pitched sound is released, briefly stunning Shadow Weaver.

Before her mother can recover, Adora jumps out from behind the tree. She pushes through the pain in her ears and sets her sights on her mother. Without hesitation, Adora leaps into the air and jumps into Shadow Weaver’s back. She bites into Shadow Weaver’s shoulder. Adora winces at the taste of copper in her mouth.

Shadow Weaver throws Adora off with no hesitation. The blonde slams onto the ground, the wind taken right out of her lungs. She sees stars and has no control of her limbs. In the distance, Adora hears Glimmer shouting her name.

"You little brat. This is the thanks I get for raising you?" Shadow Weaver hisses.

She inches her way closer, teeth bare. Adora watches an arrow fly through the air but Shadow Weaver swats it out of the air like an annoying fly. The blonde struggles to regain control of her body but it is to no avail. She curses over and over in her head.

Another arrow suddenly files through the air. It zips past both Shadow Weaver and Adora and plants itself in the ground. Without warning, it explodes into a bright flash of white light. Everyone winces at the blinding light. Adora can feel the heat on every part of her body. Where the hell did that arrow come from?

The light dies down. Adora blinks back what lingers until her sights return to normal. Her breath gets caught in her throat. Instead of Shadow Weaver in her direct line of sight, Catra stands over her. Her sister's body shields her own and Adora can tell her hair is standing on edge. Before she can say anything, Catra speaks.

"And here I thought Adora was the favorite. Too bad I don't want that spot anymore."

"Catra," Shadow Weaver growls. "First you leave me at my weakest and now another slap in the face? How could you?"

Catra shrugs. "A lot of my fuck ups I learned from you so I am taking a page out of someone else's book. I won't let you hurt Adora or anyone for that matter. And also, you can go fuck yourself."

Shadow Weaver takes another step forward. She only makes it an inch before another arrow appears. This time, it hits her in the hip.

Adora snaps her head towards the direction the arrow came from. Standing within the tree lines are Bow and Adam. Her brother has his own crossbow raised. A curse leaves his lips.

"Shit. Thought that would hit her in the leg."

"You still hit her. That's good!" Bow replies.

Adam chuckles. "Thanks."

Adora hears Catra groaning. "Stop flirting! You can do that later!"

Shadow Weaver hisses before turning on her heels. She sets her sights on the two men. Bow shoves Adam out of the way before jumping in the other direction. By now, Adora has returned to her feet and Glimmer has reunited with her.

"Glad to see you're not dead," Catra tells Glimmer.

"Glad you give a shit," Glimmer replies. "I'm getting tired of this game of cat and mouse. Let's finally end this!"

No one disagrees. Shadow Weaver has her sights set on Adam. The other twin works to put another arrow on his crossbow. Before he can, Catra whistles. Somehow, this gets the werewolf's attention.

"Still ignoring me, bitch?" Catra quips. "Some things never change do they?"

"Insolent brat!" Shadow Weaver begins chasing after her youngest daughter. Catra sprints away, her mother no match for her speed.

"If you guys can distract her and keep her still long enough for me to get a sure shot, that would be great!" Glimmer states. "Think you guys can do that?"

Adora, Adam, and Bow nod. The younger twin moves first, chasing after Shadow Weaver and Catra. He shouts at the werewolf, calling to attention that he is an *easy* target. Catra

catches on and makes a sharp turn towards Adam. Both younger siblings now act as bait.

Bow and Adora follow behind, attempting to corner Shadow Weaver. When they get close, Shadow Weaver stops short and spins around to face them. Her green eyes glare right at Adora. It is full of malice and hate. Adora fights back the urge to cower. Shadow Weaver briefly sets her sight towards Bow, snapping at him and knocking the crossbow out of his hands.

"Shoot!" Bow gasps. He is forced to back off. Shadow Weaver turns back around.

Shadow Weaver forces Adora back. Anyone who comes close to mother and daughter are chased away or threatened with being bit. Adora is forced back to the edge of the steep hill she previously fell down. Her foot momentarily slips. She gasps as the sudden loss of purchase before she finds her footing again.

Adora stands her ground. She cannot locate Glimmer. She can buy time for her girlfriend…

"I will give you one last chance," Shadow Weaver says."Why don't you come back to your mother? Do you know how much I have missed you since you left me?"

Adora's ears fall back so far on her head that they ache. She shows her teeth at Shadow Weaver. "You are *not* my mother!" Adora growls. "You took me away from my mother! From my father and brother! You lied to me all my life for what?!? Just to have someone malleable to do your bidding? No! I will *never* go back to you. Never in a million years."

Shadow Weaver sneers. She steps closer. With her body tense and fur up at all ends, she nearly towers over Adora. The blonde holds her ground, refusing to yield, even as Shadow Weaver is only inches away from her.

"This is the thanks I get for giving you this gift?!? For giving you this power?!?"

Now it is Adora's turn to tower. She stands as tall as she can, showing no signs of fear. Every hair on her body stands tall and she speaks with sheer determination. "You made me think I was a monster! That my family threw me out because I was a werewolf! That people would hate me for what I was. *Who* I was! But I know now that is nothing more than a blatant lie!"

She has bought enough time for Glimmer. An arrow flies through the air, the tip glistening in the moonlight. It strikes Shadow Weaver in the bite wound from before. The werewolf jerks back back, crying in pain. She reaches for the arrow in her back, ripping out of her body. However, the effects are immediate. Shadow Weaver begins swaying, struggling to keep her legs steady.

Another arrow hits her in roughly the same area. Shadow Weaver gasps and turns to face Adora. She takes a step forward, a paw raised, before stumbling onto the ground. There is still a fight within her as she shakily rises to her feet.

Adora prevents her from doing more. She walks over to Shadow Weaver and presses both her paws down on the other werewolf, pinning her. Shadow Weaver continues to glare at her.

"You might have 'raised' me and you might have turned me into a werewolf but that is all. I rejected your ideals, I found my family, carved out a place where people love and care for me, and I made this power my own with the help of my friends. You've never been a mother and you will be nothing more than a bad footnote in my life!"`

"You brat…" Shadow Weaver grumbles, barely able to hold her head up.

Glimmer slowly walks over, as do the others. The hunter gives her girlfriend a look. It's a mixture of relief, tiredness, and bitterness. Adora gives her girlfriend a nod. She watches as Glimmer digs into her bag, pulling out a vial of wolfsbane. The hunter pops it open.

“Have shitty dreams you son of a bitch.” Glimmer kneels down and pours the wolfsbane on Shadow Weaver’s muzzle. The werewolf sneezes and tries resisting inhaling the powder but it is fruitless. Within a minute, Shadow Weaver is unconscious. For good measure, Adam and Bow tie her in in silver chains. Once done, Adam is on the phone calling Petra.

“Is that really gonna keep her out until Petra’s buddy comes?” Catra asks.

“I gave her a stronger type than what we used on Adora the first time. Plus, a good amount. She should be out for a while and Petra’s friend should be aware of what they are getting into.” Glimmer huffs. “Let’s get her sorry ass back to the house.”

The five work together to half drag and half carry the limp body of Shadow Weaver. They remain in silence. Only the twigs and leaves below their feet make any noise. There are points where breaks are taken and jobs are switched. Between this all, and finding the correct path back, it takes about an hour to return home. Waiting at the front of the house, lying on the hood of a car, is a young man. His curly dark hair covers his eyes. Adora cannot tell him he is sleeping or looking at the stars.

“Are you Petra’s friend?” Adam asks.

The young man jumps off the hood. He smiles as he introduces himself. “Yup! This the werecreature causing all the issues as of late?”

“Yeah,” Glimmer says. “If you don’t mind, I would like you to get her ugly face out of my sight.”

The young man laughs, his dark brown eyes twinkling. “Help me get her in the car. Petra will be happy to hear this.”

They all work together to heave Shadow Weaver into the back of the car. When she is in, Adora can’t help but stare at the person that raised her for most of her life. Unconscious and beaten, there is nothing threatening about Shadow Weaver anymore. There is

no reason to shrink in fear. There is nothing to worry about any longer.

The young man shuts the door and Glimmer gives him some extra wolfsbane. He has nothing to worry about and that Petra will call them in the morning. He wishes everyone a good night (what's left of it) and heads off into the darkness. After watching the car disappear, everyone reenters the house.

The moment the door shuts, the weight of everything comes crashing down on Adora. She collapses on the ground, choking back on tears of relief. "It's finally over!" she gasps. "She's finally gone! We…We won!"

Glimmer kneels down in front of her. Tears are in her lilac eyes. She wraps her arms tightly around Adora's neck, burying her face into her fur.

"It's over! M-My mom can finally rest in p-peace!" Glimmer sobs. "No one e-else has to be h-hurt."

The sobs continue, cutting off any sort of words either wants to say. Adam, Bow, and even Catra all join in, emotions washing over all of them.

For the first time in a long time, there is no worry about the morning that is to come.

Glimmer blinks back the soft morning light that enters through the shades. The birds eager to feed their young chirp as they talk to one another. Sleep remains heavy on her bones, luring her back into its grasp. She comes close to doing so, her brain telling her that it is a wonderful idea. However, before Glimmer can fully succumb, her mind suddenly reminds her of Shadow Weaver. Of the threat she poses and all the blood she has shed.

Glimmer snaps away, her heart attempting to dig itself out of her chest. The first thought is to find Adora, *protect* her from the

harm that is to come. Out of the corner of her eyes, she notices a figure. Snapping her head around, she finds her girlfriend asleep. Blonde hair sticks to the corner of her mouth.

A flood of memories enter her mind. Hurting Adora, racing after Shadow Weaver, her girlfriend calming her down, and somehow winning their fight. Glimmer sighs in relief, flopping back down on the bed.

It's over... she reminds herself. Petra will be contacting them soon, telling them what will happen to Shadow Weaver. For now, she is out of sight and out of mind. There is no more need to worry.

Glimmer rolls over onto her side. The yellow glow of the sun lands perfectly on Adora, casting her in a soft halo. Gingerly, she reaches out and pulls the hair away from Adora's mouth, tucking it behind her ear. Smiling, the hunter rubs the back of her hand against her girlfriend's soft cheek.

This ends up waking Adora. Her sky blue eyes flutter open, lighting up the moment she sees Glimmer.

"Good morning, hon," Adora says softly.

"Good morning, love. How'd you sleep?"

"I think that was the best sleep I got in a long time. How are you feeling?"

Glimmer shifts. If she has to admit it, her body isn't happy. "Sore. But I'll be fine. How about you?"

"A little better than you but still bruised. Freezing though." Adora shivers, pulling the covers close to her body.

Glimmer laughs. "Maybe you should put on some actual clothes and then you'll feel warmer."

"Leaving this cocoon will only make me colder."

Glimmer rolls her eyes before shifting closer to his girlfriend. She lets Adora flip over before wrapping her arms around her girlfriend's body. The hunter places a soft and tender kiss between her girlfriend's shoulder blades. "Can you believe this is finally over? I'm scared that I am going to wake up and everything is going to reset."

"I know what you mean," Adora replies with a tinge of sadness. "But if so…don't tase me again." Adora says the last bit somewhat playfully.

Glimmer sighs. "I won't. I'm sorry. If I ever do that again, you can tase the hell out of me as payback. Does that sound fair?"

This gets Adora to laugh. "Yeah. That sounds fair enough."

The hunter buries her face into Adora's back. She inhales deeply, taking in the mixture of scents. Sandalwood and wet dog. Hell of a combo but it's a combo Glimmer has come to love. It's the smell of home. Safety, comfort, and unconditional love.

"Do you think the boys are awake yet?" Adora asks, her voice sounding distant.

Glimmer shuts her eyes, following Adora's lead. "Maybe Bow. I haven't even checked my phone to see if Petra has said anything."

"You probably should ya know."

Adora breathing slows. She pulls the covers tighter as she settles back in bed.

"I know but I want to stay in this moment. What is going on with Shadow Weaver, I don't care. We spent a year worrying about her. Can we enjoy n hour of peace together?"

Adora says nothing, only making a noise of agreement. Glimmer lets herself drift off into a peaceful sleep with her girlfriend by her side.

Chapter End Notes

Comments/kudos appreciated

A Tale of Moon

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

June starts off warm. Humidity has yet to grab the world in its suffocating fingers. The sun shines brightly. No clouds dare try blocking out the rays. There is a cool wind that blows through, giving the world a needed breath of relief. Trees have lost all of their flowers and it has been replaced by vibrant green leaves. Children soon will be free from school and running amok around town. For now, a calm presence covers Brightmoon.

Within the Whispering Woods, four beings walk through the trees. Bow and Glimmer lead the way through the forest with Adam and Adora trailing right behind. The former pair leads the latter to the spot where Adora was found. It has been a long time since anyone was here—where everything began. Glimmer takes everything in as she walks forward.

Things barely have changed. Having grown up here, she can tell when things change. All the trees stand as tall as ever. Many of the shrubs have begun to fruit, waiting for someone to pick their berries and eat them. Leaves remain coated on the ground, crunching under everyone's feet. Glimmer spots at least one eagle flying overhead.

It's an odd feeling, behind back here. She remembers the day so clearly. Hearing the howls at night. Waiting impatiently for Bow to come to search the woods. Finding the dead deer before quickly finding Adora at the end of her shift. Carrying her unconscious body back to the house and waiting for Adora to finally wake up.

Glimmer looks over her shoulder. Adora is currently chatting away with her brother, telling him more about her first few days in Brightmoon. The younger twin listens intently. Adora even tells

him a bit about her time before and what led up to the meeting. She seems more at ease when speaking about it.

They make a turn, heading into a clearing. Glimmer pushes back a branch, letting the others enter. She joins them, standing besides Adora.

“You remember any of this?” Glimmer asks.

“No. The first thing I remember is waking up in the guest bedroom,” Adora replies. She kneels down, brushing her hand against the ground. “Who knows where I would have been had you not shown up. I hope I wasn’t too hard to drag back.”

“Don’t worry you weren't,” Bow answers.

“Good work out, though!” Glimmer adds.

She laughs when Adora gives her a look. They don’t stay long in this stop. Having only stopped here to mark the day nearly a year ago, there is no need to be here all day. With tonight being a full moon, it only made sense to check it out. Plus, there are plans for the rest of June that are a bit more important.

Tonight will be a test run for Adora’s shift. With her control last month, everyone wants to ensure this will happen again. Adora feels sure that she will have control but nervousness remains. No one wants to take a chance. After everything that happened during the fight with Shadow Weaver, it could be chalked up to an in the moment occurrence.

Speaking of Shadow Weaver, Petra has been filling everyone in on what’s going on. It’s more than obvious that she is guilty of attacking and killing many. The question right now is how to go about punishing her and holding during the full moons. Petra has stated that Shadow Weaver will be held in a silver lined cell. There will be no way for her to harm anyone else.

The last text from the werebear was sent this morning, simply reading:

We got everything uncontrol. You guys do not have to worry any longer.

It's a great weight off her and everyone's shoulders. With that out of the way, there are better things to worry about, such as Adora's shift. Though there is another thing. Tonight's full moon is the first one of the month. A rare blue moon will occur at the end. Normally, this is nothing of note. Doesn't make werecreatures stronger or anything like the wolf's moon. But it just so happens the blue moon lands on something special.

According to Adam, it happens to land on Marlena's birthday. What better gift could a mother get than having her long lost daughter return? Adam has already set it into motion, telling his parents that he will be back for his mother's birthday. More anxiety but at least this time around, there isn't the dread of *death* hanging over everyone's head.

Upon their return home, Adam and Bow decided to play some video games to pass the time. The two bicker for a moment about who should be first player before playing a game of rock-paper-scissors. Bow ends up winning.

"What do you wanna do?" Adora asks. She leans against the table, watching her brother begrudgingly take the second player controller. "We can play loser."

Glimmer gives a shrug. "I think I'm good. Let 'em have their fun." She runs her hand through her hair, feeling the soft locks against her fingers.

Adora leans forward, brushing the bangs away from Glimmer's face. "You need another dye job. We can do that if you like. I think I saw some hair dye in the cabinet a while back."

The hunter thinks for a moment. She pinches some of her pink locks between her fingers, giving them a slight twirl. Glimmer has not seen her true hair color in full in quite some time. The last time she left her locks was when her mother was still alive.

Glimmer sighs through her nose. “No. I think we should get rid of the color.”

Adora's eyes go wide. She tilts her to the side. “Really? I figured you’d want to keep the pink and purple.”

“I think I need a change of pace. And what? Do you not like black hair?”

Adora gives her a shove. “Shut up. How do we do that anyway? Don’t you usually just let it grow out?”

“I have a special dye that will get rid of it. You pretty much do it the same as before. I think I have everything we need upstairs.” Glimmer looks back towards the boys. Both are staring intensely at the TV. The clicking of buttons fill the air along with the occasional muttering of curse words.

“I think Bow and Adam will be distracted for a while. C’mon, let’s go.”

Glimmer grabs Adora’s wrist, pulling her towards and up the stairs. When they reach the top, she lets go. Both quickly prep the bathroom. There shouldn’t be as much as a mess but just in case, Glimmer sets aside some towels.

“Is this it?” Adora asks. She pulls out a bottle full of a clear liquid.

Glimmer nods. With everything set, the hunter takes her spot on the toilet. Adora begins brushing out her hair. Gently, any knots are pulled undone and any hitchhikers from the forest are pulled out and thrown in the trash. Glimmer feels herself melting at the touch of her girlfriend. She feels her body starting to go limp. The only thing stopping her from falling into complete relaxation and bliss is hearing a snort from Adora.

Now onto the fun part. Adora carefully places the clear dye on all of Glimmer’s hair. Try as she might to be careful, some of the dye gets on both of them. Thankfully, the dye isn’t like the previous one and won’t stain clothing.

“I think I got everything,” Adora states. She sets everything down on the sink.

“Now we just have to wait. All of it will come out with some water and a towel,” Glimmer replies.

From downstairs, they hear Adam shouting in triumph. Both Adora and Glimmer chuckle, wondering what on earth is going on. While they wait, the blonde leans against the counter. She crosses her arms and looks upward.

“What are you thinking about?” Glimmer asks. “Are you nervous about tonight?”

“A little bit, yeah…” Adora scratches the side of her face. “Still can’t believe I was able to finally gain control.”

“How did that feel?”

“Well, I couldn’t quite enjoy it seeing what was going on. But, honestly, it was amazing! I could run, see, and smell better than I ever could imagine! Part of me actually can’t wait to shift so I can experience that again.”

“I never thought I would hear you utter those words.”

“Trust me, I can’t believe it either.” Adora pauses for a moment, her eyes looking far off in the distance. “I can’t believe *any* of it.”

“I know what you mean…” Glimmer leans back against the toilet, shutting her eyes.

She recalls how the morning after capturing Shadow Weaver, and ensuring she didn’t somehow break free, calling her father and aunt. Her father is one to wear his heart on his sleeve, however, Glimmer doubts she will ever forget hearing his tears of relief. The only other time he ever cried so hard he couldn’t speak was at Angella’s funeral. Even Castaspella had a hard time forming words.

It feels all like a dream. A cruel one waiting to rip this happiness away from everyone.

“Guess we’ll see if you can do it again." Glimmer taps her hand against her hair. Her fingertips are pink and purple. "I think my hair is ready."

"Guess that's my cue to leave so you can shower."

"Wait!"

Adora stops short, her hand on the door handle. She raises an eyebrow.

Glimmer stands up and grabs a towel. One of her old, raggedy ones with frayed ends. She gets it nice and damp, not missing a spot. After a quick wring out, she turns her attention towards Adora. “This is good enough to get the dye out. Wanna help me?”

Adora beams. She returns to her previous position, happily taking the towel from her girlfriend. Glimmer settles back down on the toilet. The bliss from before returns as Adora works both the towel and her fingers against the hunter’s hair. A soft moan escapes her, this time causing Adora to chuckle.

“Enjoying it?” Adora asks. She moves her fingers right behind Glimmer’s ears.

“Very much so. Thank you for doing this.”

“Of course! Think I am almost done though.”

Glimmer whines, begging Adora to continue the massage for a few more minutes. The blonde happily obliges. She continues, humming a small tune while doing so. Glimmer leans into the touch, sucking in every moment of it. Unfortunately, it must come to an end. With one final scrub, she shows Glimmer the towel.

The one, pale, cream color has turned into a colorful mess of pink and purple. It might take a couple of washes to get everything

out. Glimmer turns her attention to the mirror, getting a good look at herself. Her raven hair is free of any unnatural coloring and sticks up in many different spots. She forgot how much she looks like her father.

"You look good with black hair or purple and pink," Adora whispers gently into her ears. The blonde places a tender kiss on Glimmer's cheek.

"One day we have to dye your hair, if you like."

"I'll think about it."

There is another shout from downstairs. Glimmer rolls her eyes. She stands up, tossing the towels in a hamper. "Let's go check and see who is winning. I think they are playing Mario Kart. I'm surprised they haven't killed each other yet."

The pain is the same as usual. Nothing ever changes in that department. Thankfully, the comfort never changes either. With her head on Glimmer's lap and her girlfriend's fingers running through her hair, she can manage with the pain. Though, she still wishes that it didn't feel like her *bones* were on fire.

Adora doesn't fear what will come next. She remembers the feeling of running through the woods, all the sights and smells that were hidden from her before, and the joy of finally, *finally* being able to enjoy the night. She wants to experience that again.

Adora allows the pain to wash over her. She, however, bites down on her lip as everything explodes inside of her. It nearly is unbearable but it is over in an instant. The world spins for a moment, creating lines of color that bleed into one. After several blinks, everything returns to normal.

The first thing her eyes land on that's steady is Glimmer. Her eyes are warm and her smile is soft.

“How you feeling?” Glimmer asks. She rubs her fingers against the base of Adora’s ear.

“Been better,” Adora groans. She slowly rises to her feet. They remain unsteady as she stretches her body out. Her adjusting bones pop into place. Adora stares at her paws, the same ones she saw only a month prior. A sigh of relief escapes through her nose. “I did it again. I finally have control!”

“You look like a deer trying to stand on ice,” Adam jokes. He leans back against the couch, smirking.

Adora retaliates by swiping her paw at her brother’s feet. Adam loses his balance and falls on his tailbone. He groans, rubbing his backside, all the while giving his sister a glare. Adora sticks her tongue out before getting steady on her feet. She even does a little dance, her nails clicking on the flooring.

“Man this feels great! I want to go running!” Adora stares at the back door. Her tail wags without her command and she can *barely* contain the urge to do a play bow. She must be vibrating because Glimmer is laughing hysterically. The hunter stands and opens the door for her girlfriend.

Adora bolts out of the house, not bothering to use the porch stairs. She leaps right onto the ground. The *wet* ground. A late night storm is blowing through. In the short time the weather has covered Brightmoon, puddles have formed. Adora jumps in all of them, feeling the water splash against her fur. Through the wonderful smell of petrichor, Adora can still take in the scents of all the animals that have come by and the nearby trees.

So much energy has built up inside of her that she cannot contain it. She ends up doing laps around the house, slowing down for *no one.* By the time she becomes out of breath, Adora must’ve done ten or so laps.

Her fur is soaked and mud cakes her legs and chest. Lungs are begging for oxygen and her body can collapse at any second. Her

heart itself laps around her chest. Adora *loves* it.

"You are going to reek of wet dog!" Glimmer states. She stands on the porch, protected from the rain by the roof. Adam, meanwhile, peers his head out from the open door.

Adora smirks from ear to ear. In a few short strides, she is a foot away from Glimmer. "C'mon! You love it when I smell like a wet dog."

"In your dreams."

"Ah! C'mon on! Maybe if you smell like me you'll enjoy it!"

"Wait, what?!?"

Before Glimmer can retort further, Adora grabs her by the hem of her shirt and tugs with all her might. The hunter does her best to resist, even looking towards Adam for help. The younger twin only shrugs, earning him a glare from Glimmer. Despite the best efforts from the hunter, she loses. Adora pulls her right into a puddle.

"Gah!" Glimmer scrabbles to sit up, spitting out the water from her mouth.

Adora snickers, having the largest shit eating grin on her face. It only grows as Glimmer stares her down.

"I'm going to get you for that!"

Adora books it. She begins to taunt her girlfriend and her lack of speed. Each time she senses her girlfriend closing in, the blonde picks up the pace. Their combined laughter fills the air. The chase ends. Adora and Glimmer run together, rain pelting their faces and every part of their body becoming drenched. Adam watches them from the last step, judging to see who is in the lead.

Eventually, though, Glimmer gives in. She leans against the railing, catching her breath, as Adora does one finally lap around the house.

“I think…” Adora pants, “I am done.”

“Just don’t rub yourself all over the furniture,” Glimmer chuckles.

Adora shakes herself off on the deck before returning to the dry, warmth of the house. Glimmer disappears for a moment before returning with a towel. The hunter kneels down beside her girlfriend and begins to dry her off.

Adora’s tail wags a mile a minute. The towel is warm and her girlfriend’s touch is soft. When Glimmer reaches her ears, the blonde leans fully into it. So much so, the second hands are pulled away, Adora flops to the ground.

With the rain becoming heavy and the rumbles of thunder, everyone decides to settle down. Somehow, they all fit onto the couch. Adora keeps her head on Glimmer’s lap while her girlfriend rubs her head. The rest of her body rests on Adam, who doesn’t seem to mind. Late night shows are watched no matter how stupid they are.

Eventually, Adora feels herself slowly drifting off into sleep. She slips into some sort of unconsciousness. There are sights and noises that make no sense. Before her body can join her mind, something gives her a slight shake. A snort escapes her as her brain reboots.

“Sorry,” Adam whispers.

“Hm…It’s okay,” Adora yawns. “What’s up?”

“Just wanted to talk a little bit. Glimmer’s asleep.”

Adora turns her head around. Sure enough, Glimmer is dead to the world. Her head hangs limp while she snores softly. Her arm remains draped against Adora’s body. The blonde carefully shifts to get a better look at her brother. “What’s up?”

“Think you are ready to meet Mom and Pa?”

"I dunno. I have been dying to meet them but it's nerve-racking. Over twenty years I've waited to finally see how my parents are and now, it's only a few weeks away!"

"They've been waiting just as long. They love you, you know that."

"I know." Adora pauses for a moment. She listens to Glimmer's steady breath and heartbeat. "Can you tell me more about them? Mom and Pa?"

"Of course."

Adam leans back on the couch. He begins telling stories about their parents. Ones from before their birth. The ones he was told when he was little.

Apparently, Randor and Marlena met due to an incident during high school. Marlena, while practicing lacrosse, in a fight of rage, threw her ball as hard as she could. Unfortunately, the hard ball flew right into the side of Randor's head. By sheer chance he was walking nearby and feeling bad, Marlena took him to the nurse. The rest is history.

Even when they went off to different colleges, they spent as much time as possible together. Whenever one stayed up too late studying and fell asleep at the desk, the other always carried them to bed and tucked them in. Everyone on both campuses knew them as 'the lovebirds'.

Adam skips to the things Adam remembers. Even during the times both were at their lowest after Adora's kidnapping, there were moments of good. Marlena would pace around the living room, angry and unable to sleep. Randor would come down and rub her shoulders and hold her all night long. On the other hand, when Randor was lost in his head, Marlena would bring him back to earth with soft words and his favorite corny jokes.

"There is one thing that has always stuck out in my mind," Adam says.

“What?” Adora’s ears perk up.

“It was close to the anniversary of when you were kidnapped. I might have been like nine or ten. I happened to wake up and I heard Mom and Pa downstairs. And I heard music. So, I snuck down and went to see what was happening. I hid behind the wall but I saw them dancing.”

“Dancing?”

Adam nods. “Yeah. They were slowly dancing. I could tell they were sad. It had been a *rough* day for all of us. Mom and Pa did get into a bit of a spat over something I can’t remember. But, seeing them dance, I knew they still loved each other. They still cared.

“I dunno. Something about that made me feel like everything was going to be okay.”

“They really love each other, huh?”

“Yeah. You and Glimmer remind me of them sometimes.”

Adora chuckles. “Good to know.”

“They always tried their best to care for me, even when I had to stay with that family friend's house, I know they sent me to them to keep me safe. I love them and I couldn’t ask for better parents.”

“I’m happy to know I get to have them too.” Adora yawns. She cuddles closer to Glimmer, pressing her head against her stomach. “If you don’t mind, I am going to go to bed. I’ll see you in the morning. Are you going to stay up?”

“Probably. Don’t worry about me. I’m a big boy, I can take care of myself.”

Adora only rolls her eyes.

Glimmer exits her mother's room, leaving the door slightly ajar. She shifts the small box of equipment in her arms. Humming a small tune, she enters her room. Slowly, Glimmer has been going through her mother's things, seeing what she can use. Anything not of use, though, she keeps. At least, for now.

She puts away some things in her bags and everything else in the box gets tossed in her closet. With that all set, she heads downstairs and outside. Glimmer needs to make a quick stop at Perfuma's store. With the visit to Adora's parents quickly coming up, everyone is getting ready. They'll need to fly, which is something Adora has never done.

Getting some bottles from Perfuma to help calm Adora's nerves is needed. The faery has something less potent than the sleeping ones she gave before. Not enough to knock her out for hours but enough to keep her in a relaxed state.

Currently, she is out with Adam, trying to get him set up with Bow. Her plan is to ditch the two when they get to the diner. There have been no text updates yet.

Glimmer pulls into a spot and makes the short walk to Perfuma's store. The AC gives her goosebumps. No one is at the front desk. Rather, Scorpia is off towards the side near some clothing. Along with her are the Whitewood brothers. She is helping Edgar and Alvin pick out some clothing.

"What about this for your vacation?" she asks. Scorpia holds up a Hawaiian shirt. Edgar scrunches up his nose.

"That's something my dad would wear!" he states. "What else do you have?"

"My dad would wear that but so would I." Glimmer walks up to the trio. She looks at the red shirt with flora on every inch. "Ya got any in my size, Scorpia?"

"Sadly, no. But I'll order some for you. I'll just need to get your size."

“I’ll text ya. Where is ‘Fuma?”

“Just grabbing stuff in the back. She’ll be out in a minute.”

“Can you help us pick some clothes for our vacation?” Alvin asks.

Glimmer thinks for a moment. She pushes some of the clothing aside on the rack, searching for something good for the brothers. After sometime, she settles on one with a lizard on the side.

“What about this?” she asks the brothers. “I think I see another one. It suits you guys in a way, doesn’t it?”

Both of their eyes light up bright. Alvin says, “Yeah! I love it. It’s perfect!”

Edgar takes the shirt from Glimmer while Alvin takes the other one off the rack. The older brother digs through his pocket and hands Scorpia some money. Both women wish the boys well on their trip. Edgar and Alvin promise to take lots of photos to show everyone when they get back. The two bolt out of the store, running full speed down the sidewalk with their clothing held tightly in their arms.

Glimmer and Scorpia chat for a bit before Perfuma finally appears from the back. She puts some box of clothing in the corner before walking up to her girlfriend and friend. “Glad to see you guys didn’t set anything on fire.”

“Eh, that’s only cause I forgot my matches at home,” Glimmer reassures.

“Well if you do, then I won’t buy you lunch.” Perfuma points towards the desk. “Your bottles are behind the desk.”

Glimmer gives a small nod before walking over to the desk. She quickly spots the bottles on a shelf. They are a much lighter blue color, like that of powder. The hunter carefully puts the bottles in her bag and returns to her friends. “How’s everything been here?”

“Well. How've you guys been?” Scorpia asks.

“I see you have your natural hair back,” Perfuma points out.

“Yeah. It was time for a change,” Glimmer says. “Everything's been good, though. Glad everything is good here. When I get home, remind me to get some new summer’s clothes.”

“I’ll make sure to get a Hawaiian shirt your size,” Scorpia winks. It makes Glimmer chuckle.

“Thanks. I’ll say ‘hi’ to everyone.”

Adora rocks on her heels. They’ll be leaving for their flight soon. It’ll be a short one, much faster than driving, but still long enough to have her anxiety run wild. But that’ll be something for later. Right now she is currently waiting for her sister to open the damn door.

Glimmer and Adam wait in the car. This is something she wants—*needs*— to do this.

Adora runs her hands down her face. She is about to turn around and deal with this later when she returns to Brightmoon. However, of course, the door opens as she lifts up her foot.

Catra stands in the doorframe, her cyan and amber eyes half lit. Her hair is a mess, clearly it has yet to be brushed. Her sister’s pajamas are a tank top and boxers. Catra yawns quite loudly before speaking. “Yo, Adora. What are you doing here?”

“I guess you didn’t get any of my text. You always were a heavier sleeper than me,” Adora replies. “I wanted to stop by and see you before I travelled.”

The gears in Catra’s head turn. “Right. You’re gonna go visit your mom and dad, right? Hope they ain’t pieces of shit.”

Adora snorts. “Thanks. You’re going to be moving to Blackmoor soon, right? How’s that going for you?”

“It’s going. Packing best I can. Probably won’t finish until the night before, which is whatever…This isn’t the only reason you came here, is it?”

“No. We haven’t really had the chance to talk since we defeated Shadow Weaver. You with packing and me getting ready to see my Mom and Pa. I wanted to say thank you. For everything you have done for the past few months.”

“You don’t have to do this, Adora. I don’t need thanks for anything. I wanted to help and I did.”

“No, Cat. That's why I am here.” She pauses for a moment. “We wouldn’t’ve been able to do half the stuff we did without you. You told us who was doing all the killings. You helped us work towards working out a plan. You stood up to Shadow Weaver before I did and risked your life! If someone were to ask me a year ago what I thought of you, I would have clamped shut and fumed.”

Catra rubs her cheek.

“But now…”

Suddenly, Adora jumps forward. Her arms wrap around her sister, holding her tight. “I’m so happy you are back in my life. I missed having a sister.”

She feels Catra hesitant for a moment before she wraps her own arms around Adora’s body. “I missed you too.”

The sisters remain together for a minute, saying nothing. They simply enjoy being in each other’s presence. No ill will, no contempt, no hatred. Just…sisters.

They finally break apart. Catra gives Adora a playful punch to the arm. “Have fun meeting your parents. I’ll catch you around.”

"Have fun as well."

Adora heads back to the car, joining her brother and girlfriend. One family done, one more to go.

Everything feels strange yet familiar. She spots a park, children running around in the bright summer sun. Something about one of them climbing up the tube slide causes Adora to rub her leg. There is a pizzeria that makes her mouth water just by the *sight* of it. And then there is the forest, the long stretch of trees throughout the town. Her blood turns cold.

"So this is Etheria," Adora softly says.

"Yup," Adam replies from the driver's seat. "Anything feel familiar?"

"A little…How much longer until we get to Mom and Pa's?"

"A few more minutes."

Glimmer reaches over from her seat and places her hand on Adora's. The hunter gives it a reassuring squeeze. Adora does her best to give a smile but her mind will not cease. No matter how many times she, Adam, or Glimmer tell her everything will be alright, her mind wanders back to Shadow Weaver. Even after her defeat, she still has a cold grasp on the blonde.

So much so, last night she awoke from a nightmare where her parents were nothing but two more Shadow Weavers. *Literally.* There were three of them in her dreams, all looking over her menacingly. Adora can still feel the cold sweat on the back of her neck. Had it not been for Glimmer calming her down, she might have not gone back to sleep.

Adora turns her head back out the window. The center of town has turned into the suburban streets. Kids ride down on bikes and skateboards, parents relax on the porch with careful eyes, and pets romp around the front yard. A few homes have a sprinkler

going to cool off from the heat. Like everything before, the houses are strangers with familiar faces.

Adam finally pulls into the driveway. With a long and deep breath, Adora opens the door and steps out into the world. The first thing she does is look at the house. *Her* house. It's nothing out of the ordinary. Two stories, a simple porch and garage, and some flowers out front. There is no fence blocking the backyard, which sits up against the woods. Adam's car is the only one in the driveway.

"They are going to be home shortly. C'mon," her brother digs into his pocket, "let me show you inside."

Adora doesn't follow right away. Her hands shake and it feels like her throat has become a straw. Her brain reprimands her, asking the blonde if this is a good idea.

"You doing okay, love?" Glimmer asks. Her fingers have laced together with Adora's.

"I think I will be," Adora admits.

"Do you want me to lead?"

"Yeah. If you can."

Glimmer gives a small nod. She takes the first step forward. Adam makes way for them to enter. The second Adora passes the threshold, her breath ceases to be. She slowly steps further, taking in the sights. The hallway that leads to the living room and kitchen, the stairs that will lead to her bedroom. She faintly recalls the days playing tag with Adam only to be scolded by one of her parents for running in the house.

There is a table nearby, photos nearly set on top. Adora pulls away from Glimmer and slowly steps forward. Staring at her are images of her family. Her parents on vacation on a boat with what looks like extended family. Adam's eighth grade and high school graduation. Picture of two cats, one who Adora assumes is

Cringer. And then…one of her. Right in the middle of all the frames. Five-years-old and smiling with crooked teeth. She is opening up some presents.

"That's one of the last photos they have of you," Adam says from behind. "They always keep it in the middle of the family photos. I think so, in a way, you could be a part of all you missed."

"I'll see if I can find any photos of me for them. Shadow Weaver wasn't one to try and preserve memories," Adora says.

"Let's go upstairs."

Adam takes them up the stairs. A few groan under their weight. Upstairs, there are several doors. Adam explains one is their parents', one is the master bathroom, one is his room, and the last is her room.

"I moved out of our room some years ago. Mom and Pa figured to leave the room as yours for whenever you came back." Adam's hand rests on the doorknob. "Are you ready?"

Adora takes a deep breath. She nods. When Adam opens the door, she takes a step inside.

The walls are painted a soft, cheerful yellow. There are pictures of horses on the walls. Off towards the side is a desk with a lamp, perfect for someone to do their work on. A dresser and a bookshelf (which waits to be filled) and, finally, a bed big enough for an adult. It barely looks touched, the blankets and pillows are in perfect place. Sitting on the bed are four stuffed animals. Wolves to be exact.

Two are larger than the other. Of the former, one is a dark gold color with sky blue eyes while the other is russet color with darker blue eyes. The smaller wolves look almost exactly like the larger, yellow wolf, however, one has the same eyes as the brown one.

Adora walks up to the bed, taking one of the smaller wolves in her hands. Someone has gone through the trouble of hand making it

and the rest of its family. The sky blue eyes are bright and a small smile is stitched onto their faces. Adora can't help but hold the wolf close to her chest. She settles down on the bed.

"These guys are adorable," Glimmer says.

"Yeah. Mom and Dad made them. They started with the one Adora is holding but ending up making the whole family. It kind of helped them cope." Adam states.

"I love them," Adora whispers. She wipes away the mist from her tears. "The whole room is amazing."

"Yeah. Mom and Pa had no idea what you would like, they had to go off of what you liked at four."

Their conversation is suddenly cut off by a high-pitched meow. Everyone looks up to see a white and orange cat bounding into the room. They head directly over to Adam, purring loudly as they rub against his legs.

"Who's that?" Adora asks.

"Swift Wind! But we usually call him Swifty." Adam scoops up the cat. Swift Wind continues to meow. "We adopted him a few years back. He doesn't know when to shut up."

"I guess Cringer is gone?" Adora asks.

Her question is immediately answered. There is a raspy, second meow, followed by the appearance of an old cat. Brown fur has turned grey, eyes are milky, and hair looks scarggly. Yet other than that, Cringer looks healthy.

"He is still kicking," Adam says. "Can't slow him down. Why don't you let him sniff you?"

"Do you think he'll remember me?" Adora asks.

"Maybe. He isn't deaf so you can call him over."

Adora places the wolf down and kneels down on the ground. She calls out to Cringer, beckoning him over. The cat's ears perk up and he trots over towards Adora. She allows him to sniff the back of her hand. After a couple of inhales, Cringer meows loudly. He bumps his head against Adora's legs, purring louder than Swift Wind. His meows sound like cries.

"Sounds like he missed you," Glimmer says. She pets Cringer's back.

"I've missed you too, buddy," Adora chuckles.

A new noise catches everyone's attention. The sound of a door opening and closing. It's followed by a voice. "Adam! You home, buddy?"

"Yeah, Pa! I'll be down in a sec!" Adam places Swift Wind down on the ground. "Adora, follow me down but don't show yourself. Not until I tell you so."

"Sounds good to me," Adora says.

Adora, Glimmer, and Adam all begin to head downstairs. The older twin stays behind the others, feeling her heart drum against her chest. When they reach the first floor, Adora remains behind. Though, she carefully peeks her head out from around the corner, just enough to make out the outlines of everyone.

"Welcome home!" Randor shouts. He gives his son a huge bear hug. "It's been too long."

"I know, Pa! I know!" Adam says, choking.

"Let him go, honey," Marlena tells her husband. "So who is this lovely young lady?"

"I'm a friend. Glimmer Mizari."

"Pleasure to meet you."

“Happy birthday, Mom! I can’t wait to show you your present.”

Marlena chuckles. “Last night you could barely contain yourself over it.”

“So are you going to show this present or what?” Randor asks, giving his son a small slap on the back.

“Yeah. Well…It actually is for both of you…Come show yourself.”

With permission given, Adora steps out from the corner, down the short hallway, and into the light of the living room. The moment she is visible, she attempts to form words but finds words are nonexistent. She can only give the smallest of waves.

Both of her parent’s eyes go wide. Marlena covers a gasp with her hands. Randor is still as a statue. He himself attempts to say something but no words come out. Both of their blue eyes are brimming with tears. Behind husband and wife, Adam and Glimmer watch closely.

Marlena finally steps closer towards Adora. She is about the same height as her daughter. Streaks of grey are in her reddish-brown hair and her eyes looked tired. Yet, there is a familiar warmth to them.

“Adora?” Marlena’s voice is barely audible. Her hand reaches out and brushes Adora’s cheeks. The blonde instinctively flinches, causing her mother to snap her hand back. “Do you not like that?”

“Not really but it’s okay,” Adora reassures her.

Marlena reaches up once more, placing her hand against her daughter’s cheek. Adora pushes into the touch, feeling the soft skin against her own. Tears begin to escape from her eyes, which her mother wipes away with her thumb.

“Is that really you, baby girl?” Marlena asks.

Adora nods. “Yeah. Yeah it’s me.”

Randor joins his wife. He has grown a bit of a beard and his glasses frame are thicker than photos she has seen. He places his own hand on Adora's other cheek. It's rougher but just as warm as Marlena. "Is this real? I'm not dreaming, am I?"

"No. You're not."

"I-I can't believe t-this. M-My baby…" Tears now stream out of her eyes. She wraps her arms around Adora's, burying her face into her shoulders. Randor pulls both his wife and daughter into his embrace. He holds them tightly, crying himself.

Adora returns their hugs, burying herself into them. No words at all, only tears. Adora inhales deeply, taking in her parents' scents. The apple-cinnamon of her mother and the woody smell of her father. They cause a rush of memories. Of being held in her parents' arms during storms. Of nights nestled on their lap as they read stories to her. When they would hold her hands when walking in the rain.

Adora's legs give out and her whole weight is solely held up by her mother and father. She continues to sob, clinging tightly to her parents. If she lets go, she fears she will lose them once more. The sentiment must be the same, as her mother and father's hug crush her chest.

"We-We always h-held on hope to s-see you again but…but," Marlena starts.

"We didn't k-know if we w-would!" Randor finishes. "Twenty years…"

"We *never* s-stopped thinking about y-you!"

"I'm sorry," Adora gasps. "I didn't…I couldn't re-remember you guys! I'm sorry…"

"It's okay, baby," Randor comforts. "You were so little when it happened."

“You’re here now, Adora,” Marlena adds. “T-That’s what matters. You’re f-finally home!”

When they finally pull apart, after another minute or two of holding one another tight, eyes fall onto Adam and Glimmer. Both have remained in their place, their own eyes having tears. Adam clears his throat. “So…Do you like it?”

“How long have you known your sister was alive?” Randor asks.

“A few months now…” Adam rubs the back of his neck. “It’s complicated. A lot of explaining.”

“I’ve been staying with Glimmer for the past year,” Adora tells her parents. “She’s…actually my girlfriend.”

Glimmer gives a small smile and wave. Marlena walks up to her and gives the hunter a hug. “Thank you for helping my daughter.”

Glimmer looks stunned, not knowing what to say. Eventually, she manages to reply with, “Not a problem!”

“Your sister is gone for over twenty years and comes home with a girlfriend. When are you going to get a boyfriend, son?”

Adam turns beet red. He chokes momentarily before answering his father. “I have one!” he blurts out. “We just…just started so… not ready to meet the parents yet.”

Randor laughs. “That’s my boy!”

Marlena claps her hands together. “You must be hungry. Let’s cook!”

Everyone gathers around the dining room table. Adora slowly prepares herself to tell as much as possible to her mother and father, and even Adam. There are bits she hasn’t told him yet. A simple talk over dinner won’t cover a whole life of stories but she can give the sparknotes.

After getting some food in her stomach, Adora begins. She tells her family about the things that happened shortly after being kidnapped. How Shadow Weaver would tell her that her parents didn't want her anymore because of the bite. Repeated over and over again, she had begun to believe it and forget about her parents.

She tells them about all the moving around, never staying in one place too long. How she got bored easily by herself and the time she snuck out and harmed another child from her panic. It was shortly after that that Catra came into her life. Adora spares a lot of the details about her sister. She tells them about how there was a long stretch of time their relationship was anything but pleasant but now, it's better.

By the time Adora gets to her life over the past year. Glimmer jumps in, a much needed relief. Adora's throat is sore. The whole time, her parents listen carefully. Only a few times do they cut in, asking for a couple more details or saying how horrible something must have been. Finally, with most of the food eaten and everyone on their second drink, the stories are done.

"I'm so sorry you had to go through all of that. I wish we could've been there," Randor says. "Shadow Weaver finally is done with?"

Glimmer answers. "Yeah. We haven't heard any updates from Petra in a while but no news is good news."

"So, you are still a werewolf," Marlena asks after a sip of coffee. "I guess there isn't a cure."

"No. I don't think there is," Adora replies. "I've gotten control of the shifts anyway. That's part of the reason we came today, to show you how far I've gotten."

Adora takes a moment to sip her own drink. The tea is soothing against her throat and relaxes her body. "It's been a rough and long road, I will admit that. But, I am happy. I am happy for who I am. Everything that has happened to me, as much as a lot of it

sucks, has lead me here, to the person I am today. The person I am, I like her, and I don't think I would ever want to change that.

"Being able to love myself took most of my life. Where I am now in life, I can say I am able to look forward to the good that comes with loving me. That other part of my life is only a fraction and I don't want to change it if it means I am not *me."*

"Whatever you are, we are proud of you," Randor says.

Adora smiles softly. There remain some hours left before the full moon. Marlena decides this is the perfect time to drag out some old baby photos. At first, the blonde is excited to see herself as an infant and toddler. However, as her mother starts telling Glimmer embarrassing stories like the time Adora put a bowl of spaghetti on her head, she begins to regret it. Still, seeing herself so small and innocent is a wonderful feeling.

Randor and Marlena tell some stories about their family. How Adora has many aunts, uncles, and cousins, all who can't wait to see her again. Though, that brings up the question on how explaining Adora's return will work. But, for now, that is put in the back of everyone's minds.

As the sunlight disappears, everyone gets ready for the night. Despite telling Randor and Marlena that everything will be okay, they still fret over their daughter. Asking her if she needs anything and if it still hurts. The only thing Adora requests is not to be around during the shift. That is still something not pleasant to see.

Rinse and repeat when the moon rises into the sky. Glimmer remains at her side. There is no worry at all for a shift gone wrong. Adam keeps his parents upstairs until the shift is over. Thankfully, it is over quickly.

"You feeling okay, love?" Glimmer asks.

Adora slowly stands to her feet. She shakes out her fur. "Yeah. I think it's getting a little better. Do you mind calling my parents

and Adam?”

Glimmer nods. The rest of the Glenn family come down shortly. Adora stands in the middle of the living room, wagging her tail slightly as her parents see her for the first time. Like earlier this morning, both Marlena and Randor’s faces are full of surprise. While before it was more of a *shock* , this is more in *awe.*

“What do you think?” Adora asks.

Randor kneels down besides his daughter. He places his rough hands on top of her head, giving a good rub between her ears.

“Good to know you still have my hair,” he snorts.

Adora rolls her eyes before swatting her father’s hand away.

“You look amazing, sweetheart,” Marlena says.

“Only bad thing is you stink,” Adam teases.

“Don’t forget, I can easily kick your ass in this state.” Adora gives him a small side-eye, which only makes him laugh.

There are two other family members who come to check out Adora’s new form. Swift Wind comes up first and gives the wolf a sniff. His ears quickly fall flat on his head and he gives a harsh hiss before running away. Adam goes after him to soothe him. Meanwhile, Cringer gives his own sniff. Instead of becoming spooked, the older cat gives a headbutt and purrs.

For about a half hour or so, Marlena and Randor continue to spend time in awe over their daughter’s transformation. They still cannot believe that Adora is able to walk and talk with no problem.

As the night goes on, Adora’s attention falls towards the woods in the back. They seem darker than the Whispering Woods. More menacing. A shiver runs down her spine while she stares at it.

“Did you want to go out and explore it?” Glimmer asks. Her own gaze turns to the woods. “We don’t have to stay in the house all night.”

Adora shakes her head. “No. I’d rather not go into them. At least, not right now. Maybe one day.” A yawn suddenly escapes from her.

“Guess it’s your bedtime?” Glimmer grins.

“So what if it is? Been a long day.”

“I don’t blame you,” Glimmer herself yawns. She stretches out her body. “Where are we going to sleep? Did you want to try fitting on your bed upstairs?”

“You girls can sleep on the pull out couch,” Marlena cuts in. Adora and Glimmer look behind them, seeing the older woman walking up to the pair. “If you’re uncomfortable sleeping up there, the one on the couch might be better.”

“Thanks. I think that would work.”

Randor and Marlena pull out the hidden bed. From somewhere within the house, Adam brings down some pillows and blankets. When Adora hops up onto the bed, it creaks under her weight and feels stiffer than most beds. But, with her bones tired from the flight, drive, and shift, she could collapse on a pile of bricks if given the chance.

Adora pats down the lumps in the mattress before plopping herself down. Glimmer cuddles up next to her, looking equally as ready to fall asleep. Before Adora shuts her eyes, Marlena pulls up the covers, shielding most of her daughter’s body.

“You’re tucking me in?” Adora questions.

“Course I am. I’ve waited many years to do this again,” Marlena places a kiss on top of Adora’s head. “Besides, sometimes if I

notice Adam has kicked off his blankets while he's asleep, I'll tuck him back in."

Adora chuckles a little. "Thanks…Mom. I love you."

"I love you too. I can't wait to wake up and see you again."

Randor comes up to her and gives his own kiss on his daughter's head. "Have sweet dreams. I hope you don't have any nightmares."

"Don't worry. I got Glimmer to protect me from them…I love you, Pa."

"Love you too"

The room turns dark as Marlena and Randor leave. The only sources of light are from the TV and whatever moonlight streams between the curtains.

"So," Glimmer whispers, "how are you doing?"

"Okay, I guess. Kind of can't believe any of this is happening. Tired…" Adora answers.

"I'm happy for you. Your parents seem amazing."

"Yeah. They do." Adora shuts her eyes and soaks in the warm from the covers and Glimmer. "No more talking. Sleep…"

Glimmer places a kiss on Adora's nose. "I'll see you in the morning."

Glimmer watches the sun slowly continue its rise above the horizon. The sky is painted in blues and oranges. Temperatures remain cool. A temporary bliss before the heat scorches the earth. A few songbirds sing as they tend to their young. Inside, most everyone is asleep. Adam most likely will be out for a while and Adora's parents…Glimmer didn't hear them at all.

Adora, though, on the other hand, is semi-awake. After her shift, the hunter decided to let her girlfriend choose if she wanted to stir or not. Glimmer can feel that she won't be going back to bed anytime soon so after tucking in Adora, she stepped outside to enjoy the morning.

The forest from last night looks far less menacing than the night before. There seems to be many evergreens—pines and firs. Glimmer can just make out the outlines of maples but all the greens blend together. Somewhere deep inside there is the spot where Adora's life changed forever. Guess all woods have their dark secrets.

Glimmer takes a breath, leaning against the railing. Her eyes are fixated on the sky. She hopes that wherever her mother is, she is at peace finally. The hunter can't help but smile softly, knowing that Angella has nothing more to worry about. Her final deed has been finished.

"I'm still shocked you are up," Adora's voice says from behind.

Glimmer looks over her shoulder. Her girlfriend, half asleep, rests her body against the open door frame. She rubs her eyes and yawns. "Sorry. Still waking up."

Glimmer walks up to her. She places a tender kiss on the tip of Adora's nose. "Now you know how I feel in the morning."

"Did we pack any energy potions from Perfuma? I think I could use one right about now?"

"I don't think so. We already had to worry about the other potions while flying. What? Is coffee not good enough for you?"

"Only if you make it. I have no will to do so right now."

Glimmer rolls her eyes. She agrees, of course, and the two head back into the house. Adora flops onto the chair. She doesn't have enough strength to keep her torso up and ends up using the table

as a pseudo bed. The hunter keeps an eye on her while the coffee brews.

“You still alive, love?” Glimmer asks.

“Yes,” Adora answers, her voice muffled.

“Not an early bird?” a new voice says.

Glimmer turns around to see Marlena entering. Despite the early morning, there are no hints of tiredness in the older woman’s body or eyes.

“No, actually. Adora usually is up before. I would rather sleep until noon if I could.” Glimmer answers.

“Shifts…” is all Adora says.

“Why don’t I cook some food for you girls. That should give you some energy.”

“You don’t have to do that, Mrs.Glenn. You already made us dinner,” Glimmer says. The coffee is finally done. She takes out an extra cup and evenly pours the hot liquid.

“Call me Marlena, dear. And I don’t mind cooking. Love it actually! You’re family now so no worries!”

Glimmer doesn’t quite know what to say. She grabs two of the cups and gives one to Adora. She watches as her girlfriend’s eyes light up.

“Man that feels good,” Adora sighs.

Marlena begins cooking. Eggs, bacon, and toast. Slowly, the smell of food fills the air, causing the remaining members of the Glenn family to come down. First Adam and then Randor. Even Cringer and Swift Wind appear, begging for some bacon (which Marlena happily gives).

The breakfast is bright and happy. Randor suddenly has many words to say and tells Adora and Glimmer a number of stories, most of them at Adam’s expense. Laughter fills the air and some tears escape eyes.

Adora is finally back with her family, Glimmer has been accepted into it, Catra has found her own place, and Brightmoon is safe once more. After a year of confusion, sadness, and anger, the future is bright.

Chapter End Notes

> And with that, after nearly 2 years, werewolf au is over. Its been a long ride and thank you for your patience when I had those hiatus. I also have to thank my friends Ash, Dorku, Finn, Alex, Meg, Max, Karl, Aashi, and many in a server im in. For giving me ideas, editing, or listening to me ramble
>
> And of course everyone who read and supported me.
>
> I think for now I'm done with spop stories. If I come up with more ill write but I have other ideas for other fandoms and want to do that.
>
> I hope yall enjoyed and ill see you in the next project

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!